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1 Corinthians

1 Corinthians 1:1

Section 1:1–9: Paul began his letter

Paul began his letter to the Corinthian believers by greeting them. Then he thanked God for helping them.

Paragraph 1:1–3

In this paragraph, Paul, along with Sosthenes, sent greetings to the church in Corinth. In the Greek text, as in the BSB, 1:1–3 is a single long sentence. You may want to translate it in shorter sentences with three main topics:

1. The writer was Paul.
2. Paul wrote to the members of the church in Corinth.
3. Paul prayed that God would bless them.

See the Display on 1:1–3 for suggestions.

1:1a

Paul, called to be an apostle of Christ Jesus

- ¶ This letter is from me, Paul, chosen/appointed as an apostle of Christ Jesus,
- ¶ I, Paul, greet you^(plur). God chose/appointed me to be a representative of Christ Jesus.

Paul: The apostle Paul began the letter with his name so that the readers would know who had written this letter to them. The Greek language does not need to add anything more. However, in some languages, it is necessary to include a verb such as “write.” For example:

I, Paul, write this letter to you.

This letter is written by me, Paul.

In some languages it may not be natural for a writer to talk about/refer to himself using the same pronoun that is used to refer to another person. It may be necessary to use the first person. For example:

This letter is from me, Paul.

I, Paul, write this letter.

called to be an apostle of Christ Jesus: The phrase called to be an apostle of Christ Jesus indicates that God appointed Paul as an apostle of Christ Jesus.

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this part of the verse as a clause and use the implied subject. “God” (as in 1:1b). For example:

God called me to be an apostle of Christ Jesus.
(NCV)

called: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as called means “summoned, chosen, or appointed.”

an apostle: The Greek word that the BSB translates as apostle is literally “a messenger.” It refers to a person whom someone sends with authority to give a message or do a task. Paul was an apostle whom Jesus chose and gave authority. After Jesus returned to heaven, his apostles were the leaders for those who believed in him.

If you have already translated the Gospels, you can probably use the same term for apostle as you used there. In some languages you may need to change it slightly for this context. Some ways to translate apostle are:

a special messenger

a representative

Christ Jesus: There is a textual issue here:

1. Most Greek manuscripts have the two words in the order Christ Jesus. For example:

an apostle of Christ Jesus (GNT) (BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, NJB, NET, ESV, GW)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the two words in the order Jesus Christ. For example:

an apostle of Jesus Christ (KJV) (KJV, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1).

Christ: The Greek word for Christ is a translation of the Hebrew word for “Messiah.” It means “the one whom God anointed.” It refers to the special man God had promised to send to save his people. Here the word Christ is used as a name for Jesus. Therefore you should use the word and write it in a way that is appropriate for your language.

In the Display the name Christ, as well as all other names, is spelled according to normal English spelling.

You may need to write this and other names as they would be said and written in your language. For example:

Christo

Kraist

Kristi

1:1b by the will of God,

- because that is what God decided.
- That is the work that God wants me to do.
- That is what God appointed/willed me to do.

by the will of God: The phrase by the will of God indicates that God decided that Paul was to be an apostle. In many languages it is necessary to translate the noun will as a verb. For example:

because that is what God wanted (NCV)

according to what God willed/decided

See also 2 Timothy 1:1, where the same phrase occurs.

1:1c and our brother Sosthenes,

- Sosthenes, our^(incl) Christian brother/friend, joins me in greeting you.
- Our^(incl) fellow believer Sosthenes also sends greetings.

our brother Sosthenes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as brother is the term commonly used in the New Testament to refer to another person who believes in Jesus. This term indicates that Sosthenes was like a brother to Paul and the other Christians.

In some languages the phrase our brother is only used literally to refer to a blood relative. If that is true in your language, use a natural way to refer to a fellow Christian. For example:

our fellow believer

our friend/companion who believes in Jesus as we do

Sosthenes: Sosthenes is the name of a man who was with Paul in Ephesus when he wrote this letter.

1 Corinthians 1:2

Section 1:1–9: Paul began his letter

Paul began his letter to the Corinthian believers by greeting them. Then he thanked God for helping them.

Paragraph 1:1–3

In this paragraph, Paul, along with Sosthenes, sent greetings to the church in Corinth. In the Greek text, as in the BSB, 1:1–3 is a single long sentence. You may want to translate it in shorter sentences with three main topics:

1. The writer was Paul.
2. Paul wrote to the members of the church in Corinth.
3. Paul prayed that God would bless them.

See the Display on 1:1–3 for suggestions.

1:2a

To the church of God in Corinth,

- I send this letter to you^(plur) who meet together to worship God in Corinth.
- We^(excl) greet you, the people in the city of Corinth who belong to God.

To the church of God in Corinth: The word church refers here to a group of people who believe in Jesus Christ and meet together to worship God. Here the term refers specifically to the believers in Corinth. It does not refer to a building. Therefore the phrase the church of God can be translated as:

the group of people in Corinth who belong to God

the people in Corinth who meet together to worship God

1:2b

to those sanctified in Christ Jesus

- God has set you apart for himself by making you one with Christ Jesus.
- God has set you apart for himself by joining you together with Christ Jesus.

to those sanctified in Christ Jesus: This is the first of two phrases describing the believers in Corinth, the people who together formed the church. The Greek word that the BSB translates as sanctified means “ones having been made holy.” It indicates that those people have been dedicated to or set apart for God.

This clause is passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

to those dedicated to him in Christ Jesus,

- Use an active verb. The implied subject is “God.” For example:

to those whom God has set apart as his own people since you are united with Christ Jesus

in Christ Jesus: The phrase in Christ Jesus indicates both when and how God causes people to belong completely to himself. That takes place when they are united to Christ Jesus. God sanctified the Corinthians in Christ Jesus when he made them his own people by uniting them to Christ Jesus. For example:

in union with Christ Jesus, (GNT)

1:2c and called to be holy,

- He has called you to be his people,
- He has summoned/chosen you to be his holy people.

called to be holy: This is the second phrase that describes the Corinthian believers. The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as called to be holy is literally “the called saints.” Some English versions use “saints.” For example:

called to be saints (RSV)

The members of the Corinthian church were called to be holy people or saints because they belonged to God. They were set apart for God as his own special people to reflect his holy character. God had called or chosen them for this purpose.

Some other ways to translate this are:

who God called to be his people

who God has called to be his own holy people

This clause is passive. Some ways to translate it are:

General Comment on 1:2a-c

- Use a passive verb. For example:

You were called to be God’s holy people... (NCV)

- Use an active verb. The implied subject is God. For example:

whom God has called to be his holy people

In verse 1:2a Paul addressed the church as a whole, so he used the singular noun “church.” In 1:2b-c he addressed all the individual believers in the church, so there he used plural forms. In some languages it is not natural to make this shift. It may not be clear that this verse is still talking about the same people. You may need to make that clear by saying:

to the believers in Corinth, whom he made holy in union with Christ Jesus and whom he called to belong to him

1:2d

together with all those everywhere who call on the name of our Lord Jesus Christ,

- along with believers everywhere who worship our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ.
- He has also chosen believers/those from everywhere who pray to our^(incl) Master Jesus Christ.

together with all those everywhere: This phrase refers to a second group of people. Besides the Corinthian believers, there were believers in other places. There are two different interpretations of this phrase:

1. It is connected to the phrase “called to be holy,” and perhaps “sanctified in Christ Jesus” also. God has set apart all believers for himself. For example:

called to be saints together with all those who in every place... (RSV) (RSV, ESV, NET, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. It is connected to the phrase “to the church of God in Corinth.” Paul was writing his letter to other believers, not only to the Corinthians. For example:

and to people everywhere (GW) (GNT, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) since it seems to have stronger support in the English versions.

who call on the name of our Lord Jesus Christ: The phrase call on the name of...Jesus Christ indicates that these people all worshiped Jesus Christ. They called on his name in the sense that they worshiped him and trusted him to help them. This is a reference to Joel 2:32. See Romans 10:13 and Acts 2:21. Some other ways to translate this are:

who pray in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ
(NCV)

as we and all others do who call him Lord (CEV)

all who invoke the name of our Lord Jesus Christ
(REB)

our Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “master, chief.” In the passage in Joel, Lord was a reference to God. However, in this context it is a title for Jesus Christ. Jesus was the master whom the Corinthian believers, Paul and Sosthenes all obeyed. Some other ways to translate this are:

Master

Leader

1:2e

their Lord and ours:

- He is their Lord and our^(incl) Lord also.
- They worship/serve him as their Lord, and so do we^(incl).

their Lord and ours: This verse part adds to the information of the previous verse part. Jesus was not only the Lord whom Paul and the Corinthian believers obeyed. He was also their Lord, that is, the Lord of all believers everywhere. In some languages it may be more natural to make this phrase into a separate sentence. For example:

He is their Lord and is also our Lord.

1 Corinthians 1:3

Section 1:1–9: Paul began his letter

Paul began his letter to the Corinthian believers by greeting them. Then he thanked God for helping them.

Paragraph 1:1–3

In this paragraph, Paul, along with Sosthenes, sent greetings to the church in Corinth. In the Greek text, as in the BSB, 1:1–3 is a single long sentence. You may want to translate it in shorter sentences with three main topics:

1. The writer was Paul.
2. Paul wrote to the members of the church in Corinth.
3. Paul prayed that God would bless them.

See the Display on 1:1–3 for suggestions.

1:3

Grace and peace to you from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

- I pray that God our^(incl) Father and the Lord Jesus Christ will give you grace and peace.
- May God our^(incl) Father and the Lord Jesus Christ be kind/gracious/compassionate toward you and cause you to live in peace.
- I pray that God, who is like a father to us, and the Lord Jesus Christ may be gracious to you. May he cause you believers to live together peacefully.

Grace and peace to you: The phrase Grace and peace to you was a common Christian greeting. Paul included a similar greeting near the beginning of every letter he wrote. It is a prayer that can be translated as:

I pray/wish that God will give you grace and peace.

May God give you grace and peace.

Grace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Grace refers to God’s love and kindness toward people. People have done nothing to deserve this love and kindness.

Some other ways to translate it in this context are:

kindness

generous help

In many languages it may be more natural to translate Grace with a verb or clause. Some examples are:

My prayer is that God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ will be kind to you. (CEV)

-or-

I pray/wish that God will generously help you.

May God show his favor to you.

peace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as peace refers to general personal well-being. It indicates peaceful relations with God and also other people. Some other ways to translate this are:

I pray/wish that God bring/send/give you peace.

I pray that God will cause you to be at peace.

God our Father: God is the Father of believers since he is the one who has created them. He has given them spiritual life. God is also like a father in the sense that he takes care of his children. Therefore, they should obey him and trust him. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as a simile. For example:

God, who is like a father to us

1 Corinthians 1:4

Section 1:1–9: Paul began his letter

Paul began his letter to the Corinthian believers by greeting them. Then he thanked God for helping them.

Paragraph 1:4–9

In this paragraph Paul told the Corinthian believers what he wanted to thank God for. He thanked God for all he had done to help the believers in Corinth. Paul said that he was thankful that God had given them spiritual gifts, especially the ability to speak well about spiritual things and to know spiritual things.

Verses 1:4–8 are one long sentence in the Greek, with the one main verb “I thank” in 1:4. The BSB translated these verses using several shorter sentences. Each sentence tells something for which Paul thanked God. See the General Comment at the end of 1:9 for another suggestion.

1:4a

I always thank my God for you

- ¶ I always/continually thank my God for/concerning you,
- ¶ I often/repeatedly say thank you to my God for you,
- ¶ I am always thankful to our^(incl) God for you.

I always thank my God for you: This is a figure of speech called a hyperbole. It is an exaggeration intended to emphasize something important. Paul did not mean that he talked with God about the Corinthian believers all day long. Rather, he meant that he prayed often to God on their behalf.

Each time Paul prayed for the Corinthian believers he also thanked God for them. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this hyperbole as a negative statement. For example:

I never stop thanking my God... (CEV)

thank my God: There is a textual issue here:

1. Many Greek manuscripts have the word “my” here. For example:

give thanks to my God (GNT)

(BSB, GNT, CEV, NET, NASB, NCV, NLT04, NRSV, KJV, ESV)

1. Other Greek manuscripts do not have the word “my” here.

give thanks to God

(RSV, NIV, NJB, GW, NLT96, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) which includes the word “my.” This is the reading followed by the UBS Greek NT with an A rating, indicating that it is virtually certain to be correct. The UBS Greek NT strongly indicates this is the correct option.

my God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as my God means “the God whom I worship/serve.” A literal translation may imply that Paul worshiped a different God than the Corinthian believers did. If that is true in your language, you may need to use a plural pronoun. For example:

our^(incl) God

1:4b

because of the grace He has given you in Christ Jesus.

- because he has graciously given you many blessings by uniting you to Christ Jesus.
- because he has blessed you through Christ Jesus.
- For he has been kind/gracious to you who are in/belong to Christ Jesus.

because of: There are two ways to interpret the words because of here:

1. It gives the reason why Paul thanked God for the Corinthians. Thiselton p. 89 (“on the ground of” “the occasioning cause”), Barrett p. 35 (“the occasion or cause”); Ellingworth and Hatton p. 11 (following the RSV and GNT). For example:

because of [the grace of God] (NET) (BSB, NIV, NET, RSV, NRSV, ESV, GW, NCV, GNT)

1. It gives the content of Paul's thanksgiving. Hodges p. 6, Garland p. 32. For example:

for [the grace of God] (NASB) (NASB, KJV, REB, NJB, NLT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) which is supported by several commentaries.

the grace He has given you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as grace refers to God's kindness to people. The people have done nothing to deserve his kindness (see note on 1:3). Here Paul refers to the way God had been kind to the Corinthian believers. In some languages it may be more natural to translate grace as an adjective or adverb. For example:

he has been gracious/generous to you

because he is kind he has given you blessings

he graciously helped you

in Christ Jesus: The phrase in Christ Jesus indicates that there is a close relationship between believers and Christ. God gave the believers grace in Christ Jesus because he blessed them as they were joined with Christ Jesus. Another way to translate this phrase is:

now that you belong to Christ Jesus (NLT)

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this phrase at the beginning of this verse part. For example:

God united you to Christ Jesus and graciously gave you blessings.

1 Corinthians 1:5

Section 1:1–9: Paul began his letter

Paul began his letter to the Corinthian believers by greeting them. Then he thanked God for helping them.

Paragraph 1:4–9

In this paragraph Paul told the Corinthian believers what he wanted to thank God for. He thanked God for all he had done to help the believers in Corinth. Paul said that he was thankful that God had given them spiritual gifts, especially the ability to speak well about spiritual things and to know spiritual things.

Verses 1:4–8 are one long sentence in the Greek, with the one main verb "I thank" in 1:4. The BSB translated these verses using several shorter sentences. Each sentence tells something for which Paul thanked God. See the General Comment at the end of 1:9 for another suggestion.

1:5a

For in Him you have been enriched in every way,

- As you are united to Christ, you have received all sorts of valuable gifts.
- That is, through your union with Christ, God has abundantly given you everything you need.
- and has richly blessed you with every spiritual gift needed to serve him.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For here can be interpreted in three ways:

1. It introduces an explanation of the previous clause "the grace given to you." See Barrett p. 36; Thiselton p. 90. See Fee p. 38; Ellingworth and Hatton p. 12; Hodge p. 6. English versions that follow this interpretation often do not explicitly translate this conjunction. Other versions may start a new sentence with For. Verse 1:4 can be joined to 1:5a with a dash. For example:

I am always thankful to God for what the gift of his grace in Christ Jesus has meant to you—how... he has enriched your whole lives (JBP) (BSB, NJB, GW, NLT, NIV, GNT, NET)

1. It introduces the reason why Paul gave thanks to God. See Garland p. 32. For example:

I thank God because... (NCV) (NCV, NRSV)

1. It introduces what Paul thanked God for. He thanked God that the Corinthians were enriched. See Conzelmann p. 25 fn 3. For example:

that in every way... (RSV) (RSV, KJV, NASB, ESV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation is supported by many recent commentaries. In some languages it may be more natural to translate it with a word meaning "that is." For example:

that is, in him you have been enriched in every way

in Him: The phrase in Him means the same as “in Christ Jesus” in 1:4b. God had given the Corinthian believers these special abilities because they were united to Christ.

you have been enriched in every way: This clause indicates that the Corinthian believers had received from God many different special abilities. It does not mean that God had made them literally rich or wealthy.

This is a passive clause. Some ways to translate it are:

- use a passive verb. For example:

you have been made rich in every way, (NCV)

- use an active verb. For example:

you have received all kinds of bountiful/valuable gifts

God has richly/bountifully blessed you in many ways

in every way: The phrase in every way means “in many different ways,” or “in all sorts of different ways.” The Corinthian believers did not lack anything they needed to serve the Lord. They had not, however, each received all the gifts.

1:5b in all speech

- He has made you able to speak well about spiritual things,
- For example, he has given you the ability to tell others God’s message clearly.

in all speech: In 1:5b-c Paul talked about two specific kinds of special abilities that the Corinthian believers had received from God. The first is speech. Paul meant that they had received the ability to speak about spiritual things and tell others God’s message. He was not referring to the general ability to speak fluently.

1:5c and all knowledge,

- and you also have the ability to understand everything that God tells you.
- He has also given you the ability to understand his thoughts/message.

and: The conjunction and here indicates a second ability that the Corinthian believers had received from God.

all knowledge: This special gift of knowledge refers to the ability to understand what God’s message means. In some languages it may be more natural to translate the word knowledge as a verb phrase. For example:

you are able to understand spiritual things

1 Corinthians 1:6

Section 1:1–9: Paul began his letter

Paul began his letter to the Corinthian believers by greeting them. Then he thanked God for helping them.

Paragraph 1:4–9

In this paragraph Paul told the Corinthian believers what he wanted to thank God for. He thanked God for all he had done to help the believers in Corinth. Paul said that he was thankful that God had given them spiritual gifts, especially the ability to speak well about spiritual things and to know spiritual things.

Verses 1:4–8 are one long sentence in the Greek, with the one main verb “I thank” in 1:4. The BSB translated these verses using several shorter sentences. Each sentence tells something for which Paul thanked God. See the General Comment at the end of 1:9 for another suggestion.

1:6 because our testimony about Christ was confirmed in you.

- In this way God’s message that we told you about Christ has been confirmed/verified among you.
- Those special abilities God has given to believers in your church prove/demonstrate that our message about Christ is true.
- That is how God showed/proved to you that the message we^(excl) told you about Christ is true.

because: There are two ways to interpret the Greek conjunction here:

1. It means “just as, even as,” or “in this way.” What God did in 1:5 (enriched the Corinthian believers) is how he did what is stated/said in 1:6 (confirmed the testimony). As God enriched the Corinthian believers with spiritual gifts, so he confirmed or proved true the testimony about Christ. For example:

God has enriched your church in every way....This confirms that what I told you about Christ is true. (NLT04) (KJV, NASB, RSV, ESV, NET, NCV)

1. It means because and introduces the reason for the Corinthian believers receiving spiritual gifts. They

were enriched because the testimony about Christ had been confirmed in them. For example:

because what we testified about Christ has been confirmed... (REB) (BSB, NIV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), which is supported by several commentaries.

our testimony about Christ was confirmed in you:

The verb was confirmed is in the passive form. The whole clause probably means “God confirmed among you our testimony about Christ.” There are two different ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the testimony about Christ has been confirmed among you (NET)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God thus confirmed our testimony about Christ among you

was confirmed: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as was confirmed can be interpreted in two ways:

1. It means “was proved or shown to be true.” For example:

has been verified (GW) (BSB, GW, NIV, NLT, CEV, RSV, NET, ESV, REB, NASB, KJV)

1. It means “was established” or “was strengthened.” For example:

has become established (JBP) (GNT, NJB, JBP, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) since it has stronger support in English versions.

The implied subject of the passive verb was confirmed is God. God gave evidence that the testimony about Christ was true by giving spiritual gifts to the Corinthians.

in you: There are two ways to interpret the phrase in you here:

1. It means among you; that is, among the believers in Corinth, or in the church. For example:

was confirmed among you (ESV) (NET, RSV, ESV, GW, NLT)

1. It means in you; that is, within the hearts and lives of the individual Corinthian believers. For example:

Has been confirmed in your experience (REB) (BSB, NIV, NJB, GNT, KJV, NASB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The majority of Greek scholars support this.

The fact that God enriched the members of the Corinthian church confirmed that the message about Christ was true.

1 Corinthians 1:7

Section 1:1–9: Paul began his letter

Paul began his letter to the Corinthian believers by greeting them. Then he thanked God for helping them.

Paragraph 1:4–9

In this paragraph Paul told the Corinthian believers what he wanted to thank God for. He thanked God for all he had done to help the believers in Corinth. Paul said that he was thankful that God had given them spiritual gifts, especially the ability to speak well about spiritual things and to know spiritual things.

Verses 1:4–8 are one long sentence in the Greek, with the one main verb “I thank” in 1:4. The BSB translated these verses using several shorter sentences. Each sentence tells something for which Paul thanked God. See the General Comment at the end of 1:9 for another suggestion.

1:7a

Therefore you do not lack any spiritual gift

- God blessed/enriched your church/believers abundantly/bountifully so that you^(plur) together do not lack anything. You have every spiritual gift/ability that you need to serve God
- He/God has given you everything you need. Therefore your church does not lack any of the spiritual abilities that the Holy Spirit gives believers

Therefore: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Therefore is literally “so that.” It introduces the result of what was stated previously. There are two interpretations about what this conjunction refers to:

1. It refers back to verse 5. Verse 5a contains the main verb of the sentence which is “enriched.” For example:

in every way you were enriched in him...so that you are not lacking in any spiritual gift... (RSV) (RSV, NRSV, NET, NLT)

1. It refers back to verse 6. For example:

The message about Christ has become so firmly established in you that you have not failed to receive a single blessing... (GNT) (NCV, GNT)

It is recommended that you translate this conjunction so that Therefore refers back to verse 5 since a majority of English versions support this. For example:

God blessed/enriched the Corinthians with every kind of spiritual gift, and therefore they did not lack any spiritual gift.

you do not lack any spiritual gift: God's Spirit had given to the Corinthian believers all the abilities they needed to do God's work. Each person did not have every gift, but together as a church they had every gift they needed.

The verb phrase you do not lack is a double negative. In some languages it is more natural to translate it in the positive. For example:

you have every gift from God... (NCV)

you have every spiritual gift you need... (NLT)

any spiritual gift: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gift here means a special ability or skill. The BSB has supplied the word spiritual. It is spiritual in the sense that it is a gift from God's Spirit. The Spirit gives these special abilities to believers so that they can serve God.

1:7b

as you eagerly await the revelation of our Lord Jesus Christ.

- as/while you are eagerly waiting for our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ to appear visibly to you again.
- during this time you wait expectantly for our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ to come back to the earth again.
- as you wait eagerly to see our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ again.

as you eagerly await the revelation of our Lord Jesus Christ: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as eagerly await is literally "waiting." It refers to eagerly expecting something to happen. Here Paul indicated

that believers are waiting for what will happen at the end of the time we live in. Then Jesus Christ will come back to earth. Other ways to translate this verse part are:

while you wait for our Lord Jesus Christ to come again (NCV)

while you are eagerly waiting for the time when our Lord Jesus Christ will appear

1 Corinthians 1:8

Section 1:1–9: Paul began his letter

Paul began his letter to the Corinthian believers by greeting them. Then he thanked God for helping them.

Paragraph 1:4–9

In this paragraph Paul told the Corinthian believers what he wanted to thank God for. He thanked God for all he had done to help the believers in Corinth. Paul said that he was thankful that God had given them spiritual gifts, especially the ability to speak well about spiritual things and to know spiritual things.

Verses 1:4–8 are one long sentence in the Greek, with the one main verb "I thank" in 1:4. The BSB translated these verses using several shorter sentences. Each sentence tells something for which Paul thanked God. See the General Comment at the end of 1:9 for another suggestion.

1:8a

He will sustain you to the end,

- He will also keep you strong in your faith/spirit until the end of this age
- The Lord will also keep you trusting him right up to the day that Christ returns.
- God will also keep you firm/steadfast, believing in him until the end of the world when Christ does return.

He: The Greek word that the BSB translates as He is more literally "who." There are two ways to interpret who this pronoun refers to here:

1. It refers to God. This is not explicitly stated but is probably implied. For example:

God will keep you strong

1. It refers to the Lord Jesus Christ. For example:

Jesus will keep you strong (NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). God is the implied actor of most of the verbs in this paragraph. It is God whom Paul called “faithful” in the following verse.

will sustain you: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as will sustain you is literally “will also confirm you.” The Greek verb meaning “will confirm” is from the same verb as “was confirmed” in 1:6. The word “also” indicates that this is a second confirming action that God performed.

However, the meaning of “confirm” is a little different in this verse. Here in 1:8, it probably indicates that God will keep the believers firm and steadfast in their faith. He will help them to continue trusting him. Some other ways to translate this are:

will also strengthen you (NRSV)

will also keep you firm (GNT)

to the end: There are two ways to interpret of the phrase to the end here:

1. It refers to the time when Jesus returns to earth again. Jesus’ return was talked about in both the previous and the following verse parts. This verse may be reordered if that is more natural. For example:

And until the day Christ does return, he will keep you completely innocent. (CEV)

1. It refers to the time when the believers die, the end of their time on earth

It refers to the time when the believers die, the end of their time on earth. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Paul probably referred to Jesus Christ’s return, and the judgment which will take place then. Therefore the two phrases the end (1:8a) and “the day of our Lord Jesus Christ” (1:8b) form a doublet. A doublet is two ways of saying the same thing. A doublet is used in order to emphasize something. See the General Comment at the end of 1:8.

1:8b

so that you will be blameless on the day of our Lord Jesus Christ.

- so that you will be without fault on the day when our Lord Jesus Christ returns.

- He will keep you steadfast so that when our Lord Jesus Christ returns, no one can accuse you of any wrongdoing.

so that you will be blameless: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as so that you will be blameless is literally blameless. The BSB clause can be understood as either a purpose clause or as a result clause. It may be more natural to translate blameless as a verb clause in your language. If that is true, it is probably better to use a result clause. For example;

so that no one can accuse you... (GW)

God will keep believers strong and faithful. As a result, they will be found blameless on the day that he returns.

blameless: The Greek word that the BSB translates as blameless means “irreproachable” or “faultless.” It describes someone who cannot justly be accused of wrongdoing. When Christ returns, believers will not be found guilty of any wrong or sin. This is true because they trust in Christ alone. Some other ways to translate this are:

completely innocent (CEV)

there will be no wrong in you (NCV)

on the day of our Lord Jesus Christ: The word day here does not mean a literal day of twenty-four hours. It means the time in the future that God has chosen. Two things will happen then: the Lord Jesus Christ will return to earth, and he will judge all people. In some languages it may be necessary to make some of this implied information explicit. For example:

on the day our Lord Jesus Christ comes again (NCV)

Sometimes the phrase “the Lord’s day” is used to refer to Sunday. Paul was not saying that believers will be or should be blameless only on Sundays. If you decide to translate this phrase literally, check that readers do not think it means the Sabbath or Sunday.

General Comment on 1:8a-b

The phrases “the end” (1:8a), and “the day of our Lord Jesus Christ” (1:8b) refer to the same event. Some ways to translate this to make it clear are:

He/God will keep you strong so that there will be no fault in you on the day Christ returns.

God will keep you strong to the end so that you will be blameless on that day when he returns.

1 Corinthians 1:9

Section 1:1–9: Paul began his letter

Paul began his letter to the Corinthian believers by greeting them. Then he thanked God for helping them.

Paragraph 1:4–9

In this paragraph Paul told the Corinthian believers what he wanted to thank God for. He thanked God for all he had done to help the believers in Corinth. Paul said that he was thankful that God had given them spiritual gifts, especially the ability to speak well about spiritual things and to know spiritual things.

Verses 1:4–8 are one long sentence in the Greek, with the one main verb “I thank” in 1:4. The BSB translated these verses using several shorter sentences. Each sentence tells something for which Paul thanked God. See the General Comment at the end of 1:9 for another suggestion.

1:9

God, who has called you into fellowship with His Son Jesus Christ our Lord, is faithful.

- God is trustworthy, and he has called you into union with his Son Jesus Christ our Lord.
- You can trust God, who has invited/appointed you to be joined/united to his Son Jesus Christ our^(incl) Lord. He always does just what he says.
- God always does what he promises/says and he is the one who has chosen you to share in the life of his Son, our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ.

God...is faithful: The clause God...is faithful means that God always does what he says he will do. God called us into fellowship with his Son. Thus we can trust him to give us the blessings of verses 4–8. Another way to translate this is:

God will surely do this for you, for he always does just what he says (NLT96)

called: The Greek word that the BSB translates as called is the same word found in 1:1a. It means that God chose/invited/appointed the Corinthian believers to be united with Jesus.

fellowship with His Son: The Greek word that the BSB translates as fellowship means “to have something in common with someone.” It means that these people

who have a common desire/goal will have a close relationship.

Here it means that God has put us into a close relationship with his Son. Thus, we share with him in the life and honor that God has given him. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

to share in the life of his Son (REB)

partners with his Son (GW, CEV)

to share everything with his Son (NCV)

His Son: The phrase His Son further describes “Jesus Christ our Lord.” “God’s Son” or “the Son of God” is a title that was often used to refer to a savior who would be a descendant of King David. God would send this savior to rescue his people. This person was often referred to as the “Messiah” or “Christ.”

The title “the Son of God” also indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. The relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. The Son of God existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

In areas where people do not understand the title “the Son of God” in this way, you may want to include a footnote that explains the correct meaning. Here is a suggested footnote:

This title refers to Jesus. It indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It does not mean that God the Father had a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. Mary became pregnant with Jesus in a miraculous way by the Holy Spirit of God.

In some languages, it is natural to speak of a son as a “child,” without specifying male or female. If that is true in your language, you may use a more general term, such as:

his ChildA translation of the title “the Son of God” must include a familial term such as “son” or “child.” Translations such as “the man who is God,” “the divine man,” or “the God man” are

not acceptable, since they do not retain familial language. Examples of acceptable translation options include “the Son who comes from God,” and “the divine/unique/eternal Son of God.”

Other verses will usually make clear that Jesus was a male child. If you use a phrase such as “his male child,” be sure that it does not imply that God had another child who was female.

General Comment on 1:9

There are two main ideas in this verse. The main idea is that God is faithful. The BSB translates one idea inside the other idea. You may wish to separate the ideas and show that one is the main idea. For example:

God faithfully keeps his promises. He called you to be partners with his Son Jesus Christ our Lord. (GW)

God will do this, for he is faithful to do what he says, and he has invited you into partnership with his Son, Jesus Christ our Lord. (NLT04)

General Comment on 1:4–9

There are many ways to divide these verses into shorter sentences. For example:

⁴I always thank God for you because Christ Jesus has shown you God’s good will. ⁵Through Christ Jesus you have become rich in every way—in speech and knowledge of every kind. ⁶Our message about Christ has been verified among you. ⁷Therefore, you don’t lack any gift as you wait eagerly for our Lord Jesus Christ to be revealed. ⁸He will continue to give you strength until the end so that no one can accuse you of anything on the day of our Lord Jesus Christ. ⁹God faithfully keeps his promises. He called you to be partners with his Son Jesus Christ our Lord. (GW)

1 Corinthians 1:10

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the

Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God’s wisdom.

Paragraph 1:10–17

There were divisions among the believers at Corinth. They divided into groups according to which leader they thought was the best one to follow. Paul taught them that Christ was not divided, so neither should his church be divided. His message was that all believers are united in Christ.

1:10

In some languages it may be more natural to translate Paul’s request using direct rather than indirect speech. For example:

^{10a}Brothers and sisters, in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, I make this appeal to you. ^{10b}Agree with one another. ^{10c}Do not divide up into competing groups. ^{10d}Come together having the same purpose and goals.

1:10a

I appeal to you, brothers, in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ,

- ¶ My fellow believers, speaking with the authority of our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ, I urge you
- ¶ So now, my Christian brothers and sisters, since our Lord Jesus Christ Lord sent me to speak in his name/as his apostle, please listen to me I strongly request/urge you to do this:

In the Greek text this paragraph is connected to the previous paragraph with a conjunction. The conjunction begins a new topic. The BSB and many other versions do not explicitly translate this conjunction. However, some versions use/have “Now.” For example:

Now, dear brothers and sisters, (NLT96)

But, dear brothers, (LB) (KJV, NRSV, NASB, LB)

You may have a way in your language to indicate/show that you are beginning a new topic. If that is true, you should use it here.

I appeal to you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as appeal means “to request, encourage, or urge someone to do something.”

Another way to translate this is:

I urge you (NET)

brothers: Paul addressed the Corinthian believers in a friendly way. He was talking to both men and women. See also the note on 1:1c, where the singular form “brother” appears.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Brothers and sisters

Christian friends

my friends (GNT)

You should research/check which is the most natural order in your language. In some languages it is best/most natural to place this word or phrase in the middle of the sentence. However, in others it is best/most natural to put it at the beginning or end of the sentence. For example:

My dear friends,...

in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ: Paul made his request based on the authority that Jesus had given him. He wrote to the Corinthian believers as their apostle, as Christ’s own representative.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

By the authority of our Lord Jesus Christ (GNT)

as an apostle/representative of our Lord Jesus Christ

1:10b-d

In this verse Paul began with a positive statement. He said, “[I appeal] that all of you agree with one another” (1:10b).

Then he said the same thing in a negative way. He said, “so that there may be no divisions among you” (1:10c).

Finally he wrote in a positive way again. He said, “so that you may be perfectly united in mind and thought” (1:10d).

Research/Check whether this is a natural order in your language. In some languages it may be more natural to put the negative command at the end. For example:

^{10b}I ask all of you to live in harmony. ^{10d}Live together as one united group, with the same

thoughts and purposes. ^{10c}Do not split up into competing groups.

1:10b

that all of you agree together,

- to all agree with one another in what you say and think.
- All of you stop arguing with one another.
- Do not disagree with each other, but be in agreement in/about what you profess to believe,

that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as that introduces the content of Paul’s request or appeal. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this appeal using direct rather than indirect speech. For example:

I appeal to you, my friends, in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ: agree among yourselves... (REB)

I encourage all of you...to agree with each other and not to split into opposing groups. (GW)

all of you agree together: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as all of you agree together is literally “you all say the same thing.” However, Paul here referred to what the Corinthian believers were thinking, not just to what they were saying.

Another way to translate this clause is:

I beg you to get along with each other (CEV)

1:10c

so that there may be no divisions among you

- I want you to stop splitting up into different/opposing groups.
- Do not keep on dividing up into quarreling/competing groups.
- and not split up into opposing groups.

so that: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so that can be interpreted in two ways:

1. It introduces another part of Paul’s request. For example:

And that there be... (RSV) (RSV, NET, KJV, NASB, ESV, REB; GW, NCV)

1. It introduces a result or purpose clause. For example:

so that there will be... (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NIV)

The NLT and CEV begin a new sentence here. They omit this conjunction.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) which is supported by several commentaries.

there may be no divisions among you: Some of the believers in Corinth were disagreeing and arguing with each other. They were working against each other instead of working together as one body. The believers split up into separate groups/parties, according to what they thought the teachers were teaching them about following Christ. Paul wanted them to work together and be united.

Some other ways to translate this are:

stop dividing up into groups

end your divisions (NET)

In some languages it may be necessary to translate the abstract noun divisions as a verb phrase. For example:

I encourage all of you ...not to split into opposing groups. (GW)

1:10d

and that you may be united in mind and conviction.

- Rather, I urge you to be in harmony with each other by thinking the same thoughts, and having the same purpose.
- Rather, be one united group with the same attitudes and judgments/purposes.
- Rather, be united as one in your purpose/goals.

This verse part means almost the same thing as 1:10b. Paul was urging the believers to get along and to live in harmony.

and that you may be united in mind and conviction:

The phrase mind and conviction is a doublet. This means that these two nouns mean almost the same thing. They refer to how the believers are to be united.

If you have two words, you should use them as the BSB has done.

In some languages, both nouns can be translated by one noun or by one noun phrase. For example:

Always try to agree in what you think. (CEV)

I urge you to be united in your thoughts.

1 Corinthians 1:11

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 1:10–17

There were divisions among the believers at Corinth. They divided into groups according to which leader they thought was the best one to follow. Paul taught them that Christ was not divided, so neither should his church be divided. His message was that all believers are united in Christ.

1:11a

My brothers, some from Chloe's household have informed me

- My brothers and sisters, some people who live in Chloe's house have told me
- My fellow believers, when some believers from Chloe's family visited me, they reported to me

In the Greek, this verse is connected to the previous verse 10 by a conjunction. It is often translated as "For." For example:

For some people from Chloe's family... (GNT) (GNT, RSV, NLT, KJV, NRSV, NET, ESV, NASB)

Here the conjunction introduces Paul's reason for making his appeal in verse 10. ¹⁰He appealed to the Corinthian believers to agree with one another ¹¹because he found out there were quarrels among them.

Another way to translate this is:

I appeal to you because...

I say this because...

In some languages, it will be more natural to put the reason clause (in 11) before the result clause (in 10). For example:

¹¹My brothers, some from Chloe's household have informed me that there are quarrels among you.

¹⁰Therefore I appeal to you, brothers, in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, that all of you agree with one another so that there may be no divisions among you and that you may be perfectly united in mind and thought.

My brothers: See note on 1:1c and 1:10a. As in 10a, you should research/check where it is most natural to place this phrase in your language. For example, the RSV places it at the end of the verse. The GNT places it in the middle of the verse.

some from Chloe's household have informed me: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as some from Chloe's household have informed me is more literally "it has been reported to me by Chloe's people." In Greek, this clause is passive. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language.

Some ways to translate this phrase are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

it has been brought to my notice by Chloe's people (REB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

some members of Chloe's household have told me... (NLT)

I have heard from Chloe's people

Several people from Chloe's family have already reported to me... (CEV)

some from Chloe's household: In the Greek this is literally "those of Chloe," that is, Chloe's people. This phrase could refer to either some of Chloe's relatives, or to some servants or slaves who worked for Chloe. Chloe was a woman, probably a rich business woman. We do not know where she lived.

Apparently some of Chloe's relatives or workers traveled from Corinth to Ephesus where Paul was staying. They reported about the divisions among the believers in Corinth to Paul.

1:11b

that there are quarrels among you.

- that you are quarreling among yourselves.
- that you argue/disagree with each other.

there are quarrels among you: The word quarrels here refers to spoken arguments rather than to physical fighting. If it is more natural in your language to translate quarrels as a verb, consider doing so here. It may also be necessary to say what the disagreements were about. For example:

you are quarreling about who is the best leader

you are quarreling about which leader/teacher is the best to follow

1 Corinthians 1:12

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 1:10–17

There were divisions among the believers at Corinth. They divided into groups according to which leader they thought was the best one to follow. Paul taught them that Christ was not divided, so neither should his church be divided. His message was that all believers are united in Christ.

1:12a

What I mean is this:

- Here is what I mean:
- I am talking about:

What I mean is this: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as What I mean is this is literally "But I say this." Here this phrase introduces a detailed explanation of the previous verse part. Paul explained what sort of quarrels he meant/was talking about. Some English versions omit this phrase (see NLT, CEV). Some other ways to translate this are:

I am referring to this:

I am talking about

1:12b-e

Individuals among you are saying, "I follow Paul," "I follow Apollos," "I follow Cephas," or "I follow

Christ.”: Here Paul quoted what the Corinthian believers were saying to each other. Paul did not actually hear them say this. Chloe’s relatives/workers told Paul what the believers in Corinth were saying.

The phrase that the BSB translates as Individuals among you are saying is more literally “Each of you says.” This phrase does not mean that each person said each of these things. Paul was giving examples of the kinds of things that many people in the group were saying. In some languages it is necessary to translate this phrase in the plural, as the BSB does. Here is another way to translate this:

Some of you say, “We^(excl) are followers of Paul.”
Some others say, “We are followers of Apollos”
or “We are followers of Cephas.” Still others say,
“We follow Christ.”

In some languages it is more natural to use direct quotes, as Paul does here. However, it is also possible to translate this verse using indirect quotes. For example:

Some of you claim to be my followers. Some others say that they follow Apollos. Others say that they follow Peter. Still others say they are followers of Christ.

The Corinthian believers were proud of their differences. Those who said that they followed Paul, or Apollos, or Cephas, or Christ, all said this with a proud attitude. They thought that they were better than the others who followed someone else.

The teachers themselves were not trying to form these groups/parties. Rather, the believers separated into groups according to which leader they thought was best.

1:12b

Individuals among you are saying, “I follow Paul,”

- One believer says, “I belong to Paul.”
- Some of you claim/say that you are following Paul’s/my teaching,
- Some believers among you are saying, “As for us^(excl), Paul is our^(excl) teacher.”

I follow Paul: The pronoun I is emphatic: “As for me, I follow Paul.” The Greek literally says “I am of Paul.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I belong to Paul (NJB)

I am a follower of Paul (NLT)

We^(excl) are in Paul’s group.

You should translate each of the verse parts 12b-e in the same way. Use the form that you choose here for each of the verse parts.

In many languages it is acceptable for Paul to use his own name here, since he was only quoting what someone else said. However, in many other languages it is not natural for Paul to use his own name here. Readers may think that Paul was talking about someone else who was also named Paul, or that Paul did not write this letter. In these languages it is necessary to translate 1:12b as an indirect quote. Then Paul can refer to himself as “I/me.” For example:

Some of you say that you are followers of me.

1:12c

“I follow Apollos,”

- Someone else says, “I am follow Apollos’s teaching.”
- but others of you claim/say that you are on Apollos’s side.
- But other believers among you are saying, “Apollos is our^(excl) teacher.”

I follow Apollos: The story about Apollos and his visit to Corinth is in Acts 18:24–28. Apollos was a Jew like Paul. He was well educated and a good speaker and teacher.

1:12d

“I follow Cephas,”

- Another believer says, “I am Peter’s disciple.”
- Still others of you claim/say that you are following Peter’s teaching.
- And other believers among you are saying, “Peter is our^(excl) teacher.”

I follow Cephas: Cephas is the name of the apostle Peter in the Aramaic language. Aramaic was the language spoken in the Judean and Syrian provinces. “Peter” and Cephas both mean “a stone.” The first time Peter met Jesus, Jesus gave him that name (John 1:42). Some English versions use the name “Peter” here. For example:

I follow Peter (NCV) (CEV, NCV, NLT, GNT)

You may wish to use the name “Peter” in order to make it more clear who Paul referred to. If you choose to use

the name Cephas, explain in a footnote that Cephas was another name for Peter.

1:12e
or “I follow Christ.”

- And yet another believer says, “It is Christ’s teaching that I obey.”
- And still others of you claim/say that you are the ones who follow Christ.
- And still other believers among you say, “Christ is our^(excl) teacher.”

I follow Christ: You should use the same form here as you used in verse parts 12b-d.

1 Corinthians 1:13

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God’s wisdom.

Paragraph 1:10–17

There were divisions among the believers at Corinth. They divided into groups according to which leader they thought was the best one to follow. Paul taught them that Christ was not divided, so neither should his church be divided. His message was that all believers are united in Christ.

1:13

This verse has three rhetorical questions. They function as a rebuke. Paul rebuked the Corinthian believers for thinking it was good to separate into groups. He reminded them of three things that they knew were not true. There are two ways to translate these rebukes:

- As rhetorical questions, possibly with the answer supplied. For example:

Has Christ been divided into factions? Was I, Paul, crucified for you? Were any of you baptized in the name of Paul? Of course not! (NLT)

- As strong statements. For example:

Christ cannot be divided! Remember, it was not I who was crucified for you. You were not baptized in the name of Paul!

Translate this rebuke in the way that is most natural in your language.

1:13a

Is Christ divided?

- Can you divide Christ?
- It is impossible to divide Christ.
- Christ cannot be divided up like that!

Is Christ divided?: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a rebuke. There are three ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Has Christ been divided? (GW)

Can Christ be divided into pieces? (NLT96) (BSB, NJB, NIV, NET, KJV, NASB, RSV, ESV, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP)

- As a rhetorical question with its own response. For example:

Has Christ been divided? Of course not!

- As a statement. For example:

Christ has been divided into groups! (GNT) (GNT, NCV)

Here is another way to translate this rebuke:

How dare you divide Christ up into factions!

Translate this rebuke in the most natural way in your language.

1:13b

Was Paul crucified for you?

- Was it I Paul who died on the cross for you?
- It was not I who died on a cross to save you.
- Did they/soldiers nail me, Paul, to a wooden cross for you? Of course not!

Was Paul crucified for you?: Again, the obvious implied answer is: “Of course not.” The Corinthian believers knew that Christ is the one who died to rescue them from sin/wrongdoing. They were supposed to live like Christ taught them to. He was their Savior, not

Paul. Since Paul was talking about himself, in some languages it is natural to use a first-person pronoun. For example:

Do you think that I was crucified for you?

Was Paul crucified: The verb crucified means “to be executed by being nailed onto a wooden cross.” It is a passive clause. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this clause without using a passive verb. For example:

Was it Paul who died on the cross for you? (GNT)

Did soldiers nail Paul on a cross to die?

for you: The phrase for you here means “for your sake,” “for your benefit,” or “to help/save you.”

1:13c

Were you baptized into the name of Paul?

- When you were baptized, did they use my name, Paul?
- Or, did people baptize you using my name so that you became my disciples? Certainly not!
- Also consider this: you were not baptized in my name to become my followers.

In the Greek Paul begins this third rhetorical question with a conjunction. It can be translated as “or.” In this context, it probably signals the last in the series of rhetorical questions. For example:

Or were you baptized... (NRSV)

(NRSV, RSV, NET, KJV, ESV, NASB, NJB)

Several of the English versions do not translate this conjunction. For example:

Were any of you baptized... (NLT) (BSB, CEV, REB, NIV, GNT, NLT, GW, NCV)

Begin this last rhetorical question in a way that is natural for your language.

Were you baptized into the name of Paul?: Again, the implied answer is “no.” Paul was still talking about himself here. Thus, it may again be more natural or necessary to use a first-person pronoun in your language. For example:

Were you baptized in my name? (CEV)

As in 1:13a and 1:13b, the purpose of this rhetorical question is to rebuke the Corinthian believers. The Corinthian believers were baptized in Christ’s name. They followed Christ’s teachings, so they should not have been saying that they were Paul’s followers.

Were you baptized: The verb “baptize” means to purify people with water during a special ritual. This ritual purified people from sin. It did not mean that the person was cleaned to remove dirt. Baptism was an initiation that marked the beginning of a person’s life as one of God’s pure people.

Some other ways to translate the verb baptized are:

- Use a descriptive term. For example:

ritually washed

initiated in/with water

- Use a term for a similar ritual that is already used in your culture. You may need to indicate that in this context it has a special connection with God. For example:

purified with God’s ceremonial bath

washed in initiation water for God

- Use a term that is already accepted by the local churches. In some areas this term may have been borrowed from the national language or transliterated from Greek or English.

You may need to use footnotes or a glossary to explain the meaning more fully.

The verb Were...baptized is passive. Some ways to translate this verb are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

were you initiated/purified

- Use an active verb. For example:

Did you receive baptism

Did someone baptize/wash you in the name of Paul?

Did I baptize you in the name of Paul?

into the name of Paul: In the Greek culture of Paul's time, baptism meant ownership. Being baptized into someone's name meant that the one whose name was used owned the one being baptized. When people baptized a person using Christ's name, the person gave/submitted himself to Christ. He then belonged to Christ. He became follower of Christ. Paul did not want anyone to think that some baptized believers belonged to him rather than to Christ.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

as followers of Paul

as Paul's disciples? (GNT)

1 Corinthians 1:14

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 1:10–17

There were divisions among the believers at Corinth. They divided into groups according to which leader they thought was the best one to follow. Paul taught them that Christ was not divided, so neither should his church be divided. His message was that all believers are united in Christ.

1:14

I thank God that I did not baptize any of you except Crispus and Gaius,

- I am thankful to God that I only baptized Crispus and Gaius from among you,
- I thank God that there were only two of you Corinthian believers, namely Crispus and Gaius, whom I baptized.
- I only baptized Crispus and Gaius in Corinth. I am thankful/glad that I did not baptize any others of/ among you.

I thank God: There is a textual issue here.

1. Some Greek manuscripts include the Greek word God. For example:

I thank God... (NRSV)

(BSB, CEV, KJV, NLT, NRSV, ESV, GW, NLT, NCV, NET, NASB, GNT)

1. Other Greek manuscripts do not have this Greek word. For example:

I am thankful (NJB) (NIV, RSV, NJB, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The majority of English versions follow this option. However, both options have the same basic meaning.

Paul did not mean that he actually prayed and thanked God that he had not baptized many people in Corinth. Rather, he meant that he felt grateful that God had guided him to do what would be best later on. Be sure to translate this clause in the way that is most natural in your language. Some other ways to translate this are:

I am thankful to God that

Thanks be to God that

Thank God... (REB)

I did not baptize any of you except Crispus and Gaius: In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as a positive statement. For example:

I baptized only Crispus and Gaius from among all of you.

of your church members I only baptized Crispus and Gaius

any of you: The phrase any of you means any of the Corinthian believers. With the negative "not" it means "none of the members of the church at Corinth."

Crispus and Gaius: These are both names of males.

1 Corinthians 1:15

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were follow-

ing whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 1:10–17

There were divisions among the believers at Corinth. They divided into groups according to which leader they thought was the best one to follow. Paul taught them that Christ was not divided, so neither should his church be divided. His message was that all believers are united in Christ.

1:15

so no one can say that you were baptized into my name.

- so nobody can now say that I baptized you to be my followers/disciples, using my own name.
- As a result, no one there/in Corinth can say, “Paul baptized us^(excl) using his own name, so we are his followers/disciples.”

so no one can say that you were baptized into my name: This clause tells the reason why Paul was thankful. He was thankful because nobody could say that he had baptized Corinthian believers in order to become their spiritual leader. In some languages it may be more natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

Not one of you can say that you were baptized in my name. (CEV)

so: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so here introduces a result of Paul not baptizing many people in Corinth. Because Paul had not baptized many Corinthian believers, nobody could say that he had baptized them in his own name.

you were baptized into my name: This clause is passive. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this clause without using a passive verb. For example:

I baptized you into my name

into my name: This phrase means to become the disciples of Paul. See the notes on “into the name of Paul” in 1:13c. For example:

as my disciples. (GNT)

1 Corinthians 1:16

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 1:10–17

There were divisions among the believers at Corinth. They divided into groups according to which leader they thought was the best one to follow. Paul taught them that Christ was not divided, so neither should his church be divided. His message was that all believers are united in Christ.

1:16

In 1:14 Paul said that he had only baptized two people in Corinth: Crispus and Gaius. Here he added that he had also baptized some other people. So this verse is a correction of what he had just written.

Many English versions have used parentheses here. However, the parentheses are not part of the original Greek text. You should indicate that this verse is a correction/addition, in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

(Oh yes, I also baptized the household of Stephanas. I don't remember baptizing anyone else.) (NLT)

I did of course baptize the household of Stephanas; I cannot think of anyone else. (REB)

1:16a

Yes, I also baptized the household of Stephanas;

- Oh yes, I did baptize Stephanas and his family also.
- Correction! I did also baptize Stephanas together with his household.

Yes: The BSB has inserted the word Yes in order to introduce the parenthetical comment. This verse gives some additional information that Paul had just remembered or been reminded of. Many other English versions do not insert this word. You should introduce the new information in a way that is natural in/for your language.

the household of Stephanas: This phrase refers to Stephanas and those who lived with him in his house.

1:16b

beyond that I do not remember if I baptized anyone else.

- I do not remember whether I baptized anyone else/ any others besides them.
- Right now I do not remember if I baptized any others of you there in Corinth besides them.
- I don't think that I baptized any other Corinthians besides them.

beyond that I do not remember if I baptized anyone else: Paul indicated that he thought he had not baptized any other Corinthian believers. If he had, he had forgotten about it. Other ways to translate this are:

but I do not remember that I baptized anyone else (NCV)

I cannot think of anyone else (REB)

1 Corinthians 1:17

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 1:10–17

There were divisions among the believers at Corinth. They divided into groups according to which leader they thought was the best one to follow. Paul taught them that Christ was not divided, so neither should his church be divided. His message was that all believers are united in Christ.

1:17a

For Christ did not send me to baptize,

- For the work that Christ sent me out to do is not baptizing believers.
- I did not baptize many believers. That is because baptizing believers is not the main work that Christ gave me to do as his apostle.

For: The conjunction For introduces the reason why Paul had only baptized a few Corinthian believers.

Christ did not send me to baptize: Paul was thankful that he did not baptize a lot of people because

baptizing people was not the main task that Christ gave him. He was not saying, however, that Christ had commanded him not to baptize people. It was just not his main responsibility.

send me: The focus of this clause is not on where Christ sent Paul but on what Christ sent Paul to do. The Greek text does not say where Christ sent Paul.

In some languages it may be necessary to specify where God sent Paul. In some languages it may be possible to be general, using "out/around." For example:

Christ did not send me out...

In other languages it may be necessary to be more specific. For example:

send me to Corinth/you

send me to faraway towns

send me to foreign places

1:17b

but to preach the gospel,

- Rather, he sent me to preach the good news.
- Instead, my main work as Christ's apostle is to tell people God's/the gospel message about Christ.

but: There is contrast here. The contrast is between what Christ did not send Paul to do and what Christ did send him to do. Some English versions do not use a conjunction here. For example:

Christ did not send me to baptize. He sent me to tell the Good News (GNT)

to preach the gospel: The phrase preach the gospel indicates that Christ sent Paul out to do something special for him. He sent Paul out to preach the good news about salvation to people.

General Comment on 1:17

In 1:17a-b Paul makes a negative statement first, and then a positive statement:

Negative: For Christ did not send me to baptize,

Positive: but Christ did send me to preach the Gospel.

However, in other languages it may be more natural to structure this verse differently. For example:

^{17a}For Christ sent me, not to baptize people, ^{17b}but to preach the gospel.

In other languages it may be more natural to reorder the clauses. For example:

^{17b}Christ sent me to preach the gospel. ^{17a}He did not send me to baptize people.

If you reorder the clauses, you need to be careful about how you translate 1:17c so that the verse will be natural in your language.

1:17c

not with words of wisdom,

- I do not preach the Gospel using eloquent words of human wisdom,
- I do not use the clever/persuasive speech of human wisdom to preach the Gospel.

not with words of wisdom: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as with words of wisdom is literally “in wisdom of speech/word.” There are two ways to interpret the phrase with words of wisdom here:

1. It means “wisdom which is expressed through speech.” This refers to the rhetoric and intellectual arguments of Greek philosophy. See Fee, p. 64, and Hodge pp. 17–18. For example:

eloquent wisdom (RSV) (RSV, NIV, GNT, NCV, ESV)

1. It means “wise speech”; that is, rhetorical skill, a clever way of talking. See Garland p. 56; Thiselton p. 143–45. For example:

clever speech (NET) (NASB, REB, NET, NLT, CEV, JBP)

In some languages there may not be much difference between these two interpretations. In some English versions it is difficult to be sure which interpretation is being followed (KJV, GW).

In some languages it is necessary to choose between the two interpretations. If that is true in your language, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It has slightly more support from commentaries and English versions. However, you may also use the interpretation that is followed by your own major language version.

wisdom: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wisdom is a key/important word in this section of 1 Corinthians (1:17–31). Here it refers to the philosophical arguments that the Greek people greatly admired.

1:17d

lest the cross of Christ be emptied of its power.

- so that the death of Christ on the cross would not lose its power/impact.
- I do not want to rob the message about the cross of Christ of its power to save people/you.
- I do not want to cause the message of Christ’s death on the cross to be ineffective/powerless/useless to those listening.

lest the cross of Christ be emptied of its power:

The Greek clause is literally “in order that the cross of Christ should not be emptied of its power.” The English word lest introduces a result that Paul wanted to avoid.

If Paul preached the gospel with words of human wisdom, the power/impact of the death of Christ on the cross would be less. Paul did not want people to believe the gospel message only because of words of human wisdom. He wanted to present the gospel fully and effectively. People should decide to follow Christ because of Christ’s death on the cross for them.

the cross of Christ: The phrase the cross of Christ literally refers to the wooden cross on which Christ died. However, in this context it is a figure of speech referring to Christ’s death for us. Another way to translate this phrase is:

Christ’s death on the cross... (GNT)

be emptied of its power: The phrase be emptied of its power here means “have its power taken away,” or “be made useless/powerless.” Another way to translate this phrase is:

is not robbed of its power (GNT)

This is a passive phrase. In some languages it may be more natural to translate it using an active verb. For example:

does not lose its power

does not become powerless

1 Corinthians 1:18

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 1:18–19

God made it possible for people to know him only through believing his message about Christ and his death. He has destroyed all human cleverness.

1:18a

For the message of the cross is foolishness to those who are perishing,

- ¶ For the message/talk about Christ dying on the cross seems like nonsense to people who are perishing.
- ¶ People who are headed toward ruin/destruction think/say that the message about Christ dying on the cross is foolish talk.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* introduces a more detailed explanation of what Paul said in 1:17. In 1:17 he said that Christ sent him to preach the gospel, the message about the “cross of Christ.” He also said that he did not preach “with words of human wisdom.” Beginning in 1:18, Paul explained why the message about the cross is so important, and why human wisdom is not important.

Several English versions do not translate this conjunction.

the message of the cross is foolishness to those who are perishing: In this verse part Paul talked about how unbelievers think about the gospel message. They think it is foolishness. Some other ways to translate this are:

The teaching about the cross is foolishness to those who are being lost (NCV)

The message about the cross doesn't make any sense to lost people. (CEV)

The message about the cross is nonsense to those who are being destroyed, (GW)

the message of the cross: The phrase the message of the cross refers to the gospel. It is the message that Christ died on a cross to save people/humans from sin and eternal death.

the message...is foolishness: People who are not saved think that the message about a crucified Savior is foolishness, or nonsense. Another way to translate this text is to use an adjectival phrase. For example:

a foolish message

a nonsensical message

However, in your language it may not be natural to say that a message is “foolish.” It may be more natural to say that the people who tell this message are foolish. For example:

a message that foolish people tell

those who are perishing: In 1:18a-b Paul divided people into two groups. The first group is made up of those who do not believe God's message about Christ. He called this group those who are perishing. These people, who are now separated from God, will one day be separated from God eternally. Some other possible ways to translate it are:

those who are headed for destruction (NLT)

those who are on the way to ruin (NJB)

people who will be forever separated from God

1:18b

but to us who are being saved it is the power of God.

- However, to us^(incl) who God is saving/delivering from sin, this message is God's powerful way to save us.
- But we^(incl) who have salvation know that God powerfully saves people through the message of the cross.

to us who are being saved: Here Paul wrote about the second group of humans. These are people who accept/believe God's message about Christ. God is already saving these people, and they are already on their way to live with God forever/eternally. God's power is now at work in their lives to forgive their wrongdoing.

God helps believers stop doing things that do not please him.

This is a passive clause. In some languages it is more natural to translate this clause using an active verb. For example:

to us^(incl) whom God is saving from sin

it is the power of God: The Greek text of this clause means “it is the means through which God works powerfully to save us^(incl).” The good news is that God has the power to save people from sin and eternal death through Christ’s death on the cross.

General Comment on 1:18

In this verse Paul indicated/contrasted the difference between people who are perishing, and people who are being saved. In some languages, it may be more natural to make these two groups of people the subjects of the sentences. For example:

^{18a}People who are perishing think that the message about Christ dying on the cross for them does not make sense. ^{18b}But we^(incl) whom God is saving know that this message is the way that God works powerfully in people’s hearts to save them.

1 Corinthians 1:19

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God’s wisdom.

Paragraph 1:18–19

God made it possible for people to know him only through believing his message about Christ and his death. He has destroyed all human cleverness.

1:19a

For it is written:

- For in the Scriptures God says:
- That agrees with what God said in his book:

For it is written: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as For it is written introduces a quotation from the Old Testament Scriptures. This quote from Isaiah 29:14 confirms what Paul had just said about those who are perishing. What Paul means is: What

I have said in 1:18 is true, because the Scriptures say the same thing. Paul quotes Isaiah 29:14 because that verse is a good example of the truth that people cannot save themselves by their clever ideas. The prophet Isaiah lived long ago, at a time when the nation of Israel was in danger and suffered from enemies who came into their country and attacked them. Instead of turning from their bad ways and trusting God to help them, they listened to their humanly wise men telling them to go and get help from the people Egypt. Because of that, God used their enemies to punish them for their bad ways. In that way, God “destroyed the wisdom of the wise”; that is, he caused the wise men’s advice to come to nothing. From this passage in the OT, Paul reminds the believers that they should not trust humanly wise thoughts and plans about how to become good in God’s sight and how to live in ways pleasing to him. Some other ways to translate this are:

For it says in the Scriptures

For God’s book says

The quote that follows is spoken by God. So another way to translate this is:

As God says in the Scriptures (CEV)

1:19b–c

In this quote from the OT there are two short sentences joined with the word “and.” The second sentence says the same thing as the first sentence using/ in different words. This is a common form of Hebrew poetry. Notice how similar these two sentences are. For example:

1:19b	1:19c
“I will cause	I will make
the wise men	the wise men
to lose their	unable to
wisdom;	understand.”
	(NCV)

You may translate each of these sentences separately as the BSB and most other English versions do. However, if the repetition does not sound natural in your language, you can combine these two sentences into one. See the General Comment at the end of the Notes for 1:19c.

1:19b

“I will destroy the wisdom of the wise;

- “I will ruin/destroy the wise thoughts of wise people.
- “I will show how worthless/foolish are the clever thoughts of clever people.

I will destroy the wisdom of the wise: This clause means that God will cause the plans of people who trust in human wisdom to fail.

In some languages it is not natural to talk about destroying wisdom. You may need to translate this without using the word wisdom. For example:

I will cause wise people to fail/not succeed.

Some people think they have wise/clever plans.
However, I will cause their clever plans to fail.

I will destroy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as I will destroy is from the same verb as “perishing” in 1:18a. It means ruining something completely, making it worthless and useless.

I: The pronoun, I, here refers to God. God is the one who says these words. You may need to make the subject explicit. For example:

God says, “I will destroy...”

the wisdom of the wise: The phrase the wisdom of the wise here means something like “the clever thoughts of people who think themselves clever/wise.” In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this abstract noun wisdom as a noun phrase. You may use “wise thoughts” or “clever plans.” For example:

the clever plans that clever people make

the wise thoughts of wise people

1:19c

the intelligence of the intelligent I will frustrate.”

- I will ruin the intelligent/clever plans of smart people.”
- I will show/prove that the clever ideas of clever people are not successful.”

the intelligence of the intelligent I will frustrate: This clause means approximately the same thing as 1:19b. The intelligent people are the same people who are called “wise” in 1:19b. Some other ways to translate the phrase the intelligent are:

the clever (RSV)

those who think they know so much (CEV)

clever people

I will frustrate: The Greek word that the BSB translates as I will frustrate means “to set something aside as useless.” Some other ways to translate frustrate are:

thwart (RSV)

bring to nothing (REB)

General Comment on 1:19

In some languages it may be more natural to combine these two verse parts. For example:

I will prevent the plans of those who think they are wise and clever from coming into effect.

There are people who say that they are wise. They think up clever plans. However, I will show that they are not wise. I will make their ideas fail.

No matter how wise some people think they are, I will always defeat/thwart them and their clever schemes/plans.

1 Corinthians 1:20

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God’s wisdom.

Paragraph 1:20–25

In this paragraph Paul talked more about foolishness and wisdom. The gospel message expresses God’s power and wisdom. For different reasons, both Jewish people and Greek people may reject it. However, to those who believe the message/gospel, it brings salvation from sin and death.

1:20a-c

Paul began this verse with three rhetorical questions. Each of these questions asks where some of the clever people of this world are. Paul used these rhetorical questions to emphasize that these clever people have failed. They are not able to know God through their cleverness.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- Use rhetorical questions. For example:

Where is the wise person? Where is the educated person? Where is the skilled talker of this world? (NCV)

- Use emphatic statements. For example:

The wise man has failed. The educated person has failed. The skilled talker has failed.

1:20a**Where is the wise man?**

- ¶ What is the position/status of wise people?
- ¶ So, wise people have no special advantage before God.
- ¶ The wise people have no special significance/importance according to God's thoughts.

Where is the wise man?: This is the first of the three rhetorical questions beginning with the word Where. Paul was not asking where these people were living. Paul used this rhetorical question to emphasize that people who the world thinks are wise have failed. They are not wise according to God's thoughts or plans. God has defeated them and their clever thoughts.

Paul also did not mean that being wise is of no value at all. He meant that worldly wisdom does not help a person to know God and his eternal plan.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. You may want to indicate the implied answer. For example:

What happened to those wise people? They failed!

- As a statement. For example:

The wise man has failed completely.

The wise man is foolish.

the wise man: The phrase the wise man refers to a person whom the people of this world admire as being wise. Paul did not talk about one wise man, but about all such people. In some languages it may be more natural to use a plural form. For example:

people who are wise

those wise people (CEV)

1:20b**Where is the scribe?**

- What is the position/status of expert people?
- Scholars have no special advantage before God.
- The scholars have no special significance/importance/have failed according to God's thoughts.

Where is the scribe?: This is the second of the three rhetorical questions beginning with the word Where. This functions as an emphatic statement that people who the world thinks of as educated people are foolish.

Some ways to translate this emphatic statement are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Where is the educated person?

What happened to the educated person?

- As a statement. For example:

The educated person has failed.

the scribe: There are two ways to interpret the word scribe here:

1. It refers to an educated professional person of any culture. See Thiselton p. 164. For example:

the educated person (NCV) (NCV, NIV, REB, GNT, GW, NLT)

1. It refers to a teacher of the Jewish laws. See scribe in the Gospels (e.g., Mark 1:22) and in KBT. For example:

the expert in the Mosaic law (NET) (BSB, NET, RSV, KJV, NASB, ESV, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) since it has slightly stronger support in the commentaries.

Paul was not writing to Jewish people here. He was likely writing in general terms about any educated professional person. Professional people, at that time, were all men. Another English example is:

man of learning (REB)

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this using a plural word. For example:

the scholars (NLT)

the experts

1:20c

Where is the philosopher of this age?

- What is the position/status of the skillful debaters of this world before God?
- The clever/skillful debaters/philosophers of this world have no special advantage before God.
- The clever/skillful debaters/speakers of this world have no special significance/importance/have failed according to God's thoughts.

Where is the philosopher of this age?: This is a third rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question to emphasize that skilled speakers are foolish compared to God.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Where are the skillful debaters of this world?
(GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

The skilled talkers of this world are foolish.

the philosopher: The Greek word which the BSB translates philosopher refers to a person who has learned to debate, talk and argue cleverly. He is clever especially about philosophical thoughts. Another English example is:

the debater

Paul was talking about debaters in general. In some languages it may be more natural to use a plural word. For example:

The skillful debaters (GNT)

of this age: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as this age refers to the time we live in before Christ returns. Other ways to translate this are:

of our time (GW)

this present age (REB)

this world order

General Comment on 1:20a-c

Some other ways to translate these rhetorical questions are:

- You can combine these three "Where" questions into one sentence. For example:

Where is your wise man now, your man of learning, your subtle debater of this present age? (REB)

- You may use one full sentence and two following sentence fragments:

So then, where does that leave the wise? or the scholars? or the skillful debaters of this world?
(GNT)

1:20d

Has not God made foolish the wisdom of the world?

- God has shown that the wisdom of this world is really foolishness.
- God has turned the wise plans/schemes of those worldly people into foolishness.
- God has shown that what the wise people of this world think is worthless/nonsense.

Has not God made foolish the wisdom of the world?:

This is also a rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question for emphasis. It can be understood as an answer to the three questions in 1:20a-c. Paul was saying that God himself has made foolish the wisdom of the world.

God does not make use of people's wise thinking in his plan to save people. His thoughts/plans cause wise

thinking to come to nothing. Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Hasn't God turned the wisdom of the world into nonsense? (GW)

- As a statement. For example:

God has shown that this world's wisdom is foolishness! (GNT)

the wisdom of the world: Paul here referred to the wisdom of the three groups of people that he had just mentioned. They are: the wise men, the scholars, and the debaters. It may be more natural to make the connection clear by referring to "those wise people." You can also be general at this point and use "all." For example:

God has made them all look foolish and has shown their wisdom to be useless nonsense. (NLT96)

the world: The Greek word that the BSB translates as world here refers to the moral system of the world. The world's moral system is opposed to God and Christ.

1 Corinthians 1:21

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 1:20–25

In this paragraph Paul talked more about foolishness and wisdom. The gospel message expresses God's power and wisdom. For different reasons, both Jewish people and Greek people may reject it. However, to those who believe the message/gospel, it brings salvation from sin and death.

1:21a

For since in the wisdom of God the world through its wisdom did not know Him,

- For God in his wisdom decided that wise people cannot know God by means of their own wisdom.
- For God very wisely made it impossible for people to know him fully through their own clever thoughts.
- For God wisely decided that this world's people would not be able to know/understand him personally/fully through their own clever thoughts/ideas.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces an explanation of verse 1:20. In 1:20 Paul said that God has shown that wise people's ideas are of no value in knowing God. In 1:21–25, Paul explained that God proved that the wisdom of people who do not know God/him is really only foolishness.

since: The conjunction since introduces a contrast between the methods God could have chosen to save people. God chose the method "wise" people did not expect. God did not choose to save people by letting them know him through their own wisdom (1:21a), instead he chose to save them through the foolish gospel message (1:21b).

Another way to translate this is:

For God in his wisdom made it impossible for people to know him by means of their own wisdom. Instead, by means of the so-called "foolish" message we preach, God decided to save those who believe. (GNT)

in the wisdom of God: The phrase in the wisdom of God means "it was God's wise plan." In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as a verb phrase. For example:

since God wisely decided

as God in his wisdom ordained (REB)

the world through its wisdom did not know Him: This clause indicates human failure. People did not find a way to know God through their own wisdom. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

the world was unable to recognize God through wisdom (NJB)

the world failed to find him/God by its wisdom (REB)

the world: The word world here refers to the world as a system opposed to God. In some languages this

figure of speech may not be natural. It may be necessary to explicitly indicate “people.” For example:

the people of this world

through its wisdom: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as through its wisdom is literally “through wisdom” (as in the RSV). Some English versions have added a word to indicate that Paul referred here to human wisdom. He did not mean the wisdom of God here. For example:

through its wisdom... (NIV)

their own wisdom (GNT)

through human wisdom (NLT)

did not know Him: The phrase did not know Him indicates that people of the world were unable to know God personally or fully.

1:21b

God was pleased through the foolishness of what was preached to save those who believe.

- It pleased God to save those people who believe the good news. He saves them through the foolish message that we preach.
- It pleased God to save from punishment those who believe the good news. He used the foolish message that we preach to do this.
- It pleased God to save those people who believe the message that we preach/announce. Some consider this message to be foolish.

God was pleased through the foolishness of what was preached to save those who believe: This text explains what God did since people could not come to know him through their own wisdom. Another way to translate this is:

Instead, by means of the so-called “foolish” message we preach, God decided to save those who believe. (GNT)

God was pleased: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as God was pleased here means that God decided to save believers. This phrase also implies that God actually did what he had decided to do.

through the foolishness of what was preached: This is a figure of speech called irony. Paul meant the opposite of the literal meaning of these words. He was

not saying that the message he and the other apostles preached was really foolishness. He meant that people who were not saved by the message thought it was foolish.

the foolishness of what was preached: This phrase also does not mean that people thought that the way or manner in which Paul preached was foolish. Rather, people thought that the content, the message itself, was foolish.

Translate this in a way that makes the meaning clear in your language. For example:

we preached what others call nonsense/folly

the message that sounds foolish (NCV)

the nonsense of the Good News we speak... (GW)

what was preached: Although this clause is passive, in some languages it may be more natural to translate it as active. For example, the GW says:

the Good News we speak

General Comment on 1:21a-b

Notice that in 1:21a-b there are two things that God decided. (a) God decided not to let people of this world use their own wisdom to learn about him, and (b) God decided to save only those people who believe the foolish message that was preached. Be sure to show the connection between them. For example:

God was wise and decided not to let people of this world use their wisdom to learn about him.

Instead God chose to save only those who believe the foolish message we preach. (CEV)

For God in his wisdom made it impossible for people to know him by means of their own wisdom. Instead, by means of the so-called “foolish” message we preach, God decided to save those who believe.

1 Corinthians 1:22

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 1:20–25

In this paragraph Paul talked more about foolishness and wisdom. The gospel message expresses God's power and wisdom. For different reasons, both Jewish people and Greek people may reject it. However, to those who believe the message/gospel, it brings salvation from sin and death.

1:22

In 1:21 Paul talked about "the world." In 1:22 he started writing about two different groups of the people in "the world": the Jewish people and the Greek people. Paul said "Greeks" to refer to Gentiles, all people who were not Jewish. Both the Jewish people and the Gentiles rejected Paul's message, but for different reasons.

1:22a

Jews demand signs

- Jews demand to see miracles.
- Jewish people demand that we^(excl) prove the gospel is true by doing acts of God's power.

In the Greek verse 1:22 begins with a conjunction that can mean either "for," "since," or "because." The BSB does not explicitly translate this word, but some English versions do translate it. For example:

For Jews demand... (RSV)

Paul used this connector to introduce an explanation. He wanted to explain why the Jewish people and the Greeks thought that the gospel was foolish. You may need to make that implied information explicit. For example:

God's way seems foolish to the Jews because they want a sign from heaven to prove it is true. (NLT96)

Jews demand signs: This clause means "The Jewish people ask/want us^(excl) to do miracles." The Jewish people asked Paul and the other apostles to do miracles to prove that their message was true. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

The Jews ask for miracles, (NCV)

Jews want miracles for proof, (GNT)

The Jewish people refuse to believe our^(excl) message unless they see miracles to prove it.

Jews: When Paul said "Jews demand signs," he did not mean that all Jewish people wanted signs. Rather, he meant that Jewish people typically/usually wanted proof. He meant that many of the Jewish people he had preached to wanted proof that the message was true.

The word Jews refers to the ethnic group that is descended from the Old Testament figure Jacob, also named Israel. Today Jewish people may be of any nationality (Israeli, Russian, American, etc.). Therefore you should not translate this in a way that would imply it referred only to the citizens/inhabitants of the present day country of Israel.

signs: The Greek word that the BSB translates as signs is a word that is often used in the four Gospels and Acts. This word refers to miracles, that is, acts of God's power. (See Matthew 12:38–39; 16:1–4.) This is the main word used in the Gospel of John for miracles.

The Jewish people believed that someone who could do miracles was sent by God. Therefore, they would believe what Paul/the apostles told them about Christ if they could do miracles to prove it. Again and again the Jewish people told Jesus they would not believe what he said unless he would show them a miracle. See Matthew 12:38–39; Luke 11:16; John 4:48; John 7:3. Here in 1 Corinthians 1:22, Paul says that they demanded the same thing of the apostles, Jesus Christ's representatives. They wanted to judge God's message for themselves, rather than let God's message judge them for their sins. Jesus did many miracles, but they were not the kind the Jewish people wanted to see and therefore they did not accept them as proof that he was the one God had sent to help them.

1:22b

and Greeks search for wisdom,

- And Greek people want wise thoughts.

- Greek people want to hear what they think is a wise message.

Greeks search for wisdom: The clause Greeks search for wisdom here means that Greek people were only willing to believe things that were explained wisely. They did not want to believe things that were not presented to them in the language of Greek philosophy. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

the Greeks want wisdom (NCV)

it is foolish to the Greeks, who seek human wisdom (NLT04)

Greeks: Here this word refers to people who spoke the Greek language. They also followed the Greek culture, as opposed to the Jewish culture. Paul was probably thinking of the Greeks as representatives of the Gentiles in general. The word “Greeks” is a translation of the Greek word “Helenes.” The word “Gentiles” is a translation of the Greek word “ethnos.” It is possible that Paul uses the word “Greeks” in 1:22 and 1:24 instead of “Gentiles” because Greeks were the people who loved philosophy and wisdom the most. Also, the city of Corinth was in the province of Achaia (Greece), and so most of the Corinthians believers may have been Greeks. Most English versions follow the Greek by using the word “Greeks” in 1:22 and 1:24, and “Gentiles” in 1:23. The KJV uses the word “Greeks” in all three verses, because it follows a different Greek text. Again, Paul did not mean that all Greeks followed human wisdom, but that most of them did.

1 Corinthians 1:23

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God’s wisdom.

Paragraph 1:20–25

In this paragraph Paul talked more about foolishness and wisdom. The gospel message expresses God’s power and wisdom. For different reasons, both Jewish people and Greek people may reject it. However, to

those who believe the message/gospel, it brings salvation from sin and death.

1:23a

but we preach Christ crucified,

- However, we^(excl) preach about the crucified Christ.
- Instead, we announce/proclaim the message that Christ died on the cross.

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between what the Jewish people and the Greek people wanted (1:22) and what Paul and the other Christian teachers preached (1:23a). The Jewish people wanted to see miracles as proof that Paul and the others said was true. The Greeks wanted to hear/listen to wise words. Instead, Paul just preached the simple message that Christ was crucified for their sins.

we preach Christ crucified: The verb crucified means that people nailed Christ to a wooden cross and left him there to die.

we: The pronoun we here refers to the apostles and other preachers of the gospel. It is in an emphatic position. Its position emphasizes the contrast between what the Jewish people and Greek people wanted, and what the apostles preached.

If there is a way for you to translate this emphasis in your language, you should use it here. For example:

As for us, we proclaim the crucified Christ (GNT)

Christ crucified: This is a passive clause. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

Christ was crucified (GW)

Christ was nailed to a cross (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

Christ died on a cross

people killed Christ by nailing him to a cross

1:23b

a stumbling block to Jews

- The gospel message is like a stumbling block to the Jews,
- To the Jews, the message of Christ’s crucifixion is like a stumbling block.

- The gospel message offends the Jews.

a stumbling block to Jews: In the Greek language, this phrase refers to something that causes offense or opposition and thus may stop someone from doing something. It means something that makes people angry. This phrase is a metaphor. A stumbling block is something in a person's path that causes him to fall down.

The message that Paul preached was like a stumbling block to the Jewish people. That was because they refused to believe that God would allow the Christ (Messiah) to be crucified. This was not what they expected would happen to their Messiah. So they refused to believe the gospel, and thus they were lost.

Some ways to translate this phrase that do not use this metaphor are:

This offends Jewish people... (GW)

a message that is offensive to the Jews... (GNT)

This is a big problem to the Jews, (NCV)

to Jews: In the Greek, these words to Jews are placed at the beginning of the clause. By doing this, Paul emphasized the different responses of the three different groups to the message that Christ was crucified for them.

If there is a way for you translate this emphasis in your language, you should use it here. For example:

To Jewish people the message that Christ was crucified is a stumbling block.

1:23c and foolishness to Gentiles,

- and Gentiles think that it is nonsense.
- And non-Jews think that our^(excl) message about Christ is the talk of foolish people.

foolishness to Gentiles: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as foolishness to Gentiles is literally "to Gentiles foolishness." There is some implied information here. The complete sentence would be: "the message that we preach about Christ being crucified sounds/seems like foolishness to the Gentiles." Some other ways to translate this are:

nonsense to the Gentiles (GNT)

makes no sense to people who are not Jewish (GW)

most Gentiles think it is foolish (CEV)

Gentiles: The word Gentiles means "people who are not Jewish." Here it means approximately the same as "Greeks" in 1:22b. The Gentiles could not understand how Christ's shameful death as a common criminal could help anyone at all.

1 Corinthians 1:24

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 1:20–25

In this paragraph Paul talked more about foolishness and wisdom. The gospel message expresses God's power and wisdom. For different reasons, both Jewish people and Greek people may reject it. However, to those who believe the message/gospel, it brings salvation from sin and death.

1:24a

but to those who are called, both Jews and Greeks,

- Yet to the people God has called, both Jews and non-Jews,
- But God has chosen some people to believe in him. Some of them are Jews, and some are Greeks/non-Jews.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but indicates a contrast between believers and non-believers. Those people whom God called thought differently about the Gospel message than other people. That was true for both Jewish people and Greek people. There were both Jewish and Greek believers.

to those who are called: Here the phrase who are called refers to people whom God had chosen to become his own, to become believers. See the Notes on called at 1:1a and 1:9.

This clause is passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

to those who are the called (NRSV)

- Use an active verb. The implied subject is “God.” For example:

to those whom God has called (NIV)

both Jews and Greeks: These believers included both Jewish people and the Greek/Gentile people.

1:24b

Christ the power of God

- Christ is the power of God
- Believers realize/know that Christ is God’s powerful way to save them,

1:24c

and the wisdom of God.

- and also the wisdom of God
- and that God showed he is truly wise by sending Christ to save them.
- and that God’s plan to save them through Christ is truly wise.

1:24b-c

Christ the power of God and the wisdom of God:

There is an implied verb here. The complete sentence would be: “Christ is the power and wisdom of God.” Christ is the power of God and the wisdom of God in the sense that he reveals God’s power and wisdom. Some other ways to translate this are:

Christ is the power of God and the wisdom of God (NET)

Christ reveals the power of God and the wisdom of God

this message is Christ, who is the power of God and the wisdom of God (GNT)

Paul indicated that in/through Christ God demonstrated/showed his power and wisdom. In some languages it is more natural to translate the abstract nouns power and wisdom as adjectives. For example:

Christ shows/demonstrates how powerful and how wise God is

Christ has shown that God is both powerful and wise

the power of God and the wisdom of God: Paul used the words of God twice here to add emphasis: “the power of God and the wisdom of God.” Both the power and the wisdom are from God. Paul showed how different people respond to the gospel message very differently.

A Jew or Greek, whom God has not called, thinks only human thoughts. Thus, they reject the gospel message when they hear it. But when people whom God has called hear it, they think like God does. They understand and believe God’s message.

the power of God: Paul used the same phrase, the power of God, in 1:18b. Here Paul indicated that Jesus Christ reveals God’s power. God worked powerfully through Christ’s death and resurrection to save men and women. When Christ died on the cross, he appeared weak, but he was actually demonstrating God’s power. Through Christ’s death on the cross, God saves people powerfully.

the wisdom of God: The phrase the wisdom of God here indicates that Christ reveals God’s wisdom. God’s way/plan of saving people through the death of Christ appears foolish, but it is actually wise. Christ was crucified to take/pay the punishment for our sins.

Another way to translate 1:24 is:

But God has called some people, both Jewish people and Gentiles, to be his own. When these people hear our message, they hear a message about Christ who reveals God’s power and wisdom.

1 Corinthians 1:25

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God’s wisdom.

Paragraph 1:20–25

In this paragraph Paul talked more about foolishness and wisdom. The gospel message expresses God’s power and wisdom. For different reasons, both Jewish people and Greek people may reject it. However, to

those who believe the message/gospel, it brings salvation from sin and death.

1:25a

For the foolishness of God is wiser than man's wisdom,

- For although God appears to have done something foolish, he is wiser than any human being,
- For although people might think God was foolish, he was wise. God's plan was, in fact, wiser than any human wisdom.
- Even though God's plan to redeem humans from sin seems like nonsense to unbelievers, it is wise. God's plan is wiser than anything human beings could plan.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For here introduces the basis for what Paul wrote in 1:24. Christ is the power and wisdom of God (1:24b-c) since the foolishness of God is wiser than the wisdom of men and the weakness of God is stronger than the strength of men (1:25a-b). The message of the cross that appears foolish and weak to unbelievers is actually wise and strong.

the foolishness of God is wiser than man's wisdom:

The phrase the foolishness of God here refers to what God did when he sent Jesus to die on the cross. Paul did not really mean that God did something foolish when he sent Christ to die on a cross. Paul was speaking ironically. Even though unbelievers think that the message about Christ is foolish, God is much wiser than all people. Some other ways to translate this are:

what seems to be God's foolishness is wiser than human wisdom (GNT)

even when God appears to be acting foolishly, he is still more wise than any man

the foolishness of God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the foolishness of God is more literally "the foolish thing of God." It refers to the thing that God did that people think is foolish. God sent his Son to die on the cross. This was something that people considered foolish.

is wiser than man's wisdom: This phrase in the Greek is more literally "is wiser than people/men." The BSB has added the word wisdom for stylistic reasons. In some languages it may be more natural to omit it. For example:

is wiser than men (RSV)

is wiser than people are

is wiser than any human being

1:25b

and the weakness of God is stronger than man's strength.

- and when God appears to be weak, he is still more powerful than any human being.
- Although unbelievers think that God was weak when he allowed Christ to die, he wasn't. God is much more powerful than the most powerful person.
- Even though unbelievers think that God was weak when he allowed Christ to be crucified. God showed/demonstrated his power which is greater/stronger than that of human beings.

the weakness of God is stronger than man's strength:

In the Greek this clause is more literally "the weak thing of God is stronger than people." This clause also refers to how God allowed/sent Christ to die on the cross to save mankind. This is another use of irony. Paul did not actually mean that God was weak.

It appeared that God was not powerful enough to prevent the soldiers from killing Jesus. However, what God did was more powerful than anything people could do. It was powerful enough to break the power of sin and death in order to save people. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

what seems to be God's weakness is stronger than human strength (GNT)

when God appears to be weak, he is still stronger than any man

1 Corinthians 1:26

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 1:26–31

In this paragraph Paul reminded the Corinthians that God did not choose them because they were wise or

important. Instead, he deliberately chose people of no importance in this world. So the Corinthians had nothing to boast about, except what Christ had done for them.

1:26a

Brothers, consider the time of your calling:

- ¶ My brothers and sisters, think about your status in this world when God called you to become his people/believers.
- ¶ My Christian friends, remember what your status/position in life was when God called/summoned you to follow Christ.
- ¶ My fellow believers in Christ, remember what you were like when God called/invited you to belong to/follow him.

In Greek, 1:26 begins with a conjunction. The conjunction introduces one basis for Paul's statement in 1:25. The foolishness of God is wiser than man's wisdom and the weakness of God is stranger than man's strength. One basis for Paul saying that is that God was foolish in calling the foolish Corinthian believers to become believers (1:26–31). According to human wisdom God should have called wise and important people to become believers. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction.

Paul also used this conjunction to introduce a new part/step/point of his argument. In the BSB this change is shown by beginning a new paragraph. You should begin this part of the argument in a way that is natural in your language.

Brothers: Paul often used a term of address (like Brothers) when he began a new topic. Here he introduced the topic of boasting only about God and never boasting about ourselves.

In the BSB, the word Brothers is first in the sentence. You should put/place it where it sounds natural in your language.

If a literal translation suggests that Paul was only addressing males, you may need to be more explicit or general. For example:

Brothers and sisters

Christian friends

consider the time of your calling: In Greek this clause is literally "Consider your calling." The KJV translates this as an indicative clause: "ye see your calling." It is alone in this among the major English versions, although it is supported by Barrett, p. 56. The

imperative is supported by Fee p. 79, Thiselton p. 179. Paul wanted the Corinthian believers to think about who they were when God called them to be his people. Specifically, he wanted them to remember that they had no high status or position in the world when God called them.

Most of the first Corinthian believers were uneducated people, poor people, and slaves. However, they had become proud. Paul wanted to remind them that they had no reason to be proud of themselves. The only reason they had to be proud now came from their relationship with Christ.

the time of your calling: The Greek phrase that BSB translates as the time of your calling is literally your calling. This phrase refers to the time when God called or invited the Corinthians to believe the gospel. In some languages, it may be more natural to state who called the Corinthians. For example:

when God called you

In some languages it may be necessary to say what God called the Corinthians to do. If that is true in your language, you may add the implied information. For example:

when God called you to be Christians (GW)

when God called you to follow Christ

1:26b

Not many of you were wise by human standards;

- Not many of you were what most people consider wise.
- According to human standards, not many of you were clever/wise.
- The people of this world thought/considered very few of you to be wise people.

Not many of you were wise by human standards: In Greek this clause indicates/shows what the Corinthian people were originally like according to human standards. When the Corinthian believers were called, not many of them were considered wise by other people. Another way to translate this phrase is:

From the human point of view, few of you were wise (GNT)

by human standards: In Greek this phrase is literally "according to the flesh." This phrase is often used to

contrast earthly, worldly standards with divine standards. Worldly people did not consider the Corinthian believers to be wise, influential, or noble people.

In some languages it may be more natural to make these people the subject of the sentence. For example:

The people of this world didn't think that many of you were wise. (CEV)

1:26c

not many were powerful;

- Not many of you were powerful people.
- Not many of you held power over other people.
- Only a few of you had positions of power/influence.

not many were powerful: The Greek word that the BSB translates as powerful refers to those people who were powerful in society and politics, the prominent leaders in Corinth. Many languages have idioms for influential people. Some languages use phrases such as "big men" or "people with big names." Some other ways to translate this are:

Not many of you had great influence. (NCV)

not many were influential (NIV)

You were not in powerful positions... (GW)

1:26d

not many were of noble birth.

- Not many of you were born into the higher classes of society.
- Only a few of you were born into important/noble families.

not many were of noble birth: The Greek word that the BSB translates as noble birth refers to people whose parents are members of the ruling classes. Some languages have a term for "nobles" or "high caste" that can be used here. Some other ways to translate this are:

not many were born to a privileged position (NET)

You were not...in the upper social classes. (GW)

Not many of you came from important families. (NCV)

You may have an idiom in your language for a privileged birth. If that is true you may use it here since Paul is talking generally. For example:

He was born with a silver spoon in his mouth.

General Comment on 1:26b-d

There are two ways to understand how the phrase "by human standards" is used:

1. It is connected only to the word wise. For example:

The people of this world didn't think that many of you were wise. Only a few of you were in places of power, and not many of you came from important families. (CEV) (GW, CEV, NCV)

1. It is connected to each part of the entire sentence, that is, wise, influential, and of noble birth. For example:

From the human point of view few of you were wise or powerful or of high social standing (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) since it has stronger support in the commentaries.

1 Corinthians 1:27

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 1:26–31

In this paragraph Paul reminded the Corinthians that God did not choose them because they were wise or important. Instead, he deliberately chose people of no importance in this world. So the Corinthians had nothing to boast about, except what Christ had done for them.

1:27–28

the foolish things of the world...the weak things of the world...the lowly things of the world: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as of the world occurs three times in verses 27 and 28. There are two different ways to interpret the phrase of the world here:

1. It means “as the people of the world think, by worldly standards.” See Ellingworth and Hatton p. 38, and Garland p. 76; Barrett p. 58. For example:

what the world considers nonsense... (GNT) (GNT, NJB, NET, REB, GW, NLT)

1. It means “that part of the world that is characterized by the following quality.” Thiselton p. 184. For example:

what is foolish in the world... (RSV) (RSV, BSB, NIV, KJV, NASB, ESV, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) for each of the three places where this phrase occurs. This is consistent with the negative use of the word world in this paragraph.

1:27a

But God chose the foolish things of the world

- But God chose what people of this world think of as foolish
- On the contrary, God chose what seems foolish in the opinion of this world's people.
- Instead, God chose what seems to be nonsense according to the people/human standards of this world.

But God chose: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But indicates a strong contrast here. One would humanly expect God to choose wise, influential and noble people to follow Christ. Instead, he chose the weak and uneducated people. This conjunction can also be translated using other words that indicate contrast. For example:

Instead, God chose... (NLT)

Yet...God has chosen... (REB)

Translate this in a way that is natural for your language so that this contrast is clear.

foolish things: This phrase has a general meaning. It can include foolish people as well as foolish thoughts/plans and objects. Therefore it can include plans, such as God's plan of salvation, and also objects, such as the cross of Christ. These seem foolish to unbelievers.

Try to use an expression that can include uneducated, unsophisticated, simple people, as well as objects or ideas. If you must choose between referring to people

or to things/objects, it is recommended that you refer to people. This best fits the context of this verse.

1:27b

to shame the wise;

- in order to humiliate wise people.
- He used foolishness to dishonor/disgrace the wise people of the world.
- God's purposely used foolish things in order to show everyone that those wise people do not have true wisdom.

to shame the wise: This is a purpose clause. God chose the so-called foolish things and people, in order to shame the wise. The phrase to shame the wise here means to show that the wise people are wrong.

Wise people may proudly think that God chooses or prefers them because they are wise. However, God instead chose people who are not wise. He chose those not wise so that wise people could not proudly say, “God chose me because I am wise.” Other ways to translate this clause are:

to put to shame the wise (CEV)

to put wise people to shame (GW)

the wise: The phrase the wise here refers to people who are wise and clever in their own eyes. They may also be wise in the eyes of the world. These may be people who view themselves as wise intellectuals. Another way to translate this is:

those who think they are wise (NLT)

1:27c

God chose the weak things of the world

- God chose what this world's people think of as weak
- God chose what seems powerless, unimportant according to our human standards.

the weak things: The phrase that the BSB translated as weak things here refers to both things and people that appear to be powerless. It is the opposite of “powerful” in 1:26c. It means people who are not in important positions. However, it does not refer to people who are physically weak.

Paul does not mean that the people God chose are really physically weak. He means that “God chose people whom most people in the world consider to be unimportant.” In other words, he means those “...

whom most people in the world do not consider to be leaders/prominent.”

See how you translated weak in 1:25b.

1:27d

to shame the strong.

- in order to shame people who are powerful.
- His purpose was to show that strong/powerful people do not have true strength/power.

to shame the strong: The phrase the strong here refers to strong people. In other words, those who are influential, prominent people, leaders in the community (1:26c). Paul was not referring to people who are physically strong. As in 1:27b, the verb shame here means to show that someone is in the wrong.

1 Corinthians 1:28

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God’s wisdom.

Paragraph 1:26–31

In this paragraph Paul reminded the Corinthians that God did not choose them because they were wise or important. Instead, he deliberately chose people of no importance in this world. So the Corinthians had nothing to boast about, except what Christ had done for them.

1:28a

He chose the lowly and despised things of the world,

- God chose what the people of the world think is not important and things that people do not honor,
- God chose what seems humble according to our human standards. He chose what is despised/scorned,

the lowly...things: As in 1:27c, you should translate the phrase lowly...things so that it can refer to both things and people. Paul here referred to things and people who are not esteemed or considered important.

and despised things: The despised things are the people, and things, which most people despise or look down upon. They are “scorned” or “not honored.”

General Comment on 1:28a

In some languages it may be more natural to separate this verse part into two phrases. For example:

He chose the lowly things of this world and the despised things... (NIV)

1:28b

and the things that are not,

- the worthless things,
- in other words, the things the world considers as nothing,
- what human standards consider valueless,

and: There is a textual problem here. Some Greek texts contain the word and. Some do not have the word. According to the UBS Greek text, the original Greek likely did not contain the word the BSB has translated as and. If your language would normally use a connecting word here, you may use it. However, it is not necessary. It is also possible to begin this verse part using other words. For example:

even things that are not,... (ESV)

the things that are not: The Greek phrase that the BSB translated as the things that are not literally is “the things that do not exist.” It refers to people, things, and objects that are considered worthless and of no value. There are different ways to interpret how this phrase functions in this sentence:

1. It is a summary description of the things that God chose. It is not a separate category. For example:

²⁷No, God chose...²⁸those who by human standards are common and contemptible—indeed those who count for nothing—to reduce to nothing all those that do count for something. (NJB) (REB, NASB, RSV, GNT, NJB, ESV, NLT, NET, CEV, NJB)

1. It refers to a separate group or category. For example:

He chose what the world thinks is unimportant and what the world looks down on and thinks is nothing (NCV) (BSB, KJV, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), Translate the phrase the things that are not so that it is understood to be a summary. It describes the things that God chose.

1:28c**to nullify the things that are,**

- in order to bring to nothing the things that are
- to abolish/do away with what is valued by the world.

to nullify the things that are: The Greek word that the BSB translates as nullify means “to put an end to something, to do away with it, replace it with something more powerful.” Here it indicates that God purposely ignores or puts aside what the people of this world think of as important. Thus, God shows what is really important to him. People of this world think it is important to be rich and powerful and clever. God says that those things are not important to him.

the things that are: In Greek this phrase is literally “the things that exist.” This is the opposite of the things talked about in the previous verse part as “things that are not.”

1 Corinthians 1:29**Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.**

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God’s wisdom.

Paragraph 1:26–31

In this paragraph Paul reminded the Corinthians that God did not choose them because they were wise or important. Instead, he deliberately chose people of no importance in this world. So the Corinthians had nothing to boast about, except what Christ had done for them.

1:29**so that no one may boast in His presence.**

- Therefore nobody can boast about himself to God
- His purpose is/was that nobody can brag/boast in his presence that God chose them because of something they did. For they did nothing to deserve it.

so that no one may boast in His presence: There are two ways to understand this clause:

1. it indicates God’s final purpose in choosing the weak and lowly things and people. For example:

God did all this to keep anyone from bragging to him. (CEV) (BSB, KJV, RSV, ESV, CEV, NCV, NIV, NASB)

1. It indicates the result of God’s choice of weak and lowly things and people. For example:

As a result, no one can brag in God’s presence. (GW) (GW, REB, GNT, NET, NLT04)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is supported by more commentaries. God chose the weak things of the world so that no one could boast about himself.

boast: This verb means “to brag/boast about something you yourself are or have done.” Paul said that no one should put confidence/trust in himself or be proud of himself and his own achievements. Everything is given to him by God. So, he should not be proud of himself. Even the union Christians have with Christ Jesus is given by God. For example:

So no place is left for any human pride in the presence of God. (REB)

God did this so that no one can be proud of himself in the presence of God.

God’s purpose in doing this was so that no one can boast in his presence.

in His presence: The phrase in His presence refers to God. For example: “before God,” “in God’s presence.” No one can truthfully say, with God listening and watching, that God has chosen him/her because of something he himself is or has done.

General Comment on 1:29

In some languages it is more natural to talk about boasting by using a direct quote. For example:

Therefore,...no one will be able to proudly say, with God looking on/listening, “God chose me because I am better than other people.”

1 Corinthians 1:30**Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.**

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were follow-

ing whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 1:26–31

In this paragraph Paul reminded the Corinthians that God did not choose them because they were wise or important. Instead, he deliberately chose people of no importance in this world. So the Corinthians had nothing to boast about, except what Christ had done for them.

1:30a

It is because of Him that you are in Christ Jesus,

- No, you are united with Christ Jesus only because of what God has done.
- God is the one who unites you to Christ Jesus.
- Instead, it is because of what God has done for you that you are in Christ Jesus,

It is because of Him that you are in Christ Jesus:

Paul explained that a person is not called to belong to Christ Jesus because he/she is an important person. Rather, God calls people to be in Christ. It is as a gift from God that we are joined to Christ.

because of Him: In Greek this phrase is literally “from him.” It is by God's choice and act that humans are joined to Christ.

in Christ Jesus: The phrase in Christ Jesus means “in union with Christ Jesus,” or “in fellowship with Christ Jesus.” This is a description of everyone who trusts Jesus and thus belongs to him. See the Notes on 1:2b and 1:4b.

1:30b-e

wisdom...righteousness...holiness...redemption:

There are different ways to understand how these four words relate to each other:

1. wisdom is a general word. The three other words are more specific. The BSB shows/indicates this by putting a colon at the end of 1:30b. In other words, Paul first says that Christ became “wisdom from God” for us. Then he explains what he means about wisdom by saying that Christ became righteousness, holiness, and redemption. For example:

Christ Jesus, who has become for us wisdom from God, in other words, our righteousness, holiness and redemption. (BSB, NIV)

1. Each of the four words represents a separate thing. For example:

He sent Christ Jesus to save us and to make us wise, acceptable, and holy. (CEV) (KJV, NASB, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This appears the most likely interpretation because of the way that the Greek sentence is constructed. The wisdom from God is God's plan to make his people righteous and holy and to redeem them.

1:30b

who has become for us wisdom from God:

- Christ Jesus is God's wise way to save us^(incl).
- It is through Christ Jesus that God wisely acted to save us^(incl).
- Christ Jesus is God's wise way to save people from sin and death.

who has become for us wisdom from God: There are two different interpretations of the Greek clause that the BSB translated as who has become for us wisdom from God:

1. It means “Christ Jesus became God's wise way to save us.” Christ is the way of salvation that God in his wisdom has given to us. See Fee pp. 85–87 and Garland p. 79: “The crucified Christ became the manifestation of God's wisdom, which here refers to God's long-established plan for the world's salvation.” For example:

who became for us wisdom from God (NET) (BSB, NET, NIV, NCV, NLT, ESV, NJB, KJV, NASB, NRSV)

1. It means that Christ Jesus made us wise. For example:

He sent Christ Jesus...to make us wise.... (CEV) (GNT, CEV, GW, REB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) because it has stronger support in English versions.

In 1:24c, Paul also said that Christ is the “wisdom of God.” You will probably want to translate the phrase wisdom from God here in 1:30b similar to the way you translated “wisdom of God” in 1:24c.

1:30c

our righteousness,

- That is, God put us^(incl) right,
- Christ made us^(incl) right with God,

our righteousness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as righteousness could also be translated “justification.” The phrase our righteousness here means that Christ made it possible for us to be justi-

fied. He made it possible for humans/mankind to be made right/just in God's sight. You will probably want to translate this using your key term for "justify." Christ Jesus shows us that God is wise by making it possible for us to become acceptable to God. He has put us in a right relationship with God. For example;

By him we are put right with God. (GNT)

1:30d holiness,

- we^(incl) became God's holy people,
- he set us^(incl) apart to be God's own people,

holiness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as holiness can also be translated as "sanctification." It means "to be set apart for God." Paul was saying that through Christ Jesus, God has set us apart to be God's own people. See notes on 1:2b and 1:2c. Other ways to translate this word is:

we...have been made holy... (NCV)

1:30e and redemption.

- and by him we^(incl) are redeemed.
- and he set us^(incl) free/freed us from sin/evil.
- and through Christ we are ransomed from sin and death.

redemption: The Greek word that the BSB translates as redemption means "to set someone free, often by paying a price." Here it indicates that Christ has set his people free by paying their penalty for sin. That is, Christ released them from sin. Christ did that by dying on the cross. Some other ways to translate this are:

our ransom from sin (GW)

we...are set free (GNT)

he freed us from sin (NLT)

General Comment on 1:30

In 1:30 Paul said that Christ Jesus "became" (past tense in the Greek) for us "wisdom," "righteousness," "holiness," and "redemption." Christ Jesus did these things for us in the past, when he became a man and died on the cross and rose again. However, we are experiencing these things at the present time. So some English versions use the present tense instead of the past. For example:

has become for us wisdom from God... (NIV)

we become God's holy people and are set free.
(GNT)

Use the tense that which tense would communicate the correct meaning in your language.

1 Corinthians 1:31

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 1:26–31

In this paragraph Paul reminded the Corinthians that God did not choose them because they were wise or important. Instead, he deliberately chose people of no importance in this world. So the Corinthians had nothing to boast about, except what Christ had done for them.

1:31a

Therefore, as it is written:

- So the Scriptures say:
- As a result we^(incl) should do what is written in God's Book:
- Thus we should do as a prophet wrote in God's book:

Therefore: This word introduces the result that should occur because of what Christ has done for the believer. Some other ways to translate this word are:

And so

As the result of all that Christ has done for us

as it is written: Paul used this phrase to introduce a quotation from the Old Testament. See 1:19a. In some languages it may be helpful to make it explicit that the words which follow are quoted exactly from the Scriptures. They are repeated from God's Word. For example:

as the Scriptures say

as a prophet wrote in God's book

1:31b

“Let him who boasts boast in the Lord.”

- “If someone boasts, he should only boast about the Lord.”
- “People should not brag about anything except what the Lord/Christ has done for them.”
- The only thing that someone can truthfully boast/brag about is how Christ/the Lord saved him/her from eternal death.

Let him who boasts boast in the Lord: This is a paraphrase/quotation from Jeremiah 9:24. It is a third-person command. In some languages it may be more natural to use the second person. For example:

If you are going to boast, the only thing you can boast about is what the Lord has done for you.

In this context boasting is spoken of in a positive/good way. It is good to speak well of what the Lord has done for us. However, your word for boast may only have a negative meaning. If that is true, then you may need to follow one of these examples:

So if you want to brag, do what the Scriptures say and brag about the Lord. (CEV)

People should not boastfully say, “This and this are the reasons why I am better than other people.” No, they should say, “God has done this and this to save me.”

General Comment on 1:31a-b

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the verse parts in this verse. For example:

^{31b}If someone wants to talk with pride, he should talk proudly only about/of what Christ has done for him, ^{31a}just as God's book tells us to.

1 Corinthians 2:1

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted

them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 2:1–5

In this paragraph Paul used himself as an example of someone who did not depend on false, human wisdom. When he preached to the Corinthians, he talked only about what the Lord Jesus Christ did to save them. He trusted in God's power to enable them to believe. He did not try to persuade them with clever speech.

2:1a

When I came to you, brothers,

- ¶ My fellow believers, when I arrived in your city,
- ¶ And as for me, my Christian brothers and sisters, when I came to Corinth,

When I came to you: In Greek this sentence begins with a word that means “And I (emphatic).” Paul was referring to the time when he had been in Corinth and preached to the Corinthians (see Acts 18:1–4). He used himself as an example of one who boasted only of what the Lord had done (1:31).

came to you: Consider whether it is more natural to translate this phrase using a word meaning came or a word meaning “went.”

brothers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as brothers here refers to all the believers in Corinth.

2:1b

I did not come with eloquence or wisdom

- I did not speak to you using important-sounding speech and I did not try to sound wise
- I did not use big/fancy words, and I did not talk to you as though I knew more than others

I did not come with eloquence or wisdom: Paul indicated that when he spoke in Corinth, he did not make eloquent, clever speeches or show off his learning. He used normal words and a normal way of speaking. In some languages it may be more natural to translate the phrase with eloquence or wisdom as a clause. For example:

I did not come speaking eloquently or showing off my great wisdom.

I didn't use big words or try to sound wise. (CEV)

eloquence or wisdom: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as eloquence or wisdom is literally “excellence of speech or [excellence] of wisdom.” “Excellence of speech” or eloquence refers to speaking in a

complicated and elegant way in order to sound clever and important. “Excellence...of wisdom” or wisdom here refers to human cleverness or learning. Another way to translate this is:

I did not use big words and great learning. (GNT)

2:1c

as I proclaimed to you the testimony about God.

- as I declared to you the mystery of God.
- as I preached to you God’s hidden/secret message.

the testimony about God: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the word that means “mystery.” For example:

the mystery of God (NRSV) (NRSV, GNT, NJB, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. Other manuscripts have the word that means “testimony.” For example:

the testimony of God (NET) (BSB, NET, NIV, KJV, RSV, NASB, ESV, REB, NLT96)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It is from the UBS Greek text. Thus the NRSV is used in the Display.

The Greek word that some versions translated as “mystery” is used in a special way here. It refers to a message or truth that God did not tell people in the past, but that he has now revealed to his people. Other ways to translate “mystery of God” are:

God’s secret message

God’s secret truth (GNT)

the message that God has revealed

the mystery that God has shared with us (CEV)

General Comment on 2:1a-c

In some languages it may not be necessary or natural to use the verb “come” twice in this verse. If this is true in your language, you may say it only once. For example:

When I came to you, my friends, to preach God’s secret truth, I did not use big words and great learning.

General Comment on 2:1b-c

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of phrases in 2:1b-c. For example:

^{1c}I did not come proclaiming the mystery of God to you ^{1b}in lofty words or wisdom. (NRSV)

^{1c}I did not come preaching God’s secret ^{1b}with fancy words or a show of human wisdom. (NCV)

1 Corinthians 2:2

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God’s wisdom.

Paragraph 2:1–5

In this paragraph Paul used himself as an example of someone who did not depend on false, human wisdom. When he preached to the Corinthians, he talked only about what the Lord Jesus Christ did to save them. He trusted in God’s power to enable them to believe. He did not try to persuade them with clever speech.

2:2a

For I resolved to know nothing while I was with you except

- For I decided that while I was with you I would not tell you about anything except
- I preached plainly because I had decided that while I was with you, I would not preach about anything except

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For here introduces the reason why Paul did not use eloquence and wisdom. He had decided to concentrate upon preaching about Jesus’ death on the cross.

I resolved to know nothing...except: The clause I resolved to know nothing means “I decided not to know anything.” This is a figure of speech called a hyperbole, that is, an exaggeration. Paul actually knew a lot about

a lot of things. However, he decided to not tell about them except for one important thing. He decided he would only talk/preach about Christ's death. Other ways to translate I resolved to know nothing...except are:

I decided to concentrate only on... (NLT96)

I made up my mind to speak only about... (CEV)

I decided to be concerned about nothing...except (NET)

I decided...I would forget everything except... (NLT04)

while I was with you: The phrase while I was with you refers to an earlier time when Paul was in Corinth preaching to the Corinthians.

2:2b

Jesus Christ and Him crucified.

- Jesus Christ and that he died on the cross.
- Jesus Christ and how he died on the cross to save all mankind.

Jesus Christ and Him crucified: This phrase tells the topic that Paul decided to talk about to the Corinthians. That topic was Jesus Christ. He especially wanted to talk about his crucifixion and its meaning. Other ways to translate this are:

Jesus Christ, who was crucified (GW)

except Jesus Christ and especially his death on the cross (GNT)

General Comment on 2:2a-b

In some languages it may be more natural to use a direct quote when talking about deciding something. For example:

^{2a}While I was there with you, I said to myself: "For the whole time I am here, I will only talk ^{2b}about Jesus Christ and how he died on the cross."

1 Corinthians 2:3

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 2:1–5

In this paragraph Paul used himself as an example of someone who did not depend on false, human wisdom. When he preached to the Corinthians, he talked only about what the Lord Jesus Christ did to save them. He trusted in God's power to enable them to believe. He did not try to persuade them with clever speech.

2:3

I came to you in weakness and fear, and with much trembling.

- While I lived with you, I was weak and very afraid and trembling.
- When I was/stayed there with you in Corinth, I felt weak. I was shaking/quiver with fear.

I came to you: As in 2:1a, the Greek text begins this sentence with a word meaning "And I (emphatic)," or "And I, for my part." In 2:1 Paul was again talking about himself. He described the qualities he did not use as he spoke to the Corinthians. Now he began to describe how he did speak to them. There are two ways to interpret the phrase I came to you:

1. It refers to the time when he was with them in Corinth. For example:

I was with you... (RSV) (KJV, NASB, RSV, ESV, NET)

1. It refers to the time when Paul first arrived there in Corinth. For example:

I came to you... (NRSV) (BSB, CEV, NIV, NRSV, GW, NLT, NCV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The context suggests that Paul was thinking of his entire stay with the Corinthians.

in weakness and fear, and with much trembling:

Paul said that he experienced three things: weak-

ness, fear, and much trembling. The English versions combine these words in different ways. Also, some versions translate all three words as nouns, and others translate one or more as a verb or an adjective. For example:

And I was with you in weakness and in fear and with much trembling. (NET)

I was weak and fearful and trembling. (NCV)

I was weak and trembled all over with fear. (GNT)

I felt weak and so afraid that I was shaking.

Use the combination of grammatical forms that is natural in your language.

in weakness: Paul says that when he was in Corinth, he was there in weakness. There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. Paul was talking about feeling inadequate or not able to do his job of preaching well.
2. Paul was talking about being physically weak.

Both of these interpretations are possible. From Acts 18:9-11, we know that when Paul was in Corinth he was afraid that he could not do his job of preaching well enough. From 2 Corinthians, we also know that some people in Corinth thought that Paul was not a good speaker. They thought that he did not speak in a powerful way. (See for example 2 Corinthians 10:10.)

And from his letter to the Galatians, it appears that Paul did have some physical ailment. So it would be good to make your translation general so that it includes all different types of weakness. In 2:3 Paul wrote about the strong negative feelings he had when he first arrived in Corinth. Why did he feel that way? There may have been several reasons. The most important reason was that he greatly respected God's message about Christ and knew that God wanted the Corinthians to believe that message. So since God sent him there to tell it, he had the big responsibility of telling it in such a way that God himself could cause them to believe it. Also he understood how much the Corinthians liked to hear clever ideas and talk. But that did not make them want to change their ways. And many of them did live in sinful ways. So he knew it would not be easy for anyone to tell God's message there. Also Paul was concerned/worried about other things at the time. He was probably remembering how much he and his fellow workers had suffered in Philippi and

Thessalonica and Berea, and how the people in Athens did not really respect his message. He may have felt alone in Corinth because he had sent Timothy back to Thessalonica to encourage the believers there and had left Silas behind in Berea for the same reason.

much trembling: The word trembling indicates that Paul felt afraid in some way. If a literal translation will not communicate this meaning, you may need to be more explicit. For example:

great trepidation (REB)

very nervous (GW)

1 Corinthians 2:4

Section 1:10-2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 2:1-5

In this paragraph Paul used himself as an example of someone who did not depend on false, human wisdom. When he preached to the Corinthians, he talked only about what the Lord Jesus Christ did to save them. He trusted in God's power to enable them to believe. He did not try to persuade them with clever speech.

2:4a

My message and my preaching

- When I talked/spoke to you and preached to you,
- When I told/preached to you God's message,

My message and my preaching: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as My message and my preaching is literally "my word/speech and my preaching/proclamation." In some languages it may be more natural to translate the two nouns as verbs. For example:

When I spoke to you and proclaimed my message to you.

Paul was not necessarily referring to two different things here. He was probably using two words in order to refer to both the content and the style of

his preaching. Here are some suggestions of how to translate this phrase so that it is clear that it refers to only one thing:

The word I spoke, the gospel I proclaimed... (REB)

When I preached my message to you...

2:4b

were not with persuasive words of wisdom,

- I did not tell you my own wise thoughts and I did not speak in clever arguments.
- I did not try to persuade/convince you to believe me by using wise thoughts and clever arguments.

were not with persuasive words of wisdom: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as persuasive words of wisdom is in different forms in different Greek manuscripts. Scholars do not agree about the exact form or meaning. Most major English versions follow the same text as the BSB. The UBS Greek NT gives this a D rating, and enclosed the word *logos* in square brackets. There are two ways to interpret the phrase persuasive words of wisdom:

1. It refers to using clever words and thoughts in order to persuade people. It refers to what one talks about. For example:

to convince by philosophical argument, (NJB)
(NJB, REB, NCV, KJV, GW)

1. It refers to talking in a clever or skillful way to try to persuade listeners. This means the way one talks. For example:

clever and persuasive speeches, (NLT) (NLT, CEV)

The BSB, GNT, RSV, NET, NASB, and ESV all use the phrase words of wisdom, which could mean either interpretation. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This agrees with what Paul said in 1:17c.

persuasive: The Greek word that the BSB translates as persuasive describes words that attempt to persuade or convince the listeners of something. Some English versions translate it as a verb and use a general object. For example;

persuade people (NCV)

sway you (REB)

General Comment on 2:4a-b

In some languages it may be more natural to translate the main verb in 2:4a-b as a negative. For example:

I didn't speak my message with persuasive intellectual arguments. (GW)

2:4c

but with a demonstration of the Spirit's power,

- Instead, the Holy Spirit showed his power.
- Rather, the Holy Spirit showed you in a powerful way that the message I preached was true.
- No, you believed the message I preached because God's Spirit persuaded/convicted you with his great power that it was true.

but with a demonstration of the Spirit's power: This verse part indicates how Paul did preach/speak his message to the Corinthians. In some languages it may be necessary to add this implied information here. For example:

When I preached to you, I did not try to convince you with clever arguments. Instead, I preached to you with a demonstration of the Spirit's power.

my teaching and message were not delivered with skillful words of human wisdom, but they were delivered with convincing proof of the power of God's Spirit.

The word demonstration can also be translated as "proof" or "evidence." In many languages it may be more natural to translate this word as a verb. For example:

the Spirit's power demonstrated/proved

the Spirit displayed his power

The Spirit by his power demonstrated that Paul's message was true and that it was from God. Paul did not try to get people to believe him by speaking in clever ways or speaking about clever ideas. When he spoke, it was the Spirit's power that caused the Corinthian people to believe.

1 Corinthians 2:5

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 2:1–5

In this paragraph Paul used himself as an example of someone who did not depend on false, human wisdom. When he preached to the Corinthians, he talked only about what the Lord Jesus Christ did to save them. He trusted in God's power to enable them to believe. He did not try to persuade them with clever speech.

2:5a

so that your faith would not rest on men's wisdom,

- so that you would believe not just because I told a wise message.
- I did not want you to believe God's message because someone convinced you to believe it with clever thoughts/ideas.
- I did not want your faith in God's message to be based on a clever way of speaking.

so that your faith would not rest on men's wisdom:

This clause probably gives the purpose for Paul's decision about his preaching in verses 1–4. Paul did not want the Corinthians to believe the gospel because of his own clever words. That is why he preached plainly about Christ. Other ways to translate this clause are:

so that your faith would not be based on human wisdom (NET)

so that your faith should depend not on human wisdom (NJB)

so that your faith would not be built on human wisdom

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this clause as a complete sentence. For example:

I preached plainly so that your faith would not be based on human wisdom.

I preached Christ plainly so that you would not trust him because of human wisdom.

2:5b

but on God's power.

- Rather, I wanted you to believe because of God's power.
- Instead, I wanted you to believe in God's message because God had worked powerfully among you.

but on God's power: Some words from the previous clause are implied but not repeated here. It may be more natural in your language to include some or all of the implied words. For example:

but instead your faith would be based on God's power

Paul wanted the Corinthians to believe the gospel because of God's power in their lives/hearts. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this clause as a complete sentence. For example:

I wanted you to trust in Christ only through the power of God.

General Comment on 2:5a-b

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder these clauses. You may need to first say what Paul did want and then what he did not want. For example:

This was so that your faith in Christ would be through God's power and not through human wisdom.

1 Corinthians 2:6

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 2:6–13

In this paragraph Paul wrote about God's wisdom, that is, his wise plan to send Christ to save people. Those who follow or depend on human thinking/wisdom do not want to hear or accept God's message. It is only

God's Spirit who can cause people to know and accept God's thoughts/plans as wise. The Spirit makes God's thoughts known only to people/believers who are under the Spirit's control. These believers try to obey the Spirit in following God's ways.

2:6a

Among the mature, however, we speak a message of wisdom—

- ¶ But when we^(excl) are with mature believers, we^(excl) do tell them a wise message.
- ¶ However, even though I did not use clever words then, when we^(excl) are with believers, we do speak about wise things.

the mature: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the mature literally refers to adults, that is, people who are physically grown up. However, Paul used this phrase in a figurative sense here to refer to people who are spiritually grown up. They have enough spiritual maturity to understand and accept the message of Christ.

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate the type of maturity Paul is talking about here. For example:

those who are spiritually mature (GNT)

mature believers (NLT)

those who are mature in their faith (CEV)

however, we speak: Paul now told the Corinthians more about how he did preach the gospel message.

There are two ways to interpret the pronoun we here:

1. It means "we^(excl) apostles" or "we^(excl) people who preach the gospel." See Garland p. 91: "Paul may use an editorial 'we' here to refer to his own preaching... or may refer collectively to his fellow apostles and the unanimity of the apostolic witness... It is more likely, however, that he attests to the unanimity of the Christian witness." (BSB, NIV, NJB, KJV, NASB, RSV, ESV, NET, GW, CEV)
2. It means "I." See Fee p. 101 "his common editorial 'we.'" (GNT, REB, NLT, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) since it has stronger support in the commentaries.

If your language has both inclusive and exclusive types of we, you will want to use the exclusive we here.

a message of wisdom: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a message of wisdom is literally just wisdom. In this context it refers to true wisdom, God's wisdom. God's wisdom is displayed in his plan to save people through the death of his son Christ Jesus.

2:6b

but not the wisdom of this age

- It is not the kind of wise message that humans think up in today's world.
- Our message is not from the thoughts/ideas which the people of this world think up.

2:6c

or of the rulers of this age,

- And it is not the wise message that comes from those who are rulers in this present world.
- These are not the kind of thoughts which today's rulers/leaders are thinking.

the rulers of this age: There are two ways to understand the phrase the rulers of this age here:

1. It refers to human rulers, such as kings and governors (see Acts 4:26). See Fee pp. 103–4; Garland pp. 93–94.
2. It refers to supernatural rulers, such as the devil and his demons (see Ephesians 2:2, 6:12). See Conzelmann p. 61.

It is recommended that you translate this phrase so that it refers to rulers of the world today. This phrase refers to human leaders to whom the Corinthians would naturally defer. It is possible that Paul knew/understood that these rulers were under the influence of supernatural evil beings. However, he was not explicitly saying that at this point.

of this age: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as of this age means "of this present world order." Refer to your translation of 1:20c. The same phrase occurs in verse 1:20c. Check your translation of that verse. An example is:

to the governing powers/government/rulers of this present time...

2:6d

who are coming to nothing.

- All of those rulers will soon lose their power.
- All those rulers will soon no longer have any authority/importance/significance.

who are coming to nothing: The Greek word that is translated coming to nothing is the same word that Paul used in 1:28d. In that verse it was translated as

“nullify.” Here Paul was indicating that the rulers of this world were losing their power. It might appear that they were very powerful. However, it was certain that they would eventually/soon become powerless. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

who are doomed to perish (NRSV)

they will certainly be destroyed

who are losing their power (NCV)

1 Corinthians 2:7

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God’s wisdom.

Paragraph 2:6–13

In this paragraph Paul wrote about God’s wisdom, that is, his wise plan to send Christ to save people. Those who follow or depend on human thinking/wisdom do not want to hear or accept God’s message. It is only God’s Spirit who can cause people to know and accept God’s thoughts/plans as wise. The Spirit makes God’s thoughts known only to people/believers who are under the Spirit’s control. These believers try to obey the Spirit in following God’s ways.

2:7a

No, we speak of the mysterious and hidden wisdom of God,

- No, the wise message we^(excl) tell is God’s. It concerns his secret plan which he did not previously reveal to mankind/anyone.
- Instead, we^(excl) talk about the wise plan that God formed/made. Until now no one knew about it because God did not make it known/reveal it to anyone.

No: The BSB uses the word No to translate a strong contrast word in the Greek text. Paul used the word to indicate the contrast between wisdom of this age and the wisdom of God. Other ways to translate this word are:

But (RSV, NRSV, KJV, ESV, NASB)

Instead (NET)

Several English versions do not explicitly translate this word. You should translate this word in a way that is natural in your language.

we speak: The pronoun we here probably refers to Paul and the other apostles and Christian teachers, as in 2:6a. Follow the same interpretation here that you did there.

the mysterious and hidden wisdom of God: The Greek text that the BSB translates as the mysterious and hidden wisdom of God is more literally “the hidden wisdom of God in a mystery.” The word God is emphatic. Paul was not speaking about the wisdom that is from the world, but about wisdom that is from God.

The word mysterious here refers to something that no one can know unless God reveals it to them. The mysterious...wisdom of God means “God’s secret plan that he wisely made/formed.” Another example is, “the plan that God made with his wisdom, and which no one fully knew about.” Paul was referring to God’s plan to send Christ to die on the cross to save his people. Other ways to translate this are:

God’s wisdom, secret and hidden, (NRSV)

a secret and hidden wisdom of God, (ESV)

hidden wisdom of God: This phrase says something more about God’s wise plan to help mankind. The way it was hidden is that God had not revealed or told it to people before this. In some languages it may not be possible to use the word hidden in this figurative sense. You may need to make this explicit. For example:

this wisdom was unknown to people

God had not revealed this wise plan to people

2:7b

which He destined for our glory before time began.

- We^(excl) tell about God’s plan to give us^(incl) a glorious/wonderful life. Before God made the world he decided to do this for us.

- It is what God long ago decided to do even before he started to make anything. And it includes all the surpassingly good things he intends to do for us^(incl).

which He destined: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as destined means “to decide something ahead of time.” Other ways to translate this phrase are:

God decided (CEV)

he had already chosen (GNT)

for our glory: The phrase for our glory explains God’s purpose or intention. God formed his wise plan in order to give glory to us, that is, to believers.

our: The Greek pronoun that the BSB translates as our refers here to Paul and his readers, and to everyone who believes in the Lord Jesus Christ. If you must choose between an inclusive and an exclusive pronoun, you should use an inclusive pronoun here.

glory: Here glory refers to three things. It refers to the joy and honor of knowing God, to being made like Jesus Christ, and to being in his presence. For example:

for our joy and honor

It may not be natural for your language to use an abstract noun here. If that is true, you may need to translate glory as a verb or an adjective. For example:

so that we should be glorified

to make us glorious

before time began: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as before time began is literally “before the ages.” It indicates that God thought up his wise plan before he started to make this world. Another way to translate this is:

even before the world was made (GNT)

1 Corinthians 2:8

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most.

Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God’s wisdom.

Paragraph 2:6–13

In this paragraph Paul wrote about God’s wisdom, that is, his wise plan to send Christ to save people. Those who follow or depend on human thinking/wisdom do not want to hear or accept God’s message. It is only God’s Spirit who can cause people to know and accept God’s thoughts/plans as wise. The Spirit makes God’s thoughts known only to people/believers who are under the Spirit’s control. These believers try to obey the Spirit in following God’s ways.

2:8a

None of the rulers of this age understood it.

- No leader here on earth understood God’s plan,
- Not one of the rulers in this present age knew about God’s clever/wise plan.

None of the rulers of this age understood it: The phrase None of the rulers of this age understood it indicates that the human spiritual/religious leaders did not understand God’s wisdom, that is, God’s wise plan. Another way to translate this is:

None of the rulers of this world knew this wisdom.
(GNT)

the rulers of this age: The phrase the rulers of this age refers to the same rulers as in 2:6c. They are human authority figures, leaders, and powerful people.

2:8b-c

if they had, they would not have crucified the Lord

of glory: Paul here was talking about something that did not happen. Jesus was crucified since they did not understand God’s plan. In some languages it may be necessary to be more explicit. For example:

if those rulers had understood God’s plan, they would not have crucified the Lord of glory. But they did not understand it, and so they did crucify him.

2:8b

For if they had,

- because if they had understood what God was doing,
- It is clear that they did not understand his plan, because if they had known what God was planning to do,

For: This Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For here introduces Paul's explanation of how we know that the rulers of this world did not understand God's plan.

2:8c

they would not have crucified the Lord of glory.

- they would not have crucified the Lord, who is glorious/great.
- they would not have nailed our glorious/powerful Lord to a cross to kill him.

the Lord of glory: The phrase the Lord of glory refers to the Lord Jesus Christ. The word glory here refers to Christ's greatness and power, his majestic radiance. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the glorious/great/majestic Lord

our Lord who is so glorious/powerful

1 Corinthians 2:9

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 2:6–13

In this paragraph Paul wrote about God's wisdom, that is, his wise plan to send Christ to save people. Those who follow or depend on human thinking/wisdom do not want to hear or accept God's message. It is only God's Spirit who can cause people to know and accept God's thoughts/plans as wise. The Spirit makes God's thoughts known only to people/believers who are under the Spirit's control. These believers try to obey the Spirit in following God's ways.

2:9a

Rather, as it is written:

- But, as the Scriptures tell us^(incl),
- It is as was written in the Scriptures,

Rather: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Rather here probably indicates a contrast with 2:8a. The rulers of the world did not understand God's plan, but God revealed it to those who love him (2:10a).

The quotation that immediately follows is thus parenthetical. If it is unnatural in your language to have a contrasting conjunction before this parenthetical quotation, you may leave it untranslated. For example,

It is just as the Scriptures say...

as it is written: The phrase as it is written generally introduces a quotation from the Old Testament Scriptures. Here, however, it does not introduce a direct quote from any single OT passage. Paul probably put together these thoughts from several verses, such as the Greek translation of Isaiah 64:4 and 65:17. See Thiselton pp. 250–52 for a discussion of this issue. Since this is not a specific quotation from one passage, it may be best not to use quotation marks. However, you need to indicate that Paul was referring to some written passages of Scripture. For example:

Scripture speaks of 'things beyond our seeing...' (REB)

2:9b

"No eye has seen, no ear has heard,

- "No one has ever seen or heard about it.
- "Nobody has ever seen or heard about it.

No eye has seen: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as No eye has seen is a figure of speech that means "No person has ever seen." The object of the verb is given in 2:9c. In some languages it may be more natural to use a general object here. For example:

No one has ever seen this (NCV)

no ear has heard: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as no ear has heard means "no person has ever heard." It refers to hearing news or information about something. In some languages it may be more natural to use an object here. For example:

and no one has ever heard about it (NCV)

2:9c

no heart has imagined, what God has prepared for those who love Him."

- No one has ever imagined/thought of all of the things that God has prepared for the people who love him.
- Nobody has even dreamed of/imagined the wonderful things that God has planned to do for us^(incl), the people who love him.

no heart has imagined: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as no heart has imagined is more literally “it has not come upon the heart of man.” In Paul’s time people thought that the heart was the center of their inner life. They considered the heart to be the source of thinking and feeling. Therefore this phrase means that nobody had ever thought about God’s wise plan before God revealed it to people. You should translate this phrase in a way that is natural in your own language. For example:

No one has ever imagined... (NCV)

what no one ever thought could happen... (GNT)

what God has prepared for those who love Him:

This phrase tells what no one had ever seen, heard, or thought before. It is implied that the things God has prepared are wonderful and too good to imagine. In some languages it may be more natural to make this explicit. For example:

the wonderful things that God has prepared for those who love him

the very good things God has made ready for those who love him

General Comment on 2:9b-c

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of 2:9b-c. For example:

^{9c}What God has planned for those who love him is better than ^{9b}anyone has ever seen or heard or imagined.

^{9c}What God has planned for people who love him is more than ^{9b}eyes have seen or ears have heard. It has never even entered our minds! (CEV)

1 Corinthians 2:10

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted

them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God’s wisdom.

Paragraph 2:6–13

In this paragraph Paul wrote about God’s wisdom, that is, his wise plan to send Christ to save people. Those who follow or depend on human thinking/wisdom do not want to hear or accept God’s message. It is only God’s Spirit who can cause people to know and accept God’s thoughts/plans as wise. The Spirit makes God’s thoughts known only to people/believers who are under the Spirit’s control. These believers try to obey the Spirit in following God’s ways.

2:10a

But God has revealed it to us

- But these are the very things that God has now revealed to us^(incl)
- But now God has revealed these very things to us^(incl) who believe.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrast. The contrast is between what unbelievers are not able to understand and what God revealed to believers through his Spirit. God had allowed believers to know what he has prepared for those who love him. In some languages it may not be natural to have a conjunction here as well as in 2:9a. It may be more natural to leave it untranslated here. For example:

God has revealed those things to us by his Spirit.
(GW)

God has revealed it to us: The BSB has used the pronoun it to refer to “God’s secret wisdom” as in 2:7. It also refers to the things that “God has prepared for those that love him” in 2:9.

us: The Greek pronoun that the BSB translates as us here refers to Paul and the other apostles, and also to all believers. God had revealed the gospel to Paul and the apostles first, but then they shared this gospel with the Corinthians. Through the Holy Spirit they had all come to know the good things that God was preparing for them. You may need to choose between an inclusive and an exclusive pronoun us here. It is recommended that you use an inclusive pronoun.

2:10b

by the Spirit.

- by sending his Spirit.
- He sent the Holy Spirit to reveal these things to us^(incl).

the Spirit: The word Spirit refers to the Holy Spirit. Some other ways to translate this are:

God's Spirit

the Holy Spirit

2:10c

The Spirit searches all things,

- The Holy Spirit looks into/examines everything,
- The Spirit knows all about everything.

In the Greek text, 2:10c begins with a conjunction. It introduces Paul's basis for saying that God's Spirit was the one who had revealed God's hidden wisdom. The BSB and some other English versions do not translate this conjunction.

Here is a way to translate this conjunction:

For (NET, NLT)

You should introduce this part of the verse in a way that is natural in your language.

The Spirit searches all things: In 2:10a-b, Paul said that God revealed his wise plan through the Holy Spirit. Here in 2:10c-11, Paul explained how the Spirit knows God's plan and reveals it.

searches: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as searches is figurative. It means that he knows all about everything. He is aware of everything. It does not mean that the Spirit goes around looking for information. He is not "searching" as if there were things he was trying to find out. For example:

For nothing is hidden from the Spirit. (JBP)

2:10d

even the deep things of God.

- even God's most secret thoughts/plans.
- Indeed, he even knows those things about God that are hardest to understand.

even the deep things of God: The phrase deep things of God refers to the hardest things there are to know about God. It includes everything about God's nature, actions and thoughts. The Holy Spirit knows all about "the mysterious and hidden wisdom of God" mentioned in (2:7a). He also knows all about "what God has prepared for those who love him" mentioned in (2:9c). Here is another way to translate this:

even the depths of God's own nature (REB)

1 Corinthians 2:11

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 2:6–13

In this paragraph Paul wrote about God's wisdom, that is, his wise plan to send Christ to save people. Those who follow or depend on human thinking/wisdom do not want to hear or accept God's message. It is only God's Spirit who can cause people to know and accept God's thoughts/plans as wise. The Spirit makes God's thoughts known only to people/believers who are under the Spirit's control. These believers try to obey the Spirit in following God's ways.

2:11a-b

the thoughts of man...the thoughts of God: The Greek phrases that the BSB translates as the thoughts of man and the thoughts of God are literally "the [things] of a person" and "the [things] of God." They therefore have a very general meaning. They cover both human and divine identity, nature, thoughts, plans, and purposes. The GNT has translated this verse in a way that covers all these areas:

It is only our own spirit within us that knows all about us; in the same way, only God's Spirit knows all about God. (GNT)

Other English versions focus on only one or the other aspect of what is known. For example:

After all, is there anyone who knows the qualities of anyone except his own spirit, within him; and in the same way, nobody knows the qualities of God except the Spirit of God. (NJB)

You are the only one who knows what is in your own mind, and God's Spirit is the only one who knows what is in God's mind. (CEV)

Try to translate these phrases in a broad and general way. If that is not possible or natural in your language, follow the BSB or a similar example.

2:11a

For who among men knows the thoughts of man except his own spirit within him?

- For who knows all about a person's thoughts? Only that person's spirit knows his own thoughts.
- Consider this: the only one who can know what is in someone's heart is that person himself.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translated as *For* introduces the grounds for Paul's statements in 2:10a-b. Paul said that God has revealed the mystery to us by his Spirit. That statement explains how we can know the deep things of God.

who among men knows the thoughts of man except his own spirit within him?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question to emphasize that no one knows a person's thoughts except his or her own spirit. No one can know what another person is thinking about unless that person tells someone. Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

what person knows a man's thoughts except the spirit of the man which is in him? (RSV)

- As a question with the answer. For example:

Who knows the thoughts that another person has? Only a person's spirit that lives within him knows his thoughts. (NCV)

- As a statement. For example:

It is only our own spirit within us that knows all about us. (GNT)

You should translate this rhetorical question in the way that is most natural in your language for expressing emphasis.

men...man...his...him: The Greek words that the BSB translates as *men*, *man*, *his*, and *him* here refer to human beings, people in general. Paul was referring to anyone and everyone. Therefore the pronouns "our" and "us" may be used. For example:

It is only our own spirit within us that knows all about us, (GNT)

Some versions use second-person pronouns. For example:

You are the only one who knows what is in your own mind (CEV)

except his own spirit within him: The word *spirit* here means a person's inner being, his own spiritual nature. A person knows his own thoughts, attitudes, intentions. Only the person himself can tell others those things. It may not be natural in your language to say that a person's spirit knows what he is thinking. You may need to use an idiom or some other way to tell about a person's inner being. For example:

The only one who knows what is in a person's heart is that person himself.

2:11b

So too, no one knows the thoughts of God except the Spirit of God.

- In the same way, the only one who knows the thoughts/plans in God's heart is God's Spirit.
- It is the same with/concerning God. No one understands/knows about God's thoughts except God's Spirit.

So too, no one knows the thoughts of God except the Spirit of God: Here Paul used an expression similar to 2:11a to indicate the close similarity between how a person's spirit knows that person's thoughts and how God's Spirit knows God's thoughts. However, he was not saying that the relationship is exactly the same. Some other ways to translate this are:

So too, no one knows the things of God except the Spirit of God. (NET)

and no one can know God's thoughts except God's own Spirit (NLT)

except the Spirit of God: God's own Spirit is the only one who knows God's nature, thoughts, and intentions. Therefore, only God's Spirit can cause people to know God. God's Spirit helped the first believers understand God's thoughts. He also helps all believers understand God's thoughts.

General Comment on 2:11a-b

In many languages it is not possible to use the same word for a person's "spirit" (2:11a) and God's Holy "Spirit" (2:11b). In some languages the clearest way to

translate “the man’s spirit within him” is “the person himself.” For example:

Only the person himself can know the thoughts in his own mind. So also only God’s own Spirit can know what is in God’s mind.

You are the only one who knows what is in your own mind, and God’s Spirit is the only one who knows what is in God’s mind. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 2:12

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God’s wisdom.

Paragraph 2:6–13

In this paragraph Paul wrote about God’s wisdom, that is, his wise plan to send Christ to save people. Those who follow or depend on human thinking/wisdom do not want to hear or accept God’s message. It is only God’s Spirit who can cause people to know and accept God’s thoughts/plans as wise. The Spirit makes God’s thoughts known only to people/believers who are under the Spirit’s control. These believers try to obey the Spirit in following God’s ways.

2:12a

We have not received the spirit of the world,

- We^(incl) have not received the same spirit/thoughts that the people in this world have received.
- God did not give us^(incl) the same thoughts that this world’s people have.

In Greek, this verse part is connected to the previous verse part with a conjunction. Several English versions translate this conjunction as “Now.” For example:

Now we have received... (RSV)

Some other versions do not explicitly translate the conjunction. For example:

We have not received... (NIV, GNT)

Paul used this conjunction to introduce a further step in his argument. You should introduce this verse part in a way that is natural in your language, for introducing an additional part of an argument. Another way to translate this is:

And we have received... (NLT)

We have not received the spirit of the world: This clause indicates that Paul and others who have God’s Spirit do not think in the same way. Unbelievers can think only according to human wisdom. They have different attitudes and values.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

We have not received the same mind/thoughts that the other people of this world have received.

We have not received: The phrase We have not received can also be translated as “we have not been given.” In some languages it may be more natural to make God explicit here. For example:

God did not give us...

God did not cause us to have...

We: The Greek pronoun that the BSB translates as We could refer to two different groups of people.

1. It refers to Paul along with all other believers, as in 2:7b and (probably) 2:10a. This is inclusive. See Fee pp. 112–13, fn. 63, and Garland p. 99.
2. It refers to Paul and his fellow workers, as in 2:6a and 2:7a. This is exclusive. See W. Kaiser, quoted by Fee, p. 113 fn. 63.

Paul may have been thinking primarily of himself and the other apostles, but he was certainly not excluding other believers. So you should research which pronoun is most natural in your language. If you must choose, it is recommended that you follow option (1). What Paul was saying is true in principle of all believers.

the spirit of the world: The phrase the spirit of the world here refers to the way this world’s people think about things. It does not refer to an evil spirit or demon. Paul was indicating that unbelievers depend on their own ability to think about things. They have no way of knowing God’s way of thinking about things.

2:12b

but the Spirit who is from God,

- Rather, we have received the Holy Spirit of God
- Instead, God gave us^(incl) the Holy Spirit.

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between receiving the spirit of the world and receiving the Spirit of God. All believers receive the Spirit of God. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction but.

Some other ways to translate this contrast are:

we didn't receive the spirit that belongs to the world. Instead, we received the Spirit who comes from God (GNT)

we have received this Spirit from God, not the spirit of the world (GW)

the Spirit who is from God: Some words from the previous clause are implied but not repeated here. It may be more natural in your language to include some or all of the implied words. For example:

we received the Spirit who is from God

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this phrase as a separate sentence with God as the subject. For example:

God has given us his own Spirit.

General Comment on 2:12a-b

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of 2:12a-b. You may need to put the positive statement first. For example:

^{12b}But God has given us his Spirit. ^{12a}That's why we don't think the same way that the people of this world think. (CEV)

General Comment on 2:12a-b

In some languages it may not be possible to use the same word for the "spirit" that is from the world and the "Spirit" of God. The "spirit" of the world means to have a worldly mind or way of thinking. In contrast, the word "Spirit" refers to the Holy Spirit of God. It is not necessary to use the same word in your translation for these two different meanings of "spirit." For example:

But God has given us his Spirit. That's why we don't think the same way that the people of this world think. (CEV)

2:12c

that we may understand what God has freely given us.

- so that we^(incl) can know/understand everything that God has given to us^(incl) by his grace.
- He gave us^(incl) his Holy Spirit in order that we^(incl) would be able to understand the good things that he has freely/graciously given to us.

that we may understand what God has freely given us:

This is a purpose clause. It indicates God's purpose in giving the Holy Spirit to believers.

we may understand: You should translate the pronoun we here in the same way that you did in 2:12a. Paul was probably thinking first of himself and the other apostles. However, he was not excluding the believers to whom he was writing.

what God has freely given us: In this phrase the pronoun us is clearly inclusive. God has generously given the Holy Spirit and all the blessings of the gospel to all believers.

freely given: The Greek word that the BSB translates as freely given is a verb that is related to the word "grace." It means, "the things that God has graciously/kindly given" or "the things that God has given because of his grace."

General Comment on 2:12a-c

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder this verse. You may want to put 2:12c before 2:12b, and 2:12b before 2:12a. For example:

^{12c}But we can understand the things that God has freely given to us, ^{12b}because we have received the Spirit that is from God. ^{12a}We do not think like the people in this world who do not know God.

1 Corinthians 2:13

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 2:6–13

In this paragraph Paul wrote about God's wisdom, that is, his wise plan to send Christ to save people. Those who follow or depend on human thinking/wisdom do not want to hear or accept God's message. It is only God's Spirit who can cause people to know and accept God's thoughts/plans as wise. The Spirit makes God's thoughts known only to people/believers who are under the Spirit's control. These believers try to obey the Spirit in following God's ways.

2:13a**And this is what we speak,**

- This is the message that we^(excl) tell others.
- These things are exactly the things we^(excl) tell people about.

And this is what we speak: The Greek word that the BSB translates as this is literally “which things.” It refers to the things that God has freely given us mentioned in 12:12c. God has given us the blessings of the gospel.

we: This pronoun may refer to different groups of people in this context:

1. It refers to “we apostles” or “we who preach the gospel.”
2. It is an editorial we and means “I.”
3. It refers to “we who have the Spirit.”

It is recommended that you follow option (1). Paul was probably using the pronoun we in the same way he did in 2:6a. He probably refers to himself and other apostles/teachers who proclaimed the gospel. If you must choose between an exclusive and an inclusive pronoun, you should probably use an exclusive pronoun here.

2:13b**not in words taught us by human wisdom,**

- When we^(excl) tell this wonderful news, we do not use clever ways of talking that we^(excl) learned by our own human wisdom.
- And when we^(excl) tell them these things, we do not use clever words such as people think up and teach people to use.

not in words taught us by human wisdom: The verb taught is passive. In some languages it may be more natural to translate it using an active verb. For example:

we do not use words that human wisdom has taught us

In some languages it may not be natural to speak of wisdom as teaching people. It may be necessary to say, “wise or clever people teach.” For example:

not in words that wise people have taught us

2:13c**but in words taught by the Spirit,**

- Instead, we^(excl) use the words which the Holy Spirit teaches us^(excl) to use.
- No, instead we^(excl) tell things the way the Holy Spirit tells us^(excl) to tell them.

in words taught by the Spirit: The phrase in words taught by the Spirit here indicates that Paul and the other apostles/teachers spoke as the Holy Spirit guided them. God's Spirit instructed them what to say, that is, helped them know what to say. If you must include an object indicating whom the Spirit taught, you should use “us^(excl).” For example:

in words that God's Spirit taught us^(excl)

General Comment on 2:13b–c

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder 2:13b–c so that the positive statement comes first. For example:

^{13c}We use words that the Spirit teaches us. ^{13b}We do not use words taught by human wisdom.

2:13d**expressing spiritual truths in spiritual words.**

- We^(excl) explain to spiritual people the truths that the Spirit tells us.
- In that way we^(excl) apostles/workers explain what the Holy Spirit tells us to those who have the Spirit.

expressing spiritual truths in spiritual words: There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It means teaching spiritual truths to spiritual people. For example:

interpreting spiritual truths to those who are spiritual (ESV) (RSV, GNT, CEV, REB, ESV, NET, GW, NCV)

1. It means teaching spiritual truths using spiritual words. For example:

fitting spiritual language to spiritual things (NJB) (BSB, NJB, NIV, NASB, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is how the majority of English versions have understood the phrase.

It is difficult to know what Paul means by “spiritual words/language.” In the immediate context he does speak about spiritual people (2:15). The ESV is therefore used in the source line of the display. Some other ways to translate this are:

We^(excl) explain these truths that the Spirit tells us^(excl) to people who have the Holy Spirit.

We explain spiritual things to those who have the Spirit. (GW)

1 Corinthians 2:14

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God’s wisdom.

Paragraph 2:14–16

In this paragraph Paul contrasted two types of people. They are the people who have the Spirit of God, and those people who do not have the Spirit of God. People who do not have the Spirit of God cannot understand or accept spiritual things (2:14). People who have God’s Spirit can understand spiritual things, because they are able to think like Christ Jesus (2:15–16).

2:14a

The natural man does not accept the things that come from the Spirit of God.

- ¶ A person who does not have the Holy Spirit does not want to hear about the things that God’s Spirit reveals
- ¶ But people who do not have God’s Spirit refuse to accept/believe the things that the Spirit teaches.

The natural man does not accept the things that come from the Spirit of God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as natural describes people who do not accept the things that come from the Holy Spirit. They do not welcome them or want to believe them.

The natural man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as The natural man is hard to translate

into English. It refers to someone who has physical, emotional, and mental life but lives without the Holy Spirit. It can also be translated as “the man without the Spirit” (NIV). It refers to any unbeliever, man or woman. In some languages it may be more natural to translate it as a plural word. For example:

natural men

people without the Spirit

the things that come from the Spirit of God: The phrase the things that come from the Spirit of God here refers to the truths that the Holy Spirit reveals to believers. These truths are the message/plan from God that Paul talked about in 2:6–8. For example:

the truths that come from the Spirit of God (NCV)

2:14b

For they are foolishness to him,

- because those things make no sense to him/her.
- They say/think that these things are the talk of foolish people.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For here introduces a further explanation of the previous verse part. Some English versions do not use a conjunction. For example;

He thinks they’re nonsense. (GW)

You should connect this verse part to the previous verse part in a way that is natural in your language.

they are foolishness to him: This clause indicates that a person who does not have the Spirit of God thinks that spiritual truths are foolish. He thinks that God’s wise plans are foolish. For example:

they seem to be nonsense... (GNT)

2:14c

and he cannot understand them,

- An unbeliever is not able to understand/know those things
- Furthermore, such people are not able to understand these things that the Spirit teaches us^(incl).

he cannot understand them: An unbeliever can read the truths in the Bible and hear the facts of the gospel. However, he can never really understand them unless

the Holy Spirit helps him. Unless the Holy Spirit helps him, he cannot know that these things are true and he cannot personally believe them.

General Comment on 2:14b-c

It may be more natural in your language to reorder 2:14b-c. For example:

Such a person really does not understand them,
and they seem to be nonsense (GNT)

2:14d

because they are spiritually discerned.

- because a person can only understand and accept/believe these things when the Holy Spirit helps/enables him.
- This is because the Holy Spirit is the only one who can help/enable people understand/examine the things of God.

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because here introduces the reason why people without the Holy Spirit cannot understand or accept spiritual truths.

they are spiritually discerned: The pronoun they refers to the things from the Spirit of God. This clause means that only the Spirit of God can enable someone to understand the true things that come from God and his wise plans. Some other ways to translate this are:

their value can be judged only on a spiritual basis
(GNT)

their value can be assessed only in the Spirit (NJB)

a person must be spiritual to evaluate them (GW)

discerned: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as discerned refers to studying something thoroughly in order to learn all about it. It can also be translated as “judged,” “examined,” or “investigated.” A person without God’s Spirit cannot understand the value of God’s plan or understand how wise it is.

General Comment on 2:14a-d

In some languages it may be natural to place 2:14d earlier in the verse. For example:

^{14a}The person without the Spirit does not accept the things that come from the Spirit of God.

^{14d}Those truths can only be spiritually discerned,

^{14b}and so they are nonsense to him. ^{14c}He cannot understand them.

1 Corinthians 2:15

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God’s wisdom.

Paragraph 2:14–16

In this paragraph Paul contrasted two types of people. They are the people who have the Spirit of God, and those people who do not have the Spirit of God. People who do not have the Spirit of God cannot understand or accept spiritual things (2:14). People who have God’s Spirit can understand spiritual things, because they are able to think like Christ Jesus (2:15–16).

2:15a

The spiritual man judges all things,

- A person who has the Spirit is able to judge/examine/evaluate everything.
- On the other hand, people who have received the Holy Spirit can understand/examine everything.

In the Greek text this verse part includes a conjunction that indicates a contrast. The contrast is between the person without the Spirit and the man who has the spirit. For example:

But he who is spiritual appraises all things,
(NASB)

Whoever has the Spirit, however, is able... (GNT)

If it is natural in your language, you may wish to indicate this contrast as in the examples above.

The spiritual man judges all things: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as judges is a form of the same verb that is translated as “discerned” in 2:14d. The man in whom God’s Spirit lives is able to evaluate and learn all about God’s plan of salvation. Other ways to translate this are:

Whoever has the Spirit...is able to judge the value of everything (GNT)

Spiritual people evaluate everything (GW)

all things: Paul did not explain what he meant by all things. Some scholars suggest that he was referring to all things that are from the Holy Spirit. Others suggest that he meant all sorts of things in general. It is recommended that you translate this literally, as do most English versions.

2:15b

but he himself is not subject to anyone's judgment.

- But people who do not have the Spirit cannot judge/evaluate the people who do have the Spirit.
- And yet the ways/thoughts of a person who has the Holy Spirit cannot be judged or evaluated by anyone else.
- And yet no unbeliever can judge the ways/thoughts of a person who has the Holy Spirit and decide whether what he/she is doing or thinking is right or wrong.

he himself is not subject to anyone's judgment: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as subject to...judgment is a passive. It is a form of the same verb that is used in 2:15a and 2:14d. Paul was saying that a person without the Spirit is not able to examine and evaluate a person in whom the Spirit lives. Paul does not mean that a man in whom God's Spirit lives does not need discipline and advice from his spiritual leaders and that he does not need to obey God's moral laws. But he does mean that the person who is trusting his own clever thoughts is not able to examine and make judgments about the person who listens to and obeys the Spirit. A person who listens to God's Spirit does not need to fear criticism from unbelievers or immature believers who do not listen to God's Spirit (compare 3:3). Evidently some believers among the Corinthians were acting like unbelievers and were finding fault with Paul and did not want to follow his teachings. He will not evaluate such a person correctly, nor be able to appreciate his spiritual value. Other ways to translate this clause are:

no one can judge him (NCV)

they cannot be judged by others (CEV)

Spiritual people...are subject to no one's evaluation. (GW)

1 Corinthians 2:16

Section 1:10–2:16: Believers should not divide up into competing factions. They should be united by true wisdom, the message of the cross.

In this section Paul wrote about a serious problem in the Corinthian church. The Corinthian believers were dividing up into competing groups. They were following whichever human leader they admired the most. Paul tried to solve this problem by reminding the Corinthians of the message of the cross. He wanted them to stop following human wisdom and to follow God's wisdom.

Paragraph 2:14–16

In this paragraph Paul contrasted two types of people. They are the people who have the Spirit of God, and those people who do not have the Spirit of God. People who do not have the Spirit of God cannot understand or accept spiritual things (2:14). People who have God's Spirit can understand spiritual things, because they are able to think like Christ Jesus (2:15–16).

2:16a-b

who has known the mind of the Lord, so as to instruct Him?: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that no one has known the mind of the Lord and therefore no one can instruct the Lord. Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Who has known the mind of the Lord so that he can teach him? (GW)

- As a question with the implied answer. For example:

Who has known the Lord's mind and can instruct him? No one!

- As questions. For example:

Who knows the Lord's thoughts? Who knows enough to teach him? (NLT)

- As a statement. For example:

No one has known the mind of the Lord, and so no one can instruct him.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

2:16a

"For who has known the mind of the Lord,

- Because, “Can anyone know what is in the Lord’s mind?”
- What I have said is true because it agrees with what was written long ago in God’s Book: “No one has ever known what the Lord’s thoughts/plans are

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For introduces a Scripture quotation from Isaiah 40:13. That verse supports what Paul had just said in 2:15b. The GNT introduces the quotation with the words:

As the Scripture says (GNT)

known the mind of the Lord: The phrase known the mind of the Lord means to understand what the Lord is thinking. Another way to translate this is:

known the thoughts of the Lord (CEV)

2:16b

so as to instruct Him?”

- Can anyone teach/advise the Lord?”
- And so no one can tell/teach him what his thoughts should be about something.”

so as to instruct Him?: The BSB translates this part of the OT quotation in a way that shows that it is connected to 2:16a as a result clause. If someone does not know God’s thoughts, then he cannot give God any advice. Some other ways to translate this are:

so that he can teach him? (GW)

that he may instruct him? (NIV)

However, in some languages it may be more natural to translate this as a separate question. Some versions leave the fact that it is a result clause implied. For example:

Who is able to give him advice? (GNT)

Who has been able to teach him? (NCV)

instruct Him: The phrase instruct Him refers to giving advice to or counseling the Lord. Some other ways to translate this are:

been his adviser (NJB)

be his counsellor (REB)

given him advice (CEV)

2:16c

But we have the mind of Christ.

- But we^(incl) understand what is in Christ’s mind.
- But we^(incl) believers, do think the same way that Christ does.
- But as for us^(incl), we^(incl) think about things in the same way that Christ does.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces Paul’s own answer to the question in 2:16a-b. It is not the answer implied by the original author in the original context in Isaiah.

we have the mind of Christ: The emphasis in this statement is on the word we. Paul and other believers, in contrast to those without the Spirit, do have the mind of Christ. The pronoun we here refers to all believers, or at least to all mature believers.

All of God’s people are potentially able to understand spiritual things in a way similar to the way Christ knows them. Believers are able to understand because the Spirit is in them. People who are controlled by the Holy Spirit understand God’s plans and God’s ways in the same way that Christ does. Some other ways to translate this are:

we who are spiritual have the very thoughts of Christ (JBP)

We are those who have the mind of Christ. (NJB)

the mind of Christ: In 2:16a-b Paul quoted from Isaiah 40:13, where it says “the mind of the Lord.” In 2:16c Paul said the mind of Christ, since he thought of Jesus Christ as the Lord (Yahweh) of the OT. He meant that the same Holy Spirit who guides the thoughts of Christ also guides the thoughts of believers. Therefore, believers can understand spiritual truths the same way that Christ does. They can also understand God’s wise plans.

1 Corinthians 3:1

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God’s plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God’s church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord's servants

All believers belong to the Lord and should remain united

Paragraph 3:1–4

Paul introduced the problem by pointing out to the Corinthians that they were not acting like people controlled by God's Holy Spirit. They were quarreling among themselves and being jealous of one another. They were behaving just like unbelievers.

3:1a

Brothers, I could not address you as spiritual,

- ¶ My Christian friends, when I was in Corinth, I could not talk to you as I talk to spiritual people.
- ¶ My fellow believers, when I came to visit you, I was not able to teach/talk to you as I talk to people who have the Holy Spirit guiding/controlling them.

Brothers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Brothers refers to all the believers in the church in Corinth. Here as elsewhere (e.g., 1:10a), the GNT translates it as:

My friends (GNT)

I could not address you as spiritual: The clause I could not address you as spiritual means "I could not talk to you as I would have talked to spiritual people." Paul could not teach the Corinthians in the same way that he would have taught spiritual people.

Paul was referring to a time that was two or three years in the past. He was talking about how he taught the Corinthians when he was in Corinth. You may need to make this explicit in your translation. For example:

When I was with you I couldn't talk to you as I would to spiritual people. (NLT)

I: As in 2:1a, the Greek text begins with a word that can be translated "And I (emphatic)," or "And I, for my part." Paul used it here to start to talk about himself. Here is another way to translate this:

As a matter of fact,...I... (GNT)

as spiritual: The Greek word that the BSB translates as spiritual describes people who are controlled and

guided by God's Holy Spirit. Here Paul used this word to refer to mature believers, those who trusted Christ and lived as followers of Christ.

3:1b

but as worldly—

- Rather, I was only able to talk to you as I talk to people of this world.
- No, I had to talk to you as I talk to people who follow their own desires.

but as worldly: The phrase but as worldly is a short way of saying "instead I had to address you as worldly people." The GNT translates this as a separate clause:

I had to talk to you as though you belonged to this world. (GNT)

worldly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as worldly comes from the noun meaning "flesh." Here it refers to people who live as most people do, following their own natural human desires. These are people who are not living in the power of the Holy Spirit. Other ways to translate this include:

people of the flesh (NET)

acting like the people of this world (CEV)

as though you belonged to this world (GNT)

3:1c

as infants in Christ.

- It was as though you were babies for you had just begun to trust in Christ.
- I had to speak to you that way because at that time you had just begun to believe in Christ.

as infants in Christ: The word infants here is a figure of speech called a metaphor. Paul used this metaphor to show what new believers are like. They are like very young children in the sense that they cannot understand difficult things. They need to be taken care of by others. Some English versions make the metaphor more clear:

You were infants in your faith in Christ. (GW)

as though you were infants in the Christian life (NLT)

You were like babies as far as your faith in Christ was concerned.

1 Corinthians 3:2

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God's plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God's church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord's servants

All believers belong to the Lord and should remain united

Paragraph 3:1–4

Paul introduced the problem by pointing out to the Corinthians that they were not acting like people controlled by God's Holy Spirit. They were quarreling among themselves and being jealous of one another. They were behaving just like unbelievers.

3:2a

I gave you milk,

- I gave you only milk to drink.
- At that time I taught you only the beginning things from God's message, because you were like a baby that can only nurse/breastfeed.
- At that time I taught you only the simple things from God's message, as a mother gives babies only milk to drink.

I gave you milk: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as I gave you milk is a metaphor. Paul was comparing himself to a mother who nurses or breastfeeds her baby. He was like a mother who gives milk to her child in the sense that he gave or taught the new believers in Corinthian simple things that they were able to receive and absorb. He was comparing the beginning teachings from God's message to milk. In some languages it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

So I had to treat you like babies and feed you milk. (CEV)

The teaching I gave you was like milk. (NCV)

I taught you simply, as a mother gives only milk to her baby.

3:2b

not solid food,

- I did not give/feed you solid/adult food,
- I did not talk to you about things that are difficult to understand. Such teachings are like food for adults.

not solid food: Paul contrasted the solid food that adults eat with milk, which is the only food babies are able to eat. The phrase not solid food is a short way of saying "I did not give you solid food to eat." This is also a metaphor. Paul was saying that some teachings about God are like solid food. They are like solid food in the sense that only mature people can receive them and benefit from them. Other ways to translate this include:

I did not give you anything solid to eat.

I did not teach you things that are only appropriate for people who have strong/adult faith.

General Comment on 3:2a–b

The Greek text uses the same verb for both verse parts. However, in some languages this may not be natural or possible, and you may need to use separate verbs. For example:

^{2a}I caused you to drink milk. ^{2b}I did not cause you to eat solid food.

3:2c

for you were not yet ready for solid food.

- because you were not yet able to receive/accept such food/teaching.
- And at that time you were not ready to learn/understand them.

for you were not yet ready for solid food: Paul gave the reason why he had not given them solid food. Just as a baby is not yet ready for solid food, so when the Corinthians first became believers, they were not ready to understand difficult teaching. Paul was not blaming them for this or criticizing them at this point. Another way to translate this is:

for you were not yet ready for it at that time

because you were not able to take solid food
(NCV)

General Comment on 3:2a-c

In some languages it may be natural to follow the CEV and combine 3:2b-c:

[^{2a}So I had to treat you like babies and feed you milk.] ^{2b-c}You could not take solid food. (CEV)

3:2d

In fact, you are still not ready,

- But even now, you are still not ready/able to receive/understand such food/teaching.
- But what is bad is, even after all this time, you still are not ready to learn about those things which are for mature believers.

In fact: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as In fact emphasizes what Paul was saying. Other ways to translate this include:

even now (GNT)

even yet (RSV)

you are still not ready: Here Paul began to rebuke/criticize the believers. After being believers for a few years, they were still thinking and acting like babies. They were not yet mature enough in their faith to understand and benefit from the full teaching of the gospel.

not ready: Here, the phrase not ready implies that the Corinthians were not ready for “solid food;” that is, for more difficult or in-depth teaching. In some languages it may be natural to supply this implied information. For example:

not ready for solid food

not ready to eat solid food

In some languages you may be able to suggest something of the meaning of the metaphor by using words that can refer to either food or teaching. For example:

mature enough to absorb/digest anything more substantial

1 Corinthians 3:3

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God’s plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God’s church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord’s servants

All believers belong to the Lord and should remain united

Paragraph 3:1–4

Paul introduced the problem by pointing out to the Corinthians that they were not acting like people controlled by God’s Holy Spirit. They were quarreling among themselves and being jealous of one another. They were behaving just like unbelievers.

3:3a

for you are still worldly.

- You still live as the people of this world live.
- You are still influenced by your human/evil nature.
- I say that because you are still controlled by your fleshly/natural desires.

for: The word that the BSB translates as for introduces the grounds for Paul’s statement in 3:2d that the Corinthians were still not ready for solid food. Some English versions do not translate this word. You should translate the connection in a way that is natural in your language. You may wish to follow the CSB and say:

because (CSB)

you are still worldly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as worldly is almost the same as the word used in 3:1b. It literally means “fleshly”; that is, characterized by flesh. Here it probably refers to people who want to live as they please, obeying their own desires instead of obeying the Holy Spirit. The Corinthians were still willing to be controlled by their natural human impulses. Other ways to translate this verse part include:

you are still of the flesh (RSV)

you are still influenced by the flesh (NET)

you're still influenced by your corrupt nature (GW)

you still live as the people of this world live (GNT)

3:3b

For since there is jealousy and dissension among you,

- You are envious/jealous of one another, and you argue with each other.
- I know that this is true about you for you are jealous and quarrelsome.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces a further step in Paul's argument. It introduces the grounds for saying they are worldly. Some English versions such as the GNT do not explicitly translate this conjunction here. You may leave it implicit if that is natural in your language.

since there is jealousy and dissension among you:

There are several ways of understanding the Greek word that the BSB translates as since:

1. It means since and introduces a logical reason: the Corinthians' jealousy and quarreling proved that they were still worldly. For example:

since there is jealousy and dissension among you (NET) (NIV, KJV, NASB, NET, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. It means while or when and refers to a time span. For example:

As long as there are jealousy and rivalry among you (NJB) (NJB, RSV, GNT, ESV, REB, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This verse part indicates how Paul knew that the Corinthian believers were still worldly. Some of them were acting jealously, and some of them argued among themselves.

there is jealousy and dissension among you: In some languages it may be natural to translate the abstract nouns jealousy and dissension as adjectives or verbs. There is a textual problem here. (1) Some Greek manuscripts say "jealousy and quarreling." These manuscripts are followed by the BSB, CEV, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, ESV, GW, NLT, and NCV. (2) Some other

manuscripts say "jealousy and quarreling and strife." The KJV follows these manuscripts. It is recommended that you follow option 1. This is supported by the UBS Greek NT, which gives it a B rating, indicating that the text is almost certain. For example:

you are jealous/envious and contentious

you envy one another and you quarrel with one another

you are jealous of one other and quarrel with each other (NLT)

3:3c

are you not worldly?

- Does this not mean/show that you are living/just like the people of this world?
- Does this not prove that you are influenced/controlled by your human/evil nature?
- This/That shows that you are still obeying/following your own fleshly/natural desires.

are you not worldly?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul was rebuking the Corinthians. He was stating strongly that the Corinthians were worldly. They were not behaving as believers should. The Greek word translated worldly here is the same as in 3:3a. See the note there.

There are several ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- as a question with the answer implied. For example:

doesn't this prove that you belong to this world...? (GNT)

- as a statement. For example:

This shows that you are still not spiritual. (NCV)

- as an exclamation. For example:

How worldly/fleshly you are!

You should translate this in a way that is natural in your language for showing a strong rebuke.

General Comment on 3:3b-c

In some languages it may be natural to indicate the logical connection between the verse parts at the beginning of 3:3c, as the NLT does:

^{3b}You are jealous of one another and quarrel with each other. ^{3c}Doesn't that prove that you are controlled by your sinful nature? (NLT)

3:3d

Are you not walking in the way of man?

- Are you not behaving like people who do not know God?
- You are acting no differently from the people of this world.

Are you not walking in the way of man?: This is a second rhetorical question. It emphasizes Paul's rebuke. He was making a strong statement that the Corinthians were not acting like spiritual people. They were acting just like all human beings do in their natural state without the Holy Spirit. They were acting selfishly rather than for God's glory. So there are at least three ways to translate this verse part:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

are you not...behaving like ordinary men? (RSV)

- as a statement. For example:

you are acting like people of this world (CEV)

- as an exclamation. For example:

You are acting just like ordinary people!

You should translate this in a way that is natural in your language for making a strong statement about what someone is doing wrong.

walking: The Greek word that the BSB translates as walking is an idiom that refers to the way one lives and behaves in normal everyday life. The same word is used in Romans 6:4, 8:4, Galatians 5:16, and Ephesians 4:1. Refer to the notes on these passages. You may be able to use the same word or phrase here.

in the way of man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in the way of man is literally "according to man/human." It does not refer only to males. Paul was saying that the Corinthians were behaving like unbelieving people. Here is another way to translate this:

like people of this world (CEV)

General Comment on 3:3c-d

In the Greek these two questions form one sentence connected by a preposition meaning "and." The RSV follows the Greek and says:

are you not of the flesh and behaving like ordinary men? (RSV)

You may translate these questions as one sentence or as two sentences, whichever is more natural in your language.

1 Corinthians 3:4

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God's plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God's church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord's servants

All believers belong to the Lord and should remain united

Paragraph 3:1–4

Paul introduced the problem by pointing out to the Corinthians that they were not acting like people controlled by God's Holy Spirit. They were quarreling among themselves and being jealous of one another. They were behaving just like unbelievers.

3:4a

For when one of you says, "I follow Paul,"

- For if one of you says, "I listen to Paul,"
- When some people say that they are following my/ Paul's teaching,
- I say that because some of you say, "As for us^(excl), Paul is our teacher,"

3:4b

and another, "I follow Apollos,"

- while another of you says, "I listen to Apollos,"
- and other people say that they are following Apollos's teaching,
- but others of you are saying, "As for us^(excl), Apollos is our teacher."

3:4a-b

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces Paul's reason for saying that the Corinthians were walking in the way of man. Some English versions such as the GNT do not explicitly translate this conjunction.

one of you says, "I follow Paul," and another, "I follow Apollos,": Paul again referred to what some people from Chloe's household had reported to him. See 1:11-12 and the notes on 1:12b and 1:12c. It is recommended that you translate this sentence in a way that is similar to the way that you translated 1:12.

The phrase one of you says does not mean that just one person said this. Similarly, the phrase and another does not refer to just one person. Paul was talking about these people as representatives of two groups. And these two groups were just examples of some of the groups in the Corinthian church. In some languages it may be better to translate the phrases one of you says and another with plural forms. For example:

Some of you say...and some others say...

Consider whether it is natural in your language to translate what the Corinthians were saying as a direct quote, as the BSB does, or as indirect quotes as in this example:

Some of you say that you follow me. Others say that you follow Apollos.

I follow Paul...I follow Apollos: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as I follow Paul literally says "I am of Paul." The speaker was saying that he belonged to a group that admired Paul and followed his teachings. Other people were saying that they looked to Apollos as their spiritual leader and teacher. Other ways to translate these clauses include:

I belong to Paul...I belong to Apollos (RSV)

I am on Paul's side...I am on Apollos's side.

Paul is the teacher that I/we like...Apollos is the teacher that I/we like.

Paul: Paul was referring to himself. In some languages it may therefore be necessary to use the first-person pronoun "me" when using indirect speech:

some of you say that you follow me

3:4c**are you not mere men?**

- are you not just like the rest of the world?
- you are behaving like people who do not know God.
- That behavior/talk of yours shows that you are no different from the people of this world.

are you not mere men?: This is a third rhetorical question. It means approximately the same thing as "Are you not walking in the way of man?" in 3:3d. Paul used this question to emphasize what he was saying: the Corinthians were behaving like unbelievers. Again, there are at least two ways to translate this question:

- as a question. For example:

isn't this how ordinary people behave? (CEV)

- as a statement. For example:

you are acting like people of the world (NCV)

1 Corinthians 3:5**Section 3:1-23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together**

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God's plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God's church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord's servants

All believers belong to the Lord and should remain united

Paragraph 3:5-9

Paul told why the Corinthians should not divide into groups and following their favorite Christian workers. It was because all Christian workers are working for God. He and Apollos were not important in themselves. They were just servants of God whom God sent to help the Corinthians to believe.

3:5a**What then is Apollos? And what is Paul?**

- ¶ And besides that, consider what/who Apollos and I are.
- ¶ As for Apollos and myself, let me tell you about us.
- ¶ Now I want you to remember what kind of people Apollos and I are.

What...is Apollos? And what is Paul?: These are rhetorical questions. Paul used them to introduce a new topic that he wanted his readers to think about. He wanted them to think about the status of Apollos and Paul (that is, himself). He was not asking for information. So there are several ways to translate these questions:

- as rhetorical questions. For example,

And besides that, who do you think Apollos and I are?

Why do you think that Apollos and I are so important?

Who is Apollos, and who is Paul, that we should be the cause of such quarrels? (NLT)

- as questions with the answer supplied. For example:

Is Apollos important? No! Is Paul important? No! (NCV)

- as statements. For example:

Consider Apollos and me.

What: There is a textual problem here.

1. Some Greek texts say what. For example:

What is Apollos, really? Or what is Paul? (NET) (BSB, NIV, REB, RSV, NJB, NET, ESV, NASB)

1. Some Greek texts say who. For example:

After all, who is Apollos? And who is Paul? (GNT) (KJV, NLT, GNT, GW)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), as does the UBS Greek text. Some of the English versions that say “who” are almost certainly doing so for reasons of English style and naturalness.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as What is a neuter form, usually used for speaking of things,

objects, rather than people. It is a low-status word, indicating that Paul and Barnabas were instruments, not important for their own sake or in their own selves. In some languages it will not be possible to refer to men by a neuter pronoun. In that case, you should consider using an expression that makes it clear that the questions deal with how important the people are. For example, the NCV translated this as:

Is Apollos important? (NCV)

Or you could use a word or expression in your language that implies a low status person such as a servant.

then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as then is usually translated as “therefore” or “so then.” In this context it introduces a further step in Paul’s argument concerning Christian workers. Here he began to talk about Apollos and himself and how the Corinthians should think about them and their other teachers.

3:5b

They are servants

- We^(excl) are only God’s workers/servants.
- We^(excl) are merely ones who do the work that God orders us^(excl) to do.

They are servants: The pronoun They refers to Apollos and Paul. In many languages it may be more natural to use the first-person plural pronoun and say:

we^(excl) are only servants

servants: Paul was indicating that he and Apollos were servants of God. As servants they were not important because of who they were themselves but only because they served God.

General Comment on 3:5a-b

In some languages it may be natural to combine the rhetorical question in 3:5a and the answer in 3:5b into one statement. For example:

^{5a}Apollos and I are ^{5b}merely servants. (CEV)

3:5c

through whom you believed,

- We^(excl) helped you to believe in the Lord Jesus.
- God gave us^(excl) the work of leading/causing you to trust in Jesus.
- We^(excl) both told you the good news about Christ so that you began to trust him.

through whom you believed: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as through whom you believed means that both Paul and Apollos helped the Corinthians to believe in Christ. They preached the gospel in Corinth and taught the people there about Jesus Christ.

3:5d

as the Lord has assigned to each his role.

- We^(excl) each/both do the work that the Lord gave us^(excl).
- The Lord gave to each/both of us^(excl) a job to do.

as the Lord has assigned to each his role: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as as the Lord has assigned to each his role indicates that the Lord had given both Paul and Apollos a task to do. He had given them both a role in helping the Corinthians to trust Christ. Different ways to translate this include:

Each of us performed the task which the Lord assigned to him. (REB)

Each did what the Lord gave him to do. (GW)

Each of us did the work the Lord gave us. (NLT)

each: Paul was speaking primarily of himself and Apollos, so in some languages it will be natural to use a word meaning “both.”

1 Corinthians 3:6

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God’s plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God’s church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord’s servants

All believers belong to the Lord and should remain united

Paragraph 3:5–9

Paul told why the Corinthians should not divide into groups and following their favorite Christian workers. It was because all Christian workers are working for God. He and Apollos were not important in themselves. They were just servants of God whom God sent to help the Corinthians to believe.

3:6–9

In 3:6–9 Paul used a figure of speech called an extended metaphor. He talked about planting seeds, watering plants, and the way plants grow. However, he was actually referring to the way the church in Corinth started and grew.

There are several ways to translate this extended figure of speech. In the following illustration, 3:6a is used as an example of how to translate the rest of the figure of speech:

- as a metaphor. For example:

I am the one who planted the seeds.

The NLT makes it clearer that this is a metaphor by supplying the words “in your hearts”:

My job was to plant the seed in your hearts. (NLT)

- as a simile, using a word meaning “like.” For example:

I am like a person who planted the seeds.

My job is like the job of a person who planted the seeds.

- as a metaphor or simile, with the comparison explained. For example:

I planted the seeds—meaning I began the work of teaching you God’s message.

I was like a person who planted seeds, because I was the one who began the work of teaching you God’s message.

- without a figure of speech, translating only the meaning with no mention of planting or seed. For example:

I am the one who began the work of teaching you God’s message.

It is best if you can use one of the first three methods to translate the metaphor in 3:6–9. But if people in your language group are confused by this metaphor and cannot understand what Paul means, you may have to translate all of 3:6–9 using the fourth method.

Here is a sample translation of 3:6–9 that uses the fourth method:

^{6a}I am the one who began the work of teaching you God's message. ^{6b}Apollos continued this work. ^{6c}But it was God who caused you to have faith. ^{7a}So it is not the person who began the work or the person who continued the work that is important. ^{7b}God is the one who is important; he is the one who causes you to believe. ^{8a}The person who began the work among you and the person who continued the work, they/we^(excl) are all just part of the team. ^{8b}God will give each of us^(excl) a reward for the work we^(excl) have done, ^{9a}because we^(excl) are working as a team doing God's work, not our^(excl) own. ^{9b}You are God's people, not ours^(excl). ^{9c}You are like a house that God is building for himself.

3:6a I planted the seed

- I am the one who planted the seed of the good news in your hearts.
- I am like a person who plants seeds, for I am the one who began telling the gospel in your city.
- I was the first one to tell you God's message, so I am like a person who plants seeds in the ground.

I planted the seed: This is a metaphor. Paul was indicating that he was the one who first preached the gospel to the Corinthians. See the notes on 3:6–9 above for suggestions of different ways to translate this.

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as I planted the seed is literally I planted. In many languages it will be natural or even necessary to follow the BSB and say what was planted. The pronoun I is emphatic here, to make a contrast with “Apollos” in 3:6b and “God” in 3:6c.

planted: In some languages there are different words for different kinds of planting. For example: planting by scattering seeds, planting by making a hole with a stick and dropping seeds in, planting with a shovel or other tool. Paul used a general word that can mean any kind of planting. So you can use whatever word will be the most easily understood in your language as a figure of speech.

the seed: The BSB has supplied this phrase. In this context it refers to many individual grains that are all of one kind/type. In some languages it may be natural to use a plural form:

the seeds

3:6b and Apollos watered it,

- Apollos is the one who watered the seed.
- Apollos is like a person who watered the seed/sprouts, for he continued the work of teaching you.
- After that, Apollos helped you to become stronger in your faith, just like another person waters the plants that have begun growing.

Apollos watered it: This verse part continues the metaphor. Paul was saying that after he had himself preached the gospel in Corinth, Apollos helped the church by preaching and teaching.

The Greek text that the BSB translates as Apollos watered it is literally Apollos watered. In many languages it may be necessary to say what he watered. You may be able to follow the BSB or you may need to say explicitly:

Apollos watered the seeds/seed.

Apollos watered the sprouts/plants.

If it is not a normal custom in your part of the world to water crops, you may need to translate the verb watered with a general word such as “tended” or “took care of”:

Apollos took care of the seedlings.

3:6c but God made it grow.

- But it was God who made the plants grow.
- But God is the one who caused the seed to sprout, that is, he is the one who gave you spiritual life.
- But it was God who gave you new life, just as he is the one who makes seeds grow into plants.

but God made it grow: The Greek word that the BSB translates as but indicates contrast. Here in 3:6a–c, the strong contrast is not between Paul and Apollos. It is between both of them and God. Show this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

made it grow: The verb made...grow means to cause to become bigger, or to cause to increase. In the figure of speech Paul was referring to the way seeds sprout and grow into plants. The meaning of this figure of speech is this: Paul was the first one who came and preached the gospel to the Corinthians. Then Apollos came and helped them understand the gospel more. But God is the one who caused them to believe and grow in their faith, not Paul or Apollos.

General Comment on 3:6a-c

In Greek, the verbs in 3:6a and 3:6b (“planted,” “watered”) are in the simple past tense. But the verb in 3:6c (“made it grow”) is in the imperfect tense, indicating continuous action. The following translation helps explain the meaning of these tenses:

I at one time planted the seeds. At another time Apollos watered the plants. But during the whole time God was causing the plants to grow.

Try to show this difference in the verbs in a way that is natural in your language.

1 Corinthians 3:7

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God’s plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God’s church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord’s servants

All believers belong to the Lord and should remain united

Paragraph 3:5–9

Paul told why the Corinthians should not divide into groups and following their favorite Christian workers. It was because all Christian workers are working for God. He and Apollos were not important in themselves. They were just servants of God whom God sent to help the Corinthians to believe.

3:7a

So neither he who plants nor he who waters is anything,

- So then, the person who plants the seed/seeds and the person who waters it/them are not the important ones.
- So then, people who do the job of planting the seeds and people who do the job of watering the plants are insignificant/unimportant.
- In the same way, I who began God’s work among you and Apollos who continued God’s work among you are not the ones who really matter.

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So here introduces a logical conclusion to what Paul had just said. The GNT does not translate this explicitly here. Consider how to introduce Paul’s conclusion in a natural way in your language.

neither he who plants nor he who waters is anything: This is a figure of speech called a hyperbole. Paul meant that he and Apollos were nothing in comparison to God. Their work was not the work that ultimately made the difference in the Corinthians’ lives. Other ways to translate this include:

neither the one who plants nor the one who waters is important (GW)

The one who plants and the one who waters really do not matter. (GNT)

neither the planter nor the waterer counts for anything (NJB)

he who plants...he who waters: Here Paul talked about himself as well as Apollos in the third person. He did this because he was teaching something that is true of all Christian workers. See the General Comment on 3:7–8 at the end of 3:8b for other ways to translate this.

3:7b

but only God, who makes things grow.

- God is the important one, for he makes the plants grow.
- No, God is the one who matters, for he is the one who causes/brings growth.
- No, rather, God is the one who is really important, because he gives you new life and makes you grow spiritually.

but only God, who makes things grow: The phrase but only God is a short way of saying “but God is

everything,” that is, only God is important/significant. The relative clause who makes things grow gives the basis for what Paul had just said, that God is the one who is truly important. God is the only one who can make seeds grow into plants, and God is the only one who can create new spiritual life in people’s hearts. He is the one who causes them to have faith and grow strong in faith. Here is another way to translate this:

It is God who matters, because he makes the seeds grow. (GNT)

General Comment on 3:7a-b

In some languages it may be natural to make the comparison in 3:7a-b more clear. For example:

So the one who plants is not important, and the one who waters is not important. Only God, who makes things grow, is important. (NCV)

The ones who do the planting or watering aren’t important, but God is important because he is the one who makes the seed grow. (NLT)

The one who plants and the one who waters are not important. Rather it is the one who gives the growth that is important. And the one who gives the growth is God.

1 Corinthians 3:8

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God’s plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God’s church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord’s servants

All believers belong to the Lord and should remain united

Paragraph 3:5–9

Paul told why the Corinthians should not divide into groups and following their favorite Christian workers.

It was because all Christian workers are working for God. He and Apollos were not important in themselves. They were just servants of God whom God sent to help the Corinthians to believe.

3:8a

He who plants and he who waters are one in purpose,

- The person who plants the seeds and the person who waters the seeds/plants work with the same goal/aim in mind.
- I began the work among you and Apollos continued the work among you but we are both working to get the same task/thing done, just as the person who plants seeds and the person who waters plants are both trying grow a crop.
- I who first taught you God’s message and Apollos who continued teaching you God’s message both have the same goal/purpose.

The Greek text for this verse begins with a connecting word. Here it introduces a new point in the metaphor that Paul began in 3:6. The BSB and some other English versions do not explicitly translate it, but the KJV translates it as “Now.”

He who plants and he who waters are one in purpose:

A literal translation of the Greek is “the one planting and the one watering are one.” There are two ways to interpret this:

1. The workers have the same purpose. They work together as a team. For example:

The one who plants and the one who waters have the same goal. (GW) (BSB, NJB, NIV, NLT, NRSV, NET, GW, REB, NCV)

1. The workers are equally important or equally unimportant, even though they have different tasks. For example:

He who plants and he who waters are equal. (RSV) (CEV, RSV)

The KJV, ESV, NASB, NJB, and GNT can be interpreted in either way. For example:

There is no difference between the one who plants and the one who waters. (GNT)

It is recommended that you try to maintain the ambiguity of the Greek. If you must choose between the interpretations, it is recommended that you follow

interpretation (1), since it has stronger support from the commentaries.

3:8b

and each will be rewarded according to his own labor.

- Both will receive pay/wages in accordance with their work.
- And God will pay/reward each worker for the way each has done his work.
- God will give both/each of us^(excl) workers a reward for what we^(excl) do,

each will be rewarded: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as each will be rewarded is literally “each one will receive his own pay.” In the context of the metaphor, this means that the farm workers will receive the wages they have earned. But in the context of the figure of speech, this means that each Christian worker will receive a reward. God will reward each of his servants for doing his work well. In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that it is God who will give the reward. For example:

God will reward each one (GNT)

according to his own labor: The phrase according to his own labor means “in proportion to the work he has done.” The pay or reward will be appropriate for the work that the worker has done. A worker who has worked well will receive a big reward. Here is another way to translate this:

for what they do (CEV)

In some languages it may be natural to translate the words according to his own labor as an adjective describing the reward; that is, as a proper or appropriate reward. For example, it may be possible to translate 3:8b as:

each will receive appropriate compensation

each will have the proper pay for the work that he has done (NJB)

General Comment on 3:7–8

In these verses Paul referred to himself in the third person as “he who plants” (3:7a) and “the man who plants” (3:8a). If this is not natural in your language, you may be able to:

- use plural third-person subjects. For example:

people who plant and people who water

- use plural first-person subjects. The “we” should include both Paul and Apollos, and should exclude Paul’s readers:

we^(excl) who plant and water

- use the singular first-person as the subject of “plants”:

I who plant and Apollos/he who waters

1 Corinthians 3:9

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God’s plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God’s church together.

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Paragraph 3:5–9

Paul told why the Corinthians should not divide into groups and following their favorite Christian workers. It was because all Christian workers are working for God. He and Apollos were not important in themselves. They were just servants of God whom God sent to help the Corinthians to believe.

3:9

In the Greek text of 3:9, the word “God” is emphasized three times. The workers belong to God. The church in Corinth belongs to God, not to Paul or Apollos. The church is like a building which God is making for himself to live in. Paul was trying to help the Corinthians understand that God is the important one. It was foolish to divide into competing groups following different workers, for the workers were all serving God..

3:9a

For we are God’s fellow workers;

- Apollos and I work together for God (CEV)
- For we^(excl) are workers/servants who do together what God orders us^(excl) to do.
- for we^(excl) are both workers who do his work.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces the grounds for what Paul has been saying. It is a very general connection and it may not be necessary to translate this word explicitly.

we are God's fellow workers: There are two ways of understanding the Greek clause that the BSB translates as we are God's fellow workers:

1. It indicates that Paul and Apollos were working together for God. For example:

we are fellow workers in God's service (REB)
(NRSV, NET, REB, NLT, NCV, GNT)

1. It indicates that Paul and Apollos were doing the same task as God. For example:

we are labourers together with God (KJV) (BSB, KJV, NIV, NASB, RSV, ESV, GW)

The NJB is ambiguous: "We do share in God's work." It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This fits better with the context of 3:7, where Paul and Apollos are said to be insignificant in comparison with God. Other ways to translate this include:

We are coworkers belonging to God. (NRSV)

We are God's workers, working together. (NCV)

we are both God's workers (NLT)

3:9b

you are God's field,

- and you believers in Corinth are a field/plot/garden that belongs to God.
- You are like the field that God has ordered us^(excl) to work in.
- God is the one you belong to, just like a field belongs to the owner.

you are God's field: This is a metaphor. Paul compared the Corinthian church to a field that God owned. This is a reference to a field used for growing crops, a field in which people plant and water seeds. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a simile:

you are like a field that belongs to God

3:9c

God's building.

- You are a house that belongs to God.
- Also, I can compare you to a house/building that God is building.
- Or think about yourselves in this way: All of you believers are like a building which God is constructing/making.

God's building: This is another metaphor. It is a short way of saying "you are also God's building." The phrase God's building means "a house/building that belongs to God." The Corinthian church as a whole was like a house that God was building for himself. God was causing this house to be built by using/ordering Paul and others to work for him. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a simile:

you are like a house belonging to God

In 3:6–9b, Paul used one metaphor: he talked about planting seeds and watering seeds and God making plants to grow. But here in 3:9c Paul changed to a new metaphor: he compared the Corinthian believers to God's building. This metaphor continues through 3:15. In some languages it may be natural to introduce this new metaphor with a word meaning "or" (as the JBP does)

or God's building

Most English versions begin a new paragraph at 3:10. (See 3:10 in the BSB, NASB, RSV, ESV, CEV, NJB, NIV, NLT, and the NCV). But some versions begin a new paragraph at 3:9c. (See 3:9 in the REB and the GNT).

1 Corinthians 3:10

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God's plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God's church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord's servants

All believers belong to the Lord and should remain united

Paragraph 3:10–15

In this paragraph Paul used an extended metaphor. This is about constructing a building. Paul said that he was an expert builder who laid a foundation. This means that he started the church in Corinth. He was the one who first preached the gospel in Corinth and first taught the people there to believe in Jesus.

Paul said that other people were building on the foundation that he had laid. This means that other Christian workers were continuing the work in Corinth. They were teaching the believers. God will reward such workers if they do their work faithfully.

In these verses Paul talked about a building, house-builders, the materials used to build the building, and about fire. It is best if you can keep this metaphor in your translation. But if the people who read your translation will not understand what Paul was saying, you may need to change how you translate it. There are several ways to translate these verses:

- literally, as a metaphor. For example:

I was the expert builder who laid the foundation.

- as a simile. For example:

I was like an expert builder who laid a foundation.

- giving both the metaphor and the meaning. For example:

I began God's work among you. I was like an expert builder who laid the foundation.

- giving the meaning of the metaphor without the metaphor. For example:

I began God's work among you.

This metaphor is an important part of Paul's teaching in 3:10–15. Because of this, it is best if you translate these verses using one of the first three methods above. You should remove the metaphor only if the people in your language group cannot understand the metaphor when it is translated in any of the first three ways. In the footnote is a sample translation of 3:10–15 that follows the third method. Here is a sample translation of 3:10–16 that translates the extended metaphor as a simile and also gives the

meaning:“(10a) God graciously gave me ability to do his work. So, using that ability, (10b) I began God's work among you. I was like a wise house builder who begins building a house by laying the foundation. (10c) Now, other workers are continuing God's work among you. they are like house builders who are building on top of the foundation that I already laid. (10d) But I warn each of those who are doing God's work: Be careful what you do! (11) No one should teach any other way to be saved, except the way that God has given us. Jesus Christ is the only Savior that God has given us. He is like the foundation to the house.(12a) Some workers do God's work well. They are like house builders who build on the foundation using good quality materials like gold, silver and valuable stones. (12b) Other workers do not do God's work well. They are like house builders who build on the foundation using poor-quality materials like wood, hay and straw. (13a) In the future it will become clear what kind of work each worker has done, (13b) because when Jesus returns, he will make this all clear. (13c) When he returns he will judge what everyone has done. When he judges people, it will be like a fire. (13d) It will be like a person who tests different materials by putting them in a fire to see if they are good quality or not. (14a) When Jesus judges the works of some workers, he will say/declare that their works are good. Their works will be like good quality materials that do not burn up in the fire. (14b) He will reward those workers. (15a) But when he judges the works of other workers, he will declare/say that their work was not good. Their works will be like poor-quality materials that burn up in the fire. (15b) These workers will not get any reward. (15c) God will still save them from the punishment of their sins, (15d) but all of the work they have done will be of no value. They will be like a person who has run out of a burning house: he did not die but everything he had was burned up.”

3:10a

By the grace God has given me,

- ¶ Using the ability that God graciously gave to me,
- ¶ God was gracious to me and made me able to work for him.

By the grace God has given me: The Greek word that the BSB translates as grace here refers to a gift or special ability that God had given Paul. God had made Paul an apostle and had given him the ability to do the work of an apostle. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as:

God has graciously enabled/allowed me

Using the gift that God gave me (GNT)

3:10b

I laid a foundation as an expert builder,

- I did the work of an wise/skillful expert house builder by laying the foundation.
- I was the first to preach the gospel among you, like a skilled builder laying a foundation.

I laid a foundation: A foundation is a strong stone base on which a house is built. It is the part of a building that the worker makes first. It holds up the rest of the building or it holds it together in a firm way. In some cultures, people start making a house or building by setting posts deep into the ground, or by putting up a center pole. If in your area people do not understand what a foundation is, you may want to substitute another part of a house that has a similar function. For example:

I planted the center pole

I put together the main beams on which the house is

I firmly set down the main rocks on which the house is

The meaning of this metaphor is that Paul began the church in Corinth with the firm foundation of the gospel of Jesus Christ. He was the first one to proclaim the gospel in Corinth.

as an expert builder: The Greek word that the BSB translates as builder refers to someone who is experienced at building. The Greek word that the BSB translates as expert means “skilled” or “wise.” It is the same word as in 1:19–20 and 1:25–27. In some languages it may be natural to put this information at the beginning of 3:10b. For example:

like a skilled master-builder I laid a foundation (NET)

3:10c

and someone else is building on it.

- Since that time, other workers are continuing the work by building on top of the foundation that I laid.
- Now other Christian workers are teaching you, just like other builders put/build the rest of the building on top of the foundation.

someone else is building on it: Paul was talking about other Christian workers in general who were continuing the work he began in Corinth. They were teaching and leading the believers there at that time.

someone else: Paul used a singular form here, but he was probably not referring to only one person. If it is more natural in your language, you can translate this using a plural. For example:

I laid a foundation on which others have built (3:10b-c, CEV).

3:10d

But each one must be careful how he builds.

- But every worker must be careful how he builds.
- But each worker must make sure that he teaches well/correctly, just like builders must make sure that they build carefully/correctly on the foundation,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates here as But introduces a warning. The RSV does not explicitly translate this conjunction. You should introduce Paul’s warning in a way that is natural in your language.

each one must be careful how he builds: This is a warning to the Christian workers in Corinth who were not doing God’s work well. Paul was probably talking about people in the Corinthian church who were causing the believers to argue about who was the best teacher. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Everyone should/must be careful how they build.

You workers, be careful how you each/all build.

1 Corinthians 3:11

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God’s plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God’s church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord’s servants

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In this paragraph Paul used an extended metaphor. This is about constructing a building. Paul said that he was an expert builder who laid a foundation. This means that he started the church in Corinth. He was the one who first preached the gospel in Corinth and first taught the people there to believe in Jesus.

Paul said that other people were building on the foundation that he had laid. This means that other Christian workers were continuing the work in Corinth. They were teaching the believers. God will reward such workers if they do their work faithfully.

In these verses Paul talked about a building, house-builders, the materials used to build the building, and about fire. It is best if you can keep this metaphor in your translation. But if the people who read your translation will not understand what Paul was saying, you may need to change how you translate it. There are several ways to translate these verses:

- literally, as a metaphor. For example:

I was the expert builder who laid the foundation.

- as a simile. For example:

I was like an expert builder who laid a foundation.

- giving both the metaphor and the meaning. For example:

I began God's work among you. I was like an expert builder who laid the foundation.

- giving the meaning of the metaphor without the metaphor. For example:

I began God's work among you.

This metaphor is an important part of Paul's teaching in 3:10–15. Because of this, it is best if you translate these verses using one of the first three methods above. You should remove the metaphor only if the people in your language group cannot understand the metaphor when it is translated in any of the first three ways. In the footnote is a sample translation of 3:10–15 that follows the third method. Here is a sample translation of 3:10–16 that translates the extended metaphor as a simile and also gives the

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3:11

For no one can lay a foundation other than the one already laid, which is Jesus Christ.

- For no one can put down a different/new foundation. The foundation has already been put in place. This foundation is Jesus Christ.
- because no one can put anything else as the foundation. Jesus Christ is the only foundation of God's house.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For here introduces the basis for what Paul had just said in 3:10d.

no one can lay a foundation other than the one already laid, which is Jesus Christ: This verse part

indicates that there is only one possible foundation for the church. In some languages it may be natural to reorder the phrases in this verse part as the NCV has done:

The foundation that has already been laid is Jesus Christ, and no one can lay down another foundation (NCV)

foundation...which is Jesus Christ: Paul continued to use the metaphor of the church as God's building. He said that the foundation of God's building is Jesus Christ. This probably means that the message about Jesus Christ must be the basis of all the other teaching of all Christian workers.

the one already laid, which is Jesus Christ: The verb laid is passive. In some languages it may be more natural to use a active verb and provide a subject. However, Paul did not say here who had laid this foundation. There are two possible subjects:

1. It was Paul who had laid the foundation. Paul laid the foundation among the Corinthians by telling them what God has done through Christ. The foundation is thus a metaphor for the message about Christ.
2. It was God who had laid the foundation. The foundation is the actual sending of Christ to die on the cross for our sins. For example:

God has already placed Jesus Christ as the one and only foundation, and no other foundation can be laid. (GNT)

Many English versions use the passive. Because of this they can be understood in either way: BSB, NIV, NET, KJV, NASB, RSV, ESV, REB, GW, NCV, and JBP.

It is recommended that you leave this ambiguous. You may be able to do this by using a passive verb or by following the NJB:

nobody can lay down any other foundation than the one which is there already, namely Jesus Christ (NJB)

If you must make the subject explicit, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This fits the context better, since Paul in 3:10b had just referred to himself as the one who laid the foundation. Paul laid the foundation in the sense that he preached about Jesus Christ and taught about who he was and what he did to save people.

1 Corinthians 3:12

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God's plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God's church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord's servants

All believers belong to the Lord and should remain united

Paragraph 3:10–15

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In these verses Paul talked about a building, house-builders, the materials used to build the building, and about fire. It is best if you can keep this metaphor in your translation. But if the people who read your translation will not understand what Paul was saying, you may need to change how you translate it. There are several ways to translate these verses:

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- as a simile. For example:

I was like an expert builder who laid a foundation.

- giving both the metaphor and the meaning. For example:

I began God's work among you. I was like an expert builder who laid the foundation.

- giving the meaning of the metaphor without the metaphor. For example:

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This metaphor is an important part of Paul's teaching in 3:10-15. Because of this, it is best if you translate these verses using one of the first three methods above. You should remove the metaphor only if the people in your language group cannot understand the metaphor when it is translated in any of the first three ways. In the footnote is a sample translation of 3:10-15 that follows the third method. Here is a sample translation of 3:10-16 that translates the extended metaphor as a simile and also gives the meaning: "(10a) God graciously gave me ability to do his work. So, using that ability, (10b) I began God's work among you. I was like a wise house builder who begins building a house by laying the foundation. (10c) Now, other workers are continuing God's work among you. they are like house builders who are building on top of the foundation that I already laid. (10d) But I warn each of those who are doing God's work: Be careful what you do! (11) No one should teach any other way to be saved, except the way that God has given us. Jesus Christ is the only Savior that God has given us. He is like the foundation to the house. (12a) Some workers do God's work well. They are like house builders who build on the foundation using good quality materials like gold, silver and valuable stones. (12b) Other workers do not do God's work well. They are like house builders who build on the foundation using poor-quality materials like wood, hay and straw. (13a) In the future it will become clear what kind of work each worker has done, (13b) because when Jesus returns, he will make this all clear. (13c) When he returns he will judge what everyone has done. When he judges people, it will be like a fire. (13d) It will be like a person who tests different materials by putting them in a fire to see if they are good quality or not. (14a) When Jesus judges the works of some workers, he will say/declare that their works are good. Their works will be like good quality materials that do not burn up in the fire. (14b) He will reward those workers. (15a) But when he judges the works of other workers, he will declare/say that their work was not good. Their works will be like poor-quality materials that burn up in the fire. (15b) These workers will not get any reward. (15c) God will still save them from the punishment of their sins, (15d) but all of the work they have done will

be of no value. They will be like a person who has run out of a burning house: he did not die but everything he had was burned up."

3:12

Paul wrote more about building an important house or building. In this verse he talked about the materials that the construction workers can decide to use. This is a metaphor. The building materials represent the quality of each Christian worker's work, that is, whether his teaching was focused on Christ or not.

3:12a

If anyone builds on this foundation using gold, silver, precious stones,

- Some workers use good material such as gold, silver, or valuable stones, to build upon that foundation.
- If Christian workers do their work well, they are like home/house builders who build on the foundation using high-quality materials such as gold, silver, and valuable stones.

gold, silver, precious stones: In the list of six materials, the first three are of lasting value and they will not burn. Also, they are fitting materials for making a beautiful building for God, such as a temple.

precious stones: The Greek word that the BSB translates as precious stones probably refers to gemstones like diamonds, rubies, or emeralds. See the CEV, KJV, NJB, JBP, NLT, NRSV, RSV, GNT and the REB. The NEB had "fine stone," that is, good quality stone. These kinds of stones were used to decorate buildings. The Jewish people decorated their temple with precious stones like this. Another way to translate this is:

jewels (NCV)

If in your language there is no word for jewels, you may be able to translate this as:

beautiful/valuable rocks/stones

expensive decorations

3:12b

wood, hay, or straw,

- Other workers use poor material such as wood, dried grass, or straw.
- But if Christian workers do not do their work well, they are like home/house builders who use poor-quality materials such as wood, hay, and straw.

wood, hay, or straw: The last three materials that Paul lists are not valuable as building materials. They

do not last as long, and they will burn if they catch fire. These materials represent work that Christian workers do that is not good quality.

wood: In some cultures wood may be considered a valuable and good quality building material. If this is the case in your language, you should try to translate wood with a word or phrase that refers to cheap, thin wood that can burn easily.

hay, or straw: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hay generally refers to grass. Here it probably refers to long dried grass. The word translated as straw refers to dried stalks of grain. In your translation, try to use words referring to cheap building materials that poor people can use to build temporary shelters.

General Comment on 3:12a-b

In some languages, it may be necessary to explain the meaning of this metaphor so that the readers will understand it. For example:

In building on this foundation, some workers use valuable, long lasting materials, such as gold, silver or valuable stones. Other workers build using materials that are not valuable or strong, such as wood, dried grass, or straw. So, in a similar way, some of God's workers faithfully teach God's ways. But other workers do not help God's people to understand God's ways.

1 Corinthians 3:13

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God's plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God's church together.

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means that he started the church in Corinth. He was the one who first preached the gospel in Corinth and first taught the people there to believe in Jesus.

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In these verses Paul talked about a building, house-builders, the materials used to build the building, and about fire. It is best if you can keep this metaphor in your translation. But if the people who read your translation will not understand what Paul was saying, you may need to change how you translate it. There are several ways to translate these verses:

- literally, as a metaphor. For example:

I was the expert builder who laid the foundation.

- as a simile. For example:

I was like an expert builder who laid a foundation.

- giving both the metaphor and the meaning. For example:

I began God's work among you. I was like an expert builder who laid the foundation.

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This metaphor is an important part of Paul's teaching in 3:10–15. Because of this, it is best if you translate these verses using one of the first three methods above. You should remove the metaphor only if the people in your language group cannot understand the metaphor when it is translated in any of the first three ways. In the footnote is a sample translation of 3:10–15 that follows the third method. Here is a sample translation of 3:10–16 that translates the extended metaphor as a simile and also gives the meaning:“(10a) God graciously gave me ability to do his work. So, using that ability, (10b) I began God's work among you. I was like a wise house builder who begins building a house by laying the foundation. (10c) Now, other workers are continuing God's work among you. they are like house builders who are building on top of the foundation that I already laid. (10d) But

I warn each of those who are doing God's work: Be careful what you do! (11) No one should teach any other way to be saved, except the way that God has given us. Jesus Christ is the only Savior that God has given us. He is like the foundation to the house. (12a) Some workers do God's work well. They are like house builders who build on the foundation using good quality materials like gold, silver and valuable stones. (12b) Other workers do not do God's work well. They are like house builders who build on the foundation using poor-quality materials like wood, hay and straw. (13a) In the future it will become clear what kind of work each worker has done, (13b) because when Jesus returns, he will make this all clear. (13c) When he returns he will judge what everyone has done. When he judges people, it will be like a fire. (13d) It will be like a person who tests different materials by putting them in a fire to see if they are good quality or not. (14a) When Jesus judges the works of some workers, he will say/declare that their works are good. Their works will be like good quality materials that do not burn up in the fire. (14b) He will reward those workers. (15a) But when he judges the works of other workers, he will declare/say that their work was not good. Their works will be like poor-quality materials that burn up in the fire. (15b) These workers will not get any reward. (15c) God will still save them from the punishment of their sins, (15d) but all of the work they have done will be of no value. They will be like a person who has run out of a burning house: he did not die but everything he had was burned up."

3:13a

his workmanship will be evident,

- Someday everyone will see the quality/kind of work each one has done,
- In the future it will become clear/obvious whether or not a person worked well.

his workmanship will be evident: This refers to what will happen in the future, when Christ returns. At the present time it is not always obvious whether the work that each person has done for God is good or not. When Christ returns and judges everything, it will become obvious.

There are at least two ways to translate the clause his workmanship will be evident:

- using a passive verb. For example:

each builder's work will be plainly seen (NET)

their work will be clearly seen (NCV)

- using an active verb. For example:

one/they/you will be able to see clearly what kind of work he has done

God will show everyone/others what kind of work he has done

3:13b

because the Day will bring it to light.

- because when Jesus returns, he will make these things clear/obvious.
- I say that because Jesus Christ will clearly make these things known when he returns.

because the Day will bring it to light: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Day here refers to the future time when Jesus will return to earth and judge people. He will examine the way believers worked for him. In some languages it may be necessary to make it clear what Day Paul was referring to. For example:

the Day of Judgment will make it visible (NCV)

In many languages it is not natural to talk about a Day bringing something to light. Since the Day here means the time when Jesus return and judges people, you can make Jesus the subject of the sentence in your translation:

because Christ Jesus will make it visible on the Day when he returns/judges

General Comment on 3:13a-b

These two verse parts are talking about the same thing in different words. So in some languages it may be natural to combine them. For example:

On the day/time when Christ judges all things, he will expose the quality of every person's work.

The day will make what each one does clearly visible. (GW)

3:13c

It will be revealed with fire,

- The day will come/arise/dawn with fire.
- That day will be a time of fiery testing.
- For that time will be like a time when materials are put in a fire to test them.

- In that day Christ is going to judge the work of people. It will be like putting it through fire.

In the Greek text 3:13c begins with a conjunction that is generally translated as “because.” 3:13c gives the reason why the Day will bring the quality of everyone’s work to light. The BSB does not explicitly translate this conjunction, but the RSV translates it as “because” and the GNT as “For.” You should connect 3:13c to 3:13b in the way that is most natural in your language.

It will be revealed with fire: There are two ways of interpreting this clause. The subject, It, could refer to:

1. the day, that is, the day Christ returns, judgment day. For example:

That day will appear with fire. (NCV) (NJB, REB, NCV)

1. each man’s work, that is, the quality of what each worker did. For example:

The day will make what each one does clearly visible because fire will reveal it. (GW) (GNT, GW, NLT)

Several English versions translate literally and do not explicitly say to what It refers: BSB, KJV, RSV, NASB, ESV, NIV.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the interpretation recommended by the majority of commentators. The Greek word for be revealed usually means that in the future someone will come or an event will take place. It does not normally refer to something being made clear by testing it.

with fire: In both the OT and NT, fire is a common metaphor for judgment. For example, see 2 Thessalonians 1:7-8: “When the Lord Jesus is revealed from heaven in blazing fire...he will punish...” Here also in 1 Corinthians 3:13 the fire probably refers to testing and judgment. In some languages it may be helpful to make this explicit. For example:

with the fire of judgment

3:13d

and the fire will prove the quality of each man’s work.

- The fire will test/show whether each worker has done good work.

- Just as fire makes clear/apparent which building materials are good/strong/valuable, so Christ will declare whether or not each worker has worked well.

the fire will prove the quality of each man’s work:

In this verse part Paul indicated that the fire would test how all the builders had done their work. It would check if they had used good materials. Here is another possible way to translate this:

the fire will test everyone’s work to see what sort of work it was (NCV)

1 Corinthians 3:14

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God’s plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God’s church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord’s servants

All believers belong to the Lord and should remain united

Paragraph 3:10–15

In this paragraph Paul used an extended metaphor. This is about constructing a building. Paul said that he was an expert builder who laid a foundation. This means that he started the church in Corinth. He was the one who first preached the gospel in Corinth and first taught the people there to believe in Jesus.

Paul said that other people were building on the foundation that he had laid. This means that other Christian workers were continuing the work in Corinth. They were teaching the believers. God will reward such workers if they do their work faithfully.

In these verses Paul talked about a building, house-builders, the materials used to build the building, and about fire. It is best if you can keep this metaphor in your translation. But if the people who read your translation will not understand what Paul was saying, you may need to change how you translate it. There are several ways to translate these verses:

- literally, as a metaphor. For example:

I was the expert builder who laid the foundation.

- as a simile. For example:

I was like an expert builder who laid a foundation.

- giving both the metaphor and the meaning. For example:

I began God's work among you. I was like an expert builder who laid the foundation.

- giving the meaning of the metaphor without the metaphor. For example:

I began God's work among you.

This metaphor is an important part of Paul's teaching in 3:10-15. Because of this, it is best if you translate these verses using one of the first three methods above. You should remove the metaphor only if the people in your language group cannot understand the metaphor when it is translated in any of the first three ways. In the footnote is a sample translation of 3:10-15 that follows the third method. Here is a sample translation of 3:10-16 that translates the extended metaphor as a simile and also gives the meaning: "(10a) God graciously gave me ability to do his work. So, using that ability, (10b) I began God's work among you. I was like a wise house builder who begins building a house by laying the foundation. (10c) Now, other workers are continuing God's work among you. They are like house builders who are building on top of the foundation that I already laid. (10d) But I warn each of those who are doing God's work: Be careful what you do! (11) No one should teach any other way to be saved, except the way that God has given us. Jesus Christ is the only Savior that God has given us. He is like the foundation to the house. (12a) Some workers do God's work well. They are like house builders who build on the foundation using good quality materials like gold, silver and valuable stones. (12b) Other workers do not do God's work well. They are like house builders who build on the foundation using poor-quality materials like wood, hay and straw. (13a) In the future it will become clear what kind of work each worker has done, (13b) because when Jesus returns, he will make this all clear. (13c) When he returns he will judge what everyone has done. When he judges people, it will be like a fire. (13d) It will be like a person who tests different materials by putting them in a fire to see if they are good quality or not. (14a) When Jesus judges the works of some workers,

he will say/declare that their works are good. Their works will be like good quality materials that do not burn up in the fire. (14b) He will reward those workers. (15a) But when he judges the works of other workers, he will declare/say that their work was not good. Their works will be like poor-quality materials that burn up in the fire. (15b) These workers will not get any reward. (15c) God will still save them from the punishment of their sins, (15d) but all of the work they have done will be of no value. They will be like a person who has run out of a burning house: he did not die but everything he had was burned up."

3:14a

If what he has built survives,

- If the work that a worker has built on the foundation does not burn up,
- If Christ says/declares that what a certain worker has done is good,

If what he has built survives: This clause gives the condition that must exist in order for 3:14b to happen. Most English versions use the word *If* to introduce this condition. The NJB has stated the condition without using the word *If*.

The one whose work stands up to it [will be given his wages]

You should translate this condition in a way that is natural for your language.

he: The pronoun *he* here does not refer to any one specific person. It refers to any Christian worker. In some language it may therefore be natural to use plural forms. For example:

If what they have built endures....

The work that some workers have done will survive. In that case...

has built: The Greek word for *has built* literally means "has built on." It refers to the way that walls are built on a foundation. So 3:14a can be translated as:

If what he has built on the foundation survives...

survives: The verb *survives* means "lasts, endures, does not burn up." If good quality materials like gold, silver or jewels are put in a fire, the fire will not burn them up. These things will "survive." So also, when

Jesus judges the work a person has done and says that it is good, his work has “survived” the judgment.

3:14b

he will receive a reward.

- he/Christ will give a reward to that person/worker.
- he/Christ will reward that worker.

he will receive a reward: See the note on 3:8b. The Greek word that the BSB translates as reward here refers to the way Christ will do good to a worker because he has done God’s work faithfully. In the metaphor it refers to the pay that a good construction worker receives. The Bible often talks about rewards. In Jesus’ sermons and parables he talked about rewarding people. See, for example, Matthew 5:12, 6:1, 10:42, 25:21. He helps us understand what the rewards will be like, such as praise from a good master (Matthew 25:21), a position of honor with Jesus in the future, and taking part in important responsibilities (Matthew 25:21–23). Other ways to translate this include:

he will be rewarded (REB)

the builder will get a reward (NCV)

1 Corinthians 3:15

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God’s plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God’s church together.

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given us. Jesus Christ is the only Savior that God has given us. He is like the foundation to the house. (12a) Some workers do God's work well. They are like house builders who build on the foundation using good quality materials like gold, silver and valuable stones. (12b) Other workers do not do God's work well. They are like house builders who build on the foundation using poor-quality materials like wood, hay and straw. (13a) In the future it will become clear what kind of work each worker has done, (13b) because when Jesus returns, he will make this all clear. (13c) When he returns he will judge what everyone has done. When he judges people, it will be like a fire. (13d) It will be like a person who tests different materials by putting them in a fire to see if they are good quality or not. (14a) When Jesus judges the works of some workers, he will say/declare that their works are good. Their works will be like good quality materials that do not burn up in the fire. (14b) He will reward those workers. (15a) But when he judges the works of other workers, he will declare/say that their work was not good. Their works will be like poor-quality materials that burn up in the fire. (15b) These workers will not get any reward. (15c) God will still save them from the punishment of their sins, (15d) but all of the work they have done will be of no value. They will be like a person who has run out of a burning house: he did not die but everything he had was burned up."

3:15a

If it is burned up,

- But if his work is burned up,
- But if/when Christ says/declares that what a certain worker has done is not good,

If it is burned up: Fire is a metaphor for judgment as a testing time (see the note on 3:13c). The picture of work being burned up illustrates a situation in which Christ declares that a worker has not done his work faithfully. His work did not help the church as God meant it to. Just as a fire burns up poor-quality materials like wood or straw, so when Christ judges these people, he will show that the work they have done is of no value.

The verb is burned up is in the passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

if it is destroyed by the fire (CEV)

The one whose work is burned down... (NJB)

- using an active verb. For example:

If the fire destroys/consumes someone's work

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language in this context.

3:15b

he will suffer loss.

- that worker will get nothing.
- he/Christ will not reward that worker/person.

he will suffer loss: The clause he will suffer loss here means "the builder/worker will lose his reward," that is, "the builder/worker will not receive his reward." This verse part continues the metaphor. Its literal meaning is that a worker will lose (that is, not receive) what his boss had planned to give him as his pay. This figure of speech means that Christ will withhold some blessings or benefits which otherwise he would have given to his worker. Other ways to translate this include:

the builder will suffer great loss (NLT)

he will lose that reward

3:15c

He himself will be saved,

- He himself, however, will be saved,
- Yet God will save him personally.
- He will receive salvation,

In the Greek text 3:15c connects to 3:15b with a conjunction that the GNT translates as "but." The BSB does not translate this conjunction. Here the conjunction indicates contrast: what happens to the worker is different from what happens to his work. The RSV translates this conjunction as "though."

You should indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

He himself will be saved: This clause literally indicates that the builder will not die, that is, perish in the fire that consumed his work. The metaphor indicates that a Christian worker will not fail to receive salvation even if he has not worked well. This is a passive clause. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the builder will be saved

- Use an active verb. For example:

he himself will not lose his life

They/God will save the worker himself

himself: The Greek word that the BSB translates as himself here probably has a intensive meaning. It emphasizes the contrast between what happens to work done by the worker versus what happens to the worker himself.

3:15d

but only as if through the flames.

- but only like somebody escapes though fire/flames.
- But he will be like a person who has to be saved from a fire.
- but only in the way a person is rescued from a burning building.

but only as if through the flames: There are two ways to interpret the Greek expression that the BSB translates as through the flames.

1. It means through flames or through fire. The person must escape by passing through fire, or like someone passing through fire. For example:

though it will be like going through a fire (GW)
(BSB, NIV, REB, GW, NLT, NASB, RSV, ESV, NET)

1. It means from flames or from fire. The person escapes the fire and does not necessarily have to pass through it. For example, the NJB says;

as someone might expect to be saved from a fire
(NJB, CEV, NCV)

The KJV has “by fire,” which could mean either. If you must choose between the interpretations, it is recommended that you choose interpretation (1). The person is indeed saved from the fire, but he has to go through the flames, like a worker who is rescued from his burning building. This figure of speech shows how serious it is if a worker for God does not faithfully carry out his task. Paul was emphasizing how important it is for a worker to build well. Other ways to translate this include:

though only by passing through the fire (REB)

but like someone barely escaping through a wall of flames (NLT)

1 Corinthians 3:16

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God’s plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God’s church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord’s servants

All believers belong to the Lord and should remain united

Paragraph 3:16–17

Paul now explained that the building the workers were helping to make is the church, the community of God’s people. It is like a holy/sacred building, a place for God to live in. Some workers were causing divisions in the church by trying to get people to follow their own teachings. They were causing believers to give up trusting in Christ alone as their leader. It was as though they were causing the church to fall apart instead of building it up. Paul warned that God will severely punish such false workers.

3:16a-b

Do you not know...?: This introduces a rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question to rebuke the Corinthian believers. He meant “Surely you know this,” or “You should know that this is true.” Paul was reminding the Corinthians of something that they should already have known. They were acting as though they did not know it. So there are at least two ways of translating this question:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you not know that you are God’s temple and that God’s Spirit lives in you? (NET)

- as a statement. For example:

I want you to remember that....

Surely you know that...

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language for rebuking someone.

3:16a

Do you not know that you yourselves are God's temple,

- ¶ Surely you know that you yourselves are like a temple for/of God
- ¶ I want you to remember that you yourselves are like a holy place/building where God is present.

you yourselves are God's temple: Paul continued the metaphor of the building and those working on it. He explained that the kind of building that God had sent him to build was God's temple in Corinth. A temple is a sacred building where God or gods are believed to be present in a special way. But the temple Paul was referring to here was not a building people could look at. Instead, God's temple was his people. God was present in and among his people. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as a simile:

you yourselves are like a temple of/for God

God's temple: The phrase God's temple here indicates a sacred building or location where God is present in a special way. Other ways to translate this include:

a house for God to dwell/live in

a special house for God

3:16b

and that God's Spirit dwells in you?

- and that God's Spirit is living among you^(plur).
- The Holy Spirit of/from God dwells in your midst.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces something that explains the previous statement. It explains in what way the believers in Corinth could be called "God's temple" (3:16a). It may be natural to make this relationship clear by following one of these models:

you are a temple of God with the Spirit of God living in you (NJB)

you are God's temple, where the Spirit of God dwells (REB)

God's Spirit dwells in you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as you is plural. The word you^(plur) included all of the believers in Corinth. Paul said that

the Holy Spirit was in the church as a whole. The entire congregation of believers in Corinth was like a temple. So it is also possible to translate this as:

God's Spirit dwells among you^(plur)

1 Corinthians 3:17

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God's plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God's church together.

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3:17a

If anyone destroys God's temple,

- If any person destroys this temple of/for God,
- If some workers cause you who are like God's temple to become disunited/disunified,

If anyone destroys God's temple: Paul continued the metaphor. He warned people against destroying, that is, ruining or harming, the church, the holy place where God is present. He did not say how someone might destroy it. It might be through causing division over leadership or doctrine. Or it might be by giving false teaching, by adding to God's message or taking away from God's message.

3:17b

God will destroy him;

- then God will punish that person severely,
- God will ruin those workers completely.

God will destroy him: This verse part indicates that God will judge and punish anyone who does harm to the church. Try to translate the verb destroy using the same or a related verb to the verb you used in 3:17a. For example:

God will bring him to ruin

General Comment on 3:17a-b

Paul gave a condition in 3:17a and a consequence in 3:17b. In English a condition is usually introduced by the word “If” as the BSB has done. It is possible to state a condition without using “If.” The CEV has done this by reversing the order of the condition and the consequence.

^{17b}God will destroy ^{17a}anyone who destroys his temple.

You should translate this in a way that is natural for your language.

General Comment on 3:17a-b

Paul was talking about anyone and everyone who might harm God’s church. So in some languages it may be more natural to use plural forms. For example:

^{17a}As for those who destroy God’s temple, ^{17b}God will destroy them.

3:17c

for God’s temple is holy,

- because the temple/place where God lives is holy,
- God’s dwelling place is set apart for God himself,

for God’s temple is holy: Paul now gave the reason why God will destroy anyone who destroys his temple.

holy: The word that the BSB has translated as holy refers to something dedicated to God. Here is another way to translate this:

sacred (NIV)

3:17d

and you are that temple.

- and you yourselves as a group are that very holy temple/place.
- and you^(plur) are God’s dwelling place.

and you are that temple: The clause that the BSB translates as and you are that temple is literally “who you are” in the Greek. The pronoun you is plural. This clause probably emphasizes that the believers in Corinth were indeed a temple for God, and so by implication they were holy/sacred. Another way to translate this is:

You are that holy temple! (GW)

1 Corinthians 3:18

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God’s plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God’s church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord’s servants

All believers belong to the Lord and should remain united

Paragraph 3:18–23

Paul summarized what he had been saying in this section (3:1–3:23) by giving two warnings. First, no one should follow the wisdom of this world. Second, no one should boast about following one teacher or another. This could cause divisions in the church. God in his wisdom sent Christ to be the only leader of his people. All the teachers should agree with Christ in their teaching.

3:18a

Let no one deceive himself.

- ¶ I do not want anyone to keep deceiving himself.
- ¶ Stop deluding yourselves.

Let no one deceive himself: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as Let no one deceive himself is a command in the singular third person, addressed to each believer as an individual. You may use whichever person is more natural in your language. For example, you may translate this:

- using the second-person singular:

You should not fool yourself. (GNT)

- using the second-person plural:

Do not deceive yourselves. (NIV)

- using the third-person singular:

Let no one deceive himself. (BSB)

Apparently some believers in Corinth thought that they were wiser than other believers because of the teacher that they followed (see the notes on 1:12b, 1:12c, and 1:12d). They were mistaken in thinking this, and Paul was rebuking them for allowing themselves to think wrongly about this. Other ways to translate this include:

Guard against self-deception, each of you. (NET)

Do not fool yourselves. (NCV)

Make no mistake about this. (REB)

deceive himself: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deceive suggests that some people were thinking incorrectly about teachers, and Paul wanted them to stop. Another way to translate this is:

stop deceiving himself/themselves

3:18b

If any of you thinks he is wise in this age,

- Any of you who considers himself to be wise according to the standards/opinion of this age/world
- Some of you consider yourselves to be wise, in the way that people of this world think about wisdom.

If any of you thinks he is wise in this age: Paul was talking to some people in the church at Corinth who thought they were wise. They were using human wisdom to decide which teacher was best and then had pride in the teacher they followed.

wise in this age: The phrase that the BSB translates as wise in this age refers to what is considered wise by the standards of this age. Evidently some of the Corinthian believers were deciding who was the best teacher by using the same standards that unbelievers used to judge their teachers. This would include deciding whether they spoke persuasively and argued

cleverly and used clever ideas. Another way to translate this is:

what this world considers wise

this age: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as this age refers to this time we live in before Christ returns. See how you translated this phrase in 1:20c.

3:18c

he should become a fool,

- must become one who is thought foolish.
- You must be willing to stop thinking like this and let others/unbelievers consider you to be foolish

he should become a fool: The clause he should become a fool indicates that these proud believers should give up their worldly wisdom. They should stop trying to be wise in the way that people of the world admire. Instead they should become fools according to the world's standard by accepting what God considers wise (see 1:18a).

Other ways to translate this verse part include:

he must make himself foolish in the opinion of others

let him discard his cleverness (JBP)

he should do what the world considers foolish and accept God's wisdom

fool: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as fool means someone who is not very smart rather than someone who is a mad or crazy person.

3:18d

so that he may become wise.

- In that way you may become wise in God's opinion.
- so that God can make you truly wise.

so that he may become wise: This is a purpose clause. When a person stops judging by this world's standard and starts living by God's standards, then he becomes a fool in the eyes of the world and wise in the eyes of God. Other ways to translate this include:

so that you may know/receive true wisdom

that he may become truly wise (JBP)

General Comment on 3:18a-d

The Greek uses singular forms throughout this verse. Paul was not talking about any one individual. So in some languages it may be natural to use plural forms throughout. For example:

^{18a}Do not deceive yourselves. ^{18b}Those of who you think you are clever in the ways of this world ^{18c}must be willing to be thought fools ^{18d}in order to become wise.

^{18a}Do not deceive yourselves. ^{18b}If you^(plur) think you are wise in the ways of this world, ^{18c}you must get rid of your cleverness ^{18d}in order to become truly wise.

1 Corinthians 3:19

Section 3:1-23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

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3:19a

For the wisdom of this world is foolishness in God's sight.

- For what the people of this world think is wise/clever, God says is foolish/worthless.

- I say that because the things the people of this world consider/call wise/clever are of no value in the way God looks at things.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For here introduces Paul's basis for saying that a person wise in this world needed to abandon his worldly wisdom. Here is another way to translate this:

This is because (CEV)

the wisdom of this world is foolishness in God's

sight: Paul was indicating that the people of the world think totally differently from how God thinks. They have different standards and values. What the world considers wisdom, God considers foolishness. See how you translated foolishness in 1:18a.

In some languages it may be natural to translate one or both of the abstract nouns wisdom and foolishness with adjectives. For example, the CEV translated wisdom as a noun but changed foolishness to an adjective:

God considers the wisdom of this world to be foolish. (CEV)

Or you could translate both nouns as adjectives. For example:

God thinks foolish the things that this world considers wise.

God thinks that the things this world considers to be wise are, in fact, foolish.

3:19b

As it is written:

- This is like the words written in the Scriptures:
- We know that is true because it agrees with what God's Book says. It says this:

As it is written: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as As and the RSV as "For" here introduces some Scriptures that support what Paul had just said. These quotations show that what this world's people think is wise is actually not wise at all in the way God thinks about things. See the notes on it is written in 1:19a.

3:19c

"He catches the wise in their craftiness."

- "He traps the wise in their own cunning." (REB)

- “Some people think they are wise, but God uses their own clever thoughts/plans to defeat them.”

He catches the wise in their craftiness: This is a quotation from Job 5:13. One of Job’s friends was speaking. The pronoun He refers to God. This is a metaphor taken from hunting and trapping animals. A hunter knows about the crafty ways of the animal he wants to catch, and he uses that knowledge to trap it. In a similar way, God can use a person’s most clever arguments to show that person that he is wrong.

catches: The verb catches here is a figure of speech. It means that God defeats these people.

In the BSB, as in the Greek, the words “wise” and “craftiness” are not part of the metaphor. They have their literal meaning and help the reader to understand the metaphor.

Other ways to translate this verse part include:

God uses the cleverness of wise people as a trap to catch them. (Ellington and Hatton)

He catches those who are wise in their own clever traps. (NCV)

He traps the wise in the snare of their own craftiness. (NLT)

1 Corinthians 3:20

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God’s plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God’s church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord’s servants

All believers belong to the Lord and should remain united

Paragraph 3:18–23

Paul summarized what he had been saying in this section (3:1–3:23) by giving two warnings. First, no one should follow the wisdom of this world. Second,

no one should boast about following one teacher or another. This could cause divisions in the church. God in his wisdom sent Christ to be the only leader of his people. All the teachers should agree with Christ in their teaching.

3:20a

And again,

- And these words are also written in the Scriptures:
- And it also says this:

And again: The words that the BSB translates as And again are translated literally from the Greek. Paul quoted another verse from Scripture to support his statement in 3:19. In some languages it may be natural to follow the GNT and say explicitly:

and another scripture says (GNT)

3:20b

“The Lord knows that the thoughts of the wise are futile.”

- “The Lord knows that what wise/clever people think is worthless.”
- “Some people consider themselves to be wise, but the Lord knows that their plans/thoughts are of no value.”

The Lord knows that the thoughts of the wise are futile: This is a quotation from Psalm 94:11. It indicates that God is aware that people who consider themselves wise think thoughts that are ultimately foolish and useless.

the thoughts of the wise: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as thoughts refers to schemes/plans/reasonings. The phrase the wise refers to people who are clever according to the standards of this world.

futile: The Greek word that the BSB translates as futile means “empty, useless.” When human beings refuse God’s way of looking at things and make up their own thoughts, their thinking is useless. Other ways to translate this include

worthless (GNT)

pointless (GW)

like a puff of wind (compare NCV)

1 Corinthians 3:21

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God's plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God's church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord's servants

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Paragraph 3:18–23

Paul summarized what he had been saying in this section (3:1–3:23) by giving two warnings. First, no one should follow the wisdom of this world. Second, no one should boast about following one teacher or another. This could cause divisions in the church. God in his wisdom sent Christ to be the only leader of his people. All the teachers should agree with Christ in their teaching.

3:21a

Therefore, stop boasting in men.

- So you should no longer boast about human beings.
- So then, stop talking proudly about your human leaders.
- Therefore, I command/urge you: Do not brag/boast about which teacher you follow,

Therefore: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Therefore here introduces Paul's conclusion to what he had been saying.

stop boasting in men: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as stop boasting in men is literally "let no one glory in humans/people." There are at least two ways of understanding this:

1. It means that the Corinthians were to stop taking pride in the human leaders and teachers they followed. For example:

you should not brag about human leaders (NCV) (NCV, NRSV, NLT)

1. It means that the Corinthians were not to boast about what people could do. For example:

no one...should boast about what human beings can do (GNT) (GNT, CEV)

The BSB, RSV, NIV, KJV, NASB, ESV, GW, NJB, JBP, and REB translate this literally so that either interpretation can be understood. A possible model for a literal translation is the REB:

never make any human being a cause for boasting (REB)

If you must choose between the interpretations, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul was probably referring back to what he wrote in 1:12. Some Corinthian believers were boasting that they followed Paul or Apollos. Here in 3:21a, Paul commanded them to not boast about who their leaders were. Other ways to translate this include:

do not boast about being the follower/disciple of any human being

stop bragging about which human leader you follow

3:21b

All things are yours,

- All things belong to you,
- because already you have everything.

In the Greek text 3:21b is connected to 3:21a with a conjunction. In this context it introduces the basis for Paul's command in 3:21a. In other words, 3:21b gives the reason believers should not proudly say they follow one teacher and not another. The BSB has not explicitly translated this conjunction, but the RSV translates it as "for."

You should introduce this verse part in a way that is natural in your language.

All things are yours: The expression All things are yours can also be translated as "All things belong to you." All things belong to believers because they belong to Christ and have everything in him. Paul was arguing that it was foolish to argue over which teacher was the best because God had already given the Corinthians everything by joining them together with Christ.

3:21b is a general statement, and Paul followed it by listing eight specific things that are ours in Christ. The first three are people; the last five are things. In your language you may need to separate the people from the things. For a good explanation of what Paul talks about in 3:21–23, see Gordon D. Fee’s book on 1 Corinthians, pages 152–155.

1 Corinthians 3:22

Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God’s plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God’s church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord’s servants

All believers belong to the Lord and should remain united

Paragraph 3:18–23

Paul summarized what he had been saying in this section (3:1–3:23) by giving two warnings. First, no one should follow the wisdom of this world. Second, no one should boast about following one teacher or another. This could cause divisions in the church. God in his wisdom sent Christ to be the only leader of his people. All the teachers should agree with Christ in their teaching.

3:22a–e

In verse 22, Paul listed eight things that belonged to the Corinthian Christians because of their relationship with Christ. In the Greek these eight things are listed in an “either-or” relationship. They could also be put into a coordinate (“and”) statement such as:

Paul, Apollos, and Peter; the world, life, death, the present, and the future—all these belong to you. (NCV)

Paul, Apollos, and Peter; this world, life and death, the present and the future—all these are yours. (GNT)

You should express these eight things in a way that is natural for your language.

3:22a

whether Paul or Apollos or Cephas

- including I Paul and Apollos and Peter.
- Apollos and Peter and I belong to you.
- God has given/sent you teachers/leaders like me and Apollos and Cephas/Peter.

whether Paul or Apollos or Cephas: See the notes on 1:12b, 1:12c, and 1:12d. Because the Corinthian Christians were in Christ, Paul and Apollos and Cephas belonged to them. These leaders “belonged” to the Corinthians in the sense that God’s purpose in giving them these leaders was that the leaders would serve the Corinthians and help them become strong in faith. In some languages it may not be possible to say that these leaders “belonged” to the Corinthians. This might convey the wrong meaning that they were slaves. So it may be necessary to say something like:

Paul and Apollos and Cephas, all serve you

Paul and Apollos and Cephas live/work for your sake/good

God has given/sent you Paul and Apollos and Cephas to help you

In some languages it may not be natural for Paul to mention himself first. Put this list of names in the order that is natural in your language.

Paul: In some languages it may be necessary for Paul to speak of himself using the first-person pronoun:

I Paul

I

Cephas: Cephas is another name for Jesus’ disciple Simon Peter. You may wish to follow the GNT and use the better-known name Peter here.

3:22b

or the world

- It/This includes the whole world,
- The world belongs to you.

3:22c

or life or death

- life and death,

- Life belongs to you. Death belongs to you.

3:22d**or the present or the future.**

- whatever happens during this present time and whatever happens in the future time.
- The things that are happening now belong to you. The things that will happen in the future belong to you.

3:22b-d

the world or life or death or the present or the future: In this verse part Paul listed five things that now “belonged” to the Corinthians. They are things that people often fear and do not understand. But when people are joined to Christ, these things belong to them and serve them. They can understand that God is using all these things for good in their lives. Other ways to translate this include:

this world or this life or dying or what is happening now or what will happen later

this world and our living and dying, and events that take place now and in the future

3:22e**All of them belong to you,**

- All these belong to you.
- All those people and all those things are for your sake.
- God causes all those things to serve/help you.

All of them belong to you: The words All of them belong to you are almost the same as 3:21b, “All things are yours.” In your translation you can make 3:21b and 3:22e exactly the same, or you can make them a little different, depending on what sounds natural in your language. For example:

All these things are yours

1 Corinthians 3:23**Section 3:1–23: Christian workers serve the Lord by building his church together**

In this section Paul told the believers in Corinth that they had not become spiritually mature. That was why they were dividing into separate groups and arguing with one another about teachers. They needed to learn about God’s plan for Christian workers and leaders. Christian workers and leaders all belong to God and are all building God’s church together.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul and all the other apostles were the Lord’s servants

All believers belong to the Lord and should remain united

Paragraph 3:18–23

Paul summarized what he had been saying in this section (3:1–3:23) by giving two warnings. First, no one should follow the wisdom of this world. Second, no one should boast about following one teacher or another. This could cause divisions in the church. God in his wisdom sent Christ to be the only leader of his people. All the teachers should agree with Christ in their teaching.

3:23a**and you belong to Christ,**

- Furthermore/moreover, you are Christ’s,

and: The Greek word that the BSB translates as and introduces a further development in Paul’s talk. Paul now talks about the Corinthian Christians’ relationship with Christ.

you belong to Christ: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as you belong to Christ indicates that the Corinthian believers were the possession of Christ. They are who they are because of Christ. Their relationship to all other things comes through their relationship with Christ. They belong to Christ and should live only for Christ. Other ways to translate this include:

you are of Christ (NIV)

you are Christ’s people/possession

3:23b**and Christ belongs to God.**

- and Christ is God’s.

and: The Greek word that the BSB translates as and introduces a further development of Paul’s logic.

Christ belongs to God: The phrase Christ belongs to God indicates that Christ lived (and lives) for God and for God’s glory. Here is another way to translate this:

Christ is of God (NIV)

1 Corinthians 4:1

Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul's teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect him and Apollos

Paul and Apollos deserved respect as Christ's servants

Paragraph 4:1–5

Paul explained that he was a worker whom Christ had sent to teach and work for him. Christ alone was the one to decide whether or not Paul had done his work well.

4:1a

So then, men ought to regard us as servants of Christ

- ¶ As for us^(excl) teachers/evangelists, you should think about us^(excl) like this: We^(excl) are Christ's helpers/servants,
- ¶ You should consider us^(excl) Christian workers to be merely people who serve Christ.

So then, men ought to regard us as servants of Christ: There are two ways of understanding the Greek word that the BSB translates *So then*:

1. It means "in this way" and refers forward. For example:

Think of us in this way, as servants of Christ... (NRSV) (KJV, RSV, NASB, NET)

1. It refers back and introduces a conclusion to what Paul had just said. For example:

So look at Apollos and me as mere servants of Christ (NLT) (BSB, NIV, NLT)

Many English versions do not explicitly translate this conjunction. In English this would be a natural way

of translating interpretation (1) rather than interpretation (2). It is therefore recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

men ought to regard us as servants of Christ: This verse part indicates the way in which believers should view or think about Christian workers. Other ways to translate this include:

People should think of us as servants of Christ (NCV)

People should consider us to be Christ's servants.

This functions as a command to the Corinthians to regard Christian workers as servants of Christ. In some languages it may be natural to translate this command using the second person ("you"). For example:

You^(plur) should regard us as Christ's servants.

Think of us as servants of Christ. (CEV)

us: The pronoun *us* here refers to Paul and his fellow workers. If you need to make this explicit, you could say:

As for us^(excl) teachers/evangelists, here is how you should think about us^(excl).

servants of Christ: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *servants* refers to people who work for others. The phrase *servants of Christ* refers to people who work for Christ. They belong to him and serve him. The Greek word for *servants* is different from the one in 3:5, but the meaning is similar. You may translate this using the same word or expression as you used in 3:5.

4:1b

and stewards of the mysteries of God.

- and God has made us^(excl) guardians/trustees of the things/matters that previously he did not make known to anyone.
- God has sent us^(excl) to tell people his plans/teachings that he has never told anyone before.

stewards of the mysteries of God: This phrase indicates that Paul and his fellow workers had been given responsibility for God's hidden truths. Their job was to proclaim and teach these truths correctly. In many languages it may be necessary to make this explicit:

stewards entrusted with proclaiming/declaring the mysteries of God

stewards: The Greek word that the BSB translates as stewards is more literally “household-managers, administrators.” The Greek word *oikonomoi* means “stewards, house-managers, administrators.” In Bible times a rich man with many servants and much land usually had one special servant who was called a steward. He was the one in charge of the household and fields. His job was to oversee the other servants as they did the work. By using that word here, Paul meant that Christ had made him and his fellow workers responsible for telling God’s people all about the good things God had prepared for them and for teaching God’s people to follow his ways. This is a metaphor. Paul was indicating that he and his fellow workers were like managers of someone’s important possessions. Christ had given them an important work to do for God and they were responsible to him for doing it faithfully.

There are several ways of translating this metaphor:

- keep the metaphor and use a word referring to someone who manages or organizes another person’s goods or wealth. For example:

we^(excl) are managers/trustees

- as a simile. For example:

we^(excl) are like administrators/stewards

- explain the meaning of the metaphor. Some possible ways to explain the metaphor include:

we^(excl) have been given the responsibility/duty

God has put us^(excl) in charge of

the mysteries of God: For the Greek word that the BSB translates as mysteries, see the notes on 2:1c and 2:7a. The mysteries of God are the truths that God did not reveal clearly to anyone in the past, but that he has now revealed to all believers. God had not told anyone these mysteries until Christ came to earth, and now he has sent the apostles to tell everyone. Here is another way to translate this:

God’s secret truths (GNT)

General Comment on 4:1a-b

In the Greek text these verse parts are connected with a conjunction, which the BSB translates literally as “and.” This conjunction here introduces a further explanation of what Paul had said about himself and other Christian workers. They were servants in the sense that they were stewards of God’s mysteries. It was their task or duty to preach God’s secret truths. There are several other ways to translate this connection:

- use a relative pronoun such as “who”:

Think of us as servants of Christ who have been given the work of explaining God’s mysterious ways (CEV)

You should think of us as Christ’s servants, who have been put in charge of God’s secret truths. (GNT)

- omit the conjunction and use a comma:

People should think of us as Christ’s servants, stewards entrusted with the mysteries of God. (NJB)

People should think of us as servants of Christ, the ones God has trusted with his secrets. (NCV)

- start a new sentence:

You should consider us Christian workers to be merely people who serve Christ. God has given us the responsibility/duty of proclaiming truths he has not previously revealed.

Connect 4:1a and b in whichever way is natural in your language.

1 Corinthians 4:2

Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul’s teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect him and Apollos

Paul and Apollos deserved respect as Christ's servants

Paragraph 4:1–5

Paul explained that he was a worker whom Christ had sent to teach and work for him. Christ alone was the one to decide whether or not Paul had done his work well.

4:2

Now it is required of stewards that they be found faithful.

- In such a case, it is necessary that stewards/guardians/trustees do their work faithfully.
- And people who have been given a responsibility like this must show themselves to be dependable/trustworthy.
- Since God has given us^(excl) this responsibility, it is our^(excl) duty to fulfill/perform it faithfully.

Now: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Now is more literally “here moreover.” In this context it introduces another part or aspect of Paul’s metaphor. It may be also translated with a phrase like “in such a case” or “in a situation like that.”

it is required of stewards that they be found faithful: Paul pointed out what people expect from servants who have a job to do. The servant must do his work in the way his master wants him to. It is necessary for him to be trustworthy and dependable. Other ways to translate this include:

a person who has been put in charge as a manager must be faithful (NLT)

Managers are required to be trustworthy (GW)

what is expected of stewards is that each one should be found trustworthy (NJB)

If you have used the pronoun “we/us” in the previous verse part it may be natural to continue using it here. For example:

it is necessary that we^(excl) who have been given this trust must prove faithful

our first duty is to be faithful to the one we work for (CEV)

stewards: The Greek word that the BSB translates as stewards is the same word that was translated stewards in 4:1b. It is literally “administrators.” See the notes and endnote on 4:1b. Use the same word or phrase here that you used there. If it not natural in your language to repeat this word/phrase, make sure that it is clear that the same people are being referred to.

they be found faithful: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as be found faithful indicates that people must be able to see that a steward has been faithful.

This clause is passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

they should be found trustworthy (NRSV)

- Use an active verb. The implied subject is whoever put the steward in charge. For example:

must be a person his master can trust (WE)

faithful: The Greek word that the BSB translates as faithful in this context means “dependable” or “trustworthy” (RSV). The servant must follow the instructions of his master.

1 Corinthians 4:3

Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul’s teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

Other possible section headings include:

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Paragraph 4:1–5

Paul explained that he was a worker whom Christ had sent to teach and work for him. Christ alone was the one to decide whether or not Paul had done his work well.

4:3a**I care very little, however,**

- But it does not matter to me
- But it is not important to me

I care very little, however: In Greek this verse part connects to the previous verse part with a conjunction that the BSB translates as however. In this context this conjunction introduces the next point in Paul's argument. This point involves some contrast with what Paul has just said. English versions introduce this next point in a variety of ways. The NIV, REB, and NJB, for example, leave the conjunction untranslated. Other versions say:

But with me it is a very small thing (RSV)

Now, I am not at all concerned (GNT)

You may introduce this next point in Paul's argument in the way that is most natural in your language.

I care very little: Paul did not mean that he did not care whether he did his work well. He knew that Christ's helpers must do their work well. But he knew that it was only to Christ that he was responsible. Therefore, he did not care what others thought. Other ways to translate this include:

it is a minor matter (NET)

it doesn't matter to me (CEV)

it is not important to me

4:3b**if I am judged by you or by any human court.**

- if you or anyone else judges/examines me.
- whether you or any human authority think I have done my work well or not.

if I am judged by you or by any human court: The verb I am judged is in the passive. Paul was suggesting that the Corinthians or other human authorities might examine and criticize the way he was working. There are two ways to translate this clause:

- using a passive verb. For example:

if I am called to account by you or by any human court (REB)

- using an active verb. For example:

if you or any human court judges me

you or any human court should cross-examine me (GW)

judged by you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as judged here refers to examining or investigating someone in a critical way. Some of the Corinthian believers were judging Paul in the sense that they were saying that he was not a good teacher. They were criticizing the way he had been working for the Lord.

by any human court: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as human court is literally "human day." The word "day" refers to a day of judgment. Paul was probably referring not only to official courts of law but to any human evaluation or criticism. Here is another way to translate this:

by any human judgment (GNT)

General Comment on 4:3a-b

In some languages it may be natural to translate 4:3a-b as two separate sentences, repeating the information from 4:3a in both sentences. For example:

But it is not important to me whether you think I have done my work well or not. It is not important to me what any human being thinks of my work.

How you judge me is of little significance to me. How any human beings judge me is of little significance to me.

4:3c**In fact, I do not even judge myself.**

- Even I do not judge myself.
- In fact, I do not even evaluate how well I done my own work.
- Actually I do not even try to assess/examine my own work.

In fact: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as In fact here emphasizes what Paul is about to say. The NIV translates it as "indeed."

I do not even judge myself: This verse part indicates that Paul himself did not try to evaluate whether he

had worked well or not. He knew that what he thought was not important.

1 Corinthians 4:4

Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul's teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect him and Apollos

Paul and Apollos deserved respect as Christ's servants

Paragraph 4:1–5

Paul explained that he was a worker whom Christ had sent to teach and work for him. Christ alone was the one to decide whether or not Paul had done his work well.

4:4a

My conscience is clear,

- Actually, I do not know of anything I have done wrong,
- It is true, I am not aware of any time I did not do my best,
- I think I have done my work well.

My conscience is clear: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as My conscience is clear is more literally "I am aware of nothing against myself." Paul was saying that as far as he knew he had been a faithful steward. He was not aware of having failed his master. Other ways to translate this include:

my conscience does not reproach me (NJB)

I have nothing on my conscience (REB)

I know of no wrong I have done (NCV)

4:4b

but that does not vindicate me.

- but that does not mean that I am innocent before the Lord.
- but that is not what puts me in the right before the Lord.
- However, that in itself does not vindicate/justify me.

but that does not vindicate me: The Greek word that the BSB translates as vindicate in this context means to show or prove that someone has acted well. In this context, Paul thought that he had been a faithful steward, but that did not mean that he actually had been faithful. His clear conscience was not enough to prove that he had acted in a way that pleased the Lord. Other ways to translate this include:

I am not acquitted because of this (NET)

that is not enough to justify me (NJB)

4:4c

It is the Lord who judges me.

- It is the Lord who judges/evaluates me.
- No, the Lord is the one who examines/assesses my work.
- Rather, the Lord Jesus himself determines if the work I have done for him is good or not.

It is the Lord who judges me: The Greek word that the BSB translates as judges is from the same verb as that in 4:3b meaning "examine, investigate." Here it is in the present tense, indicating in a general way that the Lord is always the rightful judge.

1 Corinthians 4:5

Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul's teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

Other possible section headings include:

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Paragraph 4:1–5

Paul explained that he was a worker whom Christ had sent to teach and work for him. Christ alone was the one to decide whether or not Paul had done his work well.

4:5a**Therefore judge nothing**

- So then, you should not pass/render any such judgment
- So you should not decide, “This worker works well, and that worker does not,”
- Therefore I command/urge you not to judge/declare whether or not someone has been faithful to the Lord.

Therefore: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Therefore here introduces a command that states what Paul wants the Corinthians to stop doing as a result of what he has just told them. Here is another way to translate this:

So (GNT)

judge nothing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as judge here refers to declaring a verdict at the end of a trial. It is a slightly different word from that used in 4:4c. Other ways to translate it include:

pass judgment (GNT)

pronounce judgment (RSV)

4:5b**before the appointed time;**

- until the appropriate time.
- because this/now is not the right time.
- It is not yet the proper time to judge/decide such things.

before the appointed time: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as before the appointed time refers to the right or opportune/appropriate time for something. This time is the Lord’s judging day when he returns to earth. See the note on 3:13b. Here is another way to translate this:

before the right time (GNT)

4:5c**wait until the Lord comes.**

- That time will be/come when the Lord comes/returns.

- When the Lord Jesus comes back, he will judge.

wait until the Lord comes: The BSB has supplied the word wait. Paul was not implying that people should pass judgment on others at the time when the Lord comes.

In your translation, make sure that it is clear that until the Lord comes is explaining the meaning of the phrase “the appointed time” in the previous verse part.

4:5d**He will bring to light what is hidden in darkness**

- He will shine light on the things that are hidden/concealed in/by darkness
- He will reveal whatever is now in the dark.

He will bring to light what is hidden in darkness:

The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as what is hidden in darkness is literally “the hidden things of darkness.” This is a metaphor. It refers to things that a person has thought or done secretly, things that other people do not know about. Other ways to translate this part of the verse include:

He will bring our deepest secrets to light (NLT)

he will bring into the light of day all that at present is hidden in darkness (JBP)

He will show what is hidden in the dark (CEV)

what is hidden in darkness: This is a passive phrase. It literally refers to things that cannot be seen because of darkness and figuratively refers to what is not known by other people. There are several ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

what is concealed by/in the dark

- using an active verb. For example:

what darkness hides (REB)

- remove the metaphor of darkness. For example:

secrets/mysteries of men

all the things people have done that other people do not know about

Translate this in the way that is most natural in your language in this context.

4:5e

and will expose the motives of men's hearts.

- and reveal the thoughts/purposes in people's hearts/minds.
- He will make clear to everyone what everyone thinks/plans.

will expose the motives of men's hearts: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as will expose the motives of men's hearts indicates that God will reveal people's intentions, the reasons why they do things. He will make plain everyone's inward thoughts and purposes. In your translation, you should refer to the part of the body where people think and plan (for example, the mind). Other ways to translate this include:

He will show...what is in everyone's hearts. (CEV)

reveal people's motives (GW)

Paul did not say to whom the Lord would expose or reveal these things, whether to the people themselves or to others. He was probably thinking of people in general, rather than just the people themselves. So if you must make this explicit, you may be able to say:

will make clear to all people what is in everyone's heart

General Comment on 4:5d-e

Paul said that the Lord will do two things that are closely related (he will "bring to light what is hidden in darkness" and he will "expose the motives of each man's heart.") The action in the first clause is described in a figurative and general way. The clause refers to exposing anything that is now hidden. The second clause is more specific. The Lord will expose people's motives. There are several possible ways of translating these verse parts:

- use a conjunction that is broad or general in meaning, like the English "and." For example:

He will bring to light things that are now hidden in darkness, and will make known the secret purposes of people's hearts. (NCV)

- start a new sentence, leaving the relationship between the two sentences implied. For example:

He will bring to light what is hidden in darkness.
He will reveal the motives of each one's heart.

- indicate that the two clauses are closely related by using only one main (independent) verb. For example:

He will bring to light what is hidden in darkness, disclosing everyone's internal/inward motives.

He will show what is hidden in the darkness and what is in everyone's heart. (CEV)

4:5f

At that time each will receive his praise from God.

- And at that time God himself will praise each person as he deserves.
- Then God will tell each person how well they have done the work that he gave them to do.

At that time each will receive his praise from God:

This verse part emphasizes that it is God who will praise his workers at the proper time. The proper time is when the Lord comes. Other ways to translate this include:

then will be the time for each to receive commendation from God (REB)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this verse part with God as the subject:

At that time God will praise each one.

1 Corinthians 4:6

Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul's teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect him and Apollos

Paul and Apollos deserved respect as Christ's servants

Paragraph 4:6-13

In this paragraph Paul rebuked the Corinthians for talking proudly about their abilities. Since all their abilities came from God, they had no reason to talk proudly about them. Paul talked about Apollos and himself to contrast the suffering that true workers of Christ were enduring with the proud, boastful attitudes of the Corinthians.

4:6a

Brothers, I have applied these things to myself and Apollos for your benefit,

- ¶ I My brothers and sisters, I have been talking/writing about Apollos and myself in order to help you understand these things.
- ¶ I My Christian friends, I have used Apollos and myself as illustrations in order to teach you something.
- ¶ Well now, my friends, I have illustrated these things for you by referring to Apollos and myself.

In Greek this verse part connects to the previous verse part with a conjunction that is often translated as "but." Here this word introduces a new idea. Many English versions, including the RSV and GNT, do not translate this conjunction explicitly. Some English versions translate the Greek word as "now" (see the NIV) or "and" (see the KJV). Introduce this new idea in a way that is natural in your language.

Brothers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Brothers refers to the Corinthian believers in general.

I have applied these things to myself and Apollos:

By these things, Paul was probably talking about what he had said in chapter 3. He had used himself and Apollos as examples or illustrations of what he had been saying about Christian workers. He had mentioned himself and Apollos in 3:4-5 and had talked about himself and Apollos in his metaphors about planting (3:6-9b) and building (3:9c-15). For example:

I have used Apollos and myself to illustrate what I've been saying (NLT)

for your benefit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as for your benefit is literally "for you." Here it means "for your good" or "to help you understand." Paul used himself and Apollos as examples or illustrations to help the Corinthians understand what he was saying. In some languages it may be natural to translate this phrase at the beginning of the sentence, as the GNT has done:

For your sake, my friends, I have applied all this to Apollos and me.... (GNT)

4:6b

so that you may learn from us

- Through us^(dual/excl) I want you to understand this saying/principle/maxim:
- I want you to think about us so that you will understand these words:
- I am using the two of us^(excl) as examples so that you will learn what this means:

4:6b-c

so that you may learn from us not to go beyond what is written:

The Greek of 4:6b-c is literally "so that from us you may learn the not beyond what is written." Ancient Greek writing did not use quotation marks to indicate quoted material. So it is not always clear what words are quotations. Because of that, there are two ways to understand these verse parts:

1. 4:6c is a quotation. For example:

^{4b}so that you may learn what the saying means,
^{4c}"Observe the proper rules." (GNT) (NIV, GNT, NJB, CEV, NET, NCV, NRSV, REB)

1. Paul was himself encouraging the Corinthians to obey what was written. For example, the GW has translated this as:

^{4b}You should learn from us ^{4c}not to go beyond what is written in Scripture. (GW) (BSB, RSV, GW, NASB, ESV, KJV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation has strong support from English versions and commentaries. Other ways to translate it are:

so that through us you may learn "not to go beyond what is written" (NET)

so that you can learn how the saying "Nothing beyond what is written" is true of us (NJB)

to teach you what this means: "Follow what is written."

4:6c

not to go beyond what is written.

- You should not do or say anything beyond what someone wrote in God's Book.
- "Go by the book."
- "Follow/Obey the teachings exactly as they are written in the Scriptures."

not to go beyond what is written: The Greek words that the BSB translates as not to go beyond what is written are literally "not beyond what is written." If you choose to treat this as a quoted saying, then it may be natural to translate it as a command. This command may be positive or negative:

Follow only what is written in the Scriptures (NCV)

You should not say or do anything other than what is written in the Scriptures

In some languages there may be a saying or idiom that is appropriate in this context. For example:

Follow the rules. (CEV)

Go by the book!

Stick/Keep to the written word!

not to go beyond: This is a metaphor. Not obeying rules is like stepping over a boundary line. It is like going outside the place where one is supposed to be. Consider if there is a metaphor or idiom to express this in your language. Other ways to translate it in English include:

do not do anything apart from....

do only....

keep within....

follow....

what is written: Paul was probably referring to the instructions or commands that are written in the OT Scriptures. He meant that the written word should be followed and that it has authority. You may be able to suggest this authority in your language. One way to do this in English is to say:

what stands written

In your translation you may also need to add the implied information that the writing is about judging people. For example:

what the book says about judging others.

4:6d

Then you will not take pride in one man over another.

- I have done this so that you will not be proud, saying that the teacher you follow is better than another teacher.
- My desire is that you will learn not to take sides and boast about one teacher/leader and criticize other teachers/leaders.
- For I do not want you to proudly think/say that the teacher/leader you follow is better than another teacher/leader.

Then: There are several ways to understand the function of the Greek word that the BSB translates as Then:

1. It introduces a purpose. For example:

so that none of you will be puffed up in favor of one against the other (NET) (NASB, RSV, REB, CEV, NET, ESV)

1. It introduces a result. For example:

Then you won't arrogantly place one of us in opposition to the other. (GW) (BSB, NIV, NCV, GW, NLT)

1. It introduces an explanation of the meaning of the saying. For example, the NJB translates 4:6b-d as:

so that you can learn how the saying "nothing beyond what is written" is true of us: no individual among you must become filled with his own importance... (NJB) (KJV, GNT, NJB)

In this context, interpretations (1) and (2) are not very different from one another. Paul's purpose in teaching was that the Corinthians would learn the meaning of the saying, and he expected the result of this would be that they would not take pride in their teachers. It is recommended that you translate in such a way that the conjunction introduces either purpose or expected result. If you must choose between the two interpretations, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), which is the normal meaning of the conjunction.

take pride in one man over another: The Greek word for take pride in literally means “to be puffed up, to be full of hot air.” In this context it is a metaphor. Paul was referring to people who were proud because of the teacher they followed. In some languages there is an idiom that describes a person who is “puffed up.” Other ways to translate it in English include:

be more proud of one person than another (NCV)

inflated with pride as you take sides in support of one against another (REB)

one man over another: Paul was referring to the way the Corinthians were taking sides and arguing over what teacher or leader was the best. See 1:12b, 1:12c, 1:12d, and 3:4a-b. It may be necessary to make this clear by translating man as “teacher” or “leaders”:

one of your teachers more than another

one of your leaders at the expense of another (NLT)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this verse part with a direct quote. For example:

My purpose is that none of you will speak boastfully in this way: “I follow so-and-so, but you only follow so-and-so.”

I do not want you to be proud and say, “I am following the best teacher. That teacher of yours is not as good.”

1 Corinthians 4:7

Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul’s teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect him and Apollos

Paul and Apollos deserved respect as Christ’s servants

Paragraph 4:6–13

In this paragraph Paul rebuked the Corinthians for talking proudly about their abilities. Since all their abilities came from God, they had no reason to talk proudly about them. Paul talked about Apollos and himself to contrast the suffering that true workers of Christ were enduring with the proud, boastful attitudes of the Corinthians.

4:7

In this verse Paul used three rhetorical questions to rebuke the Corinthians for the way they argued over teachers and talked proudly about themselves. He wanted them to feel ashamed of themselves for talking proudly about one teacher and showing dishonor toward another. So there are two ways to translate these questions:

- As rhetorical questions. In some languages it is common to use questions like this to criticize or show anger. But make sure that people who read your translation understand these questions as rebukes, not as real questions. For example:

My friend, who makes you so important? What do you possess that was not given you? And if you received it as a gift, why take the credit to yourself? (REB)

Who says you are better than others? What do you have that was not given to you? And if it was given to you, why do you brag as if you did not receive it as a gift? (NCV)

- As emphatic statements that by implication rebuke or criticize the Corinthians. For example:

You should not think that you are superior to others. All that you have was given to you. So there is no need to brag about it.

In all three of these questions, Paul used the singular pronoun for “you.” It is as though he were talking to only one person. But he was actually addressing anyone in the group who thought that he or she had the right to look at the work of the teachers and judge them (4:3). In many languages it may therefore be best to translate this verse using the plural “you.”

4:7a

For who makes you so superior?

- For has anyone made you better than anyone else?
- None of you should say that, since no one made you more important than any other believer.
- None of you should judge/criticize your teachers/leaders, for no one has given you a higher status than other believers.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* introduces a rhetorical question that indicates the basis for Paul's statement; that is, the reason why the Corinthians should not be proud or puffed up. Some English versions, such as the GNT, do not explicitly translate this conjunction. You should introduce the following question in a way that is natural in your language.

who makes you so superior?: This is a rhetorical question. In Greek it is literally, "who judges you^(sing) to be superior?" The implied answer is "no one." Paul was saying that anyone who was claiming to be superior and to have the right to judge Paul or another worker was wrong. No one had given him that right.

Paul used this rhetorical question to make an emphatic negative statement: no one had made the Corinthians superior to other believers. This statement implied a rebuke: the Corinthians should stop thinking and acting as though they were superior. There are therefore several ways to translate this verse part:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Who made you superior to others? (GNT)

Who says you are better than others? (NCV)

Who made you so important? (NJB)

- as a question with the answer supplied. For example:

Did someone/God declare you to be above everyone else? No!

- as an emphatic statement or exclamation. For example:

No one has made you superior to others!

You are wrong to think you are better than others.

Consider what is the most natural way to translate this as a rebuke in your language.

4:7b

What do you have that you did not receive?

- Do you have anything that you did not receive as a gift from God? Nothing.
- You do not have anything except what God has given you.
- Everything you have is a gift from God.

What do you have that you did not receive?: This verse part has some implied information. The Corinthians had received everything from God. God gave the Corinthians their salvation, all their material possessions, and all the abilities they had. So it is also possible to translate this as:

What do you have that God hasn't given you? (NLT)

Didn't God give you everything you have? (GNT)

This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this question to make a strong negative statement. He meant "You have nothing that you did not receive." In other words, "everything you have comes from God." This implied a rebuke: the Corinthians should not act and speak proudly, because they were totally dependent on God. So there are several ways to translate this question:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

What do you have that was not given to you? (NCV)

- as a question with the answer supplied. For example:

Do you have anything that was not given by God? No!

- as a strong statement. For example:

Everything you have, you have received from God.

- as a rebuke. For example:

You should remember that God gave you every good thing you have.

Translate this question in whichever way is natural in your language.

4:7c**And if you did receive it,**

- Thus, since God gave you everything you have,
- So then, if you agree with me that God gave you everything you have,

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *And* here introduces a third rhetorical question that functions as a concluding rebuke.

if you did receive it: Paul was implying that this condition was true. The Corinthians had received everything from God. This verse part gives the basis for the verse part that follows. So in this context the word *if* can be translated as “since”:

since you did receive it

General Comment on 4:7b-c

If you translate 4:7b as a strong statement, it may be unnatural to repeat the same information in 4:7c. Instead you may need to abbreviate this verse part. For example:

^{7b}Everything you have was given to you. ^{7c}And so...

4:7d**why do you boast as though you did not?**

- then it is not proper/right for you to talk proudly about yourself, as though you did not receive everything as a gift.
- you should not talk proudly/boastfully as if you had earned/obtained everything yourselves.

why do you boast as though you did not?: This is a third rhetorical question. It functions as a rebuke. Paul was telling the believers in Corinth that they should not be boasting in the way they were. It was foolish and wrong to boast about things they had been given. So there are at least two ways to translate this question:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

why do you brag as if you did not receive it as a gift? (NCV)

- as a rebuke. For example:

You should not boast as though you had not received it.

Translate this question in the way that is natural in your language for rebuking someone.

boast: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *boast* means to brag or talk arrogantly. The Corinthians had been thinking and talking as if the things God had given to them made them more important than other people.

as though you did not: The phrase *as though you did not* here means “as though you did not receive everything good you possess as a gift from God.” In some languages it may be more natural to leave this phrase implicit. For example, the CEV translates 4:7c-d as:

And if it was given to you, how can you brag? (CEV)

General Comment on 4:7b-d

If you translate 4:7b as a strong statement, it may be unnatural to repeat the same information in 4:7c. Therefore you may not need to include all of 4:7c. For example:

^{7b}Everything you have was given you. ^{7c}And so ^{7d}do not boast as if you had not received it from God.

1 Corinthians 4:8**Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ**

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul’s teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

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4:8a-c

Paul continued to rebuke the Corinthians because they felt satisfied, rich, and powerful. They thought of themselves as spiritually successful. In this verse Paul rebuked them in three short sentences. There are two ways to interpret the form of the Greek sentences:

1. They are ironic statements. Irony is a figure of speech that involves saying the opposite of what one means in order to criticize or rebuke others. For example:

Already you are satisfied! Already you are rich! You have become kings without us! (NET) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NJB, NCV, KJV, NASB, REB, GW, NET, NLT, ESV)

1. They are rhetorical questions. For example:

Are you already satisfied? Are you now rich? Have you become kings while we are still nobodies? (CEV) (GNT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This has the strongest support among the English versions. Paul was using irony to rebuke the Corinthians. He wanted them to change their proud thoughts about themselves. They thought of themselves as successful, as wise and rich and powerful in spiritual things. But actually, in the way God looked at things, their pride and lack of maturity were causing them to be foolish, poor, and weak.

In your translation, you will want to be sure that your readers do not understand these statements literally. There are several ways to translate them:

- using irony or sarcasm. Consider how it might be natural to show this. One way in English is by the use of exaggerated or emphatic language and an exclamation point. For example:

You are already full to the brim! Already multi-millionaires! Already reigning without us!

How comfortable you are! How wealthy! How royal! You are not like us!

- as statements implying rebuke. For example:

You think you already have everything you need. You think you are rich. You think you have become kings without us. (NCV)

- as direct rebukes. For example:

You are wrong to act/think as though you already have all you need. You are not rich yet! You are (unlike us) already kings!

4:8a**Already you have all you want.**

- You are already so satisfied!
- You seem to have everything you could desire.
- You act as though you had everything you needed.

Already you have all you want: The Greek words that the BSB translates as you have all you want are more literally “you are filled,” as in the RSV. This refers to eating and drinking so much that a person does not want anything more to eat or drink. This is a figure of speech. Paul meant that the Corinthian believers thought that they were not lacking anything spiritually. They did not think that they needed any help or instruction from him. So there are several ways of translating this verse part:

- with a metaphor. For example:

You have had enough to eat.

- with a simile that is explained:

Just like people who have eaten so much that they feel satisfied, you act as if you know all you need to know.

- without a figure of speech. For example:

You act as if you already have all you need spiritually.

You apparently think you have already learned all you need to know about God’s ways.

Translate this figure of speech in a way that is natural in your language. If possible, use language that can refer both to feeling content after having had enough to eat and to feeling content after having enough of something else. For example:

You are already satisfied/content.

4:8b**Already you have become rich.**

- You are already so wealthy/well-off!

- You seem to have all the blessings there are!
- You act as though you had every spiritual blessings.

Already you have become rich: Here Paul used a second figure of speech. It means almost the same as that in 4:8a. Paul was using the word rich as a metaphor for having many spiritual blessings, gifts, and abilities from the Holy Spirit. The Corinthians seemed to think that they had received all the spiritual blessings possible. So there are several ways to translate this figure of speech:

- using a metaphor. For example:

you have come into your fortune already! (REB)

- using and explaining a metaphor or simile. For example:

You are like rich men—you don't need anything from anyone!

- with no figure of speech. For example:

You already have all the spiritual blessings there are to have!

As in the previous verse part, it may be possible to use language that has both a figurative and a non-figurative meaning. For example:

You are indeed very successful/well-off!

You already have all there is to have!

4:8c

Without us, you have become kings.

- You are reigning already! But you are reigning without us.
- We^(excl) are not yet kings, but you act as if you were kings already!
- Apparently you think that you are already as strong/prosperous/powerful as kings. But we^(excl) evangelists/apostles are not yet in that position.

Without us: There are two ways to interpret the phrase Without us:

1. It means “and we are not kings like you.” For example:

even though we are not (GNT) (GNT, CEV)

1. It means “apart from our help.” For example:

without any help from us (NJB) (NJB, probably the NRSV)

Many English versions are ambiguous (BSB, NIV, RSV, NET, REB, NLT, NCV, GW, NASB, KJV, ESV). It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This fits better with the context of 4:8e.

you have become kings: This is another figure of speech. The Corinthians felt themselves to be as prosperous, strong, and powerful as kings. There are two ways to translate this metaphor:

- using a metaphor. For example:

you have come into your kingdom (REB)

you are already reigning!

- explaining the metaphor. For example:

you are as prosperous/powerful as kings!

In this verse part, it is not recommended that you remove the metaphor altogether. The New Testament frequently uses this metaphor to speak of the spiritual blessings Christians will enjoy after Christ returns. See, for example, 2 Timothy 2:12.

kings: A king is a legal, hereditary ruler. If kings are not common in your area, it may be natural to use a more general word for leaders, such as “rulers.”

General Comment on 4:8c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of these phrases. For example:

You have become kings—and that without us! (NIV)

4:8d

How I wish you really were kings,

- I wish that you really had begun to reign
- I would be happy if you really were as strong/prosperous/powerful as kings.

How I wish you really were kings: This is a wish for something to be true that was not true. Paul wished the time for the Corinthians to reign as kings were already here. But the Corinthians were not already kings. They were not as prosperous and powerful as they supposed they were.

Other ways to translate this include:

How I wish you had indeed come into your kingdom. (REB)

Well, I wish you were kings. (NJB)

I wish you really were on your thrones already. (NLT)

4:8e

so that we might be kings with you!

- so that we^(excl) also could be ruling/reigning with you.
- That way we^(excl) could be spiritually powerful/prosperous along with you.

so that we might be kings with you: This verse part indicates Paul's purpose for wishing that the Corinthians were already kings. If the Corinthians were already enjoying the spiritual blessing of reigning with Christ, then so would he and the other apostles.

Other ways to translate this:

so that we could reign with you (NET)

so we^(excl) could be on our thrones as well

1 Corinthians 4:9

Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ

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abilities came from God, they had no reason to talk proudly about them. Paul talked about Apollos and himself to contrast the suffering that true workers of Christ were enduring with the proud, boastful attitudes of the Corinthians.

4:9

In this verse Paul compared himself and the other apostles to prisoners about to die in an arena. These prisoners entered the arena last, behind the more important people. They were forced to fight until they died. Other people watched this for amusement. The apostles were like these prisoners in two ways: first, they were in the worst possible place, and second, everyone could watch their suffering. Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

For it seems to me that God has given the very last place to us apostles, like people condemned to die in public as a spectacle for the whole world of angels and of human beings. (GNT)

But it seems to me that God has put us apostles in last place, like those sentenced to die. We are like a show for the whole world to see—angels and people. (NCV)

It seems to me that God has put us apostles in the worst possible place. We are like prisoners on their way to death. Angels and the people of this world just laugh at us. (CEV)

4:9a

For it seems to me that

- For I think it is like this:
- For this is what I think.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For here introduces Paul's basis for saying that he wished he and the other apostles were reigning like kings.

it seems to me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as it seems to me here introduces how Paul perceived things. Paul began to tell his emotional reaction to how the Corinthians were acting. It may be natural to translate this as:

It feels as though

I think that (RSV)

4:9b**God has displayed us apostles at the end of the procession,**

- God has put us^(excl), Christ's apostles, in the last place of all.
- It is as if God has caused us^(excl) apostles to appear as the most despised/insignificant of all people.
- God has caused us^(excl), Christ's representatives/messengers, to be viewed with no honor/respect.

God has displayed us apostles: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as displayed means to show or cause others to see something. Here is another way to translate this:

exhibited (RSV)

at the end of the procession: The Greek word that the BSB translates as at the end of the procession is literally "last." This can refer to being last in line or last in place. In either case, it figuratively refers to being last in importance, lowest in rank. Paul was saying that the apostles were in the worst possible place. They were certainly not kings. Try to translate this with an expression that implies being both last in place or time and last in importance. For example:

last of all (RSV)

4:9c**like prisoners appointed for death.**

- It is as if we have been sentenced to a public death.
- We are like criminals/prisoners about to be killed in front of everyone.
- People make fun of us^(excl) and treat us badly, just as if we^(excl) were people who are going to be killed in the arena,

like prisoners appointed for death: The Greek word that the BSB translates as prisoners appointed for death is an adjective indicating that these people were about to die. In this context, it describes criminals or prisoners of war who were going to be put to death. The phrase like prisoners appointed for death is a simile comparing the apostles to these condemned prisoners. Other ways to translate this verse part include:

as though sentenced to death (NRSV)

We are like prisoners on their way to death. (CEV)

We^(excl) are like the people who will be killed.

4:9d**We have become a spectacle to the whole world, to angels as well as to men.**

- Many people are watching us^(excl), both people on earth and angels in heaven, to see what is going to happen to us.
- I say this because everyone is watching us^(excl) to see what will happen to us. Not only people but also angels are watching us.
- as if we^(excl) were a public show for the entire angelic and human cosmos/creation.

In the Greek this verse part connects to the previous verse part with a conjunction that the RSV translates as "because." In this context it introduces the basis for what Paul had just said. The apostles were like men condemned to die in the arena because, or in the sense that, the whole world watched them as they suffered.

We have become a spectacle: The Greek word that the BSB translates as spectacle refers to a display or theatrical show. The NCV translates this as a simile:

We are like a show (NCV)

We have become: The context of 4:9b makes it clear that God was the one who caused the apostles to be a spectacle or show. So it is also possible to translate this as:

God made us

to the whole world, to angels as well as to men:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as world refers here to the whole created order, including both the realm of angels and the realm of humans. The KJV translates this phrase as though there were three separate entities: "unto the world, and to angels, and to men." This is not followed by most other English versions. The BSB, NIV, NJB, GNT, and RSV/NRSV all understand the world/universe to consist of two groups: angels and men. At first reading the RSV and NRSV appear ambiguous ("to the world, to angels and to men/mortals"), but the absence of a comma after the word angels shows that angels and men together form the world. Had the RSV and NRSV intended to refer to three separate entities, they would have said "to the world, to angels, and to men." Elsewhere they consistently use a serial comma for such phrases: see 5:11, 14:26, and 2 Cor 6:6-7.

General Comment on 4:9a-d

The GNT translates 4:9a-d as one sentence in order to make it clear that the “spectacle” consisted of a public death:

For it seems to me that God has given the very last place to us apostles, like people condemned to die in public as a spectacle for the whole world of angels and of human beings. (GNT)

Consider how to best make it clear that the “spectacle” consisted of people being publicly put to death.

1 Corinthians 4:10

Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul’s teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect him and Apollos

Paul and Apollos deserved respect as Christ’s servants

Paragraph 4:6–13

In this paragraph Paul rebuked the Corinthians for talking proudly about their abilities. Since all their abilities came from God, they had no reason to talk proudly about them. Paul talked about Apollos and himself to contrast the suffering that true workers of Christ were enduring with the proud, boastful attitudes of the Corinthians.

4:10

In this verse Paul used three statements that each showed contrast between the pride of some of the Corinthians and the humility of the apostles. In each of these statements Paul used a type of expression called irony. This is a kind of statement that states the opposite of what it really means. It is often used to rebuke people. Some translations indicate that the statements are a form of irony by putting exclamation marks (!) at the end of each sentence. In your translation,

make sure that it is clear that Paul was rebuking the Corinthians. He was not praising them.

4:10a

We are fools for Christ,

- We^(excl) are/appear foolish because we work for Christ!
- You think we^(excl) are acting foolishly for the sake of Christ!
- You seem to think that we^(excl) are fools as we^(excl) live for Christ,

We are fools for Christ: Paul continued to use irony. He did not mean that he and the other apostles were really fools. Rather, some of the Corinthians thought that they were fools because of the way they followed Christ and lived as Christians. There are two ways this could be translated:

- use irony as Paul did. For example:

How foolish we^(excl) are for Christ!

- use a literal statement. For example:

Many of you people say/think we^(excl) are being foolish. We are this way because of Christ!

Because of Christ we are thought of as fools. (CEV)

Because of the way we live as followers of Christ, we are thought of as fools.

Translate this in your language in a way that makes it clear that Paul was rebuking the Corinthians.

for Christ: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as for Christ means “for the sake of Christ.” It can also be translated as:

because we follow Christ

because we are devoted/dedicated to Christ

because we believe in Christ

4:10b

but you are wise in Christ.

- But as for you, you think that you are very wise because you belong to Christ.
- How wise you think yourselves now that you have become one/united with Christ!

- but that you are such very wise Christians!

you are wise in Christ: This is also sarcasm. Paul did not mean that the Corinthians were really wise. He meant that some of them thought they are wise. So there are two ways to translate this:

- using an ironic statement. For example:

How wise you are in Christ!

- using a literal statement. For example:

You think that you are wise/clever Christians, but you are not.

wise in Christ: The phrase wise in Christ means “wise as Christians.” You may be able to translate this as:

wise Christians

wise believers in Christ

wise because you follow Christ

4:10c

We are weak,

- We^(excl) are/appear powerless,
- You consider us^(excl) to have no authority/power.

We are weak: The word weak here does not mean physically weak. It means to have no authority to be God’s representative and no power to influence people. This is still irony. Paul did not mean that he and the other apostles really had no power. Rather, the world’s people mistakenly thought that he was weak. So there are two ways to translate this:

- as an ironic statement. For example:

We are so weak/powerless!

- as a literal statement. For example:

Many people, including some of you, consider us^(excl) to have no power.

4:10d

but you are strong.

- while you are spiritually strong/influential!
- But as for you, you think that you have much spiritual authority/power.

you are strong: The word strong here does not mean physically strong, but spiritually strong. Paul was continuing to speak ironically. He meant “You think you are so strong spiritually!” It is likely that some of the Corinthians were talking proudly about their spiritual abilities. See the notes on 1:5. Paul wanted them to know that God did not like their proud talk. So there are two ways to translate this:

- as an ironic statement. For example:

How strong you are!

- as a literal statement. For example:

You talk proudly that you have God’s power to do many things.

4:10e

You are honored,

- People honor/praise you,
- You receive honor/deference/respect
- You think it right for others to respect you

4:10f

but we are dishonored.

- but they humiliate/despise us^(excl).
- but not us!^(excl)
- while they treat us^(excl) with scorn.

4:10e-f

You are honored, but we are dishonored: 4:10e-f is another example of irony. Because some of the Corinthians thought like this world’s people do about cleverness, they were happy to have people praise them. They also joined with this world’s people in criticizing Paul and perhaps other apostles also.

There are two ways to translate these verse parts:

- as an ironic statement. For example:

How others honor you! How they scorn us!

You are honored; we are in disgrace! (REB)

- as a literal statement. For example:

You receive honor, but we are shamed. (NCV)

You think that it is good when people praise you, but you think it is all right when people think of us^(excl) as unimportant.

1 Corinthians 4:11

Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul's teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect him and Apollos

Paul and Apollos deserved respect as Christ's servants

Paragraph 4:6–13

In this paragraph Paul rebuked the Corinthians for talking proudly about their abilities. Since all their abilities came from God, they had no reason to talk proudly about them. Paul talked about Apollos and himself to contrast the suffering that true workers of Christ were enduring with the proud, boastful attitudes of the Corinthians.

4:11

In this verse Paul stopped using irony and began to use plain talk. He said that the apostles were suffering many bad things.

All the things Paul says in 4:11–12a are connected with the Greek word for “and.” Here is a literal translation:

Until this present hour we both hunger and thirst and we lack clothes and we are beaten and we are homeless and we labor working with our hands.

Most English versions do not translate every occurrence of the word “and” because that would not be natural in English. For example:

To the present hour we are hungry and thirsty, poorly clothed, brutally treated, and without a roof over our heads. (NET)

You should translate this list of things in a way that is natural in your language.

4:11a

To this very hour we are hungry and thirsty,

- Right up to the present time we^(excl) often do not have enough to eat and drink
- Even up to now, we^(excl) often lack food and water.

To this very hour we are hungry and thirsty: This means that in the past Paul and the other apostles often did not have enough to eat or drink, and that this was still true even when he wrote this letter. Another way to translate this is:

Even to this very hour we do not have enough to eat or drink (NCV)

To this very hour: This phrase refers to the time when Paul was writing. In many languages it is not natural to translate this using the word hour, but to use a more general time word, for example:

Even now

Up to this present time

To this moment (GW)

4:11b

we are poorly clothed,

- and are poorly clothed.
- Our^(excl) clothes are very worn/poor.

we are poorly clothed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as we are poorly clothed indicates that the apostles had poor and insufficient clothes. Here are some other ways to translate this:

we are...poorly dressed (GW)

we are in rags (NIV)

4:11c

we are brutally treated,

- And/Also people often hit/beat us^(excl).
- People treat us^(excl) badly/roughly.

we are brutally treated: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as brutally treated is a general one meaning “badly treated.” In this context it refers to being struck or beaten. Other ways to translate it include:

we are mistreated (CEV)

4:11d

we are homeless.

- We^(excl) have no home of our own.
- We^(excl) do not have our own home.

we are homeless: The Greek word that the BSB translates as homeless can be literally translated as “unsettled.” It describes people who travel around and have no permanent home. English versions translate it in various ways. You may be able to follow one of these models:

we...don't have a place to live (CEV)

we have no homes of our own (NLT)

we wander from place to place (GNT)

without a roof over our heads (NET)

Paul and the other apostles traveled from one city to another city, preaching the gospel and teaching the believers. They did not have a house of their own to sleep/stay in. They usually stayed in the homes of other people. Find a natural way to say this in your language.

1 Corinthians 4:12

Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul's teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect him and Apollos

Paul and Apollos deserved respect as Christ's servants

Paragraph 4:6–13

In this paragraph Paul rebuked the Corinthians for talking proudly about their abilities. Since all their abilities came from God, they had no reason to talk proudly about them. Paul talked about Apollos and himself to contrast the suffering that true workers

of Christ were enduring with the proud, boastful attitudes of the Corinthians.

4:12a

We work hard with our own hands.

- And/Also we^(excl) have to work very hard with our own hands to earn money.
- We^(excl) work hard to earn a living.

We work hard with our own hands: This verse part indicates that that Paul and his coworkers had to do hard physical labor. They did not depend on the work of others as kings do. Another way to translate this is:

We do hard manual labor.

4:12b

When we are vilified, we bless;

- When people say bad things to us^(excl) we bless them.
- If people wish bad to happen to us^(excl) we wish good to happen to them.
- We ask God to help/bless those who insult us^(excl).

When we are vilified, we bless: This verse part indicates that the apostles spoke good things to people who spoke badly to them. Translate using verbs that form a strong contrast. Other ways to translate this in English include:

when we are verbally abused, we respond with a blessing (NET)

we are vilified: The Greek word that the BSB translates as vilified refers to someone being spoken to in an insulting way. The speaker expresses hatred toward someone by insulting him or calling him bad names. The verb we are vilified is in the passive. There are two ways of translating this:

- with a passive verb. For example:

we are verbally abused (NET)

- with an active verb. For example:

people abuse us (NCV)

enemies/unbelievers insult us

Translate in whichever way is most natural in your language in this context.

we bless: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bless refers to a special kind of prayer that God would

do good to someone. In some languages it may be natural to use direct speech here. For example:

we say to them, “May God do good to you.”

4:12c

when we are persecuted, we endure it;

- When people cause us^(excl) to suffer, we do not fight back.
- We^(excl) are patient when people treat us badly.

when we are persecuted, we endure it: This verse part indicates that the apostles were patient rather than violent when others did evil to them.

we are persecuted: This is a passive verb. There are two ways to translate it:

- as a passive verb. For example:

we^(excl) are mistreated

- as an active verb. For example:

When people persecute us (GW)

we endure it: The phrase we endure it means that the apostles were patient while they were suffering persecution. They did not fight back. Here is another way to translate this:

we are patient (CEV)

1 Corinthians 4:13

Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul’s teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

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4:13a

when we are slandered, we answer gently.

- When people say bad things about us^(excl) we say good things about them.
- When people lie about us^(excl) we respond with kind, friendly words.
- We^(excl) speak gently to those who slander us.

we are slandered: The Greek word that the BSB translates as we are slandered is similar in meaning to the word translated as “we are vilified” in 4:12b. Probably the difference is that in 4:12b Paul was referring to people directly insulting the apostles, and here in 4:13a he was referring to people saying bad things about the apostles to others. To “slander” someone is to try to ruin their good name by saying untrue bad things about them.

This is a passive clause. There are two ways to translate it:

- with a passive verb. For example:

we are slandered (NJB)

our reputations are attacked (GW)

- with an active verb. For example:

they slander us (REB)

people slander us^(excl)

they tell evil lies about us (NCV)

we answer gently: The clause we answer gently indicates that the apostles did not speak back in a bad way to those who slandered them. Other ways to translate this include:

we speak nice words about them (NCV)

we remain courteous (GW)

4:13b

Up to this moment we have become the scum of the earth, the refuse of the world.

- Even now people treat us^(excl) as if we^(excl) were rubbish/garbage that they throw away, or like dirt/scum that they scrape off a pot.
- Right up to this day/hour people still do not respect us^(excl). They say we^(excl) are worthless.

Up to this moment: This means the same as “To this very hour” in 4:11a. See the notes there. Paul made it clear that people were still treating Christ’s representatives and workers badly, even at the time he was writing this letter. In the Greek, this phrase comes at the end of the verse. Combined with the similar phrase at the beginning of verse 11, these phrases seem to give the boundaries of Paul’s statements that apply only to the apostles. In verses 8 to 10, Paul compared the Corinthians with the apostles but in verses 11 through 13, he no longer makes comparisons with the Corinthians. Translators should use this structure if it is appropriate for their language.

we have become the scum of the earth, the refuse of the world: Paul used these two figures of speech to describe himself and Christ’s other workers. He compared them to rubbish because people considered them worthless and treated them badly. There are two ways to translate these figures of speech:

- keep the figures of speech. For example:

we are treated like the world’s garbage, like everybody’s trash (NLT)

People treat us like dirt, like the world’s unwanted junk.

- translate the meaning. For example:

People treat us^(excl) apostles as if we^(excl) were of no value.

Your language may have colorful figures of speech that you can use to translate this. Translate this in such a way that it is clear that people scorned and despised the apostles.

the scum of the earth: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scum literally refers to anything people remove when they clean. This would include dirt, trash, rubbish, and whatever people throw away.

the refuse of the world: The Greek word that the BSB translates as refuse means anything people remove

when they scrape or wash things. This would include, for example, what a person removes from a pot by scraping or scouring.

The meanings of the two words “scum” and refuse are close. They both refer to something that people think of as worthless, no longer any good. What Paul meant by these metaphors is that people were treating Christ’s workers very badly. Sometimes they were trying to kill them or drive them away. They treated them as if they were unimportant.

1 Corinthians 4:14

Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul’s teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect him and Apollos

Paul and Apollos deserved respect as Christ’s servants

Paragraph 4:14–21

Paul wanted the Corinthians to change the way they were thinking about him and accept his authority again. So he used another metaphor—that of a father with his children—to help them understand how they should respect and obey him.

4:14a

I am not writing this to shame you,

- ¶ It is not to embarrass you that I have written those words to you.
- ¶ My purpose in writing like this is not to make you feel ashamed.

4:14b

but to warn you

- Rather, I want to teach you something you need to know,
- Instead, I want to correct you
- No, my purpose is to warn you.

4:14a-b**I am not writing this to shame you, but to warn you:**

Here Paul was referring back to the harsh words he used earlier in this chapter, especially in 4:6–13. Paul did not write those words to shame the Corinthians, but to warn them. In some languages it may be natural to use the past tense to refer to what Paul had already written:

I did not write like that in order to shame you but to warn you.

shame: The Greek word that the BSB translates as shame means to humiliate someone in front of others. The CEV translates it as “embarrass.”

warn: The Greek word that the BSB translates as warn here means to correct someone’s their bad behavior. It is the word that describes what a father or mother might do to try to correct a child who is not behaving well.

General Comment on 4:14a-b

In some languages it may be natural to make the positive statement first:

^{14a}I am writing this to warn you, ^{14b}not to put you to shame.

4:14c**as my beloved children.**

- because you are like my children whom I love.
- just as if you were my own dear/beloved children.
- I am warning/disciplining/treating you as if you were my own children whom I love.

1 Corinthians 4:15**Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ**

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul’s teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect him and Apollos

Paul and Apollos deserved respect as Christ’s servants

Paragraph 4:14–21

Paul wanted the Corinthians to change the way they were thinking about him and accept his authority again. So he used another metaphor—that of a father with his children—to help them understand how they should respect and obey him.

4:15a**Even if you have ten thousand guardians in Christ,**

- Even though you^(plur) might have thousands of Christian guardians/supervisors,
- I can warn/discipline you like that, because even if you have had more people than I can count who tried to guide/correct you as you follow Christ,
- Perhaps you have had millions of people to train you in the Christian way.

Even if you have ten thousand guardians in Christ:

This is a figure of speech called a hyperbole. Paul did not mean that the Corinthian believers really did have ten thousand guardians. But however many they had, none of them were like Paul. You can reword this sentence like this:

You may have had many teachers in your Christian life. But even if you had ten thousand teachers...

ten thousand: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as ten thousand was used to indicate a vague but impossibly large number. In translating it, you should try to translate it as a strong statement. There may be a word you use that shows you are exaggerating, such as the English slang “zillion.” In many languages it will probably be more natural to say something like:

a billion/million/trillion

countless/innumerable

too many to count

guardians in Christ: The phrase guardians in Christ indicates that these guardians were people who helped the Corinthians to follow Christ. You may also translate this as:

Christian guardians

leaders who have helped you in the Christian life

guardians: The Greek word that the BSB translates as guardians can also mean “caretaker.” It literally means “one who leads children.” In the Greek culture of Paul’s time, a guardian took care of a boy all the time he was not in school. He trained the boy and watched over him. Other ways to translate this are:

tutors (REB)

guides (RSV)

4:15b

you do not have many fathers;

- not many people are like fathers to you.
- only one person is like your father.
- But I am the only person who is your father in the Christian way.

you do not have many fathers: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as you do not have many fathers means “you have only one father.” This is a metaphor. Paul was talking about himself as the one who had first taught the Corinthians about Christ. If a literal translation would suggest physical, biological fatherhood, it may be necessary to follow the NLT:

you have only one spiritual father (NLT)

4:15c

for in Christ Jesus I became your father through the gospel.

- For I am the one who first proclaimed the good news to you^(plur) and so became your father in the family of Christ Jesus.
- For I am your father. That is, I am the one who led/helped you to believe in Christ Jesus.
- I am like a father to you because I am the one who first brought to you the good news about Christ Jesus.

for in Christ Jesus I became your father through the gospel:

This verse part explains the basis for Paul calling himself their father. He was like a father to the Corinthians because he was the one who first invited them to become a part of God’s family by telling them the gospel, God’s message about Christ. In some languages it may be helpful to make some of this explicit:

For I became your father in Christ Jesus when I preached the good news to you. (NLT)

I say this because you became my children when I told you the good news about Christ Jesus.

1 Corinthians 4:16

Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul’s teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect him and Apollos

Paul and Apollos deserved respect as Christ’s servants

Paragraph 4:14–21

Paul wanted the Corinthians to change the way they were thinking about him and accept his authority again. So he used another metaphor—that of a father with his children—to help them understand how they should respect and obey him.

4:16

Therefore I urge you to imitate me.

- Therefore I plead/ask you to behave and think the way I do.
- So I strongly encourage you to follow my example.

Therefore: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Therefore introduces what Paul commanded the Corinthians to do because he was their spiritual father. It can also be translated as:

So (GW)

then (RSV)

I urge you to imitate me: Paul wanted the Corinthians to act/live as he acted/lived, as a son acts like his father. He wanted them to follow his example. Paul also talked about people following his example in 1 Corinthians 11:1 and 1 Thessalonians 1:6. Other ways to translate this include:

I encourage you...be imitators of me. (NET)

I beg you, please follow my example. (NCV)

I ask you to follow my example and do as I do.
(NLT)

1 Corinthians 4:17

Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul's teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

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Paragraph 4:14–21

Paul wanted the Corinthians to change the way they were thinking about him and accept his authority again. So he used another metaphor—that of a father with his children—to help them understand how they should respect and obey him.

4:17a

That is why I have sent you Timothy,

- That is why I have sent Timothy to visit you.
- That is the reason I have asked/ordered Timothy to go to Corinth.

That is why: The Greek phrase that the BSB has translated as That is why is literally "For this." In this case, the pronoun That refers to what immediately precedes it. It refers to the clause "I urge you to imitate me." Because Paul wanted the Corinthians to imitate him, he sent Timothy to them.

I have sent you Timothy: Paul wanted Timothy to visit the Corinthians. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as:

I have asked/ordered Timothy to go/come to you.

I have told Timothy to visit you.

I have sent: In the Greek this verb is in the past tense: "I sent." There are two ways to understand this:

1. Paul meant that he had already sent Timothy. When Paul wrote this letter, Timothy had already left Ephesus (where Paul was) and was on his way to Corinth. See Acts 19:22. For example:

I have sent you Timothy (NJB) (BSB, CEV, KJV, RSV, NASB, REB, GW, NJB, NET)

1. Paul meant that Timothy was still with him in Ephesus, but he was planning to send him to Corinth soon. By the time the Corinthians received this letter, Timothy would already be on his way. For example:

I am sending to you Timothy (GNT) (NIV, GNT, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because there is stronger commentary support for it. Paul probably meant that Timothy had already left Ephesus. There is good evidence from the Bible itself to support this interpretation: (a) Paul did not mention Timothy in 1:1 as he did at the beginning of other letters when Timothy was with him (2 Corinthians 1:1, Philippians 1:1, Colossians 1:1, 1 and 2 Thessalonians 1:1, Philemon). (b) In 1 Corinthians 16:10 Paul said, "If Timothy should come..." instead of "When Timothy comes..." Paul was not sure if Timothy would arrive in Corinth or not.

4:17b

my beloved and faithful child in the Lord.

- He is like my child in the Lord. I love him and can depend on him.
- I love him like a son. He is a believer and constantly/faithfully helps me.

my beloved and faithful child in the Lord: There are two possible ways to interpret the Greek words that the BSB translates as my beloved and faithful child in the Lord:

1. Timothy was faithful to Paul, his spiritual father in Christ. For example:

a dear and faithful son to me in the Lord (NJB) (BSB, NJB, RSV, GNT, NET, NASB, NLT, ESV)

1. As Paul's spiritual son, Timothy was faithful to the Lord. For example:

I love him like a son, and he is a faithful servant of the Lord. (CEV) (CEV, REB, GW)

The NIV, KJV, and NCV are more ambiguous and do not explicitly say to whom Timothy was faithful. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) because it has stronger translation support. Paul considered Timothy to be his faithful son as they followed Christ together.

my beloved and faithful child: Timothy was not Paul's child in the physical sense. Paul was Timothy's spiritual father. See 1 Timothy 1:2. Paul had taught and trained Timothy, and Timothy had become one of Paul's helpers.

faithful: The Greek word that the BSB translates as faithful means trustworthy or dependable. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as a verb phrase. For example:

I can trust him

I can rely/depend on him

he keeps his promises

in the Lord: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in the Lord here probably indicates that Timothy belonged to the Lord. He was a believer. Here is another way to translate this:

in the Christian life (GNT)

the Lord: This probably refers to the Lord Jesus. But it is best to keep your translation ambiguous unless you have a good reason not to.

4:17c

He will remind you of my way of life in Christ Jesus,

- He will remind you what I teach and how I behave as a follower of Christ Jesus,
- When he arrives, he will tell you again about the way I live as I follow Christ's ways.

He will remind you of my way of life in Christ Jesus: This verse part indicates that Timothy would help the Corinthians remember Paul and how he lived as a Christian. Other ways to translate this include:

He will help you remember my way of life in Christ Jesus. (NCV)

Timothy will tell you what I do to follow Christ. (CEV)

my way of life: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as my way of life is literally "my ways." Paul was probably referring not only to his behavior, the way he acted, but also to the reasons for his behavior and to his way of thinking.

in Christ Jesus: In this context the common phrase in Christ Jesus likely goes with "my way of life." The phrase "my way of life in Christ Jesus" thus refers to the way Paul lived as a follower/believer in Christ Jesus.

Christ Jesus: There is a textual problem here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts say Christ Jesus. (BSB, NIV, NRSV, GNT, NLT, NCV)
2. Some Greek manuscripts say Christ. (RSV, KJV, NASB, ESV, NJB, REB, NET, CEV, GW)

It is uncertain which form is original. Either is acceptable. It is recommended that you use the form found in the major language version in your area.

4:17d

which is exactly what I teach everywhere in every church.

- which is the same thing that I teach to believers in every town/place I go.
- And this is the same way that I teach in all God's groups everywhere.

which is exactly what I teach everywhere in every church: This verse part indicates that Paul's way of life was in agreement with his public teaching. He acted in the same way that he taught all other believers to act. Here is another way to translate this:

just as I teach it in all the churches everywhere (NCV)

General Comment on 4:17c-d

In some languages it may be natural to connect 4:17c-d with a word meaning "and." For example:

Timothy will tell you what I do to follow Christ and how it agrees with what I always teach about Christ in every church. (CEV)

He will remind you of the principles which I follow in the new life in union with Christ Jesus and which I teach in all the churches everywhere. (NJB)

General Comment on 4:17a-d

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in these verse parts and tell about Timothy's character at the end. For example:

^{17a}That's why I've sent Timothy to you ^{17c}to help you remember my Christian way of life ^{17d}as I teach it everywhere in every church. ^{17b}Timothy is my dear child, and he faithfully does the Lord's work. (GW)

1 Corinthians 4:18**Section 4:1-21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ**

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul's teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect him and Apollos

Paul and Apollos deserved respect as Christ's servants

Paragraph 4:14-21

Paul wanted the Corinthians to change the way they were thinking about him and accept his authority again. So he used another metaphor—that of a father with his children—to help them understand how they should respect and obey him.

4:18a**Some of you have become arrogant,**

- Some of you have become proud/arrogant
- Some among you have started to boast.

Some of you have become arrogant: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as have become arrogant is the same word as in 4:6d, where the BSB translates it as "take pride." It refers to a bad kind of boastful pride. Other ways to translate this include:

Some of you have become proud. (NCV)

Some of you have apparently grown conceited. (JBP)

4:18b**as if I were not coming to you.**

- as though I were not coming back to you.
- You think/say that I will never come to Corinth again.

as if I were not coming to you: After Paul had started the church in Corinth, he left. At the time he was writing this letter, he had been gone from Corinth for two and a half or three years. We do not know why some people in Corinth were saying that Paul was not coming back. But this was not true. In your translation, use the form of a verb for something that people believe to be true but is not true. For example:

as though I were not coming back to you

thinking that I will not come to you again (NCV)

because you think I won't pay you a visit (GW)

General Comment on 4:18a-b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of these two verse parts, following the Greek sentence structure. For example:

^{18b}Now some people there think that I am not going to visit you again, ^{18a}and so they have begun to talk proudly about their own importance/authority.

Some of you think I am not coming for a visit, and so you are bragging. (CEV)

But some of you, thinking that I am not coming to you, have become arrogant. (NRSV)

General Comment on 4:18a-b

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this verse using a direct quote, for example:

^{18b}Some of you are talking like this among yourselves: "Paul will not come here again." ^{18a}And so you have begun to be proud and boast about yourselves.

1 Corinthians 4:19**Section 4:1-21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ**

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders,

especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul's teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect him and Apollos

Paul and Apollos deserved respect as Christ's servants

Paragraph 4:14–21

Paul wanted the Corinthians to change the way they were thinking about him and accept his authority again. So he used another metaphor—that of a father with his children—to help them understand how they should respect and obey him.

4:19

Some of the believers in Corinth had been saying bad things about Paul because he did not use fine talk like this world's people do (see 2:1–5). So Paul began to write about changing the way they think about him. He planned to come and visit them again soon. Then he would be able to find out if they had stopped bragging and had started helping people to follow Christ's ways.

4:19a

But I will come to you shortly, if the Lord is willing,

- However, I will be coming to visit you in a short time, if the Lord makes it possible,
- But I will come to Corinth. I will come soon if the Lord allows me to do so.
- But in spite of what some of you say, I will come visit you. It will not be long before I come, if that is what the Lord wants.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrast with what the Corinthians appear to have thought.

I will come to you shortly, if the Lord is willing:

Although the Corinthians thought he would not come, Paul was planning to come soon. This probably meant that within the next several months Paul would visit them. It was a long journey from Ephesus (where Paul was when he wrote this letter) to Corinth. Such a journey would take at least two or three weeks, and perhaps longer if Paul stopped to visit other churches on his way.

if the Lord is willing: The phrase if the Lord is willing indicates that Paul was willing to change his plans if the Lord wanted him to.

the Lord: In this context the phrase the Lord could refer to either the Lord Jesus or the Lord God. It is best to leave your translation ambiguous if you can.

4:19b

and then I will find out not only what these arrogant people are saying,

- and then I will learn whether those arrogant people are just talking
- At that time I will discover for myself not only what those proud people are saying,
- When I come I will not be interested in hearing what those boastful people claim.

4:19c

but what power they have.

- or if they really do have power.
- but if they have power/authority from from God.
- I want to know what they can do with God's power helping them.

4:19b–c

and then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and then here introduces what would happen when Paul arrived at Corinth. In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here and say simply:

Then (NCV)

I will find out not only what these arrogant people are saying, but what power they have:

In these verse parts Paul indicated that he was more interested in learning about the power of the arrogant people in Corinth than he was in what they were saying. He did not really care about what they claimed about themselves. He wanted to see whether they acted in the power of God through the Holy Spirit. Other ways to translate these verse parts include:

I shall find out not what these self-important people say, but what power they have. (NJB)

I will find out if the ones who are doing all this bragging really have any power (CEV)

I will find out not only what these arrogant people are saying:

The Greek words that the BSB translates as I will find out not only what these arrogant people are saying is literally "I will know not the speech

of those who are arrogant.” Paul’s real interest was in knowing whether these people were acting in the power of God. It did not matter to him very much what these people were actually saying. The BSB has supplied the word only. Consider whether or not this is necessary in your language.

but what power they have: There are at least two ways to interpret this:

1. It refers to the power that God’s Spirit gives believers to do God’s work. People would see this in the way they use the gifts that the Holy Spirit gives them (1 Corinthians 12:4-11). Believers should use those special abilities to help people know God and become strong to follow Christ’s ways.
2. It refers to the power that God’s Spirit uses to cause believers to become like Christ in their character and actions. People would see this in the lives of the believers, their love, joy, peace, patience, and kindness (Galatians 5:22-23).

Both are part of the work of God’s kingdom, his rule over the lives of believers. In this context Paul was expecting to see God’s power at work in their lives during a short visit to Corinth. So he was probably referring to the way people were using their special abilities to work for God instead of just talking proudly about having them.

General Comment on 4:19b-c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 4:19b and c. For example:

^{19c}I will find out for myself the power which these proud people have, and not just what they say. (GNT)

^{19c}I will see for myself whether those braggarts can really do anything, ^{19b}or whether it is all talk.

1 Corinthians 4:20

Section 4:1-21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul’s teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect him and Apollos

Paul and Apollos deserved respect as Christ’s servants

Paragraph 4:14-21

Paul wanted the Corinthians to change the way they were thinking about him and accept his authority again. So he used another metaphor—that of a father with his children—to help them understand how they should respect and obey him.

4:20

For the kingdom of God is not a matter of talk but of power.

- For the kingdom of God does not consist in talk/ words but in power.
- For when God rules his people, he gives them power to follow his ways. If they are just talking, they are not acting as his people.
- People who have God as their king do not just talk about it. They obey him by/through the power that he gives.

For the kingdom of God is not a matter of talk but of power:

In the Greek this verse does not have an explicit verb. The BSB has supplied the words is not a matter of. Paul was probably indicating that God’s kingdom consists in his power to work in people’s lives to bring about faith and righteousness. Their boastful claims were not relevant.

Other ways to translate 4:20 include:

For the kingdom of God consists not in spoken words but in power. (NJB)

For the kingdom of God is demonstrated not in idle talk but with power. (NET)

For the Kingdom of God is not just fancy talk; it is living by God’s power. (NLT)

For: Paul now gives the basis for his desire to find out what power the Corinthians actually have. The things that the Corinthians were saying about their Christian lives were not so important. What was important was whether they were actually living their Christians lives using and demonstrating the power of God.

the kingdom of God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the kingdom of God refers to God’s ruling

over his people. Here are a few suggestions as to how to translate this phrase:

God rules in a person's life

When God rules over people/us...,

We/People submit to God as king....

but of power: Paul was telling the Corinthians that the important thing was not talking about the kingdom of God but actually seeing God's power in the lives of people. See the notes on 4:19b for what kind of power Paul is talking about here. Some ways to translate this are:

but of the power of Christian living (JBP)

it is living by God's power (NLT)

1 Corinthians 4:21

Section 4:1–21: The Corinthians should respect Paul as a servant of Christ

Paul continued to talk about how the Corinthian believers should think about their Christian leaders, especially himself. He said that Christian leaders are servants of Christ and should be judged only by Christ. Some Corinthian believers were saying that they did not have to listen to Paul's teaching. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to respect and obey him as their spiritual father.

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4:21a

Which do you prefer?

- Now which way do you want me to act toward you when I arrive?

- When I arrive there, I can treat you in one of two ways.

Which do you prefer?: This is a rhetorical question. It is literally "What do you want?" Paul was about to ask the Corinthians to choose between two alternatives. This question introduces the two alternatives. There are several ways to translate it:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Which do you want...? (NCV)

Which do you choose? (NLT)

- as a command. For example:

Choose which of these you want/prefer.

Think about what you want/prefer.

- as a statement. For example:

Now it's up to you to choose! (JBP)

Translate this introduction in a way that is natural in your language.

4:21b

Shall I come to you with a rod,

- Do you want me to punish you?
- If you have still not stopped your bad ways, I will rebuke/discipline you severely.

4:21b-c

Shall I come to you with a rod, or in love and with a gentle spirit?:

These verse parts give two alternatives. Paul could either come to deal with them harshly or he could deal with them in a meek and gentle way. This is a rhetorical question. It is obvious which way was preferable. There are two ways to translate these verse parts:

- as one or more rhetorical questions. For example:

Should I come with punishment, or with love and gentleness?

- as a statement or statements. For example:

I'm sure you do not want me to come to you with a whip. You want me to come with a gentle spirit.

Translate these verse parts in the way that is most natural in your language for offering choices when one choice is clearly preferable.

rod: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rod can refer to any stick or rod made out of wood. Here the word refers to a stick that a father would use to correct a disobedient child. Paul used this as a figure of speech. He did not mean that he would come with a real rod. He meant that he would behave firmly and even harshly to the Corinthians. He wanted them to listen to him and obey his authority as Christ's representative, like disobedient children change and become obedient to a loving father. If a literal translation would suggest that Paul would physically punish the Corinthians, you may need to say something like:

Should I come with a rod to punish you... (NLT)

Would you prefer that I be very harsh with you?

Do you want me to be hard on you...? (CEV)

General Comment on 4:21a-b

In some languages it may be natural to mention Paul's arrival in Corinth in 4:21a rather than 4:21b. Several English versions follow this model. For example:

When I come to visit you, would you prefer that I punish you...? (GW)

What do you want me to do when I arrive? Do you want me to be hard on you...? (CEV)

4:21c

or in love and with a gentle spirit?

- Or do you want me to talk to you lovingly and gently?
- But if you have repented, I will be kind to you and show you that I love you.

in love: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in love here refers to a kind or affectionate manner of acting and speaking.

with a gentle spirit: The Greek words that the BSB translates as with a gentle spirit means "with a gentle attitude" or just "with gentleness." It refers to a kind manner of acting and talking.

General Comment on 4:21a-c

In some languages it may be natural to combine these verse parts into one sentence. For example:

^{21a}Do you want me ^{21b}to come to you with a whip
^{21c}or with love and gentleness?

^{21a}Now it is up to you to choose ^{21b}whether my visit will be for discipline ^{21c}or for sharing love and kind words.

1 Corinthians 5:1

Section 5:1-13: Paul commanded the believers to punish the immoral church member

Someone had told Paul that one of the men in the church in Corinth had been having sexual relations with his father's wife, that is, his step-mother. Paul wrote that the believers must punish this man by expelling him from the church. They should not allow this man to meet with them when they gathered to worship God together. Paul urged the Corinthians to keep away from people who called themselves believers but continually committed grave sins. The main point of this section is that the Corinthians were to judge and discipline the man within their fellowship who was sinning.

Paragraph 5:1-5

Paul introduced a new problem in the church at Corinth. One of the believers was behaving immorally. Paul urged the others to expel him from the church.

5:1a

It is actually reported that

- ¶ Some people have told me that
- ¶ I have heard people talking about you.

It is...reported that: Paul was living in the city of Ephesus when he heard some bad news about the church group in Corinth. He did not tell the Corinthian believers who it was that had told him this bad news. This is a passive verb phrase. There are several ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

It is...being said that (NCV)

- using an active verb. For example:

people are saying that

I have heard (CEV)

people have told me that

the word/report going around is that

Use the verb form that is natural in your language. If it is natural to report what Paul had heard as direct speech, refer to the General Comment at the end of 5:1d.

actually: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as actually.

1. It intensifies the verb “reported” and expresses surprise and shock. For example:

Now, it is actually being said that... (GNT) (BSB, NIV, NLT, NET, ESV, NASB, RSV, GNT, REB, NCV)

1. It means “commonly, everywhere” and indicates where the news was reported. For example:

It is widely reported that (NJB) (NJB, KJV)

CEV and GW do not explicitly translate this word. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Another way to express surprise and shock is to follow the model of the NLT:

I can hardly believe the report about... (NLT)

5:1b

there is sexual immorality among you,

- someone in your group is having a sinful sexual relationship.
- They say that one of you is sinning with a woman.

there is sexual immorality among you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sexual immorality is a general term for sinful sexual behavior. It can refer to any situation in which people who are not married to one another have sexual relations.

In some languages it may not be possible to talk about immorality in the abstract. It may be necessary to say that one or more people are behaving in this way. Since the context shows that Paul was thinking primarily of one man, you may be able to translate this as:

one of you is behaving immorally

one of you is sinning sexually

among you: Paul was indicating that it was someone in the Corinthians’ church group who was committing

this sin. A man who said that he was a follower of Christ was breaking God’s laws about sexual purity and marriage.

5:1c

and of a kind that is intolerable even among pagans:

- His sin is so serious/wicked that even heathen people do not practice/permit it.
- It is so wrong/sinful that even those who do not know God do not do/allow it.

of a kind that is intolerable even among pagans:

Paul told how bad the specific immorality occurring in the Corinthian church was. He said that it was so bad that even people who did not know the true God did not commit this kind of sin. In some languages it may be necessary to define what kind of sin Paul was referring to. For example:

such incest as is intolerable even among pagans

The Greek text is more literally “of such a kind not among the pagans.” The BSB has supplied the word intolerable. It is possible to supply other words, such as, for example, “is not permitted.” Paul did not mean that this sin never occurred anywhere else. He meant that it was rare and that when it did happen, people condemned it as evil. They did not view it as acceptable. Someone who behaved like this would be punished. If a literal translation would suggest that this never happened among pagans, you may need to say something like:

you are behaving worse than the Gentiles (CEV)

Even the pagans do not accept/practice such immorality!

In the OT God told the Jewish people that it was forbidden for a man to have sexual intercourse with any woman who used to be married to his father. See Leviticus 18:8; Deuteronomy 22:30; Deuteronomy 27:20. The Greeks and Romans agreed that it was wrong for people to marry or sleep with their close relatives, whether they were blood relatives or related through marriage.

pagans: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pagans refers to people who were not Jewish. They were called “pagans” because they did not worship the one true God.

Here is another other way to translate this word:

people who do not know God (NCV)

5:1d

A man has his father's wife.

- One of you is living/cohabiting/sleeping with a woman who used to be his father's wife.
- What I am referring to is this: A man in your group has been having sexual relations with his stepmother.

A man has his father's wife: This verse part indicates specifically the type of sexual immorality that Paul had heard about: a man in their group had a sexual relationship with his father's wife. Perhaps this man's father had divorced his wife, or perhaps the father had died. We do not know.

has his father's wife: The phrase has his father's wife is in the present tense. This probably indicates that the man did not have sex with his father's wife just one time. She was probably his regular sexual partner.

Paul used a euphemism here. A euphemism is talking about something in a polite way. When Paul said "a man has his father's wife," he meant "a man is having sex with his father's wife." Paul knew that the people in Corinth would understand what he meant. Consider how people talk about this in your language. Translate this in such a way that people can read it aloud in church without it sounding crude or embarrassing.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

has taken his step-mother

is living with his father's wife (RSV)

is sleeping with his stepmother (GNT)

his father's wife: The phrase his father's wife refers to the man's step-mother. The man was not having sex with his own mother. This man's father must have had more than one wife.

General Comment on 5:1a-d

This verse records something that Paul had heard and his own comment on it. In some languages it may be natural to use direct speech for the words that Paul had heard. In those languages it may be necessary to reorder the information and put Paul's own comment at the end of the verse. For example:

^{1a}People have told me, ^{1b}"Someone in the church in Corinth is doing what is immoral. ^{1c}He is sleeping

with his father's wife!" ^{1d}Even the pagans do not accept such incestuous behavior!

^{1a}Some people have said to me, ^{1d}"In the Corinthian church there is a man who is living with his stepmother." ^{1b}This sexual immorality is ^{1c}so bad that it does not even occur among the heathen!

1 Corinthians 5:2

Section 5:1-13: Paul commanded the believers to punish the immoral church member

Someone had told Paul that one of the men in the church in Corinth had been having sexual relations with his father's wife, that is, his step-mother. Paul wrote that the believers must punish this man by expelling him from the church. They should not allow this man to meet with them when they gathered to worship God together. Paul urged the Corinthians to keep away from people who called themselves believers but continually committed grave sins. The main point of this section is that the Corinthians were to judge and discipline the man within their fellowship who was sinning.

Paragraph 5:1-5

Paul introduced a new problem in the church at Corinth. One of the believers was behaving immorally. Paul urged the others to expel him from the church.

5:2a

And you are proud!

- And yet how arrogant you are!
- And you are so pleased with yourselves!

And you are proud!: There were no punctuation marks in the early Greek texts. There are several ways to understand how this sentence should be punctuated.

1. It is an exclamation. It shows that Paul was very shocked and concerned about the attitude of the proud people in the church. For example:

And you are arrogant! (RSV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NCV, REB, ESV, NET, NLT, NJB)

1. It is a rhetorical question that functions as a rebuke. Paul was rebuking the Corinthians for being arrogant as though there were no sinful behavior in their group. For example:

How, then, can you be proud? (GNT) (GNT)

1. It is a statement of fact. Paul was trying to cause the Corinthians to become aware of their attitude. For example:

You are proud.... (CEV) (CEV, GW, NASB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Find a way to translate this into your language so that it is clear that Paul is rebuking the Corinthian believers for their pride.

5:2b-c

In the BSB this is a rhetorical question with two parts. Paul was rebuking the Corinthian believers because they were not sad about the man and his sin. He was telling them what they ought to do about the sin.

5:2b

Shouldn't you rather have been stricken with grief

- Why have you not mourned over this man's sin?
- Instead, you should have become very sorrowful/sad about this sin in your group,

Shouldn't you rather have been stricken with grief...?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses how the Corinthians should have reacted to their member's sin. There are two ways to translate this:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Shouldn't you have been deeply sorrowful instead...? (NET) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NLT, JBP, NET, ESV)

- as a statement. For example. the GNT says:

you should be filled with sadness (GNT) (GNT, CEV, NCV, GW, REB, NASB, KJV, NJB)

You may translate this either as a rhetorical question or as a statement of rebuke, whichever is the more natural in your language.

stricken with grief: The Greek word that the BSB translates with the idiom stricken with grief refers to the way people cry for a person who has just died. Paul used it here in a figurative way to emphasize to the believers in Corinth how they should have responded to the man in their group who was being immoral. They should have been very sad that a member of their church was living immorally. The believers should have felt sorrowful for three reasons: 1. This man was disobeying God and his laws. 2. His sin has caused unbelievers to disrespect the Christians in Corinth, and also to disrespect God and Jesus. 3. A sin committed by one person in a group in one sense causes the whole

group to be guilty and separated from the blessing of God. An example of this in the OT is recorded in Joshua 7, the story of Achan. Thus the believers in Corinth should be truly mourning about this sin that is being committed by someone who is a member of their group. Compare what other Scriptures say about mourning for people who have committed sin: Ezra 9:1-3, Daniel 9:3-19, and 2 Corinthians 12:21. In James 4:8-9, James told the carnal Christians to grieve, mourn and weep (BSB).

Here is another way to translate this:

grieving bitterly (NJB)

5:2c

and have removed from your fellowship the man who did this?

- Why have you not removed/expelled him from your fellowship/group?
- and then you would have forbidden the man who committed this sin to meet/fellowship with you.

and: There are several ways to understand the function of the Greek word that the BSB translates as and:

1. It introduces the result of the grief. For example:

so that he who has done this would have been removed from among you (NRSV) (NRSV, GW, NJB)

1. It introduces the purpose of the mourning. For example:

so that the one who has done this deed would be removed from your midst (NASB) (NASB, KJV, NCV)

1. It introduces a command. For example:

Let him who has done this be removed from among you (RSV) (RSV, REB, GNT, NLT)

The BSB can imply any of these. If you must choose between them, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Other ways to translate this include:

You should have felt sad and upset about this man so that you would have made him leave your group.

You should have been so sad and upset about this man that you made him leave your church group.

have removed from your fellowship the man who did this?: This is also a rhetorical question. The full form of the question would be “Should you not have removed from your fellowship the man who did this?” As with the previous verse part, there are two ways of translating this:

- as a rhetorical question. For example,

Shouldn't you have...removed the one who did this from among you? (NET)

why haven't you removed this man from your fellowship? (NLT) (NET, BSB, NIV, NLT, NRSV)

- as a statement. For example:

The man who has done such a thing should certainly be expelled from your fellowship. (JBP) (JBP, RSV, GNT, KJV, NASB, REB, GW, CEV, NCV)

removed from your fellowship: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as removed from your fellowship is in the passive: “be removed from among you.” The BSB has supplied the implied agent: the Corinthians were the ones who were to remove the man. They were to treat him as though he were not part of the church. Paul wanted the Corinthians to tell the man that he could not be part of their group. He did not mean that they should physically push or chase the man away. Rather, they should forbid the man from coming to their meetings. Other ways to translate this include:

expelled from your fellowship (GNT)

turned out of your community (REB)

1 Corinthians 5:3

Section 5:1–13: Paul commanded the believers to punish the immoral church member

Someone had told Paul that one of the men in the church in Corinth had been having sexual relations with his father's wife, that is, his step-mother. Paul wrote that the believers must punish this man by expelling him from the church. They should not allow this man to meet with them when they gathered to worship God together. Paul urged the Corinthians to keep away from people who called themselves believers but continually committed grave sins. The main point of this section is that the Corinthians were to

judge and discipline the man within their fellowship who was sinning.

Paragraph 5:1–5

Paul introduced a new problem in the church at Corinth. One of the believers was behaving immorally. Paul urged the others to expel him from the church.

5:3–5

These three verses are one sentence in Greek. In your translation you will probably want to break it into several sentences. For example:

³I am not with you in person, but I am with you in spirit. And I have already judged the man who did that sin as if I were really there. ⁴When you meet together in the name of our Lord Jesus, and I meet with you in spirit with the power of our Lord Jesus, ⁵hand this man over to Satan. So his sinful self will be destroyed, and his soul will be saved on the day of the Lord. (NCV)

5:3a

Although I am absent from you in body,

- Even though I am not there with you,
- Although I am far away from you,

In Greek 5:3a begins with a connecting word that is often translated as “for” or “because” (See 5:3 in the NRSV.) In this context this word introduces one reason why the Corinthians should have expelled the man who had sinned.

Although I am absent from you in body: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as absent from you in body indicates that Paul was not actually in Corinth in person. Other ways to translate this include:

Even though I am not physically present (NIV)

I am not there with you in person, but.... (NCV)

5:3b

I am present with you in spirit,

- I am there with you in my spirit/heart/mind.
- I am present with you spiritually.

I am present with you in spirit: The Greek clause that the BSB translates literally as I am present with you in spirit means: “I am there with you in my spirit,” that is, I am with you spiritually.

5:3c–5a

There is a problem with understanding the structure of these verse parts. There are three ways of under-

standing where the phrase “in the name of our Lord Jesus” belongs. The three main views are:

1. It belongs with the phrase “you are assembled.” The believers came together in the name of the Lord Jesus. For example:

I...have already condemned the man who behaved in this way, just as though I were present in person. When you have gathered together in the name of our Lord Jesus.... (NJB) (BSB, NIV, REB, NCV, NET, ESV, NJB)

1. It belongs with the phrase “I have already pronounced judgment.” Paul passed judgment on the sinner with the authority of the Lord Jesus. For example:

and as if present I have already passed judgment in the name of the Lord Jesus on the man who has done such a thing. When you are assembled... (NRSV) (RSV, GNT, CEV, NLT)

1. It belongs with the phrase “hand this man over to Satan.” Paul said the man should be handed over to Satan by the authority of the Lord Jesus. Here is another way to translate this:

Then, in the name of our Lord Jesus, and with his power, hand such a person over to Satan... (GW) (GW)

The KJV can be understood either way. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) since it has strong translation support.

5:3c

and I have already pronounced judgment on the one who did this,

- And I have already decided that/how we must punish/discipline the man who has sinned.

I have already pronounced judgment on the one who did this: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as I have...pronounced judgment is literally “I have judged.” This is the main verb in 5:3. Paul had already made his decision about what the Corinthian believers should do with this immoral man in their group.

5:3d

just as if I were present.

- I am acting/speaking as one who is present/there with you.

just as if I were present: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as just as if I were present is more literally “as present.” That is, Paul was emphasizing that he was spiritually present rather than that he was physically absent.

General Comment on 5:3c-d

In some languages it may be natural to follow the NRSV and reverse the order of these verse parts:

^{3d}as if present ^{3c}I have already pronounced judgment (NRSV)

1 Corinthians 5:4

Section 5:1–13: Paul commanded the believers to punish the immoral church member

Someone had told Paul that one of the men in the church in Corinth had been having sexual relations with his father’s wife, that is, his step-mother. Paul wrote that the believers must punish this man by expelling him from the church. They should not allow this man to meet with them when they gathered to worship God together. Paul urged the Corinthians to keep away from people who called themselves believers but continually committed grave sins. The main point of this section is that the Corinthians were to judge and discipline the man within their fellowship who was sinning.

Paragraph 5:1–5

Paul introduced a new problem in the church at Corinth. One of the believers was behaving immorally. Paul urged the others to expel him from the church.

5:4a-c

Verse parts 4a, 4b, and 4c give three conditions that Paul said should be present when the sinful man is handed over to Satan.

- The Corinthian Christians should be gathered together, 4a.
- Paul should be present with them in spirit, 4b.
- The power of the Lord Jesus should be present with the Corinthians, 4c.

5:4a

When you are assembled in the name of our Lord Jesus

- When you are gathered together in the name of our Lord Jesus
- When you meet together to worship in the name of our Lord Jesus,

When you are assembled in the name of our Lord Jesus: This phrase refers to a time when the

Corinthian believers would meet together officially, as a church body, to worship the Lord Jesus.

our Lord Jesus: There is a textual problem here:

1. Some Greek texts say our Lord Jesus.

(BSB, NJB, NIV, NASB, REB, GW, CEV, NCV, NET)

1. Some Greek texts say the Lord Jesus

(NLT, RSV, ESV)

1. Some Greek texts say our Lord Jesus Christ.

(KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This is followed by the majority of English versions. The UBS Greek text omits the word “Christ” and encloses the word our in square brackets, indicating that it is doubtful.

5:4b

and I am with you in spirit,

- and I am with you in my spirit/heart/mind,
- and I am with you spiritually,

I am with you in spirit: The phrase I am with you in spirit here, like the similar phrase in 5:3b, indicates that Paul would be spiritually present with the Corinthians.

5:4c

along with the power of the Lord Jesus,

- our Lord Jesus will give us power to do what he wants us to do.
- then our Lord Jesus will cause to happen what you/we agree to do.

along with the power of the Lord Jesus: Here, the power of the Lord Jesus refers to the ability and authority that is given by the Lord Jesus. Jesus had given to Paul and the church the authority to represent him. Paul made the decision that they should expel the man who was acting immorally from their group. And Jesus had promised to do whatever a group of believers agreed on and decided to do. (See Matthew 18:20; John 14:14.)

There are several ways of understanding how this phrase connects to the rest of the sentence:

1. It is connected to the phrases “when you are assembled” and “I am with you in spirit.” For example:

When you are assembled, and my spirit is present, with the power of our Lord Jesus, you are to deliver... (RSV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, KJV)

1. It is connected only with the phrase “you are assembled.” For example:

So when you meet together and the power of the Lord is with you, I will be there too. (CEV) (CEV, NLT, NJB)

1. It is connected only with the phrase “I am with you.” For example:

When you meet together in the name of our Lord Jesus, and I meet with you in spirit with the power of our Lord Jesus, then hand this man over to Satan. (NCV) (NCV, NRSV)

1. It is connected with the phrase “hand this man over to Satan.” For example:

through the power of the Lord Jesus you are to consign this man to Satan (REB) (REB, GW, GNT)

The NET, ESV, and NASB are all unclear or deliberately vague (as the NET footnote points out). If it is necessary for you to choose between these interpretations, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In some languages there may not be much difference between interpretations 1 and 2, as illustrated by the NJB, where only the word “and” indicates the interpretation that is being followed: When you have gathered together in the name of our Lord Jesus, with the presence of my spirit, and in the power of our Lord Jesus, hand such a man over to Satan.

1 Corinthians 5:5

Section 5:1–13: Paul commanded the believers to punish the immoral church member

Someone had told Paul that one of the men in the church in Corinth had been having sexual relations with his father’s wife, that is, his step-mother. Paul wrote that the believers must punish this man by expelling him from the church. They should not allow this man to meet with them when they gathered to worship God together. Paul urged the Corinthians to keep away from people who called themselves believers but continually committed grave sins. The main point of this section is that the Corinthians were to judge and discipline the man within their fellowship who was sinning.

Paragraph 5:1–5

Paul introduced a new problem in the church at Corinth. One of the believers was behaving immorally. Paul urged the others to expel him from the church.

5:5a**hand this man over to Satan**

- I want you to surrender/give that man to Satan
- I order you to expel this man from your church/group, giving/putting him back into Satan's control/kingdom.
- Give this man to Satan: tell him he can no longer be part of your group/church.

hand this man over to Satan: This verse part indicates what Paul wanted the Corinthian believers to do. This was the judgment that he had already passed: the Corinthians were to hand the man over to Satan.

The phrase hand this man over to Satan apparently refers to expelling the man from the church. This would be like putting him back under Satan's power. He would no longer be one of God's people or part of the kingdom of God. Not only would this separate the man from the other believers, but it would also remove Christ's protection over his life.

Refer to your translation of 1 Timothy 1:20, where the same phrase occurs.

Satan: Satan is another name for the devil. The name Satan means "enemy, opponent." Satan is God's enemy and the enemy of those who belong to God.

5:5b**for the destruction of the flesh,**

- in order that his fleshly/corrupt nature may/will be destroyed
- The reason you are to expel him from your group is so that what is fleshly/sinful in him will be brought to an end.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for here introduces the purpose of the Corinthians in handing the man over to Satan. In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here and say something like:

Do this for...

the destruction: The Greek word that the BSB translates as destruction in this context refers to something being brought to an end or coming to ruin/disaster. There are several ways of translating the phrase "for the destruction":

- with a passive verb. For example:

So his sinful self will be destroyed (NCV)

- with an active verb. It is best if you do not supply a specific subject for the verb "destroy." For example:

to destroy his corrupt nature (GW)

so that his carnal/fleshly self will come to ruin

and that way he will stop desiring evil

- with a noun phrase. For example:

for the purpose of the destruction of the/his fleshly nature

the flesh: The Greek word that the BSB translates as flesh is used in the NT with several meanings. There are two main ways to interpret it here:

1. It refers to the man's sinful nature, that part of his being that was corrupt or carnal. For example:

his sinful self (NCV) (NIV, NCV, GW, NLT)

1. It refers to the man's physical body. For example:

his body (CEV) (GNT, CEV, REB)

The NJB says "natural life." The BSB, RSV, KJV, ESV, NET, and NASB say flesh, which can have either meaning (though the physical one is the more natural use of the word in English). It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is strongly supported by several major modern commentaries.

5:5c**so that his spirit may be saved on the Day of the Lord.**

- and so his spirit will be saved on the day the Lord returns.
- It is important that his sinful nature be destroyed in order that God may save him on the day the Lord comes to judge people.

so that his spirit may be saved on the Day of the Lord:

The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so that here introduces the main purpose of the action to expel the man. Paul was telling the Corinthian believers that their main purpose or goal in handing the wrongdoer over to Satan was to save the man's spirit. Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

that his spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord Jesus (NKJV)

his spirit may be saved: A person's spirit means the person himself. Paul was saying that the man would be saved or rescued by God from eternal death.

This is a passive clause. There are two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

his spirit will be saved (NCV)

- using an active verb. For example:

God will save his spirit

he may experience/receive salvation

on the Day of the Lord: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Day of the Lord refers to the time when the Lord Jesus returns to judge people.

1 Corinthians 5:6

Section 5:1–13: Paul commanded the believers to punish the immoral church member

Someone had told Paul that one of the men in the church in Corinth had been having sexual relations with his father's wife, that is, his step-mother. Paul wrote that the believers must punish this man by expelling him from the church. They should not allow this man to meet with them when they gathered to worship God together. Paul urged the Corinthians to keep away from people who called themselves believers but continually committed grave sins. The main point of this section is that the Corinthians were to judge and discipline the man within their fellowship who was sinning.

Paragraph 5:6–8

In this section, Paul referred to two Jewish feasts. The Passover Feast was held each year in remembrance of the time that the Israelites departed from Egypt. Its name comes from the way the angel of death "passed over" each family that had placed the blood of a lamb on their doorposts. After celebrating the Passover, the Jewish people celebrated a second feast, the Feast of Unleavened Bread. It lasted for seven days. It was called this because people ate bread made without yeast.

Paul assumed that the Corinthian believers knew about these Jewish holidays. But the people who

read your translation may not know about them. In your translation you may want to use a dictionary/glossary or footnotes to explain the Jewish customs of Passover and Unleavened Bread. Here are some brief explanations about Passover, Feast of Unleavened Bread and yeast. You may want to put information like this into a dictionary (glossary) in the back of your translation, or in a footnote at 1 Corinthians 5:6–8, to explain background information to your readers. **Passover:** On the day of Passover, the Jewish people remember the day that God freed them from being slaves in Egypt long ago. We read this story in Exodus 12. On that day long ago, God punished the Egyptian people so they would allow the Jewish people to go free. Here is what he did. First he gave the Jewish people these instructions: Each family was to kill a lamb and put its blood on the sides and top of the doorway of their house. Then they were to stay inside the house all night, cook the lamb and eat it. On that same night, God killed every firstborn son in the land of Egypt. But he did not kill anyone who was in a house where there was the blood of a lamb on the door. In the NT, Jesus was killed at the time of the Passover feast (Matthew 26:2; Luke 22:1; John 13:1). Jesus is like a lamb that the Jewish people killed at Passover time, because he died in our place, so that God would not punish us for our sins. See John 1:29, 36; 1 Corinthians 5:7; 1 Peter 1:18–19; Revelation 5; Isaiah 53:6–7; Acts 8:32–35. **Feast of Unleavened Bread:** This is the name of a special holiday of the Jewish people. Every year they removed all yeast from their houses. They ate bread made with no yeast. They did this beginning on the day of Passover and for the seven days that followed (Exodus 12:15–20). This custom reminded them of the time when they left Egypt long ago. At that time long ago, God caused the Egyptian people to free the Jewish people from being slaves. They left Egypt quickly and did not have time to put yeast in their bread dough (Exodus 12:39). **Yeast:** This is a sort of fungus that is mixed with flour. When the flour is mixed with water and sugar, the yeast causes the mixture to get bigger. A very small amount of yeast will affect a large amount of flour, water and sugar. In the NT, yeast is often a symbol of evil behavior. See Matthew 16:6–12; Mark 8:15–21; Luke 12:1; 1 Corinthians 5:6–8; Galatians 5:9. But in Matthew 13:33 and Luke 13:20–21, yeast is a symbol of how God's kingdom becomes bigger.

In these verses Paul used the Passover lamb and yeast as symbols/metaphors. First, the Passover feast was a reminder of the joy and the freedom from slavery that the Jewish people experienced after God delivered them from the power of the Egyptian king. Slavery can be compared to the bondage that sinning causes us

to experience, so the metaphor of Passover refers to a new life of freedom from sin. Second, just as the Jewish people removed yeast from their houses, so the Corinthian believers should remove the immoral man from their church group (5:7a), because the immoral man was like yeast among the believers. Believers should stop behaving in evil ways (5:8).

5:6a

Your boasting is not good.

- ¶ You should not feel proud about your church group.
- ¶ Since/Because there is an immoral person in your group, you should not be talking proudly about yourselves.
- ¶ There is an immoral person in your group. But even so, you are proud of yourselves. This is not good/proper.

Your boasting is not good: The Corinthians thought that they had many reasons to boast. They had special abilities that God's Spirit had given them. They were proud of these special abilities and the important roles of leadership that some of them had in their church group. Paul said that, because someone in their group was committing a serious sin, they should not be proud. Actually they had much of which they should be ashamed. Other ways to translate this include:

Your bragging is not good. (NCV)

It's not good for you to brag. (GW)

5:6b

Do you not know that a little leaven works through the whole batch of dough?

- Remember: a little bit of yeast can make a lot of dough puff up.
- Remember what it is like when people make bread. They only need to use a small amount of yeast to make all of the bread rise. Bad behavior is like that yeast!
- Don't you know that even one sinner in your group may cause others to sin?

Do you not know that a little leaven works through the whole batch of dough?: This is a rhetorical question. The expected answer is something like "Of course we know that." Paul asked this rhetorical question so that the Corinthian believers would think start to think truthfully about the situation in their church group. (Compare 3:16a and the note on 3:16a.) Paul wanted them to understand that it was very dangerous for

them to allow the immoral man to remain as a member of their group.

There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Don't you know that a little yeast affects the whole batch of dough? (NET)

- as a statement. For example:

You know the saying, "Just a little yeast makes the whole batch rise." (NCV)

You may translate this in whichever of these ways is the more natural in your language.

a little leaven works through the whole batch of dough: This was probably a well-known saying. In English we have a similar saying: "One rotten apple spoils the whole barrel." James also used a figure of speech with a similar meaning: "Consider what a great forest is set on fire by a small spark" (James 3:5). The meaning of all these metaphors is that something small can have a big influence. Paul used this saying about leaven/yeast to teach that one immoral man in the church causes other people in the church to sin or to suffer. The batch/lump of dough represents the church, God's group of people. The little bit of leaven represents one person's wrongdoing and its bad effect on the others.

There are several ways to translate this metaphor:

- Literally. Do this only if people in your language group understand about leaven and will understand the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

Don't you know that a little yeast spreads through the whole batch of dough? (GW)

- Keep the metaphor but make the meaning of the metaphor explicit. For example:

Just like a little leaven can make a lot of dough rise, so one immoral man in your group can cause many others to suffer or even fall into sin.

- Remove the metaphor. For example:

Don't you realize that if even one person is allowed to go on sinning, soon all will be affected? (NLT96)

leaven: The Greek word that the BSB translates as leaven refers to a substance that people mix into flour when they are making bread. It is a fungus that causes the bread dough to ferment and rise. In some English versions it is called "yeast." There are several verses in the Bible where yeast or leaven is a symbol of evil behavior (Matthew 16:6-12; Mark 8:15-21; Luke 12:1; Galatians 5:9). Here Paul used leaven as a metaphor to teach the Corinthian believers that one evil person can influence many people in a group.

1 Corinthians 5:7

Section 5:1-13: Paul commanded the believers to punish the immoral church member

Someone had told Paul that one of the men in the church in Corinth had been having sexual relations with his father's wife, that is, his step-mother. Paul wrote that the believers must punish this man by expelling him from the church. They should not allow this man to meet with them when they gathered to worship God together. Paul urged the Corinthians to keep away from people who called themselves believers but continually committed grave sins. The main point of this section is that the Corinthians were to judge and discipline the man within their fellowship who was sinning.

Paragraph 5:6-8

In this section, Paul referred to two Jewish feasts. The Passover Feast was held each year in remembrance of the time that the Israelites departed from Egypt. Its name comes from the way the angel of death "passed over" each family that had placed the blood of a lamb on their doorposts. After celebrating the Passover, the Jewish people celebrated a second feast, the Feast of Unleavened Bread. It lasted for seven days. It was called this because people ate bread made without yeast.

Paul assumed that the Corinthian believers knew about these Jewish holidays. But the people who read your translation may not know about them. In your translation you may want to use a dictionary/glossary or footnotes to explain the Jewish customs of Passover and Unleavened Bread. Here are some brief explanations about Passover, Feast of Unleavened Bread and yeast. You may want to put information like this into a dictionary (glossary) in the back of your translation, or in a footnote at 1 Corinthians 5:6-8, to explain background information to your

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In these verses Paul used the Passover lamb and yeast as symbols/metaphors. First, the Passover feast was a reminder of the joy and the freedom from slavery that the Jewish people experienced after God delivered them from the power of the Egyptian king. Slavery can be compared to the bondage that sinning causes us to experience, so the metaphor of Passover refers to a new life of freedom from sin. Second, just as the Jewish people removed yeast from their houses, so the Corinthian believers should remove the immoral man from their church group (5:7a), because the immoral man was like yeast among the believers. Believers should stop behaving in evil ways (5:8).

5:7a-c

This verse continues the metaphor of the yeast. Consider whether your readers would understand that the yeast refers to sin. There are several ways of translating it:

- literally, keeping the metaphor. For example:

Clean out the old yeast so that you may be a new batch of dough—you are, in fact, without yeast. (NET)

- explaining something of the meaning of the metaphor. For example, the GNT has made it clear that the expression “old yeast” refers to sin:

You must remove the old yeast of sin so that you will be entirely pure. Then you will be like a new batch of dough without any yeast... (GNT)

- removing the metaphor and translating the meaning. For example:

Remove this wicked person from among you so that you can stay pure. (NLT)

Consider how much explanation is necessary to make it possible for your readers to understand what Paul was saying.

5:7a**Get rid of the old leaven,**

- Remove the old yeast of sin
- Just as the Jews remove all yeast from their houses before they celebrate the Passover feast, so you should remove/expel this immoral man from your group.

Get rid of the old leaven: At the time of the Feast of the Unleavened Bread, the Jewish people carefully removed all the old leaven from their homes and then for seven days they ate bread that had no leaven in it. But in this context this is a figure of speech. Paul did not really want the Corinthian to throw leaven out of their houses. The leaven is a symbol of sin, and Paul wanted the Corinthians to get rid of the sin in their church. He wanted them to stop allowing wrongdoing to go on among the people in the church. This would mean expelling from the church the man who had married his step-mother.

5:7b**that you may be a new unleavened batch,**

- so that you may become like bread that has no yeast in it, that is, a pure church.
- Then you will be holy/pure, like new bread made without yeast,

that you may be a new unleavened batch: This is a purpose clause. Paul said that the Corinthian believers were to throw out the old leaven in order that they might be a new unleavened batch. The phrase a new... batch means a new piece or lump of dough. This is an illustration of a pure and holy church. Another way to translate this is:

Then you will be like fresh bread made without yeast (CEV)

so that you may be like a new batch of bread made without leaven

5:7c**as you really are.**

- God has indeed made you clean/pure.
- just as you really are God's holy/special people.

as you really are: The phrase as you really are here means “as you really are new bread without yeast.” This continues the figure of speech. Paul was saying that Christ had forgiven the Corinthians' sin and made them clean on the inside. They had been cleansed from their sin and therefore they really were God's holy people. So they should act like it.

5:7d**For Christ, our Passover lamb, has been sacrificed.**

- For Christ has been sacrificed for us^(incl), like a Passover lamb.
- For Christ has died as our^(incl) sacrifice, our^(incl) Passover Lamb.
- For Christ died to set us^(incl) free from our^(incl) sins. He is like the lamb that the Jews kill/sacrifice at Passover time.

For Christ, our Passover lamb, has been sacrificed:

Paul gave the reason for saying that the Corinthians were unleavened or pure. The Corinthians were like a new batch of bread made without yeast because Christ had already been sacrificed for their sins. Christ had already died as their complete payment for sin. He had set them free from being slaves to their old life of sin. This is illustrated by the Passover story. The Jewish people left their life of slavery in Egypt as soon as they had sacrificed their Passover Lamb.

Christ, our Passover lamb, has been sacrificed: This is a metaphor taken from the Jewish Passover Feast.

Passover was the feast/holiday that the Jewish people celebrated immediately before the Feast of Unleavened Bread. On Passover they sacrificed a lamb (young sheep), and then immediately began to use only bread made without yeast for seven days. You can read about those two feasts in Exodus 12:3–8, 14–20 and Leviticus 23:5–7.

This is a passive clause. There are two ways of translating it:

- with a passive verb. For example:

Our Passover Lamb is Christ, who has already been sacrificed. (CEV)

- with an active verb. For example:

Christ, our passover lamb, has died as our sacrifice.

Christ has become our sacrifice, our passover lamb.

They have already sacrificed Christ, who is our passover lamb.

Christ, our Passover lamb: Christ is like a Passover lamb in several ways. The lamb was killed at the first Passover so that God’s people, the Hebrews, would not be killed when God’s angel killed all the firstborn sons in Egypt. In the same way, Christ was killed so that God’s people will not be punished for their sins. Also, on the day that the Hebrews killed the Passover lamb, they were set free from slavery in Egypt. In the same way, Christ died to set us free from being slaves to sin. See the endnote on 5:6–8. In some languages it may be natural to translate this metaphor as a simile:

Christ is like our Passover Lamb

1 Corinthians 5:8

Section 5:1–13: Paul commanded the believers to punish the immoral church member

Someone had told Paul that one of the men in the church in Corinth had been having sexual relations with his father’s wife, that is, his step-mother. Paul wrote that the believers must punish this man by expelling him from the church. They should not allow this man to meet with them when they gathered to worship God together. Paul urged the Corinthians to keep away from people who called themselves believ-

ers but continually committed grave sins. The main point of this section is that the Corinthians were to judge and discipline the man within their fellowship who was sinning.

Paragraph 5:6–8

In this section, Paul referred to two Jewish feasts. The Passover Feast was held each year in remembrance of the time that the Israelites departed from Egypt. Its name comes from the way the angel of death “passed over” each family that had placed the blood of a lamb on their doorposts. After celebrating the Passover, the Jewish people celebrated a second feast, the Feast of Unleavened Bread. It lasted for seven days. It was called this because people ate bread made without yeast.

Paul assumed that the Corinthian believers knew about these Jewish holidays. But the people who read your translation may not know about them. In your translation you may want to use a dictionary/glossary or footnotes to explain the Jewish customs of Passover and Unleavened Bread. Here are some brief explanations about Passover, Feast of Unleavened Bread and yeast. You may want to put information like this into a dictionary (glossary) in the back of your translation, or in a footnote at 1 Corinthians 5:6–8, to explain background information to your readers. **Passover:** On the day of Passover, the Jewish people remember the day that God freed them from being slaves in Egypt long ago. We read this story in Exodus 12. On that day long ago, God punished the Egyptian people so they would allow the Jewish people to go free. Here is what he did. First he gave the Jewish people these instructions: Each family was to kill a lamb and put its blood on the sides and top of the doorway of their house. Then they were to stay inside the house all night, cook the lamb and eat it. On that same night, God killed every firstborn son in the land of Egypt. But he did not kill anyone who was in a house where there was the blood of a lamb on the door. In the NT, Jesus was killed at the time of the Passover feast (Matthew 26:2; Luke 22:1; John 13:1). Jesus is like a lamb that the Jewish people killed at Passover time, because he died in our place, so that God would not punish us for our sins. See John 1:29, 36; 1 Corinthians 5:7; 1 Peter 1:18–19; Revelation 5; Isaiah 53:6–7; Acts 8:32–35. **Feast of Unleavened Bread:** This is the name of a special holiday of the Jewish people. Every year they removed all yeast from their houses. They ate bread made with no yeast. They did this beginning on the day of Passover and for the seven days that followed (Exodus 12:15–20). This custom reminded them of the time when they left Egypt long ago. At that time long ago, God caused the Egyptian people to free the Jew-

ish people from being slaves. They left Egypt quickly and did not have time to put yeast in their bread dough (Exodus 12:39). Yeast: This is a sort of fungus that is mixed with flour. When the flour is mixed with water and sugar, the yeast causes the mixture to get bigger. A very small amount of yeast will affect a large amount of flour, water and sugar. In the NT, yeast is often a symbol of evil behavior. See Matthew 16:6-12; Mark 8:15-21; Luke 12:1; 1 Corinthians 5:6-8; Galatians 5:9. But in Matthew 13:33 and Luke 13:20-21, yeast is a symbol of how God's kingdom becomes bigger.

In these verses Paul used the Passover lamb and yeast as symbols/metaphors. First, the Passover feast was a reminder of the joy and the freedom from slavery that the Jewish people experienced after God delivered them from the power of the Egyptian king. Slavery can be compared to the bondage that sinning causes us to experience, so the metaphor of Passover refers to a new life of freedom from sin. Second, just as the Jewish people removed yeast from their houses, so the Corinthian believers should remove the immoral man from their church group (5:7a), because the immoral man was like yeast among the believers. Believers should stop behaving in evil ways (5:8).

5:8a

Therefore let us keep the feast,

- So let us^(incl) keep/celebrate the Passover Festival/ Feast
- Since that is true, we^(incl) should celebrate the new life that Christ has given us.
- So we^(incl) should live our new lives

Therefore: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Therefore introduces the conclusion to Paul's argument. It is also possible to translate it as

then (GNT)

So (NCV)

let us keep the feast: This is a command in the first-person plural. It is also possible to translate it as:

we should keep the feast

keep the feast: This is an English idiom. To keep a festival means to celebrate or follow the customs and ceremonies of the festival. But this is also a metaphor. Paul did not mean that believers should literally follow the Jewish customs of Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread. Paul meant that since Christ has already died to redeem the Corinthians from their sins

(5:7d), they should rejoice and act like God's people who have been freed from sin. So there are at least two ways to translate this verse part:

- literally, keeping the metaphor. For example

let us celebrate this feast (NCV)

- explaining the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

let us celebrate our freedom

let us celebrate how Christ has freed/redeemed us

5:8b

not with the old bread,

- and not make use of old yeast, that is, old ways of behaving.
- We^(incl) should not use that bad old yeast,
- without any of our^(incl) old/former way of living/behaving.

5:8c

leavened with malice and wickedness,

- We^(incl) should stop acting in hateful, evil ways.
- that is, our^(incl) former wicked ways of living.
- We^(incl) should stop doing the evil and wicked things we used to do.

5:8b-c

not with the old bread, leavened with malice and wickedness: The phrase that the BSB translates as old bread is more literally "old leaven," as in the NASB. Here Paul used the metaphor of "old leaven" in a general sense to refer to the Corinthians' former way of life. Before they became believers they used to act in ways that were malicious and wicked. Here is a way to translate these verse parts so that the meaning of the metaphor is more clear:

We should get rid of the old leaven. That is, we should stop acting in the hateful and evil ways we had in the old times before we became believers.

In some languages it will be clearer if you use words like "previous" or "former" rather than old. For example:

not with the leaven you previously/formerly used, that malicious and wicked leaven

leavened with malice and wickedness: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as leavened with malice and wickedness here means “the leaven that consists of malice and wickedness.” This phrase helps explain the meaning of Paul’s figure of speech. He was using the phrase “old leaven” to refer to an evil way of life.

malice and wickedness: The Greek words that the BSB translates as malice and wickedness mean approximately the same thing. Paul used two words in order to emphasize the idea of evil. He was saying strongly that believers should stay away from every kind of evil and bad behavior. Other ways to translate this phrase include:

vice and wickedness (JBP)

being evil and sinful (CEV)

5:8d

but with the unleavened bread

- We^(incl) should make use only of bread without yeast,
- Instead, we^(incl) should act/behave only in ways that are clean/pure.

5:8e

of sincerity and of truth.

- acting/behaving sincerely and truthfully.
- We^(incl) should always be honest and speak the truth.

5:8d-e

but with the unleavened bread of sincerity and of truth: In 5:8d Paul said that the Corinthian believers should use unleavened bread. In 5:8e he explained what he meant: they should act with sincerity and truth.

of sincerity and of truth: Paul probably used the two words sincerity and truth together as a way of saying strongly that believers should follow every kind of good way. They should treat others in only good ways. To behave with sincerity means to speak and act openly, according to one’s true intentions, rather than deceitfully. To act or speak with truth is to be honest and trustworthy. Other ways to translate this include:

of purity and truth (GNT)

be sincere and truthful

General Comment on 5:8

There are several ways to reorder these verse parts. Here are two suggestions:

^{8a}So don’t celebrate the festival ^{8c}by being evil and sinful, ^{8b}which is like serving bread made with yeast. ^{8e}Be pure and truthful ^{8d}and celebrate using bread made without yeast. (CEV)

^{8d-e}Celebrate the festival by being pure and truthful which is like serving bread made without yeast. ^{8c}Do not be evil and sinful ^{8a}when you celebrate the festival, ^{8b}which is like serving bread made with yeast.

1 Corinthians 5:9

Section 5:1–13: Paul commanded the believers to punish the immoral church member

Someone had told Paul that one of the men in the church in Corinth had been having sexual relations with his father’s wife, that is, his step-mother. Paul wrote that the believers must punish this man by expelling him from the church. They should not allow this man to meet with them when they gathered to worship God together. Paul urged the Corinthians to keep away from people who called themselves believers but continually committed grave sins. The main point of this section is that the Corinthians were to judge and discipline the man within their fellowship who was sinning.

Paragraph 5:9–11

In this paragraph Paul corrected something that the Corinthians had misunderstood. In a letter he had written to them earlier, he had told them to have nothing to do with sexually immoral people. Some people in Corinth thought he meant unbelievers only. So they ignored the bad doings of a man in their own group. What Paul had meant was not to have anything to do with people who said they were Christians and yet behaved immorally.

5:9a

I wrote you in my letter

- ¶ When I wrote a letter to you before,
- ¶ Not long ago I wrote you another letter. In that letter I said that

I wrote you in my letter: Paul was referring to a letter that he had written before he wrote 1 Corinthians. That letter is now lost, and we do not have any copies. But the Corinthians knew about it at the time Paul wrote this present letter. Other ways of translating this verse part include:

I have written to you in my letter (NIV)

In my other letter I told you... (CEV)

5:9b

not to associate with sexually immoral people.

- I told you not to be friends with people who commit sexual sins.
- you should not fellowship with people who are immoral/unchaste.

not to associate with sexually immoral people: To associate with people means to mingle freely with them, to fellowship with them, be close to them, and do things with them. People who are sexually immoral are people who have sex with people to whom they are not married.

sexually immoral people: The Greek word that the BSB has translated as sexually immoral people is literally “fornicators.” A fornicator is a person who engages in sexual sin. In your translation, use a word that is appropriate for public reading. Some English versions use a euphemism and say simply:

immoral people (GNT)

General Comment on 5:9a-b

In some languages it may be natural to translate Paul’s words from his earlier letter as direct speech. For example:

In my previous letter I said, “Don’t mix with the immoral.” (JBP)

1 Corinthians 5:10

Section 5:1–13: Paul commanded the believers to punish the immoral church member

Someone had told Paul that one of the men in the church in Corinth had been having sexual relations with his father’s wife, that is, his step-mother. Paul wrote that the believers must punish this man by expelling him from the church. They should not allow this man to meet with them when they gathered to worship God together. Paul urged the Corinthians to keep away from people who called themselves believers but continually committed grave sins. The main point of this section is that the Corinthians were to judge and discipline the man within their fellowship who was sinning.

Paragraph 5:9–11

In this paragraph Paul corrected something that the Corinthians had misunderstood. In a letter he had written to them earlier, he had told them to have

nothing to do with sexually immoral people. Some people in Corinth thought he meant unbelievers only. So they ignored the bad doings of a man in their own group. What Paul had meant was not to have anything to do with people who said they were Christians and yet behaved immorally.

5:10a-c

I was not including the sexually immoral of this world, or the greedy and swindlers, or idolaters:

In these verse parts Paul corrected the Corinthians’ misunderstanding of his earlier letter. The Corinthians had thought he was referring to unbelievers who were sinners. But this was not what Paul had meant.

5:10a

I was not including the sexually immoral of this world,

- I was not referring to unbelievers who commit sexual sins,
- When I wrote that, I was not talking about people who are not Christians. Many of them are immoral/unchaste,

I was not including: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as I was not including is more literally “not at all,” as in the RSV. There are two ways of understanding this phrase:

1. It modifies the word including (supplied by the BSB) and indicates that Paul did not include these people at all in what he had said. For example:

In no way did I mean.... (NET) (NIV, RSV, NASB, REB, NET)

1. It modifies the command not to associate and means not without exception, not totally. For example:

I didn’t tell you that you couldn’t have any contact with.... (GW) (KJV, GW, NJB)

The BSB, CEV, NLT, GNT, and NCV do not explicitly translate the phrase “at all.” It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions.

the sexually immoral of this world: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the sexually immoral of this world here refers to unbelievers who act in sexually immoral ways. Other ways to translate it are:

people in general who are immoral (REB)

pagans who are immoral (GNT)

**5:10b
or the greedy and swindlers,**

- or are greedy/covetous and cheat others,
- are always wanting more possessions and cheat/defraud other people to get them,

the greedy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the greedy refers to people who are never satisfied with their possessions. They strongly desire more and more things for themselves.

swindlers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as swindlers refers to people who deceive others in order to get their money or possessions. For example:

who cheats (CEV)

**5:10c
or idolaters.**

- or worship idols.
- and many of them follow/obey false gods.

idolaters: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as idolaters refers to those who worship, follow, or obey any god, gods, or spirits other than God himself.

**5:10d
In that case you would have to leave this world.**

- To avoid people doing these sinful things, you would have to get out of this world.
- You cannot stay away from wicked people like these, unless you go far away from everybody in the world.

In that case you would have to leave this world: Paul was saying that in this world it is impossible to avoid associating with sinners. The BSB has started a new sentence here. The RSV follows the Greek and continues the same sentence. It says:

since then you would need to go out of the world

The GNT gives an example of another way to start a new sentence:

To avoid them you would have to get out of the world completely. (GNT)

1 Corinthians 5:11

Section 5:1–13: Paul commanded the believers to punish the immoral church member

Someone had told Paul that one of the men in the church in Corinth had been having sexual relations with his father's wife, that is, his step-mother. Paul wrote that the believers must punish this man by expelling him from the church. They should not allow this man to meet with them when they gathered to worship God together. Paul urged the Corinthians to keep away from people who called themselves believers but continually committed grave sins. The main point of this section is that the Corinthians were to judge and discipline the man within their fellowship who was sinning.

Paragraph 5:9–11

In this paragraph Paul corrected something that the Corinthians had misunderstood. In a letter he had written to them earlier, he had told them to have nothing to do with sexually immoral people. Some people in Corinth thought he meant unbelievers only. So they ignored the bad doings of a man in their own group. What Paul had meant was not to have anything to do with people who said they were Christians and yet behaved immorally.

5:11a But now I am writing you

- I will explain what I meant:
- Here is what I meant:
- What I meant when I wrote that other letter to you is this:

But now I am writing you: A literal translation of the Greek is "But now I wrote to you..." It is not clear whether Paul was referring to the letter he had written earlier, or if he was referring to what he was now writing in this letter.

1. This refers to Paul's earlier letter. for example, the GNT says:

What I meant was that... (GNT) (GNT, CEV, GW, REB, RSV, NASB, NJB, NLT)

1. The BSB translates 5:11a in this way: But now I am writing you.... This translation makes Paul refer to what he is writing here in 1 Corinthians. For example:

But in this letter I tell you (JBP) (BSB, NCV, NIV, NRSV, NET, ESV)

The KJV is not clear. The Greek could mean either one. But it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the view of the majority of commentators. Paul was probably explaining the command he had given them in his other letter. So another way to translate this is:

But now I will explain to you what I wrote.

5:11b-f

In these verse parts Paul indicated that the believers were not to associate in a friendly way with anyone who called himself a Christian but was deliberately sinning. Paul listed six kinds of serious sins as examples of the sins he was referring to. Paul was referring to anyone and everyone who might claim to be a Christian but continue to behave in these ways. So in some languages it may be natural to use plural forms. For example:

you must not associate with people who call themselves believers but behave immorally, or are greedy, or worship idols, or slander others, or get drunk, or cheat others. Do not even eat with people like this.

In some languages it may be natural to reorder these verse parts to put the two commands “you must not associate” and “do not even eat” together. See the General Comment at the end of 5:11f.

5:11b

not to associate with anyone who claims to be a brother

- Do not spend time with someone who claims/says that he is your fellow believer in Christ,
- You must not fellowship with people who say that they are Christians

not to associate with: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as associate with means to mingle freely with them, to fellowship with them, be close to them, and do things with them. See 5:9b, where the same word occurs.

anyone who claims to be a brother: Paul was referring to someone who claimed to be a brother in Christ, that is, a believer. If a literal translation would not make this clear, you may need to translate this as:

any professing Christian (JBP)

In some languages it may be natural to use a direct quote here. For example:

you must not associate with a person who says, “I follow Christ as you do”

5:11c-e

These verse parts lists six ways in which someone could sin. If a person who called himself a believer sinned in any of these ways, the other believers were not to associate with him. In your translation, consider how best to express each type of sin and how to put the expressions into a list in the most natural way. It is natural to connect each of the sins. In some languages it may be natural to use a word meaning “or” after each sin, but in other languages this may not be necessary.

The various items in the list can be translated in various ways:

- as a series of verb phrases (describing the various ways of sinning). For example:

who sin sexually, covet things, worship idols, slander others, get drunk or cheat

- as a series of nouns (identifying the type of sinner)

who are fornicators, greedy people, idol worshipers, slanderers, drunkards, swindlers

- as a series of adjectival phrases (describing people who sin in these ways).

who are sexually immoral, greedy/materialistic, idolatrous, slanderous, addicted to alcohol, or dishonest

The Greek uses nouns to identify the people (fornicators, idol worshipers, etc). The BSB uses a combination of last two forms, because this is natural in English. Use whatever type is the most natural in your language.

5:11c

but is sexually immoral or greedy,

- but yet he/she continues to commit sex/sexual sins, and is greedy for more possessions,
- but behave immorally, or want more and more things,

but is sexually immoral: A person who is sexually immoral is one who has sexual relations with someone other than his or her spouse. See note on 5:1b and 5:9, where the same word occurs.

greedy: This refers is the same word that occurs in 5:10b. See the note there.

5:11d

an idolater or a verbal abuser,

- who worships idols, or says bad things about other people,
- or pray to other gods, or insult other people.

an idolater: See note on 5:10c, where the same word occurs.

a verbal abuser: The Greek word that the BSB translates as verbal abuser means a person who insults another, abusing him with hard words. Paul used the verbal form of the same word in 4:12b (where the BSB translates it as “vilified”). See the notes there.

5:11e

a drunkard or a swindler.

- or who becomes drunk or cheats people.
- or frequently drink too much alcohol, or take other people’s things.

a drunkard: The Greek word that the BSB translates as drunkard refers to a person who often get drunk/intoxicated by drinking too much alcoholic drink such as beer, wine, or whiskey.

swindler: See 5:10b, where the same word occurs.

5:11f

With such a man do not even eat.

- I do not want you to even eat a meal with that kind of a person.
- Do not even let those people share meals with you.

With such a man do not even eat: There are two ways to understand this verse part:

1. It means that believers are not to even eat normal meals with people who claim to be Christians but are deliberately sinning.
2. It means that believers are not to allow such people who behave like this to eat communion (the Lord’s Supper) with them.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In those days, Christians often ate together when they gathered for worship. They often ate normal meals together as well as the Lord’s Supper. Probably Paul was referring to all occasions when the Christians ate together. He did not want them to allow a fellow believer who behaved in sinful ways to eat with them. He did does not want the believers to let such a person think that his bad ways were all right.

General Comment on 5:11b-f

In some languages it may be natural to reorder these verse parts by putting the verb from 11b (“do not associate with”) next to the command in 11f (“do not eat with”). For example:

^{11b}If people say they are your fellow believers,
^{11c}but they behave immorally with women or are greedy, ^{11d}or they worship false gods, or bad-mouth people, ^{11e}or if they are drunkards or swindlers, ^{11b}do not fellowship with them. ^{11f}Do not even eat with them.

1 Corinthians 5:12

Section 5:1–13: Paul commanded the believers to punish the immoral church member

Someone had told Paul that one of the men in the church in Corinth had been having sexual relations with his father’s wife, that is, his step-mother. Paul wrote that the believers must punish this man by expelling him from the church. They should not allow this man to meet with them when they gathered to worship God together. Paul urged the Corinthians to keep away from people who called themselves believers but continually committed grave sins. The main point of this section is that the Corinthians were to judge and discipline the man within their fellowship who was sinning.

Paragraph 5:12–13

Paul concluded his discussion of the incestuous man by telling the believers that they must put him out of the church.

5:12a

What business of mine is it to judge those outside the church?

- ¶ Do I have the authority to judge people who are not a part of the church? Not at all!
- ¶ It is not my responsibility to condemn people who are not believers.
- ¶ I did not tell you not to associate with unbelievers who are immoral, for it is not my/our^(incl) job to decide what to do with people who do not belong to our^(incl) group.

In Greek this verse begins with a connecting word often translated as “for” or “because” (see 5:12 in the RSV). Paul used it here to introduce the basis for his statements in 5:10 and 11. The GNT introduces this paragraph with the words:

After all (GNT)

What business of mine is it to judge those outside the church?: This is the first of two rhetorical questions. Paul used this rhetorical question to try to correct the thinking of the believers just as he did in 5:9 and 10. The expected or implied answer is “None at all.” Paul was really making a strong statement. He meant: “It is not my responsibility to judge wrongdoers who are not a part of our group.” There are two ways to translate this question here:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Why should I judge outsiders? (CEV)

- as a strong statement. For example:

It is not my business to judge those who are not part of the church. (NCV)

It is no concern of mine to judge outsiders. (NJB)

Use whichever form is more natural in your language for making a strong statement.

What business of mine is it: Paul used himself as an example of any Christian. He was not just speaking about himself personally. He meant that it is not our job as Christians to judge those who are not Christians. If translating this literally would imply that Paul was speaking only of himself and excluding other Christians, you may need to say:

What business of ours^(incl) is it

those outside the church: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as those outside the church is literally those outside. The BSB has supplied the words the church to make the meaning clear. Paul was referring to those who were not part of the church, that is, those who did not believe in Jesus.

5:12b

Are you not to judge those inside?

- But certainly you should judge the people who are a part of your church group, shouldn't you?
- But you should judge/discipline any people who belong to your church group who do the sinful things which I just mentioned.

Are you not to judge those inside?: This is a second rhetorical question. The implied answer to the question is: “Yes, it is our responsibility to judge the wrongdoers who are a part of the church.” Paul used this question to make a strong statement. He was

emphasizing that the Corinthians were supposed to judge those within the church, that is, believers. There are two ways to translate this verse part:

- with a rhetorical question. For example:

Isn't it your business to judge those who are inside? (GW)

- with a strong statement:

But you must judge the people who are part of the church. (NCV)

Use whichever form is most natural in your language for emphasizing responsibility.

1 Corinthians 5:13

Section 5:1–13: Paul commanded the believers to punish the immoral church member

Someone had told Paul that one of the men in the church in Corinth had been having sexual relations with his father's wife, that is, his step-mother. Paul wrote that the believers must punish this man by expelling him from the church. They should not allow this man to meet with them when they gathered to worship God together. Paul urged the Corinthians to keep away from people who called themselves believers but continually committed grave sins. The main point of this section is that the Corinthians were to judge and discipline the man within their fellowship who was sinning.

Paragraph 5:12–13

Paul concluded his discussion of the incestuous man by telling the believers that they must put him out of the church.

5:13a

God will judge those outside.

- As for the people who are not part of the church, God will judge them.
- God himself will judge the people who are not believers.
- You do not need to think about judging people who are not part of your church group, because God will do that.

In the Greek this verse part connects to the previous verse part with the conjunction *de*. Here it indicates a contrast between who is supposed to judge those inside the church versus who will judge those outside the church. Christians are supposed to judge those within the church and God will judge those outside the

church. See also the General Comment on 5:12b-13a. The BSB has not explicitly translated this conjunction, but the NET translates it as:

But (NET)

God will judge those outside: There is a textual problem in this verse part. Not all the Greek texts have the same form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as will judge. As a result, there are two ways to interpret the tense of this verb:

1. It is in the future tense. For example:

God will judge (GNT) (BSB, NIV, NET, NLT, NRSV, NCV, GW, GNT)

1. It is in the present tense. For example:

God judges (RSV) (KJV, NASB, ESV, RSV, CEV)

Some English versions translate in such a way that either meaning is possible. For example, the REB says, “God is their judge,” and the NJB says, “outsiders are for God to judge.” It is good for you to translate in this way. If you must choose between the two options, it is recommended that you follow option (1) and use the future tense. But there is really not much difference in meaning. Paul’s main point was not when God will judge unbelievers. Rather, his main point is this: “God, not you, is the one who will judge unbelievers.” The NEB says “God is their judge.”

General Comment on 5:12a-13a

The main point is that people in the church should be judged by the church. If someone is concerned about those outside the church, then he should know that God is the one who will judge them. Some English versions make the main point more clear by rephrasing these verse parts. For example:

¹²It isn’t my responsibility to judge outsiders, but it certainly is your job to judge those inside the church who are sinning in these ways. ¹³God will judge those on the outside (NLT)

Other English versions reorder these verses. For example:

^{12a}It is not my business to judge those who are not part of the church. ^{13a}God will judge them. ^{12b}But

you must judge the people who are part of the church (NCV)

You should translate this in a way that makes the main point clear.

There is a contrast between the pronoun “you” in 5:12b and the word “God” in 5:13a. Consider how you might indicate this contrast in your language. For example:

It is for you to judge those inside the church, but God is the judge of those outside.

5:13b

“Expel the wicked man from among you.”

- So, “Do not allow the immoral man to associate with your group.”
- As God’s book says: Tell this man who is behaving wickedly that he can no longer be part of your church group.

Expel the wicked man from among you: This is a command. Paul ordered the Corinthian believers to reject the man who had sexual relations with his stepmother. He quoted words that Moses had spoken (Deuteronomy 17:7). He did not specifically say that this was a quotation from the Scriptures, but you may wish to note this in a footnote. It is also possible to follow the GNT and make this explicit in the text:

As the scripture says, “Remove the evil person from your group.” (GNT)

Expel the wicked man: Paul meant that the Corinthians should not allow the wicked man to be part of their church. They should not let him worship with them. Paul did not mean that the Corinthian believers should physically shove or chase the man out of their meeting. If you translate this literally, be careful that people do not misunderstand it in this way.

General Comment on 5:12-13

There are four sentences in 5:12-13. The main point of these verse parts is that people in the church should be judged by the church. If someone is concerned about those outside the church, then he should know that God is the one who will judge them. Some English versions make the main point more clear by rephrasing these verse parts. For example:

¹²It isn’t my responsibility to judge outsiders, but it certainly is your responsibility to judge those inside the church who are sinning. ¹³God will judge

those on the outside; but as the Scriptures say, “You must remove the evil person from among you.” (NLT)

You may want to put the four sentences in a different order in order to finish Paul’s comments on judging unbelievers before starting his comments on judging believers. For example:

^{12a}It is not my business to judge those who are not part of the church. ^{13a}God will judge them. ^{12b}But you must judge the people who are part of the church. ^{13b}The Scripture says, “You must get rid of the evil person among you.” (NCV)

^{12a}After all, it is none of my business to judge outsiders. ^{13a}God will judge them. ^{12b}But should you not judge the members of your own fellowship? ^{13b}As the scripture says, “Remove the evil person from your group.” (GNT)

^{12a}We believers do not need to decide about people who are not fellow believers. ^{13a}God will do that. ^{12b}But you believers in Corinth should decide about the punishment of your own church members. ^{13b}So then, in the case of the man who is behaving immorally, you should remove him from your group of believers.

1 Corinthians 6:1

Section 6:1–11: Believers must not take fellow believers to court before unbelieving judges

In this section Paul discussed another problem in the church in Corinth. At least one of the believers had taken another believer to a pagan/civil court to settle a dispute. Paul told the Corinthian believers that this was unwise and harmful to the church. He taught them what they as believers should do if another believer wronged them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Believers should not go to law before unbelievers

Christians should not sue other Christians in pagan courts

Advice about lawsuits

Paragraph 6:1–6

In this paragraph Paul told the Corinthian believers how foolish they were to take disputes among themselves to be settled before unbelievers. He gave them some reasons why they should not have unbelievers judge between them. Paul used sarcasm and rhetorical questions to show the Corinthians how serious the situation in their church was. He wanted them to feel ashamed of themselves. They should settle disputes between believers themselves.

6:1a–c

This is a long rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question to show that he strongly disapproved of taking a dispute between Christians to a pagan/civil court. There are two ways of translating it:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

When any of you has a legal dispute with another, does he dare go to court before the unrighteous rather than before the saints? (NET)

- as a statement. For example:

If one of you has a grievance against another, it is quite wrong for you/him to go before the ungodly for judgment, instead of before God’s people.

When one of you has a complaint against another, you should not dare to go to court to settle the matter in front of wicked people. You should settle it in front of God’s holy people!

6:1a

If any of you has a grievance against another,

- ¶ When/If one of you has a disagreement/argument with another believer,
- ¶ When/If you^(sing/plur) have a legal problem with a fellow believer,

This verse begins a new topic in a new section. There is no special word or phrase to mark this in the Greek or the BSB. Consider if you need an introductory word or phrase here.

If any of you has a grievance against another: This clause introduces a situation that can and does happen from time to time. The Greek here is a participle phrase, as the KJV translates: “Dare any of you, having a matter against another.” It is acceptable to understand and translate it as a conditional clause, as the BSB and some other versions do. It is a potential fact conditional clause with a probable future fulfillment.

See Appendix 1, sense 2 (c). Disputes between believers will occur occasionally. It is therefore possible to translate this as:

When one of you has a grievance against a brother.... (RSV)

When you have something against another Christian.... (NCV)

a grievance: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a grievance is a general one meaning “a matter, an affair.” In this context it refers to a legal matter such as a lawsuit. Apparently at least one believer in the Corinthian church had already done something wrong to another believer. Perhaps he had cheated him or taken something that belonged to him. The second believer had gone to a court in Corinth and accused his fellow believer before the judge, who was not a believer.

6:1b

how dare he go to law before the unrighteous

- how could you/he think of asking ungodly people to judge between you?
- you should not dare/presume to go to/before a judge who is not one of God’s people.
- it is totally/absolutely wrong/shocking to take your disagreement to a public court, where the judges do not know/respect God.

how dare he go to law before the unrighteous:

These words indicate that Paul was upset/shocked by what he heard. He was implying: “A believer should not even think of taking another believer before an unbelieving judge.”

how dare he go to law: The Greek word that the BSB translates as dare means to be bold or courageous to do something beyond what people would normally expect. In this context it means to act boldly in a disrespectful or shameless way. Another way to translate it is:

he should be ashamed to take it

before the unrighteous: The Greek word that the BSB translates as unrighteous can also be translated as “ungodly.” Here it refers to people who are not believers, not members of the church. Paul was probably talking about the judges in the public courts in Corinth. These judges worked for the Roman government and did not know or respect God’s laws.

6:1c

instead of before the saints!

- Why not rather ask God’s people to judge?
- Instead, the right thing for you to do is to ask people who belong to God to decide your case.
- You should ask other believers/Christians to help make peace between you.

instead of before the saints: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as instead of before the saints is a short way of saying “he should take his dispute before the saints.”

the saints: The Greek word that the BSB translates as saints here refers to believers, Christians. Here is another way to translate this:

God’s people (GNT)

The word saints is related to the word “sanctified” that Paul used in 1:2b (see the notes there). Believers are people set apart for God’s service. They have been made holy. This word is also used in this way in Acts 9:13 and Philippians 1:1.

General Comment on 6:1a-c

In some languages it may be natural to break up this long question into two or more questions. Some Greek texts do punctuate in this way. See Thiselton p. 430. For example:

When one of you has a complaint against another, do you take your complaint to a court of sinners? Or do you take it to God’s people? (CEV)

When one of you has a complaint against another, how dare you go to court to settle the matter in front of wicked people? Why don’t you settle it in front of God’s holy people? (GW)

1 Corinthians 6:2

Section 6:1–11: Believers must not take fellow believers to court before unbelieving judges

In this section Paul discussed another problem in the church in Corinth. At least one of the believers had taken another believer to a pagan/civil court to settle a dispute. Paul told the Corinthian believers that this was unwise and harmful to the church. He taught them what they as believers should do if another believer wronged them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Believers should not go to law before unbelievers

Christians should not sue other Christians in pagan courts

Advice about lawsuits

Paragraph 6:1–6

In this paragraph Paul told the Corinthian believers how foolish they were to take disputes among themselves to be settled before unbelievers. He gave them some reasons why they should not have unbelievers judge between them. Paul used sarcasm and rhetorical questions to show the Corinthians how serious the situation in their church was. He wanted them to feel ashamed of themselves. They should settle disputes between believers themselves.

6:2–3

In verses 2 and 3, Paul gave two reasons why Christians should not ask unbelievers to judge disputes between Christians. The reason given in verse 2 is that the Christians are going to judge the world. In verse 3 the reason is that the Christians will judge the angels.

6:2a

Do you not know that the saints will judge the world?

- Have you forgotten that God's people will one day judge the people of this world?
- Remember that those who belong to God are going to judge this world.
- For you know that some day we^(incl), God's holy people, will be judges over the people of this world.

Do you not know that the saints will judge the world?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it to remind the Corinthians of something they had already heard from Paul or other Christian teachers. He was also using the rhetorical question to rebuke the Corinthians by implying that they should have remembered this teaching. There are two ways to translate this question:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Don't you know that God's people will judge the world? (CEV)

- as a statement. For example:

Surely you know that God's people will judge the world. (NCV)

the saints will judge the world: This is the reason why a believer should not take another believer to a public court. Paul was probably referring to the final judgment. God's people, those who belong to Christ, will share with Christ the work of judging the world.

the world: It is likely that the phrase the world here refers to all human beings, including people who do not know God. See, for example, Daniel 7:22; Matthew 19:28 and Luke 22:29–30; Matthew 20:21–23; 2 Timothy 2:12; Revelation 20:4–6.

6:2b

And if you are to judge the world,

- Well then, since you are going to judge the people of this world,
- And since this is the case,

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And here introduces the conclusion Paul made from what he had just said. Here is another way to translate this:

Well, then,... (GNT)

if you are to judge the world: Paul assumed that this condition was true. This was going to happen. So in some languages it may be more natural to translate this as:

since you are to judge the world

In some languages it may not be natural to repeat the phrase judge the world here. In those languages you may be able to say something like:

since this is true

you are to judge the world: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as you are to judge the world is in the passive: "the world is to be judged by you." You may translate this using either a passive or an active verb, whichever is the more natural in your language here.

6:2c

are you not competent to judge trivial cases?

- are you not able now to judge/decide your small disagreements?
- you should certainly know how to settle/resolve your own various little problems/arguments.
- when you have small disagreements/arguments among yourselves, you should be able to make peace.

are you not competent to judge trivial cases?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul was making a strong statement that implied a rebuke. He wanted the Corinthians to realize how foolish they were to ask others to settle their disagreements. They should be able to settle their own problems. There are two ways to translate this verse part:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Are you not competent to settle trivial suits? (NET)

- as a statement. For example:

you can surely judge everyday matters (similar to the CEV)

are you not competent...?: The Greek word that the BSB translates as competent means “capable” or “able.” So other ways to translate this phrase include:

aren’t you capable...? (GNT)

are you not able...? (NCV)

Don’t you know how...?

trivial cases: The Greek word that the BSB translates as trivial cases means “unimportant problems” or “very little lawsuits.” The arguments the Corinthians were having were about very insignificant things compared to the judging work that God’s people will do in the future.

1 Corinthians 6:3

Section 6:1–11: Believers must not take fellow believers to court before unbelieving judges

In this section Paul discussed another problem in the church in Corinth. At least one of the believers had taken another believer to a pagan/civil court to settle a dispute. Paul told the Corinthian believers that this was unwise and harmful to the church. He taught them what they as believers should do if another believer wronged them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Believers should not go to law before unbelievers

Christians should not sue other Christians in pagan courts

Advice about lawsuits

Paragraph 6:1–6

In this paragraph Paul told the Corinthian believers how foolish they were to take disputes among themselves to be settled before unbelievers. He gave them some reasons why they should not have unbelievers judge between them. Paul used sarcasm and rhetorical questions to show the Corinthians how serious the situation in their church was. He wanted them to feel ashamed of themselves. They should settle disputes between believers themselves.

6:3a

Do you not know that we will judge angels?

- Have you forgotten that in the future we^(incl) will even judge angels?
- Listen to this: some day we^(incl) believers will be judges over angels.
- I want to remind you that in the future we^(incl) who are God’s people will even decide about God’s angels.

Do you not know that we will judge angels?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question to introduce another reason why the Corinthians did not need outside judges to settle disputes between them. He reminded the Corinthians of something someone had taught them before: Christians will someday judge angels. He reminded them of this in order to emphasize the difference between the important things believers will judge in the future and the unimportance of the disputes they were having at that time. There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Are you not aware that we are to judge angels...? (REB)

- as a statement. For example:

You know that in the future we will judge angels. (NCV)

judge angels: Paul did not say here whether he was referring to good angels only, or bad angels only, or all angels, good and bad. So it would be good to use an expression that can cover any of those. Paul was emphasizing the high place/position God’s people will share with Christ in the kingdom of God. Believers will share in Christ’s authority over angels. You should not include in your translation any implied information

about what God's people will judge angels for. The Scriptures teach that angels, God's heavenly messengers, will answer to God for the choices they make about serving God or the devil. See, for example, 2 Peter 2:4; Jude 6; Revelation 20:10; Matthew 25:41. But Paul does not discuss this here.

6:3b

How much more the things of this life!

- So then, we^(incl) are certainly able to decide about the usual/ordinary disagreements which come up in this life!
- So surely you/we^(incl) can settle little everyday problems/arguments!

How much more the things of this life!: Paul did not write a complete sentence here. He expected the Corinthians to make a comparison in their thoughts, something like this: "Since we will some day judge angels, then how much more we can judge and settle little everyday affairs." If you need to translate this as a complete sentence, you may use:

- a statement. For example:

How much more should we^(incl) be able to judge the things of this life!

- a rhetorical question. There is some question about the correct punctuation of this verse. There is no punctuation in the earliest Greek manuscripts. The third edition of the UBS Greek New Testament notes the possibility of placing a question mark after 6:3a; the fourth edition places one only at the end of 6:3b. The translator can do what is natural in his or her language. The RSV, GNT, and NJB, like the BSB, place a question mark at the end of 6:3a. The RSV and NJB then punctuate 6:3b as a question, and the GNT punctuates it as an exclamation. Either is acceptable. For example:

Should we^(incl) not be even more capable of judging the things of this life?

the things of this life: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the things of this life refers to things connected with life here on earth, the everyday affairs of food, clothing, houses, and lands. Believers might have disagreements over money, possessions, inheritance, boundaries of fields, gardens, grazing area for animals, fishing rights, and so on. These are all things of this life. Other ways to translate this include:

the ordinary things of this life (NCV)

everyday matters (CEV)

1 Corinthians 6:4

Section 6:1–11: Believers must not take fellow believers to court before unbelieving judges

In this section Paul discussed another problem in the church in Corinth. At least one of the believers had taken another believer to a pagan/civil court to settle a dispute. Paul told the Corinthian believers that this was unwise and harmful to the church. He taught them what they as believers should do if another believer wronged them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Believers should not go to law before unbelievers

Christians should not sue other Christians in pagan courts

Advice about lawsuits

Paragraph 6:1–6

In this paragraph Paul told the Corinthian believers how foolish they were to take disputes among themselves to be settled before unbelievers. He gave them some reasons why they should not have unbelievers judge between them. Paul used sarcasm and rhetorical questions to show the Corinthians how serious the situation in their church was. He wanted them to feel ashamed of themselves. They should settle disputes between believers themselves.

6:4a

So if you need to settle everyday matters,

- Since that is true, whenever you have problems/disagreements like this,
- And so, if one believer has a problem/case to settle with another believer,

So: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as So introduces the conclusion that Paul drew from what he had told them in 6:2 and 6:3. Since his conclusion is in the form of a rhetorical question, some English versions such as the GNT do not translate this word explicitly. The RSV translates it as "then."

if you need to settle everyday matters: It is likely that such disputes would occur from time to time. So in some languages it may be more natural to translate this clause using a word meaning "when." For example:

When you have cases dealing with this life (GW)

when you have matters of this life to be judged (NJB)

whenever you have this sort of dispute

The Greek word that the BSB translates as everyday matters is more literally “things of this life,” as in 6:3b. Consider if it is natural to repeat this word/phrase here. Other ways to translate this clause include:

If such matters come up (GNT)

If...you have such cases (RSV)

If you have ordinary cases that must be judged (NCV)

matters: The Greek word that the BSB translates as matters is the same word that the BSB translates as “cases” in 6:2c. Another way to translate it is “law-suits.”

6:4b

do you appoint as judges those of no standing in the church?

- why do you choose as judges people whom believers do not esteem?
- you should not go to outside/pagan judges whom you/we^(incl) believers do not respect.

do you appoint as judges those of no standing in the church?: This sentence is difficult to interpret. It is not clear whether Paul was saying that the believers should appoint men of little account as judges, or whether he was saying that they should not. Here are the two main ways to interpret this sentence:

1. Paul was referring to the pagan judges. He was saying that the believers should not be looking to these outsiders to judge them. For example:

how can you entrust jurisdiction to outsiders with no standing in the church? (REB) (BSB, REB, NLT, probably GNT, CEV, GW, NCV, RSV, NJB, ESV)

1. Paul was referring to believers. He was saying that the church should be appointing them. For example:

set them to judge who are least esteemed in the church (KJV) (NIV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions.

Here are some other ways to translate 6:4b in accordance with interpretation (1):

You should not go to judges who are not part of the church.

Do not go to judges who do not even belong to the church.

Do not ask people whom no one in your church group respects to resolve/settle/judge your problems/disagreements.

1 Corinthians 6:5

Section 6:1–11: Believers must not take fellow believers to court before unbelieving judges

In this section Paul discussed another problem in the church in Corinth. At least one of the believers had taken another believer to a pagan/civil court to settle a dispute. Paul told the Corinthian believers that this was unwise and harmful to the church. He taught them what they as believers should do if another believer wronged them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Believers should not go to law before unbelievers

Christians should not sue other Christians in pagan courts

Advice about lawsuits

Paragraph 6:1–6

In this paragraph Paul told the Corinthian believers how foolish they were to take disputes among themselves to be settled before unbelievers. He gave them some reasons why they should not have unbelievers judge between them. Paul used sarcasm and rhetorical questions to show the Corinthians how serious the situation in their church was. He wanted them to feel ashamed of themselves. They should settle disputes between believers themselves.

6:5a

I say this to your shame.

- I write this because I want you to be/feel ashamed of taking your disagreements to ungodly judges.

- You should be ashamed that I have to talk to you like this.

I say this to your shame: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as I say this to your shame indicates that Paul wanted the Corinthians to feel ashamed. It is not clear if the word this refers back to what he had just said, or forward to what he was about to say. It is best to keep this ambiguous. Other ways to translate this include:

Shame on you! (GNT)

You should be ashamed of yourselves! (GW)

6:5b

Is there really no one among you wise enough

- Is there not even one person among you who is wise enough
- Surely there is at least one wise person in your church group

6:5c

to arbitrate between his brothers?

- to decide in a disagreement between one believer and another?
- who can settle a dispute between two believers.

6:5b-c

Is there really no one among you wise enough to arbitrate between his brothers?: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a strong statement that implies a rebuke.

Here are two ways to translate this strong statement:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Is there no one among you wise enough to settle disputes between fellow Christians? (NET)

- as a statement that implies a rebuke. For example:

Surely there is at least one wise person in your fellowship who can settle a dispute between fellow Christians. (GNT)

Translate this in the way that is most natural in your language for rebuking someone. Paul told the Corinthians that they should settle their disputes among themselves. They should not take the dispute to judges who were not believers.

1 Corinthians 6:6

Section 6:1–11: Believers must not take fellow believers to court before unbelieving judges

In this section Paul discussed another problem in the church in Corinth. At least one of the believers had taken another believer to a pagan/civil court to settle a dispute. Paul told the Corinthian believers that this was unwise and harmful to the church. He taught them what they as believers should do if another believer wronged them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Believers should not go to law before unbelievers

Christians should not sue other Christians in pagan courts

Advice about lawsuits

Paragraph 6:1–6

In this paragraph Paul told the Corinthian believers how foolish they were to take disputes among themselves to be settled before unbelievers. He gave them some reasons why they should not have unbelievers judge between them. Paul used sarcasm and rhetorical questions to show the Corinthians how serious the situation in their church was. He wanted them to feel ashamed of themselves. They should settle disputes between believers themselves.

6:6a

Instead, one brother goes to law against another,

- But instead of appointing such a person, one of you has gone to a public/government judge/court and accused another believer of doing wrong.
- But as it is, when two of you argue about a matter, one of the two goes to a judge to ask him to decide who is right.

6:6b

and this in front of unbelievers!

- And the judges whom you ask to judge/decide your case are not believers!
- Even worse, you accuse one another and argue while judges who do not believe in Jesus listen.
- You go to judges who are not believers. This is very bad/improper.

6:6a-b

Instead, one brother goes to law against another, and this in front of unbelievers!: There are several ways of understanding how this sentence should be punctuated:

- It is an exclamation. For example:

^{6a}Instead, one Christian goes to court against another ^{6b}and lets unbelievers judge the case! (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NIV, NCV, NLT)

- It is part of the rhetorical question in 6:5. For example:

^{5b}Can it be that there is no man among you wise enough to decide between members of the brotherhood, ^{6a}but brother goes to law against brother, ^{6b}and that before unbelievers? (RSV) (RSV, ESV, NASB, NJB)

- It is a separate question. For example:

Must Christian go to law with Christian—and before unbelievers at that? (REB) (REB, CEV, NET)

- It is a statement. For example:

Instead, one believer goes to court against another believer, and this happens in front of unbelievers. (GW) (KJV, GW)

Punctuate these verse parts in a way that is natural for making strong statements. In this verse, Paul strongly rebuked them because when they had disagreements among themselves, they went for trial in front of unbelievers.

one brother goes to law against another: The word brother here refers to a believer, a Christian. Here is another way to translate this:

a believer goes to court against a believer (NRSV)

goes to law against: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as goes to law against here means to take someone to court to try to cause him to be punished. Other ways to translate it include:

sue (NET)

goes to court against (GNT)

in front of unbelievers: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in front of unbelievers here indicates that the arguing believers went to have their disputes settled by judges who were not believers.

They accused one another in front of pagan judges/courts.

1 Corinthians 6:7

Section 6:1–11: Believers must not take fellow believers to court before unbelieving judges

In this section Paul discussed another problem in the church in Corinth. At least one of the believers had taken another believer to a pagan/civil court to settle a dispute. Paul told the Corinthian believers that this was unwise and harmful to the church. He taught them what they as believers should do if another believer wronged them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Believers should not go to law before unbelievers

Christians should not sue other Christians in pagan courts

Advice about lawsuits

Paragraph 6:7–8

In 6:7–8 Paul rebuked the Corinthian believers even more strongly. When a Christian opposed another Christian in court, they were both doing something wrong. In verse 7 Paul rebuked any believer who took his fellow believer to court for doing wrong to him. Then in verse 8, Paul rebuked to any believer who had done wrong to his Christian brother.

6:7a

The very fact that you have lawsuits among you means that you are thoroughly defeated already.

- ¶ You are arguing with one another in front of judges. That by itself shows that you have totally failed to live/ behave like God's people.
- ¶ Even if the judge decides you are right, in God's eyes you are wrong for taking a fellow believer to court.
- ¶ To go to law against another believer is in itself a moral failure/defeat.

The very fact that you have lawsuits among you means that you are thoroughly defeated already:

This verse part indicates that Paul totally disapproved of believers using the legal system to attack one another. He considered that in a situation like this neither party could truly be the winner. Ultimately, both lost; that is, they harmed themselves and the church. Other ways to translate this include:

The fact that you have lawsuits against each other shows that you are already defeated. (NCV)

When one of you takes another to court, all of you lose. (CEV)

In fact, to have lawsuits at all with one another is already a defeat for you. (NRSV)

lawsuits: The Greek word that the BSB translates as lawsuits is a different word from the words translated as “disputes” in 6:1a and 6:4a, but the meaning is about the same. The word Paul uses here is a more technical word for a court case or lawsuit.

you are thoroughly defeated: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as you are...defeated is more literally “is a failure for you.” Paul was saying that a lawsuit between believers is a spiritual and moral failure. Even if the person who takes his fellow believer before an ungodly judge wins the case, both he and the whole church have failed in their Christian lives. They did not let God’s Spirit guide and control how they lived.

The BSB translates this as a passive clause. There are two ways of translating it:

- with a passive verb. For example:

you have been defeated

- with an active verb. For example:

you have failed

If you must show the one who has caused the defeat or loss, you could say the devil is the one who has caused it. For example, this could be translated as:

you have been defeated by the devil.

thoroughly: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as thoroughly:

1. It goes with the verb “defeated.” For example:

The very fact that you have legal disputes among yourselves shows that you have failed completely. (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NIV, KJV, GW, CEV)

1. It goes with the word “lawsuits.” For example, the RSV says;

To have lawsuits at all with one another is defeat for you. (RSV, REB, NJB, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is supported by the majority of commentators.

6:7b-8b

In 6:7b-d Paul talked mostly to the persons in the Corinthian church who were wronged or cheated and who took their fellow believers to court. In 6:8a Paul talked to the persons who did wrong and cheated others. But in the whole passage Paul was also talking to the whole group. He wanted them all to listen to what he said and learn from it. He used the plural pronoun meaning “you.”

6:7b-c

Why not rather be wronged? Why not rather be cheated?: These are both rhetorical questions. Paul was talking mainly to those who accuse others, that is, those who took their fellow believers to court. He wanted those who accuse others to understand that, even though they had been wronged, it would have been better to not take their Christian brothers to court. Paul was using these questions to make strong statements that it was better to be wronged or cheated than to take other believers to court. There are therefore two ways of translating these verse parts:

- as rhetorical questions. For example:

Why not let yourselves be wronged? Why not let yourselves be cheated? (NCV)

- as statements. For example:

It would be better/preferable to be wronged. It would be better/preferable to be cheated.

6:7b

Why not rather be wronged?

- Why not rather suffer/accept the wrong/injustice?
- It would be better to let the other believer wrong you.
- If another Christian has done something wrong to you, do not go to a judge to accuse him. It is better to do nothing.

Why not rather be wronged?: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as be wronged means to submit to or accept/suffer injustice. This is a passive clause. There are two ways to translate it:

- with a passive verb. For example:

Would it not be better to be treated unjustly?

- with an active verb. For example:

Why not rather suffer wrong? (ESV)

Why not rather submit to wrong? (REB)

It would be better to allow your Christian brother to wrong you.

6:7c

Why not rather be cheated?

- Why not rather suffer/accept the loss?
- It would be better to let the other believer cheat/swindle you.
- Or if another Christian has taken/stolen something from you, do not go to a judge to accuse him. Just let it be that way.

Why not rather be cheated?: The Greek word that the BSB translates as be cheated refers to a situation in which someone has lost money or possessions because another person has deceived them. This is another passive clause. There are two ways to translate it:

General Comment on 6:7b-c

- with a passive verb. For example:

Why not rather be defrauded? (ESV)

- with an active verb. For example:

Would it not be better to just accept the loss?

It would be better to let your Christian brother cheat you.

In some languages it may be natural to combine these verse parts into one clause. For example:

Why not let yourself be wronged or cheated? (JBP)

It would be better to let yourselves be cheated and robbed. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 6:8

Section 6:1–11: Believers must not take fellow believers to court before unbelieving judges

In this section Paul discussed another problem in the church in Corinth. At least one of the believers had taken another believer to a pagan/civil court to settle a dispute. Paul told the Corinthian believers that this was unwise and harmful to the church. He taught them what they as believers should do if another believer wronged them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Believers should not go to law before unbelievers

Christians should not sue other Christians in pagan courts

Advice about lawsuits

Paragraph 6:7–8

In 6:7–8 Paul rebuked the Corinthian believers even more strongly. When a Christian opposed another Christian in court, they were both doing something wrong. In verse 7 Paul rebuked any believer who took his fellow believer to court for doing wrong to him. Then in verse 8, Paul rebuked to any believer who had done wrong to his Christian brother.

6:8a

Instead, you yourselves cheat and do wrong,

- But some of you have done wrong and taken things from others—
- But it is some of your group/church who have done wrong and taken/stolen something from others.

Instead, you yourselves cheat and do wrong: Paul now began to talk mostly to those who did the wrong to their fellow believers. Here Paul shifts from talking about the ones wronged to talking to the wrongdoers who commit the initial wrongs. We can tell this because of two things: First, Paul uses a strong contrast connector *alla* “but, however.” Here it means: “but on the other hand.” In the second place, he changes from passive forms of the verbs (“you are wronged...you are cheated”) in 6:7b-c to active forms of the same verbs (“you do wrong and you cheat”) in 6:8a. It is as if he turns to talk to the wrongdoer. The BSB translation gives the impression that Paul is talking here to the same person as in 6:7. But the change from passive to active verb forms does not allow that. The word *you* is emphasized in the Greek sentence. The BSB has shown

this by supplying the word yourselves. Another way to show this emphasis is by following the REB:

But instead, it is you who are wronging and defrauding. (REB)

The BSB has reversed the order of the Greek verbs meaning cheat and do wrong. You should translate them in the order that is most natural in your language.

6:8b even against your own brothers!

- yes, even from other Christians/believers!
- And the people you wronged are your fellow believers!

even against your own brothers!: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as even against your own brothers is literally “and this to brothers.” Paul was saying that some of the Corinthians believers were cheating and wronging their fellow believers. You should supply as much of this information as is natural in your language. The NIV is an example of a translation that supplies a verb here:

and you do this to your brothers (NIV)

1 Corinthians 6:9

Section 6:1–11: Believers must not take fellow believers to court before unbelieving judges

In this section Paul discussed another problem in the church in Corinth. At least one of the believers had taken another believer to a pagan/civil court to settle a dispute. Paul told the Corinthian believers that this was unwise and harmful to the church. He taught them what they as believers should do if another believer wronged them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Believers should not go to law before unbelievers

Christians should not sue other Christians in pagan courts

Advice about lawsuits

Paragraph 6:9–11

This paragraph is another basis for Paul’s appeal to the Corinthian believers not to take each other to court. The basis is that the unrighteous will not enter

God’s kingdom (verse 9). Some of the Corinthian believers had been very unrighteous in the past, but Paul reminded them that they should now live righteous lives because of what Christ has done for them (verse 11). Therefore they should no longer take each other to court.

6:9a

Do you not know that the wicked will not inherit the kingdom of God?

- ¶ Have you forgotten that evil people will not possess/receive the kingdom of God?
- ¶ Let me remind you that people who live sinful/bad lives will not be able to live in God’s kingdom.
- ¶ You know very well that wrongdoers/evildoers will not be among God’s people when he rules/reigns as king.

Do you not know that the wicked will not inherit the kingdom of God?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this question to remind the believers of something they seemed to have forgotten. See the notes on 6:2a. There are two ways to translate this verse part:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you not know that the unrighteous will not inherit the kingdom of God? (RSV)

- as a statement. For example:

Surely you know that the wicked will not possess God’s kingdom. (GNT)

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language for reminding people of something they should have known.

the wicked will not inherit the kingdom of God: This clause indicates that wicked people will not be able to possess or enjoy the benefits and blessing of living in God’s kingdom. They will not be part of that kingdom and God will not reign over them as their king. To inherit something generally means to receive it as a gift from someone who has died. But here there is no thought of someone dying. If the metaphor inherit suggests that someone must die, you may wish to translate this as:

the wicked will not possess God’s Kingdom (GNT)

those who do wrong will have no share in the Kingdom of God (NLT1)

the wicked will not enter/receive the kingdom of God

For the phrase inherit the kingdom of God, see also Matthew 25:34, 1 Corinthians 15:50, Galatians 5:21, and Ephesians 5:5.

the kingdom of God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the kingdom of God refers to God's rule over his people. Here Paul was mostly referring to the eternal blessings which God's people will enjoy in the future. You will probably want to translate kingdom of God here in a way similar to how you translated it in other parts of the NT. See, for example, Luke 14:15, Matthew 8:11–12, and Acts 14:22. Some ways to translate this are:

- As a noun. For example:

God's rule/reign

God's kingship

God's chieftaincy

God's government

- As a verbal expression:

the way God rules his people

6:9b

Do not be deceived:

- Make no mistake.
- Do not let anyone deceive you.
- Stop believing lies.

Do not be deceived: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Do not be deceived can also be translated as "Stop being deceived." It implies that there were people in the Corinthian church who said that it was all right if believers behaved in sinful ways. Paul wanted the believers to stop believing these lies.

be deceived: While the BSB and Greek are passive, in some languages it may be more natural to translate it as active. For example:

let other people deceive you

6:9c

Neither the sexually immoral,

- As for people who commit sex sins,

- Specifically, I am talking about immoral people,

the sexually immoral: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the sexually immoral is the same as in 5:1b, 5:9b, and 5:10a. It is a general word referring to all who sin by having sexual relations outside of marriage. See the notes on 5:1b and 5:9b

6:9d

nor idolaters,

- and people who worship idols,
- people who follow/obey other gods,

idolaters: The Greek word that the BSB translates as idolaters is the same as in 5:10c. It refers to all who worship any god other than the one true God. See the note on 5:10c.

6:9e

nor adulterers,

- people who commit adultery,
- people who are unfaithful to their spouses,

adulterers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as adulterers refers to married people who have sexual relations with someone other than their spouse.

6:9f

nor men who submit to or perform homosexual acts,

- men who allow other men to do sexually shameful things with them, or who do these things to other men,
- homosexuals,

men who submit to...homosexual acts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as men who submit to...homosexual acts literally means "soft" or "effeminate." It probably refers to those males who were the passive partners in homosexual activity, that is, men who allowed themselves to be treated like women.

men who...perform homosexual acts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as men who...perform homosexual acts probably means "males having sex with males." In other places this word is often translated as "homosexuals" or "sodomites" (named for the people of Sodom; see Genesis 19). It is possible that in this context it refers to the active partner in a homosexual relationship, that is, men who treated other males as though they were women.

General Comment on 6:9f

In translating this verse part, it is important to use words or phrases that are suitable for public worship. Consider whether some euphemism may be natural.

In some languages it may be natural to combine the two groups into one: “homosexuals.”

1 Corinthians 6:10

Section 6:1–11: Believers must not take fellow believers to court before unbelieving judges

In this section Paul discussed another problem in the church in Corinth. At least one of the believers had taken another believer to a pagan/civil court to settle a dispute. Paul told the Corinthian believers that this was unwise and harmful to the church. He taught them what they as believers should do if another believer wronged them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Believers should not go to law before unbelievers

Christians should not sue other Christians in pagan courts

Advice about lawsuits

Paragraph 6:9–11

This paragraph is another basis for Paul’s appeal to the Corinthian believers not to take each other to court. The basis is that the unrighteous will not enter God’s kingdom (verse 9). Some of the Corinthian believers had been very unrighteous in the past, but Paul reminded them that they should now live righteous lives because of what Christ has done for them (verse 11). Therefore they should no longer take each other to court.

6:10a nor thieves,

- people who steal things,
- people who take other people’s things,

thieves: The Greek word that the BSB translates as thieves refers in general to people who steal from others. It is usually used of people who sneak into others’ houses and take their things without permission. It does not refer to people who violently attack others and forcibly take their things (“robbers”; see 6:10e).

6:10b nor the greedy,

- people who want more and more things,
- people who strongly desire more things than they need,

the greedy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as greedy is the same word as in 5:10b. It refers to people who are never satisfied with their possessions. They strongly desire more and more things for themselves.

6:10c nor drunkards,

- people who often get drunk/intoxicated,
- people who frequently drink too much alcohol,

drunkards: The Greek word that the BSB translates as drunkards is the same word as in 5:11g. It refers to people who often get drunk/intoxicated by drinking too much alcoholic drink.

6:10d nor verbal abusers,

- people who abuse/revile others,
- people who insult others,

verbal abusers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as verbal abusers refers to people who insult others and speak harsh, abusive words to them. It is the same word as in 5:11f. See also the note on “vili-fied” at 4:12b. Another way to translate it is:

anyone who curses...others (CEV)

6:10e nor swindlers,

- and people who cheat others—
- people who deceive others in order to take their things.

swindlers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as swindlers refers to people who deceive others in order to take their money or possessions. It is the same word as in 5:10b and 5:11h. Here is another way to translate this:

who cheats (CEV)

6:10f will inherit the kingdom of God.

- these people will not receive/inhabit the kingdom of God.
- None of the people who do those things will have a part/share in the kingdom of God.

will inherit the kingdom of God: See 6:9a and the notes on 6:9a.

1 Corinthians 6:11

Section 6:1–11: Believers must not take fellow believers to court before unbelieving judges

In this section Paul discussed another problem in the church in Corinth. At least one of the believers had taken another believer to a pagan/civil court to settle a dispute. Paul told the Corinthian believers that this was unwise and harmful to the church. He taught them what they as believers should do if another believer wronged them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Believers should not go to law before unbelievers

Christians should not sue other Christians in pagan courts

Advice about lawsuits

Paragraph 6:9–11

This paragraph is another basis for Paul's appeal to the Corinthian believers not to take each other to court. The basis is that the unrighteous will not enter God's kingdom (verse 9). Some of the Corinthian believers had been very unrighteous in the past, but Paul reminded them that they should now live righteous lives because of what Christ has done for them (verse 11). Therefore they should no longer take each other to court.

6:11a

And that is what some of you were.

- And this is what some of you used to be.
- It is true, some of you used to live/ behave like that.

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces the concluding part or stage of Paul's argument. Many English versions do not explicitly translate this conjunction. Consider how in your language it is natural to introduce the next part of Paul's argument.

that is what some of you were: This clause indicates that before they became believers in Jesus some of the Corinthian believers used to sin in the ways just mentioned. God had made them his own people, and so now they should behave differently. Other ways to translate this include:

Some of you used to be like that. (CEV)

In the past, some of you were like that. (NCV)

6:11b–d

But: In the Greek text the word But occurs three times, once in each verse part. This gives emphasis to the contrast with the previous verse part. The NASB follows the structure of the Greek:

but you were washed, but you were sanctified, but you were justified.... (NASB)

The BSB translates this word once only, as this is more natural in English. You should consider if it is natural to repeat this word in your language.

you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified: These three verbs are all in the past tense. Paul was talking about what happened to the Corinthian believers when they first believed in Jesus. All three verbs are passives. The implied agent in each case is God. He is the one who washed, sanctified, and justified the Corinthians. So there are two ways to translate these verse parts:

- using passive verbs. For example:

your sins have been washed away, and you have been set apart for God. You have been made right with God. (NLT)

you were washed clean. You were made holy, and you were made right with God (NCV)

- using active verbs. For example:

God washed you, sanctified you, and justified you.

6:11b

But you were washed,

- But you have been washed/cleansed/purified,
- But you are no longer like that. Now God has taken away your sin,
- But now you no longer do those things because God has made you clean on the inside,

you were washed: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as you were washed is a metaphor. It refers to God cleansing a believer from sin.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

you have been washed clean (REB)

you have been purified from sin (GNT)

God has made you pure/clean by taking away your sins.

6:11c

you were sanctified,

- you have been made holy/pure,
- he has made you one of his holy people,
- and he has caused you to belong completely to himself,

you were sanctified: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sanctified means “made holy,” or “set apart for God,” that is, made part of God’s own holy people. It is the same word that Paul used in 1:2b. See the note on 1:2b. Some other ways to translate this are:

you have been dedicated to God (GNT)

You were made holy (NCV)

you have been set apart for God (NLT)

6:11d

you were justified,

- and you have been made/put right with God.
- and he has made you just/upright/acceptable in his sight.
- and he has taken away your guilt.

you were justified: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as you were justified means “you were made right.” To justify someone is to declare them not guilty. In this context Paul was saying that God had declared the believers not guilty. God had put them right with himself. See also, for example, Romans 3:24, 3:26, 3:28, 5:1, and Galatians 2:16. Other ways to translate this include:

you have been put right with God (GNT)

made...acceptable to God (CEV)

6:11e

in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ

- God did that by means of the Lord Jesus Christ,
- The Lord Jesus Christ made all that possible.
- God did this through the Lord Jesus Christ,

6:11f

and by the Spirit of our God.

- and he did it by means of his Spirit.

- and he did that by sending his Spirit to work powerfully in you.
- and through his Holy Spirit.

6:11e-f

in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God: These two phrases are related to all three verbs in 6:11b-d. That is, God washed us, sanctified us, and justified us, and he did it all in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God.

in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ: There are several ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ. Here are some ways that different scholars have suggested to reword 6:11e: “by the power of the Lord Jesus Christ,” “because of our union with the Lord Jesus Christ,” “on the authority of the Lord Jesus Christ,” and “in the domain where the Lord Jesus Christ rules.” See Ellington and Hatton. The two main ways to understand this are:

1. God washed, sanctified, and justified us by means of the Lord Jesus Christ. Jesus was the instrument or agent that God used to save us. For example, this could be translated as:

through the name of the Lord Jesus Christ

1. God washed, sanctified, and justified us because of the Lord Jesus Christ. In other words, it was because of what Jesus did for us that God was able to save us. For example:

because of what the Lord Jesus Christ and the Spirit of our God have done for you (NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), since it has stronger translation and commentary support. Also, interpretation (1) is probably closer to Paul’s meaning, since it fits in better with 6:11f (“by the Spirit of our God”).

the Lord Jesus Christ: There is a textual problem here.

1. Some Greek manuscripts say the Lord Jesus Christ. For example:

in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ (NCV) (BSB, NCV, CEV, NASB, RSV, GNT, NJB, NET, ESV, NLT, GW)

1. Some Greek manuscripts say the Lord Jesus. For example:

through the name of the Lord Jesus (REB) (REB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with the majority of English versions.

by the Spirit of our God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as by the Spirit of our God here probably means “you were washed...by means of the Spirit of our God.” God washed, sanctified, and justified us by means of the power of the Holy Spirit.

the Spirit of our God: This means the Holy Spirit. In some languages it is not normal to say our God. In those languages it is better to translate this phrase some other way, for example: “the God whom we worship.” The entire phrase, the Spirit of our God, can be translated “the Holy Spirit who is from our God,” or “the Spirit whom our God sent/gave to us.”

General Comment on 6:11b-f

Since God is the implied agent of the verbs in 6:11b-d, you may want to use the phrase “our God” as the subject in 6:11b. For example:

^{11a}Some of you used to behave in those evil ways.

^{11b}But our God washed you clean. ^{11c}He made you his own holy people ^{11d}and freed you from your sins. ^{11e}He did all this through the Lord Jesus Christ ^{11f}and the power of his own Spirit.

Notice in this translation that the words “our God” are in 6:11b, and in 6:11f it says “his own Spirit.” The “his” in 6:11f refers back to “our God” in 6:11b rather than to the Lord Jesus Christ. It is in order to make this clear that the word “own” has been supplied.

1 Corinthians 6:12

Section 6:12–20: Believers must live pure lives because they belong to the Lord

In 6:12–20 Paul talked about another problem in the church in Corinth. He had heard that some people in Corinth were behaving immorally. It appears that some of the Christians there were saying that it was all right for them to live as they pleased, because God would save and forgive them. They were saying that it did not matter what they did with their bodies. Paul said that they were wrong. In this section he told them why as believers they should honor God in everything they did.

Paragraph 6:12–17

In this paragraph Paul wrote that it is wrong for Christians to behave immorally, that is, to disobey God’s laws about sex. It seems some believers in Corinth had

misunderstood what Paul had taught them. Paul had taught that a believer does not have to obey Jewish rules and rituals in order to become acceptable to God. But the Corinthians thought that since Christians do not have to keep the Jewish law, they could do whatever they wanted. Paul said that immoral behavior is wrong because our bodies belong to the Lord and he sent his Spirit to live in our bodies.

6:12a

“Everything is permissible for me,”

- ¶ Someone has said: “I am permitted to do anything.”
- ¶ It has been said: “I am allowed to do whatever I want.”
- ¶ Some of you like to quote this teaching/saying: “We^(incl) can do/be anything we choose.”

Everything is permissible for me: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Everything is permissible for me is more literally “everything is allowed to me,” that is, nothing is forbidden or against the law. The speaker was claiming that he or she was permitted to do anything. In most English versions these words are put in quote marks. These quote marks are not in the Greek text, and the KJV, NASB, and JBP do not include them. It is not clear whether Paul was quoting his own teaching or what someone else had said. Perhaps the people in Corinth wrote these words to Paul in a letter they sent to him. Or perhaps Paul had heard that some people in Corinth had said this. In your translation, you may need to supply a speaker as subject. Try to make this as general as possible. For example:

Someone will say, “I am allowed to do anything.” (GNT)

Some of you say, “Everything is permissible for me.”

“I am free to do anything,” you say. (REB)

Here the first-person pronoun “I” (me in the BSB) refers to any Christian, so in some languages it will be clearer to say “we” or “we believers.” For example:

Some of you say, “We can do anything we want to.” (CEV)

6:12b

but not everything is beneficial.

- Some things, however, are not useful/helpful.

- Well, yes. But that does not mean that everything is good/helpful for you/us^(incl).
- In one sense that may be true, but some things have no value/profit/advantage.

but not everything is beneficial: These words are Paul's own words. They are not part of the quotation. Paul was indicating that the truth of the saying in 6:12a was limited or partial. It is true that Christians do not have to keep the ceremonial laws that God gave to the Jewish people. But this is not an excuse to sin. In Romans 6:1 and 6:15, Paul wrote something that is similar to what he wrote here in 1 Corinthians 6:12: "Shall we continue in sin so that grace may increase?" (Romans 6:1) and "Shall we sin because we are not under law, but under grace?" (Romans 6:15). Paul said that God saves us because of his grace, that is, he saves us freely, because he wants to. We do not have to earn or buy salvation by keeping laws. So some people wanted to know "Since God graciously forgives our sins and because we don't have to keep any laws to be saved, does that mean that we can keep on sinning?" In both Romans 6:2 and 6:15 Paul answers this question "Certainly not!" This is the same expression that the BSB translates "Never!" in 1 Corinthians 6:15b. Consider how it is natural in your language to accept a saying with caution or hesitation and to introduce limits to its meaning or application. Some ways to do this in English are:

Yes, but... (GNT)

Be that as it may...

Granted, but...

not everything is beneficial: The Greek word that the BSB translates as beneficial can also be translated as "helpful." Paul did not say whether he meant helpful to oneself or to others. He may well have been thinking of both things, and it is recommended that you translate this in a general way, as do most English versions. The context suggests that Paul was probably thinking primarily of one's own spiritual benefit. So if you cannot keep this general, you may wish to say:

not everything is good for you (GNT)

not everything is good for us (CEV)

6:12c

"Everything is permissible for me,"

- "I am permitted to do anything," yes,
- Someone has said: "I am allowed to do whatever I want,"
- You say that we^(incl) are free to do anything we want/choose to do,

Everything is permissible for me: These are the same words as in 6:12a. Paul repeated this saying or quotation here. Some English versions do not put the words in quote marks this second time. If it is unnatural in your language to repeat the quotation exactly, you may be able to follow one of these models:

True, for me everything is permissible. (NJB)

No doubt I am free to do anything. (REB)

I could say that I am allowed to do anything. (GNT)

6:12d

but I will not be mastered by anything.

- but I will not let anything be my boss/master.
- but I will not become a slave to anything.
- but I refuse to allow anything to control me.

but I will not be mastered by anything: This is a response to the quotation in 6:12c. The pronoun I in this sentence probably refers to Paul himself. He was indicating that while in one sense it was true that he was permitted to do anything, he chose not to do everything. He did not want to do anything that would control him.

I will not be mastered by anything: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as I will not be mastered here indicates Paul's determination not to allow anything to have control of his life. He refused to let this happen. This is a passive clause. There are two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

I will not be controlled by anything. (NET)

- using an active verb. For example:

I must not become a slave to anything. (NLT)

I won't allow anything to gain control over my life. (GW)

I refuse to let anything have power over me. (CEV)

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language in this context.

1 Corinthians 6:13

Section 6:12–20: Believers must live pure lives because they belong to the Lord

In 6:12–20 Paul talked about another problem in the church in Corinth. He had heard that some people in Corinth were behaving immorally. It appears that some of the Christians there were saying that it was all right for them to live as they pleased, because God would save and forgive them. They were saying that it did not matter what they did with their bodies. Paul said that they were wrong. In this section he told them why as believers they should honor God in everything they did.

Paragraph 6:12–17

In this paragraph Paul wrote that it is wrong for Christians to behave immorally, that is, to disobey God's laws about sex. It seems some believers in Corinth had misunderstood what Paul had taught them. Paul had taught that a believer does not have to obey Jewish rules and rituals in order to become acceptable to God. But the Corinthians thought that since Christians do not have to keep the Jewish law, they could do whatever they wanted. Paul said that immoral behavior is wrong because our bodies belong to the Lord and he sent his Spirit to live in our bodies.

6:13a

“Food for the stomach and the stomach for food,”

- Some are saying: “Things to eat exist only for the stomach. And the stomach exists only for the foods we^(incl) eat.”
- But maybe someone will say: “God made food for our stomachs, and he made our^(incl) stomachs to desire food.”
- Some of you say, “Our^(incl) bodies want food, and food is there for us to eat.”

Food for the stomach and the stomach for food:

These words are in quote marks in the BSB. However, some English versions do not use quotation marks here. The two interpretations are:

1. This is a quotation. For example:

Someone else will say, “Food is for the stomach, and the stomach is for food.” (GNT) (BSB, NIV, NET, GNT, RSV, NLT, REB, ESV, CEV, NCV)

1. This is a simple statement, not a quotation. For example:

Foods are for the stomach, and the stomach is for foods. (NJB) (NJB, KJV, NASB, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions. Some people may have used this saying to argue that sexual intercourse outside of marriage is not wrong. They meant: “Eating is just a physical activity. We do it because our body desires food. Sex is the same way: it is just physical, and we do it because our body desires it. It is not sinful.”

In many languages it may be natural to supply verbs in this verse part. For example:

Food is for the stomach and the stomach is for food. (NET)

Food was meant for the stomach and the stomach for food. (JBP)

the stomach: The Greek word that the BSB translates as stomach refers to the inner parts of the body that digest food. It includes both the stomach and the intestines. Since it refers to any and every human stomach, in some languages it may be natural to use the plural: “stomachs.”

Here Paul used this word to stand for our body's need for food. In some languages it is more natural to translate this verse without using the word for stomach. For example:

Food is good for our bodies, and our bodies need food.

6:13b

but God will destroy them both.

- But I say: but one day God will do away with both stomachs and food.
- My answer to that is this: I agree, but in the future he will change things so that we^(incl) will not have stomachs and we will not need food.
- Granted, and/but in the future life God will bring an end to these stomachs and their food.

but God will destroy them both: Paul agreed with the statement in 6:13a, but he wanted to correct or limit the way the Corinthians applied it. Here is another way to translate this:

True, and one day God will put an end to both. (REB)

Paul did not say whether he was thinking of the time when we will die or the time when God will give us new bodies. Try to translate this in a general way. In the future God will bring to an end our present way of life. Then we will no longer need food or our stomach.

destroy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as destroy means to abolish or set something aside. Paul knew that God will abolish our present earthly bodies that need food. He will change our bodies (1 Corinthians 15:51–53; Philippians 3:21). The new body God will give us will not need food as our earthly bodies do.

6:13c

The body is not intended for sexual immorality,

- Our^(incl) bodies are not made/intended for sexual sin
- God did not make our^(incl) bodies so we can behave in immoral/promiscuous ways.
- But it is wrong to use our^(incl) body/bodies to have sex with someone we are not married to.

In Greek this sentence begins with a connecting word that is often translated as “but” (as in the NJB). In this context it introduces the contrast between what Paul had said before and what he is going to say now. The stomach is made for food but the body is not meant for sexual immorality. Introduce this sentence in a way that is natural in your language.

The body is not intended for sexual immorality:

This clause part indicates that God did not make the human physical body so that people could behave immorally. That is not its purpose. Since Paul was referring to any and every human body, in some languages it may be more natural to use the plural. For example:

But our bodies were not made for sexual immorality. (NLT)

We are not supposed to do indecent things with our bodies. (CEV)

6:13d

but for the Lord,

- but for serving the Lord,
- Rather, God made our^(incl) bodies to serve the Lord Jesus,
- No, we should use our^(incl) body to work for the Lord

but for the Lord: These words are not a complete sentence. In your translation you may need to make this a complete sentence. For example:

But the body is meant/made for the Lord.

Paul probably meant that God made our bodies so that we could serve the Lord Jesus. We can honor and serve the Lord with our physical human bodies here on earth. After the Lord returns, we will be able to honor and serve him with the new bodies he will give us. Compare 1 Corinthians 15:50–54.

6:13e

and the Lord for the body.

- and the Lord is concerned for our^(incl) bodies.
- and the Lord cares about our^(incl) bodies.
- as the Lord works to help our^(incl) body.

the Lord for the body: This also is not a complete sentence. The Lord is for the body in the sense that he cares about our physical bodies and provides for them. One day he will raise them from the dead. If you need to translate this as a complete sentence, you may be able to say:

the Lord provides for the body (GNT)

the Lord cares about our bodies (NLT)

General Comment on 6:14c–e

In the Greek these verse parts do not have any explicit verbs. There are various verbs that can be supplied in one or more of the verse parts.

Here are some English versions that use different verbs:

But the body is not for fornication; it is for the Lord—and the Lord is for the body. (REB)

We are not supposed to do indecent things with our bodies. We are to use them for the Lord who is in charge of our bodies. (CEV)

The body is not to be used for sexual immorality, but to serve the Lord; and the Lord provides for the body. (GNT)

But our bodies were not made for sexual immorality. They were made for the Lord, and the Lord cares about our bodies. (NLT)

1 Corinthians 6:14

Section 6:12–20: Believers must live pure lives because they belong to the Lord

In 6:12–20 Paul talked about another problem in the church in Corinth. He had heard that some people in Corinth were behaving immorally. It appears that some of the Christians there were saying that it was all right for them to live as they pleased, because God would save and forgive them. They were saying that it did not matter what they did with their bodies. Paul said that they were wrong. In this section he told them why as believers they should honor God in everything they did.

Paragraph 6:12–17

In this paragraph Paul wrote that it is wrong for Christians to behave immorally, that is, to disobey God's laws about sex. It seems some believers in Corinth had misunderstood what Paul had taught them. Paul had taught that a believer does not have to obey Jewish rules and rituals in order to become acceptable to God. But the Corinthians thought that since Christians do not have to keep the Jewish law, they could do whatever they wanted. Paul said that immoral behavior is wrong because our bodies belong to the Lord and he sent his Spirit to live in our bodies.

6:14a

By His power God raised the Lord from the dead,

- Just as God in/through his power raised the Lord from death,
- God worked powerfully to cause the Lord Jesus to live again after he died,

6:14b

and He will raise us also.

- so also he will raise us^(incl) from the dead.
- and some day God will work/act in power to make us^(incl) alive again also.
- and he is strong/powerful/mighty and he will also cause us^(incl) to live again after we die.

6:14a-b

In the Greek this verse connects to the previous verse part with a common conjunction. The BSB and GNT do not translate it, but the RSV translates it as "And." Introduce this next step in Paul's argument in a way that is natural in your language.

By His power God raised the Lord from the dead, and He will raise us also: Paul said this in order to show that our physical bodies are important to God. He did not want the Corinthians to think that what they did with their bodies did not matter. God will bring our bodies back to life some day and make them new and glorious, just as he did to Jesus' body. He will

do this by his power, just as he worked powerfully to raise Christ. Other ways to translate this include:

God will raise us from death by the same power that he used when he raised our Lord to life. (CEV)

And God raised the Lord and will also raise us up by his power (ESV)

By His power: The phrase By His power indicates that God worked powerfully. In some languages it may be natural to translate the noun power as an adjective:

God is strong/powerful and he....

The/Our powerful/mighty God

General Comment on 6:14a-b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 6:14a-b. For example:

^{14b}And God will raise our bodies from the dead by his marvelous power, ^{14a}just as he raised our Lord from the dead. (NLT)

^{14b}And God is powerful enough to raise our^(incl) bodies from the dead, ^{14a}in the same way that he raised our Lord from the dead.

1 Corinthians 6:15

Section 6:12–20: Believers must live pure lives because they belong to the Lord

In 6:12–20 Paul talked about another problem in the church in Corinth. He had heard that some people in Corinth were behaving immorally. It appears that some of the Christians there were saying that it was all right for them to live as they pleased, because God would save and forgive them. They were saying that it did not matter what they did with their bodies. Paul said that they were wrong. In this section he told them why as believers they should honor God in everything they did.

Paragraph 6:12–17

In this paragraph Paul wrote that it is wrong for Christians to behave immorally, that is, to disobey God's laws about sex. It seems some believers in Corinth had misunderstood what Paul had taught them. Paul had taught that a believer does not have to obey Jewish rules and rituals in order to become acceptable to God. But the Corinthians thought that since Christians do

not have to keep the Jewish law, they could do whatever they wanted. Paul said that immoral behavior is wrong because our bodies belong to the Lord and he sent his Spirit to live in our bodies.

6:15a

Do you not know that your bodies are members of Christ?

- Do you not know that your bodies are parts of Christ himself?
- You surely remember/know that your bodies are like parts/components of Christ's body.
- When you think/say that behaving immorally is all right, you show that you have forgotten that your bodies are like limbs and organs of the body of Christ.

Do you not know that your bodies are members of Christ?: This is the first of several rhetorical questions. Paul used this question to remind the believers of an important teaching they had forgotten or were ignoring. There are two ways to translate this verse part:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Do I need to remind you that your bodies are members of Christ?

- as a statement. For example:

Surely you know that your bodies are parts of Christ himself. (NCV)

You should translate this verse part in a way that is natural for reminding people of something they seemed to have forgotten.

your bodies are members of Christ: This is a metaphor. The picture is that of various body parts together forming Christ's body. This illustrates how believers are united with Christ. Not just our soul (inner being) is joined to Christ, but our whole person, including our body, belongs to Christ. Other ways of translating this include:

your bodies are part of the body of Christ (CEV)

your bodies are limbs and organs of Christ (REB)

your bodies: In the Greek culture of Paul's time, people thought that the inner part of a person, his spirit, went on living somewhere after he died, but that a person's body finished and came to nothing. They thought that there was no resurrection of

the body (compare Matthew 22:23). Paul used the metaphor about being members of Christ to show that a believer's body is significant. A believer must not use his body to do anything sinful. A believer is responsible to Christ for what he does with his body.

6:15b

Shall I then take the members of Christ and unite them with a prostitute? Never!

- So should I take this body, a part of Christ, and make it one with a prostitute? Absolutely not!
- So then, because my body is joined together with Christ, it is not proper/right for me to join it to a prostitute's body! I should never think of such a thing!
- Since our bodies are joined to Christ, it is unthinkable that we should unite them to prostitutes!

Shall I then take the members of Christ and unite them with a prostitute?: This is also a rhetorical question. Paul himself went on to provide the question to this question: "Never!" There are two ways of translating this verse part:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Should I take the members of Christ and make them members of a prostitute? (NET)

- as a statement. For example:

It is not right/proper for me to take my body and join it to a prostitute's body.

So I must never take the parts of Christ and join them to a prostitute! (NCV)

Translate this in a way that is strong/emphatic to show Paul's strong emotion.

Shall I then take: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Shall I...take here means "Should I...take." Paul means that he should not do this, and nor should anyone else. This is a general principle. What Paul said here is true of anyone who is a believer. In some languages it may be better to use a different subject, such as "we" or "any Christian." For example:

Should we^(incl) take...

Should a believer take...

take the members of Christ and unite them with a prostitute: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as take means “to remove, take away.” Paul was saying that when a believer has sex with a prostitute, it is as though he has taken his body away from Christ and joined it to a prostitute instead. A person cannot be joined together with Christ and with a prostitute at the same time. It is either one or the other.

the members of Christ: When Paul says members of Christ here, he is referring to the bodies of believers. In some languages it may be helpful to make this explicit:

our ^(incl) bodies, which are united to Christ,

prostitute: The Greek word that the BSB translates as prostitute refers to a woman who makes a living by having sex with various men she is not married to. Be careful to use a word that is polite enough that people can read your translation aloud in church without being embarrassed. If in your language and culture there is no word for prostitute, you may need to substitute a more general term for an immoral woman. In 6:15b and 6:16a Paul was talking primarily to the Christian men in Corinth. He said it was wrong for a Christian man to have sex with a prostitute. He did not say anything about what is right or wrong for Christian women. But what Paul said about sexual immorality (6:13c, 6:18a), about our bodies belonging to the Lord (6:13d-e, 6:15a), and about our bodies being a temple of the Holy Spirit (6:19–20), is true of both men and women believers.

Never!: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Never! is very strong. It means “May it never be!” or “Don’t even think of such a thing!” Other ways to translate it include:

That’s unthinkable! (GW)

Out of the question! (NJB)

1 Corinthians 6:16

Section 6:12–20: Believers must live pure lives because they belong to the Lord

In 6:12–20 Paul talked about another problem in the church in Corinth. He had heard that some people in Corinth were behaving immorally. It appears that some of the Christians there were saying that it was all right for them to live as they pleased, because God would save and forgive them. They were saying that it did not matter what they did with their bodies. Paul said that they were wrong. In this section he told them

why as believers they should honor God in everything they did.

Paragraph 6:12–17

In this paragraph Paul wrote that it is wrong for Christians to behave immorally, that is, to disobey God’s laws about sex. It seems some believers in Corinth had misunderstood what Paul had taught them. Paul had taught that a believer does not have to obey Jewish rules and rituals in order to become acceptable to God. But the Corinthians thought that since Christians do not have to keep the Jewish law, they could do whatever they wanted. Paul said that immoral behavior is wrong because our bodies belong to the Lord and he sent his Spirit to live in our bodies.

6:16a

Or don’t you know that he who unites himself with a prostitute is one with her in body?

- Do you not know that when you join yourself to a prostitute, you unite your body with hers?
- You must/surely know that when a person has sex with an immoral person, the two of them become one person/body.
- Do not forget that when a man has relations with a prostitute, he and the prostitute have become like one person.

Or: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Or often occurs before a rhetorical question. It implies that the following sentence will support what Paul said in 6:15. Here this word is not used to indicate a choice between two options. It is perhaps for that reason that some English versions omit this word.

don’t you know: This is another rhetorical question. Paul used this question to make the Corinthians feel ashamed for not remembering important things and thinking like unbelievers. There are two ways to translate this verse part:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Don’t you realize that the person who unites himself with a prostitute becomes one body with her? (GW)

- as a statement. For example:

So you should know that anyone who joins with a prostitute becomes one body with the prostitute. (NCV)

You surely know that anyone who joins himself to a prostitute becomes physically one with her (REB)

he who unites himself with a prostitute is one with her in body: The Greek word that the BSB translates as unites himself means “associates oneself in a very close way.” Here it refers to joining oneself to another in a very close way as a sexual partner.

is one with her in body: This is referring to the physical unity of the sex act. When a man and woman join themselves together sexually, in one sense they become like one person.

6:16b

For it is said,

- This is written in God’s Book:
- I say that because the Scriptures say:

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For here introduces an explanation of the previous verse part.

it is said: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as it is said here introduces a quotation from Genesis 2:24. Other ways to translate it include:

the Scriptures say (NLT)

it is written

6:16c

“The two will become one flesh.”

- “The two people will become like one person/body.”
- “The man and woman will unite and become as one.”

The two will become one flesh: This is a quotation from Genesis 2:24. Paul quoted from this verse in order to explain what he had just said about a man becoming like one person with the prostitute. When God made man and woman, he told them: “a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife and they will become one flesh” (Genesis 2:24).

Genesis 2:24 is also quoted in Matthew 19:5, Mark 10:7–8, and Ephesians 5:31. You will probably want to translate it here in a way similar to the way you translated it in those places. Other possible translation models include:

The two will become one body. (NCV)

The two are united into one. (NLT)

The two of them will be like one person. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 6:17

Section 6:12–20: Believers must live pure lives because they belong to the Lord

In 6:12–20 Paul talked about another problem in the church in Corinth. He had heard that some people in Corinth were behaving immorally. It appears that some of the Christians there were saying that it was all right for them to live as they pleased, because God would save and forgive them. They were saying that it did not matter what they did with their bodies. Paul said that they were wrong. In this section he told them why as believers they should honor God in everything they did.

Paragraph 6:12–17

In this paragraph Paul wrote that it is wrong for Christians to behave immorally, that is, to disobey God’s laws about sex. It seems some believers in Corinth had misunderstood what Paul had taught them. Paul had taught that a believer does not have to obey Jewish rules and rituals in order to become acceptable to God. But the Corinthians thought that since Christians do not have to keep the Jewish law, they could do whatever they wanted. Paul said that immoral behavior is wrong because our bodies belong to the Lord and he sent his Spirit to live in our bodies.

6:17

But he who unites himself with the Lord is one with Him in spirit.

- But whoever has united himself to the Lord is one with him in his spirit.
- But when someone joins himself to the Lord, his spirit and the Lord’s Spirit become one.
- But people who believe in the Lord Jesus are united/connected to the Lord in their hearts/spirits.

he who unites himself with the Lord is one with Him in spirit: The Greek word that the BSB translates as unites himself is the same word as in 6:16a and again means “associates oneself in a very close way.” Paul was comparing and contrasting a believer’s sexual union with a prostitute, and his spiritual union with Christ. He was saying that since a believer’s spirit is already joined to the Lord, it would be very wrong to join his body to a prostitute.

There is a contrast between 6:16a and 6:17. The verse parts in between (6:16b–c) are parenthetical. In some languages it may be natural to reorder the clauses in these verse parts so that the contrasting verse parts come immediately next to one another. For example:

General Comment on 6:16–17

There is a contrast between 6:16a and 6:17. The verse parts in between (6:16b–c) are parenthetical. In some languages it may be natural to reorder the clauses in these verse parts so that the contrasting verse parts come immediately next to one another. For example:

^{16b}It is written in the Scriptures, ^{16c}“The two will become one body.” ^{16a}So you should know that anyone who joins with a prostitute becomes one body with the prostitute. ¹⁷But the one who joins with the Lord is one spirit with the Lord. (NCV)

1 Corinthians 6:18

Section 6:12–20: Believers must live pure lives because they belong to the Lord

In 6:12–20 Paul talked about another problem in the church in Corinth. He had heard that some people in Corinth were behaving immorally. It appears that some of the Christians there were saying that it was all right for them to live as they pleased, because God would save and forgive them. They were saying that it did not matter what they did with their bodies. Paul said that they were wrong. In this section he told them why as believers they should honor God in everything they did.

Paragraph 6:18–20

Paul again commanded the believers not to behave in sexually immoral ways. Then he gave more reasons for this command: A person ruins his body as the Holy Spirit’s living place if he takes part in sexual immorality. God bought our bodies by paying a big price for them. So our bodies belong to him, and we must honor him by using our bodies in right ways.

6:18a

Flee from sexual immorality.

- ¶ Be very careful that you do not behave immorally.
- ¶ Have nothing at all to do with sexually bad ways.
- ¶ Absolutely do not have sex with anyone except your spouse.

Flee from sexual immorality: This is a strongly worded command. Paul told them to avoid all connection with sexually bad behavior. The Greek word that the BSB translates as sexual immorality is the same word as in 5:1b. See the note there.

Flee: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Flee is a figure of speech. To Flee means to run away from something or someone. Paul was not commanding the Corinthian believers to literally run away. Rather, he was saying “Be very, very careful not to commit sexual sin.” There are two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- literally, keeping the figure of speech. For example:

run away from sexual sin (NCV)

- remove the figure of speech. For example:

Don’t be immoral in matters of sex. (CEV)

Try to retain the figure of speech if this makes the command more emphatic or memorable. If necessary you may substitute a slightly different figure of speech. For example:

Avoid immorality like the plague!

6:18b–c

Paul now gave a reason for his strong command in 6:18a. He explained that there was a difference between sexual wrongdoing and other kinds of wrongdoing. Other wrongdoings may harm the body, but they do not cause the believer’s body to become one with someone outside of God’s will. Sexual wrongdoing harms the believer in a way no other wrongdoing does.

This is a general principle. It is true of everyone. In this context Paul was specifically thinking of “a man” who might visit a prostitute, but his main point applies to women as well as to men. It is therefore possible to translate this using a different subject. For example:

Other sins that people commit don’t affect their bodies the same way that sexual sins do. (GW)

Every sin that a person commits is outside the body, but the fornicator sins against the body itself. (NRSV)

See the General Comment on 6:18b–c for other ways to structure this sentence.

6:18b

Every other sin a man can commit is outside his body,

- Other kinds of sins are not sins against one’s own body in the same way.
- When people sin, they usually do not sin against their own bodies.
- All the other sins that people do are not sins that affect/harm their own bodies in the way

Every other sin a man can commit is outside his body: The BSB, like most English versions, supplies the word other. It is not explicit in the Greek text. Paul was indicating that other sins were different from sexual sins in that they do not affect or involve the body in the same way. Other ways to translate this include:

All other sins that people may commit are done outside the body. (NJB)

Every other sin people do is outside their bodies. (CEV)

6:18c

but he who sins sexually sins against his own body.

- But when people have sex with people they are not married to, they sin against their own body.
- But people who behave in sexually bad ways are wronging their own bodies.
- that having sex with someone they are not married to harms them.

he who sins sexually sins against his own body:

When a believer gives his body to become one with a prostitute, he ruins himself both morally (by breaking God's laws) and spiritually (by greatly harming his union with Christ). He forgets God's purpose for his body. He has chosen to disobey God's laws about what is right and what is wrong.

General Comment on 6:18b-c

There are several ways to combine the information and show the contrast in these verse parts. For example:

That is a sin against your own body in a way that no other sin is. (CEV)

No other sin so clearly affects the body as this one does. (NLT)

1 Corinthians 6:19

Section 6:12–20: Believers must live pure lives because they belong to the Lord

In 6:12–20 Paul talked about another problem in the church in Corinth. He had heard that some people in Corinth were behaving immorally. It appears that some of the Christians there were saying that it was all right for them to live as they pleased, because God would save and forgive them. They were saying that it did not matter what they did with their bodies. Paul said that they were wrong. In this section he told them why as believers they should honor God in everything they did.

Paragraph 6:18–20

Paul again commanded the believers not to behave in sexually immoral ways. Then he gave more reasons for this command: A person ruins his body as the Holy Spirit's living place if he takes part in sexual immoral-

ity. God bought our bodies by paying a big price for them. So our bodies belong to him, and we must honor him by using our bodies in right ways.

6:19a-c

This is one long rhetorical question. Paul used this question to remind the Corinthians of something he expected them to know. They were acting as though they had forgotten it.

There are two ways to translate it.

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit within you, which you have from God? (RSV)

- as a statement. For example:

You surely know that your body is a temple.... (CEV)

You should know that your body is a temple.... (NCV)

See the General Comment on 6:19a-d at the end on 6:19d for suggestions of different ways to break up the sentences in this verse.

6:19a

Do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit

- Have you forgotten that your bodies are a temple for the Holy Spirit?
- You surely know that your body is like a temple the Holy Spirit.
- Remember that your body is a dwelling place for the Holy Spirit.

In the Greek text, this verse begins with a word which means "or" (see 6:19 in the NRSV). The meaning is: If you do not agree with what I just said there, then you should think about this.

Do you not know...?: Paul was reminding the Corinthians of an important truth. He was trying to get them to think in good and right ways.

your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit: This is a metaphor. A temple is a building that people make for their God or gods to live in. Here Paul was indicating that the Holy Spirit lives within the individual believer. Compare notes on 3:16a and 3:16b, where Paul talked about the church as a group. Different ways to translate this include:

- as a metaphor. For example:

your body is the temple of the Holy Spirit (GNT)

- as a simile. For example:

your body is like a temple for the Holy Spirit

- Explaining something of the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

Your body is a dwelling-place for the Holy Spirit.

6:19b who is in you,

- The Holy Spirit lives in/inside you.

who is in you: The phrase who is in you indicates that the Holy Spirit lives inside, or within, the believer. This phrase helps to explain the meaning of the previous verse part. This is the sense in which the body is a temple of the Holy Spirit.

6:19c whom you have received from God?

- God himself gave you the Holy Spirit.
- God sent him to live/dwell in you.

whom you have received from God: This verse part indicates that the Holy Spirit is a gift that God gives to believers. In some languages it may be natural to translate this with God as the agent. For example:

whom God has given to you

Another possible way to translate this is to follow the REB:

the Spirit is God's gift to you (REB)

6:19d You are not your own;

- You do not belong to yourselves.
- You are not your own lord/master.
- He/God owns you. You do not own yourself.

You are not your own: When Paul says You are not your own, he implies that we belong to God. God is the owner of our bodies. In some languages it may be necessary to make this implied information explicit. For example:

You do not belong to yourselves but to God. (GNT)

General Comment on 6:19a-d

In the Greek text 6:19a-d forms one long rhetorical question. This is reflected in the NET:

Or do you not know that your body is the temple of the Holy Spirit in you, whom you have from God, and you are not your own? (NET)

It is acceptable to break this up into two sentences and translate 6:19d as a strong statement, as in the BSB. Other ways to break up this long sentence include:

You should know that your body is a temple for the Holy Spirit who is in you. You have received the Holy Spirit from God. So you do not belong to yourselves,... (NCV)

You surely know that your body is a temple where the Holy Spirit lives. The Spirit is in you and is a gift from God. You are no longer your own. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 6:20

Section 6:12–20: Believers must live pure lives because they belong to the Lord

In 6:12–20 Paul talked about another problem in the church in Corinth. He had heard that some people in Corinth were behaving immorally. It appears that some of the Christians there were saying that it was all right for them to live as they pleased, because God would save and forgive them. They were saying that it did not matter what they did with their bodies. Paul said that they were wrong. In this section he told them why as believers they should honor God in everything they did.

Paragraph 6:18–20

Paul again commanded the believers not to behave in sexually immoral ways. Then he gave more reasons for this command: A person ruins his body as the Holy Spirit's living place if he takes part in sexual immorality. God bought our bodies by paying a big price for them. So our bodies belong to him, and we must honor him by using our bodies in right ways.

6:20a you were bought at a price.

- God bought you. He has paid for you.
- God paid a high/big price to make you his own.

you were bought at a price: This is a metaphor taken from the custom of buying slaves in the market. When a man bought a slave, he became the owner of the slave. The slave was obliged to obey his new master. In a similar way a believer does not belong to himself. He or she now belongs to God, and God may command him or her to live for him just as he chooses. The verb *you were bought* is in the passive. So there are two ways to translate this clause:

- using a passive verb. It is possible to supply the agent (God). For example:

you were bought by God for a price (NCV)

- using an active verb. For example:

God paid a great price for you. (CEV)

a price: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *price* refers to the cost of freeing people from sin and making them God's own people. Paul does not tell us here what price God paid to make us his own possession. However, he implies that it was not cheap or easy. Nor does Paul say to whom the price was paid. You should not try to supply this information.

6:20b

Therefore glorify God with your body.

- So then, everything you do with your bodies should show that you honor/respect God.
- So then, use your bodies to cause people to respect/praise/glorify God.
- So bring glory to God by what you do with/in your body.

Therefore: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *Therefore* introduces a command Paul gave to the Corinthians. On the basis of what he has told them, Paul commanded the Corinthians to honor God by the way they lived. The GNT translates this as "So."

glorify God with your body: Paul was addressing the whole group, but he used the word *body* as though he were talking to only one person. He wanted each hearer to listen to it as a command to himself. Consider whether it is more natural for you to use the singular or plural in this context. The KJV has some extra words at the end of 6:20. It says: "For ye are bought with a price; therefore glorify God in your body, and in your spirit, which are God's." These final words translated as "and in your spirit, which are God's," are found in many Greek texts. But since these words are not found in many of the oldest Greek texts, which are considered more accurate, most English versions do

not include them. It is recommended that you do not include these words in your translation. Other ways to translate this include:

use your body to honor God (CEV)

use your bodies for God's glory (GNT)

1 Corinthians 7:1

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:1–7

Paul began to discuss the subjects the Corinthians had written to him about. It seems that some believers were thinking that sexual intercourse was not good. Those people even said that married Christians should not have sexual intercourse with each other. Paul said that it was good for married believers to live together normally as man and wife. This would help them avoid being tempted to commit sex sins.

7:1a**Now for the matters you wrote about:**

- ¶ Now I will address/discuss the things you wrote to me about.
- ¶ Now about/concerning the contents of your letter:
- ¶ And now let us^(incl) discuss what you wrote to me.

Now for the matters you wrote about: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Now for can also be translated as “Now concerning.” This phrase introduces a new topic. Paul was about to begin to discuss a letter that the Corinthian believers had written to Paul. Another way to translate this verse part is:

Now I will discuss the things you wrote me about.
(NCV)

7:1b**It is good to abstain from sexual relations.**

- You wrote/write, “It is good for a man to refrain from relations with a woman”
- You say/said, “It is better for a man not to have sex with a woman.”
- You asked me if it was better for Christian men to remain celibate.

It is good to abstain from sexual relations: Scholars disagree as to whether these are Paul’s own words or whether he was quoting from the Corinthians’ letter. The two views are:

1. This is a quotation. The Corinthians had asked Paul if he agreed with them concerning this matter. Paul was referring back to what they had said. For example, the NRSV shows this by putting the words in quotation marks:

“It is well for a man not to touch a woman.” (NRSV) (ESV, NJB, NET, NLT, NRSV, REB, CEV)

1. These are Paul’s own words. For example:

It is well for a man not to touch a woman. (RSV) (BSB, RSV, GNT, KJV, NASB, GW, NCV, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). These words were probably a Corinthian saying or slogan that they had written in their letter to Paul. The Display text meaning lines show that these are some of the words from the Corinthians’ letter. Here are some reasons why it is best to interpret 7:1b as a quote from the Corinthians’ letter: (1) In other parts

of 1 Corinthians Paul quoted what the Corinthians said; for example: 6:12, 6:13; and 10:23. (2) In 1 Timothy 4:3, Paul talked about some false teachers who were forbidding people to get married; Paul did not agree with their teaching. (3) Paul was a Jew; the Jewish people as a whole thought that marriage was good (following Genesis 2:18). If you use quotation marks in your language, it is good to use them here. However, quotation marks alone will not help the listener. So it is good to also use a phrase such as “You say” or “You wrote” so that the listener will understand that these words are not Paul’s own teaching.

It is good: The Greek word that the BSB translates as good here probably means useful, beneficial, or helpful. The saying implies that the Corinthians thought it was better for Christian men, even those who were married, not to have any intimate relations with women. They believed that this would make them more holy.

to abstain from sexual relations: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to abstain from sexual relations is literally “not to touch a woman.” This is a euphemism. (A euphemism is the use of a polite or indirect expression in place of an expression that might offend.) There are two views about the meaning of this euphemism.

1. It refers to sexual intercourse in general. For example:

It is good for a man not to have sexual relations with a woman. (ESV) (BSB, ESV, NET, NLT, REB, NCV)

1. It refers to marriage. For example:

A man does well not to marry. (GNT) (NIV, GNT, GW, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because Paul would not have needed to use a euphemism to speak about marriage. In his culture it was acceptable to speak openly about marriage. But it was common to use euphemisms when talking about sex.

Consider whether it is good to use a euphemism here in your translation. Consider carefully which euphemism might be appropriate. Do not use the euphemism “touch” if your readers will understand it literally as referring to any form of touching.

1 Corinthians 7:2

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:1–7

Paul began to discuss the subjects the Corinthians had written to him about. It seems that some believers were thinking that sexual intercourse was not good. Those people even said that married Christians should not have sexual intercourse with each other. Paul said that it was good for married believers to live together normally as man and wife. This would help them avoid being tempted to commit sex sins.

7:2a

But because there is so much sexual immorality,

- But because many people have relations/sex with people they are not married to,
- Yes/Granted, but it is very common for people to commit sexual sin. So I say that
- My answer is: Many people behave immorally.

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But here introduces a limit or qualification to the previous

verse part. Paul implied that he only partly agreed with the Corinthians that celibacy was good. He did not believe that everyone should live that way, and certainly he did not believe that married people should live that way. Other ways to translate this include:

Rather (REB)

Yes, but (see the NLT, and the NJB)

because there is so much sexual immorality: In Greek the word that the BSB translates as sexual immorality is in the plural. So this clause can be translated as:

since there are so many cases of sexual immorality (see 7:2 in the NRSV)

In some languages it may be natural to translate sexual immorality as a verb phrase. For example:

since so many people commit sex sins

Paul meant that sexual immorality was common in the city of Corinth.

7:2b

each man should have his own wife,

- each man should keep/hold to his own wife,
- you married men should all have relations with your own wife,
- For that reason, each of you married men are to live in a normal/intimate way with your own wife,

7:2c

and each woman her own husband.

- and each woman should keep/hold to her husband.
- and all you women should have relations with your husband.
- and each woman must do the same with her husband.

7:2b-c

each man should have his own wife, and each woman her own husband: These are commands. This is what Paul wanted the believers to do. He wanted each of them to have their own spouse. This would help them avoid the temptation to immorality.

The Greek phrases that the BSB translates literally as have his own wife and “have her own husband” are idioms. There are two ways to understand the meaning of these idioms:

1. They mean to have sexual relations with one's spouse. For example, the NET footnote says that the word have means "have marital relations with."
2. They mean to get married. For example:

every one, both men and women, should be married

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the view of several commentaries, and it fits the context well. Paul quoted the Corinthian saying that it was good to avoid sex, but then said that he wanted married people to have sexual relations with their spouses. Paul used a euphemism here in order to avoid talking directly about sex. There is no reason he would have avoided talking directly about getting married.

In your translation, use a euphemism if that is natural and appropriate in your language. An example of an English euphemism is:

you married men should sleep with your wives,
and you wives with your husbands

each man...each woman: In some languages there may be different words for married and unmarried men and women (as in older English the word woman referred to a married woman, in contrast to a "maid"). If this is the case in your language, you should use words that refer specifically to married adults. In some languages it may be natural to say:

all men...all women

every man...every woman

1 Corinthians 7:3

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

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Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

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7:3a

The husband should fulfill his marital duty to his wife,

- Each husband should have normal/intimate marriage relations with his wife,
- A wife has the right to expect her husband to have sex with her. That is his duty to her.
- A husband must not refuse to have relations with his wife. It is right/proper for him to make love to her.

The husband should fulfill his marital duty to his wife:

When a man and woman marry, they make an agreement with each other. The agreement may be different in various cultures, but in all cultures the husband and wife are expected to have sex with each other. That is what Paul meant by marital duty. Both the husband and the wife should accept that as something they must do.

The words marital duty are a euphemism for sexual relations. You should consider how to make this clear and yet use language that is acceptable to read in public. Other ways to translate this include:

The husband must give the wife what is due to her, and equally the wife must give the husband his due. (REB)

The husband should give his wife all that he owes her as his wife. And the wife should give her husband all that she owes him as her husband. (NCV)

Husbands and wives should be fair with each other about having sex. (CEV)

7:3b and likewise the wife to her husband.

- and each wife should have normal/intimate marriage relations with her husband.
- And in the same way, a husband has the right to expect his wife to have sex with him. That is her duty to him.
- Also, a wife must not refuse to have relations with her husband. It is right/proper for her to make love to him.

1 Corinthians 7:4

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

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Paragraph 7:1–7

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7:4a

The wife does not have authority over her own body,

- The wife does not own/control her body.
- A married woman is not the boss over her own body.
- A married woman cannot always do just what she wants to do.

7:4b

but the husband.

- Rather, her husband owns/controls it.
- Instead her husband is also the boss over her body.
- She must do what her husband wants.

7:4a–b

The wife does not have authority over her own body, but the husband: Paul was saying that when people marry they agree to keep their bodies for the person they are married to. They agree that the person they are married to is the only one with the right to their bodies. Other ways to translate this include:

The wife's body does not belong to her alone but also to her husband (NIV)

A wife is not the master of her own body, but her husband is. (GNT)

have authority over: The Greek word that the BSB translates as have authority over means to have power or rights over someone. Paul meant that married people have the right to expect to have sexual intercourse with the person they are married to. That is a right which is part of their marriage agreement.

7:4c

Likewise the husband does not have authority over his own body,

- Likewise, the husband does not own/control his body.
- Also, a married man is not the boss over his body.
- Also, a married man cannot always do just what he wants to do.

7:4d**but the wife.**

- Rather, his wife owns/controls it.
- Instead, his wife is the boss over his body.
- He must do what his wife wants to do.

7:4c-d

Likewise the husband does not have authority over his own body, but the wife: Paul said the same thing to the husband that he had said to the wife. Both husband and wife have the same right and duty of having intercourse with their spouse. In your translation, try to use the same verb phrase in these verses that you used in 7:4a-b.

1 Corinthians 7:5**Section 7:1-40: Paul answered questions about marriage**

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Paragraph 7:1-7

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7:5a**Do not deprive each other,**

- To you married people I say: Stop refusing to fulfill your duty to one another.
- So now I command you married people to stop denying your spouse his or her marriage rights.
- Do not say to your spouse, "I will not sleep with you."

Do not deprive each other: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deprive here means to keep back from someone something that belongs to him or her. It means to prevent someone from having and enjoying what rightfully belongs to him or her. In this context it refers to someone refusing to have sexual relations with his or her spouse. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as direct speech. For example:

Do not say to your spouse, "I will no longer have sex with you."

Do not deprive: In Greek this is in the present tense. This probably indicates that when Paul wrote 1 Corinthians, some married Christians in Corinth were not having sex with their husbands or wives. So you can translate this as:

Stop depriving each other.

Stop refusing to give your spouse his marriage rights.

7:5b**except by mutual consent and for a time,**

- The only exception to normal relations should be when you have both agreed to stay apart from each other for a little while
- However, it is all right if you decide together that you will not be intimate for a short time
- You may perhaps both agree not to sleep together for a little while

except by mutual consent and for a time: Paul was allowing some exceptions to what he had just said. He

accepted that sometimes husbands and wives might not have sexual relations.

by mutual consent: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as by mutual consent can also be translated as “by agreement.” It indicates that the husband and wife must both wish to stay apart from one another. They must agree to refrain from sexual relations.

for a time: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as for a time means “for a short time” or “for a little while.” The husband and wife should not stay apart for very long.

7:5c

so you may devote yourselves to prayer.

- so that you will be able to use your time for praying.
- so that you can spend your time praying.
- so you will have more/extra time to pray.

so you may devote yourselves to prayer: This is a purpose clause. It indicates the purpose for which a husband and wife might refrain from sexual relations for a while. Among the Jewish people in the OT and among the Christians in the NT, it was a custom to pray and fast for several days at a time. During these times it was common for husbands and wives to refrain from sexual relations. (See for example Exodus 19:15.) The KJV translates 7:5c this way: “that ye may give yourselves to fasting and prayer.” Many Greek copies of 1 Corinthians have the words “fasting and prayer” in 7:5c, instead of just the word “prayer.” But the UBS Greek text does not include the words “fasting and,” because these words are not in the oldest Greek copies of 1 Corinthians. It gives the shorter version an A rating, indicating that the words “fasting and” were almost certainly not in the original text of 1 Corinthians. Almost all English versions follow the UBS Greek text. It is recommended that you do not include the words “fasting and.” Other ways to translate this include:

in order to spend your time in prayer (GNT)

to leave yourselves free for prayer (NJB)

devote yourselves: The Greek word that the BSB translates as devote yourselves means to focus on something strongly. Here Paul is saying that it is permissible for a husband and wife to abstain from sexual relations for a while in order to focus more strongly on prayer.

7:5d

Then come together again,

- But after that, you should have normal relations with each other again
- But after that you must begin to live together again as husbands and wives should

Then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Then is the common conjunction often translated as “and.” The RSV and GNT translate it here as “but then.”

come together again: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as come together again is a euphemism meaning “begin again to have sexual intercourse.” Other ways to translate this include:

resume normal marital relations (GNT)

you should get back together (GW)

start sleeping together again

Consider if a euphemism would be appropriate in this context in your culture.

7:5e

so that Satan will not tempt you

- so that Satan will not tempt you to behave immorally.
- in order to avoid Satan’s temptations to sin/immorality,

so that Satan will not tempt you: These words connect to the command in 7:5a, “Do not deprive each other.” This is a negative purpose clause. Paul gave his command not to “deprive each other” so that believers would not be tempted by Satan. He knew that when married people do not have sexual intercourse, they give Satan a chance to tempt them.

Satan: Satan is a name for the devil, the chief of the evil angels. See the note on 5:5a.

tempt you: If you need to say what the Corinthians might be tempted to do, you could say:

tempt you to sin

tempt you to commit adultery

7:5f

through your lack of self-control.

- For it is hard for you keep control of yourselves.
- since you may not be able to control your own desires/passions.

through your lack of self-control: The Greek word that the BSB translates as lack of self-control means that a person is not able to control himself. In some languages it may be necessary to make this more specific and say:

because you are not able to control your strong sexual desire

General Comment on 7:5e-f

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 7:5e and 5f. For example:

If you fail to have sex with your spouse, ^{5f}you may have strong desires that you cannot control ^{5e}and then Satan will easily tempt you to commit sex sins.

1 Corinthians 7:6

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

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Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:1–7

Paul began to discuss the subjects the Corinthians had written to him about. It seems that some believers were thinking that sexual intercourse was not good. Those people even said that married Christians should not have sexual intercourse with each other. Paul said that it was good for married believers to live together normally as man and wife. This would help them avoid being tempted to commit sex sins.

7:6a

I say this as a concession,

- I am allowing you to do this,
- I do permit married people to keep themselves from sexual relations during times of prayer.

7:6b

not as a command.

- but I do not order you to do it.
- But that is not something you are obliged to do.

7:6a-b

I say this as a concession, not as a command: The BSB, like most English versions, does not make explicit the reference of the word this. Many modern commentators believe that Paul was here referring back to what he had just said in 7:5b, that married couples could abstain from normal relations. He allowed them to abstain for a short while if they both agreed and wanted to pray. But he was not commanding them to abstain. They did not need to refrain from normal relations in order to be able to pray. In some languages it may be necessary to make some of this explicit. For example:

I say this to give you permission to stay away from sexual relations for a time. It is not a command to do so. (NCV)

concession: The Greek word that the BSB translates as concession means to agree with what someone thinks about something or to meet someone halfway. Paul thought it was not good for husbands and wives to stop having sexual intercourse. But he agreed or conceded that sometimes there could be good reasons for stopping for a while.

General Comment on 7:6a-b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 7:6a and 6b. For example:

^{6b}I do not order you to stop sleeping with your spouse. ^{6a}I only say that you may do it/this if you want to.

1 Corinthians 7:7

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

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Paragraph 7:1–7

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7:7a

I wish that all men were as I am.

- I would like it if all believers were not married, as I am not married.
- Actually I think/say that it would be good if all Christians were like me, that is, were happy to live without being married.
- I do not need to get married, and I wish all Christians were like me in this way.

I wish that all men were as I am: Paul's readers knew that Paul was unmarried at this time. He may have been widowed, or he may have never married. We do not know. In some languages it may be necessary to include here the implied information that Paul was unmarried:

I wish that all men were unmarried/celebrate, as I am.

I wish that: Paul was not saying that this was what he actually wanted. He knew that this was not practical or even desirable. But this is a way of saying that he liked something himself and was content. It would have been fine by him if everyone was content to be single. In your translation, make sure that Paul was not indicating that this was what he actually wanted or expected to happen. Use a very mild or moderate expression. For example:

I would be perfectly happy if...

I would have no objections if...

all men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as all men can also be translated as "all people." Paul was likely referring to both male and female believers.

7:7b

But each man has his own gift from God;

- But each person/believer has received his own gift from God.
- But God gives different abilities to each Christian.
- Yet God is the one who makes it possible for each Christian/person to live in the way that is best for him or her to live.

7:7c

one has this gift,

- To one person/believer he gives the gift of living a single/celebrate life,
- He gives to some the ability to live as a married person,

7:7d

another has that.

- and to another person/believer he gives the gift of living a married life.
- and to some he gives the ability to live as a single/celebrate person.

7:7b–d

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces the contrast between what Paul de-

sired for other people and what God actually wanted for them.

each man has his own gift from God; one has this gift, another has that: The word that Paul translates as gift refers to any special ability that God gives believers. To some believers God gives the gift of living without being married and without having sexual intercourse. To others God gives the gift of being married. God causes one person to be able to live as an unmarried person. He causes another person to be able to live as a married person. Other ways to translate this include:

each person has a special gift from God, and these gifts vary from person to person (GW)

each person has the gift God has granted him—one this gift and another that (REB)

each man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as each man is more literally “each one” and can refer to both men and women.

1 Corinthians 7:8

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul’s answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person’s husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

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Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul’s teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:8–9

In this paragraph Paul discussed people who were not married at that time. Some Corinthian believers thought it would be better for them to remain unmarried. Paul advised them to remain as they were. However, if they strongly desired to marry, then they should do so.

7:8a

Now to the unmarried and widows I say this:

- ¶ Now I will talk to those of you who are unmarried, including widows.
- ¶ Now, you also asked me about believers who are not married, and about widows. So I will tell you what I think they should do.

Now to the unmarried...I say this: In this verse part Paul began to address unmarried people directly. Introduce this new topic in a way that is natural for your language.

In some languages it may be natural to refer to the unmarried by using a second-person pronoun:

Now I am speaking to you who are unmarried

Now I will talk to you who are not married

the unmarried and widows: In this context the phrase the unmarried and widows means “the unmarried, including the widows.” Paul made special mention of widows, but they are also included with the group of the unmarried.

the unmarried: The Greek word that the BSB translates as unmarried in this context is probably a general term referring to both men and women who were not at present married. They might have never married, or they might have been widowed.

widows: A “widow” is a woman whose husband has died.

7:8b

It is good for them to remain unmarried, as I am.

- It is good for them/you to stay alone/single/celebrate, as I am.
- I recommend that you do not get married again. Stay alone/single, just as I do.

It is good for them to remain unmarried, as I am:

Paul told the non-married believers that it was perfectly acceptable for them to remain in the same state he was, that is, single. The BSB has supplied the word unmarried. It is not explicit in the Greek. In many languages it will be necessary to supply something like this. However, we do not know if Paul had never been married, or if he had been married and his wife had died. Before he became a Christian, Paul was a rabbi, a Jewish Pharisee and a teacher (Galatians 1:14), and a voting member of the Sanhedrin, the highest court of the Jewish people (Acts 26:10). Jewish rules generally did not allow men to be in those important positions before they were married. So perhaps Paul had been married. So try to supply a general word referring to any person not married at the present time. In some languages it may be good to use a second-person pronoun here. For example:

It would be better for you to continue to live alone as I do. (GNT)

1 Corinthians 7:9**Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage**

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:8–9

In this paragraph Paul discussed people who were not married at that time. Some Corinthian believers thought it would be better for them to remain unmarried. Paul advised them to remain as they were. However, if they strongly desired to marry, then they should do so.

7:9a**But if they cannot control themselves,**

- However, if they/you are not controlling their/your desires/passions,
- But if a celibate life is too hard for you,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces an exception to what Paul had just said. Although he thought it good for people to remain single, he understood that for some people it was not good, and these people should marry.

if they cannot control themselves: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as if they cannot control themselves refers to a situation in which single or widowed people strongly desire to have sexual intercourse. Perhaps they cannot stop this desire or they cannot control their thoughts. If a literal translation does not make this meaning clear, you may be able to translate this as:

if their desires are so strong they cannot control them

Again, in some languages it may be natural to use a second-person pronoun. For example:

But if you cannot restrain your desires (GNT)

7:9b**let them marry.**

- then it is better for them/you to have a wife or a husband.
- then you ought to marry someone,

let them marry: This is Paul's direction to these people. It is also possible to translate it as a direct command in either the third or second person:

they are to get married

go ahead and marry (GNT)

7:9c**For it is better to marry than to burn with passion.**

- For it is better for them/you to get married than to stay single and always be longing for marriage/relations.
- because marriage is preferable to unsatisfied desire.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* introduces the basis for Paul advising that those people should marry. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language.

it is better to marry than to burn with passion: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *burn with passion* is literally simply *burn*. This is a figure of speech that refers to having unsatisfied desires/wants, especially strong unsatisfied sexual desire. So the BSB and most other versions add the implied information with *passion* to show that Paul was referring to sexual desire.

1 Corinthians 7:10**Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage**

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: *Remain as you are*. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:10–11

In this paragraph Paul began to address married believers. He told them not to divorce each other, and he reminded them of Jesus' command.

7:10a**To the married I give this command**

- ¶ Now I have a command for you who are married.
- ¶ Now, you married believers, this is what I command you to do:

To the married: Paul began to talk to husbands and wives who were believers. As in 7:8–9, you may want to use the second-person pronoun "you." For example:

To you believers who are married I give this command.

I give this command: This phrase introduces a firm and strong command. It is not a recommendation. This phrase emphasizes that what Paul was about to write is important and that believers must obey it.

7:10b**(not I, but the Lord):**

- Actually, this command does not come from me; rather, it is what the Lord Jesus himself said when he was here on earth.
- —Actually the Lord Jesus himself commands this, not I alone—

(not I, but the Lord): This phrase indicates that Paul's command was not just his own but came from the Lord Jesus. The Lord Jesus Christ himself had given this command when he was on earth. See Matthew 5:32 and 19:4–6. The BSB has placed these words in parentheses, but it is not necessary to do this. Another way to translate this is:

that comes not from me, but from the Lord (NLT)

General Comment on 7:10a–b

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence after the words "Not I" in 7:10b:

The command I give to you married believers does not come from me. It is what the Lord already said when he was here on earth.

7:10c**A wife must not separate from her husband.**

- A married woman must not divorce/leave her husband.
- You wives, you are not to go away from your husbands.

A wife must not separate from her husband: The Greek word that the BSB translates as separate from means to leave or desert one's spouse and thus break the marriage. Paul said that a wife must not end her marriage in this way. Other ways to translate this include:

A wife must not leave her husband (NLT)

Wives should not abandon/desert their husbands.

1 Corinthians 7:11

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:10–11

In this paragraph Paul began to address married believers. He told them not to divorce each other, and he reminded them of Jesus' command.

7:11a

But if she does, she must remain unmarried

- And even if she does divorce/leave him, then she should remain/stay unmarried,
- And if you ever do go away from your husband, then do not marry anyone else.

But if she does, she must remain unmarried: The English phrase if she does is a short way of saying "if she does separate from her husband." Paul recognized that sometimes there would be severe problems in marriages and that some wives would leave their husbands. He gave the instruction that in such a case the wife should not marry a different person. Another way to translate this is:

But if she does leave, she must not marry again.
(NCV)

7:11b

or else be reconciled to her husband.

- or else she should go back to live with her husband.
- If you do not want to stay single/unmarried, then return to your husband and be his wife again.

or else: The Greek word that the BSB translates as or else here introduces an alternative action. The woman may either remain single or reconcile with her husband.

be reconciled to her husband: The Greek word that the BSB translates as be reconciled in this context means "reunite with" or "get back together with." Paul was indicating that a Christian woman who for some reason separates from her husband may later begin to live with him again. The verb be reconciled is in the passive. There are two ways to translate it:

- as a passive. For example:

be reconciled to her husband (NET)

- as an active. For example:

go back to her husband (CEV)

Translate using the verb form that is most natural in your language.

7:11c**And a husband must not divorce his wife.**

- And if you are a husband, you must not divorce/leave your wife.
- And you husbands, do not send your wives away.

a husband must not divorce his wife: The Greek word that the BSB translates as divorce means “send someone away.” In Greek and Roman culture, a husband could end his marriage by sending his wife away from his home. Paul said that a husband must not send his wife away to go and live somewhere else. He was also indicating in a short way that everything he said to wives in 7:10a-11b is also true for husbands. A Christian man should not divorce his wife. But if he does, he should remain unmarried or else reconcile with his wife.

1 Corinthians 7:12**Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage**

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul’s answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person’s husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul’s teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:12–16

Paul now discussed the case of believers married to unbelievers. Paul had first preached the gospel in Corinth only three or four years before he wrote this letter. So most believers in Corinth had only been believers for a few years. Some men had become believers but their wives had not. And some women had become believers but their husbands had not. Apparently some people in Corinth were wondering whether Christians should remain married to unbelievers. Paul’s answer was that the believer is not to ask for a divorce. But if the unbelieving husband or wife chooses to leave, the believer need not think he or she has to stay married to that person.

7:12a**To the rest I say this**

- ¶ Now I am talking to you other believers who are married to people who are not believers.

To the rest I say this: Paul was now beginning to talk to married believers who had unbelieving partners. Other ways to translate this include:

For all the others I say this (NCV)

I...say to the rest of you (GW)

7:12b**(I, not the Lord):**

- This command is from me, not from the Lord Jesus.
- Since the Lord Jesus did not tell us if we should stay married to unbelievers or not, I will tell you what I think is the right thing for you to do.
- The Lord Jesus did not give us any command/teaching about this, but I will give you my teaching/command.
- These are my own teachings/instructions to you. The Lord Jesus did not say anything on this topic.

(I, not the Lord): This verse part indicates that the Lord Jesus had given no specific commands about what believers should do when married to unbelievers. Paul himself was giving this command. The BSB has placed these words in parentheses, but it is not necessary to do this. Other ways to translate this include:

as my own word, not as the Lord’s (REB)

I am saying this, not the Lord (NCV)

General Comment on 7:12a-b

In some languages it may be natural to combine these verse parts. For example:

I (not the Lord) say to the rest of you (GW)

I will speak to the rest of you, though I do not have a direct command from the Lord. (NLT)

7:12c**If a brother has an unbelieving wife**

- If a Christian man is married to a woman who does not believe in Jesus Christ,
- Suppose/Perhaps a follower of Christ has a wife who is not a follower,
- Some of you Christian men have wives who are not believers.

If a brother has an unbelieving wife: The word brother here means a Christian man. Paul used the singular, a brother, but he did not mean that there was only one Christian man who had an unbelieving wife. So in some languages it will be more natural to use the plural:

If there are Christian men...

Paul knew that there were some husbands among the believers in Corinth who had wives who were not believers. The word If does not mean that Paul was unsure or doubtful. This is a present real conditional clause which presents a fact which is true. See Appendix 1, part 1 (a). In some languages it may be better to translate this as a fact. For example:

Some of you believing men have wives who are not believers.

As for you believers whose wives are not believers....

7:12d**and she is willing to live with him,**

- and she does not want to leave him,
- and she wants to continue being his wife.
- If your wife is willing to live with you,

she is willing to live with him: This refers to a situation in which an unbelieving wife was content to remain with her husband after he became a Christian.

7:12e**he must not divorce her.**

- then he should not send her away.
- Then tell him that he should not divorce her.
- then do not divorce/leave her.

he must not divorce her: Paul now told a believing husband what to do when his unbelieving wife said she was willing to go on living with him. Paul told the believing husband not to divorce his wife.

divorce: This is the same Greek word as in 7:11c. See the note there.

1 Corinthians 7:13**Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage**

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:12–16

Paul now discussed the case of believers married to unbelievers. Paul had first preached the gospel in Corinth only three or four years before he wrote this letter. So most believers in Corinth had only been believers for a few years. Some men had become believers but their wives had not. And some women had become believers but their husbands had not.

Apparently some people in Corinth were wondering whether Christians should remain married to unbelievers. Paul's answer was that the believer is not to ask for a divorce. But if the unbelieving husband or wife chooses to leave, the believer need not think he or she has to stay married to that person.

7:13a

And if a woman has an unbelieving husband

- Also, if a Christian woman is married to a man who does not believe in Jesus Christ,
- In the same way, when a woman who follows Christ has a husband who does not follow him,
- Also, if you are a woman who believes in Jesus, and your husband is not a believer,

7:13b

and he is willing to live with her,

- and if he wants to remain married to her,
- and he does not want her to leave,
- and yet he himself is willing to continue being your husband,

7:13c

she must not divorce him.

- then she should not divorce him.
- then she should not divorce/leave him.
- do not separate from him.

7:13a-c

And if a woman has an unbelieving husband and he is willing to live with her, she must not divorce him: Paul said the same thing to a believing wife that he had said to a believing husband. Neither must divorce the unbelieving spouse. Consider whether it is natural in your language to translate this as the exact equivalent of the previous verse, or if you should use different structure or vocabulary. In some languages it may be helpful to make it explicit that the woman in the example is a believer. For example:

And if a Christian woman has a husband who is an unbeliever, and he is willing to continue living with her, she must not leave him. (NLT)

1 Corinthians 7:14

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section

Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:12–16

Paul now discussed the case of believers married to unbelievers. Paul had first preached the gospel in Corinth only three or four years before he wrote this letter. So most believers in Corinth had only been believers for a few years. Some men had become believers but their wives had not. And some women had become believers but their husbands had not. Apparently some people in Corinth were wondering whether Christians should remain married to unbelievers. Paul's answer was that the believer is not to ask for a divorce. But if the unbelieving husband or wife chooses to leave, the believer need not think he or she has to stay married to that person.

7:14a

For the unbelieving husband is sanctified through his believing wife,

- For the husband belongs to the Lord because of his Christian wife.
- The husband who is not a believer is made holy through his believing wife. (NCV)

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For here introduces a reason why believers should not leave their husbands or wives who were not believers.

the unbelieving husband is sanctified through his believing wife: The Greek word that the BSB translates as is sanctified means to be made holy or set

apart to belong to God. See the notes on 1:2b and 1:2c. Paul was saying that the husband of the believer was set apart by his marriage and in some way made holy or acceptable to God. In 1 Timothy 4:5, Paul said that food “is sanctified by the word of God and prayer.” The Greek word that Paul used for “sanctified” is the same Greek word that is translated “sanctified” in 1 Corinthians 7:14. In 1 Timothy 4:5 Paul meant that the food is not unclean, and therefore it is fit/proper for us to eat. In Romans 11:16 Paul said, “If the root is holy, so are the branches.” By this he meant that if the ancestors of the Jewish people (Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob) belonged to God, all the Jewish people belong to God. But yet not all Jewish people are saved. These two verses show us that someone can be said to be “sanctified” or “holy” in one sense and yet not be saved. Therefore the marriage was not impure, and the believing wife was not to separate from him. Other ways to translate this include:

the unbelieving husband is made acceptable to God by being united to his wife (GNT)

The husband who is not a believer is made holy through his believing wife. (NCV)

Paul did not mean that the unbeliever was saved or that his or her sins are forgiven because he or she was married to a believer. But he did mean that the Lord sees the unbelieving partner and the marriage as acceptable or holy.

7:14b

and the unbelieving wife is sanctified through her believing husband.

- And the wife belongs to the Lord because of you, her Christian husband.
- And the wife who is not a believer is made holy through her believing husband. (NCV)

and the unbelieving wife is sanctified through her believing husband: The text that the BSB has translated as her believing husband is literally “the brother.” This refers to a believing man, a Christian. The man was not his wife’s brother in either a literal or a spiritual sense. Most English versions do not use the word “brother” here. Here is another way to translate this:

the unbelieving wife is made acceptable to God by being united to her Christian husband (GNT)

General Comment on 7:14a-b

In some languages it may be natural to combine rather than repeat the information in these 7:14a-b. For example:

Your husband or wife who isn’t a follower is made holy by having you as a mate. (CEV)

7:14c-d

Otherwise your children would be unclean, but now they are holy: These verse parts explain Paul’s reason

for saying that the unbeliever was sanctified by his or her believing spouse. If it were not true, the children of the marriage would be unclean. But Paul and his readers assumed that the children were not unclean. So, he argued, it must be true that in some way the unbelieving partner was made holy through his or her believing spouse and, because of that, the children are considered holy.

7:14c

Otherwise your children would be unclean,

- If it were not so, then your children would not belong to God.
- If that were not true, then their children would be like the children of parents who are not Christians.

Otherwise: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Otherwise here means “If this were not so” (GNT); that is, if the unbelieving spouse were not in some way made holy.

your children: The phrase your children refers to the children born from the marriage between the believer and the unbeliever. In some languages it may be natural to use a third-person pronoun to match the previous verse, after the model of the GNT:

their children (GNT)

Paul was saying that if one parent is a believer, the children in some way belong to God. Paul wanted the Corinthians to see that as an important reason for remaining married to their unbelieving husbands and wives.

unclean: The Greek word that the BSB translates as unclean is a word used for people or things that were, for various reasons, ceremonially impure. They were not acceptable to God and could not be used for serving him. This word does not imply sinfulness, but it does imply something that is not sacred; in this context, outside the community of God’s believing people. Other ways to translate this include:

like pagan children (GNT)

they would not belong to God

7:14d

but now they are holy.

- But because both you and your unbelieving husband or wife belong to God, your children belong to God too.
- But because one parent belongs to God, God cares for the children as belonging to himself also.

but now: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as but now here introduces the actual state of affairs.

they are holy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as holy in this context is the opposite of the word “unclean” in the previous verse part. The word holy comes from the same root word as “sanctify” (see the note on 1:2c). Someone who is holy is someone who belongs to God. So Paul was saying that the children of mixed marriages belong to God. They can be considered part of the community of God’s people and under God’s special care. Other ways to translate this include:

they are acceptable to God (GNT)

they are actually consecrated to God (JBP)

they belong to God

1 Corinthians 7:15

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul’s answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person’s husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about

his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul’s teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:12–16

Paul now discussed the case of believers married to unbelievers. Paul had first preached the gospel in Corinth only three or four years before he wrote this letter. So most believers in Corinth had only been believers for a few years. Some men had become believers but their wives had not. And some women had become believers but their husbands had not. Apparently some people in Corinth were wondering whether Christians should remain married to unbelievers. Paul’s answer was that the believer is not to ask for a divorce. But if the unbelieving husband or wife chooses to leave, the believer need not think he or she has to stay married to that person.

7:15a

But if the unbeliever leaves, let him go.

- However, if the unbeliever wants to leave/divorce you, let him or her leave.
- But if the unbeliever wants to get a divorce, allow him to get the divorce.
- But if a believer is married to an unbeliever, and the unbeliever wants to divorce/leave the believer, then you should accept this.

But if the unbeliever leaves, let him go: Paul realized that sometimes an unbeliever would not choose to remain married to a partner who became a Christian. He told the believer to allow the unbeliever to leave if that was what the unbeliever wanted to do.

leaves: The Greek word that the BSB translates as leaves means “separates himself” and is the same word used in 7:10c and 11a. See the note on 7:10c. This word should have the same meaning here as it did in 7:10c–11a. This probably refers to a situation in which the unbeliever divorces the believer.

let him go: The Greek word that the BSB translates as let him go is literally “let him/her separate.” Paul was saying that the believer should accept the situation. He should allow the unbeliever to separate/leave.

7:15b**The believing brother or sister is not bound in such cases.**

- In a case like this, a Christian man or woman is not obliged to remain with their spouse.
- When that happens, the believer is free from the marriage.
- In this case/situation the believer does not have to stay married to the unbelieving spouse.

The believing brother or sister is not bound in such cases: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as The believing brother or sister is literally “The brother or the sister.” It refers to men and women within the believing community. The word that the BSB translates as is not bound can also be translated as “is not enslaved.” In this context it is used as a figure of speech. It indicates that the believing partner is not obligated to stay with an unbelieving spouse who wants to separate. God does not require the believer to live with the unbeliever if the unbeliever is the one who decides to leave the believer. Other ways to translate this include:

When this happens, the Christian man or woman is free. (NCV)

You are no longer bound to that person. (CEV)

In such cases the Christian husband or wife is no longer bound to the other. (NLT)

Under these circumstances a Christian man or Christian woman is not bound by a marriage vow. (GW)

7:15c**God has called you to live in peace.**

- God has called/chosen you to be his people so you will live in harmony with other people.
- However remember, God wants us^(incl) believers to live in peace with others.

This verse part connects to the previous verse part with a conjunction that is often translated as “but” as in the NJB. The BSB does not translate it here. Whether and how you translate it will depend on your interpretation of the verse. See the following note. Connect this verse part to the previous verse part in a way that is natural for the flow of thought.

God has called you to live in peace: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as God has called you to live in

peace is literally “In peace God has called you/us.” The word translated as called means “invited, summoned, chosen.” See the notes on 1:1a, 1:2c, and 1:9, where the same word appears. God has chosen/invited us to be his people, part of his family, and he wants his people to live in peace. In some languages it may be necessary to make some of this implicit information clear in the translation. For example:

God chose you and wants you to live in peace. (CEV)

There are two ways to interpret this verse part:

1. It explains why Christians should not separate from their unbelieving spouses. It means “But if possible, remain married to your unbelieving husband or wife, for God has called you to live in peace.” God wants us to live in harmony and get along with our husband or wife, even if he or she is not a Christian. This interpretation is implied by the NCV:

When this happens, the Christian man or woman is free. But God called us to live in peace. Wife, you don’t know; maybe you will save your husband. (NCV) (NCV, NJB)

1. It explains why a believer should let his or her unbelieving spouse depart. It means “If your unbelieving husband or wife wants to divorce you, let them divorce you, for God has called you to live in peace.” In other words, it will be difficult to live a peaceful life with an unbelieving husband or wife who wants to divorce you, so it is better to divorce. For example:

In such cases the husband or wife is not required to stay with them, for God wants his children to live in peace. (NLT) (RSV, CEV, NLT, REB)

Several English versions leave this open or ambiguous (BSB, GNT, NET, GW, KJV, NASB, ESV, NRSV). It is probably best to see this as a general statement that indicates that the believer should try to live in peace with their spouse, maintaining the marriage if possible, and living in peaceful separation if not. A peaceful separation may also hold out hope of salvation and reconciliation.

you: There is a textual problem here. Some Greek manuscripts have a second-person plural pronoun (you) and some have a first-person plural pronoun (“us”). The two options are:

1. The original Greek text said you. For example:

God has called you to live in peace. (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NJB, NET, NRSV, GW, CEV)

1. The original Greek text said “us.” For example:

God has called us in peace. (RSV) (RSV, NIV, KJV, NASB, NCV, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This is the reading in the Greek UBS text. This reading is given a B rating in the 4th edition. In some languages it may be unnatural to use a second-person pronoun, or this may imply that Paul was not called to live in peace. In these languages it may be necessary to use an inclusive first-person plural pronoun.

in peace: The words in peace describe the way a believer is to live. Paul puts these words first in the sentence to show that they are emphatic, that is, these words are the most important part of the sentence. The words in peace can include the idea of living in harmony with others and peacefully inside oneself. In some languages it may be natural to translate the abstract noun peace as an adjective or adverb. For example:

a peaceful life

peacefully

1 Corinthians 7:16

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul’s answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person’s husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed

Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul’s teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:12–16

Paul now discussed the case of believers married to unbelievers. Paul had first preached the gospel in Corinth only three or four years before he wrote this letter. So most believers in Corinth had only been believers for a few years. Some men had become believers but their wives had not. And some women had become believers but their husbands had not. Apparently some people in Corinth were wondering whether Christians should remain married to unbelievers. Paul’s answer was that the believer is not to ask for a divorce. But if the unbelieving husband or wife chooses to leave, the believer need not think he or she has to stay married to that person.

7:16a–b

This verse connects to the previous verse with a conjunction that the KJV translates as “For.” This conjunction indicates that this verse gives a reason for living in peace.

How do you know, wife, whether you will save your husband? Or how do you know, husband, whether you will save your wife?:

In the first of these questions, Paul addressed Christian women who are married to men who are not Christians. In the second question, he addressed Christian men who are married to women who are not Christians. These are both rhetorical questions. There are two ways to understand these questions:

1. Paul was speaking in a hopeful way: “Who knows? Perhaps you, believer, will cause your spouse to become a believer.” For example:

Wife, you don’t know; maybe you will save your husband. And husband, you don’t know; maybe you will save your wife. (NCV) (NLT, NRSV, GNT, NCV, REB)

1. Paul was speaking in a pessimistic or discouraging way: “Who knows? Perhaps you will never cause

your husband/wife to become a believer.” For example:

how do you know if you will be able to save your husband or wife? (CEV)

The BSB, NET, NASB, KJV, NIV, NJB, RSV, ESV, and GW are ambiguous. It is recommended that you translate this in an ambiguous, open-ended way so that either answer is possible. If that is not possible, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

7:16a

How do you know, wife, whether you will save your husband?

- Wives, do you^(sing) know if you will bring/lead your husband to salvation? No, you do not know.
- You^(plur) Christian wives may cause your non-Christian husbands to become Christians. You do not know what will happen.
- I ask you believing wives: Will your^(sing) husband follow Christ because of you? Perhaps/Possibly.

How do you know, wife, whether you will save your husband?: The Greek word that the BSB translates as save in this context means “help/lead someone to receive salvation.” Paul meant that the woman might help her husband to believe in Jesus so that God would save him. (Paul uses the word save in this same way in 1 Corinthians 9:22 and Romans 11:14.)

This is a rhetorical question. It indicates that a believing wife does not know whether or not she will be able to help her husband to believe in Jesus and be saved. There are two ways to translate this question:

- as a rhetorical question, possibly with an answer supplied. For example:

as a wife, how can you tell whether you are to be the salvation of your husband...? (NJB)

- as a statement. For example:

You do not know—perhaps you will save your husband.

7:16b

Or how do you know, husband, whether you will save your wife?

- And husbands, do you know if you will bring/lead your wife to salvation? No, you do not know.
- In the same way, perhaps you Christian husbands will help your wives to believe in the Lord as you do.

- This is true for you also, you believing husbands: Perhaps your wife will follow Christ also because of you.

Or: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Or here introduces a second rhetorical question, this time addressed to the believing husband. In some languages it may be natural to follow the RSV and not translate this conjunction explicitly.

how do you know, husband...?: Consider whether it is natural to translate this question using exactly the same phrasing as the question in the previous verse part, or whether some variation is natural and desirable. The meaning should be the same. Neither the believing husband nor the believing wife can know if they will be able to save their unbelieving spouse.

1 Corinthians 7:17

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul’s answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person’s husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul’s teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:17–24

In these verses Paul taught the Corinthians his general rule or principle: “Remain as you are.” He said that a believer does not have to change his or her situation in life to please God. So each believer should try to stay the way they were when God called them to belong to Christ. They could serve him as Jew or Gentile, married or single, and slave or free. They could please God in whatever situation he has put them.

In these verses Paul began by giving his general rule (7:17). Then he gave an example of this rule: When you become a Christian, it does not matter if you are circumcised or not; just stay that way (7:18–19). Then he repeated the general rule (7:20). Then he gave a second example: When you become a Christian, it does not matter if you are a slave; you can serve God as a slave or as a free man (7:21–23). Then he repeated his general rule (7:24).

7:17a**Regardless, each one should lead the life**

- ¶ Except for that case, it is best for every believer to remain/continue living in the condition/situation
- ¶ But in general each of you should continue to live

Regardless: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Regardless here introduces Paul’s general principle to which 7:15–16 was an exception. It can also be translated as:

apart from that situation

except in a case like that

but in general

each one should lead the life: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as each one should lead the life is literally “so/thus let him walk.” The word “walk” is an idiom meaning to live day by day. (See the notes on 3:3d.) The word “so/thus” refers to the situation to which the Lord assigned the believer at the time when God called him. Other ways to translate this include:

so must he live (NET)

let each person lead the life (ESV)

let everyone continue in the part (NJB)

7:17b**that the Lord has assigned to him**

- that the Lord Jesus gave to them
- the way the Lord has given you to live,

the Lord has assigned to him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as has assigned refers to dividing up and giving out something. This is a figure of speech. Paul said that the Lord has placed each believer in a certain situation or place in life. Here is another way to translate this:

whatever situation the Lord has put you in (NLT)

When a person first believes in Jesus, he may be a slave or free, married or unmarried. God wants him to serve Christ in the situation he is in. He should not think he must change that place so that he can be a better follower of the Lord.

to him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to him is literally “to each one,” and means “to each believer.”

7:17c**and to which God has called him.**

- and where/as they were when God called them to be his own/people.
- the way you were when God chose you to serve/believe him.

and to which God has called him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as called means “invited, summoned.” See the notes on 7:15c, 1:1a, 1:2c, and 1:9. There are two ways of understanding the meaning of this verb:

1. It refers to the call of God to salvation. For example:

[let everyone continue]...as he was when God called him (NJB) (GNT, RSV, NLT, NCV, NJB, REB, CEV)

1. It refers to the call of God to a situation or condition in life. For example:

[let each person lead the life]...to which God called him (ESV) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NASB, NRSV, ESV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation is more likely, based on the way the word called is used in verse 18. In some languages it may be helpful to say explicitly to what God called believers. For example:

when God called them to be his own (CEV)

In some languages it may be natural use the second-person pronoun “you” as the GNT has done:

Each of you should go on living...as you were when God called you. (GNT)

General Comment on 7:17a-c

The BSB has reordered the verse parts. The Greek order of this verse is as follows:

Except, ^{17b}as the Lord assigned to each person, ^{17c}as God has called each person, ^{17a}so/thus let him/her walk.

In some languages it may be natural to follow the Greek order, as the NET has done:

Only, ^{17b}as the Lord has assigned to each one, ^{17c}as God has called each person, ^{17a}so let him live. (NET)

The NLT provides another model of how to reorder this verse:

You must accept ^{17b}whatever situation the Lord has put you in, ^{17a}and continue on as you were ^{17c}when God first called you. (NLT)

7:17d

This is what I prescribe in all the churches.

- This is the same thing I tell believers to do in every church group I go to.
- Whenever I go to visit any of the other churches, I tell them to follow this same teaching/principle.

This is what I prescribe in all the churches: To prescribe something means to tell people a rule, or to order people to follow a rule. Paul is talking about a general principle or guideline. Other ways to translate this include:

This is my rule for all the churches. (NLT)

This is a rule I make in all the churches. (NCV)

I give this sort of direction in all the churches (NET)

what I prescribe: In some languages it may be more natural to translate the phrase what I prescribe as a noun phrase. For example:

the rule I lay down (NIV)

General Comment on 7:17a-d

In some languages it may be clearer to place 7:17d at the beginning of the verse. For example:

^{17d}In every church I tell the people ^{17a}to stay living in the situation ^{17b}that the Lord had put them in ^{17c}when God called them to be his own. Now I say the same thing to you. (compare the CEV)

1 Corinthians 7:18

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:17–24

In these verses Paul taught the Corinthians his general rule or principle: “Remain as you are.” He said that a

believer does not have to change his or her situation in life to please God. So each believer should try to stay the way they were when God called them to belong to Christ. They could serve him as Jew or Gentile, married or single, and slave or free. They could please God in whatever situation he has put them.

In these verses Paul began by giving his general rule (7:17). Then he gave an example of this rule: When you become a Christian, it does not matter if you are circumcised or not; just stay that way (7:18–19). Then he repeated the general rule (7:20). Then he gave a second example: When you become a Christian, it does not matter if you are a slave; you can serve God as a slave or as a free man (7:21–23). Then he repeated his general rule (7:24).

7:18a

Was a man already circumcised when he was called?

- For example, if God calls a man to become one of his people, and this man is a Jew and so he has already been circumcised,
- What I mean is this: If you are a man who was already circumcised according to the Jewish custom, and later God called/chose you to become a Christian/believer,

Was a man already circumcised when he was called?: This is a rhetorical question. It introduces a possible scenario. There are several ways to translate it:

- using a rhetorical question. For example:

Was anyone called after he had been circumcised? (NET)

- using a conditional clause. For example:

If a man was already circumcised... (NCV)

If you were already circumcised at the time when you became a believer...

- as a descriptive clause. For example:

a man who was circumcised before he became a believer [should not try to reverse it] (NLT)

Introduce this situation in a way that is natural in your language.

Was a man already circumcised...?: This is a passive clause. There are two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

If someone has already been circumcised

If you are already circumcised (CEV)

- using an active verb. For example:

Had someone circumcised you?

Has someone already received circumcision?

Use the expression that is natural in your language. If necessary and natural, use a euphemism.

already circumcised: In these verses, a circumcised person refers to a male who was a Jew and who worshiped God as Jewish people did. All Jewish boys were circumcised, usually on the eighth day after they were born. This was the mark of being a Jewish male.

In some languages it may be natural to translate the verb circumcised with a noun and a verb:

already received circumcision

when he was called: This refers to the time when God saved a man and he became a believer. There are two ways to translate this:

- using a passive verb. For example:

when he was called to be a Christian (NCV)

- using an active verb. For example:

when God called/saved him/you.

he became a believer (NLT)

accepted God's call (GNT)

7:18b

He should not become uncircumcised.

- this man does not need to change his body so he no longer is circumcised.
- you should not try to remove the mark/sign of circumcision from your body.

- then I do not want you/him to do anything to change that.

He should not become uncircumcised: The Greek word that the BSB translates as become uncircumcised is a medical word for a surgical operation to try to hide a circumcision. You may want to translate the meaning in a way such as the following:

hide the circumcision

change the circumcision to look like uncircumcision

remove the sign of circumcision

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Was anyone called after he had received circumcision? He should not try to hide the fact. (NET)

If you are already circumcised, don't change it. (CEV)

7:18c

Was a man still uncircumcised when called?

- Another example: if God calls a man to become one of his people, and this man is not a Jew and so he has not been circumcised,
- Likewise, if you^(sing) are a man who was not circumcised when God called/chose you to become a Christian/believer,
- Or if you^(sing) had not been circumcised before God called/chose you to belong to Christ,

7:18d

He should not be circumcised.

- this man does not need to get circumcised.
- then I do not want you^(sing) to allow people to circumcise you.
- you do not have to follow the Jewish customs by getting circumcised in order to please God.

7:18c-d

Was a man still uncircumcised when called? He should not be circumcised: You will probably want to translate this using the same pattern as you did in the previous two verse parts. Again, consider whether a rhetorical question is clear and natural here.

He should not be circumcised: Paul was not absolutely forbidding the practice of circumcision (for he himself approved of Timothy being circumcised in Acts

16:3). Rather, he was saying that it is not necessary. It does not make any difference to God whether a person is circumcised or uncircumcised. As in 7:18a, it is possible to translate be circumcised with an active verb:

He should not receive circumcision.

He should not order/allow someone to circumcise him.

1 Corinthians 7:19

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:17–24

In these verses Paul taught the Corinthians his general rule or principle: "Remain as you are." He said that a believer does not have to change his or her situation in life to please God. So each believer should try to stay the way they were when God called them to belong to Christ. They could serve him as Jew or Gentile, married

or single, and slave or free. They could please God in whatever situation he has put them.

In these verses Paul began by giving his general rule (7:17). Then he gave an example of this rule: When you become a Christian, it does not matter if you are circumcised or not; just stay that way (7:18–19). Then he repeated the general rule (7:20). Then he gave a second example: When you become a Christian, it does not matter if you are a slave; you can serve God as a slave or as a free man (7:21–23). Then he repeated his general rule (7:24).

7:19a

Circumcision is nothing and uncircumcision is nothing.

- It does not matter if a person is circumcised or not circumcised.
- We cannot please God more by getting circumcised. And we cannot please him more by not getting circumcised.
- It does not matter to God whether a man is circumcised or uncircumcised.

Circumcision is nothing and uncircumcision is nothing: The custom of circumcision was very important to the Jewish people. It was a mark that they were the descendants of Abraham and that God had made an agreement with them. But Paul said that it was not important. He meant that we cannot please God or make ourselves more holy by being circumcised or by not being circumcised. Customs like circumcision only affect us physically. These customs cannot make us more holy. In the agreements or covenants that God made with Abraham and his descendants (Genesis 17:9–14) and with the nation Israel (Joshua 5:2–8), God commanded that all the boy babies be circumcised as a sign that they were joined together with God. But since God began his new agreement by sending his Son Jesus Christ to die as a complete sin payment, he no longer commands that boy babies be circumcised. Paul also taught that in Romans 2:28–29 and in Galatians 5:1–6. Other ways to translate this include:

For it makes no difference whether or not a man has been circumcised. (NLT)

It is not important whether a man is circumcised or not. (NCV)

Being circumcised or uncircumcised isn't really what matters. (CEV)

7:19b

Keeping God's commandments is what counts.

- What is important is that we^(incl) do what God tells us.
- We can please God only by doing/obeying what he commands us to do.

Keeping God's commandments is what counts:

The Greek text literally says “but keeping God's commandments.” The “but” shows the contrast between something like circumcision which does not matter to God, and keeping God's commandments, which does matter to God.

The BSB has supplied the words is what counts to make the sentence complete. The CEV completes the sentence in a different way:

The important thing is to obey God's commands. (CEV)

God's commandments: In this context the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as God's commandments refers to God's moral laws. Those include the Ten Commandments that God gave to Moses and other moral and ethical laws that came from them. Jesus and the apostles explained how those moral laws were to tell us how to live. When Moses gave God's laws to the Israelite people under the first covenant/agreement, there were three kinds of laws: (1) The moral laws, that is, the Ten Commandments, giving the main rules for living, telling people what is right and what is wrong for them to do. (2) The ceremonial laws, rules for worshiping God under the first covenant. These included the system of sacrifices and offerings. (3) The civil laws, telling the people how to rule the nation. After Jesus came to earth and gave himself to God as the complete sin payment, God did away with the ceremonial laws because they were no longer needed. But Jesus taught people how to live following God's moral laws. The teachings of Paul and the other apostles came from the teaching of Christ. See, for example, the Sermon on the Mount in Matthew 5–7 and the Great Commission in Matthew 28:18–20. In 1 Corinthians 7:19 Paul was talking about God's moral laws as taught by Jesus and the apostles. See Law, “Teachings of Christ” in KBT. Paul was not referring to the Jewish ceremonial law, of which being circumcised was a part.

1 Corinthians 7:20

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

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Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:17–24

In these verses Paul taught the Corinthians his general rule or principle: "Remain as you are." He said that a believer does not have to change his or her situation in life to please God. So each believer should try to stay the way they were when God called them to belong to Christ. They could serve him as Jew or Gentile, married or single, and slave or free. They could please God in whatever situation he has put them.

In these verses Paul began by giving his general rule (7:17). Then he gave an example of this rule: When you become a Christian, it does not matter if you are circumcised or not; just stay that way (7:18–19). Then he repeated the general rule (7:20). Then he gave a second example: When you become a Christian, it does not matter if you are a slave; you can serve God as a slave or as a free man (7:21–23). Then he repeated his general rule (7:24).

7:20

Each one should remain in the situation he was in when he was called.

- Each believer should remain living in the situation/condition he was in when God called/chose him/her to become one of his people.
- When you become a believer, it is best if you do not try to change your position in life. You should keep on living the way you were when God called/chose you to become a believer.

Each one should remain in the situation he was in when he was called: This verse says almost the same thing as 7:17. Paul repeated that the believers were to remain as they were when they came to believe on Christ. This is a major theme of this chapter.

1 Corinthians 7:21

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

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Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:17–24

In these verses Paul taught the Corinthians his general rule or principle: "Remain as you are." He said that a

believer does not have to change his or her situation in life to please God. So each believer should try to stay the way they were when God called them to belong to Christ. They could serve him as Jew or Gentile, married or single, and slave or free. They could please God in whatever situation he has put them.

In these verses Paul began by giving his general rule (7:17). Then he gave an example of this rule: When you become a Christian, it does not matter if you are circumcised or not; just stay that way (7:18–19). Then he repeated the general rule (7:20). Then he gave a second example: When you become a Christian, it does not matter if you are a slave; you can serve God as a slave or as a free man (7:21–23). Then he repeated his general rule (7:24).

7:21a

Were you a slave when you were called?

- For example, if you were a slave when God called you to become one of his people,
- What I mean is this: Some of you were slaves when you obeyed/accepted God's call/invitation to follow Christ.

Were you a slave when you were called?: As in 7:18a and c, Paul asked a rhetorical question. This introduces a possible scenario or situation. There are two ways to translate this:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Were you called as a slave? (NET)

- as a statement using a conditional clause. For example:

If you were a slave when you were called...

In Greek the word translated you is singular. It is as though Paul were speaking to only one person. But actually his words are for any believer who is a slave, so this could be translated as a plural. You should translate it in a way that is natural in your language for addressing multiple people. For example:

Were you^(plur) slaves...?

slave: The Greek word that the BSB translates as slave refers to someone who belonged to their master as a possession. Slaves normally worked without pay. Their owners gave them food, clothes, and a place to stay. They were not allowed to leave their masters and their

work. Many of the believers in Corinth were probably slaves.

when you were called: The words when you were called refer to the time when the slave became a believer. There are two ways to translate them:

- using a passive verb. For example:

when you were called (REB)

- using an active verb. For example:

when God called you (GNT)

7:21b

Do not let it concern you—

- you must not feel bad about that.
- If that is true for you, do not worry about it.

Do not let it concern you: Paul was talking to slaves who were believers. It is likely that some of them thought they could serve Jesus Christ better if they were free. Paul wanted them to know that even if they were slaves, Jesus Christ was in control of their lives and their situation in life. They should be content to live as his followers, no matter what their situation was. Other ways to translate this include:

Don't let that bother you. (NCV)

Don't let that worry you. (CEV)

Don't be sad/hurt in your heart, saying, "I cannot be a good follower of Christ if I am only a slave."

7:21c

but if you can gain your freedom, take the opportunity.

- However, if you are able to become a free person, then do that.
- But if your master lets you go free, then go.

but: The Greek word that the BSB translates as but here introduces an exception or limitation to what Paul had just said. The slaves should not be troubled about their situation, but that did not mean Paul required them to remain slaves for always. Paul told them to gain their freedom if they could.

if you can gain your freedom, take the opportunity: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as take the opportunity is literally "rather/instead use it." There

are two ways to understand how a slave should “use” this situation:

1. Slaves should make use of their chance to be free by becoming free. For example:

but if you get a chance to be free, take it (NLT)
(BSB, CEV, NLT, NIV, RSV, GNT, NET, NCV, GW, REB,
NASB, KJV, ESV)

1. Slaves should make use of their slavery by remaining a slave and living as a slave in a way that honors the Lord. For example:

even if you have a chance of freedom, you should prefer to make full use of your condition as a slave (NJB) (NRSV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the interpretation that almost all English versions follow. Here are some reasons for following the first interpretation: (1) The verb “use it” in Greek is in the past tense (aorist), which means it is something that happens at a specific time. This fits better with the meaning “If you get the opportunity to become free, take it.” This past tense does not fit well if Paul was saying: “If you get the opportunity to become free, remain a slave and work for the Lord as a slave.” (2) Paul did not tell slaves to run away (see Philemon 10–16), but he did know that many slave owners decided to free their slaves for one reason or another. (3) When Paul says, “do so,” we ask, do what? The answer is: “Make use of your opportunity to become free.” (4) The main thing Paul was saying in chapter 7 was “Remain as you are.” But already several times in this chapter he had given some exceptions to this rule. In 7:3–5a he gave a rule that married couples should not stop having sex with each other; but then in 7:5b–c he gave an exception to that rule. In 7:8 he gave a rule that Christians whose husband or wife had died should remain unmarried; then in 7:9 he gave an exception to that rule. In 7:12–14 he gave a rule that Christians who are married to non-Christians should not divorce their spouse; then in 7:15 he gave an exception to that rule. The same thing is true here in 7:21. In 7:21a–b Paul said that Christians who are slaves should not worry about being a slave; they can be good Christians as slaves. But in 7:21c he gave an exception: he said that if a slave can become free, that is all right too, and he should do it. (5) In the Roman world, slaves probably did not have a choice to remain slaves or to be freed. If their masters chose to free them, they probably had to accept it.

gain your freedom: In some languages it may be natural to translate the noun freedom with an adjective. For example:

become free (JBP)

1 Corinthians 7:22

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul’s answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person’s husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul’s teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:17–24

In these verses Paul taught the Corinthians his general rule or principle: “Remain as you are.” He said that a believer does not have to change his or her situation in life to please God. So each believer should try to stay the way they were when God called them to belong to Christ. They could serve him as Jew or Gentile, married or single, and slave or free. They could please God in whatever situation he has put them.

In these verses Paul began by giving his general rule (7:17). Then he gave an example of this rule: When you become a Christian, it does not matter if you are

circumcised or not; just stay that way (7:18-19). Then he repeated the general rule (7:20). Then he gave a second example: When you become a Christian, it does not matter if you are a slave; you can serve God as a slave or as a free man (7:21-23). Then he repeated his general rule (7:24).

7:22a

For he who was a slave when he was called by the Lord is the Lord's freedman.

- For a person who was a slave when he was called to become a Christian is now a freedman to/of the Lord.
- It is all right either way because even if you were a slave at the time when God called/invited you to be united with the Lord Jesus, the Lord Jesus has made you his own and freed you from the power of evil/wrongdoing.

For: This verse begins with the connecting word For. Paul was giving the basis for what he said in 7:21a-b, that the Christian slave need not be distressed about his slavery.

he who was a slave when he was called by the Lord is the Lord's freedman: Christians who are slaves should not be worried about being slaves, for God accepts all believers as his people and can use them whether are slaves or not. A person's place in life is not the important thing in God's eyes/opinion.

he was called by the Lord: There are two ways to understand the Greek words that the BSB translates as he was called by the Lord:

1. It means "he was called in the Lord." Paul was talking about slaves whom God called to be "in the Lord," that is, God called/chose them to become believers. For example:

the one who was called in the Lord (NET) (REB, NJB, KJV, NASB, RSV, ESV, NET)

1. It means "he was called by the Lord," that is, the Lord is the one who called the slave. For example:

If the Lord called you (GW) (BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV, NLT, GW, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In the NT the phrase "in the Lord" almost always means "as a Christian." Read Pam Bendor-Samuel's article 'In Christ'—Another Look at Its Meaning in the NT, 1998, published by SIL. In section 6.1 of her article, Bendor-Samuel says that the phrase "in the Lord" occurs more

than 50 times in the NT, and that it almost always means "as a Christian."

he was called: This is in the passive. In some languages it may be natural to translate it with an active verb and to supply the subject "God":

God called him

See also 7:17c, 7:18a, and 7:21a.

the Lord's freedman: The Greek word that the BSB translates as freedman refers to someone who used to be a slave but is now free. In this context this is a figure of speech. The Christian slave is actually still a slave in the human way of thinking, but God has rescued him from being like a slave to wrongdoing. He no longer has to do all the bad things people want to do. Paul encouraged and comforted slaves by reminding them of the kind of freedom they have as Christians.

This metaphor has several components or aspects of meaning:

- the Christian slave is free from the power of sin
- the Lord is the one who made the slave free
- the freedman belongs to the Lord, who is his protector or patron
- the freedman is obliged to serve his protector/patron

Most English versions translate the metaphor literally, so that any or all of the above components can be understood (see the BSB, NIV, GNT, KJV, NASB, REB, NET, GW, RSV, and ESV). Some English versions focus on one or the other of the components. For example:

is a freedman belonging to the Lord (NRSV)

free persons who belong to the Lord (NCV)

free in the Lord (NLT)

his free people (CEV)

It is recommended that you translate this metaphor in a general way that allows readers to understand any or all of these aspects.

7:22b

Conversely, he who was a free man when he was called is Christ's slave.

- In the same way, a person who was free when God called/chose him to become a Christian now belongs to Christ and so is Christ's slave.
- In the same way, if you were without a master when God called/invited you to be joined together with the Lord Jesus Christ, you now belong to Christ and he is your master.

Conversely, he who was a free man when he was called is Christ's slave: Paul now addressed believers who were not slaves. The term free man means anyone who is not a slave. It includes both people who used to be slaves but are now free, and also people who have never been slaves.

Christ's slave: This is a figure of speech. When a free man believes in Jesus, he is still a free man in earthly terms, but when he believed in Jesus Christ, God joined him together with Christ. He now belongs to Christ and is under Christ's control. See Ephesians 6:9, Colossians 4:1, and Romans 6:18–22.

1 Corinthians 7:23

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:17–24

In these verses Paul taught the Corinthians his general rule or principle: "Remain as you are." He said that a believer does not have to change his or her situation in life to please God. So each believer should try to stay the way they were when God called them to belong to Christ. They could serve him as Jew or Gentile, married or single, and slave or free. They could please God in whatever situation he has put them.

In these verses Paul began by giving his general rule (7:17). Then he gave an example of this rule: When you become a Christian, it does not matter if you are circumcised or not; just stay that way (7:18–19). Then he repeated the general rule (7:20). Then he gave a second example: When you become a Christian, it does not matter if you are a slave; you can serve God as a slave or as a free man (7:21–23). Then he repeated his general rule (7:24).

7:23a

You were bought at a price;

- God paid a high/big price for you^(sing).
- Jesus Christ paid for you with his blood/life.

You were bought at a price: Here Paul was speaking to all believers, both slaves and free people. This verse part is the same as 6:20a. See the notes on 6:20a. This is a metaphor taken from the custom of buying slaves in the market. When a man bought a slave, he owned him and the slave was obliged to obey his new master. In a similar way God paid for our freedom. So a believer does not belong to himself. He or she belongs to God.

This verse part uses a passive verb. There are two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

You were bought with a price. (NET)

- Using an active verb. The actor could be either Christ or God. For example:

God paid a great price for you. (CEV)

7:23b

do not become slaves of men.

- So do not become slaves of any human being.
- Therefore do not obey people in place of God/Christ/him.

do not become slaves of men: The phrase slaves of men is a figure of speech here. Paul was saying that he wanted the Corinthians to remember that Christ was their new master. They were not to follow or obey anyone who told them to do anything different from what Christ told them. Other ways to translate this include:

Don't become anyone else's slave. (compare the CEV)

men: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as men refers to any human being other than Christ himself.

1 Corinthians 7:24

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

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life to please God. So each believer should try to stay the way they were when God called them to belong to Christ. They could serve him as Jew or Gentile, married or single, and slave or free. They could please God in whatever situation he has put them.

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7:24

Brothers, each one should remain in the situation he was in when God called him.

- So then, my fellow believers, I want each one of you, with God's help, to stay/remain in the place/situation in life you were in when God called/chose you.
- And so, my fellow believers, we^(incl) each should keep on living the same kind of life we^(incl) had when God called/chose us to become one of his people, for he is near to help us.

Brothers, each one should remain in the situation he was in when God called him:

Paul ended this paragraph by repeating his main teaching: Remain in the situation/place you were in at the time God called you and joined you together with Christ. The words here are similar to what Paul said in 7:17 and 7:20.

After the phrase that the BSB translates as each one should remain, the Greek text includes a phrase that can be translated as "with God" or "at the side of God" or "near God." There are two ways to understand what that means here:

1. It means "with God at his side to help." God is near to help the believer no matter what his place in life. Paul was comforting and encouraging the believers. Here is another way to translate this:

My friends, each of you should remain in fellowship with God in the same condition that you were when you were called. (GNT) (GNT, GW and probably the KJV, RSV, ESV, NET, NCV, and NASB, which all say "with God")

1. It means "before God," that is, in the sight or presence of God, or with God looking on. Since God is watching, the believer should live in a way pleasing

to God no matter what his place in life is. For example:

So, my friends, everyone is to remain before God in the condition in which he received his call. (REB) (NIV, NJB, REB)

The BSB, CEV, and NLT do not explicitly translate this phrase. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions. Paul wanted to remind the believers that God is present and can make each one content wherever he is.

Brothers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Brothers refers to all the Corinthian believers. Paul was addressing them in an affectionate way as members of the family of faith. The GNT translates it as “My friends.”

each one: The Greek word that the BSB translates as each one refers to each one of the group of believers.

should remain in the situation he was in when God called him: There are two ways to understand Paul’s meaning here:

1. Paul meant that God called the believers to himself in a situation. They should remain in the situation they were in at that time. For example:

stay as you were when you were called (NCV) (BSB, RSV, GNT, NJB, NCV, CEV, NLT, GW, NET, NASB, ESV)

1. Paul meant that God called the believer to a situation. For example:

remain in the situation God called him to (NIV) (NIV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is in agreement with the meaning of 7:17. See the note there.

General Comment on 7:24

In some languages it may be natural to translate this verse using the inclusive pronoun “we” (referring to all Christians):

And so, Christian brothers and sisters, whatever way of life we had when God called us to belong to him, we do not have to change that. Let us keep living that same way of life, with God helping us.

1 Corinthians 7:25

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul’s answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person’s husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

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Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul’s teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:25–28

Paul now began to talk to the believers about those people in their group who were not married. Perhaps some of the Corinthian believers were thinking: “A person will be more holy and please God more if he remains unmarried.” Paul agreed that there are good reasons to remain unmarried. But he did not believe that it was a sin to get married. Paul allowed each person to choose for himself.

7:25a

Now about virgins,

- ¶ Now I will answer the question you asked me about the unmarried women.
- ¶ Now I will talk about what the single women should do.

Now about: The Greek words that the BSB translates as Now about here indicate that Paul was starting to talk about something else the Corinthians had written

in their letter to him. He used this same phrase at several other places in 1 Corinthians to introduce a new topic (7:1, 8:1, 12:1, 16:1, 16:12). Introduce this new topic in a way that is natural for your language. Another way to translate this is:

Now about what you said in your letter

virgins: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as virgins refers to people who have never had sexual intercourse. There are two ways to interpret it in this context:

1. It refers to women only. This is the normal meaning of the English word virgins. The root form of this Greek word is used five more times in this paragraph. In all five of those occurrences it refers to women. For example:

the young women who are not yet married (NLT)
(BSB, KJV, NIV, NASB, NRSV, GW, NLT)

1. It refers to both men and women. For example:

people who have never been married (NET) (RSV, GNT, NET, NJB, REB, CEV, ESV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In the following verses Paul used the Greek word for “virgin” five more times. Each time the word clearly refers to a young woman so it is likely Paul had the same meaning in focus here. Also, the majority of commentaries follow interpretation (1).

7:25b

I have no command from the Lord,

- The Lord Jesus did not give me a command/rule about that.
- The Lord Jesus has not told me what is best for them to do.

I have no command from the Lord: This verse part indicates that as far as Paul knew, the Lord Jesus had not taught specifically about this topic. Nor had Paul received any special revelation concerning this from the Lord. Another way to translate this is:

I do not have a command from the Lord for them.
(NLT)

The Lord has not given me a command concerning them.

7:25c

but I give a judgment as one who by the Lord's mercy is trustworthy.

- However, the Lord has been very kind to me, and so I believe you can trust what I say about this.
- And yet, because the Lord has helped me to become a person whom people can trust, I will tell you^(plur) what I think is best.
- But I will give you my teaching/advice about this. You should listen to what I say, because the Lord has kindly helped/saved me and given me wisdom.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here indicates a contrast. Paul did not have a command from Jesus to give, but instead he gave his own judgment.

I give a judgment: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as I give a judgment can also be translated as “I give an opinion,” or “I tell you what I think.” In 2 Corinthians 8:10 the BSB translates the same clause as “And this is my opinion....” Paul was telling or advising the Corinthians what he thought they should do. Here is another way to translate this:

I give my opinion (NET)

as one who by the Lord's mercy is trustworthy:

Paul indicated why the Corinthians could trust his judgment or opinion. It was because the Lord had been very kind to him. The Lord had made him a person whom they could trust. Other ways to translate this include:

as one shown mercy by the Lord to be trustworthy
(NET)

I'm a person to whom the Lord has shown mercy,
so I can be trusted. (GW)

the Lord's mercy: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Lord's mercy indicates that the Lord had been merciful to Paul. The Lord had been kind and compassionate to Paul in that he had forgiven him and called him to be an apostle and made him trustworthy. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as:

the Lord has been kind/compassionate to me

trustworthy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as trustworthy refers to someone who deserves trust,

someone who is faithful. The Corinthians could depend on Paul to give them wise advice.

1 Corinthians 7:26

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:25–28

Paul now began to talk to the believers about those people in their group who were not married. Perhaps some of the Corinthian believers were thinking: "A person will be more holy and please God more if he remains unmarried." Paul agreed that there are good reasons to remain unmarried. But he did not believe that it was a sin to get married. Paul allowed each person to choose for himself.

7:26a

Because of the present crisis,

- We^(incl) are living in difficult times. And so because of this,
- Because difficult/hard things are happening to believers during these days,

Because of the present crisis: The Greek word that the BSB translates as crisis refers to a time of trouble or distress. At that time many unbelievers were persecuting believers and making life hard for them. Other ways to translate this include:

The present time is a time of trouble. So... (NCV)

We are now going through hard times. (CEV)

7:26b

I think it is good for a man to remain as he is.

- I advise that you believers remain as you are.
- I suggest it is a good idea for a man to remain as he is.

I think: The Greek words that the BSB translates as I think are more literally "Therefore I judge this good." Since the word "good" occurs again later in the same verse, most English versions avoid using it here. Here is another way to translate this:

the right thing seems to be this: (NJB)

it is good for a man to remain as he is: The Greek words that the BSB translates as it is good for a man to remain as he is are literally "good for a man to be thus." By "thus" Paul was probably referring forward to what he was about to say in 7:27. In other words, believing men who were married should remain married, and believing men who were not married should remain unmarried. However, what he said did not exclude women. The same was true of them. Another way to translate this is to follow the model of the NJB and use the third-person plural "people":

it is good for people to stay as they are (NJB)

General Comment on 7:26a–b

The BSB has reordered the Greek clauses in this verse. The Greek has the words meaning "I think" at the beginning of the verse, as does the RSV:

^{26b}I think that ^{26a}in view of the present distress ^{26b}it is well for a person to remain as he is. (RSV)

These verse parts could also be reordered in the following way:

^{26b}I think it is good for a person to remain as he is, ^{26a}because of the present distress.

Translate this in the order that is natural in your language.

1 Corinthians 7:27

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

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Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:25–28

Paul now began to talk to the believers about those people in their group who were not married. Perhaps some of the Corinthian believers were thinking: "A person will be more holy and please God more if he remains unmarried." Paul agreed that there are good reasons to remain unmarried. But he did not believe that it was a sin to get married. Paul allowed each person to choose for himself.

7:27a-d

Are you committed to a wife?...Are you free of commitment?: There is a problem with the punctuation of the Greek text here. The oldest Greek manuscripts do not have punctuation at all. The two options are:

1. These are questions. For example:

Do you have a wife?...are you divorced from your wife? (GW) (BSB, REB, NIV, GNT, GW, KJV, NASB, RSV, ESV)

1. These are statements. For example:

The one bound to a wife should not seek divorce. (NET) (NET, NJB, NLT, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow option 1. However, in some languages it may not be natural to use rhetorical questions in this way. If this is the case in your language, it may be natural to use conditional statements. For example:

If you are joined to a wife, do not seek to be released; if you are freed of a wife, do not look for a wife. (NJB)

You should use whatever form is more natural in your language for emphasizing something.

7:27a

Are you committed to a wife?

- However, if you are a man who already has a wife,
- But if you are a man who is already married,
- Suppose you are a man who is already married.

Are you committed to a wife?: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Are you committed to a wife? is literally "Have you become tied to a woman?" This is a figure of speech. A man is "tied to a woman" in the sense that he is legally her husband and permanently responsible for her. There are two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Use this or a similar metaphor. For example:

Are you bound in marriage? (REB)

- Translate it without a metaphor. For example:

If you have a wife (NLT)

Translate in the way that is most natural in your language.

you: The Greek pronoun that the BSB translates as you is singular. Paul addressed the men in the Corinthian church. He was not talking to just one person. In some languages it is more natural to translate this using a plural pronoun.

7:27b

Do not seek to be released.

- do not try to find a way to divorce her.
- Do not divorce your wife.

Do not seek to be released: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Do not seek to be released is more literally “Do not seek release.” This is a command. Paul commanded married men to remain married. They should not try to free themselves from the marriage bond. Consider whether it is natural in your language to use this figure of speech here. The RSV translates it using the figure of speech:

Do not seek to be free. (RSV)

7:27c

Are you free of commitment?

- If you do not have a wife,
- If you are an unmarried man,

7:27d

Do not look for a wife.

- do not try to find/obtain a wife.
- do not search for a woman to marry.
- then do not get married.

7:27c-d

Are you free of commitment? Do not look for a wife:

The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as free of commitment probably refers to any men who were not at present married, included the widowed, the never-married, and the divorced. Paul advised such men to remain content in their present situation.

1 Corinthians 7:28

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul’s answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person’s husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed

Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul’s teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:25–28

Paul now began to talk to the believers about those people in their group who were not married. Perhaps some of the Corinthian believers were thinking: “A person will be more holy and please God more if he remains unmarried.” Paul agreed that there are good reasons to remain unmarried. But he did not believe that it was a sin to get married. Paul allowed each person to choose for himself.

7:28a

But if you do marry,

- However, if you do marry,
- But if you do take a wife,

7:28b

you have not sinned.

- you are not sinning.
- you have not done anything wrong in God’s sight/opinion.

7:28a-b

But if you do marry, you have not sinned: Paul was still addressing men who were not married (7:27c-d). Paul agreed with the Corinthian believers that being unmarried is good, but he did not agree with their reasons for it. There is nothing in God’s laws or in Jesus’ teaching saying that it is a sin to marry. So it is wrong to say that a believer can be more holy or more pleasing to God if he remains unmarried. Other ways to translate this include:

But it is not a sin for you to get married.

But getting married is not sinful.

7:28c

And if a virgin marries,

- And if a Christian girl/virgin marries,

- And if the unmarried women you wrote to me about do get married,

7:28d
she has not sinned.

- she not sinning.
- that is not a sin.

7:28c-d

if a virgin marries, she has not sinned: The Greek word that the BSB translates as virgin here refers to any unmarried woman. It was assumed in such a culture that this woman would be a virgin, but this was not Paul's main point here. In your translation, it is fine to use a word implying virginity, like the older English word "maiden." If, however, such a word is normally used only in technical or medical contexts, you may wish to follow the GNT and translate this as:

if an unmarried woman marries, she hasn't committed a sin (GNT)

7:28e

But those who marry will face troubles in this life,

- But as you know, people who get married will suffer difficulties in their daily life,
- However, married people will experience unpleasant/painful things in their life in this world,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces a disadvantage to marrying. Even though it is not sinful, it involves some problems.

those who marry will face troubles in this life: The English idiom face troubles means to experience many difficulties or hard times. The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in this life is literally "in the flesh" and refers to life on this earth. Another way to translate this is:

those who marry will have worldly troubles (RSV)

7:28f

and I want to spare you this.

- and I would like you to be free from suffering such troubles.
- and I do not want you to have to experience/suffer those difficulties.
- and I would like to keep you from having hard things like that happen to you.

I want to spare you this: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as I want to spare you this indicates that Paul wished to keep or protect the Corinthians from experiencing unnecessary trouble. He knew that

marriage and family life could involve a lot of pain and suffering, especially at a time when unbelievers were persecuting Christians. Other ways to translate this include:

I am trying to spare you those problems. (NLT)

I want to protect you from that. (CEV)

General Comment on 7:28e-f

In some languages it may be natural to follow the GNT and combine the information in these verse parts:

But I would rather spare you the everyday troubles that married people will have. (GNT)

1 Corinthians 7:29

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:29–31

Paul addressed the whole group of believers. He told them that the present way of life in this world would not last much longer. He instructed them as to how they should think and live when all will soon change.

7:29a

What I am saying, brothers, is that the time is short.

- ¶ My fellow believers, I will explain what I mean. Our^(incl) time here is brief/limited.
- ¶ And furthermore, my friends, consider this: This time we live in will not last much longer.

What I am saying: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as What I am saying here can literally be translated as: “Now this I declare.” Here Paul introduced some important Christian teaching that is background explanation for what he had just said.

brothers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as brothers here refers to the believers in the church.

the time is short: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as the time is short is more literally “the time has been shortened.” Paul was saying that the time had become or grown brief/short. Soon God will change the world and the way people live in it. Other ways to translate this include:

we^(incl) do not have much time

only a short while remains

the time we live in will not last long (REB)

there is not much time left (GNT)

the time: The Greek word that the BSB translates as time refers to a period of time set aside for a purpose. Here it refers to the time God has set aside to finish his work. That time will end when Christ comes back to earth again.

7:29b-31a

These five verse parts are very similar in form. Each of them is a polite or soft command. Paul was telling the Corinthian believers how he wanted them to live. He wanted them to realize that the things of this earthly life are not the most important. Christ will return and then all these things will come to an end. Things like marrying and buying are all part of our life in this world and will not last forever.

In some languages it may be natural to translate these indirect third-person commands as polite second-person commands. For example:

From now on I want those of you who have wives to live as if you had no wives, those of you who weep as though you did not weep, those of you who are joyful, as though you were not, and those of you who make a purchase, as though you had nothing. And those of you who use the things of this world, I want you to not be dependent on them.

For another suggestion as to how to break up the long sentence in the BSB into shorter sentences, see the General Comment on 7:29b-31a at the end of 7:31a.

7:29b

From now on those who have wives should live as if they had none;

- So from this time on, Christian/believing men who are married should live as if they were not married.
- So for the rest of the time we are living in this world, do not be overly/too concerned/worried about your wife/marriage.
- So during the time we have left in this world, remember that having a wife or not is not the most important thing in our life.

those who have wives should live as if they had

none: In this part Paul addressed men, but the same teaching would be true for anyone who was married. Paul wanted them to remember that our time here in this life is short. He did not want them to spend all their time thinking about the things of this life such as marriage. Other ways to translate this include:

those with wives should not focus only on their marriage (NLT)

you married men should not make your wife your main concern

1 Corinthians 7:30

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual

intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1-16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17-24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25-38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39-40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:29-31

Paul addressed the whole group of believers. He told them that the present way of life in this world would not last much longer. He instructed them as to how they should think and live when all will soon change.

7:30a

those who weep, as if they did not;

- Likewise, believers who are mourning/grieving over some sadness/loss should not be too/overly concerned about it.
- If you are weeping now, remember that your sadness/grief is not the most important thing in your life and soon it will be gone.
- And even if you are weeping/crying and being sad, you should go on serving the Lord, since you know that soon you will no longer be sad.

those who weep, as if they did not: This is a short way of saying "those who weep should live as if they did not weep." The Greek word that the BSB translates as weep means to cry from sadness. This verse part implies that something bad has happened. Paul did not want believers to be dominated or controlled by their grief over sad things that happen in this life. Other ways to translate this include:

Those who are crying should live as if they were not crying. (NCV)

Those who weep...should not be absorbed by their weeping. (NLT)

Those who have tears in their eyes should live as though they have no sorrow. (GW)

mourners should be as if they had nothing to grieve them (REB)

7:30b

those who are joyful, as if they were not;

- Likewise, believers who are happy should not think only about being happy.
- If you are happy, remember that your happiness/joy is not the most important thing in your life, and what is making you happy will soon be gone.
- And even if you are laughing and feeling happy, you should not let your happiness make you forget about serving the Lord.

those who are joyful, as if they were not: This is a short way of saying "those who are joyful should live as if they were not joyful." The Greek word that the BSB translates as are joyful means to rejoice over something. People who are joyful about some good thing should remember that this is only a temporary thing. This is not something that is ultimately important. Another way to translate this is:

those who enjoy life should live as though they did not enjoy it (NJB)

7:30c

those who make a purchase, as if they had nothing;

- Likewise believers who buy things should not be too/overly concerned with the things they own.
- If you buy things, remember that having/owning things is not the most important thing in your life, and some day you will no longer own those things.
- And when you buy things, you should consider that they are not yours to possess/enjoy for ever.

those who make a purchase, as if they had nothing:

Paul wanted people to realize that their possessions did not belong to them on a permanent basis. Other ways to translate this include:

those who buy, as though they did not own what they bought

Those who buy things should live as if they own nothing. (NCV)

General Comment on 7:30a-c

In some languages it may help to make Paul's main point clear if you combine these verse parts by using the same verb. For example:

Those who weep or who rejoice or who buy things should not be absorbed by their weeping or their joy or their possessions. (NLT)

1 Corinthians 7:31**Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage**

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:29–31

Paul addressed the whole group of believers. He told them that the present way of life in this world would not last much longer. He instructed them as to how they should think and live when all will soon change.

7:31a

and those who use the things of this world, as if not dependent on them.

- Believers who are busy making a living here in this world should not be concerned only with the things in this world,
- In other words, whenever you do any of these things which people do as part of our life here on earth, do not spend all your time thinking about them,
- When you have anything to do with the things of this world, do not allow these things to be all that you think about.

and those who use the things of this world, as if not dependent on them:

The root of the Greek verb is the same in both clauses of this verse part. In the first clause the BSB translates the word as use. In the second clause the Greek has a stronger form of the same verb, which the BSB translates as dependent.

To use the things of this world means to be involved with anything that has to do with life on this earth, such as buying, selling, eating, getting married, burying the dead, and working to make a living. All these things are what people here on earth do. Believers do these things also. But believers are not to be dependent on them; that is, they are not to be so absorbed in them that they spend all their time thinking about only those things. They are not to allow those things to control them. Believers can still make use of these things, but their primary focus should stay on God. Other ways to translate this include:

those who are involved with the world as though they were people not engrossed in it (NJB)

Those who use the things of the world should not become attached to them (NLT)

General Comment on 7:29b–31a

In some languages it may be helpful to break up this long sentence into several shorter sentences. For example:

^{29b}From now on, if a man has a wife, he must not think of her alone. ^{30a}If a person is distressed in his heart, he must not think only about that. ^{30b}If a person is happy and rejoicing, he must not only think about that. ^{30c}If a person is buying and selling things, he must know that he will not have these things forever. ^{31a}And if he is involved in worldly things/affairs, he must not be absorbed/engrossed in them.

7:31b

For this world in its present form is passing away.

- because the way we^(incl) live in this world now and all these things that are part of our^(incl) life here will soon come to an end.
- because the world we^(incl) are living in now will soon cease.
- I say that for this reason: the way things are here on earth now will not last much longer.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For here introduces the basis for Paul's commands in 7:29–31. People should realize that this world is not permanent, and so should not focus all their energy and attention upon it.

this world in its present form is passing away: The Greek word for form refers to a way of doing things. Paul was saying that the present way of doing things in our lives and in business is coming to an end. Jesus Christ will make those things new and different when he returns. Other ways to translate this include:

this world as we know it is passing away (NJB)

this world, as it is now, will not last much longer (GNT)

1 Corinthians 7:32

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:32–35

Paul addressed the whole group of believers. He wanted them to be “free from concern” (7:32a). Many scholars think that in these verses Paul was giving a reason why he thought it was good to stay unmarried. This paragraph is difficult to interpret.

7:32a

I want you to be free from concern.

- ¶ I want you to be free from anxiety.
- ¶ I do not want you to feel worried/troubled/anxious about how you should live.

I want you to be free from concern: The Greek word that the BSB translates as free from concern here means not worried or anxious. Paul wanted the Corinthian believers to be able to live peaceful lives, trusting in the Lord. Other ways to translate this include:

I want you to be free from worry. (NCV)

I don't want you to have any concerns. (GW)

7:32b

The unmarried man is concerned about the work of the Lord,

- If a man believer does not have a wife, he constantly thinks about the Lord and working for the Lord.
- For example: Christian men who are not married devote their thoughts/energy to serving the Lord.

The unmarried man is concerned about the work of the Lord:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as is concerned about here indicates spending time thinking about something, paying attention to something, and caring about that thing. Although in general this can be a good thing or a bad thing, in this context it is a good thing. Here is one reason why this is probably a good thing: In 7:32b–c, Paul says “The unmarried man is concerned about the work of the Lord, how he can please the Lord.” In other places where Paul talks about pleasing the Lord or pleasing God, it is a good thing. (See Romans 8:8, 1 Thessalonians 2:15, 4:1, and Colossians 1:10, 3:20.) So here in 1 Corinthians 7:32b–c, being “concerned about the work of the Lord” is probably also a good thing. But this interpretation does have difficulties. In 7:32a Paul said he wants the

Corinthian believers to be “free from concern” (Greek: *amerimnos*). So when Paul said in 7:32b-34e that some people are “concerned about the work of the Lord” and other people are “concerned about the affairs of this world,” he may have meant this in a bad sense. Some Corinthian believers were worried about how to please the Lord, and Paul wanted them to learn that they did not have to worry about this. They could please the Lord if they were married or single. Read Gordon Fee’s commentary on 1 Corinthians (pages 342-345) for a discussion of this interpretation problem. See Philipians 2:20, where the same word is used in a positive way. There the BSB translates it as “will genuinely care for [your needs].” Other ways to translate this here include:

A man who is not married is busy with the Lord’s work. (NCV)

An unmarried man can spend his time doing the Lord’s work. (NLT)

The unmarried man gives his mind to the Lord’s affairs. (NJB)

7:32c how he can please the Lord.

- He thinks about what he can do to make the Lord pleased/happy with him.
- They want to please the Lord.

how he can please the Lord: This man wants to please the Lord. This is his goal or aim. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as a direct quote. For example:

He says to himself, “How does the Lord want me to work for him?”

He asks himself, “What can I do to make the Lord happy/pleased with me?”

1 Corinthians 7:33

Section 7:1-40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul’s answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section

Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person’s husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1-16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17-24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25-38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39-40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul’s teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:32-35

Paul addressed the whole group of believers. He wanted them to be “free from concern” (7:32a). Many scholars think that in these verses Paul was giving a reason why he thought it was good to stay unmarried. This paragraph is difficult to interpret.

7:33a

But the married man is concerned about the affairs of this world,

- But if a man has a wife, he constantly thinks about his day-to-day life in this world.
- On the other hand, a man with a wife spends time thinking about getting the things he and his family needs to live from day to day.
- But married men devote their thoughts/energy to things that have to do with living in this world.

But the married man is concerned about the affairs of this world:

This verse part indicates that a man who has a family has to spend much of his time thinking about things of this life. He has to work and provide for his family. Another way to translate this is:

but the man who is married gives his mind to the affairs of this world (NJB)

But a married man has to think about his earthly responsibilities (NLT)

7:33b**how he can please his wife,**

- He wants to take care of his wife.
- They want to make their wife happy.

how he can please his wife: See the notes on 7:32c. As there, it may be natural to translate this as a direct quote. For example:

He asks himself, “How can I make my wife happy/content?”

1 Corinthians 7:34**Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage**

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul’s answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person’s husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

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Paul’s teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:32–35

Paul addressed the whole group of believers. He wanted them to be “free from concern” (7:32a). Many scholars think that in these verses Paul was giving a reason why he thought it was good to stay unmarried. This paragraph is difficult to interpret.

7:34a**and his interests are divided.**

- The outcome of that is this: His thoughts are pulled in two directions/ways.
- And so they must think of two things at once.

his interests are divided: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as his interests are divided is more literally “he is divided.” There is a textual problem here. The UBS Greek text and some old Greek manuscripts connect this verse part to the previous verse part so that it is the married man who is “divided.” This is followed by the BSB and most English versions. But other Greek texts connect this verse part to the following verse part and say “Divided also are the wife/woman and the virgin. The unmarried woman is concerned about the Lord’s affairs....” This is followed by the KJV. It is recommended that you follow the reading of the UBS text and the BSB. Paul meant that the believing husband must and should spend part of his time taking care of his wife. Other ways to translate this include:

his attention is divided (GW)

he is pulled in two directions (GNT)

He must think about two things—pleasing his wife and pleasing the Lord. (NCV)

7:34b**The unmarried woman or virgin is concerned about the work of the Lord,**

- And think about how it is with women believers: If a woman no longer has a husband or has never had a husband, she can be always/constantly thinking about serving the Lord.
- In the same way, a woman who is not married now or who has never married spends her time thinking about what she can do as the Lord’s servant.
- The same is true with Christian women. Women who are not married or who have never been married occupy themselves serving the Lord.

The unmarried woman or virgin: In the rest of 7:34, Paul discussed the difference in the way a married woman believer and an unmarried girl must spend their lives. A married woman takes care of and spends time with her husband and family, while a single woman is free from those things and can use her time to serve the Lord Jesus in other ways.

There are several ways to understand the distinction between an unmarried woman and a virgin here:

1. It means that the first one is no longer married and the second one has never been married at all.
2. The difference is one of age: one is an adult and the other is a girl.
3. There was a special group of young girls in the Corinthian church who were called “virgins.” Perhaps these girls had said they would never get married.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) since it has stronger commentary support.

7:34c

how she can be holy in both body and spirit.

- She wants to be holy in her body and in her spirit.
- She wants to behave in a pure way, both in the physical and in the spiritual realm.
- They want to offer/give their whole beings/lives to God and please him in everything they do and think.

how she can be holy in both body and spirit: The Greek word that the BSB translates as holy refers to being pure or to belonging to the Lord. To be holy in both body and spirit means to be holy in every way: in the way one behaves outwardly (with the body), and in the way one thinks inwardly (in one’s heart/mind/spirit). Another way to translate this is:

her aim is to be dedicated to him [the Lord] in body as in spirit (REB)

In some languages it is not natural to talk about being holy in...body. If this is true of your language, you may want to reword this:

they keep their bodies and minds pure (CEV)

They want to be holy/pure in how they behave outwardly as well as in how they think in their hearts.

They want to be holy/pure in all they do and think.

7:34d

But the married woman is concerned about the affairs of this world,

- But if a woman has a husband, she constantly thinks about her day-to-day life in this world.

- On the other hand, a woman with a husband spends her time thinking about the things her family needs to live from day to day.
- But married women devote their thoughts/energy to things that have to do with living in this world.

But the married woman is concerned about the affairs of this world: The structure and meaning of this verse part is very similar to that of 7:33a. The difference is that 7:33a is about a man and this one is about a woman. You should probably try to translate this verse part in the same way you translated verse part 7:33a.

7:34e

how she can please her husband.

- She wants to please her husband.
- They want to make their husband happy.

how she can please her husband: See the notes on 7:32c and 7:33b. Again, in some languages it may be natural to translate this as a direct quote. For example:

she asks herself, “How can I please my husband?”

1 Corinthians 7:35

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul’s answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person’s husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:32–35

Paul addressed the whole group of believers. He wanted them to be “free from concern” (7:32a). Many scholars think that in these verses Paul was giving a reason why he thought it was good to stay unmarried. This paragraph is difficult to interpret.

7:35a

I am saying this for your own good,

- I talk to you like this because I want to help you think about what is best for you.
- I have said these things to you because I think it will help you to decide for yourself what is best for you to do.

I am saying this for your own good: The word this refers to the things Paul had just said. Paul indicated that he had written in this way in order to help the Corinthian believers. Another way to translate this is:

I'm saying this for your benefit. (GW)

7:35b

not to restrict you,

- I am not giving you commands you must obey.
- I do not want to take away your freedom to decide what is best.
- -or-
- You are free to get married or stay single, and I do not want to limit you.

not to restrict you: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as not to restrict you is literally a figure of speech: “I am not trying to throw a noose over you.” A noose is a rope tied in a circle that is used to catch and tie up animals. Paul meant that he was not giving the Corinthian believers rules that they must obey. He was not trying to take away their freedom to choose how to live for Christ. There are two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- using a metaphor or simile. For example:

I have no wish to keep you on a tight rein. (REB)

- without a figure of speech. For example:

not to limit you (NCV)

7:35c

but in order to promote proper decorum

- Rather, I want to help you to live in a way/manner that is appropriate/fitting,
- On the contrary, I want to help you live/behave as the Lord's people should live/behave.

but in order to promote proper decorum: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in order to promote proper decorum is more literally “to/for what is proper/seemly.” This refers to behavior that is orderly and decent. Paul was indicating that he had written these things to the Corinthians in order to help them to live in ways fitting for people who belong to the Lord. Other ways to translate this include:

to promote what is appropriate (NASB)

I want you to do what is right and proper (GNT)

7:35d

and undivided devotion to the Lord.

- so you can serve the Lord in the best way with nothing worrying/distracting you.
- and so that you can work for the Lord without always having to think of other things you have to do.

and undivided devotion to the Lord: This verse part indicates a second thing that Paul wanted to promote. The first is in 7:35c. Paul wanted to promote or encourage two things: first, what is proper, and second, undivided devotion to the Lord. This verse part refers to serving the Lord faithfully without distractions. Other ways to translate it include:

so that you are able to give your undivided attention to the Lord (NJB)

to give yourselves fully to the Lord without concern for other things (NCV)

so that without distraction you may give...constant service to the Lord (NET)

undivided: The Greek word that the BSB translates as undivided literally means “not pulled or dragged away”; that is, not distracted by things that take your thoughts or attention away from what you are doing. It refers to being able to do something without having to think of something else. Here is another way to translate this:

unhindered (NRSV)

1 Corinthians 7:36

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:36–38

In these verses Paul discussed how a man should treat "his virgin," probably referring to the girl to whom he was engaged. These verses are difficult to understand. We do not know what was happening in Corinth, and we do not know what the Corinthian believers had said to Paul in their letter. They probably had asked him some specific questions about virgins and whether it was best for a man to marry a virgin he was engaged to.

7:36a

However, if someone thinks he is acting inappropriately toward his betrothed,

- ¶ If there is a man who is engaged to be married to a girl, and he thinks he is not treating her well by delaying their marriage,

- ¶ If any of you have been engaged for a long time, and think you are not being fair to your fiancée,
- ¶ As for those of you who are engaged but have delayed getting married: if you have begun to think that you are acting inappropriately toward your girlfriend,

However: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as However here introduces a contrast. The contrast is between what Paul said in the previous verse about one reason not to marry and what he says in this verse about one reason to marry. Many English versions do not translate this conjunction. Other English versions use the word "But." Translate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

if someone thinks he is acting inappropriately toward his betrothed: The Greek word that the BSB translates acting inappropriately means to behave in a way that is improper or dishonorable. Apparently there were some men in the Corinthian church who were engaged to be married but had delayed getting married. Now one or more of these men was beginning to think that he was not doing the right thing. Apparently he was thinking that it was unfair to the girl. Although Paul did not say why this was so, presumably it was because the man was preventing her from entering a marriage that would give her a home and family. Other ways to translate this include:

If anyone thinks that he is not behaving properly toward his fiancée (NRSV)

if someone thinks that he is treating his fiancée badly

if a man thinks he is not doing the right thing with the girl he is engaged to (NCV)

his betrothed: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as his betrothed is literally "his virgin." There are two ways to understand this phrase:

1. It refers to the man's fiancée, the girl to whom he was betrothed or engaged to be married. For example:

the girl he is engaged to (NCV) (BSB, RSV, ESV, REB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. It refers to the man's unmarried daughter. The community expected that he would make marriage arrangements for this girl. For example:

his virgin daughter (GW) (NASB, GW, probably the KJV)

The NET is ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The virgin is thus the young woman whom the man's family had made arrangements for him to marry. His family and the community expected that he would marry this girl. You should translate this using a phrase that is natural in your language, such as "his fiancée." Try to avoid using an expression that suggests that the man had himself pledged/promised to marry this girl.

7:36b

and if she is beyond her youth

- and if he strongly desires to marry her,
- and you feel passionately toward her,
- and if you are deeply in love with her,

if she is beyond her youth: There are two ways to understand the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as she is beyond her youth:

1. It refers to the man and means "has strong sexual desires." For example:

if his passions are too strong (GNT) (NLT, GNT, RSV, ESV, REB, NJB, CEV)

1. It refers to the woman and means "old enough that she should marry." For example:

if she is almost past the best age to marry (NCV) (BSB, NCV, NIV, KJV, NASB, NET, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It has stronger support from the translations and the commentaries. It also fits better with the interpretation followed by these notes that Paul was addressing a man and his fiancée. However, both interpretations have strong support, and if your national language version follows the second view, you may wish to follow that.

7:36c

and they ought to marry,

- and so he thinks that he should marry her,
- and now you realize it would be good to marry her,

they ought to marry: This verse part is more literally "it has to be so/thus." This probably refers to the man's own judgment or understanding that it is right for him to get married. Other ways to translate this include:

and it has to be (ESV)

he feels that they ought to marry (GNT)

thinks...that things should take their due course (NJB)

7:36d

let him do as he wishes;

- then he should do what he thinks is good.
- then you should marry her, if that is what you want.

let him do as he wishes: This implies that the man should marry his fiancée. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit:

He should do as he wants and marry her.

7:36e

he is not sinning;

- He is not doing wrong.
- It is not a sin.

he is not sinning: Paul used almost these same words in 7:28b and d. There he told unmarried men that if they got married "you do not sin," and he told "the virgin" that if she got married, "she does not sin." He said again here that it was not a sin to get married.

7:36f

they should get married.

- The couple should marry.
- You should marry her.

1 Corinthians 7:37

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul's answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed

Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:36–38

In these verses Paul discussed how a man should treat “his virgin,” probably referring to the girl to whom he was engaged. These verses are difficult to understand. We do not know what was happening in Corinth, and we do not know what the Corinthian believers had said to Paul in their letter. They probably had asked him some specific questions about virgins and whether it was best for a man to marry a virgin he was engaged to.

7:37a–d

In these verse parts Paul gave four conditions that should exist if a man decides not to marry a virgin. He must have “settled the matter in his own mind,” “be under no compulsion,” “have control over his own will,” and “made up his mind.” If these conditions exist, then the man has “done the right thing” in deciding not to marry.

7:37a

But the man who is firmly established in his heart

- On the other hand, suppose that this man has firmly decided what he will do
- But perhaps you have come to a definite conclusion in your heart/mind that it is better not to marry,

the man who is firmly established in his heart: The Greek words that the BSB translates as the man who is firmly established in his heart are more literally “whoever stands firm in his heart.” This is a figure of speech that refers to someone who has made a decision that he is sure is the right one and is determined to keep. Other ways to translate this include:

if someone stands firm in his resolve (NRSV)

if a man is steadfast in his purpose (REB)

In some language it may be helpful to make it explicit that the decision was a decision not to marry. For example:

if a man...has firmly made up his mind not to marry (GNT)

if a man is sure in his own mind that there is no need for marriage (NCV)

7:37b

and under no constraint,

- and no one is forcing him to decide one way or another.
- and you decided/chose this freely,

and under no constraint: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as under no constraint is more literally “not having necessity.” This probably refers to a situation in which no one is telling the man what to do. He does not feel forced or obliged by any outside pressure to refrain from marriage. Another way to translate this is:

without being forced (GNT)

7:37c

with control over his will

- He is able to exercise self-control
- and you can control your passions/desires.

This verse part begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “but.” It introduces another condition which is necessary for it to be right for the man not get married. Since this contrasts with the previous condition, the NIV, RSV, and NJB translate the Greek conjunction as “but.” The GNT, however, translates it as “and.” Connect these two conditions in a way that is natural in your language.

with control over his will: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as with control over his will is literally “has authority over/concerning his own will.” This probably refers to the man's self-control over his sexual desires. Some English versions make it explicit that this is the aspect of his will that is referred to here. For example:

having his desire under control (RSV)

if...he can control his passion (NLT)

7:37d**and resolve in his heart not to marry the virgin,**

- and he has decided to keep his fiancée a virgin.
- And so you have decided that you will not marry your fiancée.

resolve in his heart: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as resolve in his heart is similar to the phrase “firmly established in his heart” in 7:37a. It means that someone has made a decision that he is sure is the right one and is determined to keep. Here are some other ways to translate this:

who has made up his mind (NIV)

he decides (EASY)

not to marry the virgin: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as not to marry the virgin is literally “to keep his own virgin.” It probably means “to keep his fiancée as a virgin.” It does not say whether or not the engagement will be continued.

7:37e**he will do well.**

- If he does that, he will do a good thing in God’s eyes.
- It is fine/acceptable for you to decline to marry her.

he will do well: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as he will do well is literally “he does well.” Paul was saying that what the man was doing was good and acceptable.

1 Corinthians 7:38**Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage**

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul’s answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person’s husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed

Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul’s teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:36–38

In these verses Paul discussed how a man should treat “his virgin,” probably referring to the girl to whom he was engaged. These verses are difficult to understand. We do not know what was happening in Corinth, and we do not know what the Corinthian believers had said to Paul in their letter. They probably had asked him some specific questions about virgins and whether it was best for a man to marry a virgin he was engaged to.

7:38a**So then, he who marries the virgin does well,**

- So then, both ways are alright/good/acceptable: If a man marries the girl he is betrothed to, he does a good thing.
- So the result/summary is this: if you get married to your fiancée, that is good.

7:38b**but he who does not marry her does even better.**

- And/But a man who does not marry her will do a better thing.
- But if you do not marry her, that is even better.

7:38a–b

This verse gives the conclusion for the paragraph. It is a restatement of what Paul said in the earlier verses. Both the man who marries and the man who does not marry do well, but Paul gave a special commendation to the man who does not marry. Introduce the conclusion in a way that is natural in your language.

1 Corinthians 7:39**Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage**

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul’s answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had

asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person's husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

From the way Paul talked, it appears that the Corinthians were thinking that if believers want to be holy, they should abstain from sexual relations. The Corinthians were wondering if married people should sleep together, if Christians who were married to non-Christians should divorce them, and if Christians should get married. Paul gave them some wise teaching on each of these topics. In 7:1–16 he addressed Christians who were married. In 7:17–24 he wrote about his general rule for Christians: Remain as you are. In 7:25–38 he taught Christians who were not married. In 7:39–40 he addressed women whose husbands had died.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul's teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:39–40

Some women in the Corinthian church were widows. Apparently the Corinthians had asked Paul whether they should remarry. Some of the believers seem to have thought that these widows could be more holy and please God more if they stayed unmarried. Paul said that when a woman's husband dies, that breaks the marriage tie, and in God's eyes it is all right for her to marry someone else. But it is also all right if she remains unmarried, and in Paul's opinion, she may be happier that way.

7:39a

A wife is bound to her husband as long as he lives.

- ¶ A wife is joined/tied/united to her husband as long as he is alive.
- ¶ A married woman is obliged to remain her husband's wife for his whole life.
- ¶ If a woman is married, the laws of marriage make her permanently married to her husband all his life.

A wife is bound to her husband: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bound indicates that marriage obliges the two people to behave in a certain way to one another, both in the eyes of the law and in the eyes of God. This the same word Paul used in 7:27a, where the BSB translated it as “committed.” See the note on 7:27a.

as long as he lives: Paul indicated that marriage is supposed to be permanent. He did not want believers to get divorced. Here Paul repeated in different words the same thing he said in 7:10–11.

7:39b

But if her husband dies,

- But if her husband dies,
- However, if it happens that he dies before she does,

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrasting set of circumstances. That new set of circumstances is if her husband dies. His death sets her free from her marriage. In some languages a conjunction may not be natural here. The RSV does not translate the conjunction and begins a new sentence.

if her husband dies: A marriage ends when the husband or wife dies. It is possible that some believers in Corinth thought that a husband and wife were “bound” (permanently joined) in marriage not only in life here on earth, but in the future life also. (See Matthew 22:23–33). Paul told them that the marriage tie is for life here on earth only.

dies: The Greek word that the BSB translates as dies is literally “sleeps.” The word “sleep” is a euphemism for talking about death. A euphemism is an indirect way of saying something that might offend someone if it was said directly. You may substitute a euphemism that is natural in your language if death is something you would not talk about directly and if the meaning remains clear.

7:39c

she is free to marry anyone she wishes,

- then it is all right for her to marry someone else if she wants to,
- she is released from that marriage and may get married again to any man she wants to.

she is free to marry anyone she wishes: The word free here contrasts with the word “bound” in 7:39a. The widow is neither obliged to marry again nor obliged to remain unmarried. Paul said that Christian widows could decide for themselves if they will marry again and whom they will marry.

7:39d

as long as he belongs to the Lord.

- as long as he is also a believer.
- But she should marry a Christian.

as long as he belongs to the Lord: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as as long as he belongs to

the Lord is literally “only in the Lord.” Here is another way to translate this:

but only if he is a Christian (GNT)

1 Corinthians 7:40

Section 7:1–40: Paul answered questions about marriage

In an earlier letter to Paul, the Corinthians had mentioned some problems and asked him some questions. There are no longer any copies of this letter, so we can only guess what they wrote by reading Paul’s answers. Apparently some of the questions the Corinthians had asked were about marriage and sex. In this section Paul discussed these topics. He wrote about sexual intercourse, divorce, marrying again after a person’s husband or wife dies, and never marrying.

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Other possible section headings include:

Paul gave/wrote instructions about Christian marriage

Paul’s teaching on marriage

Paragraph 7:39–40

Some women in the Corinthian church were widows. Apparently the Corinthians had asked Paul whether they should remarry. Some of the believers seem to have thought that these widows could be more holy and please God more if they stayed unmarried. Paul said that when a woman’s husband dies, that breaks the marriage tie, and in God’s eyes it is all right for her to marry someone else. But it is also all right if she remains unmarried, and in Paul’s opinion, she may be happier that way.

7:40a

In my judgment, however,

- But in my opinion,
- However, here is what I think is good for her to do:

In my judgment, however: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as however introduces a contrast with what Paul said in the previous verse about how a widow is free to marry after her husband dies. Here he says that he thinks that a widow will be happier if she does not marry again. Some versions do not translate this conjunction. Express the contrast in a natural way in your language.

The phrase In my judgment has the same meaning as the phrase “I give a judgment” in 7:25c. See the note on 7:25c. Another way to translate this is:

This is my opinion (NCV)

7:40b

she is happier if she remains as she is.

- she will be happier if she stays unmarried.
- her life will be better if she does not marry again.

she is happier if she remains as she is: The Greek word that the BSB translates as happier can also be translated as “more blessed.” A widow’s life may in some ways be easier or less stressful if she decides not to remarry. She may also have more time and energy to serve the Lord. Paul may have been thinking of “the present crisis” he mentioned in 7:26a, and of the troubles he mentioned in 7:38e. Here is another way to translate this:

it would be better for her to stay single (NLT)

7:40c

And I think that I too have the Spirit of God.

- And I think that I too have God’s Spirit to help/guide me.
- And I say this with the help of God’s Spirit, who is with/in me as well as with/in you.

I think that I too have the Spirit of God: Apparently there were some people in the Corinthian church who said that the Holy Spirit was speaking through them. Paul here claimed that he, as well as they, had God’s Spirit to help him. God’s Spirit helped him to know how to answer the Corinthians’ questions and what to tell them about the problems they were having.

General Comment on 7:40a–c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder these verse parts in order to make clear the implication that

Paul's opinion or judgment came from the Spirit of God. For example:

^{40b}She will be happier, however, if she stays as she is. ^{40a}That is my opinion, ^{40c}and I think that I too have God's Spirit. (GNT)

1 Corinthians 8:1

Section 8:1-13: Paul answered questions about eating meat that had been offered to idols

In this section Paul wrote about something else the Corinthians had asked him in their earlier letter. They had asked him whether it was acceptable for them to eat the meat of an animal that had been sacrificed to an idol. The primary context for eating such meat was at an idol's temple. Sometimes an animal would be offered to a false god in connection with a celebration such as a birthday or wedding to seek the god's blessing and presence at the celebration. The animal would be butchered by a priest and a portion of the meat would be burned on an altar as an offering to the false god. Some of the remaining meat would be returned to the person who offered it and could be eaten together with family or other invited guests at a private banquet room at the temple. (Some of the remaining meat might be sent to the meat market to be sold, a situation that Paul addresses in 10:25-26.)

There were two opinions in the Corinthian church about whether this meat could be eaten by a believer in Christ. Some of the Corinthian believers, including those who wrote the letter, understood that idols were only things that people have made or imagined. They were hoping Paul would agree with them that it was acceptable to eat this meat. However, some other believers thought that it was wrong to enter a temple and eat such meat. They still believed the false gods were real and believed that eating meat offered to them in sacrifice was an act of worship or fellowship with these gods.

Paul agreed in this chapter that the idols worshiped at these temples were not real gods. But he did not give permission to eat this meat at their temple. Doing so might influence other believers to also eat the meat, even though they believed it was wrong. Paul asked the Corinthians believers to act in love toward these brothers rather than selfishly demanding the right to eat this meat.

In chapter 10, Paul will continue to answer the question about eating meat sacrificed to idols. He says that a believer can have no part in the worship of idols and also that demons are active in the sacrifices to idols.

He also addresses the separate situations of buying and eating meat sold in the meat market and what to do when someone invites you to eat meat in their home. Before this, in chapter 9, he uses himself as an illustration of the principle he set down at the end of chapter 8 of giving up your rights in love. He had the right to be paid for his work as an apostle, but he gave up his right so that the good news of Jesus would be better accepted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul gave instructions about eating meat of/from animals that had been sacrificed to false gods

Believers should not eat anything that causes other believers to sin

Paragraph 8:1-3

Paul introduced his new topic of eating the meat of animals that had been offered to idols. He talked about the difference between doing things because we know something and doing things because we love other people.

8:1a

Now about food sacrificed to idols:

- ¶ Now I say this concerning meat of/from animals that have been sacrificed to idols/gods.
- ¶ You^(plur) also asked if it is right to eat meat that people have offered to false gods. So now I will talk/write to you about that.

Now about: The Greek words that the BSB translates as Now about here introduce the next topic Paul wanted to discuss: whether or not to eat the meat of animals that had been sacrificed to idols. This was probably something the Corinthians had written about in their earlier letter to Paul. Some English versions make this explicit. For example:

Now, concerning what you wrote about... (GNT)

In your letter you asked me about food offered to idols. (CEV)

food sacrificed to idols: The Greek word that the BSB translates as food sacrificed to idols is formed from two root words, "idol" plus "to sacrifice." Most versions are like the BSB and translate this as "food sacrificed/offered to idols." A few versions translate

this as “meat sacrificed to idols” since this offering was always meat. The Greek root *θύω* that is compounded in the Greek word *εἰδωλόθυτος* ‘food sacrificed to idols’ means “to kill” or “to slaughter ceremonially in offering a sacrifice.” This implies that the word always refers to meat because wine or grain offerings are not “killed.”

In this chapter Paul was talking about feasts that were eaten in a temple for an idol. When people brought an animal to a temple to be offered to an idol, the priests would kill the animal and burn parts of it on the altar there for the false god that the idol represented. The priests kept some parts of the meat for themselves and gave the rest of it to the person who brought the animal. That person could then use that meat to have a feast in the temple for himself and any invited guests.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

meat that people have sacrificed to idols

food which has been dedicated to false gods (NJB)

meat that has been grilled/burned at shrines/
temples

idols: Jewish people and Christians used the word idols to describe objects or statues that represent a god. People used these idols when they worshiped the gods. Often the idols were made of wood or stone. Depending on the context, the word “idol” can refer to the statue, to the god of the stature, or to both. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

image/object/statue that is worshiped

gods

false gods

fetishes

8:1b

We know that we all have knowledge.

- It is true, as you^(plur) say, we^(incl) all know many things about God.
- I agree with you that we believers all know things about God.

We know: Paul was talking here about something that the Corinthians had said in their letter to him. He agreed with what they said. So when Paul said “we,” he meant himself and the Corinthian believers. This is an inclusive pronoun.

we all have knowledge: These words are probably a quotation from the Corinthians’ letter to Paul. Some English versions make this clear by using quotation marks. For example:

“all of us possess knowledge” (RSV)

Quotation marks alone will not make this clear to someone who is simply listening to this text. So you may wish to follow the REB and supply this information:

‘We all have knowledge,’ as you say. (REB)

knowledge: The Greek word that the BSB translates as knowledge here refers to the knowledge that the Holy Spirit gives to all believers concerning God and his ways. Refer to your translation of knowledge in 1:5. Paul and the Corinthians all had this knowledge, so the pronoun “we” is inclusive.

In some languages it may be natural to translate the abstract noun knowledge as a verb. It may also be necessary to supply the content of their knowledge. For example:

we all know about God

8:1c

Knowledge puffs up,

- Knowledge makes us^(incl) arrogant,
- Knowing things about God can make people feel big,
- When you^(plur) know something, that makes you feel important.

Knowledge puffs up: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as puffs up originally meant “to blow air into something to make it bigger.” In 1 Corinthians, Paul uses the word to simply mean “to cause a person to be arrogant.” Knowing things can make people feel arrogant. Some of the believers in Corinth had wrongly become proud about what they knew about God and how to follow Christ. Some other ways to translate this are:

Knowledge makes people arrogant (GW)

knowledge makes us proud of ourselves (CEV)

knowledge makes us feel important (NLT)

In some languages it may be natural to translate the abstract noun Knowledge as a verb:

When you know something, that makes you proud/arrogant.

If you think you know something, then you boast.

8:1d

but love builds up.

- but love encourages God's people.
- but loving other people makes the church strong in faith.
- But when you^(plur) care about other believers, you cause them to be better.

love builds up: The Greek word that the BSB translates as builds up means to encourage someone and make them strong in their faith. In Greek, there is no explicit object to the verb. It is not clear who is built up by love. If you need to supply an object, try to translate this in a general way indicating that love builds up everyone involved. For example:

it is love that strengthens the church (NLT)

love encourages people

the nature of love is that it serves/helps other people to grow in their faith

love: In this context, the word love means the devotion shown toward another person that causes someone to seek what is good for that person. It does not refer to romantic love between a man and a woman or husband and wife. In some languages it may be natural to translate the abstract noun love as a verb. For example:

When you love someone, you make them strong.

If people devote themselves to others, that helps/encourages them.

1 Corinthians 8:2

Section 8:1–13: Paul answered questions about eating meat that had been offered to idols

In this section Paul wrote about something else the Corinthians had asked him in their earlier letter. They had asked him whether it was acceptable for them to eat the meat of an animal that had been sacrificed to an idol. The primary context for eating such meat was at an idol's temple. Sometimes an animal would be offered to a false god in connection with a celebration such as a birthday or wedding to seek the god's blessing and presence at the celebration. The animal would be butchered by a priest and a portion of the meat would be burned on an altar as an offering to the false god. Some of the remaining meat would be returned to the person who offered it and could be eaten together with family or other invited guests at a private banquet room at the temple. (Some of the remaining meat might be sent to the meat market to be sold, a situation that Paul addresses in 10:25–26.)

There were two opinions in the Corinthian church about whether this meat could be eaten by a believer in Christ. Some of the Corinthian believers, including those who wrote the letter, understood that idols were only things that people have made or imagined. They were hoping Paul would agree with them that it was acceptable to eat this meat. However, some other believers thought that it was wrong to enter a temple and eat such meat. They still believed the false gods were real and believed that eating meat offered to them in sacrifice was an act of worship or fellowship with these gods.

Paul agreed in this chapter that the idols worshiped at these temples were not real gods. But he did not give permission to eat this meat at their temple. Doing so might influence other believers to also eat the meat, even though they believed it was wrong. Paul asked the Corinthians believers to act in love toward these brothers rather than selfishly demanding the right to eat this meat.

In chapter 10, Paul will continue to answer the question about eating meat sacrificed to idols. He says that a believer can have no part in the worship of idols and also that demons are active in the sacrifices to idols. He also addresses the separate situations of buying and eating meat sold in the meat market and what to do when someone invites you to eat meat in their home. Before this, in chapter 9, he uses himself as an illustration of the principle he set down at the end of chapter 8 of giving up your rights in love. He had the right to be paid for his work as an apostle, but he gave

up his right so that the good news of Jesus would be better accepted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul gave instructions about eating meat of/from animals that had been sacrificed to false gods

Believers should not eat anything that causes other believers to sin

Paragraph 8:1–3

Paul introduced his new topic of eating the meat of animals that had been offered to idols. He talked about the difference between doing things because we know something and doing things because we love other people.

8:2a

The one who thinks he knows something

- If someone is sure/confident that he knows something,
- A person who believes that he really knows something about God
- What I mean is this: when you^(sing) think that the most important thing is what you know,

The one who thinks he knows something: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as The one who thinks he knows something is literally “If anyone/someone thinks he knows something.” Some of the believers in Corinth had become proud of what they knew. The perfect tense of the verb “he has come to know” confirms that emphasis. For example, Fee says: “The perfect tense of the infinitive implies that they consider themselves to have arrived as far as knowledge is concerned.” If simply translating this as thinks he knows something does not communicate that this person is also proud of what he knows, you may want to make the idea of pride clear.

This verse (2a and 2b together) states a general principle. Consider what is a natural way to translate this kind of general principle in your language. Your language may use a word like “anyone,” “you^(sing),” “you^(plur)” or something else as the subject. For example:

If anyone thinks he knows something

If you^(sing) believe you know many things

When people think they know so much

Those who boast that their understanding is great

8:2b

does not yet know as he ought to know.

- then he still needs to learn more.
- does not yet really know about God in the way he should.
- it shows that you^(sing) do not know what/as you should know.

does not yet know as he ought to know: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as does not yet know as he ought to know indicates that this person does not truly understand the things of God. He ought to realize that God gives him knowledge so that he can help other people. The implication of this verse part is that the person may know about something, but he does not use that knowledge in a way that shows love for his fellow believers. Therefore he does not know as he ought to know.

In some languages it may be necessary to supply an object for the verb know. If this is the case in your language, try to supply a general word. For example:

you do not yet know the things you should know

1 Corinthians 8:3

Section 8:1–13: Paul answered questions about eating meat that had been offered to idols

In this section Paul wrote about something else the Corinthians had asked him in their earlier letter. They had asked him whether it was acceptable for them to eat the meat of an animal that had been sacrificed to an idol. The primary context for eating such meat was at an idol’s temple. Sometimes an animal would be offered to a false god in connection with a celebration such as a birthday or wedding to seek the god’s blessing and presence at the celebration. The animal would be butchered by a priest and a portion of the meat would be burned on an altar as an offering to the false god. Some of the remaining meat would be returned to the person who offered it and could be eaten together with family or other invited guests at a private banquet room at the temple. (Some of the remaining meat might be sent to the meat market to be sold, a situation that Paul addresses in 10:25–26.)

There were two opinions in the Corinthian church about whether this meat could be eaten by a believer in Christ. Some of the Corinthian believers, including those who wrote the letter, understood that idols were

only things that people have made or imagined. They were hoping Paul would agree with them that it was acceptable to eat this meat. However, some other believers thought that it was wrong to enter a temple and eat such meat. They still believed the false gods were real and believed that eating meat offered to them in sacrifice was an act of worship or fellowship with these gods.

Paul agreed in this chapter that the idols worshiped at these temples were not real gods. But he did not give permission to eat this meat at their temple. Doing so might influence other believers to also eat the meat, even though they believed it was wrong. Paul asked the Corinthians believers to act in love toward these brothers rather than selfishly demanding the right to eat this meat.

In chapter 10, Paul will continue to answer the question about eating meat sacrificed to idols. He says that a believer can have no part in the worship of idols and also that demons are active in the sacrifices to idols. He also addresses the separate situations of buying and eating meat sold in the meat market and what to do when someone invites you to eat meat in their home. Before this, in chapter 9, he uses himself as an illustration of the principle he set down at the end of chapter 8 of giving up your rights in love. He had the right to be paid for his work as an apostle, but he gave up his right so that the good news of Jesus would be better accepted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other possible headings for this section are:

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Believers should not eat anything that causes other believers to sin

Paragraph 8:1–3

Paul introduced his new topic of eating the meat of animals that had been offered to idols. He talked about the difference between doing things because we know something and doing things because we love other people.

8:3a

But the one who loves God

- But if someone/anyone loves God,
- However, a person who loves God
- When you^(sing) are devoted to God,

8:3b

is known by God.

- he is known by God.
- is known by him.
- then God knows you^(sing).

8:3a–b

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrasting thought. The contrast is between having knowledge (8:2) and loving God (8:3).

the one who loves God is known by God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the one who loves God is literally “if someone loves God.” And he was talking about anyone and everyone, male or female, who loves God. Some other ways to translate this are:

if anyone loves God, he is known by God (ESV)

if you love God, you are known by him

when people love God, they are known by him

those/all who love God are known by him

loves: In this context, the word loves means the devotion that a person has toward God. If possible, use the same word for love or devotion here that you used in 8:1d.

is known by God: This is in the passive. There are two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

is known by him (NRSV)

- using an active verb. For example:

God knows that person/one

Use whichever form is more natural in your language.

1 Corinthians 8:4

Section 8:1–13: Paul answered questions about eating meat that had been offered to idols

In this section Paul wrote about something else the Corinthians had asked him in their earlier letter. They had asked him whether it was acceptable for them to eat the meat of an animal that had been sacrificed to an idol. The primary context for eating such meat was at an idol's temple. Sometimes an animal would

be offered to a false god in connection with a celebration such as a birthday or wedding to seek the god's blessing and presence at the celebration. The animal would be butchered by a priest and a portion of the meat would be burned on an altar as an offering to the false god. Some of the remaining meat would be returned to the person who offered it and could be eaten together with family or other invited guests at a private banquet room at the temple. (Some of the remaining meat might be sent to the meat market to be sold, a situation that Paul addresses in 10:25-26.)

There were two opinions in the Corinthian church about whether this meat could be eaten by a believer in Christ. Some of the Corinthian believers, including those who wrote the letter, understood that idols were only things that people have made or imagined. They were hoping Paul would agree with them that it was acceptable to eat this meat. However, some other believers thought that it was wrong to enter a temple and eat such meat. They still believed the false gods were real and believed that eating meat offered to them in sacrifice was an act of worship or fellowship with these gods.

Paul agreed in this chapter that the idols worshiped at these temples were not real gods. But he did not give permission to eat this meat at their temple. Doing so might influence other believers to also eat the meat, even though they believed it was wrong. Paul asked the Corinthians believers to act in love toward these brothers rather than selfishly demanding the right to eat this meat.

In chapter 10, Paul will continue to answer the question about eating meat sacrificed to idols. He says that a believer can have no part in the worship of idols and also that demons are active in the sacrifices to idols. He also addresses the separate situations of buying and eating meat sold in the meat market and what to do when someone invites you to eat meat in their home. Before this, in chapter 9, he uses himself as an illustration of the principle he set down at the end of chapter 8 of giving up your rights in love. He had the right to be paid for his work as an apostle, but he gave up his right so that the good news of Jesus would be better accepted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul gave instructions about eating meat of/from animals that had been sacrificed to false gods

Believers should not eat anything that causes other believers to sin

Paragraph 8:4-6

Paul began to write his answer to the Corinthians' questions about eating food sacrificed to idols. In this paragraph he began by agreeing with them about several things.

8:4a

So about eating food sacrificed to idols:

- ¶ Well then, here is what I say/teach about eating meat that has been sacrificed to idols/gods.
- ¶ Now, I give this answer to what you^(plur) said about eating meat of/from animals that people have offered/given to false gods.

So about eating food sacrificed to idols: In this verse part Paul reintroduced the topic that the Corinthians had asked him about in their letter. He had also introduced this topic in 8:1a. Here he is more specific, mentioning eating this food. Other ways to translate this include:

So this is what I say about eating meat sacrificed to idols (NCV)

So, what about eating meat that has been offered to idols? (NLT)

So about...: The Greek conjunction that the BSB has translated as So, together with the repetition of the topic (food sacrificed to idols), indicates that Paul is returning to the topic mentioned in 8:1a. You should introduce this return to topic in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Well then, about... (REB)

Now about... (GW)

So this is what I say about... (NCV)

eating food sacrificed to idols: The Greek word that the BSB translates as food sacrificed to idols is the same as in 8:1a. Translate it here as you did there.

8:4b-c

In these verse parts Paul stated things that he and the Corinthians who had written the letter to him all believed. He may be directly quoting two things they said in their letter. Or he may be restating what they said in their own words. Some English versions (RSV,

ESV, REB, NET) use quotations marks to indicate that Paul is quoting, but most versions do not. There is no way to know for sure since we do not have a copy of the Corinthians' letter to Paul. Some ways to translate this that indicate that Paul is agreeing with something they had said are:

we know that “an idol has no real existence,” and that “there is no God but one.” (RSV)

as you say, we know that an idol is nothing at all in the world and that there is no God but one

I agree with you that idols do not really exist and that there is only one God.

8:4b

We know that an idol is nothing at all in the world,

- We^(incl) know, as you say, that none of the idols/gods in the world are real gods,
- I agree with you^(plur) that false gods are not alive,

We know: The pronoun We here is inclusive. It refers to Paul himself and some of the believers in Corinth, at least the ones who wrote the letter to Paul. Paul had probably taught them that the gods represented by idols were not real. But Paul says in verse 8:7 that at least some of the believers at Corinth did not know or believe this.

an idol is nothing at all in the world: This indicates that none of the idols in the world exist as living beings. They are made of things such as gold or stone, but they do not have life. They do not represent true gods, they do not hear prayers, and they cannot help or hurt people.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

none of the idols in this world are alive (CEV)

an idol is not really a god

false/idol gods do not really exist

idol: The word idol here, as in 8:1, describes an object or statue that represents a god. In this context, when Paul agrees that “an idol is nothing,” he is referring primarily to the god that is represented by the idol. The god is nothing. The idol is nothing more than the object or statue. It is not a god. Some other ways to translate this are:

gods

false/fake gods

8:4c

and that there is no God but one.

- and there is only the one God.
- and that the God whom we^(incl) worship is the only true and living God.

there is no God but one: This is another thing that Paul and most of the Corinthian believers knew: there is only one true God, the living and powerful God. This truth is basic to both Jewish people and to Christians, and so was certainly something that Paul and the other teachers had taught the believers in Corinth. Another way to translate this is:

there is only one God (NLT)

there is no other god beside the true God

1 Corinthians 8:5

Section 8:1–13: Paul answered questions about eating meat that had been offered to idols

In this section Paul wrote about something else the Corinthians had asked him in their earlier letter. They had asked him whether it was acceptable for them to eat the meat of an animal that had been sacrificed to an idol. The primary context for eating such meat was at an idol's temple. Sometimes an animal would be offered to a false god in connection with a celebration such as a birthday or wedding to seek the god's blessing and presence at the celebration. The animal would be butchered by a priest and a portion of the meat would be burned on an altar as an offering to the false god. Some of the remaining meat would be returned to the person who offered it and could be eaten together with family or other invited guests at a private banquet room at the temple. (Some of the remaining meat might be sent to the meat market to be sold, a situation that Paul addresses in 10:25–26.)

There were two opinions in the Corinthian church about whether this meat could be eaten by a believer in Christ. Some of the Corinthian believers, including those who wrote the letter, understood that idols were only things that people have made or imagined. They were hoping Paul would agree with them that it was acceptable to eat this meat. However, some other believers thought that it was wrong to enter a temple and eat such meat. They still believed the false gods were real and believed that eating meat offered to

them in sacrifice was an act of worship or fellowship with these gods.

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It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul gave instructions about eating meat of/from animals that had been sacrificed to false gods

Believers should not eat anything that causes other believers to sin

Paragraph 8:4–6

Paul began to write his answer to the Corinthians' questions about eating food sacrificed to idols. In this paragraph he began by agreeing with them about several things.

8:5–6

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* here introduces a further explanation of what Paul said in 8:4b–c. Some English versions do not translate this word.

You should introduce this further explanation in a way that is natural in your language.

even if: The Greek words that the BSB translate as *even if* here introduce a contrast between what the idol worshipers believed and what the Christians believed. Verse 5 tells what the idol worshipers believed.

Verse 6 tells what the Christians believed. Some other ways to translate the contrast between 8:5 and 8:6 are:

⁵People may say that there are gods in heaven and on earth...⁶But for us, "There is only one God,... (GW)

⁵Even though there are things called gods,...⁶for us there is only one God... (NCV)

8:5a

For even if there are so-called gods, whether in heaven or on earth

- For even though for others there may be beings called gods, in heaven or on earth,
- -or-
- Some people may say that other gods do live, either in heaven or on earth.

so-called gods: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *so-called gods* here indicates that people spoke about beings that they called gods. Many people thought of the idols as being real gods or as representing real gods. Paul did not agree that they were gods. Other ways to translate this include:

beings whom/that people call gods

things called gods (NCV)

People may say that there are gods (GW)

whether in heaven or on earth: Paul was indicating that people talked about gods as either dwelling in heaven or on earth.

8:5b

(as there are many so-called gods and lords),

- and in fact there are plenty of gods like this and plenty of lords,
- They actually worship/honor many such gods and try to please/serve many such powerful spiritual beings.

(as there are many so-called gods and lords): Paul adds that some of these *so-called gods* are referred to as gods and some are called lords. He himself did not think of idols as real gods and lords, but he knew that this is what people called them. The BSB indicates this by using the word *so-called*. Some English versions use quotation marks around gods and lords to indicate this. For example:

as indeed there are many “gods” and many “lords” (RSV)

lords: Here this word refers to nonhuman beings that the Greeks and others at this time considered to be rulers in spiritual realms. Some other ways to translate this are:

spiritual rulers

powerful spiritual beings

General Comment on 8:5a-b

In 5b, Paul adds a further comment about the “so-called gods” mentioned in 5a. Some English versions punctuate this with parenthesis (as the BSB). But it is also possible to use commas or whatever is most natural in your language. For example:

For even if there are so-called gods whether in heaven or on earth, there are many so-called gods and many lords,... (NASB)

Verse 5 begins with the concept of “so-called gods” and then further explains them saying they may be found in heaven or on earth and they may be called either “gods” or “lords.” It may be more natural to reorder these elements. For example:

Many things in heaven and on earth are called gods and lords, but none of them really are gods or lords. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 8:6

Section 8:1-13: Paul answered questions about eating meat that had been offered to idols

In this section Paul wrote about something else the Corinthians had asked him in their earlier letter. They had asked him whether it was acceptable for them to eat the meat of an animal that had been sacrificed to an idol. The primary context for eating such meat was at an idol’s temple. Sometimes an animal would be offered to a false god in connection with a celebration such as a birthday or wedding to seek the god’s blessing and presence at the celebration. The animal would be butchered by a priest and a portion of the meat would be burned on an altar as an offering to the false god. Some of the remaining meat would be returned to the person who offered it and could be eaten together with family or other invited guests at a private banquet room at the temple. (Some of the

remaining meat might be sent to the meat market to be sold, a situation that Paul addresses in 10:25-26.)

There were two opinions in the Corinthian church about whether this meat could be eaten by a believer in Christ. Some of the Corinthian believers, including those who wrote the letter, understood that idols were only things that people have made or imagined. They were hoping Paul would agree with them that it was acceptable to eat this meat. However, some other believers thought that it was wrong to enter a temple and eat such meat. They still believed the false gods were real and believed that eating meat offered to them in sacrifice was an act of worship or fellowship with these gods.

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Paragraph 8:4-6

Paul began to write his answer to the Corinthians’ questions about eating food sacrificed to idols. In this paragraph he began by agreeing with them about several things.

8:6a**yet for us there is but one God, the Father,**

- yet for us^(incl) there is only one God, the Father,
- But we acknowledge/worship the one true God. He is the Father of us all.

yet for us there is but one God, the Father: Paul was indicating that believers believe there is only one God, and that he is the only true God. Idol worshipers would have agreed that Christians worshiped their own “god” and their own “lord,” but they would not have agreed that he was “the only God” and “the only Lord.”

yet: The Greek word that the BSB translates as yet indicates the contrast between the idol worshipers who believe in many gods and many lords and the Christians who believe there is one God and one Lord. There are different ways to indicate this contrast. (See the note about “even if” above at 8:5–6.) For example:

But for us (GW)

for us: The Greek text draws attention to this contrast by moving the words for us to the front of the clause. Consider if it would be helpful to emphasize the words for us in some way in your language.

God, the Father: God, the Father refers to the first person of the Trinity. In this context, it indicates that he is the father of all people because he created all things and all things were made to serve him, as is said in 8:6b–c. In some languages, it is necessary to say who a father is in relation to. For example:

God, our^(incl) Father

8:6b**from whom all things came**

- who caused everything else to begin/exist,
- He is the one who made/created everything there is.

from whom all things came: In Greek, there are no verbs in this verse. This verse part simply says: from whom all things. This means that God is the one who caused everything to exist. Some other ways to translate this are:

who created everything (NLT)

who caused all things to be/begin

all things are from him

he is the source/origin of everything

8:6c**and for whom we exist.**

- and we^(incl) live/exist for him.
- Because he made/created us, we live in order to serve him.

for whom we exist: In Greek, this clause does not have a verb and just says: “and we for him.” This means that “we live/exist in order to serve God.” The pronoun we includes Paul and all other believers.

8:6d**And there is but one Lord, Jesus Christ,**

- And Jesus Christ is the only true/rightful Lord.
- And we^(incl) acknowledge/worship only one Lord/master, Jesus the Messiah,

there is but one Lord, Jesus Christ: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord is a title meaning “master.” Paul was saying that Jesus Christ is the one who has authority over all believers and even of the whole world.

8:6e**through whom all things came**

- Through him God the Father caused everything in creation to begin,
- to whom the Father gave the work of making/creating everything.

through whom all things came: Once again in Greek, this clause does not have a verb. It says: through whom all things. The all things here are the same all things as in 8:6b. This means that the universe and everything in it “were created,” “came into existence,” or “began” because of what Jesus Christ did. God the Father is ruler of everything. He gave the task of creating all things to Jesus Christ. In that sense, God the Father created all things through Jesus. Some other ways to translate this are:

God the Father created all things through/by him.

God the Father caused/commanded Jesus to create everything.

For other Scriptures about the work of God’s Son in making everything, see John 1:1–3; Colossians 1:15–17; Hebrews 1:1–3.

8:6f**and through whom we exist.**

- and through him we^(incl) receive life from God.

- And we live only because of him.

through whom we exist: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as through whom we exist has no verb. It is literally “we (emphatic) through him.” The BSB has supplied the verb exist. The we means “we believers” or “we who belong to God.” It is not certain if “we exist through him” means that we exist because Jesus created us (physical life) or that we live spiritually because Jesus saved us. Many commentaries interpret this as a reference to spiritual life. For example, Fee says: “the Lord Christ is the divine mediator, through whom God created all things and redeemed us.” However, most English versions translate this as “exist” (physical life) or “live” (neutral). Additionally, the Greek verbless clauses *δι’ οὗ τὰ πάντα* ‘through whom all things’ and *καὶ ἡμεῖς δι’ αὐτοῦ* ‘and we through him’ seem better understood as expressing a similar sense. The same way that all things are through him (= by creation), we are through him. With support for both spiritual life and physical life, we have chosen to recommend translating in way that can include either idea. It is recommended that you translate in a way that could be understood in either sense. For example:

through whom we have been given life (NLT)

1 Corinthians 8:7

Section 8:1–13: Paul answered questions about eating meat that had been offered to idols

In this section Paul wrote about something else the Corinthians had asked him in their earlier letter. They had asked him whether it was acceptable for them to eat the meat of an animal that had been sacrificed to an idol. The primary context for eating such meat was at an idol’s temple. Sometimes an animal would be offered to a false god in connection with a celebration such as a birthday or wedding to seek the god’s blessing and presence at the celebration. The animal would be butchered by a priest and a portion of the meat would be burned on an altar as an offering to the false god. Some of the remaining meat would be returned to the person who offered it and could be eaten together with family or other invited guests at a private banquet room at the temple. (Some of the remaining meat might be sent to the meat market to be sold, a situation that Paul addresses in 10:25–26.)

There were two opinions in the Corinthian church about whether this meat could be eaten by a believer in Christ. Some of the Corinthian believers, including those who wrote the letter, understood that idols were only things that people have made or imagined. They were hoping Paul would agree with them that it was

acceptable to eat this meat. However, some other believers thought that it was wrong to enter a temple and eat such meat. They still believed the false gods were real and believed that eating meat offered to them in sacrifice was an act of worship or fellowship with these gods.

Paul agreed in this chapter that the idols worshiped at these temples were not real gods. But he did not give permission to eat this meat at their temple. Doing so might influence other believers to also eat the meat, even though they believed it was wrong. Paul asked the Corinthians believers to act in love toward these brothers rather than selfishly demanding the right to eat this meat.

In chapter 10, Paul will continue to answer the question about eating meat sacrificed to idols. He says that a believer can have no part in the worship of idols and also that demons are active in the sacrifices to idols. He also addresses the separate situations of buying and eating meat sold in the meat market and what to do when someone invites you to eat meat in their home. Before this, in chapter 9, he uses himself as an illustration of the principle he set down at the end of chapter 8 of giving up your rights in love. He had the right to be paid for his work as an apostle, but he gave up his right so that the good news of Jesus would be better accepted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul gave instructions about eating meat of/from animals that had been sacrificed to false gods

Believers should not eat anything that causes other believers to sin

Paragraph 8:7–13

In this paragraph Paul discussed a problem related to the knowledge that an idol is nothing. The problem is that not all believers have this knowledge. When those without this knowledge eat food sacrificed to idols, they think they are participating in rites to real gods. They know this is wrong, but being weak they are easily influenced to do it anyway. So believers who know that idols are nothing should not think only about what they have freedom to do, but rather should think about how what they do may influence other believers toward idolatry. They should not do anything that would cause another believer to do something he thinks is wrong.

8:7a**But not everyone has this knowledge.**

- ¶ But not all believers know this.
- ¶ However, some believers do not yet understand that idols are nothing.
- ¶ But remember: some among you^(plur) think that idols are alive and powerful.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrast. In the previous paragraph Paul said, “We know that an idol is nothing in the world and that there is only one God.” In contrast, some people do not know those things to be true.

not everyone has this knowledge: When Paul used the word everyone here he was referring to believers. Not all the Corinthian believers knew that the idols were false gods and had no existence. The NLT makes this explicit:

However, not all believers know this. (NLT)

8:7b**Some people are still so accustomed to idols**

- Some of them worshiped idols for so long
- Serving idols was an important/large part of their life before they believed in Christ.

Some people are still so accustomed to idols: There is a textual issue here.

1. Some Greek manuscripts have a word that means “custom.” For example:

Some are accustomed to thinking of idols as being real (NLT) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NASB, ESV, REB, NET, GW, NLT, NCV, CEV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have a word that means “conscience.” For example:

There are some in whose conscience false gods still play such a part (NJB) (NJB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option 1, since it has strong support from Greek manuscripts and English versions. This is the reading in the UBS Greek NT, which gives it an A rating, indicating that it is almost certainly correct.

Some people: Paul was still referring to believers here.

so accustomed to: Many of the believers in Corinth had worshiped idols since childhood. They had only

recently stopped worshiping idols. Some of them still believed these idols were real, even though they had decided to no longer worship them.

Other ways to translate this include:

Some people are so used to worshiping false gods.... (GW)

Some, by being accustomed to idols in former times.... (NET)

8:7c**that they eat such food**

- that if/when they eat food that has been sacrificed to idols,
- So when they go to a feast in the idol’s temple/ house,

8:7d**as if it were sacrificed to an idol.**

- they consider that as taking part in a sacrifice to a real god.
- they think they are eating sacred food that has been given to a god who is alive and powerful.

8:7c-d**they eat such food as if it were sacrificed to an idol:**

Paul was saying that when the new believers ate such meat, they thought they were sharing or participating in a sacrifice to a real god. As a result of this, they considered this meat sacred food (food belonging to the god), and not ordinary food. Other ways to translate this include:

so when they eat food that has been offered to idols, they think of it as the worship of real gods (NLT)

they believe they are eating food offered to a real god (GW)

when they eat this meat, they think of it as sacred/holy food that belongs to the god

sacrificed to an idol: This phrase translates the same Greek word that is used in 8:1a and 8:4a: “food sacrificed to idols.” See the note on 8:1a and translate it here in the same way as you translated it there.

8:7e**And since their conscience is weak,**

- And so, because their understanding/awareness of right and wrong is not strong enough to cause them to do what is right,
- They think this is wrong but they are weak and do it anyway,

their conscience: The Greek word that the BSB translates as conscience refers to a person's awareness about what is right and what is wrong. It guides a person to do what is right and not do what is wrong. Another way to translate this is:

their awareness/understanding of what is right and what is wrong

is weak: A weak conscience Different scholars have explained "weak conscience" in different ways. Some scholars think that a person with a "weak conscience" lacks the knowledge necessary to make the a decision about what is right and what is wrong. They need to learn more to do so. Garland supports this. Other scholars think that a person with a "weak conscience" is able to decide what is right and what is wrong, but their conscience is not strong enough to cause them act in a way that is consistent with what they think. This is the approach we have taken. Fee and Witherington support this. is one that does not cause a person to act in obedience to what he knows is right or wrong. He may be easily influenced to do the wrong thing. His conscience may be too weak to lead to right behavior because it is not yet strong enough to resist following the example of other Christians who "know" what is right. Some other ways to translate a "weak conscience" are:

their conscious/awareness is too weak to cause them to do what is right

their awareness/understanding of what is right is not enough to make them do it

though they believe/know it is wrong to eat the food, it is hard for them to choose to do what is right

8:7f it is defiled.

- their conscience becomes unclean/impure.
- so they feel guilty/shame before God.

it is defiled: The pronoun it refers to "their conscience." The word "defile" literally means "to make dirty." The person's conscience has become unclean or

impure in the sense that he feels he is guilty. His good relationship with God is broken because he thought it was wrong to eat meat that had been sacrificed to an idol but he did it anyway. Other ways to translate this include:

their weak consciences are spoiled

they feel guilty (NCV)

And so they have guilt/shame before God

General Comment on 8:7b-f

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in these verse parts and mention what defiles the conscience after 8:7f. For example:

^{7b}There are some who have been so accustomed to idolatry ^{7d}that they still think of this meat as consecrated to the idol, ^{7e}and their conscience, being weak, ^{7f}is defiled ^{7c}by eating it. (REB)

1 Corinthians 8:8

Section 8:1–13: Paul answered questions about eating meat that had been offered to idols

In this section Paul wrote about something else the Corinthians had asked him in their earlier letter. They had asked him whether it was acceptable for them to eat the meat of an animal that had been sacrificed to an idol. The primary context for eating such meat was at an idol's temple. Sometimes an animal would be offered to a false god in connection with a celebration such as a birthday or wedding to seek the god's blessing and presence at the celebration. The animal would be butchered by a priest and a portion of the meat would be burned on an altar as an offering to the false god. Some of the remaining meat would be returned to the person who offered it and could be eaten together with family or other invited guests at a private banquet room at the temple. (Some of the remaining meat might be sent to the meat market to be sold, a situation that Paul addresses in 10:25–26.)

There were two opinions in the Corinthian church about whether this meat could be eaten by a believer in Christ. Some of the Corinthian believers, including those who wrote the letter, understood that idols were only things that people have made or imagined. They were hoping Paul would agree with them that it was acceptable to eat this meat. However, some other believers thought that it was wrong to enter a temple and eat such meat. They still believed the false gods

were real and believed that eating meat offered to them in sacrifice was an act of worship or fellowship with these gods.

Paul agreed in this chapter that the idols worshiped at these temples were not real gods. But he did not give permission to eat this meat at their temple. Doing so might influence other believers to also eat the meat, even though they believed it was wrong. Paul asked the Corinthians believers to act in love toward these brothers rather than selfishly demanding the right to eat this meat.

In chapter 10, Paul will continue to answer the question about eating meat sacrificed to idols. He says that a believer can have no part in the worship of idols and also that demons are active in the sacrifices to idols. He also addresses the separate situations of buying and eating meat sold in the meat market and what to do when someone invites you to eat meat in their home. Before this, in chapter 9, he uses himself as an illustration of the principle he set down at the end of chapter 8 of giving up your rights in love. He had the right to be paid for his work as an apostle, but he gave up his right so that the good news of Jesus would be better accepted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul gave instructions about eating meat of/from animals that had been sacrificed to false gods

Believers should not eat anything that causes other believers to sin

Paragraph 8:7–13

In this paragraph Paul discussed a problem related to the knowledge that an idol is nothing. The problem is that not all believers have this knowledge. When those without this knowledge eat food sacrificed to idols, they think they are participating in rites to real gods. They know this is wrong, but being weak they are easily influenced to do it anyway. So believers who know that idols are nothing should not think only about what they have freedom to do, but rather should think about how what they do may influence other believers toward idolatry. They should not do anything that would cause another believer to do something he thinks is wrong.

8:8a

But food does not bring us closer to God:

- But what we^(incl) eat or do not eat does not make us more acceptable to God.
- I agree with you^(plur) who say that our^(incl) relationship with God is not based on whether we eat or do not eat certain foods.

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the statement in verse 7 and the statement in 8:8a. In verse 7, the believer with a weak conscience thinks that eating food sacrificed to an idol can injure the relationship between him and God. Verse part 8a says that what we eat does not make any difference in our relationship with God. Although eating food sacrificed to idols causes these believers to have guilt before God, it is not the food itself that causes the problem. Some English versions, such as the RSV, do not explicitly translate this conjunction. Consider if it is natural for you to translate this conjunction here.

food does not bring us closer to God: Paul believed that what you eat does not make you right with God. Eating the right food does not cause God to approve of you. Other ways to translate this include:

food will not bring us into God's presence (REB)

Food will not affect our relationship with God.
(GW)

In saying this, Paul was probably agreeing with the position of the Corinthians who had written to him and asked the question about eating food offered to idols. Some English versions translate this in a way that expresses agreement with what the Corinthians had said, and you may want to do the same. For example:

It's true that we can't win God's approval by what we eat. (NLT)

But of course food cannot make us acceptable to God (NJB)

food: The Greek word that the BSB translates as food is a general word that can refer to anything that is eaten. In this verse Paul was not speaking specifically of food that had been offered to idols, or of food that was eaten in a pagan temple.

8:8b-c

Though Paul agreed with the Corinthians who wrote the letter to him that food does not affect our relationship with God, in 8:8b-c (and the rest of the chapter) he challenges their position. They believed that not

eating food offered to idols was the wrong choice. And they believed they would benefit in different ways from choosing to eat this food at the temple. Paul says the opposite. He says that people who choose not to eat this food make a good choice; they are not worse off. And people who choose to eat this food do not gain anything.

These verse parts form a complementary pair. Translate them so that they match one another. For example:

We are no worse off if we do not eat, and no better off if we do. (RSV)

we shall not lose anything if we do not eat, nor shall we gain anything if we do eat (GNT)

Refusing to eat does not make us less pleasing to God, and eating does not make us better in God's sight. (NCV)

8:8b

We are no worse if we do not eat,

- If we^(incl) do not eat certain foods, that does not do us any harm.
- We do not displease God by not eating them,
- It is actually a good thing to not eat food offered to idols.

We are no worse if we do not eat: The believers Paul mentioned in 8:7 believed that they should not eat certain foods. Paul defends them here saying that their choice was a good one. These believers did not displease God by not eating such foods. Another way to translate this is:

we will not be less pleasing to God if we do not eat

If we do not eat, that is fine. God is still pleased with us.

8:8c

and no better if we do.

- And if we^(incl) do eat those foods, that does not do us any good.
- and we do not please God by eating them.
- And we gain no benefit when we eat idol food.

no better if we do: This is a short way of saying "We are no better if we do eat such foods." Paul was continuing to address the believers who had written to

him and who understood that idols are not real. They apparently thought they were pleasing God by eating idol food and so showing that they did not respect idols. Paul said that eating such foods does not please God or benefit them more than not eating them.

1 Corinthians 8:9

Section 8:1–13: Paul answered questions about eating meat that had been offered to idols

In this section Paul wrote about something else the Corinthians had asked him in their earlier letter. They had asked him whether it was acceptable for them to eat the meat of an animal that had been sacrificed to an idol. The primary context for eating such meat was at an idol's temple. Sometimes an animal would be offered to a false god in connection with a celebration such as a birthday or wedding to seek the god's blessing and presence at the celebration. The animal would be butchered by a priest and a portion of the meat would be burned on an altar as an offering to the false god. Some of the remaining meat would be returned to the person who offered it and could be eaten together with family or other invited guests at a private banquet room at the temple. (Some of the remaining meat might be sent to the meat market to be sold, a situation that Paul addresses in 10:25–26.)

There were two opinions in the Corinthian church about whether this meat could be eaten by a believer in Christ. Some of the Corinthian believers, including those who wrote the letter, understood that idols were only things that people have made or imagined. They were hoping Paul would agree with them that it was acceptable to eat this meat. However, some other believers thought that it was wrong to enter a temple and eat such meat. They still believed the false gods were real and believed that eating meat offered to them in sacrifice was an act of worship or fellowship with these gods.

Paul agreed in this chapter that the idols worshiped at these temples were not real gods. But he did not give permission to eat this meat at their temple. Doing so might influence other believers to also eat the meat, even though they believed it was wrong. Paul asked the Corinthians believers to act in love toward these brothers rather than selfishly demanding the right to eat this meat.

In chapter 10, Paul will continue to answer the question about eating meat sacrificed to idols. He says that a believer can have no part in the worship of idols and also that demons are active in the sacrifices to idols. He also addresses the separate situations of buying and eating meat sold in the meat market and what

to do when someone invites you to eat meat in their home. Before this, in chapter 9, he uses himself as an illustration of the principle he set down at the end of chapter 8 of giving up your rights in love. He had the right to be paid for his work as an apostle, but he gave up his right so that the good news of Jesus would be better accepted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul gave instructions about eating meat of/from animals that had been sacrificed to false gods

Believers should not eat anything that causes other believers to sin

Paragraph 8:7–13

In this paragraph Paul discussed a problem related to the knowledge that an idol is nothing. The problem is that not all believers have this knowledge. When those without this knowledge eat food sacrificed to idols, they think they are participating in rites to real gods. They know this is wrong, but being weak they are easily influenced to do it anyway. So believers who know that idols are nothing should not think only about what they have freedom to do, but rather should think about how what they do may influence other believers toward idolatry. They should not do anything that would cause another believer to do something he thinks is wrong.

8:9a

Be careful, however, that your freedom

- But, you^(plur) must beware that by acting/doing as you have a right to do
- Those of you who believe you are free to eat any food you want, I warn you

8:9b

does not become a stumbling block to the weak.

- you^(plur) do not cause weak believers to do something they think is wrong.
- not to lead believers with weak consciences into sin.

8:9a-b

Be careful: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Be careful is literally “Watch” or “Look.” It introduces a warning. Paul wanted the believers to avoid a dangerous situation. They should therefore carefully consider the consequences of eating meat sacrificed to idols.

however: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as however here introduces a warning that contrasts with what Paul had just said. In 8:8a, Paul agreed that food does not affect our relationship with God, and so in principle Christians have freedom or right to eat food that had been sacrificed to idols. Starting in this verse, Paul warned the Christians to be careful how they used that freedom.

Consider what would be a natural way to connect 8:9 to 8:8 in your language. Since the point of contrast is with the first part of verse 8 (8:8a) more than the last part of the verse (8:8b-c), you may or may not want to use a conjunction that indicates contrast. Among English versions, some mark the contrast and some do not. For example:

But take care that this liberty of yours does not somehow become a stumbling block to the weak. (NRSV)

Don’t cause problems for someone with a weak conscience, just because you have the right to eat anything. (CEV)

your freedom: The Greek words that the BSB translates as your freedom are more literally “this right of yours.” In some languages it may be helpful to say what this right was. The following English versions make this more explicit:

the right to eat anything (CEV)

your freedom to eat meat (JBP)

does not become a stumbling block to the weak:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as stumbling block is a metaphor. It refers to a log or a stone in a road or path that causes someone to fall down. Here the “exercise of your freedom” (to eat meat offered to idols) is compared to this kind of stone or log in the path. They are similar in that they both cause someone to fall and result in hurt or harm. One causes a person to literally fall down. The other causes a person to “fall into sin” (a biblical idiom) and harms his or her relationship with God. A different Greek word with a similar meaning is used in 1:23b.

If the meaning of the metaphor may be difficult to understand, some other ways this are:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

be careful that the exercise of your freedom does not become like a log/stone that makes the weak trip/fall

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

be careful that the exercise of your freedom does not cause your brothers with weak consciences to sin

- Keep the metaphor and also make the meaning clear. For example:

be careful that the exercise of your freedom does not cause the weak to fall into sin like a log across the path makes people fall

be careful that the exercise of your freedom not become a stone in the way that causes the weak to fall into sin

the weak: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the weak here refers to the people mentioned in 8:7a, those believers whose consciences were weak. You may want to make that clear in your translation.

1 Corinthians 8:10

Section 8:1-13: Paul answered questions about eating meat that had been offered to idols

In this section Paul wrote about something else the Corinthians had asked him in their earlier letter. They had asked him whether it was acceptable for them to eat the meat of an animal that had been sacrificed to an idol. The primary context for eating such meat was at an idol's temple. Sometimes an animal would be offered to a false god in connection with a celebration such as a birthday or wedding to seek the god's blessing and presence at the celebration. The animal would be butchered by a priest and a portion of the meat would be burned on an altar as an offering to the false god. Some of the remaining meat would be returned to the person who offered it and could be eaten together with family or other invited guests at a private banquet room at the temple. (Some of the remaining meat might be sent to the meat market to be sold, a situation that Paul addresses in 10:25-26.)

There were two opinions in the Corinthian church about whether this meat could be eaten by a believer in Christ. Some of the Corinthian believers, including those who wrote the letter, understood that idols were only things that people have made or imagined. They

were hoping Paul would agree with them that it was acceptable to eat this meat. However, some other believers thought that it was wrong to enter a temple and eat such meat. They still believed the false gods were real and believed that eating meat offered to them in sacrifice was an act of worship or fellowship with these gods.

Paul agreed in this chapter that the idols worshiped at these temples were not real gods. But he did not give permission to eat this meat at their temple. Doing so might influence other believers to also eat the meat, even though they believed it was wrong. Paul asked the Corinthians believers to act in love toward these brothers rather than selfishly demanding the right to eat this meat.

In chapter 10, Paul will continue to answer the question about eating meat sacrificed to idols. He says that a believer can have no part in the worship of idols and also that demons are active in the sacrifices to idols. He also addresses the separate situations of buying and eating meat sold in the meat market and what to do when someone invites you to eat meat in their home. Before this, in chapter 9, he uses himself as an illustration of the principle he set down at the end of chapter 8 of giving up your rights in love. He had the right to be paid for his work as an apostle, but he gave up his right so that the good news of Jesus would be better accepted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul gave instructions about eating meat of/from animals that had been sacrificed to false gods

Believers should not eat anything that causes other believers to sin

Paragraph 8:7-13

In this paragraph Paul discussed a problem related to the knowledge that an idol is nothing. The problem is that not all believers have this knowledge. When those without this knowledge eat food sacrificed to idols, they think they are participating in rites to real gods. They know this is wrong, but being weak they are easily influenced to do it anyway. So believers who know that idols are nothing should not think only about what they have freedom to do, but rather should think about how what they do may influence other believers toward idolatry. They should not do anything

that would cause another believer to do something he thinks is wrong.

8:10a-b

This verse is made up of a conditional clause (8:10a) followed by a rhetorical question (8:10b). The conditional clause states something that could possibly happen: someone sees you eating at an idol's temple. The rhetorical question suggests what the probable result would be: the person who sees you would be emboldened to also eat meat sacrificed to an idol there. It may be more natural in your language to change the form of the conditional clause or the rhetorical question to a statement.

Ways to translate the conditional clause include:

if anyone with a weak conscience sees you who have this knowledge eating in an idol's temple (NIV)

For example, suppose someone with a weak conscience sees you, who have this knowledge, eating in the temple of a false god. (GW)

someone who is weak in faith might see you eating there (NCV)

The rhetorical question implies the answer "Yes." Paul used this question to suggest what was likely to happen if 8:10a were true. Ways to translate this include:

- as a rhetorical question:

will not his conscience be emboldened to eat meat consecrated to the heathen deity? (REB)

- as a question and supply the implied answer "yes":

Will the person be encouraged to do what they think is wrong? Yes, he will.

- as a positive statement with a high degree of certainty. For example:

someone with a weak conscience will surely be encouraged to eat meat sacrificed to idols while thinking it wrong to do so

8:10a

For if someone with a weak conscience sees you who are well informed eating in an idol's temple,

- For suppose a believer with a weak conscience sees you^(sing) who know about idols while you^(sing) are eating idol food in an idol's temple.
- Perhaps one of you^(plur) who understands that idols are not real may go to an idol's place and eat food there. Then another believer who finds it hard do what is right may see you^(sing) eating there.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For here introduces Paul's reasons for warning the knowledgeable believers to be very careful about how they make use of their rights and freedoms. You should connect 8:10 to 8:9 in a way that is natural in your language.

someone with a weak conscience: The Greek subject here is literally "someone/anyone." The BSB has supplied the words with a weak conscience from the Greek of 8:10b.

you who are well informed: The Greek pronoun meaning you is singular. Paul uses the singular pronouns "someone" and you because he wants the Corinthians to think about an imaginary situation involving one believer with a weak conscience and one believer who believes it is permitted to eat meat offered to idols. The phrase you who are well informed here means "each one of you believers who knows that an idol is nothing."

an idol's temple: The Greek word that the BSB translates as an idol's temple refers to a building that contains something (often a statue) that people think represents a god. In Paul's time people used to gather at an idol's temple in order to honor the god by sacrificing animals and then eating the meat of those animals. Some ways of translating an idol's temple are

a house sacred/dedicated to an idol

a place where people go to worship one of their gods

8:10b

will he not be encouraged to eat food sacrificed to idols?

- Don't you^(sing) think he will be encouraged to eat meat that has been sacrificed to idols?
- That will surely give him false confidence to do what he sees you^(sing) doing. He will eat meat that has been offered/given to an idol even though he thinks it is wrong.

will he not be encouraged: The English verb phrase will he not be encouraged means "will he not be made

bold?” The Greek word that the BSB translates as be encouraged literally means “to be made strong to do something.” It is the same word that is used in 8:1d, where it is translated as “builds up.” Here however it is used in a bad sense. The weak believer feels strong to do something that he should not do. It is a passive verb. There are two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

won't he be emboldened...? (NIV)

- using an active verb. For example:

will not this encourage him...? (GNT)

food sacrificed to idols: The Greek word here is the same as in 8:1a. See the note there on food sacrificed to idols and translate it here in the same way.

General Comment on 8:10a-b

In some languages it may be natural to break this long sentence up into two or more sentences. For example:

^{10a}For example, suppose someone with a weak conscience sees you, who have this knowledge, eating in the temple of a false god. ^{10b}Won't you be encouraging that person to eat food offered to a false god? (GW)

1 Corinthians 8:11

Section 8:1-13: Paul answered questions about eating meat that had been offered to idols

In this section Paul wrote about something else the Corinthians had asked him in their earlier letter. They had asked him whether it was acceptable for them to eat the meat of an animal that had been sacrificed to an idol. The primary context for eating such meat was at an idol's temple. Sometimes an animal would be offered to a false god in connection with a celebration such as a birthday or wedding to seek the god's blessing and presence at the celebration. The animal would be butchered by a priest and a portion of the meat would be burned on an altar as an offering to the false god. Some of the remaining meat would be returned to the person who offered it and could be eaten together with family or other invited guests at a private banquet room at the temple. (Some of the remaining meat might be sent to the meat market to be sold, a situation that Paul addresses in 10:25-26.)

There were two opinions in the Corinthian church about whether this meat could be eaten by a believer

in Christ. Some of the Corinthian believers, including those who wrote the letter, understood that idols were only things that people have made or imagined. They were hoping Paul would agree with them that it was acceptable to eat this meat. However, some other believers thought that it was wrong to enter a temple and eat such meat. They still believed the false gods were real and believed that eating meat offered to them in sacrifice was an act of worship or fellowship with these gods.

Paul agreed in this chapter that the idols worshiped at these temples were not real gods. But he did not give permission to eat this meat at their temple. Doing so might influence other believers to also eat the meat, even though they believed it was wrong. Paul asked the Corinthians believers to act in love toward these brothers rather than selfishly demanding the right to eat this meat.

In chapter 10, Paul will continue to answer the question about eating meat sacrificed to idols. He says that a believer can have no part in the worship of idols and also that demons are active in the sacrifices to idols. He also addresses the separate situations of buying and eating meat sold in the meat market and what to do when someone invites you to eat meat in their home. Before this, in chapter 9, he uses himself as an illustration of the principle he set down at the end of chapter 8 of giving up your rights in love. He had the right to be paid for his work as an apostle, but he gave up his right so that the good news of Jesus would be better accepted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul gave instructions about eating meat of/from animals that had been sacrificed to false gods

Believers should not eat anything that causes other believers to sin

Paragraph 8:7-13

In this paragraph Paul discussed a problem related to the knowledge that an idol is nothing. The problem is that not all believers have this knowledge. When those without this knowledge eat food sacrificed to idols, they think they are participating in rites to real gods. They know this is wrong, but being weak they are easily influenced to do it anyway. So believers who know that idols are nothing should not think only about what they have freedom to do, but rather should

think about how what they do may influence other believers toward idolatry. They should not do anything that would cause another believer to do something he thinks is wrong.

8:11

So this weak brother, for whom Christ died, is destroyed by your knowledge.

- So by knowing so much you^(sing) will ruin a weak believer, a person for whom Christ died.
- In that way, you will harm/damage a believer who is weak because of what you know. And Christ died for this person.

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So here introduces the result that Paul thinks will happen if a weak believer feels encouraged to do something his conscience tells him is wrong for him to do. Some other ways to translate this are:

In that case (GW)

and then (NJB)

As a result

this weak brother...is destroyed by your knowledge: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as is destroyed. The Greek word that the BSB translates as “destroyed” occurs numerous times in the New Testament. It is often translated as lose, kill, destroy or ruin. When it is used to refer to people, it usually refers to a non-Christians being lost or destroyed. In this verse, the verb refers to a Christian brother. The two most common English translations for this word are “destroy” and “ruin.” In order to help decide how to translate this word in this verse, it is useful to consider the entire chapter. The best information is found in 1 Corinthians 8:12 since it is a restatement of some of the information in verse 11. Verse 11 talks about a brother being “destroyed by your knowledge.” Verse 12 talks about “wounding their weak conscience.” Verse 7 says “their conscience is defiled,” verse 9 says, “become a stumbling block to the weak,” and verse 13 says, “causes my brother to stumble.” All of these expressions are weaker than “destroy” so when you translate this verse, it is probably better to use a weaker word like “ruin.” means to be ruined. In this context, it probably indicates that the believer’s conscience, and as a result his spiritual life, will be harmed. This believer becomes weaker in his ability to do what is right as a Christian. By eating food that

was sacrificed to idols, he has begun to go back to the worship of idols.

Some ways to translate this are:

This weak believer for whom Christ died is ruined because of your “knowledge.” (NCV)

by your knowledge, you cause spiritual disaster to a weaker brother

your example/practice, based on what you know [about idols], harms/damages the faith of your weaker brother

is destroyed: The verb is destroyed is passive. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this clause without using a passive verb. For example:

And so this weak person, this brother for whom Christ died, will perish because of your knowledge. (GNT)

This ‘knowledge’ of yours destroys the weak, the fellow-Christian for whom Christ died. (REB)

by your knowledge: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as by your knowledge here means “through your knowledge” or “because of your knowledge.” Directly or indirectly, the knowledge of the strong believer destroys the weak believer. Other ways to translate this include:

because of your superior knowledge (NLT)

through your knowledge (NJB)

what you know has destroyed someone (CEV)

General Comment on 8:11

You may wish to reorder the phrases in this verse. For example:

So because of your superior knowledge, a weak believer for whom Christ died will be destroyed. (NLT)

This ‘knowledge’ of yours destroys the weak, the fellow Christian for whom Christ died. (REB)

1 Corinthians 8:12

Section 8:1–13: Paul answered questions about eating meat that had been offered to idols

In this section Paul wrote about something else the Corinthians had asked him in their earlier letter. They had asked him whether it was acceptable for them to eat the meat of an animal that had been sacrificed to an idol. The primary context for eating such meat was at an idol's temple. Sometimes an animal would be offered to a false god in connection with a celebration such as a birthday or wedding to seek the god's blessing and presence at the celebration. The animal would be butchered by a priest and a portion of the meat would be burned on an altar as an offering to the false god. Some of the remaining meat would be returned to the person who offered it and could be eaten together with family or other invited guests at a private banquet room at the temple. (Some of the remaining meat might be sent to the meat market to be sold, a situation that Paul addresses in 10:25–26.)

There were two opinions in the Corinthian church about whether this meat could be eaten by a believer in Christ. Some of the Corinthian believers, including those who wrote the letter, understood that idols were only things that people have made or imagined. They were hoping Paul would agree with them that it was acceptable to eat this meat. However, some other believers thought that it was wrong to enter a temple and eat such meat. They still believed the false gods were real and believed that eating meat offered to them in sacrifice was an act of worship or fellowship with these gods.

Paul agreed in this chapter that the idols worshiped at these temples were not real gods. But he did not give permission to eat this meat at their temple. Doing so might influence other believers to also eat the meat, even though they believed it was wrong. Paul asked the Corinthians believers to act in love toward these brothers rather than selfishly demanding the right to eat this meat.

In chapter 10, Paul will continue to answer the question about eating meat sacrificed to idols. He says that a believer can have no part in the worship of idols and also that demons are active in the sacrifices to idols. He also addresses the separate situations of buying and eating meat sold in the meat market and what to do when someone invites you to eat meat in their home. Before this, in chapter 9, he uses himself as an illustration of the principle he set down at the end of chapter 8 of giving up your rights in love. He had the right to be paid for his work as an apostle, but he gave

up his right so that the good news of Jesus would be better accepted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul gave instructions about eating meat of/from animals that had been sacrificed to false gods

Believers should not eat anything that causes other believers to sin

Paragraph 8:7–13

In this paragraph Paul discussed a problem related to the knowledge that an idol is nothing. The problem is that not all believers have this knowledge. When those without this knowledge eat food sacrificed to idols, they think they are participating in rites to real gods. They know this is wrong, but being weak they are easily influenced to do it anyway. So believers who know that idols are nothing should not think only about what they have freedom to do, but rather should think about how what they do may influence other believers toward idolatry. They should not do anything that would cause another believer to do something he thinks is wrong.

8:12a,c

By sinning against your brothers in this way

- When/if you^(plur) sin like that against other Christian brothers and sisters
- And not only that, by doing wrong to other believers,

By sinning against your brothers in this way...

you sin against Christ: Paul strengthens his warning against eating idol meat at the temple by saying that sinning against your Christian brothers by doing this (8:12a) is the same as sinning against Christ (8:12c). Some ways to express the relation between 8:12a and 8:12c could be:

When/if you sin against your brothers by doing those things..., you sin against Christ.

By sinning in this way against your brothers..., you also sin against Christ.

Sinning like that against your brothers...is the same as sinning against Christ.

In 8:12, Paul states another consequence of the strong believers eating food in an idol's temple. Not only do

they cause significant spiritual harm to their Christian brothers (8:11), sinning against them in this way is the same as sinning against Christ. The words “in this way” connect the consequence stated in 8:12 to the actions described in 8:10–11. See the note below on “in this way.”

By sinning against your brothers: The believers who considered themselves strong and wise were harming other Christians. They were sinning against them in the sense that they were causing them to sin.

in this way: In Greek the word that the BSB translates as in this way refers back to the way in which the strong believers would harm the weak believers if they were seen eating meat offered to idols as described in 8:10–11. You may want to make the relationship between 8:11 and 8:12 clear at the beginning of 8:12 with a connecting word or phrase. For example:

And in this way (GNT)

Thus, sinning against your brothers... (ESV)

And so, by sinning against the brethren... (NASB)

Another way to translate this is:

by doing this/that

8:12b

and wounding their weak conscience,

- by hurting/injuring/weakening their ability to know and do what is right,
- and making it even harder for them to know and do what is right,

and wounding their weak conscience: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as wounding literally means to strike or hit something. If what is being hit is soft and tender, the hitting causes real harm or injury. Paul used this verb here as a figure of speech to describe how a strong believer might injure other believers by making them even weaker. This happens when the actions of the strong believer cause the weak believer to do something he thinks he should not do. Other ways to translate this include:

cause them to do what they think is wrong (NCV)

hurting a follower with a weak conscience (CEV)

8:12c

you sin against Christ.

- you^(plur) are also sinning against Christ himself.
- you are doing wrong to Christ himself.

you sin against Christ: Paul was probably referring to what Jesus himself had said, that when anyone does something to help or hurt one who belongs to him, they are helping or hurting him also (Matthew 25:40, 25:45; Acts 9:1–5).

1 Corinthians 8:13

Section 8:1–13: Paul answered questions about eating meat that had been offered to idols

In this section Paul wrote about something else the Corinthians had asked him in their earlier letter. They had asked him whether it was acceptable for them to eat the meat of an animal that had been sacrificed to an idol. The primary context for eating such meat was at an idol's temple. Sometimes an animal would be offered to a false god in connection with a celebration such as a birthday or wedding to seek the god's blessing and presence at the celebration. The animal would be butchered by a priest and a portion of the meat would be burned on an altar as an offering to the false god. Some of the remaining meat would be returned to the person who offered it and could be eaten together with family or other invited guests at a private banquet room at the temple. (Some of the remaining meat might be sent to the meat market to be sold, a situation that Paul addresses in 10:25–26.)

There were two opinions in the Corinthian church about whether this meat could be eaten by a believer in Christ. Some of the Corinthian believers, including those who wrote the letter, understood that idols were only things that people have made or imagined. They were hoping Paul would agree with them that it was acceptable to eat this meat. However, some other believers thought that it was wrong to enter a temple and eat such meat. They still believed the false gods were real and believed that eating meat offered to them in sacrifice was an act of worship or fellowship with these gods.

Paul agreed in this chapter that the idols worshiped at these temples were not real gods. But he did not give permission to eat this meat at their temple. Doing so might influence other believers to also eat the meat, even though they believed it was wrong. Paul asked the Corinthians believers to act in love toward these brothers rather than selfishly demanding the right to eat this meat.

In chapter 10, Paul will continue to answer the question about eating meat sacrificed to idols. He says that a believer can have no part in the worship of idols and also that demons are active in the sacrifices to idols. He also addresses the separate situations of buying and eating meat sold in the meat market and what to do when someone invites you to eat meat in their home. Before this, in chapter 9, he uses himself as an illustration of the principle he set down at the end of chapter 8 of giving up your rights in love. He had the right to be paid for his work as an apostle, but he gave up his right so that the good news of Jesus would be better accepted.

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Believers should not eat anything that causes other believers to sin

Paragraph 8:7–13

In this paragraph Paul discussed a problem related to the knowledge that an idol is nothing. The problem is that not all believers have this knowledge. When those without this knowledge eat food sacrificed to idols, they think they are participating in rites to real gods. They know this is wrong, but being weak they are easily influenced to do it anyway. So believers who know that idols are nothing should not think only about what they have freedom to do, but rather should think about how what they do may influence other believers toward idolatry. They should not do anything that would cause another believer to do something he thinks is wrong.

8:13

Paul concluded this section by using himself as an example. He said that he would give up his rights and freedoms in order not to hurt other believers. He implied that he wanted the Corinthians to think and act in the same way that he did.

8:13a

Therefore, if what I eat causes my brother to stumble,

- So now, if I might cause/lead another believer to do something wrong by my choice of what to eat,
- So if what I choose to eat may harm the faith of a brother or sister in Christ,

Therefore: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Therefore here introduces a conclusion to this part of Paul's discussion.

if what I eat causes my brother to stumble: Paul assumed that this could be true, though it was probably not true that Paul caused a brother to fall into sin by what he ate. Paul says this to make the point that he would happily give up eating all meat if it might influence someone to do what they believed was wrong.

what I eat: The Greek word that the BSB translates as what I eat is literally “food.” It is the general word for food that was used in 8:8a.

causes...to stumble: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as causes...to stumble means much the same as “become a stumbling block to the weak” in 8:9b. See the note there. In this context, this verb refers to causing someone to do what he thinks is wrong.

8:13b

I will never eat meat again,

- then I will never eat any kind of meat anymore.
- I personally have decided I will not eat meat again forever.

I will never eat meat again: Paul uses a general word for meat here and not the specific word that means “meat offered to idols.” He probably says this with some hyperbole, that is, Paul expressed this in extreme terms to make a strong point: I will not eat any meat at all ever again.

8:13c

so that I will not cause him to stumble.

- I will do that so that I will not cause another believer to sin.
- I do not want to lead another believer to sin by doing what he thinks is wrong.

so that I will not cause him to stumble: This is a negative purpose clause. Paul would gladly give up eating meat in order to avoid causing someone else to sin. The Greek verb that the BSB translates as cause...to stumble is the same as in 8:13a where the BSB translates it as “causes...to stumble.” You may be able to translate it here in the same way as you translated it there. Other ways to translate this include:

rather than cause my brother's downfall (NJB)

for fear I might do him harm (JBP)

for I don't want to cause another believer to stumble (NLT)

him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as him is literally "my brother," as in the RSV. Here it refers to a fellow believer. You should translate it in a way that is natural in your language for referring to another believer.

1 Corinthians 9:1

Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:1–2

In this paragraph Paul argued that he truly was an apostle and gave proof of his apostleship.

9:1a–d

In this verse there are four rhetorical questions which describe Paul's authority as an apostle and why he acted as he did.

9:1a

Am I not free?

- ¶ I am a free person, am I not?
- ¶ Am I not free from the law? Yes I am.
- ¶ I am free. (CEV)

Am I not free?: This is the first of four rhetorical questions in 9:1.9:1 In some Greek manuscripts the first two questions are in reverse order. The KJV follows these manuscripts. It is recommended that you follow the order in the BSB, which is the same as that of the UBS Greek NT. Paul used this question as a strong statement that expects the response "yes." He stated

that he was free. Here are some ways to translate this strong statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Don't you agree that I'm a free man? (GW)

Am I not free from the law?

- Use a rhetorical question with its own response. For example:

Am I not a free person? Of course I am.

- Use a strong statement. For example:

I am free (CEV)

Nothing controls me

I am free from the law

Translate this strong statement in a way that is natural in your language.

free: There are at least two ways to interpret the meaning of the word free.

1. Paul was free from the ceremonial law, and thus free to eat and drink what he liked. This refers back to chapter 8. This could be expressed as:

Am I not free from the law?9:1 See Thiselton, Robertson and Plummer, or Lenski.

1. Paul was free to not have to work for a living. This refers forward to 9:5–12. This could be expressed as:

Am I not free from working for my living?9:1 See Ellington & Hatton.

It is best to translate this in a way that allows for either interpretation, if possible. If you must make a choice, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the interpretation supported by several commentaries. The word free in this verse does not refer to freedom from slavery.

9:1b

Am I not an apostle?

- I am an apostle, am I not?
- I am a messenger of Christ.

Am I not an apostle?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement that expects the response “yes.” It introduces Paul’s proof that he was an apostle. He continued to make this point in 9:3–18. Here are some ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Don’t you agree that I am an apostle? (GW)

Do you think that I am not an apostle?

- Use a rhetorical question with its own response. For example:

Am I not an apostle? Of course I am.

- Use a strong statement. For example:

Certainly, I am an apostle

Translate this strong statement in a way that will help readers to think about Paul’s authority and his position as an apostle.

apostle: The word apostle means “a messenger.” It is someone who is sent on a mission or sent with a message. An apostle represents the people who sent him, and has their authority.

The “apostles” were the people whom Jesus sent with his authority to heal the sick, cast out evil spirits, and preach the good news of the Kingdom.

Here are some ways to translate the word apostle:

- Translate the meaning of the Greek word apostle. For example:

messenger

representative

person sent to speak/act for Jesus

person with authority from Jesus

- Indicate the role or function of apostles. For example:

chief leader of Jesus’ work

person who is in charge of Jesus’ work

Use the word for apostle that you used in the gospels. See for example, Matthew 10:2.

Be careful to choose different terms for apostle, “disciple,” “angel,” “elder,” and “prophet.”

See also the article in KBT about the term apostle.

9:1c

Have I not seen Jesus our Lord?

- I have seen Jesus our^(incl) Lord, have I not?
- I myself have seen our Lord Jesus.

Have I not seen Jesus our Lord?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement. He expected them to respond, “Yes, you have.” Here are some ways to translate this strong statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Haven’t I seen Jesus our Lord with my own eyes? (NLT)

- Use a rhetorical question with its own response. For example:

Have I not seen Jesus our Lord? Of course I have.

- Use a statement. For example:

I myself have seen Jesus our Lord

Translate this strong statement in a way that is natural in your language.

One requirement for becoming an apostle was to see Jesus after his resurrection.9:1 See Acts 1:21–22. Paul saw Jesus when Jesus appeared to him on the road to Damascus. Paul told them that he had seen Jesus in order to prove to them that he was an apostle. See Acts 9:1–6; 1 Corinthians 15:8; Galatians 1:11–17.

9:1d

Are you yourselves not my workmanship in the Lord?

- Are you^(plur) not the fruit of my work in the Lord?
- You became followers of the Lord as a result of the work that he helped me to do, did you not?
- You are my work in the Lord.

Are you yourselves not my workmanship in the Lord?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement. He expected them to respond, “Yes,

we are.” Here are some ways to translate this strong statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Aren’t you the result of my work for the Lord?
(GNT)

- Use a rhetorical question with its own response. For example:

Are you not my workmanship in the Lord? Of course you are.

- Use a statement. For example:

You are my workmanship in the Lord

Translate this strong statement in a way that is natural in your language.

The second requirement for becoming an apostle was to receive a commission from the Lord Jesus to preach the gospel. Paul received that commission, and the Corinthians believed in the Lord Jesus through his message. See Acts 22:14–15, Galatians 1:15–16, and 1 Corinthians 2:1–5. So the Corinthians believers were proof that Paul was an apostle.

my workmanship: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as my workmanship is more literally “my work.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

You are the fruit of my work

Are you not my work in the Lord? (NJB)

Isn’t it because of my work that you belong to the Lord? (NLT)

Translate this phrase so that the meaning is clear. Paul preached the gospel and the Corinthians became believers through hearing him preach. Here is another way to translate this:

I...have led you to have faith in him (CEV)

in the Lord: There are three ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in the Lord:

1. It means that Paul worked through the Lord. The Lord enabled Paul to do this work. For example:

aren’t you the result of my work which the Lord helped me to do?

1. It means that Paul worked for the Lord. For example:

aren’t you the result of my work for the Lord?
(GNT) (GNT, GW)

1. It indicates that the Corinthians were in the Lord. For example:

Isn’t it because of my work that you belong to the Lord? (NLT) (NLT, CEV)

It is recommended that you choose interpretation (1). This is supported by several commentaries.^{9:1} See, for example, Ellington & Hatton, page 193, which says, “In the Lord means in this context ‘by the Lord working through me.’” Most English versions translate this literally and it is not clear which view they support.

General Comment on 9:1a-d

In some languages it may not be natural to have four short sentences in a row like this. You may wish to combine two or more into a longer sentence. For example:

^{1a}I am free. ^{1b}I am an apostle. ^{1c}I have seen the Lord Jesus ^{1d}and have led you to have faith in him. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 9:2

Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:1-2

In this paragraph Paul argued that he truly was an apostle and gave proof of his apostleship.

9:2a

Even if I am not an apostle to others,

- Even if others say I am not an apostle,
- Some people do not think I am Christ's messenger,

Even if I am not an apostle to others: In this clause Paul said that some people did not accept him as an apostle. He did not say that he was not an apostle. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

Others may think that I am not an apostle (CEV)

Even if others do not accept me as an apostle (GNT)

9:2b

surely I am to you.

- surely you^(plur) must accept me.
- but you know that I am, for sure.

surely I am to you: The phrase surely I am to you means "surely I am an apostle to you." It indicates that the Corinthians should acknowledge that Paul was a true apostle. Translate this in a way that fits with your translation of the previous verse part. For example:

Even if others do not accept me as an apostle, surely you do! (GNT)

9:2c

For you are the seal of my apostleship in the Lord.

- For you^(plur) are like a seal which proves that I am an apostle of the Lord Jesus.
- The fact that you live in union with the Lord proves that I am his apostle.
- The fact that you believe in the Lord shows that I am his messenger, because I am the one who told you about him.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces Paul's grounds for saying that he was an apostle to the Corinthians.

you are the seal of my apostleship: The word seal refers to a mark pressed into wax or clay. For example, a person put a seal onto a letter as proof that it was

genuine. The seal proved that the letter came from the person it claimed to be from. Paul used this word as a metaphor. He was saying that the believers in Corinth were proof that he was a true apostle. Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- keep the figure of speech. For example:

you are the very seal of my apostleship (REB)

you are like a seal showing to others that I am an apostle

- use the figure of speech and explain the meaning. For example:

You are the seal which proves I am the Lord's apostle (GW)

- translate the meaning only. For example:

you are proof that I am an apostle (NCV)

my apostleship: The word apostleship refers to the official position or work of an apostle. See apostle in 9:1.

in the Lord: There are several ways to understand how this phrase relates to the rest of the sentence:

1. It relates to the word "you." It indicates that the Corinthians were in the Lord, or united to the Lord. 9:2 See Thiselton, Fee, Robertson and Plummer, Ellington and Hatton, or Deibler. For example:

Because of your life in union with the Lord you yourselves are proof of the fact that I am an apostle (GNT) (GNT, GW)

1. It relates to the word "apostleship." It indicates that Paul was an apostle in the Lord or for the Lord. For example:

You yourselves are the proof of my work as the Lord's apostle (NLT) (NLT, NCV)

1. It relates to the whole sentence in general. For example:

For in the Lord you are the very seal of my apostleship (REB) (REB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). That is supported by several English versions and several commentators. However, the exact emphasis of Paul's thought is not certain.

1 Corinthians 9:3

Section 9:1-27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:3-7

In this paragraph Paul discussed his right to receive food and drink from the people he served. He used three examples from everyday life to illustrate his argument.

9:3

This is my defense to those who scrutinize me:

- ¶ This is how I defend myself to those who judge me.
- ¶ When people question my authority, this is how I answer them.

This is my defense: The word This refers to what Paul is about to say. 9:3 Several commentators think that "this" refers to what Paul has just said. However, none of the main English versions follow this interpretation. The defense is what follows in 9:4-12b. If you start a new paragraph at verse 3 it may help to make this clear. Or, your language may have another way to show this. For example:

The following is my defense

my defense: The word defense refers to the answer that a person gives to someone who is accusing him.

In some languages it may be more natural to translate the noun defense as a verb. For example:

this is how I defend myself (GNT)

to those who scrutinize me: This phrase refers to those among the Corinthians who questioned whether Paul was a genuine apostle. Another way to translate this phrase is:

those who question my authority (NLT)

General Comment on 9:3

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in this verse. For example:

When people criticize me, this is how I defend myself (GNT)

To those who would call me to account, this is my defence (REB)

1 Corinthians 9:4

Section 9:1-27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:3-7

In this paragraph Paul discussed his right to receive food and drink from the people he served. He used three examples from everyday life to illustrate his argument.

9:4**Have we no right to food and to drink?**

- We^(excl) surely have the right to receive food and drink, don't we?
- When we apostles preach to you^(plur) we have the right to receive material help from you.

Have we no right to food and to drink?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement. He expected them to respond, "Yes." He said that he and his fellow workers had the right to receive food and drink. Because they served others, it was right that they receive food from them for their work.

Here are some ways to translate this strong statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Do we not have the right to eat and drink? (NCV)

- Use a rhetorical question with its own response. For example:

Do we not have the right to food and drink? Of course we do.

- Use a statement. For example:

Barnabas and I have the right to our food and drink (CEV)

Have we no right...?: A right is an opportunity to act in a way that is fair and just. Sometimes a right is guaranteed by the law. However, Paul talked about things that were proper for him and Barnabas because the other apostles did them.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

it is right that we^(excl) should receive food and drink

it is appropriate that others should give us^(excl) food and drink

we: There are two ways to interpret the pronoun we:

1. It refers to Paul and his fellow workers such as Barnabas. For example:

we (NIV) (NIV, RSV, NET, GW, ESV, NJB, NASB, CEV, NLT, NABRE, NCV, KJV)

1. It refers to Paul alone. For example:

I (GNT) (GNT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is followed by most English versions. Some languages distinguish between inclusive and exclusive we. If this is the case, you should use the exclusive we. Paul did not include his readers.

to food and to drink: There is some implied information here. The words food and drink refer also to lodging and other necessities. In some languages it may be helpful to make this explicit.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to financial support (NET)

to live in your homes and share your meals (NLT)

to food and other necessities

1 Corinthians 9:5**Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle**

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:3–7

In this paragraph Paul discussed his right to receive food and drink from the people he served. He used three examples from everyday life to illustrate his argument.

9:5a-b

Have we no right to take along a believing wife, as do the other apostles and the Lord's brothers and Cephas?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question as a statement. He expected them to respond, "Yes." He stated that he and his fellow workers had the same right as the other apostles to travel with a wife.

Here are some ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Do we not have the right to bring a believing wife with us when we travel as do the other apostles and the Lord's brothers and Peter? (NCV)

- Use a statement. For example:

We each have the right to marry one of the Lord's followers and to take her along with us, just as the other apostles and the Lord's brothers and Peter do. (CEV)

Translate this statement in a way that is natural in your language.

9:5a

Have we no right to take along a believing wife,

- We^(excl) surely have the right to have a believing wife accompany us on our journeys, don't we?
- And when we travel doing the Lord's work, it is right that we can take along a Christian wife.

Have we no right to take along a believing wife...?: In this clause Paul said that he and the other apostles have the right to take a wife with them on their journeys. He implied that it was right for the churches to support this wife as well as the apostle. Consider how you translated the idea Have we no right in 9:4. It is good to translate it in the same way in this verse. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

it is right that we should be able to ask our believing wife to accompany us

May we not travel with a Christian wife (JBP)

we: The pronoun we is exclusive. Paul referred to himself and his fellow apostles, not to his readers.

a believing wife: Here is another way to translate this:

a Christian wife (NJB)

In your translation, make sure that you do not imply that an apostle brought his Christian wife from among his several other wives. In some languages it may be better to say

a believer who is his wife

9:5b

as do the other apostles and the Lord's brothers and Cephas?

- That is what the rest of the apostles and the Lord's own brothers and Peter have the right to do.
- The other messengers of the Lord, including Peter and the Lord's brothers, are able to do this.

as do the other apostles and the Lord's brothers and Cephas: There is no verb in the last part of this sentence. The BSB has supplied the verb do. This could mean either "do have this right" or "do take along with them." It is best to translate this in a way that means "do have this right." Paul was focused on his rights as an apostle. Some ways to translate this are:

like the other apostles and the Lord's brothers and Cephas

This is what the other apostles and the Lord's brothers and Cephas have the right to do

the other apostles and the Lord's brothers and Cephas: These were not separate groups of people. The Lord's brothers were probably included in the group of apostles, and Cephas certainly was. To avoid the wrong meaning that Cephas was not an apostle, it may be necessary to say:

the other apostles, including Cephas and the Lord's brothers

the Lord's brothers: These were the younger brothers of Jesus. In some languages it may be necessary to say:

the Lord's younger brothers

Cephas: Cephas was the Aramaic name of Simon Peter. Some English versions say "Peter." If you put Cephas in the text, you may wish to include this footnote:

FOOTNOTE: Cephas is another name for Simon Peter.

If you put “Peter” in the text, you may wish to include this footnote:

FOOTNOTE: The Greek text says “Cephas,” which is the name of Peter in Aramaic.

General Comment on 9:5a-b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 9:5a-b. For example:

The other apostles and the Lord’s brothers and Peter take their Christian wives with them when they travel, and we^(excl) have this right too.9:5 See Ellington & Hatton, page 196.

1 Corinthians 9:6

Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul’s rights as an apostle

Paul’s example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:3–7

In this paragraph Paul discussed his right to receive food and drink from the people he served. He used three examples from everyday life to illustrate his argument.

9:6

Or are Barnabas and I the only apostles who must work for a living?

- Or is it only I and Barnabas who must work with our^{(excl)(dual)} hands in order to support ourselves?

- All the other apostles do not work to earn money/food, so surely Barnabas and I are not required to work either.

Or are Barnabas and I the only apostles who must work for a living?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong negative statement.

Here are some ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Are Barnabas and I the only ones who must work to earn our living? (NCV)

Are we the only ones who must support ourselves by working at another job? (CEV)

- Use a strong negative statement. For example:

It is not right that Barnabas and I are the only ones who must work for a living

Translate this strong negative statement in a way that is natural in your language.

Barnabas: Barnabas was a close friend to Paul. These two apostles worked closely together. See Acts 9:27 and 11:25–26.

work for a living: Many languages have an idiomatic way to say work for a living. Choose a way that is natural in your language. Some examples are:

work with our own hands

seek food/money/rice

feed ourselves

General Comment on 9:6

The Greek text uses a double negative, which may be natural in some languages. For example:

Or is it only Barnabas and I who have no right to refrain from working for a living? (ESV)

1 Corinthians 9:7

Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he

used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:3-7

In this paragraph Paul discussed his right to receive food and drink from the people he served. He used three examples from everyday life to illustrate his argument.

9:7a-c

In this verse Paul gave three examples of workers who receive a salary or benefit from their work. He said this to show that apostles should also receive a salary from their work.

9:7a

Who serves as a soldier at his own expense?

- Do soldiers pay their own salaries?
- While a man is fighting as a soldier, he does not have to support himself.

Who serves as a soldier at his own expense?: This is the first of three rhetorical questions in 9:7. Paul used this rhetorical question as a statement. He expected them to respond, "No one." He said that soldiers do not pay their own salary.

Here are some ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Do soldiers pay their own salaries? (CEV)

Did you ever hear of a man serving in the army at his own expense? (REB)

- Use a rhetorical question with its own response. For example:

Who serves as a soldier at his own expense? No one.

- Use a statement. For example:

No soldier ever serves in the army and pays his own salary. (NCV)

Translate this statement in a way that is most natural in your language.

soldier: In some languages it may be more natural to refer to "soldiers" in the plural, rather than soldier. See examples in the notes.

9:7b

Who plants a vineyard and does not eat of its fruit?

- Don't people who plant grape vines eat some of the grapes?
- And when a person takes care of fruit trees, he has the right to eat their fruit.

Who plants a vineyard and does not eat of its fruit?:

This is the second of three rhetorical questions in 9:7. Paul used this rhetorical question as a statement. He expected them to respond, "No one." Paul said that a person who plants a vineyard can eat some of the fruit.

Here are some ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Does anyone plant a vineyard and not eat the grapes? (GW)

Don't people who raise grapes eat some of what they grow? (CEV)

What farmers do not eat the grapes from their own vineyard? (GNT)

- Use a rhetorical question with its own response. For example:

Who plants a vineyard and does not eat of its fruit? No one.

- Use a statement. For example:

No one ever plants a vineyard without eating some of the grapes. (NCV)

vineyard: A vineyard is a field where people grow grapes. Grapes are a small, sweet fruit that people commonly grew in ancient Israel. They used them to make wine. The plant that grapes grow on is a vine with a woody trunk like a shrub or tree. The trunk and

its branches grow along the ground unless they are supported.

Here are some other ways to refer to a vineyard:

grape farm

field of grape vines/plants/trees

In some languages there may not be a word for vineyard or for “grape.” If that is true in your language, here are two other options to consider:

- Borrow the word for “grape” from another language and add a general expression that describes what a vineyard is. For example:

farm for producing a fruit called grapes

field for growing/cultivating fruit from grape vines

- Use a general word for fruit that would fit in this context. For example:

farm/field to produce a fruit used to make wine

fruit: The Greek word that the BSB translates as fruit is a general word, but in this context it is clear that it refers specifically to “grapes” from the vineyard. So, it is possible to translate this as:

grapes (NIV)

Vineyards and grapes are spoken of figuratively in many places in the Bible. You may want to look at these other contexts as you decide how to translate these words. Here are some passages that refer to vineyards: Isaiah 5:1–7, Genesis 9:20, and Matthew 20:1. Here are some passages that refer to grapes: Genesis 40:10–11, Isaiah 5:2, and Matthew 7:16.

9:7c

Who tends a flock and does not drink of its milk?

- Don’t people who take care of sheep/goats, drink some of the milk?
- And if a person raises animals, he has the right to use the milk that he gets from them.

Who tends a flock and does not drink of its milk?:

This is the third of three rhetorical questions in 9:7. Paul used this rhetorical question as a statement. He expected them to respond, “No one.” Paul said that

people who take care of animals benefit from them by using their milk.

Here are some ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

What shepherd cares for a flock of sheep and isn’t allowed to drink some of the milk? (NLT)

Don’t shepherds get milk from their own goats? (CEV)

- Use a rhetorical question with its own response. For example:

Who tends a flock and does not drink of the milk?
No one.

- Use a statement. For example:

No person takes care of a flock without drinking some of the milk. (NCV)

Translate this statement in a way that is most natural in your language

tends a flock: The phrase tends a flock normally refers to taking care of sheep. Many English versions use a general term like flock. If people in your culture use the milk of goats but not that of sheep, it is recommended that you translate it in this way. For example:

Don’t shepherds get milk from their own goats? (CEV)

drink of its milk: If people in your culture drink the milk of cattle but not of goats or sheep, it may be necessary to make this question more general. For example:

Don’t people drink the milk from the animals they care for?

If drinking of milk is unknown in your culture, it is possible to use a more general reference. For example:

Doesn’t the person who cares for the animals get his share?

1 Corinthians 9:8

Section 9:1-27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:8-12b

In this paragraph Paul explained that God in the Scriptures has taught that church leaders should receive food and drink for themselves from their work. So, Paul and his fellow workers could expect the Corinthians to give them food and drink.

9:8a

Do I say this from a human perspective?

- ¶ Am I speaking only with human analogies? No,
- ¶ Those examples are from everyday life,

Do I say this from a human perspective?: This is the first of two rhetorical questions in 9:8. Paul used this rhetorical question as a statement. He expected them to respond, "No." Paul was not speaking merely from a human perspective.

Here are some ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Am I speaking from a human perspective?

- Use a statement. For example:

I am not speaking from a human perspective.

from a human perspective: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as from a human perspective is more literally "according to a human." It refers to the three

examples that Paul gave in 9:7. These are examples of the human concept of fairness. They show people's natural judgment about how things ought to be.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Those illustrations are based on how people behave

Those are lessons from daily life

Those are human analogies/comparisons

9:8b

Doesn't the Law say the same thing?

- for God's law also says this.
- but the law God gave through Moses tells us^(incl) the same thing.

Doesn't the Law say the same thing?: This is the second of two rhetorical questions in 9:8. Paul used it as a strong statement. He expected them to respond, "Yes, the law does say this."

Here are some ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Doesn't the Law say this as well?

- Use a rhetorical question with its own response. For example:

Doesn't the Law say the same thing? Yes, it does.

- Use a statement. For example:

God's Law also says the same thing.

Translate this strong statement in a way that is natural in your language.

the Law: The Law refers to the law books that God gave to the people of Israel through Moses. These books are found in the Old Testament Scriptures. Paul was contrasting this Law to the human wisdom expressed in everyday life (9:7).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

God's Law

The book of God's laws

The Law God gave to Moses

General Comment on 9:8a-b

In some languages it may be natural to combine these sentences into one statement. For example:

This is not just based on human examples. Doesn't the Law also say so?

The illustrations I gave are based on human customs, but the Law says the same thing

1 Corinthians 9:9

Section 9:1-27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:8-12b

In this paragraph Paul explained that God in the Scriptures has taught that church leaders should receive food and drink for themselves from their work. So, Paul and his fellow workers could expect the Corinthians to give them food and drink.

9:9a

For it is written in the Law of Moses:

- For in the Law Moses wrote this:
- For we^(incl) read in the Law of Moses:

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces evidence that the Law of Moses teaches the same thing about this as human wisdom. The evidence Paul provided is a quotation from the Law.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction.

In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

it is written in the Law of Moses: The formula it is written is often used to introduce a quotation from the Holy Scriptures. See, for example, 1:19 and 2:9a. Other ways to translate this include:

in the law of Moses we read (REB)

the law of Moses says (NLT)

9:9b

"Do not muzzle an ox while it is treading out the grain."

- "When you use an ox/cow to thresh the grain, you must not tie its mouth shut to keep it from eating some of the grain."
- "You must not prevent an ox/animal from eating while it is working/treading/threshing the grain."

Do not muzzle an ox while it is treading out the grain: This is a quotation from Deuteronomy 25:4. In that time, after people cut the grain in the field, they brought it to a flat place and spread it out. Then they made animals such as oxen walk on it so that the seeds would separate from the stalks. If a farmer wanted to keep his animals from eating the grain, he tied their mouths shut. But the law Paul quoted said that the animals should be allowed to eat some of the grain.

Some English versions make it explicit that the purpose of muzzling is to prevent the ox from eating the grain. For example:

You must not muzzle an ox to keep it from eating as it treads out the grain (NLT)

treading out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as treading out is more literally "threshing." Threshing is the process of removing the seeds from the plants. Some English versions use this word.

Do not muzzle an ox when you are using it to thresh grain. (GNT)

General Comment on 9:9a-b

It may be more natural in some languages to translate this using indirect speech. For example:

The Law of Moses tells us not to muzzle an ox when it is threshing grain

9:9c

Is it about oxen that God is concerned?

- Did God make that law because he cared about the oxen?
- God was not only concerned about oxen.

Is it about oxen that God is concerned?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a statement. He expected them to respond, “No.” Paul stated that God was not thinking primarily about the well-being of oxen. Several English versions supply the word “only,” because God is concerned about animals as well as people.

Here are some ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Was God thinking only about oxen when he said this? (NLT)

- Use a question with the answer supplied. For example:

When God said this, was he thinking only about oxen? No. (NCV)

- Use a statement. For example:

When God said this he was not only concerned about oxen

Translate this statement in the way that is most natural in your language.

1 Corinthians 9:10

Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul’s rights as an apostle

Paul’s example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:8–12b

In this paragraph Paul explained that God in the Scriptures has taught that church leaders should receive food and drink for themselves from their work. So, Paul and his fellow workers could expect the Corinthians to give them food and drink.

9:10a

Isn’t He actually speaking on our behalf?

- Isn’t it certain that he was thinking about us?^(incl)
- No, surely/clearly he said this for us/for our sake.

Isn’t He actually speaking on our behalf?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a statement. It is an answer to the question in the previous verse.

Here are two ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Didn’t he really mean us when he said that? (GNT)

Wasn’t he actually speaking to us? (NLT)

- Use a statement. For example:

Surely, he said this for us

Isn’t He...speaking on our behalf: Here Paul refers to the law about the ox in 9:9b. Paul understood that the Laws of Moses were the words of God.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

when God told Moses to write this, it was for our sake

our behalf: The pronoun our is an exclusive pronoun. 9:10 Fee p.406–407. Paul refers to himself and other Christian leaders.

God gave this law so that his people will know how to treat workers fairly. He wanted them to know how to treat animals justly and also how to treat human workers justly. Paul applies this to Christian leaders who should also be treated fairly.

actually: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as actually:

1. It means certainly, undoubtedly, or actually. For example:

surely (NET) (BSB, NET, NIV, REB, NLT, GNT, ESV, CEV)

1. It means altogether, entirely. For example:

Does he not speak entirely for our sake? (RSV)
(RSV, KJV, NASB, NJB, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is supported by the standard NT Greek dictionary^{9:10 BAGD} p. 609. and a number of commentaries.

9:10b

Indeed, this was written for us,

- Yes, when he caused Moses to write down that law, he did it for our^(incl) benefit.
- Of course, the law was written/given for our sake.

Indeed, this was written for us: This is an answer to the rhetorical question in 9:10a. The phrase this was written refers to the law about the ox quoted in 9:9b.9:10 The KJV and NCV appear to interpret the words “this is written” to refer to what follows as well as what precedes. However, the words that follow are not a quotation from anywhere in the Hebrew Scriptures. That law was written in the Scriptures by Moses.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Of course that was written for us. (GNT)

This was written for our benefit. (GW)

9:10c

because when the plowman plows and the thresher threshes,

- For when people/farmers plow/dig the ground and when people/farmers thresh/beat the grain,
- When someone prepares the ground for planting seed or separates the grain from the stalk/husks,

because: The word because introduces the reason God gave the command about the oxen. Another way to translate 9:10b-d is:

It was written for us, because the one who plows a field and the one who threshes the grain should do their work expecting to receive a share of the harvest

the plowman plows: To “plow” is the work of breaking up and turning the soil to prepare it for seeds. The plowman is anyone who does such work.

the thresher threshes: To “thresh” is the work of separating the seeds from the stalks. The thresher is a person who does such work.

9:10d

they should also expect to share in the harvest.

- they ought to have a hope of getting part of the crop.
- it is right that he should expect to receive some of the grain.

they should also expect to share in the harvest:

The verb should indicates that the one preparing the ground and the one who threshes the grain have a right to expect a reward for their work. Some ways to translate this phrase are:

they ought to be able to share in the harvest

it is right that they should hope/expect to share in the harvest

expect to share in the harvest: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as expect to share in the harvest is more literally “in hope of the sharing.” It indicates that the worker should be able to receive some of the harvest himself. The BSB has supplied the words in the harvest. The GNT and RSV have supplied the words “in the crop,” and the REB has supplied “the produce.” You may supply a phrase that is natural to indicate what the workers were to share.

General Comment on 9:10c-d

In some languages it may be natural to indicate first that this is right. For example:

^{10c-d}because it is right that whoever ploughs should plough with the expectation of having his share, and whoever threshes should thresh with the expectation of having his share (NJB)

1 Corinthians 9:11

Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:8–12b

In this paragraph Paul explained that God in the Scriptures has taught that church leaders should receive food and drink for themselves from their work. So, Paul and his fellow workers could expect the Corinthians to give them food and drink.

9:11

This verse has a long rhetorical question. Paul used it as an strong statement. He stated that “We have this right.”

Here are some ways to translate this strong statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

If we have sown the seed of spiritual things in you, is it too much to ask that we should receive from you a crop of material things? (NJB)

- Use a statement or statements. For example:

When we told the message to you, it was like planting spiritual seed. So we have the right to accept material things as our harvest from you. (CEV)

- Use a statement followed by a rhetorical question. For example:

We have sown spiritual seed among you. Is it too much if we reap material benefits from you? (GNT)

Translate this strong statement in the way that is most natural in your language.

9:11a

If we have sown spiritual seed among you,

- Because we^(excl) planted the seed of spiritual truth/ life among you^(plur),
- We^(excl) gave you God's message.

If we have sown spiritual seed among you: The word If introduces a condition that was already fulfilled. Paul reminded the Corinthians that he had sown spiritual seed among them. You could translate this as the NCV has done:

Since we planted spiritual seed among you....
(NCV)

sown spiritual seed: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as sown spiritual seed is literally “sown spiritual things.” This is a metaphor that refers to the way Paul and his fellow workers proclaimed the gospel to the Corinthians. In your translation, you may either:

- keep the metaphor of sowing. For example:

planted spiritual seed (NLT)

- explain the metaphor. For example:

When we told the message to you, it was like planting spiritual seed. (CEV)

9:11b

is it too much for us to reap a material harvest from you?

- then if we^(excl) receive from you^(plur) a harvest of material things, are we^(excl) getting too much? Of course not!
- So, surely it is right/reasonable that we receive in return things of this world like food and drink.

is it too much for us to reap a material harvest from you?: In this clause Paul said that it was not too much. It was not wrong for the workers to receive material things from the Corinthians. He said that it was proper and acceptable for them to receive food and drink from the Corinthians.

reap a material harvest: This is a metaphor. In your translation, you may:

- use the metaphor of reaping a harvest. For example:

is it too much to reap material things from you?
(NET)

- explain the metaphor. For example:

aren't we entitled to a harvest of physical food and drink? (NLT)

would we be wrong to receive food from you?

a material harvest: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a material harvest is more literally “the things of the flesh.” It refers to things needed for our physical bodies, such as food and lodging.

1 Corinthians 9:12

Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:8–12b

In this paragraph Paul explained that God in the Scriptures has taught that church leaders should receive food and drink for themselves from their work. So, Paul and his fellow workers could expect the Corinthians to give them food and drink.

9:12a-b

This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement. He expected them to respond, “Yes.” Paul stated that he and Barnabas had the right to be supported by the Corinthians.

Here are some ways to translate this strong statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

If others have the right to expect this from you, don't we have an even greater right? (GNT)

- Use a statement or statements. For example:

If others have the right to get something from you, surely we have this right, too. (NCV)

- Use a statement followed by a rhetorical question. For example:

Others have been given such rights over you. Do we^(excl) not deserve more?

Translate this statement in the way that is most natural in your language.

9:12a

If others have this right to your support,

- Because other apostles have the right to receive material support from you^(plur),
- You accept that it is right/fitting to support other messengers of Christ,

If others have this right to your support: This clause suggests a condition that was true. The Corinthian believers supported other evangelists. In some languages it may be natural to say:

You allow others the right to your support

Because you support others

others have this right to your support: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as others have this right to your support is more literally “others share your right,” that is, the right to support from the Corinthians. The verb “share” is the same Greek verb used for the harvest metaphor in 9:10d. If it is natural in your language, you could use the same verb in both verses. For example:

others share this rightful claim on you (ESV)

others: The word others refers to other Christian workers. The NLT makes this explicit:

others who preach to you (NLT)

this right to your support: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as this right to your support is more literally “your right.” The BSB has added some words to make it clear what right Paul was talking about. Other ways to make this explicit include:

the right to get something from you (NCV)

the right to receive physical/material things

9:12b

shouldn't we have it all the more?

- then don't Barnabas and I have a greater right to such support?
- so surely it is even more right/fitting that you should support us^(excl) because we brought the gospel to you first.

shouldn't we have it all the more?: In this clause Paul claimed that he and Barnabas had a greater right to receive support than other Christian workers did. This was because Paul and Barnabas were the ones who first preached the gospel in Corinth. To make this implied information explicit you could say:

we have an even greater right to be supported, because we were the first to preach the good news to you

Paragraph 9:12c-14

In this paragraph Paul stated that he did not use his right to receive support. He then gave two more proofs that he had the right to receive pay for his work.

9:12c

But we did not exercise this right.

- ¶ But we^(excl) did not use this right to receive support.
- ¶ Nevertheless, we^(excl) did not let you pay us for our work, even though it would be right/fitting.

But we did not exercise this right: This clause indicates that Paul and Barnabas did not accept financial or material support from the Corinthians. Translate this in a way that makes it clear that Paul referred to the "right to your support" he mentioned in 9:12a. For example:

Yet we^(excl) have never exercised our right to be supported/paid.

But we never demanded that which is right, that you^(plur) should support/pay us.

9:12d

Instead, we put up with anything

- Rather, we^(excl) endure all kinds of difficulties
- Instead, we^(excl) are willing to accept any hardship

we put up with anything: The Greek word that the BSB translates as put up with is more literally "endure" (as in the ESV). Paul and Barnabas were willing to endure hunger, and the weariness that comes from working hard for a living (see 4:11-12). Other ways to translate this include:

we^(excl) suffer every kind of hardship

we are willing to accept every difficulty

9:12e

rather than hinder the gospel of Christ.

- to avoid hindering the gospel of Christ.
- so that the good news about Christ may advance without any obstacles.
- so that we^(excl) will not do anything that will make it hard for people to believe the gospel of Christ.

rather than hinder the gospel of Christ: This clause indicates the reason why Paul did not want to do anything to make it hard for the gospel to advance. He did not want to make it hard for people to receive God's message. Other ways to translate this include:

in order not to put any obstacle in the way of the Good News about Christ (GNT)

to keep from causing trouble for the message about Christ (CEV)

we do not do anything that causes people to reject the gospel of Christ

the gospel of Christ: The phrase the gospel of Christ means "the good news about Jesus Christ." See how you translated the phrase the gospel in 1:17, and see the gospel in the glossary.

1 Corinthians 9:13

Section 9:1-27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any

kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:12c-14

In this paragraph Paul stated that he did not use his right to receive support. He then gave two more proofs that he had the right to receive pay for his work.

9:13a-b

This is a long rhetorical question with two parts. Paul used it as a statement. He talked about customs that were familiar to his readers. He expected them to respond, "Yes, we know that." Paul wanted them to understand that he had the right to take pay for his work among them.

Here are some ways to translate this question:

- Use rhetorical questions. For example:

Don't you know that people who work in the temple make their living from what is brought to the temple? Don't you know that a person who serves at the altar is given part of what is offered? (CEV)

- Use statements. For example:

Surely you know that the men who work in the Temple get their food from the Temple and that those who offer the sacrifices on the altar get a share of the sacrifices. (GNT)

Translate this long rhetorical question in the way that is most natural in your language.

9:13a

Do you not know that those who work in the temple eat of its food,

- Those who perform the temple rites get their food from the gifts that people bring, do they not?
- As you know, the priests receive their food from what is offered in the temple.

those who work in the temple eat of its food: The phrase those who work in the temple is more literally "those who work in sacred things." It refers to the priests who did the temple rituals. The priests ate part of the gifts that people brought as sacrifices. They ate

part of the grain and oil offerings, and parts of the animals. See Leviticus 6:16-18, Numbers 18:8-19, and Deuteronomy 18:1-5.

Here are some other ways to say this clause:

those who do the temple rites get their food from the gifts that people bring there

the priests receive their food from what is offered in the temple

9:13b

and those who serve at the altar partake of its offerings?

- Those who work at the altar receive part of the meat from the animals that people offer to God, do they not?
- They make sacrifices on the altar and themselves receive a share of the offerings.

and: The BSB has supplied the word and. There is no conjunction in the Greek. The two clauses are saying the a similar thing in different words.

those who serve at the altar partake of its offerings:

The phrase those who serve at the altar refers to the priests who offered sacrifices in the temple. The priests received part of what was sacrificed. Some ways to say this are:

those who work at the altar receive part of the meat from the animals that people offer to God

priests make sacrifices on the altar and themselves receive a share of the offerings

1 Corinthians 9:14

Section 9:1-27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:12c-14

In this paragraph Paul stated that he did not use his right to receive support. He then gave two more proofs that he had the right to receive pay for his work.

9:14a

In the same way, the Lord has prescribed that

- In a similar way, the Lord has ordered that
- The Lord said that similarly,

In the same way: The phrase In the same way introduces a comparison. Paul compared the way in which priests received their food with the way in which God's workers should receive their food.

the Lord has prescribed: This is a reference to Jesus Christ and his instructions to his disciples. See Matthew 10:10 and Luke 10:7. It may be good to say:

the Lord Jesus has prescribed

prescribed: As can be seen from the Matthew and Luke passages, what the Lord said was not in the form of a command but in the form of a principle. Paul did not live according to these instructions, and he did not see himself as disobeying the Lord. Here is another way to translate this:

the Lord wants everyone who preaches the good news to make a living from preaching this message (CEV)

9:14b

those who preach the gospel should receive their living from the gospel.

- those who preach the good news should make their living from it.
- those who tell the gospel to others should receive what they need to live from the people who believe the gospel.

those who preach the gospel: The word those refers to Paul, Barnabas, and other Christian workers, including the brothers of the Lord and other apostles he mentioned in 9:5b. In some languages a literal translation may imply that Paul was not one of these people. In those languages it may be necessary to say:

we^(excl) who preach the gospel

receive their living from the gospel: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as receive their living is literally "live." It refers to receiving the necessities of life: food, drink, clothes, and shelter. Preachers of the gospel were to receive these things from the gospel in the sense that those who listened to the gospel were to give the preachers enough to support their life. Other ways to translate this include:

get their living from it (GNT)

be supported by those who benefit from it (NLT)

General Comment on 9:14

In some languages it may be natural to translate Jesus' words as a direct quote. However, these are not Jesus' exact words but a summary of them. If changing this to a direct quote suggests that these are Jesus' exact words, do not change them. If it is necessary to use a direct quote you may be able to say:

Jesus commanded, "Those who preach the gospel should receive their living from the gospel."

1 Corinthians 9:15

Section 9:1-27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:15-18

This paragraph begins and ends with a reference to Paul's right to be paid for preaching the gospel. In this

paragraph he further explained his choice not to make use of this right. He stated this choice in emphatic terms in v. 15. He described this choice as “my boast.” He then explained that he does not boast about the fact that he preaches the Gospel. The Lord Jesus commanded him to preach. He had no choice, he must do it. His reward for his work is the satisfaction he gets from giving up his right.

9:15a

But I have not used any of these rights.

- ¶ But I have never used/claimed my right to support.
- ¶ But I have never asked anything from you.

But I have not used any of these rights: The Greek text says literally, “But I have not used any of these things.” The BSB has supplied the word rights. This repeats what he said in 9:12c: “But we did not exercise this right.” Paul said that he had not insisted that the people he preached to must support him. Another way to say this is:

But I have not asked for anything from you.

9:15b

And I am not writing this to suggest that something be done for me.

- And I am not writing this letter to ask you to support me.
- Nor am I writing these things to you^(plur) because I want you to start giving me pay for my work.

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces a second negative statement. The RSV therefore translates it as “Nor”:

Nor am I writing this... (RSV)

Consider how it is natural to introduce consecutive negative statements in your language.

I am not writing this to suggest that something be done for me: In this clause Paul indicated that he did not want the Corinthians to start supporting him now. This was not his purpose in writing about his rights. Other ways to translate this include:

nor am I writing this now in order to claim such rights for myself (GNT)

I am not writing this letter to ask you to support me.

9:15c

Indeed, I would rather die than let anyone nullify my boast.

- It would be better to die! I will not let anyone make my boast empty!
- I would rather die of hunger than let anyone take away my boast that when I preached the gospel to you, I did not ask you for food and drink.
- It would be better for me to die than...I won't let that source of my pride disappear.

Indeed, I would rather die than let anyone nullify my boast: In the Greek this is two sentences, but the first sentence is unfinished. Here are some ways to translate this.

- Translate it literally, with an unfinished sentence, as the NET has done:

it would be better for me to die than—no one will deprive me of my reason for boasting! (NET)

- Connect the two sentences. The BSB and many other English versions do this. For example:

I would rather die than lose my right to boast about preaching without charge. (NLT)

- Translate it as two complete sentences, as the GNT has done:

I would rather die first! Nobody is going to turn my rightful boast into empty words! (GNT)

I would rather die than: In an emotional way Paul began to explain his reason for not taking pay for his work. But he did not finish the sentence. Some other ways to translate this are:

I would rather die.

It would be better if I die of hunger

let anyone nullify my boast: After breaking off his previous sentence, Paul started again. In this sentence he said that he would not let anyone make his boast untrue, that is, he did not want anyone to give him financial support. Other ways to translate this include:

lose my right to boast about preaching without charge (NLT)

have anyone say I taught you because I wanted you to support me

In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

I refuse to let anyone nullify my boast!

nullify my boast: The Greek text more literally says “empty my boast.” Here is another way to translate this:

have anyone make this boast of mine an empty one (JBP)

boast: Avoid translating boast with a word that refers to something negative or sinful. Paul rejoiced that he was able to preach without receiving pay. He did not sin by doing this.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

this thing that I am proud of

this good thing that I do

my right

1 Corinthians 9:16

Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul’s rights as an apostle

Paul’s example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:15–18

This paragraph begins and ends with a reference to Paul’s right to be paid for preaching the gospel. In this paragraph he further explained his choice not to make use of this right. He stated this choice in emphatic terms in v. 15. He described this choice as “my boast.” He then explained that he does not boast about the fact that he preaches the Gospel. The Lord Jesus commanded him to preach. He had no choice, he must do it. His reward for his work is the satisfaction he gets from giving up his right.

9:16a

Yet when I preach the gospel, I have no reason to boast,

- But I do not boast about simply preaching the good news,
- It is not the preaching of the gospel itself that I can boast about, it is giving up my right to be paid for it that I boast about.

Yet: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Yet expresses a contrast. After Paul mentioned his boast in 9:15, he went on in 9:16 to say what his boast was not. These are some ways to express this connection:

- Use a conjunction in your language that expresses contra-expectation or contrast. Paul clarified something that he did not boast about. Many English versions use the preposition “yet.”
- Use no conjunction, leaving the meaning implicit. Several English versions such as the NRSV, GNT, and CEV have no conjunction.

when I preach the gospel, I have no reason to boast:

Paul said that he did not boast about preaching the gospel. The reason was that he was compelled to preach.

when: The Greek word that the BSB translates as when is more literally “if.” Some ways to translate this include:

if (ESV)

when (NIV)

9:16b

because I am obligated to preach.

- because I am obliged to do this.
- The Lord commanded me to preach the gospel and I cannot refuse.

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason why Paul could

not boast about preaching the gospel. He had to preach because Christ had commanded him to preach. Other ways to introduce this reason include:

since (CEB)

for (NET)

I am obligated to preach: In this clause Paul said that he could not boast about preaching the gospel because he had to preach. Christ had commanded him to do so. Other ways to translate this include:

I have an obligation to do this (GW)

I am under orders to do so (GNT)

I am obligated: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as I am obligated is literally “necessity is laid upon me.” This is a passive clause and the implied agent is God or Jesus. Jesus showed himself to Paul along the road to Damascus. He told Paul that he was sending him to tell people, especially Gentiles, the good news of salvation. See Acts 9:3–6, 22:12–15, 26:12–20. There are two ways to translate this passive clause:

- with a passive verb. For example:

I am compelled by God. (NLT)

- with an active verb. For example:

God told me to preach

9:16c

Woe to me if I do not preach the gospel!

- How terrible it will be for me if I do not preach the gospel!
- If I do not tell the good news, he will judge me!

This phrase expands on the idea in 16b, using even stronger terms. The BSB does not use a conjunction to introduce this phrase. Consider how it is natural in your language to introduce a statement that adds detail and emotion.

Woe to me if I do not preach the gospel!: This is an emotive statement, implying that the Lord would punish Paul if he did not obey him. Other ways to translate this include:

How horrible it will be for me if I don’t spread the Good News! (GW)

And how terrible it would be for me if I did not preach the gospel! (GNT)

1 Corinthians 9:17

Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul’s rights as an apostle

Paul’s example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:15–18

This paragraph begins and ends with a reference to Paul’s right to be paid for preaching the gospel. In this paragraph he further explained his choice not to make use of this right. He stated this choice in emphatic terms in v. 15. He described this choice as “my boast.” He then explained that he does not boast about the fact that he preaches the Gospel. The Lord Jesus commanded him to preach. He had no choice, he must do it. His reward for his work is the satisfaction he gets from giving up his right.

9:17

In 9:16 Paul said that he was “compelled to preach.” In this verse he said more about that obligation with two contrastive sentences. Both are conditionals starting with the word “if.” The first sentence was not true of Paul, but the second sentence was true for Paul.

9:17a

If my preaching is voluntary,

- If I did this because it was my own choice,
- If I myself had chosen to proclaim the good news,

If my preaching is voluntary: The context indicates that Paul spoke of a situation that was not true for

him. Preaching was not a free choice for him. He was “compelled to preach” because God had commanded it. Thus, the word *If* introduces an unfulfilled condition. 9:17 See the GNT, REB, NJB, and NLT. Translate this using the forms that are natural in your language for referring to a situation that is not true. For example:

If I did it of my own choice (REB)

If I were doing this on my own initiative (NLT)

my preaching: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as *my preaching* is literally “I do this.” Some English versions make explicit that what Paul was doing was to preach. For example:

If I preach (NIV)

If I did my work (GNT)

It is recommended that you make the meaning clear with a word such as “preach.”

voluntary: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *voluntary* can also be translated as “willing.” Some other ways to translate this are:

because it is my own choice (NCV)

because I choose to do it

because I want to do it

9:17b

I have a reward.

- then I could expect to receive something in return.
- then I would have the right to receive payment.

I have a reward: If the condition in 9:17a were true, then Paul would expect a reward. However, the condition in 9:17a is not true. Use a form which indicates that this situation is not real in Paul’s case. For example:

I would have a reward

I would deserve to get paid

I would receive something in return

I would be given wages

9:17c

But if it is not voluntary,

- But because it was not my choice/decision to preach, but the Lord told me to do it,
- But in fact, I must preach the good news,

But if it is not voluntary: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *But if it is not voluntary* is more literally “But if unwillingly.” The word *But* shows the contrast between the unfulfilled condition of 9:17a and the true condition of 9:17c. This was Paul’s actual situation. He did not choose to preach. He preached because the Lord told him to. Some other ways to translate this are:

but I preach because I must preach

but I do it as a matter of duty (GNT)

but since I have no choice (REB)

Like the phrase in 9:17a, this phrase in the Greek is a conditional. 9:17a describes an unfulfilled condition, a situation that is not true of Paul. 9:17c describes a true condition. It is true that Paul is doing his duty. Some ways to introduce this true condition are:

since (MSG)

because

if

9:17d

I am still entrusted with a responsibility.

- I am only doing my duty/responsibility.
- for the Lord has given me this work to do.

I am still entrusted with a responsibility: The Greek clause is more literally “I have been entrusted a responsibility.” This clause explains the meaning of preaching the gospel “unwillingly” (9:17c). Paul said that his preaching was a “trust” or a responsibility because his task came from God. The Greek text leaves this connection implicit. Use a connector in your translation that makes the meaning clear. Some ways to translate 9:17c-d are:

But I have no choice, for God has given me this sacred trust. (NLT)

But I do it as a matter of duty, because God has entrusted me with this task. (GNT)

a responsibility: God made Paul responsible for preaching the gospel. It was therefore his duty to do it. Some other ways to translate this word are:

trust (NIV)

duty (NCV)

what God asked me to do

1 Corinthians 9:18

Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:15–18

This paragraph begins and ends with a reference to Paul's right to be paid for preaching the gospel. In this paragraph he further explained his choice not to make use of this right. He stated this choice in emphatic terms in v. 15. He described this choice as "my boast." He then explained that he does not boast about the fact that he preaches the Gospel. The Lord Jesus commanded him to preach. He had no choice, he must do it. His reward for his work is the satisfaction he gets from giving up his right.

9:18

Paul explained in verses 9:16–17 that preaching the Gospel was not something he could boast about, nor something that he deserved to be rewarded for. In 9:18, he said what deed he considered worthy of a reward.

9:18a

What then is my reward?

- So, what do I get as a reward?
- So, this is my reward:

What then is my reward?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it to set up for the answer in 9:18b.

Here are some ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

So what reward do I get? (NCV)

- Use a statement that points forward to 9:18b. For example:

My reward therefore, is this:

then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as then introduces the purpose of the situation described in 9:17c-d. By preaching the gospel free of charge, Paul did not make use of his rights in preaching it. This can be translated as:

then

so

reward: This is a play on words. Paul said that his reward was to receive no reward. He did not use his right to receive pay. Thus, his reward was the satisfaction that he got from preaching the gospel without charge. Some ways to translate this word are:

reward

blessing

pay

9:18b

That in preaching the gospel I may offer it free of charge,

- My reward is this: the satisfaction that I get from preaching the gospel without charging for it,
- I have the privilege of telling people the good news about Christ without asking them to pay me for it.

That in preaching the gospel I may offer it free of charge: This clause answers the question that Paul asked in 9:18a. Paul's reward was his satisfaction that he could preach the gospel to others at no cost. A word such as "satisfaction" or "privilege" may help to express this meaning. For example:

It is the privilege of preaching the Good News without charging for it. (GNT)

free of charge: Other ways to translate this include:

without charging anyone (NLT)

freely (NCV)

without the listeners paying for it

9:18c

and so not use up my rights in preaching it.

- and not making use of the rights that preaching the gospel gives me.
- In that way, I won't use my right to get money from preaching the gospel.

and so not use up my rights in preaching it: This clause explains more about Paul's reward. Paul finished the paragraph by returning to a reference to his rights.

use up: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as use up is an intensive form of the verb meaning use. There are two ways to interpret this verb:

1. It means that Paul did not use his right to be supported. For example:

without claiming my rights (GNT) (GNT, NIV, NJB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV)

1. It means that Paul did not use his full rights, or did not overuse (or did not abuse) his rights. For example:

I do not use my full rights (NCV) (BSB, NCV, RSV, ESV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul did not say that he used some of his rights but not his full rights. Rather, he said that he completely gave up his right to be supported. He did not use this right.

my rights: Translate this the way that you did in 9:4, 5, 6 and 12.

1 Corinthians 9:19

Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:19–23

In this paragraph Paul explained that he gave up his rights in order to serve others. In this way he could help more people hear and believe the message about Jesus Christ.

9:19a

Though I am free of obligation to anyone,

- ¶ For although I am free and a slave to no one,
- ¶ Nobody owns me,

Though I am free of obligation to anyone: In Greek this literally says "being free from all." It indicates that Paul was not a slave to any human being. He was able to live and work as he chose. Another way to translate this is:

I am not a slave to anyone

Though: There is something unexpected here. Paul was free and yet he made himself a slave. In the Greek text this contrast is implicit. The BSB indicates

this contrast with the use of Though. Another way to indicate this is are:

I am free and belong to no one. But I make myself a slave to all people (NCV)

I am a free man, nobody's slave; but I make myself everybody's slave (GNT)

9:19b

I make myself a slave to everyone,

- I act like everybody's slave,
- but I work as if everybody owns me,

I make myself a slave to everyone: This is a figure of speech. Paul compared himself to a slave, but he did not become an actual slave. He wanted everyone to come to know Christ, so he acted in ways that would not hinder them. Other ways to translate this include:

I act like everybody's slave

I work like a slave for everyone

I make myself a slave: This describes Paul's way of life. Choose a tense form or a grammatical pattern in your language that expresses a general principle, or a habitual action. You should use this same tense or grammatical pattern for each of Paul's statements in 9:20–23. 9:19 Paul used the Greek aorist tense in 9:19–22. This as a “gnomic aorist” which expresses habitual action. In 9:23 Paul used a present tense and continued to express his general pattern of life. When Paul said that he “became like a Jew,” “became like one under the law,” and “became weak,” he was describing the pattern of his life.

slave: In some languages it may be easier to say “have an owner” rather than “be a slave.” This could be expressed as:

Nobody owns me, but I work as if everybody owns me.

9:19c

to win as many as possible.

- so that by my help, many people will follow Christ.
- so that I will cause as many people as I can to believe in Christ.

to win as many as possible: This is a purpose clause. Paul wanted to win many people, that is, to help them

believe in Christ. Some other ways to translate this are:

so that by my help, as many people as possible will follow Christ

to persuade more people to believe

to cause many people to enter faith in Christ

1 Corinthians 9:20

Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:19–23

In this paragraph Paul explained that he gave up his rights in order to serve others. In this way he could help more people hear and believe the message about Jesus Christ.

9:20a

To the Jews I became like a Jew, to win the Jews.

- When I am with Jewish people, I follow Jewish customs, so that by my help, the Jewish people will follow Christ.
- For example, when I preach to the Jews, I behave the way Jews behave, so that I will cause Jews to believe in Christ.

To the Jews I became like a Jew: In this verse Paul began to explain in what sense he became “a slave” to others. When Paul was with Jewish people, he behaved like a Jew, that is, he followed Jewish customs. Other ways to translate this include:

When I work with Jewish people, I live like a Jewish person in order to win them.

If I am preaching to Jewish people I follow Jewish customs.

9:20b

To those under the law I became like one under the law

- They submit to the law of Moses, and so I also submit to the law of Moses,
- The Jews obey the laws that God gave to Moses. So when I preach to the Jews, I follow those laws,

To those under the law I became like one under the law: This clause explains the meaning of the previous clause. The people under the law were the Jewish people whom Paul had just mentioned. It may be necessary to make this clear. For example:

that is, to win those under the law I behaved as if under the law (REB)

They obey the law, and so I also obey the law.

under the law: To be under the law means to obey the law. Some other ways to say this are:

follow the law

live by the law

the law: The phrase the law refers to the Law of Moses. See how you translated this in 9:8 and 9:9.

9:20c

(though I myself am not under the law),

- even though I am not subject to that law.
- in spite of the fact that I am not obligated to obey those laws.

(though I myself am not under the law): This part of the sentence is parenthetical information. Paul interrupted himself to say that it was not necessary for him to obey Jewish regulations such as those about animal sacrifices, circumcision, and impure foods. 9:20 See 7:19 where Paul said, “circumcision is nothing,” and 8:8 where Paul said, “food does not bring us closer to God.” God expected the people of Israel to obey those laws only until Jesus Christ came. See law, sense 2 in Key Biblical Terms. Other ways to translate this include:

I am not bound by these customs

though I don't have to follow that law of theirs

even though I am not forced to do what is in the law, yet I do it

9:20d

to win those under the law.

- I do this so that by my help, those who submit to the law of Moses will follow Christ.
- I behave like that so that I will cause those who obey Moses' laws to believe in Christ.

to win those under the law: You should translate win in the same way you translated it in 9:19c and 9:20a.

General Comment on 9:20a-d

9:20c is parenthetical. The BSB has indicated this by the use of parentheses. In some languages it may be natural to reorder the verse and put the parenthetical information earlier in the verse. For example:

^{20a}When I am with the Jews, I live like a Jew to win Jews. ^{20b}They are ruled by the Law of Moses, ^{20c}and I am not. ^{20b}But I live by the Law ^{20d}to win them. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 9:21

Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:19–23

In this paragraph Paul explained that he gave up his rights in order to serve others. In this way he could help more people hear and believe the message about Jesus Christ.

9:21a**To those without the law I became like one without the law**

- When I am with those who don't follow the law of Moses, I make myself like someone who doesn't follow the law.
- In a similar way, when I preach to non-Jews, I do not follow the laws of the Jews.

those without the law: This refers to Gentiles, not to Jewish people. The Gentiles did not know about the laws that God gave to Moses for the Jewish people. However, they did have their own laws. In your translation, avoid implying that the Gentiles did not have any laws. Other ways to translate this are:

those who don't follow the law of the Jewish people

those outside the law of Moses

I became like one without the law: In this clause Paul said that he did not follow the Jewish laws when he was with Gentiles, nor did he force them to follow these laws. Other ways to translate this include:

I acted as if I was outside the law of Moses

I don't follow those laws either

I didn't force them to obey these laws

9:21b**(though I am not outside the law of God but am under the law of Christ),**

- That does not mean that I no longer obey God's law, because I do obey Christ's law.
- Of course, I am still subject to God's laws, because I follow those of Christ.

(though I am not outside the law of God but am under the law of Christ): This is parenthetical information. Once again, Paul interrupted himself (as in 9:20c). Paul wanted to correct a possible misunderstanding. When he said that he was "like one without the law," some people might think that he did not obey God's moral laws. But that was not true. See law, sense

4 in the Key Biblical Terms. Other ways to translate this include:

This does not mean that I don't obey God's law. I am really under Christ's law. (GNT)

But really, I am not without God's law—I am ruled by Christ's law. (NCV)

9:21c**to win those without the law.**

- I do this so that by my help, the people who do not follow the Law of Moses will follow Christ.
- I act like the non-Jews so that I will cause the non-Jews to believe in Christ.

to win those without the law: In this clause Paul said that his purpose in behaving like a Gentile was to help the Gentiles believe in Jesus Christ. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

I did this to win those who are without the law. (NCV)

General Comment on 9:21a-c

9:21b is parenthetical. The BSB has indicated this using parentheses. In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the verse. For example:

^{21a}When I am with the Gentiles who do not follow the Jewish law, I too live apart from that law ^{21c}so I can bring them to Christ. ^{21b}But I do not ignore the law of God; I obey the law of Christ. (NCV)

^{21a}And when I am with people who are not ruled by the Law, I forget about the Law ^{21c}to win them. ^{21b}Of course, I never really forget about the law of God. In fact, I am ruled by the law of Christ. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 9:22**Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle**

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do

anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:19–23

In this paragraph Paul explained that he gave up his rights in order to serve others. In this way he could help more people hear and believe the message about Jesus Christ.

9:22a

To the weak I became weak, to win the weak.

- When I am with poor people, I make myself poor, so that by my help, the poor people will follow Christ.
- In a similar way, when I preach to those who are powerless, I become powerless myself, so that I will cause the powerless to believe in Christ.

the weak: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the weak:

1. It refers to people who were powerless. They were perhaps poor, or slaves. They had low status and low influence. For example:

When I am with those who are oppressed (NLT96)

1. It refers to believers whose “conscience is weak,” as in 8:7–13. For example:

When I am with people whose faith is weak (CEV)

(CEV, GNT, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This has the strongest support amongst recent commentaries because it fits with Paul's statement that he himself became weak. 9:22 For example, Fee, page 431, says “it is probably a more purely sociological category than a socio-religious one.” See also Thiselton and Garland. It also fits with Paul's purpose of winning the weak, which implies that they were not yet believers.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the poor

those without power/influence

I became weak: This means that Paul worked with his hands and thus accepted a position of low status. Notice that he did not say “like one who is weak” (as in 9:20a, 9:20b and 9:21b), but that he actually became weak.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I live a life of poverty (NJB)

I become powerless

9:22b–c

I have become all things to all people so that by all possible means I might save some: This is a summary of the examples that Paul gave in 9:20, 21 and 22a. Translate this in the way that you normally introduce a summary in your language. One way to translate this is:

In summary, I have become all things to all people so that I may do all that I can to save some of them.

9:22b

I have become all things to all people

- When I am with people of any kind, I become like them,
- In summary, when I preach to different kinds of people, I live like they do.

I have become all things to all people: This clause indicates that Paul was willing to adapt his way of life to meet the needs of different people. He was willing to change or adjust his behavior to help others.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

When I am with people of any kind, I become like them

I change how I live to be like the people I am with

9:22c

so that by all possible means I might save some.

- so that I might save/rescue some of them from their sin.
- I do all that I can do to help some of them to survive.

so that by all possible means I might save some: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so that

indicates that this is a purpose clause. Paul wanted to save people, that is, to help them believe in Christ. Some other ways to translate this are:

in order to save some by all possible means

by all possible means: The Greek word that the BSB translates as by all possible means is more literally “certainly.” English versions often use the English idiom “by all means” in order to keep the repetition of the word all (all things, all men, all means).

Here is another way to translate this:

I want to do all that I can do to save some people

save: In 9:19–21 Paul talked about “winning” people. In this verse he used a different verb: to save. Other ways of translating it are:

bring them to salvation

rescue them from punishment for their sin

help them to survive

To “win” and to save are different ways to say the same thing. You may wish to use the same word in this verse as you used in 9:19–21.

1 Corinthians 9:23

Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul’s rights as an apostle

Paul’s example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:19–23

In this paragraph Paul explained that he gave up his rights in order to serve others. In this way he could help more people hear and believe the message about Jesus Christ.

9:23

There are two ways to interpret this verse:

1. It is a conclusion to 9:19–22. (BSB, RSV, NCV, CEV, NLT, GW, REB, ESV, NASB)
2. It begins a new paragraph. (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as do the majority of English versions and the UBS Greek text. Paul said that he acted as he had just described because he wanted to help spread the good news about Jesus.

9:23a

I do all this for the sake of the gospel,

- I live in this way to help people accept the gospel,
- I change/adapt my life in these ways to help people everywhere believe the good news about Christ,

I do all this for the sake of the gospel: The phrase all this refers back to what Paul had just said. Paul acted as he did for the sake of the gospel, that is, in order that people would believe the good news. Some other ways to translate this are:

I do all these things in order that more people will believe the message about Christ

I behave like this so that those who believe in the good news will increase

9:23b

so that I may share in its blessings.

- so that I can be among those who receive the blessings it offers.
- so that I, together with them, will receive the good things that are promised in that good news.

share in its blessings: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as share in its blessings is more literally “become a sharer in it.” In this context, share means to receive the same things as others. This is a purpose clause. Paul wanted to be among those who receive the good things that Christ gives us through the gospel. Other ways to translate this include:

receive the blessings of the gospel along with others who believe it

get a share of the good things that are promised in the good news

1 Corinthians 9:24

Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:24–27

In this paragraph Paul wrote about how he disciplined himself for the sake of the gospel. Corinth was the site of the Isthmian Games which happened every two years. Athletes and spectators from all over Greece came to this athletic contest. Paul used an extended metaphor that compared living the Christian life to competing in the Games. He compared the Christian life to running and to boxing.

9:24a-b

Do you not know that in a race all the runners run, but only one receives the prize? Run in such a way as to take the prize: This is a metaphor that compares running in a race to the way a follower of Jesus should live and act.

Paul began the metaphor by asking a rhetorical question. He expected the response “Yes, we know that.” Paul asked them to think about something that they all knew and agreed about. Then on the basis of what they knew about runners, Paul exhorted them, with an element of rebuke, to live or act in a similar way.

Here are some ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you not realize that, though all the runners in the stadium take part in the race, only one of them gets the prize? (NJB)

- Use a statement. For example:

You know that in a race all the runners run, but only one gets the prize (NCV)

Everyone in a race runs, but surely you know that there is only one winner

We all know that in a race only one runner gets the prize

Translate this rhetorical question in the most natural way in your language.

9:24a

Do you not know that in a race all the runners run, but only one receives the prize?

- ¶ Surely you^(plur) know that when people take part in a race, all of them run, but only one receives the prize.
- ¶ Think about this: All the competitors run on the race track, but there is only one person who wins.

in a race: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a race is literally “a stadium.” This is a reference to the Isthmian Games athletic contest, like the Olympic Games, that was held near Corinth every two years. The events in the games included running races in the stadium. Other ways to translate in a race include:

in the arena

on the race course

at the games (REB)

It may be helpful to include a footnote to explain this. An example footnote is:

FOOTNOTE: Every two years there were athletic games in Corinth, similar to the Olympic Games. Competitors and spectators from all over Greece came to these games. These games included races, boxing, and other sports.

the prize: In Paul's time the prize was a crown made of leaves. It may be helpful to include a footnote to explain this. For example:

FOOTNOTE: At the sports games in Corinth the prize for the winner was a crown made of leaves.

9:24b

Run in such a way as to take the prize.

- You^(plur) should run in the way that will win you the prize.
- So, just as runners run to win, you should live your life to get God's prize.

Run in such a way as to take the prize: This is a metaphor that compares running a race to the Christian life. Some ways they are similar are:

- There is the hope of a prize or reward to those who do well.
- Both require self-discipline, training, and effort to do well.

Runners train with self-discipline, and then run with great effort in order to win the prize. Every believer should live with the same kind of effort and self-discipline in order to receive a reward from God. Some ways to translate this include:

- keep the metaphor of the race:

So run to win! (NCV)

Just like they do, run hard enough to get the prize!

- keep the metaphor and make it clear that Paul compared this to the Christian life:

So just as they run to win, you too should act/live in a way to gain God's prize!

Living for Christ is like running a race—make every effort to win God's reward!

in such a way as to take the prize: This phrase does not say that only one person will receive the prize. Paul hoped that all his readers would receive the prize. In your translation, avoid suggesting that only one person will receive a reward from God. Also avoid suggesting that one person will win by beating others or doing better than others. Some ways to do this include:

only one gets the prize. Run in such a way that you may all/each receive a/the prize.

However only one gets the award. You should all run so as to get an/the award

1 Corinthians 9:25

Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:24–27

In this paragraph Paul wrote about how he disciplined himself for the sake of the gospel. Corinth was the site of the Isthmian Games which happened every two years. Athletes and spectators from all over Greece came to this athletic contest. Paul used an extended metaphor that compared living the Christian life to competing in the Games. He compared the Christian life to running and to boxing.

9:25a

Everyone who competes in the games trains with strict discipline.

- Every athlete controls his body so that he will win.
- All the competitors do hard work and make their bodies strong.

Everyone who competes in the games trains with strict discipline: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as trains with strict discipline is more literally “exercises self-control in all things.” Some other ways to translate this are:

Each competitor must control his body and make it strong

As for the contestants, their discipline is strict so that they will win

9:25b

They do it for a crown that is perishable,

- They do this in order to win a crown that will not last long.
- They work hard in order to receive the prize: a crown made of leaves. This crown will soon come to nothing/rot away.

They do it for a crown that is perishable: The crown that the winner received at the Isthmian Games was made out of leaves. Because it was made of leaves, it did not last long. Another way to translate this is:

They do this in order to win a crown. Now, that crown is one that will not last.

9:25c

but we do it for a crown that is imperishable.

- But we^(incl) do this so that we will get a crown that will last forever.
- But as for us^(incl) believers, we work hard so that we will receive a blessing from God that will never wither/spoil.

but we do it: The words we do it refer back to 9:25a and indicate that believers, like athletes, need to exercise self-control and discipline. The conjunction but indicates that believers have a different goal than athletes have.

for a crown that is imperishable: In this metaphor, the prize and the crown are equivalent. They both represent the reward that the Lord gives to those who live in a way that pleases him. The crown is identified in several ways in Scripture—as righteousness (2 Timothy 4:8), life (James 1:12), and glory (1 Peter 5:4). The crown represents a reward that God will give to people who serve him well.

Some other ways to translate this are:

in order to get God's blessing that will never pass away

so that God will give us goodness which will last forever

1 Corinthians 9:26

Section 9:1–27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:24–27

In this paragraph Paul wrote about how he disciplined himself for the sake of the gospel. Corinth was the site of the Isthmian Games which happened every two years. Athletes and spectators from all over Greece came to this athletic contest. Paul used an extended metaphor that compared living the Christian life to competing in the Games. He compared the Christian life to running and to boxing.

9:26a

Therefore I do not run aimlessly;

- So, then I do not run like someone who does not know where he is going.
- For that reason, I live my life with a clear purpose like a runner who runs for the finish line.

Therefore: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Therefore introduces the conclusion Paul drew from what he had just said. Here is another way to translate this:

That is why (GNT)

I do not run aimlessly: The metaphor of running continues in this phrase. Paul said he was not running without a goal. Other ways to translate this are:

I run straight for the finish line (GNT)

I run straight to arrive quickly

I run in order to win

The meaning of this metaphor is that Paul lived life with a clear goal. He aimed to serve Christ all his life. He did not allow himself to be distracted by other things. There are two ways to translate this:

- keep the metaphor of running. For example:

I don't run without a goal (CEV)

- keep the metaphor and make it clear that Paul compared this to the Christian life:

I live with a goal to serve Christ well, like a runner running for the finish line

9:26b

I do not fight like I am beating the air.

- And I do not fight as though I were a boxer hitting only air.
- I do not live aimlessly like a fighter who just punches the air.

I do not fight like I am beating the air: This metaphor means the same as that in the previous clause. Paul said that his activity was purposeful. This time he referred to the sport of boxing. He was aiming for his opponent's body, not just hitting the air. There are again two ways to translate this metaphor:

- keep the metaphor. For example:

I do not...box like one who hits only the air (NET)

I am like a boxer whose blows always hit the opponent

- keep the metaphor and make it clear that Paul compared this to the Christian life:

I do not waste my life/efforts, like a boxer who hits only air

1 Corinthians 9:27

Section 9:1-27: Paul did not use his rights as an apostle

In this section Paul responded to a claim by some of the Corinthians that he was not an apostle. First, he defended his calling and work as an apostle. Then he

used himself as an example of someone who did not use his rights.

In chapter 8 and chapter 10 Paul talked about food offered to idols. In this chapter Paul said that he was an example of somebody who had the right to do anything. He was thinking about the right to eat any kind of food. Out of love for others he refrained from doing things that he had a right to do. Instead, he tried to act in a way that would lead others to Christ.

Other possible section headings include:

Paul's rights as an apostle

Paul's example of not using his rights

Paragraph 9:24-27

In this paragraph Paul wrote about how he disciplined himself for the sake of the gospel. Corinth was the site of the Isthmian Games which happened every two years. Athletes and spectators from all over Greece came to this athletic contest. Paul used an extended metaphor that compared living the Christian life to competing in the Games. He compared the Christian life to running and to boxing.

9:27a

No, I discipline my body and make it my slave,

- I treat my body harshly and master its desires,
- I train/discipline my body strictly so that I have complete control over it.

I discipline my body: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as I discipline my body is more literally "I beat my body," as in the NIV. This is a metaphor from boxing. Paul used this metaphor to say that he treated his body harshly. He did not give in to sin. Instead, he disciplined his body by refusing to obey its desires. There are two ways to translate this metaphor:

- keep the metaphor. For example:

I harden my body with blows (GNT)

- explain the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

I subdue my body (NET)

I do not spare my body (REB)

my body: In some languages it may not be natural to speak of one's body as distinct from oneself. It may be necessary to say something like:

I subdue my own desires. I refuse to obey them.

I discipline myself harshly. I will not let my physical desires rule my life.

make it my slave: This is also a metaphor. Paul said that he controlled his body in the same way that a master controls his slave. There are two ways to translate this metaphor:

- keep the metaphor. For example:

make it my slave (BSB, NCV)

- explain the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

bring it under complete control (GNT)

9:27b-c

so that...I myself will not be disqualified: These verse parts express a negative purpose. Paul acted as he stated in 9:27a so that something would not happen. Other ways to say this include:

so that I myself will not be disqualified (NCV)

to keep myself from being disqualified (GNT)

9:27b

so that after I have preached to others,

- so that, after preaching the gospel to others,
- I do not want to preach to others so that they can receive God's blessings,

after I have preached to others: The word preached means to proclaim something, or to do the work of a herald. This word is used in 1:23 and 15:11 of proclaiming the gospel about Jesus.

There are two ways to interpret the use of the word preached:

1. It means to preach the gospel. For example:

after I have spread the Good News to others (GW) (BSB, GW, NIV, KJV, RSV, NASB, NET, REB, ESV, NCV, CEV, NLT)

1. It means to announce an athletic contest. It continues the metaphor of 9:24-26. For example:

after having called others to the contest (GNT) (GNT, NJB, LB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the usual meaning of the word in the New Testament. In some languages it may be necessary to say what Paul preached or proclaimed. For example:

after I have preached the gospel to others

9:27c

I myself will not be disqualified.

- I myself will not fail to win the prize/reward.
- and yet myself fail to receive God's blessings.

I myself will not be disqualified: This phrase continues to use the metaphor of an athletic contest. Sometimes a runner was successful in the competition but at the end the umpire said that he had broken the rules. He was disqualified and did not receive a prize.

Paul did not explain what it was he would lose. It is recommended that you do not try to make this explicit. However, if you must suggest the meaning, your interpretation should agree with what you chose in 9:25c. Here, as there, it is recommended that you choose interpretation (1).

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

I might be the one whom God will not reward in the future

I myself do not get God's blessings

General Comment on 9:27b-c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 9:27b-c. For example:

so that ^{9c}I myself will not be disqualified ^{9b}after I have preached to others (NCV)

1 Corinthians 10:1

Section 10:1-11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1-13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14-22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23-30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31-11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:1–5

Paul gave an example of the Hebrew ancestors. They had many spiritual blessings, but they were tempted by idolatry. Because of this, they died in the wilderness.

10:1a

I do not want you to be unaware, brothers,

- ¶ Brothers and sisters, I want to remind you^(plur)
- ¶ My friends, I want you to think about what happened

A Greek conjunction that is often translated as “for” introduces this section. There is a loose connection between this section and the previous section. Paul finished the previous section with a paragraph about self-control. In this paragraph he explained the importance of self-control. Some English versions, including the BSB, RSV, and GNT, do not translate this conjunction explicitly. Other English versions, including the NIV, ESV, and NASB, use the word “for.” Consider if it is natural in your language to introduce this new section and paragraph with a conjunction.

I do not want you to be unaware: The Corinthians probably knew some Jewish history. Paul wanted them to remember this history and understand the lessons that it taught. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a positive statement.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I don't want you to forget (NLT)

I want you to know (RSV)

I want you to remember (GNT)

brothers: Paul addressed the believers as his spiritual brothers. He did not exclude believing women, so it may be good to translate this as:

brothers and sisters

friends

10:1b

that our forefathers were all under the cloud,

- that our^(incl) ancestors all traveled under the cloud
- to our grandmothers and grandfathers. They all walked along following a big cloud which God put there to protect and guide them.

that our forefathers were all under the cloud: God used a large cloud to guide and protect the ancient Hebrews on their journey from Egypt to the Promised Land. God himself was in that cloud. See Exodus 13:20–22, and Exodus 14:19–20.

our forefathers: The forefathers were Hebrew people who lived long ago. However, most of the Corinthian believers were Gentiles. They were not descendants of those forefathers. Paul used the word in a spiritual sense. The Corinthian believers trusted God and were part of God's people. In that way they were spiritual descendants of the ancient Hebrews.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

our^(incl) ancestors

our spiritual ancestors

our grandmothers and grandfathers

were all under the cloud: This refers to a cloud from history that the readers knew about. If your readers do not know about this cloud, it may be good to explain it. For example:

They were all under the cloud which was a sign that God was with them.

They were all under the cloud that God sent to guide them.

Paul's readers also knew that the people walked under this cloud for many days.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

As they followed Moses they were all under the cloud.

When they escaped from Egypt they all walked under the cloud.

It may be helpful to have a footnote that says:

FOOTNOTE: When God led the Hebrew people out of Egypt, the Egyptian army followed them. God sent a cloud that hid them from their enemy, and guided them in the right direction.

10:1c

and that they all passed through the sea.

- and all crossed/walked through the Red Sea on dry land.
- They all went through/across the Red Sea and were not drowned.

and that they all passed through the sea: The Hebrew people crossed the Red Sea as they left Egypt. The Lord made a wind blow and divided the water in the sea. The people walked across the sea bed on dry land with the water on both sides of them. See Exodus 14:21–22.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they all went through the middle of the sea

they all went through the sea on dry land

they all walked through the Red Sea and were not drowned

1 Corinthians 10:2

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:1–5

Paul gave an example of the Hebrew ancestors. They had many spiritual blessings, but they were tempted

by idolatry. Because of this, they died in the wilderness.

10:2

They were all baptized into Moses in the cloud and in the sea.

- Also, they were baptized with the cloud and the sea to become followers of Moses.
- It was as if they were baptized in the cloud and in the sea, and this baptism showed that they followed Moses.

They were all baptized into Moses in the cloud and in the sea:

This is a metaphor. Paul compared the experience of the Hebrew people to baptism. In some languages it may be good to make it clear that this is a comparison.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it was like they were baptized into Moses by the cloud and the sea

as we are baptized when we become followers of Jesus, so they were baptized in the cloud and the sea and became followers of Moses

baptized into Moses: There are two ways to interpret this figure of speech:

1. It means that the Hebrew people became followers or disciples of Moses. For example:

This was like being baptized and becoming followers of Moses (CEV) (CEV, NCV, NLT, GNT)

1. It means that the Hebrew people joined into union or fellowship with Moses. For example:

they were all united with Moses by baptism (GW) (GW, REB)

It is not clear which Paul meant. If you must decide it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), which is recommended by some commentaries. Thiselton is among those who support this interpretation. Paul was thinking of the phrase "baptized into Christ" (see Romans 6:3). It may be possible to use a similar expression here.

1 Corinthians 10:3

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:1–5

Paul gave an example of the Hebrew ancestors. They had many spiritual blessings, but they were tempted by idolatry. Because of this, they died in the wilderness.

10:3

They all ate the same spiritual food

- They all ate from the same spiritual/miraculous food.
- All of them ate the same bread, bread that God gave them.

They all ate the same spiritual food: God provided manna for the Hebrew people during the forty years they lived in the desert. Manna was a kind of bread that came down from the sky. See Exodus 16:4–35.

spiritual food: This food was spiritual because it came from God in a miraculous way. Paul said that there was a spiritual reality behind the manna. The people who ate it were related to God, just as believers are related to Jesus Christ when they eat communion bread.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

food which God gave them

miraculous bread

1 Corinthians 10:4

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:1–5

Paul gave an example of the Hebrew ancestors. They had many spiritual blessings, but they were tempted by idolatry. Because of this, they died in the wilderness.

10:4a

and drank the same spiritual drink;

- And they all drank from the same spiritual/miraculous drink.
- And all of them drank the same water, water that God gave them.

and drank the same spiritual drink: The Hebrew people went through dry places where they could find no water. There were two times that God provided them with water from a rock. See Exodus 17:5–6 and Numbers 20:7–11.

spiritual drink: The Greek word that the BSB translates as spiritual is the same as the word in 10:3. Here it describes water that came out of a rock in a miraculous way. As with the food, Paul intended them to understand that there was a spiritual reality in the spiritual drink. The people who drank it were related to God, just as believers are related to Jesus Christ when they drink the wine at the communion service.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

drink which God gave them

miraculous water

10:4b

for they drank from the spiritual rock that accompanied them,

- This water came from the spiritual/miraculous rock that went/was with them.
- Wherever they went, they drank water out of a rock that God provided for them.

for: The word for explains how the food and drink was spiritual. In some languages it may be better to have no connecting word here.

Here is another way to translate this word:

because

they drank from the spiritual rock: The Greek word that the BSB translates as spiritual is the same as in 10:3 and 10:4. Here it describes the rocks that produced water in a miraculous way. Paul implied that there was a spiritual reality behind the rock. Although there were actually two different rocks, Paul uses the singular rock.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the rock which God gave them

the miraculous rock

that accompanied them: God provided water out of rocks two times. These rocks did not actually move with the people. Instead Christ, the spiritual rock, went with them.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

that stayed with them

that followed them

10:4c

and that rock was Christ.

- And that rock was Christ himself.
- And Christ himself was their rock.

and that rock was Christ: This is a metaphor. Paul identified the rock as Jesus Christ. Christ provided water for the Hebrew people in their journeys.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the rock was an illustration of Christ

the meaning of that rock is Christ, and he is the one who stayed with them

1 Corinthians 10:5**Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely**

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:1–5

Paul gave an example of the Hebrew ancestors. They had many spiritual blessings, but they were tempted by idolatry. Because of this, they died in the wilderness.

10:5a

Nevertheless, God was not pleased with most of them,

- However, God was displeased with most of them.
- And yet, the majority of them did not please God,
- In spite of all that, God was angry with most of them,

Nevertheless: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Nevertheless shows a contrast. Even though God blessed the Jewish people and gave them spiritual food, many of them did not follow him and because of that they died.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

but

however

God was not pleased with most of them: In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a positive statement. For example:

God was angry with most of them

most of them: The phrase most of them refers to almost all of the adults among the “forefathers” mentioned in 10:1b. In the Old Testament it says that God was only pleased with two of them, Caleb and Joshua. See Numbers 14:30.

10:5b

for they were struck down in the wilderness.

- They died and their bodies were scattered in the wilderness.
- and they all died on the journey/path through the wilderness.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *for* shows that 10:5b is evidence for what Paul had just said. The fact that the Hebrew people died in the wilderness was evidence that the Lord was not pleased with them.

Here are some other ways to translate the Greek conjunction:

we know this because

the evidence is that

they were struck down in the wilderness: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *they were struck down in the wilderness* is more literally “they were strewn in the wilderness.” This clause indicates that these Hebrew people died during a period of forty years as they walked in the wilderness, and their bodies were buried in many different places. They died because God judged them and caused them to die. See Numbers 14:20–35. Compare Hebrews 3:16–19.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they died in the wilderness

their bones are scattered many places in the wilderness

they died and their bodies are buried all over the wilderness

the wilderness: The wilderness or “desert” refers to an uninhabited place. Some parts of the wilderness were dry sand. Other parts were overgrown with thorns, or were swamps.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

desert

uninhabited place

1 Corinthians 10:6

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol’s temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord’s Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else’s conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don’t worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:6–10

Paul gave examples from the Hebrew Scriptures to warn the believers. He emphasized that it is dangerous to honor false gods and to commit sexual immorality.

10:6a

These things took place as examples

- ¶ Now these things/events happened as examples for us^(incl)
- ¶ We^(incl) should think about what happened to them so that the same thing does not happen to us^(incl).

In Greek, this verse part begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “but.” Here this word introduces an explanation of the events that Paul has just mentioned. Many English versions, like the BSB, do not use any word here. Some English translations, such as the NIV, ESV, and RSV, use the word “Now.” Introduce this explanation in a way that is natural in your language.

These things took place as examples: The events that Paul mentioned in 10:5 are examples or warnings. The events are not described in 10:5. Instead Paul described them in detail in 10:7–10.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

These things happened to warn us

We ought to learn from these things

What happened to them is a lesson for us

The destruction that happened to our ancestors will also happen to us if...

10:6b

to keep us from craving evil things as they did.

- so that we^(incl) will not wish/long/pine for evil things, as those people did.
- Those events warn us not to desire to do evil things as the ancestors did.

to keep us from craving evil things as they did: This is a negative purpose statement. God allowed these things to happen for a purpose. He wanted to warn his people not to desire evil things.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

so that we^(incl) do not desire to do bad things as they did

warning us^(incl) not to long for evil things as they did

craving: The word craving refers to a strong desire.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

desiring

longing for

1 Corinthians 10:7

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:6–10

Paul gave examples from the Hebrew Scriptures to warn the believers. He emphasized that it is dangerous to honor false gods and to commit sexual immorality.

10:7a

Do not be idolaters,

- You^(plur) must not be idol worshipers
- Do not worship other gods,

Do not be idolaters: An "idolater" is someone who worships an idol. Some of the ancient Hebrews, and also many people in the city of Corinth, worshiped idols.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Do not worship idols

Do not worship other gods

10:7b

as some of them were.

- as some of them were.
- as they worshiped.

as some of them were: This refers to the story of how Aaron led the Hebrew people to worship a golden calf. The word some is an understatement. According to Exodus 32:1–6 almost all the Hebrew people were involved.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

like they did

as they worshiped

10:7c

As it is written:

- For it is written in the Scriptures:
- We^(incl) know they worshiped idols because in God's book it says this:

As it is written: The phrase As it is written introduces a quotation from the Hebrew Scriptures. The quotation

provides evidence that many of the Hebrew people worshiped idols.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

As the Scriptures say

We know they worshiped idols because we read in God's Book

10:7d

“The people sat down to eat and to drink, and got up to indulge in revelry.”

- “The people sat down to eat and drink, and then they got up to dance immorally.”
- “The people of Israel sat down to eat and drink before their idols, and then they got up to revel/party around the idols.”

The people sat down to eat and to drink: This is a quote from Exodus 32:6 which says that the Hebrew people ate in the presence of the golden calf idol.

and got up to indulge in revelry: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as to indulge in revelry is more literally “to play.” Sometimes it refers to religious dancing (compare 1 Chronicles 13:8). In Exodus 32, the people shouted, sang, and danced (Exodus 32:17–19). Most commentators agree that this refers to dancing that has sexual overtones. Consider if there is a word or phrase in your language that suggests this. For example:

amuse/indulge themselves

have a wild party

dance immorally

1 Corinthians 10:8

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in

everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:6–10

Paul gave examples from the Hebrew Scriptures to warn the believers. He emphasized that it is dangerous to honor false gods and to commit sexual immorality.

10:8a

We should not commit sexual immorality, as some of them did,

- We^(incl) must not sin sexually as some of them sinned.
- We must not do sexual sin. That is what some of them did,

We should not commit sexual immorality, as some of them did:

In Numbers 25:1–9 some women from the country of Moab came to the camp of the Hebrews. They asked Hebrew men to eat animal sacrifices and have sexual intercourse with them in order to honor their god Baal Peor. In a similar way, the men of Corinth used to have sexual intercourse with temple prostitutes in honor of the goddess called Aphrodite or Venus. Paul told them they should not do this.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

We^(incl) must not do sexual sin as some of them did

Some of them committed sexual sins, but we must not do that

We should not: Paul addressed this command to everyone, including himself. Consider how it is most natural to translate such first-person plural commands. For example:

We^(incl) must not commit sexual immorality

Do not let us^(incl) commit sexual immorality

commit sexual immorality: The phrase commit sexual immorality refers to all kinds of sinful sexual behavior. See the note at 5:1b.

10:8b

and in one day twenty-three thousand of them died.

- Because of their sin, sickness caused twenty-three thousand of those people to die in a single day.
- and in one day twenty-three thousand of them died because of their sin.

and in one day twenty-three thousand of them died:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as died is literally “fell.” These people did not die naturally. God caused them to die from a sickness. In Numbers 25:9 the number given is twenty-four thousand. The reason for the difference is not certain. You should translate the numbers as they are written and not try to make them agree.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in one day twenty-three thousand of them died from a sickness, which was God’s punishment on them

in one day twenty-three thousand of them died because of their sin

1 Corinthians 10:9**Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely**

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol’s temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord’s Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else’s conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don’t worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:6–10

Paul gave examples from the Hebrew Scriptures to warn the believers. He emphasized that it is dangerous to honor false gods and to commit sexual immorality.

10:9a

We should not test Christ,

- We^(incl) must not challenge Christ
- Also, do not let us make Christ angry with us

We should not test Christ: For this story, see Numbers 21:4–7.

test: The verb test means to challenge a person to do something. For example, children might test their parents by acting badly to see how they will react. In the Old Testament story, the Hebrew people were tired of the manna that the Lord sent them, so they demanded that he give them meat to eat. This was sinful. It meant that they did not trust God to love them and take care of them. They acted badly to try to make God do something for them.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

challenge Christ

draw out the anger of Christ

keep on until Christ gets angry with us

Christ: There is a textual issue here.

1. Some Greek manuscripts say Christ. The NRSV follows these manuscripts and says:

We must not put Christ to the test (NRSV) (BSB, NRSV, ESV, NET, NCV, NLT, CEV, KJV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts say “the Lord.” The REB follows these manuscripts and says:

Let us not put the Lord to the test. (REB) (REB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, NASB, GW)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This is supported by many ancient manuscripts and translations and is in the United Bible Society Greek text. The reading “Christ” has a B rating in the 4th edition of the UBS Greek New Testament, indicating that the editors think “the text is almost certain.”

10:9b

as some of them did,

- as some of them challenged him.
- in the way that some of them angered him

as some of them did: The clause as some of them did means “as some of the Hebrew people tested Christ.”

In the Old Testament story, the people tested God rather than Christ. So, if you must supply an object, it is good to use a pronoun, “tested him.” Or you could use a word that refers to both Christ and God, such as “the Lord.”

10:9c

and were killed by snakes.

- Because they challenged him, snakes came/bit and killed them.
- and because of it died from snake bites.

and were killed by snakes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as were killed is a strong word that can also be translated as “were destroyed.”

The English verb were killed is passive. The Greek verb is in the middle voice.

Here are two ways to translate this passive verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

were destroyed by the snakes (REB)

- Use an active verb:

snakes bit them and killed them

they died when snakes bit them

1 Corinthians 10:10

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol’s temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord’s Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else’s conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don’t worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:6–10

Paul gave examples from the Hebrew Scriptures to warn the believers. He emphasized that it is dangerous to honor false gods and to commit sexual immorality.

10:10a

And do not complain,

- Also, you^(plur) should not complain/whine,
- Nor should you object to what God is doing.

10:10b

as some of them did,

- as some of them complained/whined.
- This was what many of the Israelites did,

10:10a-b

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces another negative command. In some languages it may be natural to follow the GNT and start a new sentence with no conjunction.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

Nor (RSV)

do not complain, as some of them did: For the biblical stories, see Numbers 14:1–38, Numbers 16:1–14, Numbers 16:41–42. In these stories, the people grumbled and complained against Moses and Aaron, the leaders the Lord had appointed to help them. Evidently some of the people of the church in Corinth grumbled against Paul as their leader.

complain: Here are some other ways to translate this word:

grumble (NIV)

speak against God

10:10c

and were killed by the destroying angel.

- Because they complained an angel of death killed them.
- and so the Lord sent his angel/messenger to kill them.

and were killed by the destroying angel: The English verb were killed is passive. The Greek verb is in the middle voice.

Here are two ways to translate this passive verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

they were destroyed by the Destroyer (REB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

The angel of death destroyed them. (GW)

the destroying angel: The Greek word that the BSB translates as destroying angel is more literally “the destroyer.” The story in Exodus 12:21–30 gives background on the destroying angel. It is likely that Paul understood this “destroyer” to be an angel sent from the Lord to carry out his judgment against the people. Compare 2 Samuel 24:15–17; 2 Chronicles 32:21; and Hebrews 11:28.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the angel whom God sent to kill them

the angel of God who had authority to kill people

1 Corinthians 10:11

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol’s temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord’s Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else’s conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don’t worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:11–13

Paul used the story of the Hebrew people to encourage his readers to stand firm and trust God when they face testing and temptation.

10:11a

Now these things happened to them as examples

- ¶ These things happened to the ancestors as an example to us,

- ¶ Those things took place to show people what can happen to them if they do the same things as those ancestors did.

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now marks a transition from the warnings of 10:8–10, to an explanation of their meaning. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. Translate it in a way that makes the transition natural in your language.

these things happened to them as examples: The words these things refer back to the events that Paul just mentioned. God allowed those things to happen to the Hebrew people so that we would have warning examples. The Greek wording is not quite the same as in 10:6a, but the meaning is about the same.

these things: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts say these things. For example:

these things (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NCV, CEV, NASB, NET, GW, ESV, NLT2004)

1. Some Greek manuscripts say “all these things.” For example:

All these events (NLT96) (NLT96, GNT, REB, NJB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This has the strongest support amongst English versions and is the reading of the UBS Greek New Testament. The reading “these things” has a B rating in the 4th edition of the UBS Greek New Testament, indicating that the editors think “the text is almost certain.”

examples: You should translate this the same way you translated examples in 10:6a.

10:11b

and were written down as warnings for us,

- and they were written down to warn us^(incl).
- God told Moses to write those things down in order to teach us^(incl) to be careful not to do those things.

and: The Greek word that the BSB translates as and marks a contrast between “them” in 10:11a and “us” in 10:11b. Paul said that these things happened to them, but they were written down for us. Use a word that marks this contrast naturally in your language. For example:

but (ESV) (ESV, RSV)

were written down: This is a passive verb.

Here are two ways to translate this passive verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

were recorded (REB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

Moses wrote them down

God caused Moses to write these things down

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language. If you use an active verb and provide a subject, you may need to supply the information that Moses wrote these narratives.

as warnings for us: The Greek word that the BSB translates as warnings can also be translated as “instruction.” The stories Paul mentioned give us instruction about what people should not do. In some languages it may be natural to use a verb:

to warn us^(incl)

to teach us to be careful

Moses wrote these things down, but God intended them to be warnings. It may be helpful to say:

by these examples God warned us^(incl)

for us: The pronoun us is inclusive, referring to Paul and his readers.

10:11c

on whom the fulfillment of the ages has come.

- We^(incl) live at a time when God is completing his work.
- For we are living in a time that is close to the end of the world.

on whom the fulfillment of the ages has come: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the fulfillment of the ages is literally “the ends of the ages.” The Greek word meaning “ends” often includes the idea of a “goal.” God had a goal for the world. Paul and his readers lived in the last age of the world before God will bring his goal to an end.

There are at least two ways to translate this phrase:

- Emphasize the idea of conclusion, that this is the last age. For example:

on whom the end of the ages has come (NET)

we live at a time when the end is about to come (GNT)

- Emphasize the idea of fulfillment. This is the age in which God fulfills his plan. For example:

we live in a time when all these things of the past have reached their goal (NCV)

we have reached the time when all things will be complete

It is good if your translation can include both these ideas. The English word “completion,” for example, contains both ideas.

1 Corinthians 10:12

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol’s temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord’s Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else’s conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don’t worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:11–13

Paul used the story of the Hebrew people to encourage his readers to stand firm and trust God when they face testing and temptation.

10:12a

So the one who thinks he is standing firm

- Therefore, if anyone thinks they are standing strong/firmly in their faith,

- Therefore in view of all those examples, if you feel confident that you will never sin,

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So introduces Paul's command based on what he has just said.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Therefore

Because of those examples

the one who thinks he is standing firm: This is a metaphor. The Greek text says literally "anyone who thinks that he stands." The BSB has supplied the word firm to help suggest the meaning of the metaphor. Paul referred to believers who felt safe spiritually. They were sure they would not sin like the Hebrew people did.

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:
- the one who thinks he is standing (NET)
- Use the figure of speech and explain the meaning. For example:

you think you can stand strong against temptation

- Translate the meaning only. For example:

those who are confident that their faith is strong

you think that you will never sin

those who say, "I will never sin like that"

10:12b

should be careful not to fall.

- then they had better take care, for otherwise they will fall into sin.
- then you should watch out that you do not stumble over evil ways and sin like our ancestors did.

should be careful not to fall: This is a warning. The word fall is used as a metaphor for sinning. It contrasts with "standing" in 10:12a.

Here are three ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

take care, or you may fall (REB)

- Use the figure of speech and explain the meaning. For example:

should be careful not to fall into sin

should be careful that they do not stumble over the evil ways

- Translate the meaning only. For example:

should be careful not to sin

Translate this figure of speech in the way that is most natural in your language.

General Comment on 10:12a-b

The Greek text uses a third-person subject: "the one who thinks he is standing." Many English versions use a second-person subject instead: "you." Another possibility is to use the third-person plural. For example:

So, people who think they are standing firmly should be careful that they don't fall. (GW)

Paul gave this warning to every believer. Use a form that is natural in your language.

1 Corinthians 10:13

Section 10:1-11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1-13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14-22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23-30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31-11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:11–13

Paul used the story of the Hebrew people to encourage his readers to stand firm and trust God when they face testing and temptation.

10:13a

No temptation has seized you except what is common to man.

- All people are tempted in the same way that you are tempted.
- The temptations that you^(plur) have encountered are those that all people encounter.

No temptation has seized you except what is common to man: Paul said that everyone is tempted. The Corinthians were not different from other people.

No temptation has seized you: The expression temptation has seized you is a figure of speech in which temptation is pictured as a person who can take hold of someone.

Here are three ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

no temptation has overtaken you (ESV)

- Use the figure of speech and explain the meaning. For example:

no temptations can seize you to make you sin

- Translate the meaning only. For example:

you are not tempted

the evil things that attract you

when Satan tempts you to do wrong

what is common to man: All people experience the same kind of temptations.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

these temptations seize other people also

all people are tempted in the same way

these evil things attract others too

Satan uses the same things to tempt all people

General Comment on 10:13a

The Greek uses a double negative. It is also possible to translate this as a positive statement. For example:

you are tempted in the same way that everyone else is tempted (CEV)

10:13b

And God is faithful;

- But you can trust God.
- However, you^(plur) do not need to surrender to temptation, because you can be sure that God will help you.

And: There are two ways to interpret the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And:

1. It introduces a contrast. Even though there is temptation, God will help us. Here are some ways to translate this contrast:

But

However (GNT, NCV, CEV, KJV)

1. It introduces a continuation of thought. This can be translated “and” as in the BSB. (BSB, NIV, NET, NLT, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the opinion of a majority of commentaries. In some languages a conjunction may not be necessary. If that is the case in your language, you may leave it implicit.

God is faithful: The phrase God is faithful indicates that God keeps his promises. His people can trust him to help them endure temptation. This phrase also occurs in 1:9.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

God keeps his promises (GNT)

you can trust/believe God

we^(incl) can be sure that God will help us

10:13c

He will not let you be tempted beyond what you can bear.

- He will not let that temptation be so strong that you^(plur) cannot endure it.

- He will not allow Satan to tempt you more than you are able to resist/overcome.

He will not let you be tempted: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as be tempted is a passive verb.

Here are two ways to translate this verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

be tempted (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

suffer temptation

God will not allow Satan to tempt you

God will not let the temptation become so strong that...

beyond what you can bear: This indicates that God will not permit temptations that he knows people cannot endure. He will not allow Satan to tempt them to the point where they cannot stop themselves from sinning.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

greater than your strength is able to endure

more than you can overcome

beyond your power to resist (GW)

10:13d

But when you are tempted, He will also provide an escape,

- And when you^(plur) suffer that temptation, he will show/give you a way out of it
- For when God allows Satan to tempt you, he will also make sure that there will be an end/exit to the tempting

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But introduces a contrast to the idea that God will not let us be tempted beyond what we can bear.

when you are tempted: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as when you are tempted is literally “with the temptation.”

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

when Satan tempts you

He will also provide an escape: God will help the believer to resist the temptation.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he will also provide a way out (NIV)

he will give you the strength to avoid sinning

God will help you say “no” to Satan

10:13e

so that you can stand up under it.

- so that you^(plur) will be able to endure that temptation and not surrender to it.
- so that you do not sin/do wrong.

so that you can stand up under it: There are two ways to interpret how this clause connects to 10:13d:

1. It expresses purpose or intended result: “God made a way of escape so that when you are tempted you can remain faithful.” For example, the NASB says

so that you will be able to endure it (BSB, NASB, NIV, NET, KJV, RSV, NLT, NCV)

1. It identifies what the means of escape is. “What I mean is, you will be able to endure the testing.” For example:

provide a way out by enabling you to put up with it (NJB) (NJB, GW, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation is supported by the Greek grammar and has the strongest support among the English versions.

1 Corinthians 10:14

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol’s temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord’s Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else’s conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control

their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:14–22

Paul forbade believers from having anything to do with idolatry. Demons control idol worship, and anyone who shares in the Lord's Supper cannot also take part in a feast that honors demons. That will cause the Lord to be angry, and no one should risk testing him in that way.

10:14

Therefore, my beloved, flee from idolatry.

- ¶ For that reason, my dear friends, you^(plur) must totally avoid/reject the worship of idols.
- ¶ So, ones I love, I urge you to turn away from bowing down before statues.

Therefore: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Therefore is an emphatic one meaning “for that reason.” Because of the example of their Hebrew ancestors, the Corinthians should flee from idolatry.

my beloved: Here Paul addressed his readers affectionately. He addressed all the Corinthian believers, whether or not he knew them personally. Here is another way to translate this:

my dear friends (NIV)

flee from idolatry: This is a strongly worded command. The phrase flee from idolatry is a metaphor meaning to avoid all connection with idolatry. Paul used the same metaphor in 6:18 “flee from sexual immorality.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

have nothing to do with idolatry (REB)

keep away from idolatry

1 Corinthians 10:15

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned

them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:14–22

Paul forbade believers from having anything to do with idolatry. Demons control idol worship, and anyone who shares in the Lord's Supper cannot also take part in a feast that honors demons. That will cause the Lord to be angry, and no one should risk testing him in that way.

10:15a

I speak to reasonable people;

- I am addressing you^(plur) as reasonable/thinking people.
- I am talking to you like this because you are intelligent people.

I speak to reasonable people: The Greek word that the BSB translates as reasonable is the same word that is translated as “wise” in 4:10. Here is another way to translate this:

I am speaking to thoughtful people. (NET)

It may be natural to use the second-person pronoun “you.” For example:

You are reasonable people. (NLT)

I am speaking to you as to intelligent people. (NCV)

10:15b

judge for yourselves what I say.

- Decide for yourselves if what I say is right.
- You^(plur) can assess/weigh the truth of what I am about to say.

judge for yourselves what I say: Paul wanted the Corinthians to be sure about the truth and importance of what he said.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

think over what I am saying (JBP)

Consider what I say. (NET)

what I say: The phrase what I say refers to the content of Paul's letter. Paul wanted his readers to think about what he had said about idolatry and decide for themselves what was right. This phrase probably looks forward to what Paul was about to write. So, the NLT96 translates this as:

what I am about to say (NLT96)

1 Corinthians 10:16

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:14–22

Paul forbade believers from having anything to do with idolatry. Demons control idol worship, and anyone who shares in the Lord's Supper cannot also take part in a feast that honors demons. That will cause the Lord to be angry, and no one should risk testing him in that way.

10:16a

Is not the cup of blessing that we bless a participation in the blood of Christ?

- During the Lord's Supper, we^(incl) give thanks for the cup of wine and we are one with Christ because of his blood.
- When we celebrate communion/eucharist, we thank God for the cup of wine. We drink it together because we are people for whom Christ shed/gave his blood.

Is not the cup of blessing that we bless a participation in the blood of Christ?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a statement. Paul said that the cup of blessing was a participation in the blood of Christ. The Corinthians already knew this, and he reminded them of it.

Here are some ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Is not the cup of blessing that we bless a sharing in the body of Christ? (NET)

- Use a statement. For example:

We give thanks for the cup of blessing, which is a sharing in the blood of Christ. (NCV)

Translate this statement in the way that is most natural in your language.

There is some implied information in this statement. Believers participate in the blood of Christ by drinking the wine in the cup. It may be clearer to make this explicit.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

When we drink wine from the cup that we ask God to bless, we share in the blood of Christ.

the cup of blessing that we bless: This is called the cup of blessing because a minister of the church prayed over it, thanked God for it, and blessed it. This ritual is similar to that of the Jewish Passover meal. The cup of wine drunk at the end of that Passover meal was called "the cup of blessing." To "bless" the cup was to thank God for it, thereby consecrating it to him. The Greek word that the BSB translates as blessing can also be translated as "thanksgiving."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the cup that we ask God to bless

the cup of wine that we thank God for

the cup: This refers to the Christian ceremony or sacrament called Holy Communion, the Eucharist, or the Lord's Supper. If your readers will not understand that the cup refers to the communion cup, it may be helpful to make this clear. For example:

the cup we drink at the communion ceremony

the cup of wine that stands for the blood of Christ

a participation in the blood of Christ: The wine in the cup represents Christ's blood shed on the cross (Mark 14:24). At the Lord's Supper, believers who drink from the cup accept Christ's death for them. They participate in the blood of Christ in the sense that they are spiritually united with him in his death and share in the benefits of his death.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

we share the blessing that comes from the blood of Christ

this shows that we are one with Christ because his blood was shed for us

10:16b

And is not the bread that we break a participation in the body of Christ?

- We^(incl) break the loaf of bread and so we are one with Christ because of his body.
- We take the bread and we break it and eat it together because we are people for whom Christ gave/surrendered his body.

And is not the bread that we break a participation in the body of Christ?: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a statement to remind Corinthians of something they already knew. Paul reminded them that when they shared bread during the Lord's Supper, they shared in the body of Christ.

Here are two ways to translate this statement:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Is not the bread that we break a sharing in the body of Christ? (NET)

- As a statement. For example:

And the bread that we break is a sharing in the body of Christ. (NCV)

the bread that we break: There is some implied information here. The believers broke the bread and each person ate a piece of it. It may be clearer to make the word "eat" explicit:

When we eat a piece of the bread that we break, we share in the body of Christ.

a participation in the body of Christ: The communion bread represents Christ's body as he died on the cross. At the Lord's Supper, believers who eat the bread accept Christ's death for them. They participate in the body of Christ in the sense that they are spiritually united with him in his death and share in the benefits of his death.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

we share the blessing that comes from the body of Christ

this shows that we are one with Christ because his body died for us

1 Corinthians 10:17

Section 10:1-11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1-13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14-22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23-30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31-11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:14-22

Paul forbade believers from having anything to do with idolatry. Demons control idol worship, and anyone who shares in the Lord's Supper cannot also take part in a feast that honors demons. That will cause the Lord to be angry, and no one should risk testing him in that way.

10:17a**Because there is one loaf,**

- Because there is one loaf of bread,
- There is only one loaf/lump/piece of bread,

Because there is one loaf: Another way to translate this is:

Because there is one loaf of bread

In Paul's time, when a group of believers took communion, they used a single loaf of bread. Today in some churches believers use individual wafers instead. If this is the case in the churches in your area, it may be helpful to include a footnote explaining the practice in Paul's time. A sample footnote is:

FOOTNOTE: In the early church, the believers broke a loaf of bread apart and shared it during Communion.

10:17b**we who are many are one body;**

- although there are many of us, we^(incl) are one body,
- and we show that we are all united

we who are many are one body: Paul expressed two ideas: we are many individuals, and we form one body. The words many and one are in contrast. It may be more natural to say:

although we are many people, we are one body

we...are one body: This is a metaphor for the unity that we have in Christ.

Here are three ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

we become one body

we are like a single body

- Keep the figure of speech with a different point of comparison. For example:

we become like one heart

we become like one person

- Translate the meaning only. For example:

we are one

we are united

it is as if we are one

10:17c**for we all partake of the one loaf.**

- for we^(incl) all eat from the same loaf.
- by eating together from that one loaf/lump/piece of bread.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces a further explanation of what Paul wrote. He said in 10:17a that there is one loaf, and now he adds that we all eat that one loaf.

we all partake of the one loaf: The verb partake means to share in something. In the Lord's Supper, believers share in one loaf by eating from it together.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

we share in the same loaf/lump/piece of bread

we all eat together from the same bread

the one loaf: The phrase the one loaf refers to the loaf of bread mentioned in 10:17a. In some languages it may be natural to make this clear by saying:

that one loaf of bread

General Comment on 10:17a-c

Some English versions combine the clauses "Because there is one loaf" and "for we all partake of the one loaf." For example:

^{17a&c}And we all eat from one loaf, ^{17b}showing that we are one body. (NLT96)

1 Corinthians 10:18**Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely**

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control

their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:14–22

Paul forbade believers from having anything to do with idolatry. Demons control idol worship, and anyone who shares in the Lord's Supper cannot also take part in a feast that honors demons. That will cause the Lord to be angry, and no one should risk testing him in that way.

10:18a

Consider the people of Israel:

- Think about the people of Israel.
- For example, take the customs of the Jews.

Consider the people of Israel: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the people of Israel is literally "Israel according to the flesh." This refers to the historical people of Israel. Paul wanted his readers to think about the customs of his own Jewish people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Think about the Jewish people

Think about the customs of the Jewish people

10:18b

Are not those who eat the sacrifices fellow partakers in the altar?

- Do they not share together in worship when they eat the sacrificed meat?
- They eat the food they sacrifice/offer to God. In that way they join in the worship of God.

Are not those who eat the sacrifices fellow partakers in the altar?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a statement. He expected people to respond, "Yes, that is true." In the laws that God gave to Moses, he arranged for the people to eat part of the animals they sacrificed. See, for example, Leviticus 7:11–18; Deuteronomy 12:27.

Here are some ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Don't those who eat the sacrifices share what is on the altar? (GW)

- Use a statement. For example:

All who eat the sacrificed food participate together in the sacrifice

Translate this statement in the way that is most natural in your language.

fellow partakers in the altar: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as fellow partakers in the altar is literally "sharers of the altar." Paul said that those who ate the sacrificed meat shared the sacrifice made on the altar. It was as though they ate together in God's presence and shared a meal with him. This is like 10:20 where those who eat the food offered to idols are "participants with demons."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they worship God together

they share in the worship

they have a part in the work of sacrifice

1 Corinthians 10:19

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:14–22

Paul forbade believers from having anything to do with idolatry. Demons control idol worship, and any-

one who shares in the Lord's Supper cannot also take part in a feast that honors demons. That will cause the Lord to be angry, and no one should risk testing him in that way.

10:19a-b

This is written as one sentence in the BSB. In the Greek it is two separate questions, as in the NASB:

What do I mean then? That a thing sacrificed to idols is anything, or that an idol is anything?
(NASB)

The second of these questions consists of two clauses that could be translated as separate questions. For example:

What do I mean then? Is food sacrificed to idols anything? Is an idol anything?

Use the number of questions and sentences that are natural in your language. See also the General Comment on 10:19a-b for a way to reorder the information in this verse.

10:19a

Am I suggesting, then, that food sacrificed to an idol is anything,

- What do I mean? I do not mean that a sacrifice people/pagans offer to an idol has any value/worth.
- I am not saying that food sacrificed/offered to idols is holy.

Am I suggesting, then, that food sacrificed to an idol is anything: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a statement. He expected people to respond "No, of course not. That is not what you are suggesting."

Here are two ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question or questions. For example:

What am I suggesting, then? Do I mean that food sacrificed to idols is anything?

- Use a statement. For example:

I am not suggesting that food sacrificed to an idol is anything.

Translate this statement in the way that is most natural in your language.

Paul gave the response to this question in the next verse. See also the notes on 8:4b. Some believers argued that eating meals in an idol's temple did not affect their standing with God. Paul agreed with them that idol food is in itself no different from any other food.

Am I suggesting, then, that: These words introduce the rhetorical question that follows.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

Am I saying that...? (NET)

What am I trying to say? (NLT)

What I am trying to say is...

food sacrificed to an idol is anything: Paul said that food sacrificed to an idol had no value or importance. It was not the means of fellowship with a god.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the food sacrificed to an idol does not have any value/worth

the meat people sacrifice to idols is not holy

the food sacrificed to idols is not different from other food

food sacrificed to an idol: The Greek word that the BSB translates as food sacrificed to an idol is the same word that is used in 8:1a and 8:4a. It refers to food that pagans dedicated to their idols. The BSB uses the passive verb sacrificed. If you need to use an active verb form, try to provide a general subject.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

food that people/they sacrifice to idols

idol food

10:19b

or that an idol is anything?

- And I do not mean that an idol has any value/worth.
- I am not saying that an idol is an actual god.

or: The Greek word that the BSB translates as or introduces a second thing that Paul did not mean. Consider

whether to start a new sentence here, as discussed in the note on 10:19a-b. For example:

Do I mean that an idol is anything?

that an idol is anything?: This is a short way of saying “do I mean that an idol is anything?” This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a statement that expects the response “No.”

Here are two ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Do I mean to say that idols are anything?

- Use a statement. For example:

Idols are not anything.

an idol is anything: Paul said that an idol had no value or importance. It was not a living deity as the worshipers thought it was. See also the notes on 8:4b, “an idol is nothing at all.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Idols are not important/valuable/useful.

Idols are not alive/powerful/divine.

An idol is not an actual god.

An idol is just something that people have made.

General Comment on 10:19a-b

Some translators find that it is clearer to mention the idols first and then the sacrifices. It is also possible to combine these two questions. For example:

Do I mean to say that idols are alive? Is there is a difference between food offered to them and other food?

The idols which people worship are not important, and the food offered to idols is just plain food.

1 Corinthians 10:20

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol’s temple. First he warned

them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord’s Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else’s conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don’t worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:14–22

Paul forbade believers from having anything to do with idolatry. Demons control idol worship, and anyone who shares in the Lord’s Supper cannot also take part in a feast that honors demons. That will cause the Lord to be angry, and no one should risk testing him in that way.

10:20a

No, but the sacrifices of pagans are offered to demons, not to God.

- No, on the contrary. When the pagans sacrifice/offer their animals/gifts to idols, they are sacrificing/offering them to demons, not to God.
- Rather, this is what I mean: people who worship idols do not make sacrifices to the/a divine being. They are actually sacrificing to demons.

No: Paul answered his own rhetorical question. If you translated the previous question as a negative statement, you will probably not need to translate this explicitly.

Here are some other ways to translate Paul’s answer:

But what I am saying is this:

Instead, I mean that...

but the sacrifices of pagans are offered to demons, not to God: The word offered is in the passive.

Here are two ways to translate this phrase:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

their sacrifices are offered to demons

- Use an active verb. For example:

people offer these sacrifices to demons

the sacrifices of pagans: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the sacrifices of pagans is a verb meaning “they sacrifice.” Some Greek manuscripts read “the nations sacrifice.” However, the 4th edition of the UBS Greek NT chose the reading “they sacrifice.” The editors give this a C rating, indicating that they “had difficulty in deciding which variant to place in the text.” The BSB has supplied the word pagans to make the meaning clear.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the sacrifices that they/people make

demons: A “demon” is an evil spirit. You should translate this the same way that you did in passages such as Matthew 7:22 or Mark 1:34. See also the article in KBT about “Evil Spirit, Unclean Spirit, Demon.”

10:20b

And I do not want you to be participants with demons.

- And/So I do not want you^(plur) to share together with demons.
- And I would hate for you to join in the worship of demons.

And I do not want you to be participants with demons: The phrase I do not want in this context indicates disapproval. Paul said that he disapproved of believers sharing in fellowship with demons by eating idol food.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I don’t want you^(plur) to have anything to do with demons.

You^(plur) should not share anything with demons.

participants with demons: See the note on “participate in the altar” in 10:18b. Try to use a similar phrase here so that your readers will understand the connection and the contrast.

1 Corinthians 10:21

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol’s temple. First he warned

them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord’s Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else’s conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don’t worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:14–22

Paul forbade believers from having anything to do with idolatry. Demons control idol worship, and anyone who shares in the Lord’s Supper cannot also take part in a feast that honors demons. That will cause the Lord to be angry, and no one should risk testing him in that way.

10:21a

You cannot drink the cup of the Lord and the cup of demons too;

- You^(plur) must not drink from the cup used at the Lord’s Supper and also drink from the cup used to honor demons.
- It is unacceptable to drink the wine in fellowship with the Lord Jesus Christ and then drink wine in fellowship with demons.

You cannot drink: The phrase You cannot drink, indicates that it is wrong to do this. But it is also a warning. If a person unites himself to demons, then he is not united to the Lord.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

you must not drink

it is not right to drink

the cup of the Lord and the cup of demons too: The cup of the Lord refers to the cup of wine that Christians drink at communion. It is dedicated to the Lord. Drinking it brings the believer into fellowship with the Lord.

The cup of demons refers to the cup of wine that pagans drink at their meals honoring idols. This wine

is dedicated to these idols. These idols represent demons. So, when people drink in their honor, they honor the demons and enter into fellowship with the demons.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

You cannot drink the wine that belongs to the Lord and also the wine that belongs to demons

You cannot drink wine at the Lord's Supper and also drink wine dedicated to demons

10:21b

you cannot partake in the table of the Lord and the table of demons too.

- And you^(plur) must not eat the bread used at the Lord's Supper and also eat the food which people have offered to demons.
- And it is unacceptable to eat the bread used at the Lord's Supper and then eat food offered to demons.

you cannot partake in the table of the Lord and the table of demons too: The table of the Lord refers to the communion meal. When believers ate the communion meal, it was to honor the Lord and to have fellowship with him. The table of demons refers to a meal in an idol's temple.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

You cannot eat at the Lord's Supper and also eat food that has been dedicated to demons

General Comment on 10:21a-b

Some translators choose to mention the demons first. For example:

It is not possible to join in eating and drinking what has been offered to demons and also join in eating and drinking the Lord's Supper.

1 Corinthians 10:22

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control

their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:14–22

Paul forbade believers from having anything to do with idolatry. Demons control idol worship, and anyone who shares in the Lord's Supper cannot also take part in a feast that honors demons. That will cause the Lord to be angry, and no one should risk testing him in that way.

10:22a-b

Are we trying to provoke the Lord to jealousy? Are we stronger than He?: This paragraph began with the command "Flee from idolatry." It ends with this warning that God will punish the Corinthians if they ignore his command. This is Paul's final response to their question about taking part in feasts at an idol's temple (see 1 Corinthians 8:4).

10:22a

Are we trying to provoke the Lord to jealousy?

- Should we^(incl) not be afraid to make the Lord jealous by worshiping someone besides himself?
- It is not good if the Lord becomes angry with us.

Are we trying to provoke the Lord to jealousy?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a warning that it is foolish to make the Lord jealous. 10:22b gives the reason why this is so. This implies that eating a sacrificial meal honoring demons will make the Lord jealous.

Here are two ways to translate this warning:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Are we trying to make the Lord jealous? (NCV)

Do you want to make the Lord jealous and angry?

- Use a strong statement or exclamation. For example:

We would make the Lord jealous if we did that (CEV)

It is dangerous to make the Lord jealous

Translate this warning in the way that is most natural in your language.

10:22b

Are we stronger than He?

- We^(incl) are not stronger than him, are we? Of course not!
- The Lord is stronger than we are!

Are we stronger than He?: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a warning that we are not stronger than the Lord. We cannot expect to win if he is angry with us. That is why we must not make him jealous.

Here are two ways to translate this warning:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Are we really stronger than he is? (NET)

We are not stronger than He, are we? (NASB)

- As a strong statement or exclamation. For example:

And we are not stronger than the Lord. (CEV)

We^(incl) are certainly not stronger than he is

1 Corinthians 10:23

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:23–11:1

Paul discussed whether believers can eat food that pagans offered to idols and later sold in the marketplace. He said that believers must consider not only their own freedom and rights. They must also consider the good of others, and how their actions will help non-believers to be saved.

10:23a

“Everything is permissible,”

- ¶ Some of you^(plur) say, “We^(incl) are allowed to do anything we want to.”
- ¶ “Nothing is forbidden to us^(incl),” people say.

Everything is permissible: This means that everything is allowed or permitted. It does not say who allows everything. The implied subject is probably “the law” or “God.” See the notes on 6:12a where there is a similar saying.

This clause is probably something that Paul himself had previously said. Now, some of the believers in Corinth used this phrase to claim that they could go to feasts in an idol's temple. Many English versions, like the BSB, use quotation marks to indicate that this is a quotation. People who listen to scripture will not see the quotation marks. So, it may be helpful to supply a phrase such as “you say.” For example:

Some of you say, “We can do whatever we want to!” (CEV)

“We are allowed to do anything,” so they say. (GNT)

10:23b

but not everything is beneficial.

- But not everything is useful/worthwhile.
- Yes, but that does not mean that everything is good for us^(incl) to do.

but not everything is beneficial: Paul agreed with the saying in 10:23a up to a certain point. Now he said why he did not agree completely: some things are not helpful. They are harmful to God's glory or to people's spiritual life. See the notes on 6:12b. These are the same words that are used there.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

maybe so, but not everything does good (NJB)

yes, but not everything is useful

10:23c**“Everything is permissible,”**

- Some of you^(plur) say, “We^(incl) are allowed to do anything we want to.”
- “Nothing is forbidden to us,” people say.

Everything is permissible: This is the same statement as in 10:23a. You should translate it in the same way that you did there.

10:23d**but not everything is edifying.**

- But not everything is helpful.
- Yet I say that some things do not strengthen the faith of others.

but not everything is edifying: Paul again implied that he agreed with this up to a certain point. The Greek word that the BSB translates as is edifying is literally “builds up.” The same word is used in 8:1d. There, as here, it refers to making people strong spiritually. Here Paul talked about making other people strong.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

but not everything builds others up (NET)

but not all things help others become firm in their faith

1 Corinthians 10:24**Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely**

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol’s temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord’s Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else’s conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don’t worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:23–11:1

Paul discussed whether believers can eat food that pagans offered to idols and later sold in the marketplace. He said that believers must consider not only their own freedom and rights. They must also consider the good of others, and how their actions will help non-believers to be saved.

10:24a**No one should seek his own good,**

- Do not be concerned for your own good
- In summary, believers should not just think of what benefits themselves.

10:24b**but the good of others.**

- but for the good of other people.
- Rather, they should think about what benefits others.

10:24a–b

No one should seek his own good, but the good of others: This is the main point of Paul’s teaching in this part of his letter.

In some languages it may be natural to use a separate subject for 10:24b:

Nobody should seek his own good. Everyone should seek the good of others.

In some languages it may be natural to translate both parts of this verse as second-person commands. For example:

Do not look out only for yourselves. Look out for the good of others also. (NCV)

seek his own good: To seek one’s own good is to act in a way that helps or benefits oneself. The Greek is more literally seek his own. The BSB has twice supplied the word good. It is also possible to supply a word that means “benefit” or “advantage. For example:

None of you should be looking out for your own interests, but for the interests of others. (GNT)

General Comment on 10:24a–b

In some languages it may be natural to state the positive command first. For example:

^{24b}We should think about others ^{24a}and not about ourselves. (CEV)

^{24b}You should each look after the interests of others, ^{24a}not your own. (REB)

1 Corinthians 10:25

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:23–11:1

Paul discussed whether believers can eat food that pagans offered to idols and later sold in the marketplace. He said that believers must consider not only their own freedom and rights. They must also consider the good of others, and how their actions will help non-believers to be saved.

10:25a

Eat anything sold in the meat market

- It is acceptable for you^(plur) to buy and eat any meat which people sell in the meat market.
- When there is meat for sale in the market, you may buy and eat it.

Eat anything sold in the meat market: When pagan people wished to make a sacrifice to their gods, they brought an animal to the priests. The priests sacrificed this animal to honor the gods. Pagan priests often received more meat than they could eat, so they sold some of it to the meat shops in the market. Paul told the believers that they could buy and eat this meat just like any other meat.

Paul gave permission rather than issuing a command. So, it may be natural to translate this as:

You^(plur) may eat whatever is sold in the meat market.

You are free to eat anything sold in the meat market. (GNT)

anything sold: Paul referred to any meat that the meat shops might sell. The word sold is a passive verb.

Here are two ways to translate this passive verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

any meat that is sold (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

any meat that they sell

the meat market: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the meat market can refer to a market where any kind of food is sold. The BSB, along with many other English versions, has supplied the word meat to help make Paul's meaning clear.

10:25b

without raising questions of conscience,

- You^(plur) do not need to ask where it came from, so that your heart doesn't condemn you.
- And it is not necessary to ask yourself whether it is right or wrong for a believer to buy it and eat it.

without raising questions of conscience: Believers do not need to ask about the meat sold in the market. Jewish people were required by their food laws to ask whether the meat they wanted to eat was ritually clean. Paul said that Christians did not need to ask about this. Jewish believers did not need to feel guilty that they might break a food law. Non-Jewish believers did not need to feel guilty about possibly eating meat that had been offered to idols.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

without letting your conscience trouble you (GW)

You don't have to ask whether it was offered to idols or not. You can eat it with a certain heart.

questions: The questions were ones like, "Where has this meat come from?" and "Has this meat been offered to idols?" Believers do not need to ask this kind of question.

conscience: The word conscience refers to the ability to discern what is good and what is evil. It is the conscience that makes a person able to distinguish right from wrong. Refer to this ability in the way that

is natural in your language. See how you translated this in Acts 24:16.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

you don't have to ask yourself whether it is right or wrong

1 Corinthians 10:26

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:23–11:1

Paul discussed whether believers can eat food that pagans offered to idols and later sold in the marketplace. He said that believers must consider not only their own freedom and rights. They must also consider the good of others, and how their actions will help non-believers to be saved.

10:26

for, "The earth is the Lord's, and the fullness thereof."

- For, as it is written, "The earth belongs to the Lord, and everything in it is his."
- Why not? because God's book says this: "The Lord owns the earth and everything which is in/on it."

for, "The earth is the Lord's, and the fullness thereof.": This is a quote from Psalm 24:1. Because God is the source of all food, a person can eat food freely and thank God for it. God did not make any food that is evil for people to eat.

for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for introduces a reason why believers could eat meat

offered for sale in the market. They could do this because everything belongs to God.

The earth is the Lord's: This clause indicates that the whole world belongs to God. It does not belong to the demons.

the fullness thereof: This is a short way of saying "Everything in the world belongs to the Lord." This includes all kinds of foods.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

everything it contains is his (GW)

1 Corinthians 10:27

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

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Paragraph 10:23–11:1

Paul discussed whether believers can eat food that pagans offered to idols and later sold in the marketplace. He said that believers must consider not only their own freedom and rights. They must also consider the good of others, and how their actions will help non-believers to be saved.

10:27a

If an unbeliever invites you to a meal

- If an unbeliever invites you^(plur) to his home for a meal,
- Suppose a nonbeliever asks you^(plur) to come to his house to eat.

If an unbeliever invites you to a meal: Paul spoke of a situation where an unbeliever invited a believer to his house to eat. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit.

Here are some ways to make this explicit:

If an unbeliever invites you^(plur) to eat at his home

If an unbeliever asks you^(plur) to come to his house for a meal

you: In the Greek the pronoun you is singular, meaning one of you, or any of you.

10:27b

and you want to go,

- and you^(plur) want to go/accept,
- If you^(plur) decide to go,

and you want to go: In some languages it may be natural to make explicit where the believer might want to go. For example:

you want to go there

you want to go to his house

10:27c

eat anything set before you

- eat whatever food he serves you^(plur).
- you may eat whatever he gives you.

eat anything set before you: Paul permitted the believer to eat whatever food the host gave him. He did not command that he must eat everything he was given. Refer to your translation of 10:25a.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

you may eat whatever you are given

anything set before you: The verb set is passive.

Here are two ways to translate this passive verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

whatever you are served (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

the food that is in front of you

whatever food they give you

10:27d

without raising questions of conscience.

- You^(plur) do not need to ask where it came from, so that your hearts do not condemn you.
- It is not necessary to ask yourself whether it is right or wrong for a believer to eat it.

without raising questions of conscience: See the notes on 10:25b, where the same words occur.

1 Corinthians 10:28

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:23–11:1

Paul discussed whether believers can eat food that pagans offered to idols and later sold in the marketplace. He said that believers must consider not only their own freedom and rights. They must also consider the good of others, and how their actions will help non-believers to be saved.

10:28a

But if someone tells you,

- However, if/suppose someone should say to you^(plur):

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces an exception to the situation Paul just discussed. Normally a believer could eat in someone's house, but in the case Paul will now describe, he or she should not eat the food served to them.

if someone tells you: We are not told who someone refers to. Maybe Paul thought of a nonbeliever who knew about the Jewish food rules. Or maybe he thought of a believer who was concerned about eating food sacrificed to idols. Either is possible, and you should be general in your translation.

10:28b**“This food was offered to idols,”**

- “This food was sacrificed to an idol,”
- “This is meat that worshipers have dedicated to an idol,”

This food was offered to idols: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as This food was offered to idols is more literally “This is a sacred-sacrifice.” The word “sacred-sacrifice” was one that a pagan could have used. Do not use a phrase that only a Christian will use. The speaker said that the meat served at the meal had been sacrificed to one of the gods that the Gentiles worshiped.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

This was sacrificed to an idol

This food was offered in the temple

General Comment on 10:28b

In some languages it may be natural to translate this quotation using indirect speech. For example:

But if you are told that it has been sacrificed to idols (CEV)

10:28c-29a

^{28c} **then do not eat it,** ^{28d} **for the sake of the one who told you** ^{28e} **and for the sake of conscience—** ^{29a} **the other one’s conscience, I mean, not your own:** This passage is difficult to translate in a language that has a phrase for “conscience,” instead of a single noun. Paul said something unclear in 28c-e. Then in 29a he clarified his meaning. You may have to say it clearly in 28, and then repeat the information in 29.

Here is one way to translate this clause:

Don’t eat it. If you eat it the person who told you will feel bad, because he thinks that anybody who eats that food is sinning. ^{29a} I am not saying that you will feel bad, but that the person who told you will feel bad.

10:28c**then do not eat it,**

- then you^(plur) should not eat it,
- then, in that case, I advise you not to eat that food.

10:28d**for the sake of the one who told you**

- both because of the person who said that
- In that way you^(plur) will be considerate of the person who informed you,

10:28e**and for the sake of conscience—**

- and because in that person’s heart it is a sin.
- and you^(plur) will not make them upset because they think you are doing wrong.

conscience: See how you translated this in 10:25b. In this verse the context is different, and it may be necessary to express this concept differently. Possibly the person who asked the question in this verse thought that Christians follow the same food laws that Jewish people do.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in his heart it is a sin

he is troubled and thinks that you are doing wrong

he will be upset if you eat it

1 Corinthians 10:29**Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely**

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol’s temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord’s Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else’s conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don’t worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:23–11:1

Paul discussed whether believers can eat food that pagans offered to idols and later sold in the marketplace. He said that believers must consider not only their own freedom and rights. They must also consider

the good of others, and how their actions will help non-believers to be saved.

10:29a

the other one's conscience, I mean, not your own.

- I am referring to that person's heart, not your^(plur) heart.
- I do not mean that you should not eat because you think it is wrong, but rather because the other person thinks it is wrong for you to eat it.

the other one's conscience, I mean, not your own:

This clause corrects a possible misunderstanding. Paul realized that he had not spoken clearly, so he explained himself. He did not want a believer to offend anyone's conscience. A believer should be willing to limit his rights and freedom because of the effect this might have on others.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I am not talking about your heart, but I am concerned about the heart of the person who told you

I am not speaking about what you think is wrong.
I am speaking about what the other person thinks is wrong

General Comment on 10:28a-29a

In the BSB this forms one long sentence. In some languages it may be natural to break it into several shorter sentences. For example:

But suppose someone warns you that this meat has been offered to an idol. Don't eat it, out of consideration for the conscience of the one who told you. It might not be a matter of conscience for you, but it is for the other person. (NLT96)

10:29b-10:30

There is an interpretation issue here. It is not clear whether the questions in these verses are Paul's own or those of someone else. The two main options are:

1. These are Paul's own rhetorical questions. He asked his readers to think about whether anyone should condemn him for doing something he was free to do. His questions imply the response, "This is wrong." For example:

For why should my liberty be subject to the judgment of someone else's conscience? If I partake with thankfulness, why should I be denounced because of that for which I give thanks? (NRSV)

(BSB, NRSV, NIV, NJB, KJV, NASB, RSV, NET, GW, NLT)

1. Paul quoted an objection by some of the Corinthians. These objectors wanted to guard their rights without thinking properly about their influence. For example:

"Well, then," someone says, "why should my freedom to act be limited by another person's conscience? If I thank God for my food, why should anyone criticize me about food for which I give thanks?" (GNT) (GNT, REB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The reason is that if this were an objector, Paul would respond to this objection in the following verses. But he did not do so. Also, the conjunction that the BSB translates as "For" normally introduces the reason for something, not an objection.

These questions should be understood as Paul's own. They present a problem he wanted the Corinthians to think about. He pointed out that it was not beneficial to eat meat if it caused someone else to judge and condemn him. These questions also function as an explanation as to why the believer should not eat this food. Thiselton, pages 788-793, discusses the different ways these verses have been understood. He refers to the rhetorical questions as part of "deliberative rhetoric." He says, "The questions answer themselves because...they sum up the thrust of the three chapters [chaps 8-10], namely, that while believers are free, concern for the well-being of the other has priority over everything else." Fee, page 486, footnote 52, also discusses several possible interpretations of these verse parts, while saying that "none of them is fully satisfactory."

10:29b

For why should my freedom be determined by someone else's conscience?

- For why should another person judge my free act to be wrong because they think it is wrong?
- When I am free to eat something, there is no reason/justification for another person to condemn me when I eat it. I should not let that happen.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces an explanation. See interpretation (1) above. It introduces Paul's explanation of why a believer should sometimes refrain from doing something he was free to do. Some English versions such as the NJB do not have a conjunction. Consider how it is natural to introduce this in your language.

why should my freedom be determined by someone else's conscience?: This is the first of two rhetorical questions. Paul used it to encourage people to think about a problem. It is not good that a believer's freedom should be judged (and condemned) by somebody else's conscience. Paul encouraged his readers to consider how to avoid this happening. They could avoid it by refraining from eating meat that people told them was offered to idols.

Here are two ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

why is my right being judged by another's conscience? (NET)

- Use a statement. For example:

it is not right that another person should condemn me for what I am free to do.

When I am free to do something, someone else should not condemn me for doing it.

Translate this statement in the way that is most natural in your language.

my freedom: The phrase my freedom refers to the believer's freedom to eat any of the food that God has created.

Here is a way to translate this using a verb:

I am free to act...

I have the right to eat...

be determined: There are two ways to interpret the Greek verb that the BSB translates as be determined:

1. It means to be judged as wrong, to be condemned and criticized. For example:

being judged by another's conscience (NET) (NET, NIV, NASB, GW, NCV, KJV)

1. It means to be limited or restricted. For example:

be limited by what someone else thinks (NLT) (BSB, NLT, ESV, CEV, GNT, NJB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This fits with the context of the following verse, where the person exercising freedom to eat is said to be "denounced."

The verb "be judged" is passive. The person who is judging is the "another" mentioned in the verse, or the other man's "conscience."

Here are two ways to translate this passive verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

be judged (GW)

- Use an active verb. For example:

someone else condemn me

1 Corinthians 10:30

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:23–11:1

Paul discussed whether believers can eat food that pagans offered to idols and later sold in the marketplace. He said that believers must consider not only their own freedom and rights. They must also consider the good of others, and how their actions will help non-believers to be saved.

10:30a–b

This is a second of two rhetorical questions. Paul used it as a statement. He said that it was not good that a believer allow himself to be denounced for what he ate. After all, he had thanked God for his food.

Here are two ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

If I partake with thankfulness, why am I blamed for the food that I give thanks for? (NET)

- Use a statement. For example:

I should not be denounced for eating food for which I thank God.

Translate this statement in the way that is most natural in your language.

10:30a

If I partake in the meal with thankfulness,

- If I thank God for the meal,
- When I thank God for the food that I eat,

If I partake in the meal with thankfulness: In some languages it may be natural to make the word “eat” explicit. It may also be natural to translate thankfulness as a verb. For example:

If I thank God when I eat the meal

10:30b

why am I denounced because of that for which I give thanks?

- should they condemn me for what I have thanked God for?
- there is no reason/justification for someone to say I have sinned in eating it. I have thanked God for it.

why am I denounced because of that for which I give thanks?: The word denounced means that others said that Paul was doing the wrong thing. This is a passive verb.

Here are two ways to translate this passive verb:

General Comment on 10:30a-b

- Use a passive verb. For example:

why am I criticized...? (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

why should anyone accuse me of doing wrong? (CEV)

There is some implied information in the argument here. Paul said that he should not be judged for doing something he was free to do, something for which

he thanked God. But his implied conclusion was that he should refrain from doing something that might lead to such judgment. He could not control other people judging him. But he could use his freedom to refrain from those actions that will cause them to judge and condemn him. It may be difficult to follow Paul’s argument. It is suggested that you translate the questions in a way that makes it clear that Paul asked the believers to think about the problem. To make the meaning clear, you may need to supply some implied information:

^{29b} I should not act in a way that causes someone else to judge me for doing something I am free to do. ^{30b} I should not eat food that allows people to denounce me ^{30a} for eating something for which I have thanked God.

General Comment on 10:29b-30

In these questions Paul said “I.” He used himself as an example of a believer. This may make your readers think that Paul referred to himself alone. It may be clearer to use an inclusive plural pronoun “we.”

1 Corinthians 10:31

Section 10:1-11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol’s temple. First he warned them (10:1-13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14-22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord’s Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else’s conscience (10:23-30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31-11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don’t worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:23-11:1

Paul discussed whether believers can eat food that pagans offered to idols and later sold in the marketplace. He said that believers must consider not only their own freedom and rights. They must also consider the good of others, and how their actions will help non-believers to be saved.

10:31a**So whether you eat or drink or whatever you do,**

- So now, whether you^(plur) eat something or drink something, or whatever else you^(plur) may do,
- In conclusion, when you eat, and when you drink, and in everything you do,

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So introduces Paul's command. This concludes and summarizes what he said in chapters 8–10.

Here is another way to translate this word:

In conclusion

whether you eat or drink: The words whether you eat...drink refer to eating meals, and deciding what to eat and what not to eat.

or: The three verbs “eat...drink...do...” are connected with a conjunction that the BSB translates as or. In some languages it may be more natural to use a conjunction meaning “and.”

or whatever you do: The phrase whatever you do refers to all the activities of life, and how one lives in this world.

10:31b**do it all to the glory of God.**

- do everything to glorify/honor God.
- always act in such a way that people who see you will praise/honor God.

do it all to the glory of God: This clause indicates that believers should live their whole life with the purpose of honoring God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

do everything to cause people to praise God

always do it so that God is famous/big/lifted up

General Comment on 10:31a-b

This verse gives Paul's general principle for how to live in this world. His main point is in 10:31b. 10:31b is the central and key command for chapters 8–10. In some languages it may be natural to show that this is the most important thought by placing it first in the sentence. For example:

^{31b}Do everything for the glory of God: ^{31a}eating, drinking, and anything else.

^{31b}Act in every way for the glory of God ^{31a}no matter what you^(plur) do, even when you are eating and drinking.

1 Corinthians 10:32**Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely**

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:23–11:1

Paul discussed whether believers can eat food that pagans offered to idols and later sold in the marketplace. He said that believers must consider not only their own freedom and rights. They must also consider the good of others, and how their actions will help non-believers to be saved.

10:32a**Do not become a stumbling block,**

- Do not cause harm to anyone,
- Live in a way that does not make it hard for others to believe/follow God's ways,

Do not become a stumbling block: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Do not become a stumbling block is more literally “be blameless.” The BSB uses a figure of speech to express the meaning. Paul said that the Corinthians should not cause people to sin. They should not discourage anybody from following the way of Christ.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Translate it literally. For example:

be blameless (toward both Jewish people and Greek people)

live in a way that doesn't make people take offense

- Explain the meaning. For example:

Don't cause anybody to sin

Don't be an obstacle that keeps people from believing in Christ

10:32b whether to Jews or Greeks

- whether that person is a Jew or a non-Jew,
- including both Jews and Gentiles,

whether to Jews or Greeks: The word Greeks is used for people who are not Jewish. See also 1:22–24. Here is another way to translate this:

Gentiles (GNT)

10:32c or the church of God—

- or a part/member of God's church/people.
- and believers/Christians too.

or the church of God: The phrase the church of God refers to the people who belong to God. This same phrase appears in 1:2a, and you should translate it here as you did there.

1 Corinthians 10:33

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:23–11:1

Paul discussed whether believers can eat food that pagans offered to idols and later sold in the marketplace. He said that believers must consider not only their own freedom and rights. They must also consider the good of others, and how their actions will help non-believers to be saved.

10:33a as I also try to please everyone in all I do.

- For I myself also try not to displease/offend anyone in any way.
- That is the way I myself live, trying to make everybody satisfied in everything.

as I also try to please everyone in all I do: Paul said that he himself did as he advised his readers to do. In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

Do the same as I do. I try to please everybody in every way.

Just as I do; I try to please everyone in all that I do. (GNT)

I also try to please everyone in all I do: Paul said that he always tried to avoid giving unnecessary offense. He did not want to make it hard for people to come to know the Lord or to follow the Lord.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I always try to be considerate to everyone. (REB)

I also try to make everybody satisfied in everything.

I also try not to offend anyone in any way.

10:33b For I am not seeking my own good,

- I do not think about what benefits/helps me.
- My goal is not my personal advantage/interests
- I do not think like this: "What will be best for me?"

For: The BSB has started a new sentence and supplied the word For. See the General Comment on 10:32–33.

I am not seeking my own good: The clause I am not seeking my own good means that Paul did not act in order to get some benefit or advantage for himself.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I do not seek my own benefit (NET)

without considering my own advantage (JBP)

I don't think about what would be good for me (GW)

10:33c but the good of many,

- Rather, I think about what I can do to benefit/help many people,
- but the advantage/interests of all people,
- Instead, I think like this: "What will be good for as many people as possible?"

but the good of many: This phrase indicates that Paul sought the good or benefit of other people. He tried to act in a way that would help others. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence:

Instead I am seeking the good of many other people.

many: The word many refers to all people. It contrasts with "myself" rather than with "everyone." So, it may be good to translate it as:

all people

everybody

10:33d that they may be saved.

- so that I will be able to help/cause many people to be saved.
- so that they might receive/obtain salvation.
- I do that so that God can rescue them from sin/wrongdoing.

that they may be saved: This was Paul's purpose in seeking the good of others. He wanted others to be saved. Here is another way to translate this:

in the hope that many of them will be saved (CEV)

be saved: This is a passive verb.

Here are two ways to translate this passive verb:

General Comment on 10:32–33

- Use a passive verb. For example:

so that they might be saved (GNT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

so that they may receive salvation

so that God will save them

In the Greek text these two verses are one long sentence. The BSB has two sentences, 10:32a–33a and 10:33b–d. The NLT is a model for how to translate it using several short sentences:

^{32a}Don't give offense ^{32b}to Jews or Gentiles ^{32c}or the church of God. ^{33a}I, too, try to please everyone in everything I do. ^{33b}I don't just do what is best for me; ^{33c}I do what is best for others ^{33d}so that many may be saved. (NLT)

1 Corinthians 11:1

Section 10:1–11:1: Avoid idolatry completely

Paul addressed believers who thought it was acceptable to eat meals in an idol's temple. First he warned them (10:1–13). He used examples from the Old Testament to show them their danger. Then he commanded them (10:14–22). He said that no one can take part in both the Lord's Supper and idol feasts. He said that believers are free to eat meat sold in the market place unless this will hurt someone else's conscience (10:23–30). In summary, he said that believers should control their behavior in two ways. They should praise God in everything they do, and they should not allow their actions to harm another person (10:31–11:1).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Don't worship idols

Do everything for the glory of God

Paragraph 10:23–11:1

Paul discussed whether believers can eat food that pagans offered to idols and later sold in the marketplace. He said that believers must consider not only their own freedom and rights. They must also consider the good of others, and how their actions will help non-believers to be saved.

11:1

Although this verse is the first verse of chapter 11, it is the last sentence in the section starting in 10:23 and the last sentence of paragraph 10:31–11:1. In this verse,

Paul referred back to 10:33. His statement in 10:33 indicates the content of the example that he wants them to follow.

11:1a

You are to imitate me,

- Make me your^(plur) pattern
- Try to live/act as I do

You are to imitate me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as You are to imitate me is more literally “Be imitators of me” (as in the RSV). Paul told his readers to act as he did. They should imitate him in the way he served God and in the way he helped other people, and put the good of others above their own.

Paul did not mean that he wanted the believers to eat, dress, or talk like him. Nor did he mean that he wanted all the believers to become tentmakers like him. Consider the best way to make this distinction and avoid this wrong meaning in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Take me as your pattern. (NJB)

Do as I do

11:1b

just as I imitate Christ.

- as I make Christ my pattern.
- as I try to live/act as Christ did.

just as I imitate Christ: Paul said that he imitated the way Christ lived. He took Christ as the pattern for his life and tried to act as Christ had. He followed Jesus’ example of serving and obeying God and helping other people.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

in the same way that I take Christ as my pattern/
model

as I do what Christ does

In some languages it may not be necessary to repeat all the information in this second half of the sentence. For example, the NJB has used the word “mine” instead of “my pattern”:

[Take me as your pattern] just as I take Christ for mine (NJB)

General Comment on 11:1a-b

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of 11:1a and 11:1b. For example:

^{1b}I follow the example that Christ has set, ^{1a}and in the same way you^(plur) should follow the example that I have set.

In this division Paul instructed the Corinthians about how to behave in their worship services. He wanted them to wear clothing and to act in a way that was appropriate, and that honored God and one another.

1 Corinthians 11:2

Section 11:2–16: Men and women should dress appropriately to worship God

In this section Paul wrote about how men and women should dress during public worship. He wanted the women to cover their heads and the men to remain bare-headed. This was appropriate and proper and the custom of the other churches.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Wear appropriate clothing in public worship

Covering the head in worship

Paragraph 11:2

In this paragraph Paul praised the Corinthians for holding to the traditions that he gave them.

11:2a

Now I commend you for remembering me in everything

- ¶ I commend you^(plur) that you remember everything I said to you
- ¶ You are doing well to remember all that I told you

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now here indicates that Paul was starting to talk about the next topic. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. Introduce this new topic in a way that is natural for your language. Another way to translate this is:

Next,

I commend you: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I praise you (NIV)

I congratulate you (NJB)

You^(plur) have done well

for remembering me in everything: The phrase in everything refers to every aspect of church life. The believers remembered Paul's teaching about their church life.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

you remember me always

you remember everything that I taught you

11:2b

and for maintaining the traditions,

- and that you^(plur) are maintaining/keeping the tradition
- and you are doing well to follow the teachings

and: The conjunction and introduces a second reason Paul praised the Corinthians.

for maintaining the traditions: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as maintaining the traditions can also be translated as "following the teachings." This refers both to believing and to doing the things Paul taught.

the traditions: The Greek word that the BSB translates as traditions often refers to information that a teacher learns from someone and then teaches to others. Here it refers to Christian teachings.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

you obey the things I taught you

11:2c

just as I passed them on to you.

- as I handed it down to you^(plur).
- exactly as I taught them to you.

just as I passed them on to you: Paul said that his readers had not altered his teachings. They followed them in the way that he had taught them.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

exactly as I passed them on to you (NJB)

General Comment on 11:2b-c

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of these phrases. For example:

^{2c}I passed on the teachings to you^(plur), ^{2b}and you have kept them without changing them.

1 Corinthians 11:3

Section 11:2–16: Men and women should dress appropriately to worship God

In this section Paul wrote about how men and women should dress during public worship. He wanted the women to cover their heads and the men to remain bare-headed. This was appropriate and proper and the custom of the other churches.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Wear appropriate clothing in public worship

Covering the head in worship

Paragraph 11:3–6

In this paragraph Paul taught that Christ is our head. Because of this, men should pray with their heads uncovered, and women should pray with their heads covered.

11:3a

But I want you to understand that

- ¶ But I want you^(plur) to know that
- ¶ But you should understand that

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But can be understood in two different ways:

1. It introduces a contrast to Paul's praise in the preceding verse. For example:

But I want you to understand (GNT) (BSB, GNT, RSV, NJB, KJV, ESV, GW, NET, NASB, NCV, NLT, REB)

1. It introduces a transition to a new topic. For example:

Now I want you to realize (NIV) (NIV, CEV)

It is recommended you follow option (1) as do the majority of English versions.

I want you to understand: The phrase I want you to understand introduces something that Paul wanted

his readers to understand. He implied that he thought they did not yet understand it.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I want you to realize (NIV)

I want you to know clearly

11:3b-d

head: The word “head” is used three times in this verse. It is a figure of speech which refers to a person who is prominent in some way. Thiselton says that “head” has “several nuances,” and is “a polymorphous concept” (p. 820). Paul “deliberately introduced a word that was polymorphous...Neither ‘headship,’ nor ‘order,’ nor ‘equality’ alone conveys the complexity of Paul’s theology. Again, multiple meaning holds the key.” (p. 822). Garland, p. 516, writes that the best option is to understand “head” as “that which is prominent, foremost, uppermost pre-eminent. To be ‘head’ of a group of people simply means to occupy the position at the top or front.” There are three ways to interpret the word “head”:

1. Paul referred to someone who is in a position of authority. For the view that Paul was talking about authority, see Grudem, “Does KEFALE Mean ‘Source’ or ‘Authority Over’ in Greek Literature?” *Trinity Journal* 6 (1985): 38–59. This could be translated as:

Christ is the leader of every man

1. Paul referred to someone who is the source of the other person. See the following commentators for the view that Paul was talking about source or origin: Fee, p. 503, Barrett, p. 248. This could be translated as:

Christ is the source of every man

Every man comes from Christ

1. Paul referred to someone who is first in order, responsibility, role, or honor. This is Thiselton’s preferred emphasis; p. 821. See also Witherington, pp. 236–38 for a similarly nuanced position. This could be translated as:

Christ is first before every man

The commentaries do not agree as to which of these concepts was uppermost in Paul’s mind. It is recommended that you use the word “head” in your language. This is especially valuable if “head” can be interpreted as having more than one of the above meanings.

Here are some ways to translate this concept:

Christ is the head of every man

Christ is like the head of every man

If a literal rendering as “head” is not meaningful in your language, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). More commentaries accept this interpretation than the others, and translations in many minority languages around the world have found this acceptable.

In some languages there may be a different figure of speech that can substitute for “head” which maintains some of the meanings that Paul intended.

11:3b

the head of every man is Christ,

- Christ is like the head of every man,
- Christ is the leader of all men
- Christ’s position is above that of all men,

the head of every man is Christ: The word head is used as a figure of speech to refer to someone who is prominent in some way. See the discussion above at 11:3b-d about the meaning of head. There are three ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

Christ is the head of every man

- Use the figure of speech and include the word “like” to make it clear that this is a comparison. For example:

Christ is like the head of every man

- Translate the meaning. For example:

Christ is the leader of every man

Christ is supreme over every man (GNT)

Christ has a position above all men

man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as man (here and in the rest of this section) means “male person.” It does not include women.

Christ himself was a man, so it may be natural to translate this as:

Christ is the head of all other men

**11:3c
and the head of the woman is man,**

- and men are like the head of women,
- and men are the leaders of women
- and men have a position above women

and the head of the woman is man: The word head is used as a figure of speech to refer to someone who is prominent in some way. It has the same meaning as it did in 3b, and you should translate it in the same way. See the discussion at 11:3b-d about the meaning of head.

Here are some ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

men are the head of women

- Use the figure of speech and include the word “like” to make it clear that this is a comparison. For example:

men are like the head of women

- Translate the meaning. For example:

men are the leaders of women

men are in a position above women

woman...man: There are two ways to interpret the words woman and man in this statement:

1. Paul referred to women and men in general. For example:

the head of woman is man (NJB) (BSB, NJB, KJV, NASB, REB, NET, CEV, NCV, NIV)

1. Paul referred to wives and husbands. For example:

the head of a woman is her husband (GNT) (GNT, ESV, RSV, GW, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is followed by most English versions and by most commentaries. The Greek words that the BSB translates as woman and man are in the singular. However, in verses 3–15 they are general statements that apply to all women and all men. Use a form in your language that is understood as a general statement. In Paul’s culture, a woman’s position or status in society was lower than that of a man. You should translate the words woman and man the same way throughout verses 3–15.

Here are some ways to translate these words:

all females...all males

women...men

all women...all men

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the leaders of men are women

men are in a position above women

**11:3d
and the head of Christ is God.**

- and God is like the head of Christ.
- and God is the leader of Christ.
- and God has a position above Christ.

and the head of Christ is God: The word head is used as a figure of speech. It has the same meaning as in the two previous examples. You should translate it in the same way. Paul said that God is in a position of prominence with regard to Christ.

Here are some ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

God is the head of Christ

- Use the figure of speech and include the word “like” to make it clear that this is a comparison. For example:

God is like the head of Christ

- Translate the meaning. For example:

God is the leader of Christ

God occupies a position above Christ

1 Corinthians 11:4

Section 11:2–16: Men and women should dress appropriately to worship God

In this section Paul wrote about how men and women should dress during public worship. He wanted the women to cover their heads and the men to remain bare-headed. This was appropriate and proper and the custom of the other churches.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Wear appropriate clothing in public worship

Covering the head in worship

Paragraph 11:3–6

In this paragraph Paul taught that Christ is our head. Because of this, men should pray with their heads uncovered, and women should pray with their heads covered.

11:4a

Every man who prays or prophesies with his head covered

- A man who prays or prophesies with something on/covering his head
- Men who pray or/and prophesy while wearing a hat/scarf/head-covering

Every man who prays or prophesies: Paul probably referred to a situation in which a man prayed aloud during a worship service.

prophesies: The word prophesies refers to declaring God's word to people. See the Glossary and Prophet in the KBT.

with his head covered: The phrase with his head covered probably refers to pulling a shawl or cloak over one's head. This was what Jewish women did during public worship. Jewish men did not cover their heads with their shawls in worship services.

11:4b

dishonors his head.

- brings disgrace to his head.
- shame/disgrace Christ who is like their head.

dishonors his head: There are two ways to interpret the phrase dishonors his head:

1. It means that a man dishonors or shows disrespect for his metaphorical head, who is Christ. See Ellingworth and Hatton, p.245; and Fee p. 506. Some authors such as Morris p.150, Kistemaker p.369, and Thiselton, p. 827 see this as a double reference to both the man's physical head and to Christ. For example:

disgraces Christ (GNT)

disgraces Christ who is like his head (GNT, GW) Many English versions are ambiguous. It is not possible to determine which interpretation the BSB, NIV, RSV, CEV, NASB, NCV, REB, and KJV follow.

1. It means that a man dishonors his own physical head, and thus brings shame on himself. See Robertson and Plummer; Conzelmann; Hodge.

he dishonors his head

If you used the word head in v. 3 it may work well for you to use it again here. If you choose one interpretation, it is recommended that you choose interpretation (1). This fits the context of 11:2.

1 Corinthians 11:5

Section 11:2–16: Men and women should dress appropriately to worship God

In this section Paul wrote about how men and women should dress during public worship. He wanted the women to cover their heads and the men to remain bare-headed. This was appropriate and proper and the custom of the other churches.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Wear appropriate clothing in public worship

Covering the head in worship

Paragraph 11:3–6

In this paragraph Paul taught that Christ is our head. Because of this, men should pray with their heads uncovered, and women should pray with their heads covered.

11:5a

And every woman who prays or prophesies with her head uncovered

- But a woman who prays or prophesies without something on/covering her head
- But women who pray or/and prophesy bareheaded

And: There are two ways to interpret the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And:

1. It introduces a contrast to the previous verse. For example:

But (ESV) (ESV, NLT, RSV, CEV, NET, NASB, NCV, REB, KJV)

1. It introduces a continuation from the previous verse. For example:

And (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NIV, NJB)

It is recommended you follow option (1) as the majority of English versions do.

every woman who prays or prophesies with her head uncovered: The phrase with her head uncovered indicates that the woman did not wear a shawl over her head and shoulders. It does not refer to a veil over the face.

11:5b dishonors her head,

- brings disgrace to her head.
- shame/disgrace their husbands who are like their heads.

dishonors her head: There are two ways to interpret the phrase dishonors her head:

1. It means that a woman dishonors her metaphorical head, who is her husband. See Ellingworth and Hatton, p.245; Fee p. 508; and Kistemaker p.369. Some ways to translate this are:

disgraces her husband (GNT)

disgraces her husband who is like her head (GNT, GW)

1. It means that a woman dishonors her own physical head, and thus brings shame on herself. See Morris p.150.

she dishonors her head

If you used the word head in v. 3 it may work well for you to use it again here. If you choose one

interpretation, it is recommended that you choose interpretation (1). This fits the context of 11:2.

11:5c for it is just as if her head were shaved.

- It is as bad as if her head/hair were shaved.
- It is as shameful as though they shaved their heads/hair.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces an explanation of what Paul said in 11:5a–b. He explains that the dishonor of a woman praying or prophesying with her head uncovered is like the dishonor of a woman having her head shaved. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. Introduce this explanation in a natural way in your language.

it is just as if her head were shaved: This is a comparison. When a woman worships with her head uncovered it is like having her head shaved.

Here is another way to translate this:

there is no difference between her and a woman whose head has been shaved (GNT)

In New Testament times, people considered it shameful for a woman to shave her head. It may be helpful to make the point of comparison clear:

it is as bad/shameful as though her head were shaved

The verb shaved is a passive verb. In some languages it may be more natural to use an active expression:

it is just as though she/someone shaved her head

1 Corinthians 11:6

Section 11:2–16: Men and women should dress appropriately to worship God

In this section Paul wrote about how men and women should dress during public worship. He wanted the women to cover their heads and the men to remain bare-headed. This was appropriate and proper and the custom of the other churches.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Wear appropriate clothing in public worship

Covering the head in worship

Paragraph 11:3–6

In this paragraph Paul taught that Christ is our head. Because of this, men should pray with their heads uncovered, and women should pray with their heads covered.

11:6a

If a woman does not cover her head,

- If a woman does not wear a head covering,
- Women who do not cover their heads in worship,

If a woman does not cover her head: As in 11:4a, Paul referred to the custom of drawing a shawl or scarf over one's head. The shawl covered the hair and shoulders, but not the face.

11:6b

she should have her hair cut off.

- it is appropriate that she cuts her hair short.
- let them cut off their hair!

she should have her hair cut off: In this context the word should means “it is fitting” or “it is appropriate.” Paul did not command the woman to cut her hair off. He said that he did not approve of a woman worshiping with her head uncovered, and he did not approve of a woman having her hair cut off either. He assumed that his readers would understand that a woman would be ashamed to have her hair cut off. Here is another way to translate this:

she might as well cut her hair (GNT)

cut off: The verb cut off can also be translated as “cut short.”

11:6c

And if it is shameful for a woman to have her hair cut or shaved off,

- But since it is shameful for a woman to cut her hair short or shave her head,
- Because cutting or shaving their hair takes away from women's honor,

And: The conjunction And introduces another link in Paul's argument. Because there is a certain contrast in the argument, the RSV translates it as:

But (RSV)

Consider how it is most natural in your language to connect these points in the argument.

if it is shameful for a woman to have her hair cut or shaved off: Paul implied that this was shameful for a

woman. In some languages it may be more natural to translate the word if as “because.” For example:

because it is a shameful thing

since it is a shameful thing

It is important to translate if as “because” when readers may be in doubt as to whether or not it was a disgrace for a woman to have short hair.

cut or shaved off: To cut one's hair refers to cutting one's hair short. The phrase shaved off refers to removing all the hair so as to appear bald.

11:6d

she should cover her head.

- she ought to cover her head when she worships.
- they should wear something over/on their heads when they worship God.

she should cover her head: Paul said that this was the right thing to do. In New Testament times, married women customarily covered their heads in public. Paul wanted Christian women to cover their heads when they prayed or prophesied in public worship. This was a sign that they were modest and respectable people.

1 Corinthians 11:7**Section 11:2–16: Men and women should dress appropriately to worship God**

In this section Paul wrote about how men and women should dress during public worship. He wanted the women to cover their heads and the men to remain bare-headed. This was appropriate and proper and the custom of the other churches.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Wear appropriate clothing in public worship

Covering the head in worship

Paragraph 11:7–12

Paul taught that men are the glory of God, and women are the glory of men. But men and women are dependent on each other.

11:7a

A man ought not to cover his head,

- ¶ A man should not cover his head
- ¶ It is not appropriate for men to cover their heads when they pray or prophesy

A man ought not to cover his head: Paul continued the argument that he began in 11:4. He again referred to praying or prophesying. It may be helpful to make that explicit so that the meaning is clear.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

A man ought not to cover his head when he prays or prophesies

A man should not wear anything on his head when worshipping (NLT)

11:7b-c

he is the...glory of God; but the woman is the glory of man: The word glory occurs twice in this verse with the same meaning. The commentaries suggest two different aspects for the meaning of one who is the glory of another:

- One who reflects or displays the nature of anotherSee Conzelmann, p. 187; Garland p. 523.
- One who brings praise and honor to the otherSee Fee p. 514; Thiselton p. 835; Barrett p. 252.

Try to translate the word glory in the same way both times. See the discussion and translation examples in the notes below.

11:7b

since he is the image and glory of God;

- because he is made in the image of God and is/reflects the glory of God.
- because God created them to be like God and display his greatness.

he is the image...of God: This is the phrase used in Genesis 1:26–27, where both man and woman are said to be in the image of God. The image of God consists of qualities such as: the ability to reason, love, appreciate and create beauty, and to choose what is good. However, it is best not to make this explicit in the translation.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

men were created to be like God (CEV)

God created men to be like him

man is a picture of God

he is the...glory of God: There are at least two ways to interpret the clause he is the...glory of God.

1. Men reflect or display the nature and greatness of God. When we look at men, we see God's glory. For example:

since he...reflects God's glory (NJB) (NJB, GNT, NRSV, REB)Several English versions retain the expression "he (man) is the...glory of God" so that the meaning they follow is not clear (BSB, NIV, RSV, GW, NET, NASB, NCV, NLT).

1. Men bring glory to God; God receives honor through men. For example:

[men were created...] to bring honor to God (CEV)

It is probable that Paul had both of these meanings in mind. They are not totally different or separate. Men are able to bring God glory and honor because they are made in the image of God and reflect God's nature. You should try to translate this in a way that does not exclude either aspect of the meaning.

If you must choose between the interpretations, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). More English versions follow it and more commentators agree with it.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

men show God's power/greatness

in man the glory of God is seen

men make the name of God be big

because of men, people praise God

General Comment on 11:7a-b

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of 11:7a and 11:7b. For example:

^{7b}Because he is the image of God and brings glory to God, ^{7a}the man should not cover his head when he prays or prophesies.

11:7c

but the woman is the glory of man.

- But a woman is/reflects the glory of man.
- But women display the greatness of men.

but the woman is the glory of man: The meaning of the word glory has the same options here as in 11:7b:

1. The woman reflects or displays the nature and greatness of man. God created woman from man, so she reflects the glory of man. For example:

woman reflects the glory of man (GNT) (GNT, NJB, NRSV, REB) Many English versions translate the woman is the glory of man literally so that the meaning they follow is not clear (BSB, NIV, RSV, GW, NET, NASB, NCV, NLT, ESV).

1. Man receives honor and glory through woman. For example:

Women were created to bring honor to men (CEV)

If possible, you should translate the word glory in such a way that both meanings are included, or at least suggested. Try to translate it in the same way that you did in 11:7b.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

women show man's power/greatness

in woman the glory of man is seen

women make the name of men be big

because of women, people praise men

1 Corinthians 11:8

Section 11:2–16: Men and women should dress appropriately to worship God

In this section Paul wrote about how men and women should dress during public worship. He wanted the women to cover their heads and the men to remain bare-headed. This was appropriate and proper and the custom of the other churches.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Wear appropriate clothing in public worship

Covering the head in worship

Paragraph 11:7–12

Paul taught that men are the glory of God, and women are the glory of men. But men and women are dependent on each other.

11:8

For man did not come from woman, but woman from man.

- For the first man did not come from a woman, but the first woman came from a man.
- When God created human beings, he created the woman from a man. He didn't create the man from a woman.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as **For** introduces a further explanation of why woman is "the glory of man."

man did not come from woman, but woman from

man: This is a reference to the story of Adam and Eve in Genesis 2:21–23. God made Adam from the dust, but he made Eve out of a rib that he took from Adam.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

God did not create man from a woman's body, but he created woman from a man's body

when God created human beings, the first man didn't come from the woman, but the first woman came from the man

1 Corinthians 11:9

Section 11:2–16: Men and women should dress appropriately to worship God

In this section Paul wrote about how men and women should dress during public worship. He wanted the women to cover their heads and the men to remain bare-headed. This was appropriate and proper and the custom of the other churches.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Wear appropriate clothing in public worship

Covering the head in worship

Paragraph 11:7–12

Paul taught that men are the glory of God, and women are the glory of men. But men and women are dependent on each other.

11:9

Neither was man created for woman, but woman for man.

- And the first man was not created for the sake of woman. Instead, the first woman was created for the sake of man.

- And also God created the first woman for the sake of the first man. He did not create man for the sake of woman.

Neither was man created for woman, but woman for man: This phrase continues Paul's explanation of how a woman is "the glory of man." God made Eve, the woman, for the sake of Adam, the man, so that the man would not be alone.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

God did not create the man to be the woman's companion, but he created the woman to be the man's companion

it was not the man who was made to help woman, but the woman who was made to help man

Neither: The Greek words that the BSB translates as Neither show that this is an additional point in Paul's argument.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

and also...not

1 Corinthians 11:10

Section 11:2–16: Men and women should dress appropriately to worship God

In this section Paul wrote about how men and women should dress during public worship. He wanted the women to cover their heads and the men to remain bare-headed. This was appropriate and proper and the custom of the other churches.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Wear appropriate clothing in public worship

Covering the head in worship

Paragraph 11:7–12

Paul taught that men are the glory of God, and women are the glory of men. But men and women are dependent on each other.

11:10a

For this reason a woman ought to have a sign of authority on her head,

- For this reason, a woman should wear a sign/symbol of authority on her head,

- Because women display the greatness of men, women should wear a head covering as a sign that they have the authority to pray,

For this reason: The phrase For this reason looks back to 11:7c and means "because the woman is the glory of man."

a woman ought to have a sign of authority on her head: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a sign of authority is literally authority. The BSB has added the phrase a sign. Most English versions understand this to be the head covering, which is a sign or symbol of authority. The NLT makes this explicit:

So a woman should wear a covering on her head as a sign of authority. (NLT)

There are two ways to interpret whose authority this is:

1. It is a sign of the woman's own authority. See Ellingworth and Hatton, p. 248; Barrett, p. 255; Robertson and Plummer, p. 232; Fee, p. 520; Thiselton, p. 839. The head covering was a sign that the woman had authority to pray and prophesy in church. For example:

as a sign of her authority (CEV) (CEV, REB)

1. It is a sign of the authority of someone else over the woman. Charles Hodge, p. 211 (first pub 1857); Lenski. The head covering was a sign that the woman was submissive and subordinate to the authority of another. For example:

to show she is under someone's authority (GW) (GW, GNT, NJB) The following versions do not say whose authority Paul referred to: BSB, NIV, ESV, NCV, NLT, NET, KJV, NASB, and RSV. The RSV appears to understand the word "authority" as a figure of speech referring to a veil. It is also possible that the RSV is following a few Greek texts that say "veil." However, the reading "authority" has an A rating in the 4th edition of the UBS Greek New Testament, indicating that the text is considered certain.

The idea that woman has her own authority connects well with 11:11a. The idea that man has authority over her connects well with 11:8–9.

It is recommended that, if possible, you translate this literally and leave the interpretation open. If you must be specific, it is recommended that you follow

interpretation (1). Recent commentators favor this interpretation because in other Greek literature the phrase “have authority” refers to exercising authority. It is never said that a person “has authority” when someone else has authority over him or her.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the woman ought to have a covering on her head,
to show that she has the authority to pray and
prophecy

11:10b because of the angels.

- out of regard for the angels.
- because the angels are watching.

because of the angels: Commentators are not sure why Paul mentioned the angels. Apparently, he believed that angels were present during church worship services. He believed that the angels were concerned about good order and behavior among people who worship God. Because of this, Christian women should dress and act appropriately during times of worship.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

out of regard for the angels

because the angels are watching

because of the angels who see

General Comment on 11:10a-b

In the Greek text the phrase “because of the angels” occurs at the end of 11:10, as in the BSB. However, it may be more natural in your language to mention first both reasons why a woman should have a sign of authority on her head. For example:

For this reason, and because of the angels, the woman ought to have a sign of authority on her head. (NIV)

1 Corinthians 11:11

Section 11:2–16: Men and women should dress appropriately to worship God

In this section Paul wrote about how men and women should dress during public worship. He wanted the women to cover their heads and the men to remain bare-headed. This was appropriate and proper and the custom of the other churches.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Wear appropriate clothing in public worship

Covering the head in worship

Paragraph 11:7–12

Paul taught that men are the glory of God, and women are the glory of men. But men and women are dependent on each other.

11:11a

In the Lord, however, woman is not independent of man,

- However, in the Lord, women do not exist without men,
- Among the Lord’s people, however, women need men,

In the Lord: The phrase In the Lord refers to the people who believe in the Lord. What follows in 11:11a-b is what the Lord has planned for his new creation, the church.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in relationships among the Lord’s people (NLT)

in the Lord’s fellowship (REB)

as believers in the Lord (GW)

however: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as however introduces something that contrasts with what Paul said in 11:8–9.

woman is not independent of man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as woman is not independent of man is more literally “woman is not without man.” Women do not live in isolation, and they should not act in isolation, as if they were the only ones who matter. As Christians, neither men nor women should dress and act proudly and independently. They should dress and act in a way that shows concern for each other.

In some languages it may be more natural to use plural forms, as the NCV has done:

women are not independent of men (NCV)

11:11b

nor is man independent of woman.

- nor do men exist without women.
- and men need women.

nor is man independent of woman: Translate this in a way that is parallel to the wording of 11:11a.

General Comment on 11:11a-b

In some languages it may be more natural to combine 11a and 11b. For example:

woman is as essential to man as man to woman
(REB)

men and women need each other (CEV)

1 Corinthians 11:12

Section 11:2–16: Men and women should dress appropriately to worship God

In this section Paul wrote about how men and women should dress during public worship. He wanted the women to cover their heads and the men to remain bare-headed. This was appropriate and proper and the custom of the other churches.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Wear appropriate clothing in public worship

Covering the head in worship

Paragraph 11:7–12

Paul taught that men are the glory of God, and women are the glory of men. But men and women are dependent on each other.

11:12a

For just as woman came from man, so also man is born of woman.

- For just as the first woman came from a man, so now every man is born from a woman.
- We know this because woman was created out of the body of a man, and every man is born out of a woman's body.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* shows that v.12 is the grounds for v.11. We know that men and women are not independent because they come from each other.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

we know this because

just as woman came from man: God created the first woman, Eve, from Adam's rib. See Genesis 2:21. Some English versions make this more explicit. For example:

It is true that the first woman came from a man
(CEV)

so also man is born of woman: In this phrase Paul stopped talking about the first man and the first woman and started talking about all of humankind. In some languages it may be necessary to use plural nouns. For example:

so also men are born of women

Paul referred to all men except Adam. In some languages it may be natural to supply a word meaning "other." For example:

all other men are born of women

In some languages it may be more natural to use an active verb:

women give birth to men

11:12b

But everything comes from God.

- But all things come from God.
- But God is the source/origin of all things.

But: There are two ways to interpret the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *But*:

1. It introduces a contrast. Men and women come from each other, but they both come from God. For example:

But all things come from God (NET) (BSB, NET, NCV, CEV, GW, NRSV, NIV)

1. It adds to what comes before it. It is true that men and women come from each other, and it is also true that they both come from God. For example:

and everything comes from God (NJB) (NJB, RSV, GNT, NASB, NLT, REB, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Although men and women are both important, God is more important.

everything comes from God: The phrase everything comes from God means that everything and everyone, including both men and women, have their origin in God. It is he who created both man and woman.

Here is another way to translate this:

God is the one who created everything. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 11:13

Section 11:2–16: Men and women should dress appropriately to worship God

In this section Paul wrote about how men and women should dress during public worship. He wanted the women to cover their heads and the men to remain bare-headed. This was appropriate and proper and the custom of the other churches.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Wear appropriate clothing in public worship

Covering the head in worship

Paragraph 11:13–16

In this paragraph Paul shows from nature that men should wear short hair and women should wear long hair.

11:13a

Judge for yourselves:

- ¶ Decide this yourselves:
- ¶ Think about this:

Judge for yourselves: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Judge means to decide a question or solve a problem.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Decide for yourselves

Consider among yourselves

Think about this

11:13b

Is it proper for a woman to pray to God with her head uncovered?

- Is it appropriate for a woman to pray to God bare-headed?
- Is it right for women to pray to God without a covering on their heads? Of course it isn't.

Is it proper for a woman to pray to God with her head uncovered?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as an emphatic statement. He thought the Corinthians would already know this to be true. He hoped that people would respond “No.”

Here are some ways to translate this emphatic statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

If a woman prays to God with her head uncovered is that proper?

It is not proper for a woman to pray to God with her head uncovered, is it?

- Use a rhetorical question with its own answer. For example:

Is it proper for a woman to pray to God with her head uncovered? Of course it isn't.

- Use a statement. For example:

It is not proper for a woman to pray to God with her head uncovered.

Use a form that is natural to emphasize something that the writer considers to be true.

Is it proper...?: When Paul asked the question Is it proper...? he asked whether this agreed with good order and social norms.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

Is it right/correct...?

Is it good...?

Is it appropriate...?

General Comment on 11:13a-b

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an indirect question, as the CEV does:

Ask yourselves if it is proper for a woman to pray without something on her head. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 11:14

Section 11:2–16: Men and women should dress appropriately to worship God

In this section Paul wrote about how men and women should dress during public worship. He wanted the women to cover their heads and the men to remain bare-headed. This was appropriate and proper and the custom of the other churches.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Wear appropriate clothing in public worship

Covering the head in worship

Paragraph 11:13–16

In this paragraph Paul shows from nature that men should wear short hair and women should wear long hair.

11:14–15a

This is a long rhetorical question with two parts. Paul used it as a statement to assert two things.

Here are some ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question or questions. For example:

Does not nature itself teach you that if a man wears long hair, it is degrading to him, but if a woman has long hair, it is her glory? (NRSV)

Does not nature itself teach you that if a man has long hair, it is a disgrace to him? And does not nature itself teach you that if a woman has long hair, it is her glory?

- Use a statement or statements. For example:

Nature teaches you^(plur) that long hair is shameful for a man, but long hair is a woman's glory.

Nature teaches you that long hair is shameful for a man. And nature teaches you that long hair is a woman's glory.

Translate these statements in the way that is most natural in your language.

11:14a

Doesn't nature itself teach you

- Surely the very nature of things shows you^(plur)
- You^(plur) can see

Doesn't nature itself teach you: By nature, Paul referred to what he observed to be the natural order of the world and society. Although in some cultures women do not wear their hair longer than men, for the people of Paul's time this was normal and appropriate.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

you^(plur) can see that

we^(incl) know that

does not the very nature of things make clear to you that

11:14b

that if a man has long hair, it is a disgrace to him,

- that if a man has long hair it is shameful/dishonorable,
- that if men have long hair it brings them shame,

that if a man has long hair, it is a disgrace to him:

Paul viewed long hair on a man as a disgrace.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it is degrading to him (RSV)

it causes him to lose honor

he should be ashamed

1 Corinthians 11:15

Section 11:2–16: Men and women should dress appropriately to worship God

In this section Paul wrote about how men and women should dress during public worship. He wanted the women to cover their heads and the men to remain bare-headed. This was appropriate and proper and the custom of the other churches.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Wear appropriate clothing in public worship

Covering the head in worship

Paragraph 11:13–16

In this paragraph Paul shows from nature that men should wear short hair and women should wear long hair.

11:15a**but that if a woman has long hair, it is her glory?**

- but if a woman has long hair, it brings her honor.
- and if women have long hair, people think that it is beautiful.

but that if a woman has long hair, it is her glory?:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as glory is the same word as in 11:7. It refers to something that brings honor to a person. A woman's long hair brings her honor and dignity. She can take pride in it because everyone considers it beautiful. See glory, sense A3c in KBT.

In many languages the key term for glory applies only to God. In this case you may need to:

- Focus on the element of honor or pride. For example:

it is her pride (RSV)

it brings honor to her

people praise her for it

- Focus on the element of beauty. For example:

it is a thing of beauty (GNT)

she makes herself beautiful

people see that it is beautiful

11:15b**For long hair is given to her as a covering.**

- For God has given a woman long hair to cover her head.
- For women have long hair to cover their heads.

For: The conjunction For introduces Paul's reason for what he said in 11:15a. Some English versions, such as the GNT, do not explicitly translate this word.

long hair is given to her as a covering: The clause long hair is given to her as a covering is passive. In some languages it may be more natural to use an active verb and supply a subject:

For God gave her long hair as a covering.

as a covering: The word covering refers to a shawl or scarf worn by both men and women. Paul said that a woman's long hair served the same purpose as a

shawl. He did not imply that she did not need a head covering because she had long hair.

1 Corinthians 11:16**Section 11:2–16: Men and women should dress appropriately to worship God**

In this section Paul wrote about how men and women should dress during public worship. He wanted the women to cover their heads and the men to remain bare-headed. This was appropriate and proper and the custom of the other churches.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Wear appropriate clothing in public worship

Covering the head in worship

Paragraph 11:13–16

In this paragraph Paul shows from nature that men should wear short hair and women should wear long hair.

11:16a-b

If anyone is inclined to dispute this, we have no other practice: The two parts of this verse are connected by some implied information.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

If anyone is inclined to dispute this, then I tell/answer them that we have no other practice

If anyone is inclined to dispute this, then they should know that we have no other practice

11:16a**If anyone is inclined to dispute this,**

- If anyone wants to argue about this,
- If people want to disagree about this,

If anyone is inclined to dispute this: The phrase is inclined to dispute means "wants to argue or disagree." Paul suggested that some people might disagree with him about whether women should cover their heads for worship.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

If anyone disagrees with us about whether women should cover their heads for worship

11:16b

we have no other practice, nor do the churches of God.

- they should know that we^(excl) don't give any other instructions, and nor do the churches of God.
- I respond to them that this is our^(excl) custom, and that of the churches of God.

we have no other practice: The pronoun we refers to Paul and the other teachers associated with him. It does not include the Corinthian believers. Paul said that it was not their practice to let women pray and prophesy with uncovered heads.

practice: The Greek word that the BSB translates as practice is more literally a custom.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

there is no other custom among us^(excl)

we^(excl) don't give any other instructions

nor do the churches of God: It was normal among the Christian churches for women to cover their heads in public worship. If a literal translation suggests that the Corinthian church was not a church of God, then you may need to say:

nor do the other churches of God

the churches of God: The phrase the churches of God means “churches that worship God.” The word churches refers to the people who form the churches.

1 Corinthians 11:17**Section 11:17–34: Eat the Lord's Supper in the proper way**

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord's Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord's Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord's Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26–28, Mark 14:22–24 and Luke 22:17–20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord's Supper

Instructions about the Lord's Supper

The Lord's Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:17–22

In this paragraph Paul scolded the Corinthians for divisions in the church, and for their greed while eating the Lord's Supper.

11:17a

In the following instructions I have no praise to offer,

- ¶ In giving these next instructions, I do not praise you^(plur),
- ¶ Now, I cannot commend you in what I am about to tell you,

The Greek text of 11:17 begins with a conjunction that the BSB does not translate. There are two ways to interpret the meaning of this conjunction:

1. It introduces a new topic within the same category of instructions. For example:

Now (NRSV) (NRSV, NET, KJV, NJB, NCV)

1. It introduces a contrast. In 11:2 Paul praised the Corinthians, but in this matter he did not praise them. For example:

But (RSV) (RSV, NASB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul used this conjunction to introduce a new subject he wished to discuss. You should introduce this new subject in a way that is natural in your language. 11:17 The BSB, NIV, CEV, REB, and GW do not translate this conjunction. The NLT translates it in both ways: “But now.”

In the following instructions: The Greek word that the BSB translates as In the following instructions is a participle that means “instructing.” Most English versions understand it to refer to what Paul said next.

Here are some other ways to translate this participle:

In the teaching that I am about to give you

There is another thing I want to say to you

I have no praise to offer: This phrase uses the same Greek word as in 11:2a. See the note there.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

it is not possible for me to praise you^(plur)

what you do is not right

11:17b

because your gatherings do more harm than good.

- for your^(plur) meetings harm more than they do good.
- for you receive more harm/damage than help/benefit from your gatherings.
- When you meet together, it harms you rather than doing you good.

because: The conjunction because introduces Paul's reason for not praising the Corinthians.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

for (NIV)

your gatherings: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as your gatherings is more literally "you come together."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

when you^(plur) meet together

when you gather to worship

do more harm than good: The phrase do more harm than good means that the meetings were harmful. Paul did not say to whom they were harmful. He probably implied that they were harmful to the believers themselves and to any others who might see what happened. If it is necessary to make this information explicit, you could say:

do more harm than good to you

In some languages it may not be natural to translate this as a comparison. Instead, you may need to say something like:

your meetings harm you instead of helping you

your meetings do not bring goodness but rather bring evil

your meetings do not strengthen your faith but they make it weaker

1 Corinthians 11:18

Section 11:17–34: Eat the Lord's Supper in the proper way

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord's Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord's Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord's Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26–28, Mark 14:22–24 and Luke 22:17–20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord's Supper

Instructions about the Lord's Supper

The Lord's Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:17–22

In this paragraph Paul scolded the Corinthians for divisions in the church, and for their greed while eating the Lord's Supper.

11:18a

First of all, I hear that when you come together as a church,

- To start with, people tell me that when you^(plur) meet as a church,
- First, people say that when you meet to worship God,

The Greek text of 11:18 begins with a conjunction that the BSB does not translate. Paul used this conjunction to introduce an explanation of why the meetings did more harm than good. You should introduce this explanation in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some ways to translate this Greek conjunction:

For

Because

First of all: The phrase First of all is often used to introduce the first item in a list. However, Paul did not continue this list with “Second,” but instead spoke about a different issue. Because of this, some versions omit this phrase.

I hear that: Paul had not seen this behavior himself. Others told him about it.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

People have told me that

when you come together as a church: The phrase when you come together as a church refers to the times when the believers gathered for worship services. They probably gathered in homes rather than in a church building. There were several such gatherings in the city of Corinth. There may have been gatherings in the homes of Titius Justus (Acts 18:7), Chloe (1 Corinthians 1:11), Gaius (Romans 16:23), and Crispus (1 Corinthians 1:14) among others. See Kistemaker, p. 386.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

when you meet to worship God

in your meetings

11:18b

there are divisions among you,

- you^(plur) separate into different groups/factions,
- you argue with each other,

there are divisions among you: The phrase there are divisions among you means that among the people in the church there were groups or factions that disagreed with each other. It does not mean that the groups met in separate houses.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you^(plur) break into different groups/factions/sides

you argue with each other

you are not in harmony

11:18c

and in part I believe it.

- and I believe this to be at least partly true.

- and I tend to believe what they are saying.

and in part I believe it: Paul had heard this news from others. He had not observed this behavior himself. So, he gave a cautious reply. He said that he expected that there were some divisions, but he did not accuse everyone of behaving badly.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I suppose/expect there is some truth to this

I tend to believe what they are saying

1 Corinthians 11:19

Section 11:17–34: Eat the Lord’s Supper in the proper way

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord’s Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord’s Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord’s Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26–28, Mark 14:22–24 and Luke 22:17–20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord’s Supper

Instructions about the Lord’s Supper

The Lord’s Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:17–22

In this paragraph Paul scolded the Corinthians for divisions in the church, and for their greed while eating the Lord’s Supper.

11:19

And indeed, there must be differences among you to show which of you are approved: There are two ways to interpret this verse:

1. Paul acknowledged that divisions were necessary. For example:

It is no bad thing, either, that there should be differing groups among you so that those who are to be trusted among you can be clearly recognised. (NJB) (NJB, NASB, RSV)

1. Paul was ironic and did not mean that divisions are necessary. He used an ironic statement to say that divisions are bad. For example:

But, of course, there must be divisions among you so that those of you who are right will be recognized! (NLT)

Do you really think you need to take sides? You probably think God favors one side over the other! (NIRV) Most English versions are ambiguous about the meaning, including BSB, NIV, NET, GNT, CEV, NCV and REB.

It is wrong that you have these divisions. (NLT, NIRV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). A majority of commentaries support this interpretation. If you choose interpretation (2), do some study of how irony and sarcasm are expressed in your language.

11:19a

And indeed, there must be differences among you

- For it is necessary for you^(plur) to be divided
- For you have to separate into different groups

And indeed: The two Greek conjunctions that the BSB translates as And indeed can also be translated as “For...also,” as in the NASB. Paul used these conjunctions to introduce a reason why he was willing to believe what he had heard about divisions. He understood that God allowed these differences for a purpose, which he stated in 11:19b. Some English versions do not translate these conjunctions. Other ways to introduce this reason include:

for (ESV)

But, of course, (NLT)

there must be differences among you: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as there must be is more literally “it is necessary for there to be” or “there need to be.” God knew it was necessary for divisions to occur, and he permitted them for a purpose.

differences: The Greek word that the BSB translates as differences is not the same as the word “divisions” in 11:18b. However, in this context it refers to the same thing. It is OK if you use the same word in your translation.

11:19b

to show which of you are approved.

- to make clear who among you^(plur) God approves of.
- so that it will be evident which of you are genuine believers.

to show which of you are approved: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as which of you are approved is more literally “the tested ones” or “the approved ones.” It refers to people who had passed a test that showed them to be genuine believers. The conflicts and divisions in the church showed who these genuine believers were.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

to show which ones of you are the genuine believers

so that people will know the ones who are right from the ones who are wrong

1 Corinthians 11:20

Section 11:17–34: Eat the Lord’s Supper in the proper way

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord’s Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord’s Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord’s Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26–28, Mark 14:22–24 and Luke 22:17–20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord’s Supper

Instructions about the Lord’s Supper

The Lord’s Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:17–22

In this paragraph Paul scolded the Corinthians for divisions in the church, and for their greed while eating the Lord's Supper.

11:20

Now then, when you come together, it is not the Lord's Supper you eat.

- When you^(plur) meet together, what you eat is not the Lord's Supper,
- When you eat the meal in honor of the Lord together, your behavior is not fitting for people who eat this meal,
- When you eat together to remember the death of the Lord, you are not thinking about him,

Now then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now then introduces a conclusion to Paul's argument. There were divisions among the people, and so the meal they ate could not properly be called the Lord's Supper. Many English versions do not translate this conjunction. Introduce this verse in a natural way in your language.

Here are some ways to translate the Greek conjunction:

So then (NIV11)

Now (NET)

when you come together: The phrase when you come together refers to times when the believers met together to worship as a church. It appears that at those times they celebrated the Lord's Supper and also ate a meal together.

it is not the Lord's Supper you eat: The people who gathered thought they were eating the Lord's Supper. However, the way they behaved made this impossible. The way they were eating was different from what the Lord had planned, and the meal could not be considered to be the Lord's Supper.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

your behavior is not fitting for people who eat the Lord's Supper

you are not really thinking about the Lord

it is as if you are not remembering the Lord at all

the Lord's Supper: The phrase the Lord's Supper refers to Holy Communion or the Eucharist. The word Lord's refers to Jesus Christ.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the meal of the Lord Jesus

the meal that is in honor of the Lord Jesus

when you eat together to remember the death of the Lord Jesus

1 Corinthians 11:21**Section 11:17–34: Eat the Lord's Supper in the proper way**

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord's Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord's Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord's Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26–28, Mark 14:22–24 and Luke 22:17–20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord's Supper

Instructions about the Lord's Supper

The Lord's Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:17–22

In this paragraph Paul scolded the Corinthians for divisions in the church, and for their greed while eating the Lord's Supper.

11:21a

For as you eat, each of you goes ahead without sharing his meal.

- for each of you^(plur) starts eating his own food.
- for as you eat, everybody eats their own food first.

For: The conjunction For introduces an explanation of why this was not really the Lord's Supper.

as you eat: The phrase as you eat indicates the occasion Paul talked about.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

when the time comes to eat (NRSV)

each of you goes ahead without sharing his meal:

The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as without sharing his meal is more literally “with his own meal.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

when the time comes to eat, you each eat your own meal

as you eat, everybody eats their own food first

11:21b

While one remains hungry, another gets drunk.

- While one person does not get enough to eat, another person drinks too much wine.
- Some people do not have enough food or drink, but others have so much that they get drunk.

The Greek text of 11:21b begins with a conjunction that most English versions do not translate. In Greek, verse 21 forms a single sentence. You should connect these two verse parts in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some ways to translate this Greek conjunction:

and (RSV)

as a result (NIV11, NLT)

so that (GNT)

While one remains hungry, another gets drunk: In the Greek text the two phrases are in contrast:

On the one hand, one person remains hungry, while on the other hand, someone else gets drunk.

You should express this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Several English versions use “and,” leaving the contrast implied. For example:

One is hungry and another becomes drunk. (NET)

In some languages it may be more natural to use the plural, as the NCV has done:

Some people do not get enough to eat, while others have too much to drink. (NCV)

Being hungry and getting drunk are not actually opposites. But one represents not getting enough, and the other represents having too much. In some languages it may be natural to supply some information and reorder the sentence to make it clear that the two phrases are opposites:

While some people do not have enough to eat and drink, others have too much.

one remains hungry: The phrase one remains hungry means “one person does not get enough to eat.” This does not refer to only one person, but to an unknown number of people. In some languages it may be clearer to say:

some people remain hungry

another gets drunk: The phrase another gets drunk means that some people had too much wine to drink. In some languages it may be clearer to use the plural:

some others get drunk

some have too much to drink

1 Corinthians 11:22

Section 11:17–34: Eat the Lord’s Supper in the proper way

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord’s Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord’s Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord’s Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26–28, Mark 14:22–24 and Luke 22:17–20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord's Supper

Instructions about the Lord's Supper

The Lord's Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:17-22

In this paragraph Paul scolded the Corinthians for divisions in the church, and for their greed while eating the Lord's Supper.

11:22a

Don't you have your own homes in which to eat and drink?

- What? Don't you have your own homes in which to eat food?
- Surely you^(plur) have homes in which to eat and drink.

Don't you have your own homes in which to eat and drink?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul knew that the believers had their own homes. He made an emphatic statement to show that he was unhappy and indignant.

Here are some ways to translate this emphatic statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

What! Do you not have houses to eat and drink in? (RSV)

- Use an exclamation. For example:

You can eat and drink in your own homes! (NCV)

You should eat and drink in your own homes

Translate this with an expression in your language to show that Paul is unhappy and indignant.

11:22b-c

This is a long rhetorical question with two parts. In some languages it may be more natural to translate it as two questions:

Do you^(plur) despise the church of God? Do you want to humiliate those who have nothing?

Some English versions make clear the close connection between the two parts by translating them as one question. For example:

Or have you such disregard for God's assembly that you can put to shame those who have nothing? (NJB)

Or are you trying to show contempt for the church of God by shaming those who have nothing? (NET)

11:22b

Or do you despise the church of God

- Why do you^(plur) scorn God's church
- You behave as though you despise God's people

Or: The conjunction Or introduces a second accusation phrased as a rhetorical question. It does not introduce an alternative problem. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this word as "and" or to leave it implicit.

do you despise the church of God...?: The phrase despise the church of God means to look down on the church and consider it to be of little importance. Some people thought that eating and drinking for their own pleasure was more important than celebrating the Lord's Supper with other believers.

The question do you despise the church of God? is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a rebuke. He rebuked the Corinthians for their attitude toward the church.

Here are some ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you hate God's church? (CEV)

Why do you despise God's church?

- Use a statement. For example:

You seem to think God's church is not important. (NCV)

You disrespect/insult your fellow believers.

Translate this in the way that is most natural for rebuking someone.

the church of God: The phrase the church of God means "the church that belongs to God." It refers to the people of God who gather together to worship, not to a building.

11:22c

and humiliate those who have nothing?

- and put poor people to shame?
- and you embarrass those who don't have enough to eat!

and humiliate those who have nothing?: The phrase humiliate those who have nothing means to cause poor people to be ashamed or embarrassed. This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a rebuke.

Here are some ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you...embarrass people who do not have anything to eat? (GW)

- Use a statement. For example:

you make those who are poor be ashamed

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language for rebuking someone.

11:22d

What can I say to you?

- What can I say to you^(plur) about this?
- I am at a loss for words to tell you how wrong this is.

What can I say to you?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul expressed his disappointment and frustration. Thiselton, p. 543 calls this a deliberative subjunctive. Actually, Paul was not uncertain about what he should say. If a question conveys this wrong meaning, you may need to remove the question form. Translate with a phrase that is a natural way to introduce criticism. For example:

Now listen to what I say.

There may be an idiom that you could use to express strong emotion. For example, in English one could say:

Words fail me at this point.

I am at a loss for words.

11:22e

Shall I praise you for this? No, I will not!

- Can I commend you^(plur) for this? Not at all!
- I certainly can give you no praise for this.

Shall I praise you for this? No, I will not!: This is a rhetorical question to which Paul supplies his own answer. If such a question and response are not nat-

ural in your language, it may be necessary to translate this as one emphatic statement:

I shall certainly not praise you^(plur) for this.

This is something I cannot praise you for!

praise: The Greek word for praise is the same as in 11:2a and 11:17a. Another way to translate it is "commend."

1 Corinthians 11:23

Section 11:17–34: Eat the Lord's Supper in the proper way

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord's Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord's Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord's Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26–28, Mark 14:22–24 and Luke 22:17–20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord's Supper

Instructions about the Lord's Supper

The Lord's Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:23–26

In this paragraph Paul told about how Jesus started the Lord's Supper.

11:23a

For I received from the Lord what I also passed on to you:

- ¶ For I received from the Lord Jesus the teaching that I then handed on to you^(plur).
- ¶ For I learned this tradition from the Lord and then taught it to you.

For: The conjunction For introduces a reason why the Corinthians should follow Paul's instructions about how to observe the Lord's Supper.

I received from the Lord: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I learned this from the Lord

The Lord taught this to me

In some languages it may be clearer to make explicit what Paul received from the Lord. He received information about what Jesus had said and done when he taught his disciples to celebrate the Lord's Supper.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

I received this teaching/tradition from the Lord

the Lord: Here, the Lord refers to the Lord Jesus.

what I also passed on to you: Paul taught the same things to the believers in Corinth that he learned from the Lord. The word also means Paul did two things with the message. He received it from the Lord and he also passed it on to the Corinthians. The word also does not refer to any other teachers besides Paul.

Here is another way to translate the word also:

I received this from the Lord and then I passed it on to you

11:23b

The Lord Jesus, on the night He was betrayed, took bread,

- Early on the night that Judas betrayed him, the Lord Jesus picked up some bread.
- On the evening in which Judas handed him over to his enemies, the Lord Jesus took a loaf of bread.

The Lord Jesus, on the night He was betrayed, took bread: The BSB has followed the Greek word order. In some languages it may be more natural to translate the two clauses separately:

On the night that he was betrayed, the Lord Jesus took bread.

on the night: The Lord Jesus was betrayed late at night. He took the bread earlier in the evening of the same day.

He was betrayed: The phrase He was betrayed is literally "he was handed over." This is a passive verb. It was Judas who betrayed Jesus. He led Jesus' enemies to him and showed them whom they should arrest. If

it is more natural in your language to use an active verb with an explicit subject, you may say:

on the night Judas betrayed him

on the night Judas handed him over to his enemies

took bread: The phrase took bread means "picked up bread." Jesus probably picked up a loaf of bread from a plate that was in front of him on the table. Jesus held the bread in his hands while he spoke the following words.

bread: This bread was a round loaf made without yeast. Use the same word for bread that you used in 10:16. Refer to the notes there.

1 Corinthians 11:24

Section 11:17–34: Eat the Lord's Supper in the proper way

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord's Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord's Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord's Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26–28, Mark 14:22–24 and Luke 22:17–20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord's Supper

Instructions about the Lord's Supper

The Lord's Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:23–26

In this paragraph Paul told about how Jesus started the Lord's Supper.

11:24a

and when He had given thanks,

- After thanking God for it
- He thanked God for it and then

and when He had given thanks: The Lord Jesus gave thanks to God the Father for the bread. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit:

and when he had thanked God for it

Jesus broke the bread after he gave thanks for it. Some English versions use the word “after.” For example:

after he had given thanks (NJB)

11:24b

He broke it and said,

- he tore it and said,
- he divided/separated it. He said,

He broke it: The phrase He broke it means that the Lord Jesus divided the bread into two or more pieces. The text does not say how many pieces he broke it into. The Greek verb is the same as in 10:16.

11:24c

“This is My body, which is for you;

- “This is my body, which will die for you^(plur).
- “This bread is my body. My body will be sacrificed for you.

This is My body, which is for you: This phrase is almost the same as Luke 22:19 but does not have the word “given.” Your translation, apart from the word or phrase meaning “given,” should be the same as in Luke 22:19c.

There is a textual issue here.

1. Some Greek manuscripts say:

This is my body, which is for you^(plur) (BSB, NASB, RSV, ESV, NJB, NET, GW, REB, GNT, CEV, NLT, NCV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts say:

Take, eat. This is my body which is broken for you^(plur) (KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This reading has an A rating in the 4th edition of the UBS Greek NT, indicating that the text is considered certain. This is the reading of most older Greek manuscripts and is followed by most modern versions.

This is My body: Jesus referred to the bread that he held in his hand. In some way this bread signified his body. Different churches understand this in different ways. It is recommended that you translate this

literally. You should check that your translation is acceptable to all the churches that plan to use it in their worship.

My body: The Greek word that the BSB translates as body is the normal word for a human body, not the word for a corpse.

which is for you: The phrase which is for you means “my body is for you.” Jesus’ enemies would soon destroy his body on the cross. Jesus allowed his enemies to kill him in order to save all those who trust in him.

In some languages it may be more natural to say in what sense Jesus’ body was for his disciples. In the Greek text of Corinthians, unlike in the Gospel of Luke, there is no verb here. If it is necessary to supply one, it may be possible to say:

which is given/sacrificed for you^(plur)

which will die for you

11:24d

do this in remembrance of Me.”

- Do this in order to remember me.”
- Break bread in this way to think about me.”

do this in remembrance of Me: This is the same as Luke 22:19d.

do this: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as do this means “continue to do this.” Jesus told his disciples to make it a custom to eat bread together in this way.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

do like this

eat bread like this

in remembrance of Me: The phrase in remembrance of Me means “in order to remember me.” Jesus wanted the disciples to remember him and his death for them when they ate the Lord’s Supper together.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in order to remember me

to think about me

1 Corinthians 11:25

Section 11:17–34: Eat the Lord’s Supper in the proper way

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord’s Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord’s Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord’s Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26–28, Mark 14:22–24 and Luke 22:17–20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord’s Supper

Instructions about the Lord’s Supper

The Lord’s Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:23–26

In this paragraph Paul told about how Jesus started the Lord’s Supper.

11:25a

In the same way, after supper He took the cup, saying,

- Similarly, after supper Jesus took the cup and said,
- After they had eaten supper Jesus also picked up the cup. He said,

In the same way: The phrase In the same way means “In the same way that Jesus picked up the bread and thanked God for it.”

after supper: These events took place during a Passover meal, which always took place during an evening.

He took the cup: Here, the cup refers to the cup of wine that was in front of Jesus. People traditionally drank a cup of wine at the end of a Passover meal. At the end of the meal Jesus picked up the cup filled with wine that was on the table.

The words He took are not in the Greek text. The BSB added these words in order to make a complete English sentence.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

When supper was over, he did the same with the cup (GW)

11:25b

“This cup is the new covenant in My blood;

- “This cup of wine is the new covenant made through my blood.
- “The wine in this cup signifies/represents the new covenant that God is making as a result of my blood.

This cup is the new covenant in My blood: The Greek text is almost the same as Luke 22:20b. Refer to your translation and the notes on that passage. It is good to translate this literally. If a literal translation does not convey any meaning, it may be possible to say:

This cup represents/signifies the new covenant in my blood

This cup is like the new covenant in my blood

cup: The word cup refers to the wine in the cup. In some languages it may be better to translate this as:

cup of wine

new: The Greek language makes a distinction between “new of a different kind” and “new of the same kind.” The word used here implies “a new one of a different kind.” It is the same word that is used in the phrase “New Testament.”

covenant: A covenant is an agreement or promise made between two people or groups of people. The cup of wine was a symbol of the agreement that God made with people through the death of Jesus. See covenant in the Key Biblical Terms.

in My blood: The phrase in My blood means “through my blood” or “by my blood.” The covenant was made by means of the blood that Jesus shed on the cross. His blood made the new covenant possible.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

sealed in my blood (GNT)

made with my blood (GW)

made as a result of my blood

blood: The blood was Jesus' blood that he shed when he died on the cross. This is a way of speaking about Jesus' death.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the blood of my death (NCV)

by the shedding of my blood (NLT)

11:25c

do this, as often as you drink it, in remembrance of Me."

- Whenever you^(plur) drink from this communion cup, drink in order to remember me."
- When you drink this wine, think about me."

do this, as often as you drink it, in remembrance of Me: Another way of ordering these phrases is:

When you drink this, do it to remember me. (NCV)

do this: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as do this means "continue to do this." Jesus told his disciples to make this a custom.

as often as you drink it: The phrase as often as you drink it refers to any time the disciples drink wine from the cup in celebrating the Lord's Supper.

it: The pronoun it refers to the cup. In some languages it may be necessary to make it clear that it is the wine in the cup that the disciples were to drink.

in remembrance of Me: The phrase in remembrance of Me means "in order to remember me." Jesus started the custom of drinking wine together to help the disciples remember him and how he died for them.

1 Corinthians 11:26

Section 11:17–34: Eat the Lord's Supper in the proper way

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord's Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord's Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord's Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26–28, Mark 14:22–24 and Luke 22:17–20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord's Supper

Instructions about the Lord's Supper

The Lord's Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:23–26

In this paragraph Paul told about how Jesus started the Lord's Supper.

11:26a

For as often as you eat this bread and drink this cup,

- For every time you^(plur) eat this bread and drink from this cup
- The Lord said this to show that, each time we^(incl) eat this communion bread and drink this communion wine

For as often as you eat this bread and drink this cup:

This verse is not a quotation of Jesus' words. This is Paul's comment on what Jesus said.

For: The conjunction For introduces Paul's explanation of the saying that the Lord's Supper is a remembrance of Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

the Lord meant that (CEV)

the Lord said this to show that

as often as: The phrase as often as refers to all the times that believers celebrate the Lord's Supper.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

whenever (NIV)

every time that

you eat this bread and drink this cup: This refers to the celebration of the Lord's Supper.

cup: The word cup refers to the wine in the cup. In some languages it may be better to translate this as:

cup of wine

11:26b**you proclaim the Lord's death until He comes.**

- until he comes back you^(plur) declare/announce to others that the Lord has died.
- we^(incl) tell others about the Lord's death until he comes again.

you proclaim the Lord's death: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

you^(plur) tell others about the Lord's death

you declare/announce that the Lord has died

until He comes: The phrase until He comes means "until the Lord comes." Because the Lord has already come once, in some languages it may be clearer to say:

until he comes back

until the Lord returns

General Comment on 11:26a-b

To make it clear that these are not Jesus' words, but Paul's comment on what Jesus said, it may be helpful to say "we" instead of "you." For example:

Whenever we^(incl) eat this bread and drink this cup, we^(incl) proclaim the Lord's death until he comes.

General Comment on 11:23-26

In many churches the pastor says these words out loud every time the Lord's Supper is celebrated. It would be good to read them out loud now and be sure they flow smoothly and sound good in an oral style.

1 Corinthians 11:27**Section 11:17-34: Eat the Lord's Supper in the proper way**

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord's Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord's Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord's Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26-28, Mark 14:22-24 and Luke 22:17-20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord's Supper

Instructions about the Lord's Supper

The Lord's Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:27-32

In this paragraph Paul taught believers to examine themselves before eating the Lord's Supper, so that God will not judge them.

11:27a**Therefore, whoever eats the bread or drinks the cup of the Lord in an unworthy manner**

- ¶ So anyone who eats the bread or drinks wine from the Lord's cup in a way that is not right/proper
- ¶ So you must eat the bread or drink the cup of the Lord in the proper way.

Therefore: The conjunction Therefore introduces a conclusion from what Paul had just said.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

It follows that (GNT)

So then

whoever eats: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

anyone who eats

all who eat

the bread or drinks the cup: The phrases the bread and the cup refer to the bread and the wine that people eat and drink during the Lord's Supper.

drinks the cup: This is the same Greek phrase as in 11:26a. See the notes there.

of the Lord: There are two ways to understand the scope of the phrase of the Lord.

1. It refers to both the bread and the cup. See, for example, Ellingworth and Hatton, p.265. For example:

eats the Lord's bread or drinks from his cup (GNT)

1. It refers only to the cup. For example:

anyone who eats this bread or drinks this cup of the Lord (NLT) (BSB, NLT, NIV, NET, ESV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). Although many English versions appear to follow option (2), most commentaries support option (1).

in an unworthy manner: The phrase in an unworthy manner means "in a way that is not proper" or "in a careless way." Some people took part in the Lord's Supper with wrong motives and attitudes.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in a way that isn't worthy of the Lord (CEV)

in a way that is not right/proper/appropriate

11:27b

will be guilty of sinning against the body and blood of the Lord.

- is sinning and they look down on the body and blood of the Lord.
- Those who do not do this disrespect the Lord's body and his blood.

will be guilty of sinning against the body and blood of the Lord: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as guilty of sinning against the body and blood of the Lord is more literally "guilty of the body and blood of the Lord." The BSB has added the words sinning against to help make the meaning clear. There are two ways to understand what these people are guilty of:

1. They are guilty of treating the death of Christ lightly. These people dishonor the symbols of Christ's death, and so dishonor Christ himself. For example:

guilty of profaning the body and blood of the Lord (RSV)

guilty because they look down on the body and blood of the Lord

they sin because they disrespect the body and blood of the Lord

1. They are guilty of causing Christ's death. For example:

will be held responsible for the Lord's body and blood (GW)

the judgment done to them will be like the judgment done to those who killed the Lord

It is recommended that you follow option (1) which has support from English versions and from some commentaries. See Ellingworth and Hatton p. 265 and Robertson and Plummer p. 251. However, option (2) also has support from some commentaries. See Fee p. 561; Garland p. 550; Kistemaker p. 400.

Many English versions translate this literally and avoid choosing either of the options given above.

Here are some ways to translate this clause literally:

he does wrong to the body and blood of the Lord

it is the same as if he sins against the body and blood of the Lord

General Comment on 27a-b

Here is another way to translate this verse:

Since that is true you must be careful. Eat the bread and drink from the cup in a way that is right. Anyone who does not do that will be guilty. They are showing that they do not respect the Lord's body and his blood that he offered as a sacrifice. (EASY)

1 Corinthians 11:28

Section 11:17–34: Eat the Lord's Supper in the proper way

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord's Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord's Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord's Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26–28, Mark 14:22–24 and Luke 22:17–20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord's Supper

Instructions about the Lord's Supper

The Lord's Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:27–32

In this paragraph Paul taught believers to examine themselves before eating the Lord's Supper, so that God will not judge them.

11:28

Each one must examine himself before he eats of the bread and drinks of the cup.

- People should test themselves before they eat the communion bread and drink from the communion cup.
- Before eating the bread and drinking the wine in the cup, you should look carefully at your own hearts/attitudes.

Each one must examine himself: The phrase examine himself means to think carefully about oneself and consider if one's own actions and attitudes are right.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

each person should think about their own heart

you should test yourself

Each one: The Greek word that the BSB translate as Each one refers to any person, male or female. Here is another way to translate this:

everyone (REB)

before he eats of the bread and drinks of the cup:

The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as before he eats is more literally “and so eat.” It means that people should only eat after they examine themselves. Here is another way to translate this:

and then eat (GNT)

1 Corinthians 11:29

Section 11:17–34: Eat the Lord's Supper in the proper way

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord's Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord's Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord's Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26–28, Mark 14:22–24 and Luke 22:17–20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord's Supper

Instructions about the Lord's Supper

The Lord's Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:27–32

In this paragraph Paul taught believers to examine themselves before eating the Lord's Supper, so that God will not judge them.

11:29a

For anyone who eats and drinks without recognizing the body

- For all who eat and drink without discerning the Lord's body
- For those who eat and drink without thinking, “This is the Lord's body,”

For: The conjunction For introduces the reason for what Paul said in 11:28.

anyone who eats and drinks: The word anyone applies to all Christians.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

if you^(plur) eat and drink

people who eat and drink

without recognizing the body: The Greek word that the BSB translates as recognizing is more literally “distinguishing” or “discerning.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

without careful regard for the body (NET)

if you do not recognize the meaning of the Lord’s body (GNT)

the body: There are two ways to interpret the expression the body:

1. The body represents the Lord’s body which was sacrificed for us. For example:

eat and drink without thinking, “This is the Lord’s body.”

without thinking about the broken body of the Lord

they do not think about how the Lord died for them

1. The body represents people who believe in the Lord. For example:

fail to understand that you are the body of the Lord (CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) which has stronger support in the commentaries. See Thiselton p. 893 and Morris p. 161. Fee p. 563 represents option (2). However, many versions translate it literally to allow for either interpretation, and it may be possible for you to do so as well.

This verse is complicated by a textual issue:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have only the word body. For example:

the body (NJB) (BSB, NJB, RSV, NET, NASB, NCV, REB, ESV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts say “the body of the Lord.” For example:

the Lord’s body (GNT) (GNT, NIV, CEV, GW, NLT, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), which is followed by the UBS Greek New Testament. Although “the Lord” is not in the best Greek manuscripts, it can be understood as implicit information. You may choose to add it if it helps to make the meaning clear.

11:29b

eats and drinks judgment on himself.

- bring judgment on themselves.
- God will judge them for the way they eat and drink.

eats and drinks judgment on himself: The phrase eats and drinks judgment on himself means “he brings judgment on himself through his eating and drinking.” By taking part in the Lord’s Supper in a wrong way, a person causes God to judge him.

judgment: The word judgment refers to God’s decision that something is wrong.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

God will punish him because of the way he eats and drinks

General Comment on 11:29a-b

In some languages it may be natural to reorder 11:29, as the NASB has done:

For he who eats and drinks, eats and drinks judgment to himself if he does not judge the body rightly. (NASB)

1 Corinthians 11:30

Section 11:17–34: Eat the Lord’s Supper in the proper way

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord’s Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord’s Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord’s Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26–28, Mark 14:22–24 and Luke 22:17–20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord’s Supper

Instructions about the Lord's Supper

The Lord's Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:27–32

In this paragraph Paul taught believers to examine themselves before eating the Lord's Supper, so that God will not judge them.

11:30a

That is why many among you are weak and sick,

- This is the reason many of you^(plur) are weak or sick
- This is why many of you are feeble and many are ill,

That is why many among you are weak and sick: The phrase *That is why* refers back to the previous verse. What Paul said in the previous verse is the reason for the many sicknesses in the Corinthian church.

weak and sick: The Greek words that the BSB translates as *weak and sick* are similar in meaning. One who is weak is feeble or without strength, whereas one who is sick is ill with some disease.

11:30b

and a number of you have fallen asleep.

- and some of you^(plur) have died.

and a number of you have fallen asleep: The phrase *a number of you have fallen asleep* means “some of you have died.” Paul did not say how many, but the phrase *a number* implies at least more than two. Several of the believers in Corinth died because they ate the Lord's Supper in a wrong way.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

a number have died (REB)

quite a few are dead (NET)

1 Corinthians 11:31

Section 11:17–34: Eat the Lord's Supper in the proper way

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord's Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord's Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If

anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord's Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26–28, Mark 14:22–24 and Luke 22:17–20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord's Supper

Instructions about the Lord's Supper

The Lord's Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:27–32

In this paragraph Paul taught believers to examine themselves before eating the Lord's Supper, so that God will not judge them.

11:31a

Now if we judged ourselves properly,

- But if we^(incl) examined ourselves first
- But if we^(incl) correct ourselves before eating and drinking

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *Now* introduces a contrast to what happened in the preceding verse. Some English versions (such as GNT, NJB) do not explicitly translate this conjunction. Other English versions use the word “But” (such as the NIV, ESV, and NASB).

if we judged ourselves properly: The phrase *if we judged ourselves properly* refers back to “each one must examine himself” in 11:28. It means “if we examined ourselves before taking part in the Lord's Supper.” Paul wanted the believers to think about their own attitudes and motives.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

if we^(incl) examine our hearts before eating and drinking

if we think/consider/look at our hearts

if we correct ourselves

11:31b

we would not come under judgment.

- we^(incl) would not be judged.
- the Lord will not have to correct us.

we would not come under judgment: The phrase we would not come under judgment is a passive phrase. In some languages it may be more natural to use an active verb and supply the subject. For example:

the Lord would not judge us

1 Corinthians 11:32

Section 11:17–34: Eat the Lord’s Supper in the proper way

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord’s Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord’s Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord’s Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26–28, Mark 14:22–24 and Luke 22:17–20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord’s Supper

Instructions about the Lord’s Supper

The Lord’s Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:27–32

In this paragraph Paul taught believers to examine themselves before eating the Lord’s Supper, so that God will not judge them.

11:32a

But when we are judged by the Lord,

- When the Lord judges us^(incl),
- When the Lord corrects us,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a contrast to the previous verse. Here are some ways to translate this conjunction:

Nevertheless (NIV11)

Yet (NLT)

when we are judged by the Lord: This is a passive clause. In some languages it may be more natural to use an active verb and make the Lord the subject:

When the Lord judges us

we: Paul was not one of the people in Corinth, but he used an inclusive pronoun to suggest that the same thing applied to everyone, including himself. The Lord judges all his people for their good.

the Lord: It is not clear whether the Lord refers to God or to Christ. It is best to translate literally in such a way that either meaning is possible.

11:32b

we are being disciplined

- he is disciplining us^(incl)
- he is teaching us

we are being disciplined: This is a passive phrase. In some languages it may be more natural to use an active verb and supply the subject “he” or “the Lord.” For example:

the Lord is disciplining us

disciplined: To “discipline” someone is to correct them and punish them in order to help them do what is right. The word is generally used of the way parents and teachers train and teach children.

Here is another way to translate this word:

the Lord is teaching/training us

11:32c

so that we will not be condemned with the world.

- so that he will not have to condemn us^(incl) with the rest of the world.
- in order that we^(incl) will not receive punishment with the unbelieving world when God judges them on the last day.

so that we will not be condemned with the world:

This gives the purpose of the Lord’s discipline. The Lord disciplined the Corinthians so that they will stop their bad behavior. If they stop their bad behavior then the Lord will not condemn them with the rest of the world.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the Lord is disciplining us to save us from being condemned with the world

he wants us to escape when he punishes the world

we will not be condemned: This is a passive phrase. In some languages it may be more natural to use an active verb. For example:

the Lord will not condemn us

condemned with the world: This refers to God's judgment at the end of the world. It may be clearer to add this as implied information:

condemned with the world on the last day

condemned with the world on the day when God judges all people

the world: The word world refers to the people of this world who oppose God. God will not condemn believers along with these people. But in a sense the believers are part of the world. It may be natural to translate this as:

the rest of the world

those who don't trust in him

1 Corinthians 11:33

Section 11:17–34: Eat the Lord's Supper in the proper way

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord's Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord's Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord's Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26–28, Mark 14:22–24 and Luke 22:17–20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord's Supper

Instructions about the Lord's Supper

The Lord's Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:33–34

In this paragraph Paul taught the Corinthians to eat the Lord's Supper together.

11:33a

So, my brothers, when you come together to eat,

- ¶ So then, my brothers and sisters, when you^(plur) come together to eat,
- ¶ So, my fellow believers, when you get together to eat the Lord's Supper,

So: The word So introduce the conclusion to the discussion that Paul started in 11:17.

my brothers: The phrase my brothers refers to Paul's fellow Christians. Paul spoke to both men and women who believed in Jesus Christ. See how you translated the similar expression in 1:10.

when you come together to eat: The believers met together in the homes of fellow believers. They ate meals and worshiped together and celebrated the Lord's Supper. Paul spoke of the times when they took the Lord's Supper together as part of a meal. Some versions, such as the GNT, have made this explicit:

when you gather together to eat the Lord's Supper (GNT)

11:33b

wait for one another.

- wait for everyone to arrive.

wait for one another: Some of the believers started to eat as soon as they arrived without waiting for everyone else. See 11:21a.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

wait for everybody to arrive

wait for each other and then eat together

1 Corinthians 11:34

Section 11:17–34: Eat the Lord's Supper in the proper way

In this section Paul discussed some problems with how the believers in Corinth ate the Lord's Supper. Some people started eating and did not wait for others to arrive. Some people ate too much while others had little or nothing.

Christians should eat the Lord's Supper in order to remember the Lord Jesus. They should repent from sin before eating and drinking, and they should wait for everyone to arrive before beginning the Supper. If anyone is hungry, they should eat at home so that they do not come under judgment.

The celebration of the Lord's Supper is also described in Matthew 26:26–28, Mark 14:22–24 and Luke 22:17–20.

Here are some other possible section headings:

How to observe/celebrate the Lord's Supper

Instructions about the Lord's Supper

The Lord's Supper should be honored

Paragraph 11:33–34

In this paragraph Paul taught the Corinthians to eat the Lord's Supper together.

11:34a

If anyone is hungry, he should eat at home,

- If anyone is hungry, he should have something to eat at his own house
- People who are too hungry to wait should first eat at their own home.

If anyone is hungry, he should eat at home: If some people were too hungry to wait for the other believers, they should eat at home before going to the worship services.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

If you are very hungry you should eat at home first

11:34b

so that when you come together it will not result in judgment.

- in order that your^(plur) meetings may not result in the Lord judging you.
- Then your meetings will not cause God to punish you.

so that...not: The phrase so that...not introduces a negative purpose. Paul wanted them to act so as to avoid something.

when you come together it will not result in judgment: Some translators have reversed the order of these two phrases. For example:

you will not come under God's judgment as you meet together (GNT)

it will not result in judgment: Paul referred to the judgment of sickness and death that he mentioned in 11:29–31. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a verb with God or the Lord as the subject:

it may not result in the Lord judging you^(plur)

Then God will not punish you for doing what is wrong

11:34c

And when I come, I will give instructions about the remaining matters.

- And when I come I will tell you more about this.
- There are some other matters I will teach you about. I will do that when I come to you.

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces a final comment on the same topic. Many English versions do not explicitly translate this conjunction.

when I come, I will give instructions about the remaining matters: This probably referred to more instructions that Paul planned to give about the Lord's Supper.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

when I come, I will tell you more about this

I have other things to give instructions about. I will say them when I come to you.

1 Corinthians 12:1

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:1

Now about spiritual gifts, brothers, I do not want you to be uninformed.

- ¶ Concerning spiritual gifts, my fellow believers, I want you^(plur) to know clearly.
- ¶ Now I move on to answer your questions about spiritual gifts. My brothers and sisters in Christ, there is something that I want you to know.

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now introduces a new topic. It is not a time word. Translate it in a way that is natural for starting to write about a new topic or theme.

about spiritual gifts: This phrase states the topic for the following section. Paul introduced a topic that the Corinthians had asked him about in a letter. He introduced new topics in a similar way in 7:1 and 8:1. See how you translated it there and use the same pattern here.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I will answer your questions about spiritual gifts

in your letter you asked about spiritual gifts

spiritual gifts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as spiritual gifts is literally “spiritual [things].” It is not the same Greek word as in 1:7. However, it refers to the same abilities that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. It is OK to translate it in the same way as 1:7.

brothers: The word brothers refers to all the believers to whom Paul wrote, both male and female. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as:

my Christian brothers and sisters

my fellow believers

I do not want you to be uninformed: The phrase I do not want you to be uninformed is a double negative.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I want you to know clearly

there is something I want you to know

1 Corinthians 12:2

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:2a

You know that when you were pagans,

- As you^(plur) know, before you believed in the true God
- You remember that when you didn’t yet know about God’s way

You know that: The phrase You know that introduces some information that the Corinthians already knew.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

as you^(plur) know

you already know that

you remember that (NJB)

when you were pagans: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pagans refers to people who do not believe in the true God.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

before you believed in the Lord

before you followed the true God

when you didn’t yet know about God’s way

when you followed the old religion

12:2b (NET) often

- many times
- again and again

There are two Greek particles here. The BSB does not translate them. The NET translates them as “often.” There are two ways to interpret these Greek particles:

1. They indicate a repetitive aspect. The Corinthians were led to worship idols many times. For example:

every time (GW) (NET, GW, NABRE, GNT)

1. They indicate that Paul was not certain. He knew that the Corinthians followed idols, but he was not sure how or why. For example:

somehow or other (NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), which is supported by several commentaries. See, for example, Thiselton p.912, Fee, p.576, Morris p.164, Kistemaker p.414. and Bible versions.

12:2c you were influenced and led astray to mute idols.

- you^(plur) were persuaded and pulled/swayed toward voiceless/speechless idols.
- something caused you to worship dead/lifeless statues.

you were influenced and led astray to mute idols:

The verbs influenced and led astray are both passive verbs. It is not clear who influenced the Corinthians. Some possibilities are other people, or their own desires. If you can, you should translate this without naming a specific agent.

Here are some ways to translate these passive verbs:

- As passive verbs. For example:

You were taken and led away to worship mute idols

- As active verbs. For example:

Someone/something influenced you and led you astray to worship mute idols

Translate these verbs in a way that is natural in your language.

influenced and led astray: The verbs influenced and led astray are similar in meaning. In some languages it may be clearer to combine them into one verb phrase.

Here are some other ways to translate these verbs:

you were tempted to worship mute idols

something took you toward mute idols

The Corinthians used to worship idols. In some languages it may be helpful to make this explicit. For example:

You let yourselves be influenced and led away to worship idols. (NCV)

mute: The word mute means that the idols could not speak. In some languages a literal translation may suggest that the idols were alive but unable to speak. If a literal translation conveys this wrong meaning, it may be clearer to say:

dead/lifeless

dead and unable to speak

idols: The word idols refers to statues that people made and worshiped.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

statues

images that people worship

1 Corinthians 12:3

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:3a

Therefore I inform you that

- So I am telling you^(plur) that
- So I want you to know that

Therefore: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Therefore introduces a point that develops logically from 12:2.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

So

For this reason

I inform you that: The phrase I inform you that can also be translated as:

I cause you to know that

I tell you that (NIV)

I declare to you that

12:3b

no one who is speaking by the Spirit of God says,

- there is no person who follows God's Spirit who says,
- if the Holy Spirit of God leads/influences a person, they cannot say

no one who is speaking by the Spirit of God says: This is something that will never happen. The Spirit does not inspire anyone to say what follows.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

there is no person who speaks following the Spirit of God and says

the Spirit of God will never cause a person to say

if the Spirit of God guides a person, they will not say

by the Spirit of God: The phrase by the Spirit of God means that the Spirit of God guides them.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

follows/depends on the Spirit of God

under the influence of the Spirit of God

has the Spirit of God

12:3c

"Jesus be cursed,"

- "May there be a curse on Jesus."
- bad words about Jesus.

Jesus be cursed: The clause Jesus be cursed is a wish that Jesus will endure harm or suffering. Use a phrase that is natural in your language for wishing evil on someone.

Here are some other ways to translate this evil wish:

"May a curse fall on Jesus."

"May Jesus die/be harmed."

In some languages it may be better to use indirect speech. For example:

(they cannot) curse Jesus.

(they cannot) say bad words about Jesus.

12:3d

and no one can say, "Jesus is Lord," except by the Holy Spirit.

- And a person cannot say, "Jesus is Lord," unless they follow the Holy Spirit.
- And only if the Holy Spirit leads/influences a person can they acknowledge that Jesus is Lord.

no one can say, "Jesus is Lord," except by the Holy Spirit: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

a person cannot say, "Jesus is Lord" unless he speaks following the Holy Spirit

only the Holy Spirit will cause a person to say, "Jesus is Lord"

only if the Holy Spirit guides a person can they say, “Jesus is Lord”

say: In some languages there may be another word that is appropriate instead of say. For example:

claim

acknowledge

confess

Jesus is Lord: When Christians say this, they mean that Jesus is God and that he is the ruler over the universe. They also mean that he is their personal Lord and master.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

“Jesus is my Lord/Master/King”

“Jesus is the true Lord”

In some languages it may be better to use indirect speech. For example:

(they cannot say that) Jesus is their Lord

(they cannot say that) Jesus rules/controls them

General Comment on 12:3b-d

The terms “Spirit of God” in 12:3b and “Holy Spirit” in 12:3d both refer to the same Spirit, the third person of the Trinity. Be sure this is clear in your translation. You could do this by:

- Making the terms more similar to each other. For example:

^{3b}no one who is led by God’s Holy Spirit ^{3c}can say “A curse on Jesus!” ^{3d}and no one who is not led by the Holy Spirit can say “Jesus is Lord.”

- Restructuring the sentence so that there is only one reference to the Holy Spirit. For example:

^{3b,d}people who speak by God’s Holy Spirit will say that Jesus is Lord ^{3c}and can never curse Jesus

1 Corinthians 12:4

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

Paragraph 12:4–11

All the different kinds of spiritual gifts come from the same Holy Spirit.

12:4

There are different gifts, but the same Spirit.

- ¶ To return to the topic of gifts, there are various gifts, but the same Spirit gives them to us^(incl).
- ¶ The gifts are of different kinds, but they all come from the one Holy Spirit.

There is a Greek conjunction which connects 12:4–11 to the previous paragraph. The BSB does not translate this conjunction. The RSV and some other versions translate this word as “Now.” This paragraph returns to the topic of spiritual gifts. You should make this connection in a way that is natural in your language.

There are different gifts, but the same Spirit: This has some implied information. It may be necessary to say explicitly that the Spirit gives the gifts. For example:

There are different gifts, but the same Spirit gives them to us

The gifts are of many different kinds, but they come from the same Spirit

different: The word different refers to varieties or variations of gifts. The gifts that the Spirit gives are not all the same.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

there are many gifts

there are gifts that are different from one another

gifts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gifts is the same word as in 1:7 and 7:7, and you should translate it the same way.

the same Spirit: The phrase the same Spirit refers to God's Spirit. It is God's Holy Spirit who gives spiritual gifts to each believer.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the one Spirit of God gives them to us

it is the Holy Spirit alone who gives them to us

Make sure that your words do not imply that there is more than one Holy Spirit.

1 Corinthians 12:5

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

Paragraph 12:4–11

All the different kinds of spiritual gifts come from the same Holy Spirit.

12:5

There are different ministries, but the same Lord.

- There are different ways that we^(incl) serve, but we^(incl) all serve the same Lord.
- We^(incl) serve God in different ways, but there is only one Lord.

There are different ministries, but the same Lord: If it is necessary to say whom we serve, it is best to say that we serve the Lord.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

there are many different ways we can serve the Lord, but we all serve the same Lord

we serve the Lord in different ways, but there is only one Lord

There are different ministries: The word for different is the same as in 12:4.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

There are different ways of serving God

There are many different works that people can do

1 Corinthians 12:6

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

Paragraph 12:4–11

All the different kinds of spiritual gifts come from the same Holy Spirit.

12:6a

There are different ways of working,

- There are different kinds of work to do,
- We^(incl) can work in various/different ways,

There are different ways of working: The Greek word for different ways is the same as in 12:4 and 12:5.

There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as working.

1. It refers to actions or activities. For example:

There are different types of work to do (GW) (BSB, GW, CEV, NIV, ESV)

1. It refers to the results of the service done in v.5. For example:

there are different results (NET) (NET, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is supported by many English versions and many commentaries. See, for example, Fee p.186, and Verbrugge & Harris p.364.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

we can each do different things (CEV)

there are a variety of activities

everybody has a different work to do

12:6b

but the same God works all things in all people.

- but it is the same God who makes it possible for everyone to do all of them.
- but in every activity it is the one God who strengthens/enables us^(incl) all.

but the same God works all things in all people: It is the one true God who strengthens every believer to serve in some way.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the same God produces every gift in every person (GW)

the one God is acting in all of them and in all people

the one God makes it possible for everybody to do all of them

all things: The phrase all things refers to the different kinds of activities mentioned in 12:6a.

people: The word people refers to all believers.

1 Corinthians 12:7

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

Paragraph 12:4–11

All the different kinds of spiritual gifts come from the same Holy Spirit.

12:7

Now to each one the manifestation of the Spirit is given for the common good.

- Each believer is given evidence of the Spirit's presence, for the benefit/good of all.
- God gives each of us gifts which shows that the Spirit is present. We are to use these gifts for the good of all believers.

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now introduces a new argument on the same theme as 12:4–6. This verse introduces and summarizes the content of 12:8–11. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction explicitly. Translate this conjunction in a way that is appropriate for introducing a new argument.

to each one: The phrase to each one means “to every believer.” This included Paul and his readers.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to all his people

to each of us^(incl)

If you use the first-person plural pronoun (we/us), you should be consistent and use that pronoun in the following verses also.

the manifestation of the Spirit is given: This is a passive clause. The implied subject is God. In some languages it may be natural to make the verb active and make the subject explicit. For example:

God gives the manifestation of the Spirit.

the manifestation of the Spirit: The manifestation of the Spirit refers to the spiritual gifts that the Holy Spirit gives.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

God gives gifts which show that the Spirit is present

we receive gifts which are a sign that we have the Spirit

God gives each of us a gift. This gift shows that we are influenced by the Spirit

for the common good: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as for the common good is more literally “for profit/benefit.” It means that what God gives is for the good of the whole church.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

for the good of all people

so that we can all help each other

we should use these gifts to be useful to our fellow believers

1 Corinthians 12:8

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church
In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

Paragraph 12:4–11

All the different kinds of spiritual gifts come from the same Holy Spirit.

12:8–10

These verses list different gifts that God gives to believers through the Holy Spirit. This list shows examples of such gifts. It does not list all the possible gifts. Consider how it is natural to translate a list in your language. In some languages it may be natural to mention the Spirit at the beginning or end of the list only, rather than four times separately.

12:8a

To one there is given through the Spirit the message of wisdom,

- Some people are given, through the Spirit, the ability to speak wise words.
- God gives some of us, through the Holy Spirit, the gift of speaking wisely.

To one: The Greek word that the BSB translates as To one introduces an example of one of the gifts. It does not mean that only one person receives this gift.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

To some people

To some of us^(incl)

there is given through the Spirit: The clause there is given through the Spirit is in the passive. The implied agent is God. There are two ways to translate this clause:

- use a passive verb. For example:

the message of wisdom is given through the Spirit

- use an active verb. For example:

God gives the message of wisdom through the Spirit

some people receive the message of wisdom through the Spirit

Use the form that is the most natural in your language.

the message of wisdom: The phrase the message of wisdom refers to a message whose content is wise. The person who receives this gift speaks words that are wise.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the ability to speak wisely

wise/intelligent words

words that tell about God's wisdom

12:8b

to another the message of knowledge by the same Spirit,

- Some people are given, through the same Spirit, a message that tells/communicates knowledge.
- He gives to some of us, by the one Holy Spirit, words that help people know about God.

to another the message of knowledge by the same Spirit: The Greek does not have a main verb. In some languages it may be necessary to supply a verb. For example:

to another person God gives the message of knowledge by the same Spirit

to another: The phrase to another means "to another person." It does not mean that only one person receives this gift.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to another person

to some other people

to others of us^(incl)

the message of knowledge: The phrase the message of knowledge refers to a message whose content is knowledge. The person who receives this gift speaks words that help people know new things.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the ability to speak with knowledge (NCV)

words that give knowledge

In some languages it is necessary to say what is known.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

words that help people to know about God

a message that helps people to know about God's word/ways/truth

by the same Spirit: The Greek word that the BSB translates as by has the same meaning as "through the Spirit" in 12:8a. There is one Holy Spirit through whom God gives all the gifts.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

by means of the same Spirit

by/through the one Holy Spirit

1 Corinthians 12:9

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

Paragraph 12:4–11

All the different kinds of spiritual gifts come from the same Holy Spirit.

12:9a

to another faith by the same Spirit,

- Some people are given, through the same Spirit, the ability to believe him deeply/firmly.
- He gives to some of us, by the same Spirit, the gift of great faith/trust/belief.

to another: The phrase to another introduces another gift that the Holy Spirit gives to some people. It does

not mean that the Spirit gives this ability to only one person. It is a different word from that translated as to another in 12:8b, but in this context it means the same thing.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to another person

to some other people

to others of us^(incl)

faith: The word faith refers to great belief in God. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as a verb phrase:

he helps them to believe firmly/strongly

he helps them to trust him very much

by the same Spirit: The Greek preposition that the BSB translates as by means the same as the prepositions translated as “through” and “by” in 12:8a and 12:8b. Paul used different Greek words for good style, but they have the same meaning. If in your language it is natural to use the same word, it is fine to translate it in that way.

12:9b
to another gifts of healing by that one Spirit,

- Some people are given, through that one Spirit the ability to heal diseases.
- He gives some of us, through that same Spirit, gifts that help/permit us to heal sick people.

to another: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to another, here and four times in 12:10, is the same as in 12:8b. The variation from 12:9a is a matter of style, and you may use the same or a different word here, as is natural in your language.

gifts of healing: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as gifts of healing is literally “gifts of healings.” The nouns are in the plural because God gives this gift at different times in order to heal different diseases.

In some languages it may be natural to translate healing as a verb. For example:

abilities to heal diseases/sick people

by that one Spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as by that one Spirit means the same as “by

the same Spirit” in 12:9a. Some Greek manuscripts read “by the same Spirit” in 12:9b. This reading is followed by the KJV. The 4th edition of the UBS Greek text gives the reading “by the one Spirit” an A rating, meaning that the text is considered certain.

1 Corinthians 12:10

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

Paragraph 12:4–11

All the different kinds of spiritual gifts come from the same Holy Spirit.

12:10a
to another the working of miracles,

- Some people are given the ability to perform miracles.
- He gives some of us the gift of doing amazing things.

From this point on Paul did not say “by the Spirit.” But it is the Holy Spirit who gives the following gifts, as well as those already mentioned.

to another the working of miracles: The phrase the working of miracles is more literally “works of powers.” The word “powers” often refers to miracles.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the ability to do miracles

able to do powerful deeds

able to do amazing things

12:10b to another prophecy,

- Some people are given the ability to prophesy.
- He gives some of us the gift of declaring God's word to people.

to another prophecy: The word prophecy refers to the ability to declare God's word to people. This word appeared in 11:4–5. You should translate it the same way here. See the Glossary and Prophet in the KBT.

12:10c to another distinguishing between spirits,

- Some people are given the ability to discern good spirits from evil spirits.
- He gives some of us the gift to know which things come from an evil spirit and which come from the Holy Spirit.

to another distinguishing between spirits: The phrase distinguishing between spirits refers to the ability to tell whether a spirit is from God or not.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the ability to distinguish good spirits from evil spirits

the ability to know which things come from an evil spirit and which come from the Holy Spirit

12:10d to another speaking in various tongues,

- Some people are given the ability to speak in various unknown tongues.
- He gives some of us the gift of speaking in unknown/miraculous languages.

to another speaking in various tongues: The word tongues refers to speech uttered by people who do not know the meaning of what they are saying. These tongues may be foreign languages that the Spirit enables the person to speak, or they may be speech that is not a real language of this world. See notes on Acts 10:46.

Here are some other ways to translate the word tongues:

various languages

unknown/miraculous languages

languages that they have not learned

languages given by the Holy Spirit

12:10e and to still another the interpretation of tongues.

- And some other people are given the ability to explain what those unknown tongues mean.
- And he gives to others of us the gift of interpreting/translating what those people say.

and to still another the interpretation of tongues: The phrase interpretation of tongues refers to the ability to explain the meaning of the tongues that somebody speaks.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the ability to explain the meaning of those languages

the ability to interpret/translate what those people say

1 Corinthians 12:11

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

Paragraph 12:4–11

All the different kinds of spiritual gifts come from the same Holy Spirit.

12:11a All these are the work of one and the same Spirit,

- All these abilities are the work of the one same Spirit,
- But it is the one Holy Spirit who works in all these ways,

There is a conjunction in the Greek that the BSB and most other English versions do not translate. The GNT translates this word as “But.” Paul used this conjunction to introduce a contrast between the many different gifts and the one Spirit who gave these gifts. You should express this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

All these are the work of one and the same Spirit:

The clause All these are the work of one and the same Spirit means that the Holy Spirit produces all these gifts.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

There is only one Holy Spirit who gives all these gifts.

It is God’s Spirit alone who does all these things.

12:11b

who apportions them to each one as He determines.

- and the Spirit gives them to every believer as he decides.
- and he gives these gifts to every believer following his own decision.

who apportions them to each one as He determines:

The Holy Spirit decides which gifts to give to each person, and he gives the gifts. In your translation, make sure that it is clear that both the word who and the pronoun He refer to the Spirit. One way to do this is to combine the clauses.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

distributing them at will to each individual (NJB)

decides which gifts to give to each of us (CEV)

who apportions them to each one: The phrase apportions them to each one implies that the Spirit gives gifts to every believer.

as He determines: The phrase as He determines means “as the Spirit decides.” The Holy Spirit decides to whom he will give each gift.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

as he pleases

following his own heart

1 Corinthians 12:12

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:12

This verse consists of a comparison, a simile. In the Greek it is one sentence, as in the RSV:

For just as the body is one and has many members, and all the members of the body, though many, are one body, so it is with Christ. (RSV)

The BSB broke this verse up into three sentences. The first two (12:12a-b) makes a statement about the human body, and the third (12:12c) introduces the comparison. Some other English versions put the comparison with Christ at the beginning of the verse. For example:

Christ is like a single body, which has many parts; it is still one body, even though it is made up of different parts. (GNT)

Christ is like a single body with its many limbs and organs, which, many as they are, together make up one body. (REB)

Consider which model is clear and natural in your language.

12:12a

The body is a unit, though it is composed of many parts.

- ¶ The human body is one unit, although it consists of many parts.

- ¶ A person's body has many different limbs and organs, but it is still one whole.

There is a conjunction in the Greek that the BSB does not translate. The RSV translates this conjunction as "For." Paul used this conjunction to connect 12:12 to the previous verse.

The body is a unit, though it is composed of many parts: In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of the two clauses:

Even though the body is composed of many parts, it is still a single unit.

The body is a unit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as The body is a unit is literally "the body is one." The parts of the body belong together and together they make up a single body.

body: The word body refers to a human body.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the human body

the body of a person

it is composed of many parts: The word parts refers to the limbs and organs of a body, such as arms, legs, nose, and stomach. Together these parts make up one whole body.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

body parts

things of the body

limbs and organs

12:12b

And although its parts are many, they all form one body.

- Even though it has many different parts, together they make one body.
- Its many different items/pieces all fit together into one.

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces a repetition of the previous statement in slightly different words.

although its parts are many, they all form one body:

This repeats the information in 12:12a with the clauses in reverse order. Consider if this is natural style in your language. If it is not, you may wish to follow one of the alternative models in the note at the beginning of 12:12.

12:12c

So it is with Christ.

- This is a picture of the body of Christ.
- So it is with the church which is like the body of Christ.

So it is with Christ: This says that the figurative language of v.12a-b illustrates a spiritual truth. Paul compared a human body with the body of Christ, the church. In some languages it may be helpful to make it clear that the topic is the church rather than Christ's human body:

So it is with the church, which is like the body of Christ.

1 Corinthians 12:13

Section 12:1-31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:13a

For in one Spirit we were all baptized into one body,

- For by/through the one Spirit we^(incl) all received baptism into one body.
- For the one Spirit baptized us^(incl) all into one whole/unit.

For: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as For introduces the grounds of the comparison in 12:12. Paul explained in what way the body of Christ, the church, is like a human body.

in one Spirit we were all baptized into one body:

Paul explained that many different believers could be one body. The reason is that the same Spirit baptized them and made them one.

There are two ways to interpret the word baptized:

1. It refers to a spiritual baptism that took place when the Corinthians became Christians, and they received the Holy Spirit.
2. It refers to water baptism.

For the Corinthian believers, baptism in water was associated with Spirit baptism. It is good if you can use a phrase that covers both ideas. If you must choose between them, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This best fits the context of 12:13c.

in one Spirit: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in one Spirit:

1. It refers to the Holy Spirit as the agent. It is the Spirit who baptizes. For example:

by one Spirit we were all baptized into one body (RSV)

God baptized us all with the same Holy Spirit (RSV, NIV, GNT, CEV, GW, NLT, NASB, KJV)

1. It refers to the Holy Spirit as the sphere or location in which believers are baptized. For example:

in a single Spirit (NJB) (BSB, NJB, NRSV, NET, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This has the strongest support among the English versions.

12:13b**whether Jews or Greeks, slave or free,**

- It does not matter whether we^(incl) are Jews or Greeks, slaves or free people.
- This is for all of us including Jews and Greeks, including slaves and free people.

whether Jews or Greeks, slave or free: These phrases give parenthetical information that is added to the main point. Paul said that it did not matter whether believers are Jewish people or not, or slaves or not. They are all part of one body.

Jews: The word Jews refers to people who are Jewish by race, rather than Jewish by religion. The Christians in Corinth who were descended from the twelve sons of Jacob considered themselves to be Jewish.

Greeks: The word Greeks refers to people from the country of Greece. However, in this context it is used in a general way for anyone who is not a Jew.

slave: The word slave refers to people who were not free to leave their place of employment. They had to remain with their owner and work for him.

free: The word free refers to people who were not slaves. They were free to leave their employment and work when and as they wished.

12:13c**and we were all given one Spirit to drink.**

- God caused us^(incl) all to drink the same Spirit.
- And that one Spirit is like water that all of us can drink.

and we were all given one Spirit to drink: This is a metaphor. God gave his Holy Spirit to all believers. The Spirit is like water that a person drinks. It is like water in the sense that it gives us life when it enters us.

The verb we were all given is passive. It is God who causes his people to receive or drink the Holy Spirit. There are two ways to translate this passive verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

we were all made to drink of one Spirit (NASB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God gave all of us^(incl) the same Spirit to drink

the one Spirit is like water that all of us can drink, and that water gives us life

Use the verb form that is the most natural in your language.

In some languages it may be clearer to remove the figure of speech and translate the meaning. For example:

we have all received the same Spirit

we all have one Spirit living in us

General Comment on 12:13a-c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder this verse and put 12:13b at the beginning. This what the CEV has done:

^{13b}Some of us are Jews, and others are Gentiles. Some of us are slaves, and others are free. ^{13a}But God's Spirit baptized each of us and made us part of the body of Christ. ^{13c}Now we each drink from that same Spirit. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 12:14

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church
In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:14

For the body does not consist of one part, but of many.

- ¶ The human body does not have just one part. It is made up of many parts.
- ¶ A person's body has many different parts, not just one part.

For: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as For introduces a return to the thought of 12:12.

Here are some other ways to translate this Greek phrase:

Now (NIV)

Even so

the body does not consist of one part, but of many:
The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as does not consist of is literally "is not."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

is not made up of (NIV)

does not have

In some languages it may be natural to state first what the body does consist of:

the body consists of many parts, not only one

the body has many parts rather than just one

the body: The word body refers to the human body. You should translate it the same way you translated it in 12:12.

1 Corinthians 12:15

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church
In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:15a

If the foot should say,

- If the foot says,
- For example, suppose a foot were to say that

If the foot should say: This is a situation that cannot occur. Consider the most natural way to translate an unreal situation.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If the foot were to say

If the foot says

Suppose the foot says

12:15b

"Because I am not a hand, I do not belong to the body,"

- "I am not a hand so I do not belong to the body,"

- it does not belong to the body because it is not a hand.

Because I am not a hand, I do not belong to the body: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

“I am not a hand and so I am not part of the body.”

“I am not part of the body because I am not a hand.”

In some languages it may be more natural to use an indirect quote:

If the foot should say that it is not part of the body because it is not a hand,

12:15c
that would not make it any less a part of the body.

- it does not stop being part of the body because it said that.
- Even though it is not a hand, it is still a part of the body.

that would not make it any less a part of the body: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

even though it speaks like that, it is not possible that it is not part of the body

even though it says that, it is still part of the body

even though it is not a hand, it is a part of the body

1 Corinthians 12:16

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church
In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:16a
And if the ear should say,

- And if the ear says,
- And as another example, suppose an ear were to say that

12:16b
“Because I am not an eye, I do not belong to the body,”

- “I am not an eye so I do not belong to the body,”
- it does not belong to the body because it is not an eye.

12:16c
that would not make it any less a part of the body.

- it does not stop being part of the body because it said that.
- Even though it is not an eye, it is still a part of the body.

12:16a–c
And if the ear should say, “Because I am not an eye, I do not belong to the body,” that would not make it any less a part of the body: The words in this verse are very similar to 12:15. This is also a situation that cannot occur. Consider using the same sentence structure that you used in 12:15.

1 Corinthians 12:17

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church
In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:17a

If the whole body were an eye, where would the sense of hearing be?

- If the whole body was nothing but an eye, how would it hear sound?
- If the body of a person is only an eye, it is not able to hear anything.

If the whole body were an eye, where would the sense of hearing be?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement. He stated that if the whole body were an eye, it would not be able to hear.

Here are some ways to translate this strong statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

If the whole body were just an eye only, how could it hear sound?

If in the body there were only eyes, how would it hear what people say?

- Use a statement. For example:

If the whole body was only an eye, we couldn't hear anything

If the body of a person was all eyes, then he could not hear sound

Translate this in a way that is natural for showing emphasis in your language.

12:17b

If the whole body were an ear, where would the sense of smell be?

- If the whole body was nothing but an ear, how would it be able to smell aromas?
- If the body of a person is only an ear, it is not able to smell anything.

If the whole body were an ear, where would the sense of smell be?: This is a rhetorical question on the same pattern as 12:17a. You should probably translate it in a similar way to 12:17a.

1 Corinthians 12:18

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church
In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believ-

ers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:18a

But in fact, God has arranged the members of the body, every one of them,

- But the truth is, God has arranged every one of the parts in the body
- But actually the body is not like that. God has placed all the limbs and organs in the body

But in fact: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as But in fact introduces the real situation. This is in contrast with verses 12:15–16 which were about situations that cannot occur.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

But the truth is

But actually the body is not like that

God has arranged the members of the body: The Greek word that the BSB translates as arranged means “placed” or “put.” God designed and arranged the human body when he created mankind.

the members: The word members refers to all the limbs and organs that make up the human body. See the note on 12:12a.

every one of them: The phrase every one of them is emphatic in Greek. The GNT shows this emphasis by translating it as:

every different part (GNT)

12:18b

according to His design.

- in just the way he wanted them to be.
- right in the place he decided they should be.

according to His design: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as according to His design is literally “just as he willed/wished.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

as he decided/chose

according to his heart

1 Corinthians 12:19

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:19

If they were all one part, where would the body be?

- If they were all the same part, how could there be a body?
- If all the parts were the same, there would be no body.

If they were all one part, where would the body be?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it to make a strong statement. He emphasized that in this situation there would be no body.

Here are some ways to translate this strong statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

If they were all the same part, how could it be called a body?

- Use a statement. For example:

It could not be a body if there was only one part.

If the whole body was one arm or one eye, it would not be a body.

Translate this strong statement in the most natural way in your language.

1 Corinthians 12:20

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:20

As it is, there are many parts, but one body.

- Actually, there are many parts but they form one body.
- But this is the truth, the body has many parts, but there is only one body.

As it is: The phrase As it is introduces the real situation. This real situation contrasts with the impossible situation suggested in 12:19.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

actually

but this is really the truth

there are many parts, but one body: This is the real situation. The body consists of many parts. All the limbs and organs together form one body.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

there are many parts, but they form one body

the body has many parts, but there is only one body

1 Corinthians 12:21

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:21a

The eye cannot say to the hand, “I do not need you.”

- ¶ An eye cannot say to a hand, “I have no need of you.”
- ¶ The eyes cannot tell the hands that they are unnecessary.

The eye cannot say to the hand: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

An eye cannot say to a hand

The eyes cannot tell the hands

I do not need you: In your translation, use an expression that expresses scorn. The eye is saying that it can live alone and that the hand is unnecessary.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I have no need of you.

You are unnecessary/worthless to me!

12:21b

Nor can the head say to the feet, “I do not need you.”

- And also a head cannot say to a foot, “I have no need of you.”
- And also the head cannot tell the feet that they are unnecessary.

Nor can the head say to the feet: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Nor is more literally “Or again.” It is often used for a series of similar quotations or sayings.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

And also the head cannot say to the feet

Furthermore, the head cannot say to the feet

can the head say to the feet: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

can a head say to a foot

can the head tell the feet

I do not need you: This is the same phrase as in 12:21a. In the Greek the pronoun you changes from the singular to the plural. Consider if it is natural in your language to use the same wording or to vary it a bit.

General Comment on 12:21a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as indirect speech. For example:

That’s why the eyes cannot say they don’t need the hands. That’s also why the head cannot say it doesn’t need the feet. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 12:22

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:22

On the contrary, the parts of the body that seem to be weaker are indispensable,

- Actually, the body parts that appear to be not important are the ones we^(incl) need very much.
- But this is the truth, there are limbs and organs that we/people think have no use, but we cannot live without them.

On the contrary: The phrase On the contrary introduces the true situation, in contrast to the impossible situation in 12:21.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Actually

But this is really the truth

the parts of the body that seem to be weaker: Some parts of the body appear weaker or less important than others. Paul did not say which parts these are. He may have thought of the organs inside the body.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the parts that seem to be weak/soft

the parts that we think are not important/strong/needed

the parts that seem to have no use/value

are indispensable: The Greek word that the BSB translates as indispensable means “necessary, essential.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

we need them very much

we cannot live without them

the body must have those parts

1 Corinthians 12:23

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order

to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:23a

and the parts we consider less honorable, we treat with greater honor.

- In fact, those parts that we^(incl) think lack honor, we clothe them with honor.
- There are limbs and organs that we think are less worthy. We honor/respect them more than the other parts.

and the parts we consider less honorable: Some parts of the body seem to have less “honor.” Paul did not say which parts these are. He may have thought of the part of the body that we cover with clothing.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the parts we^(incl) judge to be less honorable

the parts we think don’t have value/worth

the parts we don’t think highly of

we treat with greater honor: We treat these parts with greater honor by covering them with clothing. You may find it helpful to mention clothing in your translation.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

we clothe them with honor/carefully

we care for them well

we honor/respect them more than the other parts

12:23b

And our unpresentable parts are treated with special modesty,

- Those parts that nobody should see, we^(incl) are very modest/polite with them,
- Those areas that we cannot show we take care to cover them well,

And our unpresentable parts: This refers to a person's private parts. They are unpresentable in the sense that people do not show them in public.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the parts that nobody should see

the parts that we cannot show

the parts that are private

are treated with special modesty: The phrase that the BSB translates as are treated with special modesty is more literally "have greater modesty." This indicates that people cover these parts so that others will not see them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

we^(incl) are very modest/polite with them

we take care to cover/hide them well

we decorate them with clothing

1 Corinthians 12:24

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:24a

whereas our presentable parts have no such need.

- but the areas that people can see do not need this.
- but we^(incl) do not cover the parts that we can show.

whereas: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as whereas shows a contrast. It shows the contrast between the "unpresentable parts" of 12:23b and the "presentable parts" of 12:24a. It can be translated as:

but

our presentable parts have no such need: This refers to the parts of the body that can be seen, such as the face and hands. It is in contrast to the "parts that are unpresentable" in 12:23b.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

but the parts that people can look at do not need this

but the parts that we can show, we don't have to be modest/polite about them

but the parts that are not private, we don't have to cover them

12:24b

But God has composed the body

- But God has put together the parts of the body.
- But God has arranged/organized all the organs and limbs

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a transition in the argument. Paul moved from discussing how people treat their bodies to how God made the human body. Consider how it is natural to make this transition in your language.

God has composed the body: This refers to the human body. God designed the human body and put its parts together.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

God has arranged/organized all the parts of the body

God has put together the body parts

12:24c
and has given greater honor to the parts that lacked it,

- He has given more honor to the parts that we think don't have honor,
- so that the parts which we think are not important become more important.

and has given greater honor to the parts that lacked it: The phrase the parts that lacked it means “the body parts that lack honor.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and God has given honor to the parts that we think don't have honor

and the parts that we think are not important, God made them be important

1 Corinthians 12:25

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:25a
so that there should be no division in the body,

- in order that the body should not be divided/split up,
- God has done this so that the body parts will not divide/split into factions.

so that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so that introduces God's purpose in creating the body in the way he did. This purpose is indicated in negative terms here, and in positive terms in 12:25b.

there should be no division in the body: This is a negative purpose clause. God gave more honor to the parts that needed it in order that the body will not

split apart. In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence, such as:

God did this so that the body will not have divisions

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as a positive purpose. For example:

so that there will be unity in the body

so that the body will be one

division: The Greek word that the BSB translates as division refers to disagreement among people who should be united. The same Greek word is used in 1:10 and 11:18b See how you translated it there.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

(you will not) separate into different groups

(you will not) argue with each other

body: In the earlier verses 12:12–24 Paul talked about a physical body and its parts. However, now in this verse he starts to change the meaning of body. In 12:27 he uses body to mean the church which is the body of Christ.

12:25b
but that its members should have mutual concern for one another.

- but that its parts should care about one another equally.
- Instead they will all help each other in the same way.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but signals a contrast.

If you have translated the previous clause as a positive statement, you may need to use the word “and” here. For example:

(so that there will be unity in the body) and that its parts will have equal concern for each other

that its members should have mutual concern for one another: This is a positive purpose clause. God gave more honor to the parts of the body that needed it in order that all the parts will care about one another.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

all the members will take care of each other
equally

all the members will help each other in the same
way

concern: The word concern refers to caring about others. This is a figure of speech called a personification. The different body parts are pictured as people who care for one another. Although Paul talked about the human body, he intended his readers to think about the church, the body of Christ and how its members should care for one another.

General Comment on 12:24b-25b

In some languages it may be natural to break this long sentence up into two or more separate sentences. For example:

God himself has put the body together in such a way as to give greater honor to those parts that need it. And so there is no division in the body, but all its different parts have the same concern for one another. (GNT)

1 Corinthians 12:26

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the
body

About spiritual gifts

12:26a

If one part suffers, every part suffers with it;

- If one part suffers, all the other parts suffer with it.
- If one of its members is in pain, all the rest feel the pain as well.

If one part suffers, every part suffers with it: Paul talked about the human body, but he expected his readers to apply this metaphor to the members of the body of Christ, the church.

suffers: In the context of the human body, suffers refers to feeling pain. But Paul also had the picture of the body of Christ in mind. The people in the church might suffer in other ways. It is good to translate with a word that could include emotional suffering and poverty as well as physical pain.

12:26b

if one part is honored, every part rejoices with it.

- If one part receives honor, all the other parts are happy too.
- If someone praises one member, all the rest share its joy.

if one part is honored: The phrase is honored is a passive. Here are two ways to translate this clause:

- with a passive verb. For example:

if one part of our body is praised/honored

- with an active verb. For example:

if one part receives honor

if somebody praises one of the parts

every part rejoices with it: The word rejoices may refer to feeling happiness or well-being. It is good to translate using a word that could refer to people rejoicing that another person in the church has received honor.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the other parts are glad

the other parts also feel happy

1 Corinthians 12:27

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:27a

Now you are the body of Christ,

- ¶ As for you^(plur), you together form the body of Christ,
- ¶ You are like the body of Christ,

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now introduces a change in topic. It is not a time word. Paul stopped discussing the image of the human body and started discussing how the image applies to Christ's body, the church.

You should introduce this new part of Paul's argument in a way that is natural in your language.

you are the body of Christ: The Greek pronoun you is plural and means "all of you together." The body in this verse is no longer the human body. Paul began to talk about the church as a whole, which is Christ's body. In some languages it may be helpful to make it clear that Paul referred to the believers as a group. For example:

you^(plur) believers are the body of Christ

we^(incl) are all the body of Christ

This is a figure of speech. In some languages it may be clearer to make this explicit with the word "like." For example:

you^(plur) are like the body of Christ

12:27b

and each of you is a member of it.

- and every one of you^(plur) is a part of the body.
- and individually you are like its limbs and organs.

and each of you is a member of it: Paul talked about the believers as individuals. He explained what his figure of speech meant for the individual Christian. Each Christian is like one of the limbs or organs of the

body of Christ. In some languages it may be helpful to make explicit the meaning of the pronoun it.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and each one of you^(plur) is like a member of the body

and you are all included in the body of Christ

and individually you are like its limbs and organs

General Comment on 12:27a-b

In some languages it may be natural to follow the RSV and use the same subject for the two parts of 12:27:

Now you are the body of Christ and individually members of it. (RSV)

1 Corinthians 12:28

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:28a

And in the church God has appointed first of all apostles,

- And in the church God chose in the first place the apostles.
- Among the believers, there are responsibilities that God gave to people. The most important of these is to be God's representative.

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces a thought that follows naturally from and builds upon the previous one. You should make a natural connection between 12:27b and 12:28a.

in the church: The phrase in the church refers to the group of believers in Corinth. It does not refer to a church building.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

among the believers

in the body of Christ

God has appointed: The word appointed means “chosen” or “selected to do a job.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

God chose

God gave to people responsibilities

first of all: Most commentators agree that first of all means “first in importance” rather than “first in time.”

Here are some other ways to translate this linking word:

the most important of these is

first in importance

first in rank

apostles: The Greek word that the BSB translates as apostles means “people who are sent.” It refers to the people Jesus sent with authority to represent him and perform a task or mission for him. Jesus chose twelve people to be his apostles (Mark 3:14). The term “apostle” is also used to refer to Matthias (Acts 1:26), and Paul and Barnabas (Acts 14:14). See the note on “apostle” at 1 Corinthians 1:1a.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Translate the meaning of the Greek word apostles. For example:

people sent on a mission for Jesus Christ

Christ’s messengers

representatives of Jesus Christ

- Indicate the role or function of the apostles. For example:

leaders of Jesus’ work

people who are in charge of Jesus’ work

Be careful to choose different terms for “apostle,” “angel,” “elder,” and “prophet.” See also Apostle in the Key Biblical Terms.

12:28b

second prophets, third teachers,

- In the second place he chose prophets and in the third place teachers.
- The second most important are those who speak messages from God. The third most important are those who teach God’s word.

second prophets, third teachers: This continues to list the leaders that God appointed for the church. Paul numbered them to show the order of their importance in the church.

prophets: A “prophet” is one who speaks God’s message. The message may sometimes involve foretelling the future, and also telling people the things that God says.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

those who speak messages from God

those who tell the words of God

teachers: The word teachers refers to those who explain to others the meaning of God’s word. Teachers taught both adults and children.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

those who teach God’s word

those who teach spiritual truth

12:28c

then workers of miracles, and those with gifts of healing,

- Then he chose those who can perform miracles and those with the ability to heal others.
- Then there are people who can do amazing things, and also those with the ability to remove sickness.

then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as then introduces other people who work for Christ in the church but are not the main leaders. It is not a time word.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

also

in addition to these people there are

The workers that follow are not listed in order of importance. In the Greek, the list that follows is a list of spiritual gifts. Many English versions translate it as a list of people who have those gifts.

workers of miracles: The Greek word that the BSB translates as workers of miracles is literally “powers.” It refers to the ability that God gave people to do supernatural things. The BSB translated it as a person who has this ability. See Miracle in the Glossary.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

those who do miracles

those who do amazing things

people to whom God gave the work of doing miracles

and those with gifts of healing: The Greek phrase that the BSB has translated as those with gifts of healing is literally “gifts of healings.” It refers to the ability to heal those who are ill. The BSB translated it as a person who has this ability. See how you translated gifts of healing in 12:9b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

those who have the ability to heal/cure sick people

those with the ability to remove sickness

people to whom God gave the work of healing others

gifts: A “gift” is an ability given by the Holy Spirit. See how you translated this in 12:1 and 12:4.

12:28d
helping, administration,

- He chose those who can help others, those who can look after the church,
- There are those who can help others, and those with the ability to organize the affairs of the believers,

helping: The Greek word that the BSB translates as helping is literally “helps” or “helpful deeds.” It refers to an ability to assist other Christians in practical ways.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

those who have the ability to help their companions

people to whom God gave the work of helping others

administration: The Greek word that the BSB translates as administration refers to an ability to direct and manage the church.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

those who have the ability to look after the church

those with the ability to organize the affairs of the believers

people to whom God gave the work of administration

12:28e
and various tongues.

- and those who can speak in various unknown tongues.
- and those who can speak in unknown/miraculous languages.

and various tongues: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as various tongues is literally “types of tongues.” The word tongues refers to speech uttered by people who do not know the meaning of what they are saying. These tongues may be foreign languages that the Spirit enables the person to speak, or they may be speech that is not a real language of this world. See the note on 12:10d.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

those who have the ability to speak in various languages

those who can speak in unknown/miraculous languages

those who can speak in languages that they have not learned

those who can speak in languages given to them by the Holy Spirit

1 Corinthians 12:29

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:29–30

In these two verses there is a series of seven rhetorical questions. Paul used them all as strong negative statements. He hoped that people would respond “No” to all of them.

Here are some ways to translate these negative statements:

- Use rhetorical questions. For example, the NET translates them as questions that imply the response “No”:

Not all are apostles, are they? Not all are prophets, are they? Not all are teachers, are they? Not all perform miracles, do they? Not all have gifts of healing, do they? Not all speak in tongues, do they? Not all interpret, do they? (NET)

- Use statements. For example:

Not everyone is an apostle. Not everyone is a prophet. Not everyone is a teacher. Not everyone can work miracles. Not everyone can heal the

sick. Not everyone can speak different kinds of languages. Not everyone can tell what these languages mean. (CEV)

In both the NET and CEV, as in the Greek, the pattern or form of each sentence is the same. In some languages such repetition may be unnatural. In those languages it may be necessary to use varied structures. The second meaning lines in the Display suggest some ways to vary the sentence forms.

12:29a

Are all apostles?

- Are they/you all apostles? No.
- You know that the Lord did not send everyone as a special messenger in his work.

Are all apostles?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul stated that everyone knows that not all believers are apostles. This was not new information to Paul’s readers.

all: The word all refers to “all believers.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

all believers

all of you^(plur)

all of us^(incl)

apostles: This is the same word as in 12:28. You should translate it the same way that you did there.

Here are some ways to translate this rhetorical question:

Are all believers apostles? No!

Not all of you^(plur) are apostles, are you?

You know that not all of us^(incl) are apostles.

Not all believers are apostles.

12:29b

Are all prophets?

- Are they/you all prophets? No.
- God did not inspire all of us^(incl) to declare his message.

Are all prophets?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul's readers knew that not everyone is a prophet.

Here are some other ways to translate this rhetorical question:

Are all believers prophets? No!

Not all of you^(plur) are prophets.

12:29c

Are all teachers?

- Are they/you all teachers? No.
- We^(incl) are not all teachers of God's word.

Are all teachers?: This is a rhetorical question. The word teachers refers to those who explain to others the meaning of God's word. Translate this the same as you did in 12:28.

Here are some other ways to translate this rhetorical question:

Are all believers teachers? No!

Not all of you^(plur) are teachers.

12:29d

Do all work miracles?

- Are they/you all able to do miracles? No.
- Not all of us^(incl) can do miracles.

Do all work miracles?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul's readers knew that not everybody can do miracles.

Here are some other ways to translate this rhetorical question:

Are all believers able to do miracles? No!

Not all of you^(plur) can do miraculous things.

1 Corinthians 12:30

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:30a

Do all have gifts of healing?

- Are they/you all able to heal others? No.
- Not all of us^(incl) can heal sick people.

Do all have gifts of healing?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul's readers knew that not everybody has the gift of healing.

Here are some other ways to translate this rhetorical question:

Do all believers have the gift of being able to heal the sick?

Not all of you^(plur) have the ability to heal those who are sick.

gifts of healing: Translate gifts of healing the same as you did in 12:28.

12:30b

Do all speak in tongues?

- Can they/you all speak in unknown tongues? No.
- We^(incl) do not all speak in unknown/miraculous languages.

Do all speak in tongues?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul's readers knew that not everybody can speak in tongues.

Here are some other ways to translate this rhetorical question:

Can all believers speak in various languages? No!

Not all of you^(plur) can speak in unknown/miraculous languages.

12:30c

Do all interpret?

- Can they/you all explain the meaning of those languages? No.

- And not all of us^(incl) can translate/interpret those languages.

Do all interpret?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul referred to interpreting the tongues he had just mentioned. He said that not everyone is able to explain the meaning when people speak in tongues.

Here are some other ways to translate this rhetorical question:

Are all believers able to explain the meaning of those languages? No!

Not all of you^(plur) are able to interpret/translate when people speak those languages.

1 Corinthians 12:31

Section 12:1–31: Use spiritual gifts to help the church

In this section Paul wrote about different spiritual gifts, or abilities, that the Holy Spirit gives to believers. He listed some of these spiritual gifts and taught that God gave them to us to help the church. He compared the body of Christ with the human body in order to explain that all of the spiritual gifts are important to the church.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Using spiritual gifts

God gives spiritual gifts to each member of the body

About spiritual gifts

12:31a

But eagerly desire the greater gifts.

- But, you should want very much to have the most useful gifts.
- However, try hard to get the more helpful/valuable gifts.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces something that Paul wanted his readers to do that was related to what he had been talking about. Some English versions do not explicitly translate it. Here is another way to translate this:

And in any event (NLT)

eagerly desire the greater gifts: Paul urged his readers to long for, and try to get, the more important gifts.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

want very much to have the more important gifts

try hard to get the very good gifts

strongly desire to receive the most valuable abilities

In some languages there is an idiomatic way to say eagerly desire such as:

place your breath/heart in the greater gifts

focus on the greater gifts

greater: The word greater means “more important” in the sense of more useful or more valuable in the church. Some Greek manuscripts read “better” instead of “greater.” This reading is followed by the KJV (“the best gifts”) and CEV. The UBS Greek text (4th edition) does not mention this variant. Some of the spiritual gifts were more helpful to the church than others.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

greatest/highest

most valuable/useful/helpful

gifts: A “gift” is an ability given by the Holy Spirit. See how you translated this in 12:1 and 12:4.

12:31b

And now I will show you the most excellent way.

- ¶ And now I will show you^(plur) the best way of all.
- ¶ Now I will tell you^(plur) the best path of all (the path of love)

Some English versions follow the UBS Greek text and begin a new section at this point. See the BSB, the NIV84, the NJB, and the NLT. However, most English versions begin the new section at 13:1. See the GNT, RSV, CEV, KJV, NET, NASB, GW, NCV.

And now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as And now introduces a comment that both concludes this section and introduces a new section developing a different theme.

I will show you: The phrase I will show you can also be translated as:

I will tell you^(plur)

I want to show you

the most excellent way: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the most excellent way is more literally a comparative, “a more excellent way.” Paul said that what he was about to talk about is better than any of the spiritual gifts.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the way that is better than any other way

the path that is greatest of all (which is the path of love)

1 Corinthians 13:1

Section 13:1–13 Love endures forever

In this section Paul talked about the importance of love. He described how a person who loves will behave toward others. He concluded that love is more important than any of the spiritual gifts. One day all the spiritual gifts will cease, but love will never cease.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Love

Paul urged believers to act in love

The way of love

Paragraph 13:1–3

In this paragraph Paul said that love is more important than the spiritual gifts. Without love the spiritual gifts are worthless.

Each verse in this paragraph has the same structure. Each has some conditions, followed by the words “but do not have love,” followed by the thing that will result if the conditions are true.

13:1a-c

If I speak in the tongues of men and of angels, but have not love, I am only a ringing gong or a clanging cymbal: Paul talked about a hypothetical situation. There are two conditions followed by the result that will come if the conditions are true. The first condition

is that he speaks in the tongues of men and of angels, and the second condition is that he does not have love. The result is that he is like a ringing gong or a clanging cymbal.

If...but...I am...: The BSB introduces the first condition with the word If, and introduces the words “do not have love” with the word but. These two phrases are in contrast. The BSB does not use a conjunction to introduce the result. Think about the conjunctions that will be clear in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate these conjunctions:

even if...but...then I am...

even though...yet if...then I am...

what if/supposing...if...then I am...

13:1a

If I speak in the tongues of men and of angels,

- ¶ If I speak in the languages of people and the languages of angels,
- ¶ Somebody may speak in tongues like people speak and even like angels.

the tongues of men and of angels: Paul talked about the spiritual gift of speaking in tongues. Some people think that Paul talked about speaking eloquent words in the normal languages of people and angels. See for example, Barrett 1968. See the note on tongues in 12:10d.

men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as men refers to people, both men and women.

and of angels: Paul talked about the languages of angels. Probably some Corinthians understood that when they spoke in tongues they used a language that angels speak in heaven.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If I speak in the languages of people and the languages of angels

Even though I spoke the languages of human beings and even of angels

If I have the spiritual gift of speaking in tongues like people do, and my gift sounds like angel speech

13:1b**but have not love,**

- but do not love other people,
- But if that person does not have a heart of love,

but have not love: Throughout this chapter the Greek word that the BSB translates as love refers to a concern for the well-being of other people. It does not refer to sexual desire. In some languages it may be necessary to translate love as a verb.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

but if I lack love

but if I do not love other people

but I do not act with love toward others

but I do not have a heart/stomach/kidneys of love

13:1c**I am only a ringing gong or a clanging cymbal.**

- I am like a noisy gong or a crashing cymbal.
- their speech is meaningless like a person banging on a gong or a cymbal.

I am only a ringing gong or a clanging cymbal: This is a metaphor. It describes what his speech will be like if he does not have love.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I am like a ringing gong or a clanging cymbal

the words I say would be like a person banging a gong or a cymbal

I am only: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as I am only is literally “I have become.” The BSB has supplied the word only to suggest that it is not good to be a resounding gong or a clanging cymbal. The GNT supplies different words to indicate this:

my speech is no more than a noisy gong or a clanging bell (GNT)

ringing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as ringing means “loud,” or “noisy.”

gong: A gong is a metal object that a person hits to produce a loud sound. A gong does not have a clear musical pitch.

clanging: Paul talked about noises that are not pleasant to listen to. In some languages there may be a word that imitates harsh sounds. The same word is used in Mark 5:38 .

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

a noisy cymbal

a noisy for nothing cymbal

a cymbal that they hit randomly

a cymbal that makes a sound “grank-grank”

cymbal: A cymbal is a musical instrument made of metal in the shape of a shallow dish. The musician hits two cymbals together to produce a loud sound. If people where you live do not know about cymbals, you may need to substitute a similar instrument, such as a bell.

General Comment on 13:1a-b

In some languages it may be natural to break up this verse into shorter sentences. Here are some ways to do this:

I may speak in the languages of humans and of angels. But if I don't have love, I am a loud gong or a clashing cymbal. (GW)

Some people speak in the tongues of people and of angels but they do not love others. The tongues they speak are no better than resounding gongs and clanging cymbals.

1 Corinthians 13:2**Section 13:1–13 Love endures forever**

In this section Paul talked about the importance of love. He described how a person who loves will behave toward others. He concluded that love is more important than any of the spiritual gifts. One day all the spiritual gifts will cease, but love will never cease.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Love

Paul urged believers to act in love

The way of love

Paragraph 13:1–3

In this paragraph Paul said that love is more important than the spiritual gifts. Without love the spiritual gifts are worthless.

Each verse in this paragraph has the same structure. Each has some conditions, followed by the words “but do not have love,” followed by the thing that will result if the conditions are true.

13:2a–e

In Greek, this verse starts with a conjunction that the BSB does not translate. It introduces a second example of how spiritual gifts are worthless without love. Some English versions translate this conjunction as “and.” Use the natural way in your language to introduce a second example.

If...and if...but...I am...: The BSB introduces two conditions with the words If and and if. It introduces “do not have love” with the word but. The BSB does not use a conjunction to introduce the result. Use conjunctions that will be clear in your language.

Here is another way to translate these conjunctions:

if...and if...but...then I am...

13:2a

If I have the gift of prophecy

- I may have received the spiritual gift of prophetic speech
- God may give somebody the gift of declaring his word to people.

If I have the gift of prophecy: The phrase the gift of prophecy refers to an ability that God gives people to declare his word. The Greek word is the same as in 11:4–5 and 12:10b and you should translate it in the same way.

13:2b

and can fathom all mysteries and all knowledge,

- and the gift of understanding all mysteries and all knowledge.
- He may make them able to understand all kinds of hidden things and know everything about God.

and can fathom all mysteries and all knowledge: The word fathom means “understand.” Paul spoke about the ability that God gives to understand spiritual things.

mysteries: The word mysteries refers to truths that are hidden and not understood by many people.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

secrets

deep words

hidden things

things that God has hidden

knowledge: The word knowledge refers to the spiritual gift of knowing about God and his ways. Refer to your translation of the word knowledge in 12:8b.

13:2c

and if I have absolute faith so as to move mountains,

- And I may have faith great enough that I can cause mountains to move.
- They may trust God enough to make a mountain move to another place.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and introduces another spiritual gift that a person might have.

if I have absolute faith so as to move mountains:

The phrase absolute faith so as to move mountains implies having such a large amount of faith that a person can do things that seem impossible. See the notes on Mark 11:23–24.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I am so full of faith that I can move mountains

I have faith so great that I can order a mountain and it will move to another place

faith: In some languages it may be natural to translate faith as a verb:

if I trust God enough to make mountains move

if I believe very much, so that I can make mountains move

13:2d

but have not love,

- But if I do not love other people,
- But if that person does not have a heart of love,

but have not love: This phrase is the same as that in 13:1b. Consider if it is good style in your language to use an identical phrase or to vary the wording.

13:2e

I am nothing.

- I am useless.
- then the things they do do not have any value.

I am nothing: The phrase I am nothing indicates that the words and deeds of a person without love do not have any value. They are not meaningful or useful.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the things I do don't have any value

my deeds are not important

I am useless

General Comment on 13:2a-e

In some languages it may be natural to break this long sentence into two or three short sentences. For example:

I may have the gift to speak what God has revealed, and I may understand mysteries and have all knowledge. I may even have enough faith to move mountains. But if I don't have love, I am nothing. (GW)

1 Corinthians 13:3

Section 13:1–13 Love endures forever

In this section Paul talked about the importance of love. He described how a person who loves will behave toward others. He concluded that love is more important than any of the spiritual gifts. One day all the spiritual gifts will cease, but love will never cease.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Love

Paul urged believers to act in love

The way of love

Paragraph 13:1–3

In this paragraph Paul said that love is more important than the spiritual gifts. Without love the spiritual gifts are worthless.

Each verse in this paragraph has the same structure. Each has some conditions, followed by the words “but do not have love,” followed by the thing that will result if the conditions are true.

13:3a–d

In Greek, this verse starts with a conjunction that the BSB does not translate. Some English versions translate it as “And.” It introduces examples of how personal sacrifices are worthless without love.

If...and...but...I gain...: The BSB introduces two conditions with the words If and and. It introduces “have not love” with the word but. The BSB does not use a conjunction to introduce the result. Think about the conjunctions that will be clear in your language.

Here is another way to translate these conjunctions:

if...and if...but...then I gain...

13:3a

If I give all I possess to the poor

- I may give all my belongings to poor people,
- Somebody may give everything they have to others,

If I give all I possess to the poor: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as I give all I possess to the poor is more literally “I distribute all my belongings.” The BSB added the words the poor to make the meaning clear.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I give away everything I have

I give all I have to poor people

I give all my possessions to help/feed poor people

13:3b

and exult in the surrender of my body,

- and allow people to kill me by burning my body.
- and they may be willing to be burnt to death for Christ.

and: In Greek, this phrase starts with two conjunctions. The BSB translates them as and. Some English versions translate them as “and if.” These conjunctions introduce a second personal sacrifice that a person might make.

exult in the surrender of my body: There is a textual issue here.

1. Some Greek manuscripts say “surrender my body to the flames.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I allow my body to be burned

I allow them to kill me by burning my body

I am willing to be burnt to death for Christ (NIV84, RSV, NJB, ESV, GNT, GW, REB, KJV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts say “surrender my body that I may boast.” For example:

give over my body to hardship, that I may boast (NIV11) (BSB, NIV11, NRSV, NLT, NET)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This is supported by many ancient manuscripts, and many English versions and commentaries. It is the second reading of the UBS Greek text. The 4th edition of the UBS Greek New Testament chooses the reading “that I may boast.” However, they give it a rating of “C,” indicating that “the Committee had difficulty in deciding which variant to place in the text.”

13:3c but have not love,

- But if I do not love other people,
- But if that person does not have a heart of love,

but have not love: This phrase is the same as in 13:1b and 13:2d. It is the third and final time that Paul said this phrase. Consider whether in your language it is good style to vary the words or use the same phrase.

13:3d I gain nothing.

- there is no benefit for me.
- they will not receive a reward.

I gain nothing: The phrase I gain nothing means that people who act without love will gain no reward from their good deeds. God will not reward them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

there is no benefit for me

I will not receive a reward.

General Comment on 13:3a-d

In some languages it may be natural to break up this long sentence into two, as the GW has done:

I may even give away all that I have and give up my body to be burned. But if I don't have love, none of these things will help me. (GW)

General Comment on 13:1-3

In this paragraph Paul wrote in the first person. He used himself as an example of any Christian. In some languages it may be natural to use “somebody” or “we” rather than “I” in order to show that Paul spoke of a general situation. For example:

If someone speaks in the tongues of men and of angels but has no love, he is a noisy gong or a clanging cymbal. And if he has the gift of prophecy...

If we^(incl) speak in the tongues of men and of angels but have no love, we^(incl) are like noisy gongs or clanging cymbals. And if we^(incl) have the gift of prophecy...

1 Corinthians 13:4

Section 13:1-13 Love endures forever

In this section Paul talked about the importance of love. He described how a person who loves will behave toward others. He concluded that love is more important than any of the spiritual gifts. One day all the spiritual gifts will cease, but love will never cease.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Love

Paul urged believers to act in love

The way of love

Paragraph 13:4-7

In this paragraph Paul used a figure of speech called personification. He wrote as though love is a person who behaves in certain ways. In some languages it may not be possible to say that an abstract idea like love does things. The notes and the meaning lines in the Display suggest some ways to remove this personification if it is necessary.

13:4a Love is patient, love is kind.

- ¶ Love endures patiently. Love is kind-hearted.
- ¶ If we love other people, we don't get angry with them easily, and we want to help them.

Love is patient: In some languages there is no noun for Love. It may be necessary to translate the abstract noun Love as a verb.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

A person who loves other people is patient with them

If we love other people we are patient with them

The person with a heart that loves is patient

To love is to be patient

patient: A patient person does not become angry but endures the imperfections and errors of others quietly.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

endures patiently

endures a long time

doesn't easily get angry

love is kind: A person who loves acts in a kind and gentle way to others. He or she is generous and thoughtful.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

a person who loves is kind-hearted to others

a person who loves is gentle to others

a person who loves wants to help other people

13:4b

It does not envy, it does not boast, it is not proud.

- Love is not jealous of others. It does not say that it is better than other people. It is not proud.
- If we love other people we are not angry that they have more than us. We do not praise ourselves. We do not think we are better than other people.

It does not envy, it does not boast, it is not proud:

This tells three things that a person who loves does not do. It is possible that in your language there are idioms that express these actions.

not envy: A person who feels envy for someone else gets upset or angry because that person has possessions, position, or accomplishments that we don't have.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

is not jealous

is not angry when other people have more than we do

not boast: A person who "boasts" talks about their own possessions, position, or accomplishments. They say they are superior to other people. In some languages there may be an idiom for this (such as the English "show off").

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

does not boast about what he has done

does not lift himself up

does not praise herself

not proud: The RSV puts this word "proud" in the beginning of verse 5. The Greek word that the BSB translates as proud is literally "puffed up." People who are proud think that they are better or more important than other people. See how you translated this word in 4:6 and 4:18.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

is not proud of what he has/is

does not think that he is better than other people

is not conceited/arrogant/haughty

In some languages it may be better to translate this as a positive statement. For example:

A person who loves is humble

The Greek idiom for proud is “puffed up,” as if somebody has blown air into the proud person. There may be a different idiom for pride in your language. Idioms in some languages include:

lift up one’s chin/nose

have a tall heart/liver

make one’s body high

1 Corinthians 13:5

Section 13:1–13 Love endures forever

In this section Paul talked about the importance of love. He described how a person who loves will behave toward others. He concluded that love is more important than any of the spiritual gifts. One day all the spiritual gifts will cease, but love will never cease.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Love

Paul urged believers to act in love

The way of love

Paragraph 13:4–7

In this paragraph Paul used a figure of speech called personification. He wrote as though love is a person who behaves in certain ways. In some languages it may not be possible to say that an abstract idea like love does things. The notes and the meaning lines in the Display suggest some ways to remove this personification if it is necessary.

13:5a-b

It is not rude, it is not self-seeking, it is not easily angered, it keeps no account of wrongs: Verse 5 tells four more things that a person who loves does not do.

13:5a

It is not rude, it is not self-seeking,

- Love does not act in a way that is not proper. Love is not selfish.
- If we love other people, we respect them. We do not think only about what is good for ourselves.

not rude: To be rude is to behave in ways that are not appropriate. A rude person offends or embarrasses other people. A loving person does not behave in this way. See how you translated this word in 7:36.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

does not act in a way that is not appropriate/
proper

does not disrespect other people

does not lack politeness

In some languages it may be better to translate this as a positive statement. For example:

A person who loves does what is appropriate/
proper

A person who loves is polite to others

A person who loves respects other people

not self-seeking: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as self-seeking is literally “look for one’s own things.” The Greek phrase and the English word self-seeking are both idioms that mean “selfish.” Selfish people care only about what they need. They are not concerned for the needs of others. People who love do not do this. They think of the good of other people and try to help them. See how you translated this idiom in 10:24a, and 10:33b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

is not selfish

does not demand that things happen his way

does not think only about what is good for herself

In some languages it may be better to translate this as a positive statement. For example:

A person who loves seeks the good of others

13:5b

it is not easily angered, it keeps no account of wrongs.

- Love does not become angry quickly. It does not remember the wrong things that other people do.
- If we love other people, we are slow to get angry at them. We don’t count up the ways they have hurt us.

not easily angered: The Greek word that the BSB translates as easily angered is literally “made sharp.” It is used figuratively to mean “made angry.” The BSB has added the word easily because the Bible does not condemn all anger.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

is not irritable/upset

is not quick to be angry

is slow to get angry

There may be an idiom for easily angered in your language. Idioms in some languages include:

hot heart/liver

short heart/liver

keeps no account of wrongs: The phrase keeps no account of wrongs indicates that people who love others does not continue to remember wrongs. They do not hold grudges or continue to hate a person who has hurt them.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

does not remember/think about wrongs

does not count/keep track of wrongs

In some languages it may be better to translate this as a positive statement. For example:

forgets/overlooks wrongs

wrongs: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wrongs is literally “evil.” It refers to what others have done to harm us.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

how other people have hurt us

other people’s sins

the wrong things that other people do

1 Corinthians 13:6

Section 13:1–13 Love endures forever

In this section Paul talked about the importance of love. He described how a person who loves will behave toward others. He concluded that love is more important than any of the spiritual gifts. One day all the spiritual gifts will cease, but love will never cease.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Love

Paul urged believers to act in love

The way of love

Paragraph 13:4–7

In this paragraph Paul used a figure of speech called personification. He wrote as though love is a person who behaves in certain ways. In some languages it may not be possible to say that an abstract idea like love does things. The notes and the meaning lines in the Display suggest some ways to remove this personification if it is necessary.

13:6

Love takes no pleasure in evil, but rejoices in the truth.

- Love does not rejoice when people do what is wrong. Instead, it rejoices when they live according to the truth.
- If we love other people, we are not pleased when they sin. Instead we are pleased when they do good deeds.

Love takes no pleasure in evil, but rejoices in the truth: These two phrases say the same thing in two opposite ways. If we love somebody we are not happy when that person does wrong. Rather, we are glad when they do what is right.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

Love isn’t happy when people do evil things, but it is happy when people do true/righteous things

takes no pleasure...rejoices in: The Greek words that the BSB translates as takes...pleasure and rejoices have the same meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

rejoice

be happy/joyful

takes no pleasure in: In some languages it may be better to translate this as a positive statement:

Love grieves when...

The person who loves is sorry when...

evil: The word evil means “unrighteousness.” It refers to sin, not to a natural disaster such as sickness or earthquake.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

wrong/injustice

evil deeds

when people do evil things

the truth: In this context the truth is used as the opposite of “unrighteousness” rather than as the opposite of “falsehood.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

live according to the truth

do things that are true/right

do good deeds

General Comment on 13:6

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses and put the positive statement first:

Love rejoices when people do what is right, but it is sad when people do what is evil.

1 Corinthians 13:7

Section 13:1–13 Love endures forever

In this section Paul talked about the importance of love. He described how a person who loves will behave toward others. He concluded that love is more important than any of the spiritual gifts. One day all the spiritual gifts will cease, but love will never cease.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Love

Paul urged believers to act in love

The way of love

Paragraph 13:4–7

In this paragraph Paul used a figure of speech called personification. He wrote as though love is a person who behaves in certain ways. In some languages it may not be possible to say that an abstract idea like love does things. The notes and the meaning lines in the Display suggest some ways to remove this personification if it is necessary.

13:7a

It bears all things, believes all things

- Love endures anything. Love trusts the people it loves.
- If we love other people, we are willing to endure all their faults patiently. We remain loyal to them in every situation.

It bears all things: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as bears comes from a word meaning “roof.” Its exact meaning is not certain. There are two main ways to interpret its meaning:

1. It means to endure or bear the failings of others. People who love others continue to love them when they disappoint them. For example:

Love bears all things (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NJB, NASB, ESV, NET, NLT, GNT, GW, NCV)

1. It means to protect, as a roof protects those under it. For example:

It always protects (NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is followed by most commentaries. See for example Fee p. 640. and versions.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Love never gives up (GNT)

Love puts up with all difficulties

Love endures other people’s faults

bears all things: The Greek word that the BSB translates as all things refers to all types of circumstances. It indicates that there are no limits to what a loving person can endure.

Here is another way to translate this word:

in everything

believes all things: The verb believes refers to trusting the person you love. This does not mean that a loving person is gullible or easily tricked. Instead, one who loves is loyal and faithful in difficult circumstances.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

love is loyal

love remains faithful to the people we love

love always wants to think that what they are doing is good

13:7b

hopes all things, endures all things.

- Love hopes for good in all circumstances. Love continues even when it is difficult.
- If we love other people, we always hope that they will do good things. We continue to love them no matter what they do.

hopes all things: The phrase “love...hopes all things” means that a loving person always hopes that the other person will do what is right.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

love hopes for all things that are good

love always hopes that the person we love will do good things

endures all things: The phrase endures all things means that a loving person continues to love someone no matter what they do. One who loves other people does not stop because of problems or difficulties.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

love continues even when it is difficult

love endures all manner of things

love never gives up

General Comment on 13:7a-b

In some languages a literal translation of this verse may suggest that a loving person is weak and permits others to do anything to them. It is important to avoid this wrong meaning and instead to imply that a loving person is strong. One way to do this is to translate the general statements in this verse as negatives, indicating the absence of limits. For example:

There is nothing love cannot face; there is no limit to its faith, its hope, its endurance. (REB)

Love never gives up; its faith, hope and patience never fail. (GNT)

1 Corinthians 13:8

Section 13:1–13 Love endures forever

In this section Paul talked about the importance of love. He described how a person who loves will behave toward others. He concluded that love is more important than any of the spiritual gifts. One day all the spiritual gifts will cease, but love will never cease.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Love

Paul urged believers to act in love

The way of love

13:8a

Love never fails.

- ¶ Love lasts for all time.
- ¶ If we love other people, we will love them forever.

Love never fails: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as fails is literally “falls down.” This is an idiom which means that love does not end or stop.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Love never ends (NET)

Love endures forever

A person who loves other people loves them forever

A heart that loves will never fail

13:8b-d

Paul spoke about three spiritual gifts: prophecies, tongues, and knowledge. He said that these gifts are less important than love because they are temporary. They are intended for the present age, whereas love is for the future age as well.

13:8b

But where there are prophecies, they will cease;

- But the spiritual gift of prophecy will be stopped.
- God gives some people the gift of declaring his word, but in the future he will not give it any more.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a contrast. In 13:8a Paul said love will last forever. In 13:8b he contrasted that with the spiritual gifts which will not last forever.

where there are prophecies, they will cease: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as where there are prophecies is literally “if prophecies.” It implies that people were using the spiritual gift of prophecy.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

there are prophecies, but they will end

on the topic of prophecies, they will end

people who prophesy, in the future they will not prophesy any more

prophecies: The Greek word is the same as in 11:4-5, 12:10b and 13:2 and you should translate it in the same way.

they will cease: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as they will cease is a passive verb and means “will be brought to an end.” See a similar form of the same verb in 1:28 and 2:6. The implied subject is God. God will no longer give people the gift of prophecy.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

God will bring prophecies to an end

people who prophesy, in the future they will stop prophesying

13:8c

where there are tongues, they will be restrained;

- The spiritual gift of tongues will be ended.
- God gives some people the gift of speaking in tongues, but in the future he will not give it any more.

where there are tongues, they will be restrained:

The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as where there are tongues is literally “if tongues.” It implies that people were using the spiritual gift of tongues.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

there are tongues, but they will end

on the topic of tongues, they will end

people who speak in tongues will stop

tongues: The Greek word is the same as in 12:10d and you should translate it in the same way.

they will be restrained: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as they will be restrained is a passive verb and means “they will be ended.” The implied subject is God. God will no longer give people the gift of tongues.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

God will bring tongues to an end

people who speak in tongues, in the future they will stop

13:8d

where there is knowledge, it will be dismissed.

- The spiritual gift of knowledge will be stopped.
- God gives some people the gift of knowing what he is doing, but in the future he will not give it any more.

where there is knowledge, it will be dismissed: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as where there is knowledge is literally “if knowledge.” It implies that people were using the spiritual gift of knowledge.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

there is the gift of knowledge, but it will end

on the topic of knowledge, it will end

people who have the gift of special knowledge
will not have it any more

knowledge: In 12:8b Paul talked about this spiritual gift and called it a “word of knowledge.” God gave some believers a special ability to understand God and the things that he is doing.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the spiritual gift of knowledge

words that help people know about God

knowledge that God reveals to people

it will be dismissed: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as it will be dismissed is the same verb as in 13:8a. It is a passive verb, and the implied subject is God. God will no longer give people the spiritual gift of knowledge.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

God will bring knowledge to an end

people who have the gift of knowledge, in the future they will not have it any more

General Comment on 13:8b-d

In this verse there are three verbs that the BSB translates as “cease,” “be restrained,” and “be dismissed.” In Greek the first and third verbs are the same. All three mean almost the same thing. Fee p. 644, footnote 17: “the change of verbs is purely rhetorical.” The BSB varied the words for reasons of good English style. In some languages it may be more natural to use the same word each time.

General Comment on 13:8a-d

In some languages it may be better to put 8a at the end of the verse. For example:

^{8b}Prophecies will cease, ^{8c}tongues will stop,
^{8d}knowledge will cease, ^{8a}but love will never cease.

^{8b}God causes people to speak for him, ^{8c}he causes people to speak in unknown languages, ^{8d}he gives people the gift of knowledge. These things will end, ^{8a}but love will never end.

1 Corinthians 13:9

Section 13:1–13 Love endures forever

In this section Paul talked about the importance of love. He described how a person who loves will behave toward others. He concluded that love is more important than any of the spiritual gifts. One day all the spiritual gifts will cease, but love will never cease.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Love

Paul urged believers to act in love

The way of love

13:9

For we know in part and we prophesy in part,

- For we^(incl) only know part of the truth about God. We can only prophesy part of the truth about God.
- For now we only know some spiritual matters and we can only declare some things about God.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces more information about how the spiritual gifts of knowledge and prophecy will come to an end.

we know in part and we prophesy in part: Paul wrote about spiritual gifts that God gives to people in this age. By these gifts he lets us know some truths about him. No Christian knows everything or prophecies all the truth about God and his ways.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

God lets us^(incl) know things, but we don’t know everything; God lets us prophesy but he doesn’t let us prophesy all things

we^(incl) only know part of the truth about God, and we can only prophesy part of the truth about God

we know...we prophesy...: The Greek words that the BSB translates as know and prophesy are verbs. In 12:8 through 13:8 these spiritual gifts have been referred to with nouns. The Greek says “knowledge” in 12:8 and 13:8. The Greek says “prophecy” (12:10, 13:2, 13:8) and “prophets” (12:28–29). In some languages you may be able to follow the Greek usage, but in some languages it may be necessary to use verbs throughout this passage.

1 Corinthians 13:10

Section 13:1–13 Love endures forever

In this section Paul talked about the importance of love. He described how a person who loves will behave toward others. He concluded that love is more important than any of the spiritual gifts. One day all the spiritual gifts will cease, but love will never cease.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Love

Paul urged believers to act in love

The way of love

13:10

but when the perfect comes, the partial passes away.

- But when what is perfect comes, what is imperfect will go away.
- In the future we will know these things fully, and the things we know only in part will come to an end.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but indicates a contrast between what things are like at the present time (13:9) and what things will be like in the future (13:10).

when the perfect comes, the partial passes away:

Paul wrote about what things will be like in eternity. At that time people will not need spiritual gifts and so they will come to an end.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

some day what is perfect will appear, and the things that are not perfect will disappear

the perfect: The phrase the perfect refers to the perfect knowledge of God and perfect knowledge of his will that we will have in the future.

In some languages there is no word for perfect and it may be possible to translate it as:

what is full/complete

that which has no faults

we will know/understand completely

the partial: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the partial refers to the spiritual gifts Paul mentioned in 13:9.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the things that are not full/complete

the things that we know only a little

passes away: The phrase passes away indicates that what is partial will come to an end. The Greek word is the same word that the BSB translated as “will cease” in 13:8b and “will be dismissed” in 13:8d. Paul spoke about the future. In some languages it may be natural to use the future tense:

will disappear

will end

1 Corinthians 13:11

Section 13:1–13 Love endures forever

In this section Paul talked about the importance of love. He described how a person who loves will behave toward others. He concluded that love is more important than any of the spiritual gifts. One day all the spiritual gifts will cease, but love will never cease.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Love

Paul urged believers to act in love

The way of love

13:11a

When I was a child, I talked like a child,

- When I was a child, I talked as a child talks.
- When I was a child, my words were like the words of a child.

In 13:11 Paul used the analogy of a child growing up to teach about spiritual gifts. Just as childish thoughts are appropriate when one is young, but are left behind when one is an adult, so the spiritual gifts are appropriate for the church now, but will be left behind in the future.

When I was a child: Use the word for a child who is old enough to speak but cannot yet speak well.

Paul used himself as an example of any person. In some languages there is a pronoun to use in a general situation, such as:

When we/they/someone were children

I talked like a child: When he was young, Paul spoke with some errors or childlike pronunciation. Continue to use the pronoun that is natural in your language. For example:

we/they/someone used to talk like children

my words were like the words of a child

13:11b

I thought like a child, I reasoned like a child.

- I thought as a child thinks. I reasoned as a child reasons.
- I thought in a childish way. I understood things the way a child does.

I thought like a child, I reasoned like a child: The verb thought refers to the opinions and attitudes one holds. The verb reasoned refers to making logical arguments. The verbs thought and reasoned are very similar.

Here are some other ways to translate these two words:

I thought like a child. I understood like a child

I thought with the attitudes and logic of a child

I felt like a child feels. I thought like a child thinks

General Comment on 13:11a-b

In some languages it may not be natural to repeat the phrase “like a child.” Instead, you could combine the phrases. For example:

When I was a child, I used to talk, think, and reason like a child.

13:11c

When I became a man, I set aside childish ways.

- When I became an adult, I stopped behaving like a child.
- When I grew big, I rejected the ways of a child.

When I became a man: Once again Paul used himself as an example of any person.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

when we/they/someone grew up

when I became big/old/mature/adult

At the time he wrote, Paul was an adult. It may be natural to translate this as:

now that I have grown up

I set aside childish ways: The Greek word that the BSB translates as set aside is more literally “destroyed.” Paul stopped speaking, thinking, and reasoning like a child.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I stopped acting in childish/childlike ways

I stopped speaking like a child speaks

I rejected/abandoned the ways of a child

1 Corinthians 13:12

Section 13:1–13 Love endures forever

In this section Paul talked about the importance of love. He described how a person who loves will behave toward others. He concluded that love is more important than any of the spiritual gifts. One day all the spiritual gifts will cease, but love will never cease.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Love

Paul urged believers to act in love

The way of love

13:12a

Now we see but a dim reflection as in a mirror;

- Now we^(incl) can only see things as though they were reflected in a mirror.
- In this present age we understand the things of God dimly, as though we were looking at them in a mirror.

In 13:12a-b Paul used the analogy of a mirror. When we try to understand God and his ways it is as if we are looking at them in a mirror. But in the future, we will understand them well, as if we are looking at them directly.

In Greek this verse starts with a conjunction that the BSB does not translate. Some English versions translate it as “for.” The conjunction indicates that 13:12 is an explanation of the analogy Paul used in 13:11.

Now: The word Now refers to the present time, and contrasts with “then” in verse 12b.

we see but a dim reflection as in a mirror: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as we see but a dim reflection as in a mirror is more literally “we look through a mirror in a riddle.” This metaphor means that at the present time we do not clearly understand the things of God. “Seeing” is a metaphor for “knowing” or “understanding.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

we^(incl) see things as if they were reflected in a mirror

We don’t understand God’s ways completely. It is like we are looking in a mirror and we only see a reflection

mirror: In ancient times mirrors were made of a polished metal such as bronze.

13:12b

then we shall see face to face.

- In the future we^(incl) shall see them as though we were face to face.
- But in the age to come we will understand the things of God clearly, like meeting somebody face to face.

then: The word then refers to the future, in the end times. It contrasts with “now” in verse 12a.

Here is another way to translate this word:

in the future

we shall see face to face: The phrase we shall see face to face continues the metaphor, and means that in the future we will clearly understand the ways of God.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

it will be like seeing Christ face to face

face to face: The phrase face to face is also found in Genesis 32:30 and Deuteronomy 34:10. It is a figure of speech indicating direct contact with somebody. There may be an idiom in your language for seeing someone in person.

Here are some idioms that are used in some languages:

one to one

forehead to forehead

in front of our eyes

13:12c

Now I know in part;

- Now I only know some things.
- In this present age what we^(incl) know about the ways of God is only partial.

In 13:12c-d Paul continued to talk about the spiritual gift of knowledge. In the present time this gift gives us partial knowledge. In the future we will know fully.

Now: The word Now refers to the present time, and contrasts with “then” in verse 12d.

I know in part: The phrase I know in part means that Paul (and everyone else) only knows a little bit about the ways of God.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I/we know only some things

what I/we know about the ways of God is only partial

13:12d

then I shall know fully, even as I am fully known.

- In the future I will know everything, just as God knows everything about me.
- But in the age to come we^(incl) will have full knowledge, as God has full knowledge of us.

then: The word then refers to the future, in the end times. It contrasts with “now” in verse 12c.

I shall know fully, even as I am fully known: This is a comparison. Paul said that we will know about God’s ways fully, in the same way that God knows us fully.

I shall know fully: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I will know everything

I will know clearly about the ways of God

even as I am fully known: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as fully known is a passive verb, and the implied subject is God. God knows all about us.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

just as God knows everything about me/us

as God has complete knowledge about me/us

1 Corinthians 13:13

Section 13:1–13 Love endures forever

In this section Paul talked about the importance of love. He described how a person who loves will behave toward others. He concluded that love is more important than any of the spiritual gifts. One day all the spiritual gifts will cease, but love will never cease.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Love

Paul urged believers to act in love

The way of love

13:13a

And now these three remain: faith, hope, and love;

- And now these three qualities endure: faith, hope, and love.
- And now there are three things that we must continue to do. We must believe God, hope in God, and love God and others.

And now: These words mark what follows as a final summary of both paragraph 13:8–12 and of section 13:1–12.

these three remain: There are two ways to interpret the meaning of the verb remain:

1. It means that these three things will remain forever. For example:

So these three things continue forever (NCV) (NCV, REB, NLT)

1. It means that these three things remain in existence at the present time. For example:

Meanwhile these three remain (GNT) (GNT)

Many English versions (such as the BSB) translate this in a way that allows both interpretations. If you must choose one interpretation, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). There is stronger support for it in the commentaries. See for example Fee p. 651, and Morris p. 184.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

endure/stay/stand

there are three things we will continue to do

these three: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

these three things

these three qualities/virtues

faith, hope, and love: In some languages it may be natural to translate these abstract nouns as verbs. It may also be necessary to supply objects.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

trust God, hope in God, and love God and others

we will believe, we will hope, we will love

13:13b

but the greatest of these is love.

- But the most important of the three is love.
- But to love God and others is the most important.

but the greatest of these is love: This states that love is greater than faith or hope. We will continue to love God and others for all eternity.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

but of these three, the biggest is love

but of these three, the most important is that we love each other

1 Corinthians 14:1

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:1–5

In this paragraph Paul resumed his discussion about spiritual gifts that he began in 12:31. He compared the gift of speaking in tongues and the gift of prophecy. He said that the gift of prophecy is more useful to the church.

14:1a

Earnestly pursue love

- ¶ Follow after love,
- ¶ Make your^(plur) goal be to love other people,

Earnestly pursue love: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Earnestly pursue love is a command in the plural.

Here are some other ways to translate this command:

Make love your aim (RSV, NJB)

It is love...that you should strive for (GNT)

You should seek after love (NCV)

In some languages love must be a verb rather than a noun. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Love^(plur) other people

Seek to have a heart which loves other people

14:1b

and eagerly desire spiritual gifts,

- and be eager to have the spiritual gifts,
- and try hard to have the gifts that the Holy Spirit gives.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and is often translated as “but.” There are two ways to interpret this word:

1. It indicates continuity. The Corinthians should pursue love and they should also desire the spiritual gifts. For example:

Pursue love, and desire spiritual gifts (GW) (BSB, GW, NIV, RSV, ESV, NET, NCV, KJV)

1. It indicates contrast. For example:

Make love your aim; but be eager, too, for spiritual gifts (NJB) (NJB, NLT, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is followed by the majority of English versions. See also Fee, p. 235. Paul said in the first part of chapter 13 that the Corinthians should have both love and the spiritual gifts.

eagerly desire: The phrase eagerly desire is a command in the plural. Paul wanted the believers to strongly desire to have the gifts that the Spirit gives.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

desire^(plur) very much

strongly want

try hard to have

In some languages there may be an idiom with this meaning. Idioms in some languages are:

set your heart/liver/stomach on having

focus on having

spiritual gifts: These words were used in 1 Corinthians 12:1a, and you should translate them the same way here.

14:1c**especially the gift of prophecy.**

- especially the gift of prophesying.
- The gift you should desire the most is the gift of declaring God's word to people.

especially the gift of prophecy: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as especially the gift of prophecy is more literally “especially that you may prophesy.” The BSB has supplied the word gift to make it clear that Paul talked about one of the spiritual gifts mentioned in 14:1b. Here, prophecy refers to the ability to declare God's word to people. This word was used in 1 Corinthians 11:4a and 12:10b and you should translate it the same way here.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

especially desire^(plur) to prophesy

the gift you should want especially strongly is the gift of prophecy

1 Corinthians 14:2**Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way**

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:1–5

In this paragraph Paul resumed his discussion about spiritual gifts that he began in 12:31. He compared the gift of speaking in tongues and the gift of prophecy. He said that the gift of prophecy is more useful to the church.

14:2a**For he who speaks in a tongue does not speak to men, but to God.**

- This is because a person who speaks in an unknown tongue does not address people, but addresses God.
- Those who speak in unknown/miraculous languages speak to God, not to people.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces a reason why believers should especially desire to prophesy.

he who speaks in a tongue does not speak to men, but to God: Other people could not understand what the person said who spoke in tongues. Only God could understand.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

If you speak in tongues, you do not speak to people but to God

Those who speak in the spiritual gift of tongues speak to God, but not to people

a tongue: This refers to the spiritual gift of speaking in tongues. This word was used in 12:10d and 13:1a and you should translate it in a similar way here.

men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as men is literally “people.” It includes both men and women.

14:2b**Indeed, no one understands him;**

- For no one understands him,
- Truly, nobody knows what they are saying,

Indeed: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Indeed introduces the grounds for Paul's statement that a person who speaks in tongues is not speaking to people.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

for (NET, ESV)

because (GNT)

since (NLT)

no one understands him: The phrase no one understands him means that no person can understand what a person who speaks in tongues is saying.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

no one can understand them

nobody knows what they are saying

14:2c

he utters mysteries in the Spirit.

- but he speaks mysteries by the Holy Spirit.
- but by the Spirit of God they speak hidden words.

There is a Greek conjunction which connects 14:2c to 14:2b. The BSB and some other English versions do not translate this conjunction. There are two ways to understand this conjunction:

1. It introduces a contrast. Even though no one understands the person who speaks in tongues, he speaks spiritual mysteries. For example:

but he utters mysteries in the Spirit (ESV) (ESV, KJV, NLT, NASB, RSV)

1. It introduces a reason. It tells the reason why no one understands the person who speaks in tongues. For example:

for he speaks divine mysteries in the Spirit (REB) (REB, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because translation and commentary support for it is stronger. See, for example, Kistemaker, p. 477.

he utters mysteries: The phrase he utters mysteries indicates that anyone who speaks in tongues speaks hidden or secret things.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he speaks hidden matters/words

they speak deep words

in the Spirit: There are two ways to understand the meaning of the Greek word that the BSB translates as in the Spirit:

1. It refers to the Holy Spirit of God. For example:

in the Spirit (ESV) (BSB, ESV, NET, RSV, NJB, GNT, REB, CEV, NLT, NCV)

1. It refers to a person's own spirit. For example:

in his spirit (NASB) (NASB, NIV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) because translation and commentary support for it is stronger. See, for example, Thiselton, p. 1086, Fee, p. 657, Kistemaker, p. 477–478. According to 12:10–11, the person speaking in tongues spoke with the help of the Holy Spirit.

1 Corinthians 14:3

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:1–5

In this paragraph Paul resumed his discussion about spiritual gifts that he began in 12:31. He compared the gift of speaking in tongues and the gift of prophecy. He said that the gift of prophecy is more useful to the church.

14:3a

But he who prophesies speaks to men

- But someone who prophesies is speaking to people
- But those who declare God's word, speak to people

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a contrast to 14:2. The contrast is that those who speak in tongues speak to God, but those who prophesy speak to men. The RSV and NJB indicate this contrast with an English idiom:

On the other hand (NJB)

he who prophesies speaks to men: The phrase he who prophesies speaks to men implies that people who prophesy speak their message in a language that the listeners can understand.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

someone who prophesies speaks to other people (NJB)

those who proclaim God's message speak to people (GNT)

14:3b

for their edification, encouragement, and comfort.

- to strengthen them, to encourage them, and to comfort them.
- to build them up in their faith, to give them confidence, and to reassure them.

for their edification: The Greek word that the BSB translates as their edification is more literally "construction." This is a Greek idiom. It speaks as if a person is a building that is being built.

Here are some other ways to translate this Greek idiom:

to strengthen them spiritually

to build them up in their faith

to help them to believe more firmly

encouragement: When you "encourage" somebody, you give them hope or confidence.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

to encourage them

to give them confidence

In some languages there may be an idiom for this, such as:

so that their hearts/livers are strengthened

If there is an idiom that means the same thing in your language, you can use it here.

and comfort: When you comfort somebody, you give them hope about bad things that have happened.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

consolation

reassurance

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as a verb. For example:

to comfort them/their hearts

to make them feel better

to reassure them

General Comment on 14:3a-b

One important point in this verse is left implied. This point is that the listeners will be able to understand the one who prophesies. He will speak in a language they know. You may wish to follow the CEV and make this implied information explicit:

But when you prophesy, you will be understood, and others will be helped. They will be encouraged and made to feel better. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 14:4

Section 14:1-40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:1-5

In this paragraph Paul resumed his discussion about spiritual gifts that he began in 12:31. He compared the

gift of speaking in tongues and the gift of prophecy. He said that the gift of prophecy is more useful to the church.

14:4a

The one who speaks in a tongue edifies himself,

- The person who speaks in an unknown tongue strengthens himself,
- When people speak in unknown/miraculous languages they build themselves up in their faith.

The one...himself: The words one and himself refer to any person, either male or female. In some languages it may be better to translate this as a plural. For example:

those who speak in a tongue edify themselves

The one who speaks in a tongue: The phrase speaks in a tongue is the same as the phrase in 14:2a and you should translate it in the same way.

edifies himself: The Greek word that the BSB translates as edifies is more literally “constructs.” It is the same word that was translated as “edification” in 14:3b. This is a Greek idiom. It speaks as if a person is a building that is being built.

Here are some other ways to translate this idiom:

strengthens himself spiritually

builds himself up in his faith

helps himself to believe more firmly

There is some implied information here. He edifies only himself because nobody else can understand him. You may wish to make this implied information explicit. For example:

When somebody speaks in a tongue, others do not understand him, and he edifies only himself.

14:4b

but the one who prophesies edifies the church.

- but the person who prophesies strengthens the people in the church.
- When people declare God’s word they build up the group of believers in their faith.

but: The Greek word that the BSB translates as but indicates a contrast with 14:4a.

the one who prophesies edifies the church: The word prophesies is the same as in 14:1c and you should translate it in the same way. The word edifies is the same as in 14:4a and you should translate it in the same way.

There is some implied information here. He is able to edify the church because people understand what he is saying. You may wish to make this implied information explicit. For example:

When somebody prophesies, everybody understands him, and he edifies the whole church.

church: The word church refers to the community of believers, not to the building where they meet.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the group of believers

the Christian group

1 Corinthians 14:5

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:1–5

In this paragraph Paul resumed his discussion about spiritual gifts that he began in 12:31. He compared the gift of speaking in tongues and the gift of prophecy. He said that the gift of prophecy is more useful to the church.

14:5a

I wish that all of you could speak in tongues,

- I wish you^(plur) could all speak in an unknown tongue,
- My desire is for you all to speak in unknown/miraculous languages.

Verse 5 begins with a Greek conjunction that introduces a new thought. The BSB does not translate this conjunction. The RSV translates it as “Now.” Introduce this new thought in a way that is natural in your language.

I wish that all of you could speak in tongues: Paul wanted each of the Corinthian believers to speak in tongues. At the time he wrote, this was not the case.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I desire that you^(plur) all speak in tongues

I want all of you to have the spiritual gift of speaking in tongues

14:5b

but I would rather have you prophesy.

- but I wish even more that you could prophesy.
- However, my desire is greater for you to declare God’s word.

but I would rather have you prophesy: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but indicates a contrast with 14:5a. Paul made a comparison, saying that although he wanted the Corinthians to have the gift of tongues, he wanted even more for them to have the gift of prophecy.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

but even more I wish that you^(plur) could prophesy

but more than that I want you to have the spiritual gift of prophecy

14:5c

He who prophesies is greater than one who speaks in tongues,

- The one who prophesies is more important than the one who speaks in an unknown tongue.
- People who declare God’s word are doing something more valuable than are people who speak in unknown/miraculous languages.

He who prophesies is greater than one who speaks in tongues: The person who prophesies is greater in the sense that what he does is more valuable or more useful.

Here are some other ways to translate the word greater:

is more important

does something more valuable/useful/helpful

does a better thing

He: The word He refers to any person, either man or woman. In some languages it may be better to translate this as a plural. For example:

Those who prophesy are greater than those who speak in tongues

14:5d

unless he interprets so that the church may be edified.

- This is true unless he translates his message, so that people in the church are also strengthened.
- But if they explain what they mean so that the believers are built up in their faith, then that is valuable also.

unless he interprets: Paul said that if the people who speak in tongues explain what they mean, then their speech is just as valuable to the church as the prophesying.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

but if he interprets then this is also valuable/useful/helpful

he interprets: There are two ways to understand the subject of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as he interprets:

1. The one who interprets is the same as the person who spoke in tongues. For example:

unless they can interpret what they say (NJB) (BSB, NJB, NIV, NASB, REB, GW, NET, KJV)

1. The one who interprets is a different person. For example:

unless some one interprets (RSV) (RSV, GNT, NLT, CEV, ESV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the natural way to understand the Greek text.

interprets: The Greek word that the BSB translates as interprets refers to explaining the meaning of what is said in tongues.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

explains the meaning

puts into words

says it again in words that people understand

so that the church may be edified: If the speaker explains in normal language what he has just said in tongues, then the whole church can benefit from the message. The implied reason is that everyone will be able to understand him. In some languages it may be natural to make this implied reason explicit:

so that the church may understand and be edified

the church may be edified: This is a passive clause. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the church may be strengthened (NET)

- Use an active verb. For example:

so that the church may receive help

so that what he says may strengthen the whole church

1 Corinthians 14:6

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:6–12

In this paragraph Paul discussed why it is important for people to be able to understand what is said in church. He pointed out that it is not useful to speak in ways that no one can understand.

14:6

This verse contains a hypothetical condition followed by a rhetorical question. See the General Comment at the end of 14:6c for a suggested reordering of this verse.

14:6a

Now, brothers, if I come to you speaking in tongues,

- ¶ Brothers and sisters, suppose I come to you^(plur) and speak in an unknown tongue.
- ¶ Fellow believers, if I speak in unknown/miraculous languages when I visit you,

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now introduces the next point in the argument. It is not a time word. Translate it in a way that is natural in your language to introduce the next point in a discussion.

brothers: The word brothers refers to all the Christian believers in Corinth, both men and women.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

brothers and sisters

friends

if I come to you speaking in tongues: Paul talked about a hypothetical situation. He did not normally go to the Corinthians and speak to them in tongues. He described what it would be like if he did speak to them in tongues. Your translation should imply this.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

if I should come to you talking in an unknown language (NLT)

suppose...I come to you and speak in tongues (NJB)

14:6b**how will I benefit you,**

- How will I benefit/help you
- will that do you any good? No!

how will I benefit you...?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as an emphatic negative statement. It means “I will be no good to you” or “I will not benefit you.”

Here are some ways to translate this negative statement:

- Use a question. For example:

how would that help you? (NLT)

- Use a question with a response. For example:

will that help you?^(plur) No!

- Use an exclamation or strong statement of fact. For example:

obviously that will be of no help to you!

it wouldn't do you any good (GW)

Translate this emphatic negative statement in the most natural way in your language.

General Comment on 14:6a-b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of these two clauses. For example:

^{6b}what good would it do, ^{6a}if I came and spoke unknown languages to you...? (CEV)

^{6b}It will be no help to you ^{6a}if I come speaking unknown languages

14:6c**unless I bring you some revelation or knowledge or prophecy or teaching?**

- unless I also bring you a message that God has revealed to me, or some knowledge, or a prophecy, or some teaching?
- I will do good to you if I tell you something that God has shown to me, or if I speak a word of knowledge about God, or declare God's word, or teach you something.

unless I bring you some revelation or knowledge or prophecy or teaching:

Paul said that he would be useful to the Corinthians if he brought them a message that they could understand. In some languages it may be helpful to say explicitly that he referred to messages in a language they could understand. For example:

unless I bring you a revelation, knowledge, prophecy, or word of instruction in a language you can understand

In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

But if I bring you a revelation or some special knowledge or prophecy or teaching, that will be helpful. (NLT)

revelation: The word revelation refers to something that God had shown to Paul, and that Paul will tell the believers in ordinary language.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

a message that God has revealed to me

things from God that he has shown/opened to me

knowledge: The word knowledge refers to spiritual knowledge that Paul will tell them in their language. Compare how you translated this word in 12:8b.

Here is another way to translate this word:

a message that helps people know about God

prophecy: The word prophecy refers to a message from God in ordinary language. Compare how you translated this in 12:10b.

teaching: A teaching refers to some teaching in an ordinary language.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

I teach you something

General Comment on 14:6a-c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder 14:6 and say what will be useful to the Corinthians before saying what will not be useful. For example:

^{6c}If I bring you a revelation or knowledge or prophecy or word of instruction, then my coming will be useful to you. ^{6b}But it will not be useful ^{6a}if I just speak in tongues.

1 Corinthians 14:7

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:6–12

In this paragraph Paul discussed why it is important for people to be able to understand what is said in church. He pointed out that it is not useful to speak in ways that no one can understand.

14:7–8

In verse 14:6 Paul wrote about conveying meaning through speech. In verses 7–8 he wrote about some ways to convey meaning through inanimate objects. His point is that sound or noise is of no use by itself.

14:7

Even in the case of lifeless instruments, such as the flute or harp, how will anyone recognize the tune they are playing unless the notes are distinct?:

This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement.

Here are some ways to translate this strong statement:

- Use a question. For example:

It is similar for lifeless things that make a sound, like a flute or harp. Unless they make a distinction in the notes, how can what is played on the flute or harp be understood? (NET)

- Use a question with a response. For example:

Even in the case of lifeless instruments, such as the flute or harp, how will anyone recognize the tune they are playing unless the notes are distinct? No one!

- Use a strong statement. For example:

It is the same as with lifeless things that make sounds like a flute or a harp. If they do not make clear musical notes, you will not know what is being played. (NCV)

Translate this statement in a way that is natural in your language.

14:7a

Even in the case of lifeless instruments, such as the flute or harp,

- In the same way, think about objects that make music, such as the flute or the harp.
- Take the example of instruments that are not alive, like a flute or a harp.

Even in the case of lifeless instruments: The word lifeless describes objects that are not alive. In your translation, avoid suggesting that these objects were once alive but have died.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

instruments that are not alive

instruments that don't have breath

instruments: This refers to objects that people use to make music.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

musical instruments

In some languages it may be better to leave the word instruments implicit. For example:

even in the case of lifeless things such as the flute or harp

such as the flute or harp: These are two examples of musical instruments. The flute is a pipe that people blow into, and the harp is a large stringed instrument.

If you do not have words for these instruments, you could use words for similar instruments that people blow into and pluck the strings of.

14:7b

how will anyone recognize the tune they are playing

- How will anyone recognize the tune that they play
- No one will know what tune the musician is trying to play

how will anyone recognize the tune they are playing: Paul asked how people would be able to recognize the tune. He implied that it was not possible.

the tune they are playing: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the tune they are playing is passive. There are two ways to translate this:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

what is played (NASB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

what tune the musician is playing

what tune the instrument is playing

Use whichever form is more natural in your language.

14:7c

unless the notes are distinct?

- unless the notes are clear/distinct?
- unless the sounds have different pitches.

unless the notes are distinct: Paul said that the notes need to be distinct or different from one another. The distinction that Paul thought of was probably that of pitch (high or low) rather than length.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

unless they play the notes clearly

unless there is a good/distinct sound

General Comment on 14:7a-c

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as two or more sentences. For example:

It is similar for lifeless things that make a sound, like a flute or harp. If they don't make a distinction

in the notes, how will what is played on the flute or harp be understood? (NET)

General Comment on 14:7b-c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 14:7b and 14:7c. For example:

^{7c}if their notes all sound alike, ^{7b}who can tell what tune is being played? (JBP)

1 Corinthians 14:8

Section 14:1-40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:6-12

In this paragraph Paul discussed why it is important for people to be able to understand what is said in church. He pointed out that it is not useful to speak in ways that no one can understand.

14:8

Again, if the trumpet sounds a muffled call, who will prepare for battle?

- And if the trumpet does not blow a clear call, how will the soldiers know to prepare for battle?
- And also, if the army trumpet doesn't clearly tell the soldiers to attack, no one will get ready to fight.

Again: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Again introduces another example which shows that sound or noise by itself is of no use.

if the trumpet sounds a muffled call, who will prepare for battle?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement. He expected people to respond "No one." None of the soldiers who are sup-

posed to prepare for battle will do so. The commander wants them to get ready, but because the signal is not clear they do not know what his orders are.

Here are some ways to translate this strong statement.

- Use a question. For example:

If, for example, the trumpet makes an unclear sound, who will get ready for battle? (NET)

- Use a question with a response. For example:

if the trumpet makes a muffled call, will anyone get ready for battle? No!

- Use a strong statement. For example:

if the trumpet call is not clear, then no one will prepare for battle

Translate this statement in a way that is natural in your language.

if the trumpet sounds a muffled call: Military officers used trumpet signals to give orders. Different trumpet tunes told the soldiers to attack or retreat. The soldiers needed to be able to hear the sound of the trumpet and recognize its meaning. In this example, the trumpet should have signaled that it was time to fight. In some languages it may be helpful to add some implied information. For example:

if the trumpet does not clearly tell the soldiers to attack

trumpet: A trumpet is a wind instrument that makes a loud sound.

If you do not have a word for this instrument, you could use a similar instrument that soldiers might use.

sounds a muffled call: Here is another way to translate this phrase:

makes a sound which is not clear

1 Corinthians 14:9

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the

value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:6–12

In this paragraph Paul discussed why it is important for people to be able to understand what is said in church. He pointed out that it is not useful to speak in ways that no one can understand.

14:9a

So it is with you.

- The situation is the same with you^(plur).
- It is like that when you worship God.

So it is with you: The phrase So it is with you indicates that there is a similarity between musical instruments, and people who speak in tongues in the church. The similarity is that there may be a lack of understanding.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The situation is the same with you^(plur)

It is the same when you^(plur) worship God

14:9b–c

Unless you speak intelligible words with your tongue, how will anyone know what you are saying?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement.

Here are some ways to translate this strong statement:

- Use a question. For example:

If you do not speak clearly with your tongue, how will anyone know what is being said? (NET)

- Use a question with a response. For example:

If you do not speak clearly, how will anyone know what you are saying? They will not know.

- Use a strong statement. For example:

You must speak clearly, otherwise no one will know what you are saying.

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language.

14:9b

Unless you speak intelligible words with your tongue,

- If you do not speak words that others can understand,
- You must speak in a way that other people understand,

Unless you speak intelligible words: An intelligible word is a message that people can understand.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

if you^(plur) do not speak in words that people understand

if you say things that people do not understand

with your tongue: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as with your tongue is literally “with the tongue.” There are two ways to interpret what “the tongue” refers to:

1. It refers to the physical tongue of the speaker. Paul referred to anything the Corinthians might say. See, for example, Fee, p. 664; Conzelmann, p. 236; Robertson and Plummer, p. 309; Hodge, p. 283; Garland, p. 636. For example:

If you do not speak clearly with your tongue (NET) (BSB, NET, NIV, ESV, NASB, NCV, NJB, GW, KJV)

1. It refers to the gift of tongues. Paul referred to speech that was not understood by the speaker or hearers. See for example, Thiselton, p. 1081; Barrett, p. 318; Ellingworth and Hatton, pp. 309–310. For example:

If you in a tongue utter speech that is not comprehensible (RSV) (RSV, CEV, REB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is supported by many commentaries. If you choose to follow interpretation (2), make sure that

your translation does not suggest that it was possible to speak comprehensible speech in a tongue.

14:9c

how will anyone know what you are saying?

- will anyone know what you are saying? Of course not!
- or no one will know what you are trying to say.

how will anyone know what you are saying?: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

no one will know what you^(plur) are saying

no one can understand you

General Comment on 14:9b-c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the parts of this verse. For example:

^{9c}How will anyone know what you mean ^{9b}if your words cannot be understood?

^{9c}If you want people to know what you are saying, ^{9b}you must use meaningful words.

14:9d

You will just be speaking into the air.

- What you say will have no value.
- You will just be wasting your breath/effort.

You will just be speaking into the air: This is an idiom. It means that the speaker's words will be wasted because no one will understand them. You may have an idiom that you could use such as:

your words will vanish in the air (GNT)

you will only be talking to the wind (CEV)

you^(plur) will be wasting your breath

you will have empty speech

Or you may need to translate the meaning. For example:

your^(plur) words will be wasted

what you say will have no value

1 Corinthians 14:10

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:6–12

In this paragraph Paul discussed why it is important for people to be able to understand what is said in church. He pointed out that it is not useful to speak in ways that no one can understand.

14:10a

Assuredly, there are many different languages in the world,

- There are many languages in the world,
- Of course there are many languages in this world,

Assuredly: The Greek idiom that the BSB translates as Assuredly is more literally “if it should turn out that way.”

Here are some other ways to translate this Greek idiom:

probably

of course

Many English versions do not explicitly translate this phrase.

there are many different languages in the world:

The phrase there are many different languages in the world indicates that there are a large number of languages spoken in the world.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

there are all sorts of languages in the world (NIV)

14:10b

yet none of them is without meaning.

- but none of them is meaningless.
- and they all mean something.

yet none of them is without meaning: Every language has meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

all of them make sense (CEV)

but all these languages have meaning

without meaning: The Greek word that the BSB translates as without meaning is literally “voiceless.” There are two ways to interpret this word:

1. It means “without meaning” or “not communicating.” For example:

without meaning (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, ESV, NLT, CEV, GNT, NET, NASB, NCV, KJV)

1. It means “fail to make sounds.” For example:

all of them use sound (NJB) (NJB, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is followed by most English versions and many commentaries. See, for example, Thiselton, pp. 1106.

1 Corinthians 14:11

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:6–12

In this paragraph Paul discussed why it is important for people to be able to understand what is said in church. He pointed out that it is not useful to speak in ways that no one can understand.

14:11a

If, then, I do not know the meaning of someone's language,

- But if I do not understand the language someone speaks,
- But if a person doesn't understand the language that someone else speaks,

then: There are two ways to interpret the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as then:

1. It introduces a contrast. For example:

but (ESV) (ESV, RSV, GNT, NJB, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. It introduces a logical conclusion and means “therefore.” For example:

Therefore (KJV) (BSB, KJV, NIV, NRSV, NET, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is followed by many English versions and many commentaries. See, for example, Thiselton, pp. 1081, and Garland, pp. 637.

know the meaning: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates with the English idiom know the meaning is more literally “know the power.” Paul referred to a situation in which he did not understand someone else's language.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

understand

understand the meaning

of someone's language: The Greek word that the BSB translates as someone's language can also be translated as “voice.” It is the same word that was used in 14:10a.

14:11b

I am a foreigner to the speaker, and he is a foreigner to me.

- then I am like a person from another country to him, and he is like a person from another country to me.

- then they are like foreigners to each other.

I am a foreigner to the speaker, and he is a foreigner to me: Paul used the illustration of two foreigners who speak different languages. He implicitly compares this to speaking in tongues. Tongues is like another language that is not understood.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

I am like a foreigner to the speaker, and he is like a foreigner to me

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of the two clauses. For example:

the one who speaks will be like a foreigner to me and I will be like a foreigner to him

foreigner: The Greek word that the BSB translates as foreigner is the word that Greek-speakers used for people who did not speak Greek.

Here is another way to translate this word:

a person from another country/ethnic group

General Comment on 14:11

In this verse, Paul used himself as an example. In some languages it may be better to use a general subject. For example:

If someone does not understand the language that others are speaking, they will be foreigners to each other.

1 Corinthians 14:12

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:6–12

In this paragraph Paul discussed why it is important for people to be able to understand what is said in church. He pointed out that it is not useful to speak in ways that no one can understand.

14:12a

It is the same with you.

- The situation is the same with you^(plur).
- It is like that when you worship God.

It is the same with you: This is the same phrase as in 14:9a, where the BSB translates it as “So it is with you.” It indicates that there is a similarity between people who speak different languages, and people who speak in tongues in the church. The similarity is that people will not understand one another.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The situation is the same with you^(plur)

It is the same when you^(plur) worship God

14:12b

Since you are eager to have spiritual gifts,

- Because you are trying hard to have spiritual gifts,
- You want to have spiritual gifts.

Since you are eager to have spiritual gifts: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as you are eager to have is more literally “you are enthusiasts for.”

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

you strongly want spiritual gifts

spiritual gifts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as spiritual gifts is literally “spirits.” It refers to gifts or abilities that come from the Holy Spirit. See how you translated spiritual gifts in 1:7a and 12:1.

14:12c

strive to excel in gifts that build up the church.

- seek most of all to have gifts that strengthen the people in the church.
- Be especially eager to use the gifts that build up the group of believers in their faith.

strive to excel in gifts that build up the church: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as strive to excel

is more literally “seek to abound.” Paul wanted the believers to have and to use the most helpful spiritual gifts.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

seek most of all to have spiritual gifts that build up the church

be especially eager to have gifts that build up the church

build up: The Greek word that the BSB translates as build up is more literally “construction.” This is a Greek idiom. It speaks as if people are buildings that are being built. It means to strengthen the believers in their faith. See the way you translated it in 14:4b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

strengthen the church spiritually

build the church up in its faith

help the church to believe more firmly

the church: The word church refers to the community of believers, not to the building where they meet.

1 Corinthians 14:13

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:13–19

In this paragraph Paul discussed the importance of using one's understanding while worshiping God. He told people who speak in tongues in church to interpret what they say, so that other people can understand and benefit from it.

14:13

Therefore, the one who speaks in a tongue should pray that he may interpret.

- ¶ So then, someone who speaks in an unknown tongue must pray for the ability to explain what he means.
- ¶ So, people who speak in unknown/miraculous languages should ask God to help them say it again in words that others can understand.

Therefore: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Therefore introduces what Paul wanted the Corinthians to do as a result of what he had just said.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

So then

Because of this

the one who speaks in a tongue should pray that he may interpret: If the person can interpret what he says then everybody will understand it, and it will build them up. In some languages it may be natural to use plural forms. For example:

Those who speak in tongues should pray to be able to explain what they say.

should pray: This is a command. Here is another way to translate this:

must pray (NJB)

that he may interpret: The Greek word that the BSB translates as interpret refers to explaining the meaning of what is said in tongues. See how you translated this in 14:5d.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

that he may explain the meaning

that God will enable him to explain the meaning

that he may say it again in words that people can understand

1 Corinthians 14:14**Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way**

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:13–19

In this paragraph Paul discussed the importance of using one's understanding while worshiping God. He told people who speak in tongues in church to interpret what they say, so that other people can understand and benefit from it.

14:14

For if I pray in a tongue, my spirit prays, but my mind is unfruitful.

- For if I pray in an unknown tongue, my spirit prays but my thoughts are not useful to me or to others.
- For if people pray using an unknown/miraculous language, although their heart/liver may pray, their brain doesn't produce any helpful thing.

For if I pray in a tongue: Paul used himself as an example, but what he said refers to anyone who might pray in a tongue.

my spirit prays: The word spirit refers to the inner part of a person, something separate from his conscious thoughts.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

my heart/liver prays

I pray deep inside myself

I pray in the words of my spirit

but my mind is unfruitful: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as my mind is unfruitful:

1. It means that Paul's mind does not produce anything that is helpful or beneficial to Paul or to his listeners. For example:

my mind is unproductive (NRSV) (BSB, NRSV, NIV, ESV, RSV, NET, NJB, CEV, REB, GW, KJV)

1. It means that Paul's mind is not active or involved. He does not know what he is saying. For example:

I don't understand what I am saying (NLT) (NLT, GNT, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is supported by many commentaries. See, for example, Fee, pp. 669, Ellingworth & Hatton, pp. 312, Verbrugge & Harris, pp. 381, Kistemaker, pp. 491. and versions.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

my mind isn't useful for me or for others

my mind doesn't produce any helpful thing

my mind: The phrase my mind refers to Paul's conscious thoughts that used ordinary words.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

my thinking/understanding/thoughts

my brain/head

1 Corinthians 14:15

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:13–19

In this paragraph Paul discussed the importance of using one's understanding while worshiping God. He told people who speak in tongues in church to interpret what they say, so that other people can understand and benefit from it.

14:15a

What then shall I do?

- So what do I conclude from this?
- So this is what they should do:

What then shall I do?: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as What then shall I do? is more literally "What is it then?" This is a rhetorical question. It introduces Paul's conclusion about what he should do.

Here are some ways to translate this conclusion:

- Use a question. For example:

What do I conclude from this?

What then? (NJB)

- Use a statement that introduces a conclusion. For example:

So this is what I will do.

So this is the conclusion.

Translate this conclusion in a way that is natural in your language.

14:15b

I will pray with my spirit, but I will also pray with my mind.

- I intend to pray with my spirit but also with my thoughts.
- They should pray with their heart/liver but also with their brain.

14:15c

I will sing with my spirit, but I will also sing with my mind.

- I intend to sing with my spirit but also with my thoughts.
- They should sing with their heart/liver but also with their brain.

14:15b-c

I will pray with my spirit, but I will also pray with my mind. I will sing with my spirit, but I will also sing with my mind: Paul stated what he, and all believers, should do as a result of what he had just said.

but...but...: These two pairs of clauses are connected with a Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but. There are two ways to interpret this conjunction:

1. It introduces a contrasting thought. For example:

but (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NIV, NJB, NCV, NRSV, ESV, NET, REB)

1. It introduces a continuation of thought. For example:

and (RSV) (RSV, CEV, NASB, NLT, GW, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The translation and commentary support for interpretation (1) is slightly stronger.

my spirit...my mind: Paul contrasted the worship in tongues that came from his inward spiritual being, with the thoughtful praise that he expressed in ordinary language. See the notes on 14:14 on my spirit and my mind.

I will pray...I will sing: Paul said what should happen. In your translation, use verb forms that express a desire or determination to behave in a certain way. For example:

I intend to pray...I intend to sing

I shall continue to pray...I shall continue to sing

Paul did not refer to himself only but to any believer. In some languages it may be clearer to use a different pronoun. For example:

they/we^(incl) should pray...they/we^(incl) should sing

Here is another way to translate verse 14:15b-c

I will pray with my spirit, but I will pray also with my mind; I will sing with my spirit, but I will sing also with my mind. (GNT)

1 Corinthians 14:16**Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way**

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:13–19

In this paragraph Paul discussed the importance of using one's understanding while worshiping God. He told people who speak in tongues in church to interpret what they say, so that other people can understand and benefit from it.

14:16

This verse is a long rhetorical question. For suggestions on ways to make shorter sentences, see the General Comment at the end of verse 16.

14:16a**Otherwise, if you speak a blessing in spirit,**

- If you^(sing) praise God in unknown tongues with your spirit,
- If you use new languages to praise God from your heart/liver,

Otherwise: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Otherwise introduces the reason one should use both spirit and mind. Paul considered what will happen if people do not do as he said they should. Some English versions do not explicitly translate this conjunction.

Here are some ways to translate this conjunction:

After all (CEB)

Else (KJV)

if you speak a blessing in spirit: There is some implicit information here. Paul referred to someone who spoke in tongues with the spirit alone, and not with the mind. It may be helpful to make this clear. For example:

If you speak a blessing only with the spirit

you speak a blessing: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as you speak a blessing is singular. Paul wrote as though he were addressing one of the Corinthians. However, his words apply to all people. In some languages it may be clearer to use a plural. For example:

If you^(plur) speak blessings

If anybody speaks a blessing

If people speak blessings

in spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in spirit refers to the person's own spirit, praising God in tongues.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

If you speak a blessing by speaking in tongues in your spirit

If you speak a blessing with your spirit while you speak in tongues

14:16b

how can someone who is uninstructed say "Amen" to your thanksgiving,

- how can someone who does not understand say "Amen" to your thanksgiving prayer to God?
- those who do not understand will not be able to agree when you thank God.

how can someone who is uninstructed say "Amen" to your thanksgiving: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement. He said that it is impossible for other people to express agreement to a prayer uttered in tongues.

Here are some ways to translate this statement:

- Use a question. For example:

how can anyone in the position of an outsider say "Amen" to your thanksgiving? (ESV)

- Use a strong statement. For example:

those people there without understanding cannot say amen to your prayer of thanks (NCV)

Translate this statement in the way that is most natural in your language.

someone who is uninstructed: This Greek phrase is more literally "one occupying the place of the ignorant." It is not clear to whom Paul was referring. There are several views:

1. It refers to everyone there who did not understand what was said. For example:

those who don't understand you (NLT) (BSB, NLT, NIV, NCV, GNT, REB)

1. It refers to the Christians there who did not have the gift of understanding tongues. For example:

someone without the gift (NET) (NET, NASB, NJB)

1. It refers to the people there who were not part of the Christian community. For example:

some strangers (CEV) (CEV, RSV, ESV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). There is reasonably strong commentary^{See, for example, Thiselton, pp. 1115.} and translation support for it. Translate this in a way that could include both Christians and non-Christians. Use the singular or plural, whichever is most natural in your language.

say "Amen" to your thanksgiving: It was the custom to say Amen at the close of a prayer. The word Amen is a Hebrew word which expresses that the listeners agree with the prayer. Consider how worshipers in your churches express agreement at the end of a prayer.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

how can they agree with your thanksgiving

your thanksgiving: The phrase that the BSB translates as your thanksgiving can also be translated as:

your prayer of thanksgiving (GNT)

when you give thanks to God

14:16c

since he does not know what you are saying?

- For he will not know what you^(sing) are saying.
- They will have no idea what you have said.

since he does not know what you are saying: This states the reason why the person who does not understand cannot say “Amen.”

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

because he does not know what you have said

General Comment on 14:16b-c

In some languages it may be helpful to break this up into more than one sentence and perhaps reorder some of the information. For example:

^{16b}Could an ordinary person who is present say “Amen” to your thanksgiving prayer? Of course not! ^{16c}For they do not know what you have been saying.

^{16b}Everyone else will be in a position of ignorance.

^{16c}They will have no idea of what you are saying,

^{16b}and so they will not be able to express their agreement with your prayer of thanksgiving.

1 Corinthians 14:17

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:13–19

In this paragraph Paul discussed the importance of using one’s understanding while worshiping God. He told people who speak in tongues in church to interpret what they say, so that other people can understand and benefit from it.

14:17a

You may be giving thanks well enough,

- You^(sing) may have thanked God very well/nicely,
- You are saying good prayers of thanks,

You may be giving thanks well enough:

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Even though you^(sing) are thanking God well

You are saying good prayers of thanks

If you pray thanking God like this it is good

14:17b

but the other one is not edified.

- but the other person is not strengthened.
- but you have not built up other people.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but introduces a contrast with what one might expect. One might expect that a good prayer will help the listeners, but it will not help them in this case.

the other one is not edified: The phrase the other one is not edified indicates that the person listening is not strengthened as a believer. He is not helped to understand his faith better or grow as a Christian. The Greek verb translated as edified is the same as the one used in 14:4.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the other person is not built up at all (NJB)

This is a passive clause. There are two ways to translate this;

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the other person is not helped at all (GNT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

you do not build up the other person

Translate this in whichever way is most natural in your language.

the other one: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the other one refers to either men or women.

General Comment on 14:17

You can adjust the person and the number of the pronouns to fit what is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

They may be giving thanks well, but no one else is edified.

We^(incl) may be giving thanks well, but they are not edified.

1 Corinthians 14:18

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:13–19

In this paragraph Paul discussed the importance of using one's understanding while worshiping God. He told people who speak in tongues in church to interpret what they say, so that other people can understand and benefit from it.

14:18

I thank God that I speak in tongues more than all of you.

- I thank God that I speak in unknown tongues more than any of you^(plur) do.

- I thank God that he has given me the gift of unknown/miraculous languages, even more than he has to you.

I thank God that I speak in tongues more than all of you: Some Greek manuscripts read, "I thank my God." The KJV follows these manuscripts. It is recommended that you follow the majority of English versions and older Greek manuscripts that say, "I thank God." Paul used this phrase to set up the contrast he will make in 14:19. First he expressed his approval of the gift of tongues. He indicated that he himself had and used the gift of tongues.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

I thank God that I speak unknown languages more than any of you (CEV)

1 Corinthians 14:19

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:13–19

In this paragraph Paul discussed the importance of using one's understanding while worshiping God. He told people who speak in tongues in church to interpret what they say, so that other people can understand and benefit from it.

14:19a

But in the church, I would rather speak five coherent words to instruct others

- But among the people in the church I would rather speak five words that others can understand and from which they can learn

- But when I am with the group of believers, I want to teach others by speaking words that they can understand. If I can speak five such words,

14:19b**than ten thousand words in a tongue.**

- than ten thousand words in an unknown tongue.
- that is better than speaking thousands/millions of words in an unknown/miraculous language.

14:19

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a statement that the reader does not expect.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

Nevertheless (RSV)

Yet (GW)

in the church, I would rather speak five coherent words to instruct others than ten thousand words in a tongue: Because Paul could speak in tongues, one might expect him to encourage it. But instead he preferred to do something different when he was among the believers. He said that speaking five words that instructed others was better than speaking ten thousand words that did not help others.

Consider how speakers of your language make such a comparison. In some languages it may be natural to break this up into two or more sentences.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

words that make sense can help the church. That's why in church I had rather speak five words that make sense than to speak ten thousand words in a language that others don't know. (CEV)

if I could speak to the church only five words, then I might instruct you a little. But I cannot instruct you at all by speaking in a tongue, even if I spoke ten thousand words.

in the church: The phrase in the church refers to the community of believers, not to the building where they meet. Here is another way to translate this:

in church worship (GNT)

coherent words: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as coherent is more literally “with my mind.”

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

words that people can understand

to instruct others: The Greek text has a word that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as “also.” It indicates that when a person speaks in a language that other people can understand, then everyone, including the speaker, benefits from it. Here are other ways to translate this:

so that I may instruct others also (NASB)

for the benefit of others as well as myself (REB)

Consider if it is natural to translate this word in your language.

ten thousand: The number ten thousand is a single Greek word. It was the largest Greek number that could be expressed as a single word. This is a figure of speech called a hyperbole. Paul did not expect to speak ten thousand words in a tongue but he used this number to emphasize his point. Use a word that is natural in your language to express a large number. For example:

thousands

millions

1 Corinthians 14:20**Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way**

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:20–25

In this paragraph Paul contrasted the purpose of tongues and the purpose of prophecy. The gift of tongues was a sign to unbelievers of God's judgment upon them. But when the believers prophesied, unbelievers can repent.

14:20a

Brothers, stop thinking like children.

- ¶ Brothers and sisters, stop thinking like children think.
- ¶ Fellow believers, do not keep on being childish in the way you think about speaking in tongues.

Brothers: Paul addressed the believers in Corinth with a friendly term. He spoke to both men and women, so you may wish to use a term that refers to both men and women. See also 14:6a.

stop thinking like children: The Greek clause that the BSB translates stop thinking like children is more literally “do not be children in your diaphragm,” Paul used the diaphragm to represent the center of thought. He said that the believers were thinking like children, with immature opinions.

thinking: In some languages it is natural to have an object of thinking. The implied object of their thinking is the opinions they had about speaking in tongues. See, for example, Thiselton, pp. 1119; Fee, p. 679.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

stop thinking like children who don't know anything

the way you think about the gift of tongues should not be like children think

14:20b

In regard to evil be infants,

- Be as free from evil as infants,
- About evil deeds, you should behave like infants.

In regard to evil be infants: Paul wanted believers to know nothing about evil. In some languages it may be natural to make the point of the comparison explicit.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

about evil deeds, it is right for you to think like infants

so far as evil is concerned, you should be as innocent as infants

infants don't know about evil, and you should not either

infants: The Greek word that the BSB translates as infants is often translated as “babies.” It usually refers to a child who is younger than the word that is translated as “children” in 14:20a.

14:20c

but in your thinking be mature.

- but think like adults.
- but in the way you think, be as wise/thoughtful as grown ups.

but in your thinking be mature: Paul wanted the Corinthians to think in a way that was spiritually mature. He wanted them to have wise attitudes, and to know what is valuable and useful.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

think like adults

General Comment on 14:20a-c

In some languages it may be helpful to reorder the parts of the verse. For example:

^{20a}Brothers and sisters, about speaking in tongues, you^(plur) should not think like children, ^{20c}but you should think like adults. ^{20b}But concerning evil, it is right for you to think like infants.

1 Corinthians 14:21

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:20–25

In this paragraph Paul contrasted the purpose of tongues and the purpose of prophecy. The gift of tongues was a sign to unbelievers of God's judgment upon them. But when the believers prophesied, unbelievers can repent.

14:21a

It is written in the Law:

- In the Law of God it says:
- In the Scriptures the Lord says:

It is written: This was a typical way to introduce a quotation from the Scriptures. See the notes on this phrase in 1:19a.

in the Law: The quotation that follows is from Isaiah 28:11–12. By the Law Paul referred to the Hebrew Scriptures as a whole.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

In the law book

In the Bible/scriptures

In the book of God from long ago

14:21b

“By strange tongues and foreign lips I will speak to this people,

- “I will speak to this people through men of strange tongues and through the lips of foreigners,
- “I will speak to my people Israel through foreign people who speak foreign languages,

By strange tongues and foreign lips I will speak to this people: In some languages it may be necessary to state here or at the end of 14:21a who is the speaker. For example:

The Lord says, “Through men of strange tongues and through the lips of foreigners I will speak to this people.”

The phrases strange tongues and foreign lips refer to people who spoke languages that the Jewish people did not understand. The two phrases refer to one group of people, not two separate groups.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I will speak to these people through the mouths of foreigners who speak strange languages.

I will use people from other countries to speak to the Israelites. They will speak in different languages from the Israelite language.

strange tongues: The phrase strange tongues refers to languages that the people of Israel did not understand. It does not refer to the spiritual gift of speaking in tongues.

foreign lips: The phrase foreign lips is an idiom that refers to the words that foreigners speak. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as:

the mouths/speech of foreigners

I will speak to this people: The pronoun I refers to God. The words this people refer the people of Israel. We do not know what God will say to the people. In Isaiah, God told the people that he was displeased with them. In some languages it may be helpful to supply this implied information.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I the Lord will speak harsh words to this people

I will rebuke this people

14:21c

but even then they will not listen to Me, says the Lord.”

- but even then this people will not listen to me,” says the Lord.
- but still my people will not obey what I am saying.”

but even then they will not listen to Me: The word listen implies obeying someone.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

even then they will not obey me

says the Lord: In some languages it may be natural to put this phrase at the beginning or in the middle of the quotation. See the note at the beginning of 14:21b. Place this phrase where it is natural in your language.

1 Corinthians 14:22

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:20–25

In this paragraph Paul contrasted the purpose of tongues and the purpose of prophecy. The gift of tongues was a sign to unbelievers of God's judgment upon them. But when the believers prophesied, unbelievers can repent.

14:22a

Tongues, then, are a sign, not for believers, but for unbelievers.

- So unknown tongues are a sign for unbelievers. They are not a sign for believers.
- So when someone speaks in unknown/miraculous languages, it serves as a sign to unbelievers rather than to believers.

Tongues...are a sign, not for believers, but for unbelievers: In some languages it may be natural to make a positive statement before a negative. For example:

Tongues are a sign for unbelievers. They are not a sign for believers.

a sign: A sign is something that signals, or points to something other than itself. Paul did not say what tongues are a sign of. The quotation from Isaiah suggests that they are a sign of God's anger or of judgment.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

Tongues are a warning for unbelievers, not for believers.

then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as then means "therefore." It introduces a conclusion drawn from verse 14:21.

14:22b

Prophecy, however, is for believers, not for unbelievers.

- But prophecy is a sign for believers rather than unbelievers.
- But when someone declares God's word, believers receive a sign. Unbelievers do not.

The Greek begins this clause with a conjunction that the BSB translates as however, which indicates a contrast. Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

but

on the other hand

Prophecy...is for believers, not for unbelievers: The implied information is that prophecy is also a sign.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

prophecy is a sign not for unbelievers but for believers (ESV)

however: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as however indicates a contrast. See the pre-note for ways the translation this conjunction

1 Corinthians 14:23

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:20–25

In this paragraph Paul contrasted the purpose of tongues and the purpose of prophecy. The gift of tongues was a sign to unbelievers of God's judgment upon them. But when the believers prophesied, unbelievers can repent.

14:23a

So if the whole church comes together and everyone speaks in tongues,

- ¶ So if all the believers gather together and start speaking in unknown tongues,
- ¶ Suppose that all you believers meet together, and you all speak in unknown/miraculous languages.

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So introduces some illustrations of what Paul said in 14:22.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

therefore (RSV)

if the whole church comes together: The phrase if the whole church comes together refers to the times when believers in Corinth met together to worship.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

suppose that all you believers gather together

when the church meets

during a church meeting

and everyone speaks in tongues: The phrase everyone speaks in tongues refers to a situation in which many different people speak in tongues at the same time. The word everyone is hyperbole, and does not necessarily mean every single person.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

many people speak in tongues

everybody who speaks, speaks in tongues

14:23b

and some who are uninstructed or some unbelievers come in,

- and some who are not taught or who do not follow Christ join them,
- Suppose some ordinary or unbelieving people enter,

and some who are uninstructed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as some who are uninstructed is the same word as in 14:16b. It probably refers to people who did not belong to the church.

Here are some other ways to translate this Greek word:

some ordinary people (GNT)

some uninstructed persons (REB)

uninformed people (NET)

or some unbelievers come in: The word unbelievers refers to people who did not believe in Jesus Christ. They could have been Jewish or Gentiles.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

some unbelievers come in to your assembly

some unbelievers enter the room where you are meeting

You should not supply a word meaning “church building,” because at this time there were no church buildings.

14:23c

will they not say that you are out of your minds?

- what will they say? They will say that you^(plur) believers are insane.
- they will think that you are crazy people.

will they not say that you are out of your minds?:

This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement that means “they will certainly say that you are out of your minds.”

Here are some ways to translate this strong statement:

- Use a question. For example:

won't they say that you are all crazy? (GNT)

- Use a question with the response supplied. For example:

what will they say? They will say you are out of your minds!

- Use a statement. For example:

they will say you are crazy (NCV)

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language.

you are out of your minds: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as you are out of your minds refers to being crazy, or losing control of oneself. The BSB uses an English idiom. Choose a way to say this that is clear in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this Greek word:

you are mad (RSV)

you are all crazy (GNT)

General Comment on 14:23a-c

In 14:23a Paul referred to the believers in Corinth in the third person (“the whole church” and “everyone”). However, in 14:23c he referred to them in the second person (“you”). In some languages this shift may not be natural. A literal translation may suggest that Paul spoke about different people. Make it clear that Paul referred to the same people, his readers. There are several things you could do to help make this clear:

- Refer back to one of the expressions you have used in 14:23a. For example:

^{23c}will they not think that you church people are mad?

- Use only the third person in 14:23c as well as in 14:23a. For example:

^{23c}will they not say that everyone in the church is mad?

- Use the second person in 14:23a as well as in 14:23c. For example:

^{23a}if all of you in the church come together and speak in tongues

- Use a direct quotation in 14:23c. For example:

^{23c}they will say, “You people must be mad!”

1 Corinthians 14:24

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:20–25

In this paragraph Paul contrasted the purpose of tongues and the purpose of prophecy. The gift of tongues was a sign to unbelievers of God’s judgment upon them. But when the believers prophesied, unbelievers can repent.

14:24a

But if an unbeliever or uninstructed person comes in

- But if someone who does not follow Christ or someone who is not taught joins them
- Suppose, on the other hand, that an unbelieving or ordinary person enters

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But continues the contrast between tongues and prophecy.

if an unbeliever or uninstructed person comes in:

These are the same Greek words that were used in 14:23b, but here they are in the singular. Here, also, the two words are reversed. You may reverse them or use the same order as in 14:23b, whichever is most natural in your language.

14:24b

while everyone is prophesying,

- while the believers are prophesying,

- while you are all declaring God's word.

while everyone is prophesying: Here, everyone is a hyperbole and may mean "many people" or "everyone with the gift of prophecy." Paul did not mean that they were all speaking at the same time, but that several people prophesied, one after the other.

If you used second-person pronouns in 14:23, it may be natural to continue using them here:

while all of you are prophesying

General Comment on 14:24a-b

The BSB has reversed the order of the Greek words in 14:24a-b. The RSV and many other English versions follow the Greek order. Here is another way to translate this:

But if all prophesy, and an unbeliever or outsider enters (RSV)

You should follow the order that is most natural for your language.

14:24c

he will be convicted and called to account by all,

- everything he hears will convict and condemn him.
- Everything that you say will cause him to realize that he is a sinner and to know that God will judge him.

he will be convicted and called to account by all: The verbs will be convicted and called to account are passive. There are two ways to translate these phrases:

- Use passive verbs. For example:

their sin will be shown to them, and they will be judged by all that they hear (NCV)

- Use active verbs. For example:

The people who prophesy will convict him and will call him to account.

he will be convicted: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as he will be convicted means that the visitor will become aware that he has done things that are wrong. He will become conscious of his sin.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they are convicted of sin (NIV11)

he will know that he is a sinner

he will know that he has done wrong

called to account: The verb called to account means almost the same thing as "convicted." It means that this person will be made to realize that he has sinned.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he will know that he is guilty

he will know that God will judge him

by all: There is implied information in the phrase by all. In some languages it may be clearer to translate it in one of these ways:

by all these words

by all of you

by all those who prophesy

1 Corinthians 14:25

Section 14:1-40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:20-25

In this paragraph Paul contrasted the purpose of tongues and the purpose of prophecy. The gift of tongues was a sign to unbelievers of God's judgment

upon them. But when the believers prophesied, unbelievers can repent.

14:25a

and the secrets of his heart will be made known.

- His secrets thoughts will be revealed.
- The evil things that he hid in his heart will become known/open to himself.

and the secrets of his heart: The phrase the secrets of his heart refers to evil thoughts or actions that the person has not told to anybody else.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

his secret thoughts

the evil things that he has not told anybody else

will be made known: The phrase that the BSB translates as will be made known indicates that things this person kept hidden will become known. There are two ways to interpret who they will be known to:

1. They will be know to the person himself. For example:

He will realize that God knows the evil things that he has done, things that other people do not know (T4T)

1. They will be known to everybody. For example:

everybody will know the secrets of his heart

If you must make this clear, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation is followed by many commentaries. See, for example, Thiselton, p. 1129; Garland, p. 653; Hodge, p. 298. But contrast Ellingworth & Hatton, p. 318, who suggest the meaning “God’s message will cause others to know what he is secretly thinking.” Most English versions do not choose either interpretation.

This is a passive clause. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

their secret thoughts will be exposed (NLT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

Everything he hears will reveal the secrets of his heart

The evil things that he hid in his heart, he will not be able to hide them any longer

14:25b

So he will fall facedown and worship God,

- So he will kneel down and worship God,
- So he will prostrate himself as he worships God,

So: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as So is literally “and thus.” It introduces what the unbeliever will do as a result of what he has heard the believers say.

he will fall facedown: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as he will fall facedown is more literally “falling on his face.” The unbeliever will kneel down and lower his face to the floor, to express his humility before God. Some languages have a verb such as “prostrate oneself” for lying with one’s face on the floor.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he will kneel/prostrate down

and worship God: A person worships God when he shows God respect and adoration. See how you translated this word in Luke 4:7–8.

General Comment on 14:24a–25b

It is possible that more than one outsider will enter the Christian assembly. Paul used the plural form in verse 23. In some languages it may be natural to use the plural form in verses 24–25 also. For example:

But suppose all of you are prophesying when those unbelievers and outsiders come in. They will realize that they are sinners, and they will want to change their ways because of what you are saying. They will tell what is hidden in their hearts. Then they will kneel down and say... (CEV)

14:25c

proclaiming, “God is truly among you!”

- and say, “Certainly God is here in your^(plur) midst!”
- and he will declare that God is truly present among you.

proclaiming, “God is truly among you!”: This exclamation is addressed to the believers, not to God himself. It is not what the unbeliever will say to God

as he worships. In some languages it may be natural to use an indirect quotation, as the RSV has done:

and declare that God is really among you (RSV)

General Comment on 14:24–25

In the Greek text, verses 14:24–25 form a long sentence. The BSB broke this up into two sentences. In some languages it may be natural to break it up into even shorter sentences. For example:

²⁴But suppose everyone is prophesying and some people come in who do not believe or do not understand. If everyone is prophesying, their sin will be shown to them, and they will be judged by all that they hear. ²⁵The secret things in their hearts will be made known. So they will bow down and worship God saying, “Truly, God is with you.” (NCV)

1 Corinthians 14:26

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:26

In this paragraph Paul talked about the right use of spiritual gifts in the worship services of the church.

14:26a

What then shall we say, brothers?

- ¶ So what is the conclusion, brothers and sisters?
- ¶ So what does this imply, my friends?

What then shall we say: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as What then shall we say is more literally “What is it then.” The same Greek phrase

appears in 14:15. There are two ways to interpret what it means:

1. It refers to Paul’s argument. For example:

So what does this mean? (GW) (GW, NIV, GNT, REB, NLT)

1. It refers to what the believers should do. For example:

What should you do then? (NET) (NET, NRSV, NJB, NASB, NCV)

If it is necessary for you to choose between the interpretations, it is recommended that you choose interpretation (1). This is supported by several commentaries. See, for example, Thiselton, p. 1132; Fee, p. 690; Conzelmann, p. 244. Paul introduced the next logical point in his argument.

This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as an introductory statement. He introduced his conclusion that follows in verse 26.

Here are some ways to translate this statement:

- Use a question. For example:

So what does this mean? (GW)

- Use a statement that introduces a conclusion: For example:

This is what I mean (GNT)

To sum up (REB)

This is the conclusion

Translate this introductory statement in a way that is natural in your language.

brothers: The word brothers refers to all the believers in Corinth, both men and women. Paul addressed them in a friendly way. Here is another way to translate this:

my friends (GNT)

14:26b

When you come together,

- When you^(plur) meet together,
- When you meet to worship,

When you come together: The phrase When you come together refers to coming together for a church meeting. The GNT makes this explicit:

When you meet for worship (GNT)

14:26c-d

Paul stated the situation as it was in Corinth. All the believers had a gift from God that they could use to benefit the congregation. The gifts that Paul mentioned are examples of several different gifts. He did not mention all the possible gifts.

14:26c

everyone has a psalm or a teaching,

- all of you can sing a song/hymn, or teach something.
- one person has a song to sing. One person has a lesson to teach.

everyone has a psalm or a teaching: The phrase everyone has a psalm or a teaching indicates that the various believers all had something they could contribute. Each one could contribute something to the worship service. Some could participate by singing a psalm, and some by teaching the other believers.

everyone: The word everyone refers to all the believers present at the worship service. In some languages it may be natural to continue to use the second person subject that was used in 14:26b (“you”). There is a textual issue. Some Greek manuscripts read “each of you” rather than “everyone,” and this reading appears to be followed by the NJB, KJV, and REB. The reading “everyone” is adopted by the UBS Greek text without discussion. However, it is more important to translate in a way that is natural rather than to follow one reading over another.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

you all

each of you (NJB)

a psalm: The word psalm refers to a religious song. These songs may have been from the book of Psalms, or they may have been ones that the singer had composed, or they may have been improvised at the time. The verb form of psalm appears in 14:15c.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

a song (NCV)

a song of praise

a hymn (NIV)

a teaching: The phrase a teaching refers to a religious teaching. See also 14:6c, where the same phrase appears.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a word of instruction (NIV)

some instruction (NJB)

a lesson that he will teach

14:26d

a revelation, a tongue, or an interpretation.

- Or you can speak a message that God has revealed, or say something in unknown tongues, or interpret what is said.
- One person has a message that God has revealed to him. One person speaks in unknown/miraculous languages, and one person explains the meaning of what they said.

a revelation: The word revelation refers to a message that God had told the speaker. See also 14:6c.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

a revelation from God (GNT)

a message that God has revealed to him

a tongue: The word tongue refers to a message spoken using the gift of tongues. Translate tongue in the same way as in 14:2a, and 14:6a.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

a message from God spoken in tongues

or an interpretation: The word interpretation refers to an explanation of the message that was said in tongues. A similar verb form is used in 14:5d and 14:13. Here is another way to translate this:

the explanation of what is said (GNT)

General Comment on 14:26c-d

In some languages it may be natural to express these gifts of the spirit in verb forms. For example:

everyone can sing a hymn, instruct others, declare a message that God has revealed to them, speak in an unknown tongue, or explain the message

14:26e**All of these must be done to build up the church.**

- Everything should be done in order to encourage the believers.
- Whatever you do, do it to help the church.

All of these must be done to build up the church:

The Greek text is more literally “Let all be for strengthening.” The BSB has supplied the words of these and the church to make the meaning clear in English.

Paul taught that everything the believers did in their assembly should be for strengthening one another. The Greek word translated as to build up is also used in 14:12. It refers to helping believers to grow in their faith.

This is a command. Here are some other ways to translate this command:

Everything must be done to help each other grow.
(GW)

You must do all this in order to build up the church.

The verb must be done is passive. In some languages it may be necessary to use an active verb.

Here are some ways to translate this using an active verb:

The purpose of all these things should be to help the church grow strong. (NCV)

you must do everything for the good of everyone there (CEV)

1 Corinthians 14:27**Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way**

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he

said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:27–28

In this paragraph, Paul gave some advice about speaking in tongues. Paul said that when they spoke in tongues, no more than three people should speak in tongues and someone should interpret.

14:27a**If anyone speaks in a tongue,**

- ¶ If someone speaks in an unknown tongue,
- ¶ When people speak in an unknown/miraculous language in the meeting,

If anyone speaks in a tongue: This is something that often happened, so you could say:

When someone speaks in a tongue

14:27b**two, or at most three, should speak in turn,**

- then at the most two or three people should speak, one after the other.
- not more than three people should speak, and they should take turns.

two, or at most three, should speak: This phrase indicates that not more than three people should speak in tongues during one worship meeting. Paul did not forbid one person to speak alone. He forbade a period of speaking in tongues with more than three people taking part.

in turn: The phrase in turn indicates that one person should speak at a time. They should not all speak at once.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

take turns

speak one after the other

General Comment on 14:27a-b

In some languages it may not be natural to say “if someone speaks in tongues, two or three should speak.” A literal translation may not make sense, or it may wrongly indicate that Paul was forbidding one person to speak alone.

Here are some other ways to translate this and avoid the wrong meaning:

if there is going to be a time to speak in tongues, then two or at the most three people should speak

if the gift of tongues is being used, only two people, or three at the most, should speak

14:27c**and someone must interpret.**

- And someone must interpret what each one is saying.
- There must also be someone to explain the meaning of what they say.

and someone must interpret: Paul did not say whether this was to be the same person who had spoken in tongues or a different person. Either is possible. See the notes on 14:5d where the same word interpret is used.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

someone should explain the meaning of what they have said

1 Corinthians 14:28**Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way**

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:27–28

In this paragraph, Paul gave some advice about speaking in tongues. Paul said that when they spoke in tongues, no more than three people should speak in tongues and someone should interpret.

14:28a**But if there is no interpreter,**

- If there is no one to interpret,
- If there is no one who can explain the meaning,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a situation in which the rule given in the preceding verse should not be followed. Introduce this situation in a way that is natural in your language.

if there is no interpreter: The phrase there is no interpreter indicates that no one in the assembly can interpret the tongues. Here is another way to translate this:

If no one can explain (CEV)

14:28b**he should remain silent in the church and speak only to himself and God.**

- the one with the gift of unknown tongues should remain quiet in the church meeting. He should speak to himself and to God.
- those who want to speak in an unknown/miraculous language should not speak in church. They should speak in their heart/head and to God.

he should remain silent in the church: The word he refers to the person speaking in tongues.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the person who wants to speak in tongues must not speak in church

church: The Greek word that the BSB translates as church occurs several times in the next few verses. It refers to the group of believers in Corinth. You should translate it the same way you did in 11:18 and 14:4.

and speak only to himself and God: There are two ways to interpret the phrase speak only to himself and God:

1. It means to address God quietly, in one’s own mind, during the service. The REB shows that it follows this interpretation by leaving the phrase “in the church” implicit:

they should keep silent and speak to themselves and to God (REB) (REB, GNT, CEV, ESV, NRSV)

1. It means to speak in tongues privately, in one's own home, after the service. For example:

speak in tongues to God privately (NLT)

Commentators are about equally divided between the two views. If you must choose between them, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

General Comment on 14:26–28

In these verses Paul gave directions to the people to whom he was writing. Some of the instructions he gave in the second person (“you”) and some in the third person (“anyone” and “the speaker”). In some languages it may be natural to use the second person to give all these instructions. For example:

My friends, when you meet to worship, you must do everything for the good of everyone there.... No more than two or three of you should speak unknown languages during the meeting. You must take turns, and someone should always be there to explain what you mean. If no one can explain, you must keep silent in church and speak only to yourself and to God. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 14:29

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:29–33a

In this paragraph Paul wrote about the right use of the gift of prophecy in the worship services of the church.

14:29a

Two or three prophets should speak,

- ¶ Similarly, only two or three prophets should speak,
- ¶ And in the same way, when people declare God's word, only two or three people should speak.

The Greek text has a conjunction that the BSB does not translate. Some versions translate it as “and.” It introduces a new topic, the topic of prophecy. Prophecy is similar to tongues and has a similar rule. Introduce this new topic in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some ways to translate this conjunction:

Similarly

In the same way

Two or three prophets should speak: The phrase Two or three prophets should speak indicates that no more than two or three prophets should speak. Paul did not forbid one prophet to speak alone.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

when people prophesy, only two or three people should speak

14:29b

and the others should weigh carefully what is said.

- and the other people should think carefully about what they say.
- Then the believers should examine their message to know whether or not it is true.

and the others should weigh carefully what is said:

The phrase weigh carefully is an idiom that means “judge” or “decide.” Paul wanted the Corinthians to discuss the words of the prophets, and decide whether the message was truly from God and how it applied to them. The BSB has supplied the object what is said to make the English clear.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the others should evaluate the prophecies to know whether or not they are true

the others should examine the messages to decide whether they are from God or not

the others: It is not clear to whom the phrase the others refers. The two most likely possibilities are:

1. It refers to other believers present at the meeting. For example:

Two or three people should speak what God has revealed. Everyone else should decide whether what each person said is right or wrong. (GW) (GW, GNT, CEV, NET)

1. It refers to other prophets present at the meeting. For example:

Of the prophets, two or three may speak, while the rest exercise their judgment upon what is said. (REB)

If you must follow one interpretation, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is supported by several versions and commentaries. See, for example, Fee, p. 694; and Thiselton, p. 1141.

1 Corinthians 14:30

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:29–33a

In this paragraph Paul wrote about the right use of the gift of prophecy in the worship services of the church.

14:30a

And if a revelation comes to someone who is seated,

- And if God reveals something to one of the audience/listeners/congregation,
- If someone other than the speaker receives a message from God,

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces more information about the proper use of prophecy. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction explicitly. Others translate it as:

But (GNT)

You should translate it in a way that is natural in your language.

if a revelation comes to someone who is seated:

The person who spoke in their meetings would usually stand up to speak. Paul suggested that God might reveal something to one of the other believers, one who was not speaking.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

if God gives a message to someone who is sitting in the meeting

someone who is seated: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

somebody who is sitting to listen

somebody who is listening

someone in the congregation

14:30b

the first speaker should stop.

- then the first speaker should stop prophesying/ speaking.
- then the one speaking should be silent to let the other one speak.

the first speaker should stop: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as the first speaker should stop is more literally “let the first be silent.” The phrase the first speaker is used in contrast to the speaker who receives the new revelation. The phrase the first speaker does not mean the first prophet to speak. This situation could arise when the second or third prophet was speaking.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the person who is speaking should stop

the first speaker should be silent to let the other one speak

1 Corinthians 14:31

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:29–33a

In this paragraph Paul wrote about the right use of the gift of prophecy in the worship services of the church.

14:31a

For you can all prophesy in turn

- For you^(plur) can all prophesy one after the other
- If you do like this, you can take turns to declare God's word.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces the reason for the command Paul gave in 14:30. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction explicitly.

you can all prophesy in turn: Paul wanted all the prophets to whom God revealed a message to be able to speak. He told them that they should speak one at a time, not together. The word all means “up to three people” and does not mean literally “everyone.”

14:31b

so that everyone may be instructed and encouraged.

- so that everyone may learn and grow strong in their faith.
- Then those who speak may instruct and encourage everyone.

so that everyone may be instructed and encouraged: This gives the purpose for the prophets speaking one by one. The purpose was that all the believers could learn and be helped by God's word.

The verbs be instructed and be...encouraged are in the passive. There are two ways to translate these verbs:

- Use passive verbs. For example:

so that everyone may be taught and may be encouraged

- Use active verbs. For example:

so that all may receive instruction and encouragement (REB)

so that the prophets may instruct and encourage everyone

1 Corinthians 14:32

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:29–33a

In this paragraph Paul wrote about the right use of the gift of prophecy in the worship services of the church.

14:32

The spirits of prophets are subject to prophets.

- People who prophesy can control their own spirits.
- Those who declare God's word should control themselves by taking turns.

The Greek text has a conjunction that the BSB does not translate. Some versions translate it as “and.” It introduces a teaching that further explains Paul's instructions.

The spirits of prophets are subject to prophets:

There are two ways to interpret the phrase that the BSB translates as The spirits of prophets:

1. It refers to the prophets' own spirits. For example:

people who speak what God has revealed must control themselves (GW) (BSB, GW, NIV, ESV, NET, NASB, RSV, NLT, CEV, NCV, KJV)

1. It refers to the spiritual gift that the prophets possess. For example:

The gift of proclaiming God's message should be under the speaker's control (GNT) (GNT, NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is supported by many versions and commentaries. See, for example, Fee, p. 696; and Thiselton, p. 1144.

In this situation, the prophets would control themselves by waiting for the other person to speak. You can make this explicit by saying:

The prophets can control themselves by taking turns

1 Corinthians 14:33

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:29–33a

In this paragraph Paul wrote about the right use of the gift of prophecy in the worship services of the church.

14:33a

For God is not a God of disorder, but of peace—

- For God delights in peace. He does not delight in disorder.
- For God does not want us to have chaos in our worship. He wants us to have peace.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces the reason for Paul's statement in 14:32. Here is another way to translate this:

because (GNT)

God is not a God of disorder, but of peace: The clause God is not a God of disorder, but of peace indicates that God is characterized by peace and not by disorder. Because of this, he wants us to worship in an orderly and peaceful way. In some languages it may be natural to mention the positive first:

God is a God of peace, not of disorder.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

God loves good order and peace/harmony. He does not love bad order

God wants us to do things in an orderly and peaceful way, not in a disorderly way

God doesn't want us to have chaos when we worship, but to have peace

Paragraph 14:33b–35

In this paragraph Paul set out some principles for women taking part in worship services. Everything should be done in a way that is fitting and orderly. Individual churches should not invent their own practices but should follow the practices of the church at large.

14:33b

as in all the churches of the saints.

- ¶ As in all the churches of God's holy people,

- ¶ As is the case in all the Christian churches,

as in all the churches of the saints: There is an interpretation issue with this phrase. Some English versions put it at the end of verse 33.

1. This phrase starts a new sentence, and introduces a new idea about the behavior of women. For example:

As in all the churches of the saints (NET) (NET, ESV, NASB, NIV84, RSV, GW, REB, NCV, NJB, NABRE, GNT, CEV)

1. This phrase finishes the old sentence, and concludes the previous section about order in the church. For example:

—as in all the congregations of the Lord’s people. (NIV11) (BSB, NIV11, NLT, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the interpretation followed by most English versions and most commentaries. 14:33 See, for example, Grosheide, p.341; and Kistemaker, p. 511.

Here Paul introduced a custom that was common to all the churches with which he was acquainted. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

As is the case in all the churches of God’s people

churches: The Greek word that the BSB translates as churches is the same word that is used in 14:4b. It refers to a group of believers.

saints: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as saints is literally “holy ones.” It refers to Christian believers. They are holy because they belong to God. See how you translated this word in 6:1c.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

God’s people

the holy people of God

believers in Jesus

1 Corinthians 14:34

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:33b-35

In this paragraph Paul set out some principles for women taking part in worship services. Everything should be done in a way that is fitting and orderly. Individual churches should not invent their own practices but should follow the practices of the church at large.

14:34a

Women are to be silent in the churches.

- women should be quiet during the meetings/services.
- when you gather together, the women should keep quiet.

Women are to be silent in the churches: Paul did not want women to speak in a certain way during the church meetings. It was not the custom in that culture, and it was considered an example of disorder.

We know that Paul did not forbid all kinds of speech by women because in 11:5 Paul said that women can pray and prophesy in church. It is possible that Paul forbade women to question the prophets. However, the text does not make that explicit. You should translate the text as it stands.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

when you gather, the women must be quiet

be silent: The Greek word that the BSB translates as be silent is a general one that can refer either to

becoming quiet or remaining quiet. It is the same word that is used in 14:28b.

14:34b

They are not permitted to speak, but must be in submission, as the law says.

- They are not permitted to speak freely. They should be obedient, as the law says.
- They must not speak. Instead, they must obey the leaders. This is what God says in the law.

The Greek text has a conjunction that the BSB does not translate. The RSV translates it as “for.” It introduces the reason women should be silent in the church assemblies.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

for (RSV)

since (NJB)

Introduce this in a way that is natural in your language.

They are not permitted to speak: The phrase They are not permitted to speak indicates that women were not permitted to speak publicly in church worship services. Paul did not say who did not allow or permit the women to speak. It appears he was thinking of the custom of the churches. According to that custom, women did not speak out in church meetings.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

They must not speak

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but introduces a positive way to say what Paul had just stated in a negative way.

must be in submission: The expression must be in submission means that they must obey other people. Paul said the women must behave in the humble and modest way that was considered appropriate in that culture. Paul did not say who the women should submit to.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they should be obedient

they must be under other people

as the law says: Most commentators think that when Paul said the law he referred to the Scriptures, although there is no Old Testament passage that says this. In some languages it may be unnatural to say the law says something. It may be more natural to say:

as the law directs

as God tells us in the law

The Greek text has a word that the BSB does not translate. Here are some ways that it is translated in English versions:

as in fact the law says (NET)

as even the law says (RSV)

as the law also says (NRSV)

1 Corinthians 14:35

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:33b–35

In this paragraph Paul set out some principles for women taking part in worship services. Everything should be done in a way that is fitting and orderly. Individual churches should not invent their own practices but should follow the practices of the church at large.

14:35a

If they wish to inquire about something, they are to ask their own husbands at home;

- If the women want to ask questions, they should ask their own husbands when they get home.
- If one of the women wants to ask something, she should ask her own husband in private.

If they wish to inquire about something, they are to ask their own husbands at home: This phrase suggests that the women interrupted church meetings by asking questions.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

If they want to ask a question they should ask their husbands at home

14:35b

for it is dishonorable for a woman to speak in the church.

- For it is shameful for women to speak during church meetings.
- For it is improper/shocking for a woman to talk during a worship service.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *for* introduces another reason why Paul said women should remain silent in the church.

it is dishonorable for a woman to speak in the church: People thought that women behaved improperly when they spoke in church. It is not clear what kind of speaking Paul had in mind. See the note on 14:34a.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

it is a shocking thing for a woman to talk at the meeting (REB)

dishonorable: People thought this behavior was inappropriate. It made them think that Christian people did not know how to behave well.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

shameful

improper/inappropriate

it causes embarrassment

1 Corinthians 14:36

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:36–40

In this paragraph Paul talked about spiritual authority.

14:36a-b

This verse contains two rhetorical questions. Paul used these questions to rebuke the Corinthians. He said that the Corinthians were acting as though they were the only Christian believers. They were acting as though theirs was the only true church. He said that this was a wrong way to act.

14:36a

Did the word of God originate with you?

- Did God's message start with you^(plur) Corinthians?
- Do not imagine that God's word began at your church!

Did the word of God originate with you?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong sarcastic comment. He said that the word of God did not originate with them. He hoped that people would respond "No."

Here are some ways to translate this sarcastic comment:

- Use a question. For example:

Or do you think God's word originated with you Corinthians? (NLT)

Are you beginning to imagine that the Word of God originated in your church? (JBP)

- Use a statement. For example:

God's message did not start with you people (CEV)

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language to make a strong statement. In some languages there may be a way to mark this as irony or sarcasm.

originate with: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

come from

begin with

14:36b

Or are you the only ones it has reached?

- Are you the only people his message/word has reached?
- Surely you do not think that you are the only church that has received his word!

Or are you the only ones it has reached?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement. He said that the word of God went to other people besides those in Corinth.

Here are some ways to translate this statement:

- Use a question. For example:

Or are you the only ones to whom it has come?
(NCV)

- Use a statement. For example:

and you are not the only ones it has reached (CEV)

Translate this strong statement in a way that is natural in your language.

1 Corinthians 14:37

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:36–40

In this paragraph Paul talked about spiritual authority.

14:37a

If anyone considers himself a prophet or spiritual person,

- ¶ If any one considers himself a prophet, or a spiritual person,
- ¶ If any of you think that you can declare God's word or think that you have spiritual gifts,

If anyone considers himself a prophet or spiritual person: Paul addressed those Corinthians who considered themselves to have spiritual gifts. In some languages it may be natural to use a second-person pronoun:

If any of you think you are prophets or spiritual people

There were many such people in the church in Corinth. In some languages it may not be natural to use a word meaning "if." Instead, it may be possible to follow the model of the GW:

Whoever thinks that he speaks for God or that he is spiritually gifted (GW)

prophet: Translate the word prophet the way you did in 12:28b.

spiritual person: The Greek word that the BSB translates as spiritual person is literally spiritual. Here is another way to translate this:

has a spiritual gift (GNT)

14:37b

let him acknowledge that what I am writing you is the Lord's command.

- he should acknowledge that what I am writing to you^(plur) is a command from the Lord.
- you must recognize my words as the commands of the Lord Jesus.

let him acknowledge that what I am writing you is the Lord's command: Paul was an apostle of the Lord Jesus. As an apostle, Paul had the authority to declare the Lord's will in these matters.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he should acknowledge that what I write to you is the Lord's command (NET)

[he] must acknowledge that what I write to you is what the Lord commands (GW)

let him acknowledge: The verb that the BSB translates as acknowledge is in the form of a command. There are two ways to interpret this word:

1. It means to admit that something is true. Paul asked the spiritual people to confirm that they knew that what he wrote was from the Lord. For example:

he should acknowledge (NET) (BSB, NET, NIV, ESV, RSV, GW, KJV)

1. It means to understand or realize something. For example:

he must realize (GNT) (GNT, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This has strong support in English versions and in the commentaries. See, for example, Fee, p. 721; and Morris, p. 198. Paul told the prophets and other church leaders that they should accept and admit that what he wrote was a command of the Lord.

Here are some other ways to translate this Greek verb:

he must admit

he must confirm

the Lord's command: The phrase the Lord's refers to the Lord Jesus.

1 Corinthians 14:38

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he

said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:36–40

In this paragraph Paul talked about spiritual authority.

14:38

But if anyone ignores this, he himself will be ignored.

- If he does not acknowledge this fact, he himself will not be acknowledged.
- If you refuse to recognize that they are the Lord's commands, God will not recognize you as one who declares God's word.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a contrast to 14:37. The contrast is between people who acknowledge what Paul has written and those who ignore it. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. Express this contrast in a natural way in your language.

if anyone ignores this: The phrase if anyone ignores this refers to a situation in which someone refuses to acknowledge Paul's authority as an apostle.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

if someone does not recognize this (NET)

if he does not acknowledge this (GNT)

he himself will be ignored: There is a textual issue here. Some Greek manuscripts have a statement and some have a command. The two options are:

1. This is a statement. Paul said that the person who refuses to recognize Paul's authority will not be recognized. For example:

he is not recognized (ESV) (BSB, ESV, RSV, NJB, NIV, NCV, NET, NLT, NASB)

1. This is a command. Paul said that the believers should not recognize the authority of someone who does not recognize Paul's authority. For example:

is not to be recognized (NRSV) (NRSV, GW, GNT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) which is supported by the UBS Greek New Testament. This is given a B rating by the 4th edition of the UBS Greek NT, indicating that the text is "almost certain."

will be ignored: This is a passive verb. In the Greek it is in the present tense. There are two ways to translate this passive verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

is not recognized (RSV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

does not receive recognition

God will not recognize him

God will not recognize that he has spiritual gifts

In some languages it may be necessary to supply a subject. Most commentaries agree that the subject of the verb is God. See, for example, Fee, p. 712; Kistemaker, p. 527; Grosheide, p. 344. Here is another way to translate this:

Those who ignore this will be ignored by God (NCV)

1 Corinthians 14:39

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:36–40

In this paragraph Paul talked about spiritual authority.

14:39a

So, my brothers, be eager to prophesy,

- So then, my brothers and sisters, you should want to prophesy,
- In conclusion, dear friends, be enthusiastic to declare God's word,

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *So* introduces a concluding command about how the Corinthians should act. Here is another way to translate this:

So then (GNT)

my brothers: Here as elsewhere Paul referred to Christian believers, not to his relatives. He spoke to both men and women.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

my friends (GNT)

be eager to prophesy: The phrase *be eager to prophesy* indicates that Paul wanted the believers to be enthusiastic about declaring the word of God. It was a good thing, and he encouraged them to do it.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

strongly desire to prophesy

you should want to have the spiritual gift of prophecy

14:39b

and do not forbid speaking in tongues.

- and do not forbid people to speak in an unknown tongue.
- but do not stop people from speaking in unknown/miraculous languages.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *and* introduces another command. This command contrasts with the command in 14:39a. In some languages

it may be more natural to translate the conjunction as “but.” Introduce this second negative command in a way that is natural in your language.

do not forbid speaking in tongues: Although Paul wrote favorably about prophecy in this chapter, he never said the Corinthians should not use the gift of tongues. Here he told them to permit people to speak in tongues.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

do not stop people from using the gift of speaking in different kinds of languages (NCV)

1 Corinthians 14:40

Section 14:1–40 Believers should worship God in an orderly way

In this section Paul instructed the Corinthian believers about how they should worship God together. First, he compared prophecy and tongues. He stressed the value of prophecy for building up the church. Then he said they should conduct their worship services in an orderly and harmonious way. They were not to speak all at once. People who spoke in tongues should have someone to interpret, and women were to remain silent in the assembly.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Good order in worship

The spiritual gifts of prophecy and tongues

Use spiritual gifts to help the church grow

Paragraph 14:36–40

In this paragraph Paul talked about spiritual authority.

14:40

But everything must be done in a proper and orderly manner.

- But do everything in an appropriate and ordered manner.
- And all your^(plur) worship must be proper and organized well.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a concluding command. It contrasts with the previous commands. Although the Corinthians should use the gifts of prophecy and tongues, they need to do everything (including these gifts) in a “fitting and orderly way.” The GNT does not explicitly translate this conjunction. The NET translates it as

“And.” Consider how it is natural to introduce such a final command in your language.

everything must be done in a proper and orderly manner: Paul wrote a final appeal for everything to be done in a proper and orderly way in the worship services. Here is another way to translate this:

Let everything be done decently and in order (NJB)

everything must be done: This is a passive phrase. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

make sure that everything is done (NJB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

do everything (CEV)

in a proper...manner: The Greek word that the BSB translates as in a proper...manner is an adverb that means “properly, appropriately, with decorum.” Paul wanted the Corinthians to worship God in a manner that brought honor to God.

Here are some other ways to translate this Greek word:

in an appropriate way

in the right way

orderly manner: The phrase orderly manner describes actions that are regulated and controlled.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in a careful way

in a well-organized way

in a way that follows the rules

1 Corinthians 15:1

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from

the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:1–2

This paragraph serves as an introduction to the next paragraph. Paul reminded the Corinthians about the gospel message that he had preached to them.

15:1–2

In Greek these two verses form one long sentence. The NASB is an English version that translates it as one sentence:

Now I make known to you, brethren, the gospel which I preached to you, which also you received, in which also you stand, by which also you are saved, if you hold fast the word which I preached to you, unless you believed in vain. (NASB)

In English such a long sentence is not easy to understand. The BSB has broken it up into three sentences. The NCV provides a model for how to break it up into four sentences:

Now, brothers and sisters, I want you to remember the Good News I brought to you. You received this Good News and continue strong in it. And you are being saved by it if you continue believing what I told you. If you do not, then you believed for nothing. (NCV)

Consider the length of sentence that is natural and easy to understand in your language. Also consider whether it is necessary to join the sentences using words such as “and” or “also.”

15:1a

Now, brothers, I want to remind you of the gospel I preached to you,

- ¶ Now, brothers and sisters, I want to write/talk about the gospel that I preached to you^(plur).
- ¶ At this point, my friends, let me tell you again about the good news I declared to you.

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now introduces a new topic in the letter. It is not

a time word. You should introduce this new topic in a way that is natural in your language.

brothers: The word brothers was a friendly way to address people. Paul was talking to all the Corinthian believers, both men and women.

I want to remind you of the gospel I preached to you: The Corinthians already knew about the gospel. Paul reminded them of it and made it more clear.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I will tell you (again) about the gospel

I don't want you to forget the gospel

the gospel I preached to you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as preached is more literally “evangelized” or “told the gospel.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the good news that I told you about

the gospel that I taught/proclaimed to you

the gospel: The phrase the gospel refers to the good news about God's plan to save people. See how you translated this word in 1:17.

15:1b

which you received, and in which you stand firm.

- This is the gospel that you^(plur) accepted and which your faith depends on.
- You accepted this good news as true, and you trust God firmly because of it.

which you received: The verb received means both to hear something and to accept it as true. The Corinthians heard and accepted the gospel.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

which you accepted as true

which you heard and received

You may find it helpful to start a new sentence at this point. For example:

You received it

and in which you stand firm: This is a figure of speech. It compares the gospel to a strong place that the Corinthians stood in. It indicates that they trusted the gospel and continued to depend on it. There are two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

you stand firmly in the gospel

you have made it the foundation of your faith

your faith depends on it

- Translate the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

you have believed the gospel

you trust in God firmly because of the gospel

the gospel makes your faith firm

Translate this figure of speech in a way that is natural in your language.

1 Corinthians 15:2

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:1–2

This paragraph serves as an introduction to the next paragraph. Paul reminded the Corinthians about the gospel message that he had preached to them.

15:2a

By this gospel you are saved,

- You^(plur) are being saved by this gospel,
- Because of this good news God saves you

By this gospel you are saved: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as you are saved is in the present tense. It indicates that the Corinthians were in the process of being saved at that time.

This is a passive clause. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

you are being saved by this gospel

- Use an active verb. For example:

this gospel saves you

by/through this gospel God is saving you

15:2b

if you hold firmly to the word I preached to you.

- provided that you^(plur) keep the message I preached to you.
- so long as you continue to rely/depend on what I taught you.

if you hold firmly to the word I preached to you:

This phrase states a condition that would save the Corinthians. They are saved by the gospel only if they continued to trust it.

hold firmly: The verb hold firmly is a figure of speech. When we hold firmly onto something, we continue to value it and rely on it. There are two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

hold onto it

do not let it go

- Translate the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

continue to firmly believe

continue to rely/depend on

have a heart that trusts firmly

the word I preached to you: The phrase the word refers to the message that Paul taught about the gospel.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the message I taught/proclaimed to you

General Comment on 15:2a-b

This sentence is complex. In some languages it may be natural to change the order of its parts. For example:

^{2b}If you hold firmly to the message about the gospel that I preached to you, ^{2a}you will be saved by it.

15:2c

Otherwise, you have believed in vain.

- If you^(plur) do not keep it you have trusted it for nothing.
- If you do not trust God firmly, you will receive no benefit from it.

Otherwise: The word Otherwise means “if not.” It may be helpful to fill out the implied information. For example:

If you do not hold firmly to the gospel

you have believed in vain: The Greek word that the BSB translates as in vain means “with no result.” Paul said that if the Corinthians did not hold firmly to the gospel, then their faith was of no use. There may be an idiom to express this in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

you believed for nothing

your faith has no benefit

there is no use to you having believed

The benefit they receive from their faith is that God saves them. It is possible to translate it as:

If you don't hold firmly to the gospel, I cannot tell you that God will save you

1 Corinthians 15:3

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:3–8

In this paragraph Paul reminded the Corinthians of four important events that form the gospel message:

- Christ died for our sins.
- They buried his body.
- He came back to life on the third day.
- Many people saw him after he came back to life.

15:3a

For what I received I passed on to you as of first importance:

- ¶ For the teaching that other people taught me, I taught you^(plur) as most important:
- ¶ For I told you about the events that other people told me. These things are very important:

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces an explanation of what Paul said in 15:1–2. Translate it in a way that is natural in your language to introduce an explanation.

what I received I passed on to you: This clause introduces a summary of four historical events that are central to the Christian faith. Paul said that he heard this story from others, and he then told it to the Corinthians. The wording is very similar to 11:23a.

received: Paul received the gospel message from other believers.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I handed on to you the message that I received

the message that they/other people told me, I also told to you

as of first importance: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as as of first importance:

1. It means “most important.” For example:

the most important points (GW) (BSB, GW, NIV, NASB, RSV, ESV, NET, NLT, NCV, NABRE, GNT, CEV)

1. It means “first in time.” For example:

in the first place (NJB) (NJB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is supported by the majority of English versions and commentaries. See, for example, Fee p. 722; and Thiselton p. 1186.

15:3b-5

that...that...that...and that: Paul listed four points that make up the gospel message. In Greek, each of the four points is introduced by a word often translated as that. The points are connected to each other by a conjunction usually translated as and. The NJB is an example of an English version that stays close to the Greek:

^{3b}that Christ died for our sins, in accordance with the scriptures, ⁴and that he was buried; and that on the third day, he was raised to life, in accordance with the scriptures; ⁵and that he appeared to Cephas... (NJB)

The BSB uses the word and to connect only the last item in the list. Translate these conjunctions in a way that is natural in your language to connect four facts.

15:3b

that Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures,

- Christ died on account of our^(incl) sins, as the Scriptures say/foretell.
- Christ died because of our sins, which is what the Scriptures said would happen.

that: The word that introduces the first of the four events that form the gospel message.

Christ died for our sins: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as for our sins is more literally “because of our sins” or “on account of our sins.” Christ died for the wrong things that we have done.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Christ died because we^(incl) sinned

according to the Scriptures: The phrase according to the Scriptures indicates that the Old Testament Scriptures say that Christ was going to die for the sins of the people. See, for example, Isaiah 53.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

as is written in the Scriptures

as the Scriptures say it will happen

1 Corinthians 15:4

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:3–8

In this paragraph Paul reminded the Corinthians of four important events that form the gospel message:

- Christ died for our sins.
- They buried his body.
- He came back to life on the third day.
- Many people saw him after he came back to life.

15:4a

that He was buried,

- Then he was buried.
- People placed him in a tomb.

that: The word that introduces the second of the four events that form the gospel message.

He was buried: The clause He was buried is passive. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

He was placed in a tomb. (GW)

- Use an active verb. For example:

people/they buried him

buried: People buried Jesus by placing his body in a tomb that was cut into a hillside. They did not place his body under the ground. The words that you use should allow for this understanding.

15:4b

that He was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures,

- Then he was raised from the dead on the third day, as the Scriptures say/foretell.
- The third day after that, God raised him to life. Again, this is what the Scriptures said will happen.

that: The word that introduces the third of the four events that form the gospel message.

He was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures: Jesus was raised. God made him to be alive again. In some languages it may be natural to say explicitly:

that he was raised from the dead

that he was raised to life

This is a passive clause. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

he was raised to life on the third day (REB)

- Use an active verb, supplying the subject “God.” For example:

God raised him on the third day

1 Corinthians 15:5

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from

the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:3–8

In this paragraph Paul reminded the Corinthians of four important events that form the gospel message:

- Christ died for our sins.
- They buried his body.
- He came back to life on the third day.
- Many people saw him after he came back to life.

15:5

and that He appeared to Cephas and then to the Twelve.

- Then Jesus appeared to Cephas, and then he appeared to the twelve apostles.
- Then Peter and all of the twelve apostles saw him alive.

and that: The word that introduces the fourth of the four events that form the gospel message.

He appeared to Cephas: The phrase He appeared to Cephas indicates that after his resurrection Jesus came to Cephas and allowed Cephas to see him alive.

Cephas: Cephas is another name for Jesus’ disciple Simon Peter. You may wish to follow the GNT and use the better-known name Peter here.

and then to the Twelve: Jesus also appeared to the other apostles. Cephas/Peter was one of the Twelve. The phrase the Twelve refers to the original twelve disciples. Paul used this phrase even though Judas was no longer with them.

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

he made himself appear to Cephas and then to the twelve apostles

Cephas and the rest of the twelve apostles saw that he was alive

after he came back to life Cephas and the other twelve apostles saw him

1 Corinthians 15:6

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:3–8

In this paragraph Paul reminded the Corinthians of four important events that form the gospel message:

- Christ died for our sins.
- They buried his body.
- He came back to life on the third day.
- Many people saw him after he came back to life.

15:6a

After that, He appeared to more than five hundred brothers at once,

- Afterwards, he appeared to more than five hundred believers at once.
- Later, over five hundred of his followers/disciples saw him alive while they were gathered together.

After that: The phrase After that means “after Jesus appeared to Peter and the Twelve.” This time period was less than forty days. Jesus ascended to heaven forty days after his resurrection.

He appeared to more than five hundred brothers:

The word brothers refers to people who believed in Jesus. It included both men and women.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he appeared to over five hundred of his disciples/believers

he showed himself to more than five hundred people who followed him

at once: The phrase at once means that the five hundred people were together when they saw him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

on the same day

when they were gathered together

15:6b

most of whom are still living, though some have fallen asleep.

- Most of these people are still alive, although some have died.
- Some of these followers/disciples have died, but most of them are alive to this day.

most of whom are still living: Paul wrote this twenty or twenty-five years after Jesus rose from the dead. Most, but not all, of the witnesses were still alive.

though some have fallen asleep: Here, fallen asleep is another way to say that someone was dead. If this euphemism is not familiar in your language, another way to translate it is:

some of them have died

In some languages it is clearer to change the order of these clauses:

some of them have died, but most of them are still alive

1 Corinthians 15:7

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:3–8

In this paragraph Paul reminded the Corinthians of four important events that form the gospel message:

- Christ died for our sins.
- They buried his body.
- He came back to life on the third day.
- Many people saw him after he came back to life.

15:7

Then He appeared to James, then to all the apostles.

- Then he appeared to James, and then to all the other apostles.
- Later, James the brother of Jesus saw him, and then all the apostles saw him.

Then He appeared to James: This refers to James, the younger brother of Jesus. He was not one of the original twelve apostles.

then to all the apostles: This refers to a larger group than the twelve disciples. It likely included James and other leaders of the early church.

1 Corinthians 15:8**Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead**

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:3–8

In this paragraph Paul reminded the Corinthians of four important events that form the gospel message:

- Christ died for our sins.
- They buried his body.
- He came back to life on the third day.
- Many people saw him after he came back to life.

15:8

And last of all He appeared to me also, as to one of untimely birth.

- And at the end he appeared to me, as to someone born in the wrong way.
- And finally I also saw him, even though I was not worthy to see him.

And last of all: The phrase last of all means “last in a sequence.” Note a change that takes place at the beginning of verse 8. In verses 5 through 7, adverbial conjunctions are used to make the connections between the witnesses. The Greek word ‘de’ is used at the beginning of verse 8 to signal that the following information is different. It introduces a witness that is important to the development of Paul’s argument. English does not have a way to signal this. If your language has a way to signal this, use it here. Of all the people he mentioned, Paul was the last to see Christ.

He appeared to me also: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to me also is emphatic. Consider how you might show that emphasis in your translation.

as to one of untimely birth: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as as to one of untimely birth is more literally “like a miscarriage.” Paul used this figure of speech to emphasize that he did not become an apostle the same way the other twelve apostles did. He persecuted Jesus’ followers. Because of this he felt unworthy to be an apostle. There are two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

as though I was a child born abnormally (NJB)

I was like an aborted fetus whose birth is not counted as a child

I was like a stillborn child who is not expected to live

- Translate the meaning. For example:

I was not worthy to see him

of untimely birth: There are two ways to interpret the meaning of the Greek word that the BSB translates as untimely birth:

1. It means miscarriage or abortion. For example:

I am like an aborted child who was given life (GW)
(GW, NIV, GNT, NJB)

1. It means born at the wrong time. For example:

born at the wrong time (NET) (BSB, NET, ESV, RSV, CEV, NLT, NCV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is supported by many English versions and commentaries. See, for example, Fee p. 733; and Thiselton p. 1210. and it fits with what Paul said in 15:9.

If you follow interpretation (2), avoid the word “premature,” because Paul became a believer at a late time, not an early time. Instead use a phrase such as “at the wrong time.”

1 Corinthians 15:9

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:9–11

In this paragraph Paul wrote how God chose him and made him an apostle. He emphasized that the gospel he preached and the gospel the other apostles preached was the same.

15:9a

For I am the least of the apostles

- ¶ I say this because I am the least important of the apostles.
- ¶ I am the lowest/smallest of the apostles.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces an explanation of what Paul meant when he referred to himself as “one abnormally born.”

I am the least of the apostles: The clause I am the least of the apostles means “I am the least important of the apostles.” Paul is one of the apostles, but said that the other apostles were greater than him.

15:9b

and am unworthy to be called an apostle,

- In fact, I do not qualify for people to call me an apostle,
- I am not worthy of the title “apostle,”

and am unworthy to be called an apostle: The phrase am unworthy to be called an apostle can also be translated:

I am not worthy to be called an apostle

I am not qualified to be called an apostle

God should not have made me be an apostle

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence:

I do not deserve to be called an apostle

to be called an apostle: The verb phrase to be called an apostle is in the passive. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

to be called an apostle (RSV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

for people to call/consider me an apostle

15:9c

because I persecuted the church of God.

- because I acted/behaved harshly to God’s people.
- because I treated the people badly/brutally who believe in God.

because I persecuted the church of God: This is the reason why Paul felt that he did not deserve to be an apostle. Before he was converted, he put Christians in prison and treated them badly. He tried to make them stop following Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I acted harshly to the church of God

I made lots of trouble for the church of God

I caused the church of God to suffer before I believed

the church of God: The phrase the church of God refers to all the people who together form the church.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

God's people

those who believe in God

1 Corinthians 15:10

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:9–11

In this paragraph Paul wrote how God chose him and made him an apostle. He emphasized that the gospel he preached and the gospel the other apostles preached was the same.

15:10a

But by the grace of God I am what I am,

- But God in his grace/kindness made me an apostle
- But because God was kind to me I have this work to do.

by the grace of God I am what I am: Paul said that he became an apostle because God was kind to him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

It is because of God's kindness that I am an apostle

I get to do this work because God was kind to me

by the grace of God: The phrase by the grace of God means "because God was kind to me." God was kind to

Paul in that he chose him to be an apostle. See grace in the Key Biblical Terms A.2.b.

15:10b

and His grace to me was not in vain.

- and his grace/kindness to me was not useless/wasted.
- He was gracious/kind to me, and it had good results.

and His grace to me was not in vain: The phrase His grace to me was not in vain indicates that God's kindness to Paul when he made him an apostle resulted in good things.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

his grace to me has not been in vain (NET)

that kindness was not wasted on me (GW)

was not in vain: The BSB, like the Greek, uses two negative terms (not and in vain). In some languages it may be natural to translate it in a positive way. For example:

was effective

had good results

bore fruit

15:10c

No, I worked harder than all of them—

- For I worked harder than any of the other apostles.
- The result was, I worked harder at preaching the gospel than all the other apostles.

Paul demonstrated that God's grace was not in vain or wasted.

No: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as No is literally "but." It introduces a positive statement that confirms and explains the previous double negative statement.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

on the contrary (RSV, GNT)

in fact (NET)

instead (GW)

for (NLT)

If you have translated 15:10b as a positive statement, it will not be possible to translate this literally. Instead, you should use a word that is natural in your language. For example:

For

I worked harder than all of them: Paul said that he worked harder at preaching the gospel than any of the other apostles. It may be clearer to say this explicitly:

I made greater efforts to preach the gospel than any of the other apostles did.

15:10d
yet not I, but the grace of God that was with me.

- But it was not really I who was working, but God, who in his kindness was with me.
- But it was not actually I who was working. It was God, who was being kind/gracious to me.

In verse 10d Paul added some extra information that changed the emphasis of what he said in 10c. The BSB connects 15:10c and 15:10d with a dash. Some English versions start a new sentence at 15:10d. Introduce this information in a way that is natural in your language.

yet not I: The phrase yet not I is a short way to say, “yet it was not really I who worked.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

it was not really my own doing (GNT)

Actually, it is not I who did this work

but the grace of God that was with me: The phrase but the grace of God that was with me is another short form. The full clause is:

instead, it was the grace of God that was with me that worked hard

This is a figure of speech. In some languages it may not be natural to say that grace or “kindness” can work or do something.

Here are some other ways to translate this figure of speech:

actually, I didn’t work by my own ability, but God was kind to me and helped me to work

it is not that I can do this kind of work, but because God showed me his grace, I am able to do it

1 Corinthians 15:11

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:9–11

In this paragraph Paul wrote how God chose him and made him an apostle. He emphasized that the gospel he preached and the gospel the other apostles preached was the same.

15:11a

Whether, then, it was I or they, this is what we preach,

- So whether it was I or the other apostles who preached to you^(plur), we^(excl) preached that same message.
- So it does not matter if I preached to you, or the other apostles preached to you. We^(excl) all preached the same gospel,

Whether...it was I or they: Paul indicated that it was not important whether it was he or the other apostles who preached, because they all preached the same gospel.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

But it doesn’t matter if I preached or if they preached (CEV)

they: The pronoun they refers to the other apostles. The NCV makes this explicit:

if I preached to you or the other apostles
preached to you (NCV)

then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as then introduces a conclusion Paul made from his previous statement. It is not a time word. Here is another way to translate this:

So then (GNT)

this is what we preach: The word this refers to the gospel Paul wrote about in 15:3–8. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as “that.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

that is what we^(excl) preach

we all preach the same thing (NCV)

that is the message we brought you

we: The pronoun we is exclusive. It refers to Paul and the other apostles, but does not include the Corinthians.

**15:11b
and this is what you believed.**

- And that is the message that you^(plur) believed.
- and this is the gospel in which you placed your trust.

and this is what you believed: The word this refers back to the content of the gospel that Paul stated in 15:3–8.

1 Corinthians 15:12

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:12–19

In this paragraph Paul said that it is important to believe in the resurrection of the dead. If the dead are not raised, then Christ was not raised. If Christ was not raised, then his people are not saved.

15:12a

But if it is preached that Christ has been raised from the dead,

- ¶ Because we^(excl) preach that Christ has come back to life,
- ¶ We preach that God has raised Christ from among the dead people,

But: There are two ways to interpret the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But:

1. It introduces a new thought or transition in Paul's argument. For example:

Now (RSV) (RSV, GNT, KJV, NET, REB, NCV, NASB, ESV)

1. It introduces a problem or a contrast with what Paul said in 15:9–11. For example:

But (BSB) (NLT, NIV, NABRE)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). There is stronger support for it by English versions. Translate this in the way that is most natural in your language for introducing a new part to an argument.

if: This is an if clause that is true. Paul preached that Christ was raised from the dead. In some languages it may be natural to say:

since

because

it is preached that: This is a passive clause. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

if Christ is proclaimed (ESV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

if we preach that Christ has risen

Christ has been raised from the dead: This is a passive clause. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

Christ was raised (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

Christ has risen

Christ has come alive

God caused Christ to become alive

God has raised Christ from among the dead people

15:12b

how can some of you say that there is no resurrection of the dead?

- how can some of you^(plur) say that dead people do not rise?
- so you surely cannot say that the dead will not come alive again.

how can some of you say that there is no resurrection of the dead?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement. He was surprised that some of the Corinthians said that there was no resurrection of the dead. Paul said that they were not thinking clearly.

Here are some ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

how can some of you say that the dead will not be raised to life? (CEV)

- Use a strong statement. For example:

you surely cannot say that there is no resurrection of the dead!

it does not make sense for you to say that the dead will not come back to life

Translate this strong statement in a way that is natural in your language to express surprise.

1 Corinthians 15:13

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:12–19

In this paragraph Paul said that it is important to believe in the resurrection of the dead. If the dead are not raised, then Christ was not raised. If Christ was not raised, then his people are not saved.

15:13a

If there is no resurrection of the dead,

- If dead people do not rise,
- If God does not cause dead people to live again,

If there is no resurrection of the dead: This is a restatement of the end of the previous verse. It is a statement that Paul believed to be false. In some languages there may be a special way to indicate that Paul believed this to be false.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

if there were no resurrection of the dead

suppose that there is no resurrection

if it is true that there is no resurrection

resurrection: In some languages it may be natural to translate the abstract noun resurrection with a verb. For example:

if the dead are not raised

if dead people do not come back to life

If God does not cause dead people to live again

15:13b

then not even Christ has been raised.

- then not even Christ has risen.
- then Christ himself has not become alive again.

then not even Christ has been raised: This phrase states one of the consequences if the previous phrase is true. In some languages there may be a special way to indicate an untrue or unreal situation.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

then Christ himself has not come back to life

1 Corinthians 15:14

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:12–19

In this paragraph Paul said that it is important to believe in the resurrection of the dead. If the dead are not raised, then Christ was not raised. If Christ was not raised, then his people are not saved.

15:14a

And if Christ has not been raised,

- And if Christ has not risen,
- And if Christ has not become alive again,

And if Christ has not been raised: This is a repetition of the end of the previous verse. Paul continued to talk about a situation which is false. It may be natural to use the same form as in 13a.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

if Christ were not raised

suppose that Christ was not raised

if it is true that Christ has not been raised

15:14b–15b

Paul listed three things that result if there is no resurrection. This is what the situation would be if Christ has not been raised.

15:14b

our preaching is worthless, and so is your faith.

- our preaching and your^(plur) faith are both worthless.
- it is useless for us^(excl) to preach the gospel to you, and it is useless for you to believe it.

our preaching is worthless: This is the first result. The phrase our preaching refers to the content of the apostles' preaching. In some languages it may be natural to translate our preaching as a verb phrase:

what we^(excl) preach about is worthless

worthless: The Greek word that the BSB translates as worthless can also be translated as:

empty

of no value/benefit

and so is your faith: This is the second result. The phrase and so is your faith is a short way to say, "and your faith is also useless." In some languages it may be natural to translate your faith as a verb phrase:

it is also useless for you to believe the gospel

1 Corinthians 15:15

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:12–19

In this paragraph Paul said that it is important to believe in the resurrection of the dead. If the dead are not raised, then Christ was not raised. If Christ was not raised, then his people are not saved.

15:15a

In that case, we are also exposed as false witnesses about God.

- Even more, we^(excl) are then seen to have given a testimony about God that is not true.
- In addition, we apostles are people who tell lies about what God has done.

In that case: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *In that case* introduces a third thing that is true if Christ has not been raised.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

In addition (GW)

Even more

we are also exposed as false witnesses about God:

The phrase *exposed as false witnesses* was used in law courts. It indicated that somebody told a lie in a court case, and that the judge discovered they were lying.

The verb phrase *we are...exposed* is passive. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

We are shown to be lying (GNT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

it is clear that we^(excl) are false witnesses

we are guilty of lying (NCV)

we are witnesses who told a lie

we are preachers who tell lies

we: The pronoun *we* means “we apostles.” It is an exclusive *we* that does not include Paul’s readers.

false witnesses about God: The phrase *false witnesses about God* means “false witnesses about what God did.” If there is no resurrection, the apostles told a lie when they said that God raised Jesus from the dead.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

witnesses who lied about God (GW)

15:15b

For we have testified about God that He raised Christ from the dead,

- For we^(excl) have given testimony that God raised Christ from the dead.
- We lied when we said that God raised Christ from the dead.

For we have testified about God that He raised Christ from the dead: This explains the lie that the apostles told. They stated that God had raised Christ.

General Comment on 15:15a-b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 15:15a and 15:15b. For example:

^{15b}And because we^(excl) testified that God raised Christ from the dead, ^{15a}we will be found guilty of giving false testimony about God.

15:15c

but He did not raise Him if in fact the dead are not raised.

- But God did not raise Christ if in reality the dead do not rise.
- But if it is true that the dead are not raised to life, then God did not raise Christ.

but He did not raise Him if in fact the dead are not raised: This is a restatement of 15:13a-b with the order of the clauses reversed.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

God could not raise Christ if it were the case that the dead are not raised

It may be clearer to reorder the clauses, as in the GNT:

but if it is true that the dead are not raised to life, then he did not raise Christ. (GNT)

General Comment on 15:15a-c

The CEV provides another model for reordering this verse:

^{15c}If the dead won't be raised to life, ^{15a}we have told lies about God ^{15b}by saying that he raised Christ to life, ^{15c}when he really did not. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 15:16**Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead**

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:12–19

In this paragraph Paul said that it is important to believe in the resurrection of the dead. If the dead are not raised, then Christ was not raised. If Christ was not raised, then his people are not saved.

15:16a**For if the dead are not raised,**

- For if dead people do not rise,
- For if he does not cause dead people to live again,

For if the dead are not raised: Verse 16 is a repetition of verse 13 with similar words. It reminds readers of the starting point of Paul's argument. It also repeats the content of 15:15c. In some languages it may be natural to shorten the phrase. For example:

For if that is not so

For if not

15:16b**then not even Christ has been raised.**

- then even Christ has not risen.

- then he did not make Christ alive again.

then not even Christ has been raised: This repeats the content of 15:13b and 15:15c. Consider if it is natural to use identical words or to vary the vocabulary.

1 Corinthians 15:17**Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead**

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:12–19

In this paragraph Paul said that it is important to believe in the resurrection of the dead. If the dead are not raised, then Christ was not raised. If Christ was not raised, then his people are not saved.

15:17a**And if Christ has not been raised,**

- And if Christ has not risen,
- And if Christ has not become alive again,

And if Christ has not been raised: This is a repetition of the end of the previous verse. Consider whether it is natural in your language to repeat the information from 15:16b or to use a short form such as:

And if that is not so

As in 15:14a, this clause is followed by three consequences.

15:17b**your faith is futile;**

- then your^(plur) faith is meaningless.
- for you to trust Christ to forgive your sins is pointless.

your faith is futile: This is the first of three consequences if Christ has not been raised. The Greek

word that the BSB translates as futile has a similar meaning to the word in 15:14b that the BSB translates as “worthless.” Some commentators suggest that the word here is stronger and means “without result.” See, for example, Fee p. 743; and Thiselton p.1219–20.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

your faith is useless (NET)

your faith is pointless (NJB)

In some languages it may be natural to translate your faith as a verb phrase:

you believe for nothing

it is useless for you to believe

there is no good/benefit for you in believing in Christ

15:17c

you are still in your sins.

- You^(plur) are still guilty of your sins.
- Your sins remain unforgiven.

you are still in your sins: This is the second of three consequences if Christ has not been raised. The phrase you are still in your sins means that God still considers the believers to be guilty of their sin.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

your sins have never been forgiven (JBP)

you are still guilty of your sins (NCV)

you are still bearing your own sins

It is important that readers understand that this is not the real state of affairs. This is only what would be true if Christ had not risen from the dead.

1 Corinthians 15:18

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then

(15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:12–19

In this paragraph Paul said that it is important to believe in the resurrection of the dead. If the dead are not raised, then Christ was not raised. If Christ was not raised, then his people are not saved.

15:18

Then those also who have fallen asleep in Christ have perished.

- Then also those people who have died trusting Christ have died completely and will never live again.
- And in addition, if Christ has not become alive again, believers who have died are gone forever.

Then...also: The Greek words that the BSB translates as Then...also introduces the third of the three consequences if Christ did not rise from the dead. Here is another way to translate this:

It would also mean that (GNT)

those...who have fallen asleep in Christ have perished: Paul indicated that if Christ did not rise, then believers who died are still in their sins. They died in a state of guilt, unreconciled with God.

those...who have fallen asleep in Christ: The phrase fallen asleep in Christ is another way to speak about believers who died. See also 15:6b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the believers in Christ who have died (GNT)

all who have died believing in Christ (NLT)

have perished: The phrase have perished indicates a state without hope. If Christ was not raised from the dead, then believers who have died will never be raised from the dead.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

have died and will never live again

1 Corinthians 15:19

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:12–19

In this paragraph Paul said that it is important to believe in the resurrection of the dead. If the dead are not raised, then Christ was not raised. If Christ was not raised, then his people are not saved.

15:19a

If our hope in Christ is for this life alone,

- If our^(incl) hope in Christ is only for this life,
- If we can only hope that Christ will help us while we are alive here but not after we die,

If our hope in Christ is for this life alone: This suggests a situation that is not true. It suggests that believers can only trust Christ to help them during this life. Paul did not believe this. He believed that we will have eternal life.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If our hope in Christ is good only for this life (CEV)

If it is for this life only that Christ has given us hope (REB)

In some languages it may be natural to translate hope as a verb:

If we^(incl) can only hope that Christ will help us while we are alive here

If we believe in Christ, but Christ will only help us in this life

If Christ helps us in this life, but not after we die

15:19b

we are to be pitied more than all men.

- we^(incl) deserve pity more than anyone.
- people should pity us more than they pity anyone else.

we are to be pitied more than all men: This is the conclusion that Paul drew from 15:19a. However, Paul did not believe 15:19a to be true. In your translation, make sure that your readers understand that Paul did not think that believers are to be pitied.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

we should be pitied more than anyone else in the world (NCV)

we are more unfortunate than all other people

we are to be pitied: This is a passive verb phrase. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

we should be pitied (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

people should pity us^(incl)

more than all men: The phrase more than all men means “more than all other people.” No matter what condition other people are in, Christians are in a worse condition.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

more than anybody else who suffers

1 Corinthians 15:20

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the

gospel. First (15:1-11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12-34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35-58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:20-28

In this paragraph Paul wrote about how God will conquer death. God will rule over everything and everyone.

15:20a

But Christ has indeed been raised from the dead,

- ¶ But Christ has in fact come back to life.
- ¶ However, God really has raised Christ from the dead.

But...indeed: The phrase But...indeed introduces a contrast with the previous verses. In 15:12-19 Paul wrote about what it would be like if Christ had not been raised from the dead. In 15:20-33 Paul wrote about the actual situation: Christ has been raised from the dead.

Here are some other ways to introduce this contrast:

But the truth is (GNT)

In fact, however (NJB)

Christ has...been raised from the dead: Paul wrote about the true situation. For this phrase, see the notes on 15:12a.

15:20b

the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep.

- He is the first dead person to rise, like the first produce of the harvest.
- He is the first one that God raised. Because of him we know that all those who have died will be raised.

the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep: Paul used a metaphor to describe Christ. The word firstfruits refers to the first grain that is harvested, or the first grapes that are picked from the vine. In this verse,

firstfruits is used figuratively to refer to Christ as the first person who will be raised from the dead.

Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

firstfruits (NJB) If you do this, be sure that it is clear to readers that this is used in a figurative sense. It may be helpful to say:

Christ is like the firstfruits

Christ is like the rice/corn that is the first to be harvested

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor.

There are two aspects to the meaning of this metaphor:

1. It means first. For example:

But now Christ has come back from the dead. He is the very first person of those who have died to come back to life. (GW) (GW, NLT)

1. It means guarantee or proof. For example:

Christ has been raised from death, as the guarantee that those who sleep in death will also be raised. (GNT) (GNT, CEV)

Another option is to include both the meanings:

But Christ has truly been raised from the dead—the first one and proof that those who sleep in death will also be raised. (NCV)

because Christ was the first one to be raised, we know that all the dead people will be raised

fallen asleep: The expression fallen asleep refers to people who have died. See the notes on 15:6b and 15:18. Use the expression that is appropriate in your language to refer to those who have died.

1 Corinthians 15:21

Section 15:1-58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the

gospel. First (15:1-11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12-34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35-58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:20-28

In this paragraph Paul wrote about how God will conquer death. God will rule over everything and everyone.

15:21a

For since death came through a man,

- For it was because of a man that people must die,
- For it was a man, Adam, who brought death,

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as **For** introduces an explanation of what Paul meant by saying that Christ is the firstfruits of those who have died.

since death came through a man: This is a reference to the story of Adam and the fall of mankind in Genesis 3. Because Adam sinned, all people die.

The NCV shows another way to translate this:

Death has come because of what one man did
(NCV)

death: In some languages it may be natural to translate death as a verb:

we^(incl) will all die

all people will die

through a man: It may be clearer to make it explicit that this man is Adam:

because of what the man Adam did

a man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a man is literally “a person.” Since Adam was a man, it is OK to translate it as either:

a man

a person/a human being

15:21b

the resurrection of the dead comes also through a man.

- and so it is because of a man that people will come to life again.
- and it is a man, Jesus Christ, who brings life to the dead.

the resurrection of the dead comes also through a man: This indicates that because of the man Jesus Christ, dead people will rise again.

The NCV shows another way to translate this:

but the rising from death also comes because of one man (NCV)

the resurrection of the dead: In some languages it may be natural to translate resurrection as a verb. For example:

we^(incl) will be raised to life

God will raise people to life

through a man: The phrase a man refers to Christ. It may be clearer to make this explicit:

through the man Christ

because of Christ (CEV)

It is important for your readers to understand that a man in 15:21a and a man in 15:21b refer to different people.

a man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a man is literally “a person.” Since Christ was a man, it is OK to translate it as either:

a man

a person/a human being

1 Corinthians 15:22

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:20–28

In this paragraph Paul wrote about how God will conquer death. God will rule over everything and everyone.

15:22a–b

For as in Adam all die, so in Christ all will be made alive: This verse means approximately the same thing as the previous verse. It compares what Adam has done for people with what Christ has done for people.

The CEV shows another way to say this:

Adam brought death to all of us, and Christ will bring life to all of us. (CEV)

in Adam...in Christ: The phrases in Adam and in Christ mean “because of Adam” and “because of Christ.” Because humans are descended from Adam, and because they sin like Adam, they die. Because humans are joined to Christ by faith, they will live again.

It is important that your readers understand that the man mentioned in 15:21a is the Adam referred to here, and the man mentioned in 15:21b is the Christ referred to here.

15:22a

For as in Adam all die,

- For because of Adam everyone dies,
- For because we^(incl) are joined/connected with Adam we^(incl) will all die.

in Adam all die: The word all means all who are in Adam, that is, all people, including the writer and his readers.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because of Adam we^(incl) will all die

everybody who is descended from Adam will die

because we^(incl) sinned like Adam, we^(incl) will all die

15:22b

so in Christ all will be made alive.

- and so because of Christ everyone will live again.
- In the same way, because we^(incl) are joined/connected with Christ, we^(incl) will all come alive from the dead.

in Christ all will be made alive: The word all refers to all people who are in Christ, that is, those who belong to Christ. This included Paul and his readers.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because of Christ we^(incl) all will be made alive

everybody who is joined to Christ will be raised

because we^(incl) believe in Christ, we^(incl) will all be made alive

This is a passive clause. In some languages it may be natural to provide the subject and say:

God will make us^(incl) all alive

1 Corinthians 15:23

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:20–28

In this paragraph Paul wrote about how God will conquer death. God will rule over everything and everyone.

15:23a

But each in his own turn:

- But each person will rise again in the proper order.
- It will happen in this order:

But each in his own turn: This refers to the order of the resurrection. Paul went on to explain the order in 15:23b–c.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

it will happen in this order

everyone will be raised when the time is right

15:23b

Christ the firstfruits;

- Christ rose first, like the first produce of the harvest,
- Christ was the first to rise from the dead,

Christ the firstfruits: The metaphor of Christ as the firstfruits means that Christ was the first to be raised. Others will be raised later. This is the same word as in 15:20b. In 20b there were two figurative meanings, but here the meaning of “first in order” is in focus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Christ was the first to be raised to life (CEV)

Christ came back to life first

15:23c

then at His coming, those who belong to Him.

- and then, when he returns, those who belong to him will live again.
- and when he comes back we^(incl) who are his will also rise from the dead.

then at His coming: The phrase at His coming refers to the future time when Christ will come back to earth.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

when Christ comes back to the earth

those who belong to Him: The phrase those who belong to Him refers to Christ’s people. This is the same group that is referred to as “all” in 15:22b. Paul did not finish the phrase. It may be clearer to fill in the implied information:

then those who belong to him will be raised to life

1 Corinthians 15:24

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:20–28

In this paragraph Paul wrote about how God will conquer death. God will rule over everything and everyone.

15:24a

Then the end will come,

- Then the end of this world/age will be/come.
- Then the world will end.

Then: The word Then introduces something that happens after Christ’s people are resurrected. It is not clear whether or not there is an interval of time between these events.

the end will come: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the end will come is literally the end. The BSB has supplied the words will come. It refers to the end of this age.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the end will occur

it will be the end

15:24b**when He hands over the kingdom to God the Father**

- This will happen when Christ gives all his authority to God the Father
- Christ will willingly yield/surrender his rule/kingship to God the Father.

Some English versions begin a new sentence here. For example:

At that time... (NCV)

when He hands over the kingdom to God the Father:

The phrase hands over means “gives” or “yields.” The phrase when He hands over the kingdom to God indicates that at the end of time Christ will give the kingship to God. Christ will stop ruling as king, and God will rule instead.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

he will give the kingdom to God the Father (CEV)

the kingdom: The word kingdom refers to the activity of ruling. See Key Biblical Terms “Kingdom of God.” It refers to Christ’s rule over his people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he will cease to reign and God the Father will begin to reign

he will ask God his father to rule over his people

he will give all his authority to God his father

15:24c**after He has destroyed all dominion, authority, and power.**

- after all other rule, authority, and power has been destroyed.
- He will do this after he has defeated all the people who rule, have authority, and are powerful in this world.

after He has destroyed all dominion, authority, and power: The pronoun He refers to Christ. Make sure it is clear in your translation. For example:

Christ will overcome all spiritual rulers, authorities, and powers (GNT)

dominion, authority, and power: These Greek words have approximately the same meaning. They refer to any kind of ruler, whether a human being or a spiritual being that is opposed to God. In some languages it may be natural to translate these words using one or two terms rather than three.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

powers and forces (CEV)

all the forces that oppose God

In some languages you cannot use an abstract noun. It may be possible to say:

all the spirits who rule, and all the people who have authority and power

General Comment on 15:24a-c

In some languages it may be natural to put this verse in chronological order. For example:

^{24a}and then the end will come. ^{24c}At that time Christ will destroy all rulers, authorities, and powers, ^{24b}and he will hand over the kingdom to God the Father. (NCV)

^{24c}Then after Christ has destroyed all powers and forces, ^{24a}the end will come, ^{24b}and he will give the kingdom to God the Father. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 15:25**Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead**

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:20–28

In this paragraph Paul wrote about how God will conquer death. God will rule over everything and everyone.

15:25**For He must reign until He has put all His enemies under His feet.**

- For Christ must rule as king until all his enemies are under his feet.
- For Christ must be the king until he has defeated all his enemies.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces some words taken from Psalm 110:1 that support and explain what Paul said in 15:23–24.

He must reign: The phrase He must reign indicates that Christ must reign as king. This must happen because it is God’s will that he reign. Some English versions make the subject “Christ” explicit.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Christ must be the king

until He has put all His enemies under His feet: In Psalm 110:1 it is God who puts enemies under the feet of the king. However, this is not a direct quotation, and there are two ways to interpret who is the subject:

1. The subject is Christ. For example:

Christ must rule until he puts all enemies under his control (NCV) (NCV, CEV, NLT)

1. The subject is God. For example:

until God has put every enemy under his control (GW) (GW, GNT, REB)

If you must choose between the interpretations, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This has stronger support in the commentaries. See, for example, Fee p. 756; and Thiselton p. 1234.

put all His enemies under His feet: The phrase put all His enemies under His feet is a figure of speech that means “defeated his enemies.” There are two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

he humbles all his enemies beneath his feet (NLT)

defeats all enemies and puts them under his feet (GNT)

- Translate the meaning. For example:

he puts all his enemies under his power (CEV)

he conquers all his enemies

all His enemies: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as all His enemies is literally “all the enemies.” The BSB has supplied the word His to make it be natural English. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language.

1 Corinthians 15:26**Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead**

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:20–28

In this paragraph Paul wrote about how God will conquer death. God will rule over everything and everyone.

15:26**The last enemy to be destroyed is death.**

- The last enemy he will destroy is death itself.
- When all his enemies have been destroyed, mankind will no longer die.

The last enemy to be destroyed is death: This is a figure of speech called personification. Paul spoke of death as a person who is an enemy. At the end, Christ will conquer this enemy and take away its power. This is figurative way to say that from then on, none of God’s people will die.

Here are some other ways to translate this figure of speech:

In the end death itself will die!

Christ will cause it to be that never again will his people die.

When all his enemies have been destroyed, mankind will no longer die

to be destroyed: This is a passive verb. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

The last enemy to be eliminated is death. (NET)

- Use an active verb. If you need to supply an agent, you should supply “Christ.”

the last enemy that Christ will destroy is death

death itself, the final enemy, will die

1 Corinthians 15:27

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:20–28

In this paragraph Paul wrote about how God will conquer death. God will rule over everything and everyone.

15:27a

For “God has put everything under His feet.”

- For the scriptures say that “God has put everything under him.”
- For it is written that God has placed everything in submission to Christ.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces an explanation of the statement in 15:26. This explanation is a quotation from the Old Testament scriptures. It may be helpful to make this clear by saying:

For the scripture says (GNT)

As the scripture says

God has put everything under His feet: This is a quotation from Psalm 8:6. In the original form it is in the second person: “you have put everything under his feet.” Because of the change, some English versions do not mark the word God as part of the quotation. The BSB and many other versions do include it as part of the quotation. Either is acceptable. When Paul wrote in Greek he did not use quotation marks.

This is a prophecy. It is in the past tense, but it has not completely happened yet. At the end of this age God will defeat everything and will make everything subject to Jesus Christ. Use the tense that is appropriate in your language for a prophecy.

God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as God is more literally “he.” This pronoun refers to God, as in Psalm 8:6. The BSB makes this explicit. Refer to God in a natural way in your language.

under His feet: The phrase under His feet is a figure of speech that means “Christ rules over everything.” There are two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

God has put all things in subjection under his feet (ESV)

- Translate the meaning. For example:

God has put all things under his authority (NLT)

God has put all things under him

God has made him rule over everything

His feet: The word His refers to the feet of Christ. This is an Old Testament quotation. If the meaning is clear,

it is best to translate the pronoun His literally. If your readers do not understand that the pronoun refers to Christ you can translate it as:

Christ's feet

15:27b

Now when it says that everything has been put under Him,

- When the Scripture says that everything has been put under Christ,
- The word “everything” in this Scripture

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now introduces a logical argument. It is not a time word.

when it says: The phrase that the BSB translates as when it says means “when the Scripture says.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the Scripture that says

when we^(incl) read in the Scriptures

that everything has been put under Him: Paul referred back to the quotation in 15:27a. Because Paul did not use quotation marks, the English versions vary as to whether they use quotation marks and where they place them. For example:

when it says, “All things are put in subjection under him,” (RSV)

that “everything” has been put under him, (NIV)

the words “all things” (GNT)

The NIV placed the quotation marks where it does in order to make it clear which part of the quotation Paul would discuss. The GNT, however, made this clear by abbreviating the quotation and only translated the part Paul referred to.

If your language uses quotation marks, you could use them to make it clear that Paul discussed the meaning of the word everything.

15:27c

this clearly does not include the One

- this does not mean that God has been put under Christ.
- obviously does not include God himself.

this clearly does not include the One: Paul said that the word “everything” does not mean that the One, God the Father, will be put under Jesus Christ.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

this does not mean that God himself has been put under Christ

the word “everything” obviously does not include God

General Comment on 15:27b-c

In some languages it may be natural to combine 27b and 27c as in the GNT:

^{27c}It is clear, of course, ^{27b}that the words “all things” ^{27c}do not include God himself (GNT)

15:27d

who put everything under Him.

- This is because God is the one who put everything under Christ.
- God is the one who places everything under the authority of Christ.

who put everything under Him: This is a relative clause. In some languages it may be more natural to make it be a new sentence. For example:

God is the one who put everything under Christ

because God made Christ be the ruler

The Greek verb put is in the past tense, as in the BSB and RSV. However, because this action has not completely happened yet, the GNT uses the present tense:

who puts all things under Christ (GNT)

Him: The pronoun Him refers to Christ.

1 Corinthians 15:28

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from

the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:20–28

In this paragraph Paul wrote about how God will conquer death. God will rule over everything and everyone.

15:28a

And when all things have been subjected to Him,

- When God has done this,
- God will put everything under his Son.

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *And* introduces a contrast to what Paul said in 15:27a: “God has put everything under His feet.” It does not introduce a contrast with what Paul had just said in 15:27b–d. The NIV does not translate this conjunction, and the GNT translates it as “But.” Consider whether it is natural to translate this conjunction explicitly in your language.

when all things have been subjected to Him: This clause repeats the idea from 15:27d. In some languages it may be natural to shorten the clause. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

when Christ rules over everything

When he has done this (NIV)

15:28b

then the Son Himself will be made subject to Him who put all things under Him,

- then God who put everything under the Son, will put the Son under himself.
- When everything is under the Son’s authority, then the Son will be under the Father’s authority.

then the Son Himself will be made subject to Him who put all things under Him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as *will be made subject* is a passive verb. There are two ways to translate it.

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the Son himself will also be subjected to him who put all things under him (RSV)

- Use an active verb. The implied agent is “God the father.” For example:

God who put everything under his Son, will now put his Son under himself

If such a translation suggests that the Son was unwilling to subject himself to God the Father, choose your wording so that it is clear that Christ is willing to be subject to God. For example:

he himself, the Son, will place himself under God, who placed all things under him (GNT)

after God puts everything under his son, then that son is put under God

after everything is under the son’s authority, then the son will be under the father’s authority

15:28c

so that God may be all in all.

- He will do this in order that God may be the ruler of everything.
- God will then have authority over all things/people.

so that God may be all in all: The phrase *all in all* is an idiom which means that God rules in every way. The two words *all* can refer to “all things” or to “all people.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

God will rule completely over all (GNT)

Then God will be in control of everything (GW)

God will have authority over everything/all people

1 Corinthians 15:29

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from

the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:29–34

In this paragraph Paul used the same style of argument he used in 15:12–19. He claimed that to deny the resurrection takes away meaning from one's present life. If there is no resurrection we might just as well concentrate on enjoying the pleasures of this life. He gave two examples. If there is no resurrection, then there is no reason for people to be baptized for the dead. Nor is there any reason for people to endanger themselves for Christ.

15:29a

If these things are not so,

- ¶ If the dead will not rise again,
- ¶ If dead people do not come back to life,

If these things are not so: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *If these things are not so* is more literally “For,” as in the NASB. This word implies a hypothetical condition based on what Paul has just said. The BSB has supplied the words *If these things are not so* to help make the meaning clear. If this is natural in your language, you can follow the example of the BSB.

15:29b

what will those do who are baptized for the dead?

- what do those people think they are doing, who are baptized for the dead?
- it doesn't make sense for people to receive baptism for the dead.

what will those do who are baptized for the dead?:

Paul heard that some of the Corinthian Christians received baptism on behalf of people who died without being baptized. This practice is not mentioned anywhere else in the Bible and we do not know any more about it.

This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement. He said that if the dead will not rise again, it is useless to receive baptism for the dead.

Here are some ways to translate this strong statement:

- Use a rhetorical question:

what do those people think they are doing who are being baptized for the dead?

what about those people who are baptized for the dead? What do they hope to accomplish? (GNT)

- Use a statement:

it is senseless to be baptized on behalf of someone who has died (T4T)

Translate this strong statement in a way that is natural in your language.

baptized: The verb baptized means to purify people with a ritual that uses water. Baptism was an initiation that marked the beginning of a person's life as a Christian. You should translate it the same way you did in Mark 1:4. See “Baptize, Baptism” in the Key Biblical Terms.

15:29c

If the dead are not raised at all,

- If the dead do not rise again,
- If dead people do not come back to life,

If the dead are not raised at all: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *at all* adds emphasis to the clause. Some people might think that the dead cannot and will not ever come to life.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphatic word:

if in fact the dead will not rise

if the dead actually never rise

15:29d

why are people baptized for them?

- why are those people baptized for them?
- what they are doing is useless.

why are people baptized for them?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement. This means approximately the same as the rhetorical question in 15:29b.

Here are some ways to translate this strong statement:

- Use a rhetorical question:

Why are those people being baptized for the dead? (GNT)

- Use a statement:

it does not make sense for people to be baptized for the dead

as for receiving baptism for the dead—there is no point to it

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language to express a strong statement.

General Comment on 15:29a-d

Some English versions have reordered the clauses. For example:

^{29a,c}If the dead are not going to be raised to life, ^{29b}what will people do who are being baptized for them? ^{29d}Why are they being baptized for those dead people? (CEV)

You should translate this in a way that is natural and clear in your language.

1 Corinthians 15:30

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:29–34

In this paragraph Paul used the same style of argument he used in 15:12–19. He claimed that to deny the resurrection takes away meaning from one's present life. If there is no resurrection we might just as well concentrate on enjoying the pleasures of this life. He

gave two examples. If there is no resurrection, then there is no reason for people to be baptized for the dead. Nor is there any reason for people to endanger themselves for Christ.

15:30

And why do we endanger ourselves every hour?

- And as for us^(excl) apostles, why do we put our lives in peril all the time?
- And if there is no resurrection why are we^(excl) willing constantly to risk our lives to preach about the resurrection?

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces a rhetorical question.

why do we endanger ourselves every hour?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement. He said that if there is no resurrection, it is pointless for the apostles to risk their lives for the gospel.

Here are some ways to translate this strong statement:

- Use a rhetorical question:

why do we^(excl) continually put ourselves in such danger for the gospel?

why do we always risk our lives? (CEV)

- Use a strong statement:

we^(excl) are crazy to put our lives in danger to serve God as we do all the time

we should not be willing to live in this constant danger

Translate this statement in a way that is natural in your language.

why do we: The Greek pronoun we is an emphatic pronoun. Translate this emphatic pronoun in a way that is natural in your language. Many English versions do not show this emphasis.

we: There are two ways to interpret the Greek pronoun that the BSB translates as we:

1. It refers to Paul and the other apostles. It is an exclusive we. For example:

we (CEV) (BSB, CEV, NIV, NASB, NRSV, ESV, NJB, NABRE, REB, NET, GW, NLT, NCV, KJV)

1. It refers only to Paul. For example:

I (RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is followed by most English versions.

every hour: The phrase every hour means “frequently” or “constantly.” It does not literally mean that the apostles were in danger every single hour. Use an expression that is natural in your language to say that something happens frequently.

General Comment on 15:30

There is implied information here. Paul talked about the hypothetical situation that there might be no resurrection. Another way to translate this is:

If there is no resurrection, we are crazy to endanger ourselves as we do all the time by preaching about the resurrection.

1 Corinthians 15:31

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:29–34

In this paragraph Paul used the same style of argument he used in 15:12–19. He claimed that to deny the resurrection takes away meaning from one’s present life. If there is no resurrection we might just as well concentrate on enjoying the pleasures of this life. He gave two examples. If there is no resurrection, then there is no reason for people to be baptized for the dead. Nor is there any reason for people to endanger themselves for Christ.

15:31a

I face death every day,

- I could die any day.
- I risk death every day.

I face death every day: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as I face death every day is more literally “every day I die.” Paul was often in danger of dying. He did not actually die and come back to life every day. Paul spoke this way to emphasize his argument.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I face death every day of my life (JBP)

Every day I am in danger of death! (NET)

People keep on trying to kill me

It is as if I die every day

15:31b

brothers, as surely as I boast about you in Christ Jesus our Lord.

- Brothers and sisters, I assure you^(plur) by my pride in you in Christ Jesus our^(incl) Lord that this is true.
- This is true, dear friends. It is as certain as the fact that I am proud that you follow Christ Jesus our Lord.

brothers: There is a textual issue:

1. Some Greek manuscripts include the word brothers. (BSB, NIV, NASB, RSV, ESV, REB, GW, NLT, NCV, NABRE, GNT)
2. Some Greek manuscripts do not include the word brothers. (NJB, NET, CEV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The UBS Greek New Testament, 4th edition, includes the word “brothers” with a C rating, indicating that “the Committee had difficulty in deciding which variant to place in the text.”

When Paul said brothers he was speaking to all the believers in Corinth, both men and women.

as surely as I boast about you: This Greek phrase is more literally “by [my] glorying in you.” Paul swore by his pride in the Corinthians. There are two ways to interpret what this means:

1. Paul said that he was certain that he died every day. He compared it to the certainty of his pride in the Corinthians. For example:

This is as sure as my boasting in you (NET) (BSB, NET, NIV, NCV, NLT, NJB, REB, NRSV)

1. Paul said that his pride in the Corinthians made him write about his suffering. For example:

The pride I have in you...makes me declare this (GNT) (GNT, NABRE, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is followed by several English versions and supported by several commentaries. See, for example, Fee p. 769–770; and Thiselton p. 1250–1252.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I swear by my pride in you that it is true

That is true, brothers and sisters, just as it is true that I brag about you (NCV)

That is true. It is also true that I boast about you

I boast about you in Christ Jesus our Lord: The phrase I boast about you indicates that Paul boasted about, or took pride in, the Corinthian believers. He boasted that they believed in Christ Jesus our Lord.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I boast about you because you follow Christ Jesus our Lord

my pride in what Christ Jesus our Lord has done in you (NLT)

General Comment on 15:31a-b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of these clauses. For example:

^{31b}I swear by the pride that I take in you, in Christ Jesus our Lord, ^{31a}that I face death every day. (NJB)

1 Corinthians 15:32

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from

the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:29–34

In this paragraph Paul used the same style of argument he used in 15:12–19. He claimed that to deny the resurrection takes away meaning from one's present life. If there is no resurrection we might just as well concentrate on enjoying the pleasures of this life. He gave two examples. If there is no resurrection, then there is no reason for people to be baptized for the dead. Nor is there any reason for people to endanger themselves for Christ.

15:32a

If I fought wild beasts in Ephesus for human motives,

- In Ephesus it was as though I fought dangerous animals. If I fought with them merely for human reasons,
- In the city of Ephesus I fought with vicious people who attacked me like wolves/tigers. I did not do that just to gain the things of this life.

If I fought wild beasts in Ephesus for human motives: Paul said that he fought against his enemies, and he was glad because he did it for the right reason. He fought because he knew that Christ has risen from the dead. The wrong reasons (human motives) would be if he had fought to benefit himself.

Here is a way to translate this is using two sentences:

I fought wild beasts in Ephesus. If this was for human motives...

I fought wild beasts in Ephesus: The commentaries almost all agree that Paul spoke figuratively. The enemy he fought with was people, not animals. All modern commentaries, and most ancient ones, say that Paul referred figuratively to "people," not to literal wild animals. See, for example, Fee p. 770–771; Thiselton p. 1251–1252; Morris p. 216; Verbrugge & Harris p. 399–400; Garland p. 225; Grosheide p. 375; Kistemaker p. 561; Orr & Walther p. 336. Perhaps the most recent commentary that argues for a literal in-

interpretation is Godet (1886). According to Roman law, Roman citizens could not be punished by making them fight wild beasts.

wild beasts: Paul used a figure of speech to refer to violent people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

brutes

vicious people who have hearts like tigers/
wolves/bears

violent people who attacked me like wild beasts

If possible, translate this with a figure of speech that readers will understand to refer to violent people.

Ephesus: Ephesus was a city in what is now western Turkey. Acts 19:1–20 records how Paul visited and preached in that city.

for human motives: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as for human motives is literally “according to man.” There are at least two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It describes the reason Paul fought and means “thinking like a man” or “for human reasons.” For example:

simply from human motives (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NIV, NCV, REB, NET, NJB, NRSV, NASB)

1. It indicates that the expression “fought wild beasts” is figurative language. Paul described spiritual events using human terms. For example:

humanly speaking (RSV) (RSV, ESV, NABRE, GW, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is followed by many English versions and is supported by some commentaries. See Thiselton p. 1251. However, other commentaries support a wide range of ideas about the meaning of this phrase.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

from a human point of view (NET)

with merely human hopes (NRSV)

to benefit myself

15:32b

what did I gain?

- does that do me any good? No, it doesn't.
- If I did, there is no benefit to me.

what did I gain?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement. He expected people to respond “Nothing.” Paul would have suffered for nothing.

Here are some ways to translate this strong statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

what is the good of that?

does that benefit me? No, not at all.

- Use a strong statement:

I have gained nothing (NCV)

it does not profit me at all

Translate this strong statement in a way that is natural in your language.

General Comment on 15:32a–b

In some languages it may be natural to break up this question into a question with a response. For example:

^{32a}Did I fight with those brutes in Ephesus for merely human reasons? ^{32b}If so, I gained nothing.

15:32c

If the dead are not raised,

- If the dead do not rise from the dead,
- If God is not going to make the dead live again,

If the dead are not raised: This introduces Paul's suggestion about how people should think about life if there is no resurrection. The NJB starts a new verse at this point.

15:32d

“Let us eat and drink, for tomorrow we die.”

- “Let us enjoy food and drink today, for we will die tomorrow.”
- then as the saying goes, “We will eat a lot and get drunk. We will soon die anyway.”

Let us eat and drink, for tomorrow we die: Paul quoted a popular saying. This saying is also found in Isaiah 22:13. Paul did not agree with this saying. You should not introduce it with the words “as the Scripture says.” Instead, you should make clear that Paul quoted a common saying. The GNT does this by supplying the phrase “as the saying goes”:

as the saying goes, “Let us eat and drink, for tomorrow we die” (GNT)

You may mention in a footnote that the saying is also found in Isaiah 22:13.

If possible, you should translate this saying using the style of a proverb in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this saying:

Let’s eat a lot and get drunk. We don’t know what day we will die.

Let’s eat and drink today. We will die tomorrow.

1 Corinthians 15:33

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:29–34

In this paragraph Paul used the same style of argument he used in 15:12–19. He claimed that to deny the resurrection takes away meaning from one’s present life. If there is no resurrection we might just as well concentrate on enjoying the pleasures of this life. He gave two examples. If there is no resurrection, then there is no reason for people to be baptized for the

dead. Nor is there any reason for people to endanger themselves for Christ.

15:33a

Do not be deceived:

- Do not let anyone mislead you^(plur).
- Do not believe the false teachers.

Do not be deceived: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deceived can also be translated as “misled.” The Corinthians were deceived by people who taught them false things. Paul told them to stop believing what these false teachers were saying.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Don’t let yourselves be deceived. (JBP)

Don’t believe what the false teachers say.

Do not let those who say there is no resurrection deceive you.

15:33b

“Bad company corrupts good character.”

- It is true what people say, “Bad friends will make your good heart become bad.”
- As the old saying/proverb goes, “Evil companions will turn you evil.”

Bad company corrupts good character: This is a quotation. It was a popular saying that Paul and his readers accepted as true. It is not from the Scriptures. To make this clear you could say:

It is true what people say, “Bad company corrupts good character.”

This saying indicates that if you make friends with bad people, you will start to behave in a bad way yourself. If possible, translate this in a style of a proverb in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this saying:

Bad companions ruin good character. (GNT)

If you stay with bad people, you will become bad like them.

Bad friends will make a good heart become bad.

company: The word company refers to one's friends or companions, the people one spends time with.

character: The word character refers to a person's morals or ethics. In some languages it may be natural to speak of the person himself as being corrupted. For example:

Bad friends will corrupt you.

1 Corinthians 15:34

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:29–34

In this paragraph Paul used the same style of argument he used in 15:12–19. He claimed that to deny the resurrection takes away meaning from one's present life. If there is no resurrection we might just as well concentrate on enjoying the pleasures of this life. He gave two examples. If there is no resurrection, then there is no reason for people to be baptized for the dead. Nor is there any reason for people to endanger themselves for Christ.

15:34a

Sober up as you ought, and stop sinning;

- Come back to doing what is right and stop sinning.
- Stop being foolish. Stop doing what is wrong.

Sober up as you ought: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Sober up is more literally “become sober (after being drunk).” This is a figure of speech that means “stop behaving foolishly.” Paul rebuked the Corinthians for their wrong behavior and thinking and told them to behave in a way that pleased God. There are two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

Wake up from your drunken stupor, as is right (ESV)

- Translate the meaning. For example:

Come back to doing what is right

Stop being foolish and instead be righteous

and stop sinning: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

don't continue sinning

don't do sinful deeds any longer

15:34b

for some of you are ignorant of God.

- For some among you^(plur) have no knowledge of God.
- There are some of you who do not know about God's ways.

for some of you are ignorant of God: Paul said that there were people in the church in Corinth who did not know God. They did not know about God and his ways.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

some have no knowledge of God (NET)

some of you do not know about God's ways

some of you don't know the true teachings about God

some of you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as some of you is more literally some. The BSB has included the words of you to clarify that Paul is speaking about people in the Corinthian church. Consider whether it would be helpful in your language to make this explicit.

15:34c

I say this to your shame.

- I write this to cause you^(plur) to feel ashamed.
- I want you to be ashamed.

I say this to your shame: This is a rebuke. Paul said that the Corinthians ought to be ashamed. They should be ashamed of their behavior and their ignorance of God. In English there are idiomatic ways to say this. For example:

You should be ashamed of yourselves. (GW)

Shame on you!

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language to rebuke somebody.

General Comment on 15:34b-c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 15:34b and c. For example:

^{34c}I speak like this so that you will be ashamed because ^{34b}some of you are ignorant of God.

1 Corinthians 15:35

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:35–41

In this paragraph Paul began to talk about the bodies we will have when we rise from the dead. He indicated that God had already created a wide variety of different bodies or forms of life. He also introduced the idea that heavenly bodies are not the same as earthly bodies.

15:35a

But someone will ask, “How are the dead raised?”

- ¶I But perhaps someone will ask, “How do the dead come to life again?”
- ¶I But someone might ask how God can make dead people live again

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But indicates a transition to a different subject. Some English versions do not explicitly translate this conjunction. Translate this conjunction in a way that

indicates a transition to a new subject in your language.

someone will ask: Paul was not thinking of a specific person. He suggested that some of the doubters might ask questions like those that follow.

How are the dead raised?: This is a real question. The imaginary person who asked the question wanted to know the answer. He doubted that it is possible for the dead to rise again.

Here is another way to translate this question:

How do people come back to life?

15:35b

With what kind of body will they come?”

- What kind of body will they have?”
- and what their bodies will be like.

With what kind of body will they come?: This also is a real question. This second question connects to the first with a Greek conjunction. This conjunction probably signals the new direction that Paul’s argument will take. In the following discussion, Paul only answers this second question. The person who asked the question wanted some information.

will they come: The phrase will they come could refer to coming out of the tombs, but Paul does not say this explicitly.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

What kind of bodies will they have when they come out of the tombs?

What will their bodies be like?

General Comment on 15:35

In some languages it may be natural to use indirect quotes. For example:

Someone may ask how the dead are raised, and what their bodies will be like when they are raised.

1 Corinthians 15:36

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence

showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:35–41

In this paragraph Paul began to talk about the bodies we will have when we rise from the dead. He indicated that God had already created a wide variety of different bodies or forms of life. He also introduced the idea that heavenly bodies are not the same as earthly bodies.

15:36

You fool! What you sow does not come to life unless it dies.

- You are a foolish person! A seed that you sow must die before it can live.
- What a foolish question! Think about a seed as an example. You must bury a seed so that it will sprout.

You fool!: The Greek word that the BSB translates as You fool is literally fool. It refers to someone who is ignorant of something he or she should have known.

Here are some other ways to translate this Greek word:

Don't be foolish. (CEV)

What a foolish question! (NLT)

Anyone who asks such a question is foolish

What you sow does not come to life unless it dies:

This is the beginning of Paul's answer to the question, "With what kind of body will they come?" Paul said that a seed must rot in the ground before it can sprout into a plant. In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the phrases and put them in chronological order:

The seeds that you plant must first die. Only then will they come to life.

What you sow: Paul referred to planting seed by scattering it on the ground.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

The seed that you sow/scatter/plant in the ground

does not come to life: The phrase does not come to life refers to becoming a living plant.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

it does not sprout

it does not grow

unless it dies: This phrase states a necessary condition. The seed must first die. It must cease to exist as a seed. Then life can come from it.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

first it must rot

you have to bury the seed before it can grow

In some languages it may be more natural to refer to "seeds" in the plural. For example:

the seeds do not come to life unless they die

Compare this to how you translated similar words in John 12:24. In some languages you cannot say that a seed "lives" or dies because these words are used only for animals and people.

Here are some ways that people have translated this phrase in other languages:

You plant the seed and then it sprouts. After it sprouts the seed is no longer there

the seeds do not sprout until the body of the seeds has changed

when seeds are planted the shells rot, but the seeds sprout out

1 Corinthians 15:37

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:35–41

In this paragraph Paul began to talk about the bodies we will have when we rise from the dead. He indicated that God had already created a wide variety of different bodies or forms of life. He also introduced the idea that heavenly bodies are not the same as earthly bodies.

15:37a

And what you sow

- When you^(plur) sow seeds,
- When you plant grain,

15:37b

is not the body that will be,

- after those seeds sprout, their appearance is different
- the plant that grows is not the same shape as what you planted.

15:37a–b

what you sow is not the body that will be: Paul spoke of the form or shape of a fully grown plant. In some languages it may not be natural to speak of a plant as having a body. Instead, you may be able to translate this as:

What you plant...doesn't have the form that the plant will have (GW)

the seed you sow is not the same as the plant that grows

15:37c

but just a seed, perhaps of wheat or something else.

- from the seeds you^(plur) sowed, whether they are wheat seeds or some other seed/grain/crop.
- For you plant only a seed, of wheat for example.

but just a seed: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as just a seed is literally “a bare seed.” The seed is brown and leafless and appears to have no life.

perhaps of wheat or something else: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as something else refers to the seed of some other crop. There are many varieties of seed.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

perhaps of wheat, or of some other crop

perhaps of wheat, for example

such as wheat

If wheat is unfamiliar it is possible to say:

perhaps of rice/corn or of something else

of some kind of grain

1 Corinthians 15:38

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:35–41

In this paragraph Paul began to talk about the bodies we will have when we rise from the dead. He indicated that God had already created a wide variety of different bodies or forms of life. He also introduced the idea that heavenly bodies are not the same as earthly bodies.

15:38a**But God gives it a body as He has designed,**

- But God gives it the form that he has decided it should have,
- God made each seed in the shape that he planned.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But signals a new part of Paul's argument. Introduce this new information in a way that is natural for your language.

God gives it a body as He has designed: Paul said that God has decided what form or shape is right for each seed to become.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

God provides that seed with the body he wishes (GNT)

God made each seed with its own shape according to his heart

15:38b**and to each kind of seed He gives its own body.**

- and to every kind of seed he gives the form he decided.
- He gives each kind of seed a different shape.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and introduces another part of Paul's argument. Some English versions start a new sentence here and do not translate this conjunction. For example:

Each kind of seed grows into its own form. (GW)

Paul introduced the idea of variety. Introduce this part of his argument in the way that is most natural for your language.

to each kind of seed He gives its own body: The Greek word that the BSB translates as each kind of seed is more literally "each of the seeds." There are two ways to interpret what it refers to:

1. It refers to different kinds of seeds. For example:

God gives each kind of seed its own body (NCV) (BSB, NCV, NIV, ESV, RSV, NJB, GW, NLT)

1. It refers to seeds in general. For example:

he gives each seed its own proper body (GNT) (GNT, NET, NASB, REB, NABRE, CEV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is followed by several English versions and supported by many commentaries. See, for example, Fee p. 782; and Thiselton p. 1265. Paul said that each of the kinds or varieties of seeds grows into its own kind of plant.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

God causes each different kind of plant to grow from its own kind of seed

1 Corinthians 15:39**Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead**

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:35–41

In this paragraph Paul began to talk about the bodies we will have when we rise from the dead. He indicated that God had already created a wide variety of different bodies or forms of life. He also introduced the idea that heavenly bodies are not the same as earthly bodies.

15:39

In this verse, Paul talked more about the idea of variety which he had introduced in 15:38. The Greek does not have a conjunction to introduce 15:39. Some English versions add a conjunction to introduce this in natural English. The RSV adds "For," and the GNT adds

“And.” You should introduce Paul’s next comment in a way that is natural in your language.

15:39a

Not all flesh is the same:

- There are different kinds of muscle.
- All living things have different kinds of bodies.

Not all flesh is the same: The phrase Not all flesh is the same means that there are different kinds of physical bodies. Here is another way to translate this:

the flesh of living beings is not all the same kind of flesh (GNT)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a positive statement.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

there are different kinds of flesh

every animal has a different kind of flesh

flesh: The Greek word that the BSB translates as flesh is more literally “meat.” In some languages it is not natural to use “meat” or flesh.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

different kinds of bodies

different kinds of muscle

different forms

they don’t all look alike

15:39b

Men have one kind of flesh, animals have another, birds another, and fish another.

- People are made of one kind of muscle, and domestic animals, birds, and fish are all made of different kinds of muscle.
- The bodies of human beings, cattle, birds, and fish all have different kinds of bodies.

Men have one kind of flesh, animals have another, birds another, and fish another: Paul gave examples of the different kinds of bodies that God gave to the creatures he had made.

Men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Men is literally “people.” It refers to human beings, both males and females.

animals: The Greek word that the BSB translates as animals referred to domesticated animals rather than wild animals. If possible, you should use a term that does not include people, birds, or fish.

Here is another way to translate this word:

domestic animals

In some languages it may be helpful to change the order of the sentence. For example:

people have one kind of flesh, birds another, fish another, and the other animals another

1 Corinthians 15:40

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:35–41

In this paragraph Paul began to talk about the bodies we will have when we rise from the dead. He indicated that God had already created a wide variety of different bodies or forms of life. He also introduced the idea that heavenly bodies are not the same as earthly bodies.

15:40a

There are also heavenly bodies and earthly bodies.

- And there also are forms in the heavens, and there are forms on earth.
- There are things both in the sky and on the earth.

There are...heavenly bodies and earthly bodies: This contrasts bodies found on earth and bodies found in the sky. If possible, use a word for bodies that can refer to both animals and to objects such as stars. For example:

There are things/forms in the sky and there are also things/forms on earth

heavenly bodies: The word heavenly refers to the sky, the place where the sun and stars are.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

bodies in the sky

things in the sky

also: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as also connects 15:39 and 15:40. The GNT translates it as “and.” Paul said that just as there are differences between different kinds of flesh, there are also differences between heavenly bodies and earthly bodies. You should connect these verses in a way that is natural in your language.

15:40b

But the splendor of the heavenly bodies is of one degree,

- But the glory of the forms in the heavens is different from
- The things in the sky are beautiful in one way

15:40c

and the splendor of the earthly bodies is of another.

- the glory of the forms on the earth.
- and the things on the earth are beautiful in a different way.

15:40b-c

But the splendor of the heavenly bodies is of one degree, and the splendor of the earthly bodies is of another: Paul compared and contrasted the beauty of objects in the sky with the beauty of beings that live on earth.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The glory of the heavenly bodies is different from the glory of the earthly bodies (NLT)

things in the sky are beautiful in one way, and things on the earth are beautiful in a different way

splendor: The Greek word that the BSB translates as splendor is literally “glory.” It refers to the beauty or magnificence that objects such as stars and also living creatures such as animals can have. See Key Biblical Terms “Glory,” meaning A.1.b.

heavenly bodies: The phrase heavenly bodies refers to the things that we can see in the sky: the sun, moon, planets, and stars.

earthly bodies: The phrase earthly bodies refers to the people and animals mentioned in 15:39b.

1 Corinthians 15:41

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:35–41

In this paragraph Paul began to talk about the bodies we will have when we rise from the dead. He indicated that God had already created a wide variety of different bodies or forms of life. He also introduced the idea that heavenly bodies are not the same as earthly bodies.

15:41a

The sun has one degree of splendor, the moon another, and the stars another;

- The sun is beautiful in one way, the moon is beautiful in another way, and the stars are beautiful in their own way.
- The light of the sun is different from the light of the moon or the stars.

The sun has one degree of splendor, the moon another, and the stars another: The Greek word that the BSB translates as stars includes various lights in the sky, including stars, planets, and meteorites. It does not include the sun and the moon.

The sun has one degree of splendor: The splendor of the heavenly bodies refers to their light.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the sun has one kind of light

the sun has one degree of shining

In some languages there are different words for the splendor of things in the sky, such as the “rays” of the sun, the “beams” of the moon, and the “twinkling” of the stars.

**15:41b
and star differs from star in splendor.**

- In fact the stars each have their own beauty.
- And each star has a different light.

star differs from star in splendor: Each star is different. Here is another way to translate this:

even among stars there are different kinds of beauty (GNT)

1 Corinthians 15:42

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:42–49

In this paragraph Paul explained the meaning of the illustrations he gave in 15:36–41, and he began to answer the question he asked in 15:35b: “With what kind of body will they come?” He explained what our bodies will be like after the resurrection, and the differences between the resurrection body and the natural body.

15:42a

So will it be with the resurrection of the dead:

- ¶ It will be the same with the dead who are raised to life.
- ¶ When seeds sprout into plants, it is like what happens when the dead rise again.

So will it be with: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as So will it be with is more literally “Thus also.” Paul compared the resurrection to a seed sprouting into a plant.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

It is the same with (NET)

So it is with (REB)

That is how it will be (GW)

the resurrection of the dead: In some languages it may be necessary to translate the resurrection of the dead as a verb phrase. For example:

when the dead come back to life (GW)

when God raises dead people

Here is another way to translate this clause:

The resurrection of the dead is the same as the seeds which sprout into plants.

15:42b

What is sown is perishable;

- The body that is buried will decay,
- Our^(incl) bodies now are going to die and decay,

What is sown: The Greek word that the BSB translates as What is sown is literally “it is sown.” Verses 15:42–44 use this phrase several times. Paul continued to use the metaphor of sowing seeds that he used in 15:36–37. Just as seeds are sown and then transformed, so the human body is buried and is then resurrected. Many commentaries connect the “sowing” with burial. See, for example, Grosheide p. 383; Verbrugge & Harris p. 402; and Kistemaker p. 572. For an alternate opinion see Fee p. 784. There are two ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

It is sown (NABRE)

Our earthly bodies are planted in the ground
when we die (NLT)

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

When the body is buried (GNT)

when the body dies

is perishable: The word perishable describes something that will decay.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

it will decay/rot/stink

15:42c

it is raised imperishable.

- but when God raises it from the dead, it will never decay again.
- but when they rise to life they will not decay any more.

it is raised imperishable: This is a passive clause. In some languages it will be natural to use an active verb and say:

when it rises again, it will be imperishable

when God raises these bodies, they will be imperishable

imperishable: The word imperishable is the opposite of “perishable.” It refers to something that will never die or decay.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

immortal (GNT)

it will never decay/rot/stink

1 Corinthians 15:43

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence

showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:42–49

In this paragraph Paul explained the meaning of the illustrations he gave in 15:36–41, and he began to answer the question he asked in 15:35b: “With what kind of body will they come?” He explained what our bodies will be like after the resurrection, and the differences between the resurrection body and the natural body.

15:43a

It is sown in dishonor; it is raised in glory.

- The body that is buried is dishonorable, but when it comes back to life it will be glorious.
- When we^(incl) bury a body it is ugly, but when God raises it from the dead it will be beautiful.

It is sown in dishonor; it is raised in glory: This is a second contrast between the present body and the resurrected body. Consider if you need to repeat the subject (“the body”) or if a pronoun is clear.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

When it is buried/dies it has no honor; when it is raised it will be glorious

in dishonor...in glory: The abstract noun that the BSB translates as dishonor can also be translated as “dis-respect.” The word glory is the opposite of dishonor. It refers to something that is beautiful and worthy of honor.

Here are some other ways to translate this pair of words:

dishonorable...glorious

looks bad...looks good

ugly...beautiful

15:43b**It is sown in weakness; it is raised in power.**

- The body that is buried is weak, but when God raises it from the dead, it will be powerful.
- Our^(incl) bodies now are weak, but when they rise they will be strong.

It is sown in weakness; it is raised in power: This is the third contrast between the present body and the resurrected body. In some languages it may be natural to translate the abstract nouns weakness and power as adjectives:

When it is buried/dies it is weak; but when it is raised it will be strong

1 Corinthians 15:44**Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead**

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:42–49

In this paragraph Paul explained the meaning of the illustrations he gave in 15:36–41, and he began to answer the question he asked in 15:35b: “With what kind of body will they come?” He explained what our bodies will be like after the resurrection, and the differences between the resurrection body and the natural body.

15:44a**It is sown a natural body; it is raised a spiritual body.**

- The body that is buried is part of this world, but when God raises it from the dead, it will be above/beyond this world.
- Our^(incl) bodies now are for living in this world, but when they rise they will be for living in heaven.

It is sown a natural body: This is the fourth contrast between the present body and the resurrected body.

The word natural means that the body is made for the natural world and this present age. It is earthly or material, like that of animals.

it is raised a spiritual body: The word spiritual means that the new resurrected body is made for life in the age to come.

a natural body...a spiritual body: Here are some other ways to translate this pair of terms:

a body of flesh...a body of the spirit

a body for living in the world...a body for living in heaven

a body of an ordinary human...a body which the spirit of God makes alive

15:44b**If there is a natural body, there is also a spiritual body.**

- Because we^(incl) have a body that is part of this world, we will also have a body that is above/beyond this world.
- Now we have bodies for living in this world, then we will have bodies for living in heaven.

If there is a natural body, there is also a spiritual body:

This “if” clause implies that there is indeed a natural body. The KJV follows Greek manuscripts that do not include the word “if.” It reads “There is a natural body, and there is a spiritual body.” The word “if” is included without comment in the UBS Greek New Testament.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

For just as there are natural bodies, there are also spiritual bodies (NLT)

Now we^(incl) have bodies for living in this world, then we will have bodies for living in heaven

General Comment on 15:42–44

In these verses Paul wrote about “the body,” in the singular. In some languages it may be natural to use plural forms and say “our bodies.” See the second meaning lines in the Display for examples.

1 Corinthians 15:45

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:42–49

In this paragraph Paul explained the meaning of the illustrations he gave in 15:36–41, and he began to answer the question he asked in 15:35b: “With what kind of body will they come?” He explained what our bodies will be like after the resurrection, and the differences between the resurrection body and the natural body.

15:45a

So it is written: “The first man Adam became a living being;”

- So it says in the Scriptures, “The first man Adam became a person who lived in this world.”
- God says in the Scriptures, “Adam, the first man, had a body for living in this world.”

So: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as So is literally “Thus also.” Paul introduced some evidence that agreed with what he said in 15:42–44. Use wording that is natural in your language for introducing some supporting evidence.

it is written: The phrase it is written introduces a quotation from the Old Testament Scriptures. See the notes on it is written at 1:19.

The first man Adam became a living being: Paul quoted from Genesis 2:7. He did not quote word-for-word. He added the words first and Adam.

Adam: The Hebrew word Adam means “man.” Here it is a proper noun, the name of the first man.

a living being: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a living being can also be translated “a living person.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a person who has life

Adam, the first person, received life

God gave the first person, Adam, life in his natural body

15:45b

the last Adam a life-giving spirit.

- The last Adam, Jesus Christ, became a person who lives above this world, and gives life to us.
- Jesus Christ, who is called the last Adam, has a body for living in heaven, and he brings people back to life.

the last Adam a life-giving spirit: This is a short way to say “the last Adam became a life-giving spirit.” This is not part of the quotation from Genesis.

the last Adam: This refers to Jesus Christ. It may be clearer to make this explicit:

the last Adam, Jesus Christ

Jesus Christ, who is given the name last Adam

last: The word last means second. It is the last in a series of two. There are other people called Adam, but they are not part of this series.

a life-giving spirit: Because Jesus Christ was raised from the dead, he can give life to others.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he became a spirit who gives life to other people

he became a spirit who brings dead people back to life

General Comment on 15:45

In 15:44 Paul contrasted the “natural” body and the “spiritual” body. In this verse, he used the same Greek words when he said that Adam was a living “being” and Jesus was a life-giving “spirit.” If it is possible, use the same words in v. 44 and v. 45.

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

^{44b}There are natural bodies, and there are also spiritual bodies. ^{45a}God made the first Adam to have life in a natural body. ^{45b}He made Christ, the last Adam, to have a spiritual body. Christ gives life to other people.

^{44b}Now we^(incl) have bodies for living on this earth. Then we will have bodies for living in heaven. ^{45a}Adam, the first man, had life on this earth. ^{45b}Jesus Christ, who is called the last Adam, gives us life from heaven

1 Corinthians 15:46

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:42–49

In this paragraph Paul explained the meaning of the illustrations he gave in 15:36–41, and he began to answer the question he asked in 15:35b: “With what kind of body will they come?” He explained what our bodies will be like after the resurrection, and the differences between the resurrection body and the natural body.

15:46

The spiritual, however, was not first, but the natural, and then the spiritual.

- The spiritual body did not come first, but the natural body, and after that the spiritual body.
- In the beginning God gave people bodies for living in this world. In the future he will give them bodies for living in heaven.

The spiritual, however, was not first, but the natural, and then the spiritual: Paul said that the spiritual body, the body of Christ, came after the natural body, that of Adam.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

But first came the natural body, not the spiritual one; that came only afterwards (NJB)

The spiritual body comes after the natural body.

In the beginning God gave people bodies for living in this world. In the future he will give them bodies for living in heaven.

1 Corinthians 15:47

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:42–49

In this paragraph Paul explained the meaning of the illustrations he gave in 15:36–41, and he began to answer the question he asked in 15:35b: “With what kind of body will they come?” He explained what our bodies will be like after the resurrection, and the differences between the resurrection body and the natural body.

15:47

The first man was of the dust of the earth, the second man from heaven.

- The first person, Adam was made from the soil of the earth, but the second/last person, Jesus Christ, is from heaven.
- God created Adam, the first person, from the ground. Jesus Christ the second/last person has a body for living in heaven.

The first man was of the dust of the earth: The clause The first man was of the dust of the earth is a reference to the story of the creation of Adam in Genesis 2:7.

The first man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as man is literally “person” or “human being.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the first person, Adam

Adam, the first person

was of the dust of the earth: The phrase was of the dust of the earth means “was made from the dust of the earth.”

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

was made out of dirt/soil

the second man from heaven: Some Greek manuscripts include a phrase that means “the Lord.” The KJV follows these manuscripts and says:

the second man is the Lord from heaven (KJV)

It is recommended that you follow the majority of English versions and the UBS Greek text and do not include the phrase “the Lord.” The 4th edition of the UBS Greek text gives the shorter reading (without the word “Lord”) an A rating, indicating that this reading is considered certain.

In the Greek text, as in the BSB, there is no verb. There are several ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It means that Jesus’ resurrected body is a heavenly body. See Thiselton p. 1288; Fee p. 792; Conzelmann p. 287; Grosheide p. 388; Kistemaker p. 577; Morris p. 225. This is probably the interpretation followed by versions that supply the present tense verb “is.” For example:

the second man is from heaven (NET) (NET, RSV, NASB, ESV, NJB, NABRE, REB, KJV)

1. It means that Jesus came from heaven at the time of the incarnation. See Hodge p. 352; Verbrugge & Harris p. 402. This is the interpretation followed by versions that supply the past tense verb “came.” For example:

Christ, the second man, came from heaven (NLT) (NLT, NCV, GW, GNT, CEV)

1. It means that Jesus will come back to earth from heaven in the future. See Garland p. 736; Barrett pp. 375–76; Robertson and Plummer p. 374.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This fits the context best and is supported by several commentaries. Christ’s resurrected body is spiritual and heavenly, as opposed to natural and earthly.

the second man: The word second means the same thing as “last” in 15:45b. It is the second in a series of two.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Jesus Christ, the second person, has a heavenly body

1 Corinthians 15:48

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:42–49

In this paragraph Paul explained the meaning of the illustrations he gave in 15:36–41, and he began to answer the question he asked in 15:35b: “With what kind of body will they come?” He explained what our bodies will be like after the resurrection, and the differences between the resurrection body and the natural body.

15:48a

As was the earthly man, so also are those who are of the earth;

- People who belong to this earth have bodies like Adam, the person made of earth.
- Adam was made from the ground; his descendants are also made from the ground.

As was the earthly man, so also are those who are of the earth: The verbs was and are are not in the Greek. The BSB has added them to make the meaning clear in English. Paul compared Adam's descendants with the original Adam, and said that they all have bodies like his. They are made from dirt.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Adam was made from dirt/soil, and so are his descendants

People who live on the earth have bodies like Adam who was made from the dirt

15:48b

and as is the heavenly man, so also are those who are of heaven.

- People who belong to heaven have bodies like Jesus, the person from heaven.
- Jesus has a body for living in heaven, and so do those who live in heaven with him.

as is the heavenly man, so also are those who are of heaven: The verbs is and are are not in the Greek. The BSB has added them so that the English is clear and natural. Paul said that those who belong to Christ will be like him. They will also have heavenly, resurrected bodies.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus is the person from heaven, and those who follow him are also from heaven

Jesus has a heavenly body and so do those who live in heaven

1 Corinthians 15:49

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

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15:49a

And just as we have borne the likeness of the earthly man,

- And just as we^(incl) have bodies like Adam, the earthly person,
- We are now like Adam, the person made from the ground,

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces a continuation of Paul's argument. Some English versions do not translate this word. Continue Paul's argument in the way that is natural in your language.

just as we have borne the likeness of the earthly

man: The clause we have borne the likeness of the earthly man means "we are like Adam, who is made from dirt." The past tense have borne does not imply that this has stopped. Paul and his readers still bear the likeness of Adam.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

we are made out of the dirt, like Adam

have borne the likeness: The Greek idiom "to bear the likeness of someone" means to be like that person.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

we^(incl) are like Adam, the earthly person

we have bodies like Adam, who is made of earth

15:49b

so also shall we bear the likeness of the heavenly man.

- so we will have bodies like Christ, the heavenly person.
- but we will one day become like Christ, the person who belongs to heaven.

so also shall we bear the likeness of the heavenly man: The clause so also shall we bear the likeness of the heavenly man indicates that one day we will be like Christ. We will have spiritual bodies like the one Christ received when he rose from the dead.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

so we^(incl) will be like Christ, the heavenly person

in the same way, we will have bodies like Christ, the person from heaven

likeness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as likeness is the same word that is used in 11:7b (man is the “image” of God) and Colossians 1:15 (Christ is the “image” of the invisible God).

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

we are in the image of Adam...we will be in the image of Christ

1 Corinthians 15:50

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:50–58

In this paragraph Paul finished answering the questions of 15:35. He said that God will transform both living believers and dead believers so that they can live in God’s heavenly kingdom.

15:50a

Now I declare to you, brothers, that

- ¶ I tell you^(plur), brothers and sisters, that
- ¶ Dear friends, pay attention to this:

Now I declare to you: The phrase Now I declare to you emphasizes what Paul is about to say.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Now this is what I am saying (NET)

I tell you this (RSV)

Now listen to this:

brothers: Paul addressed his fellow Christians, both male and female.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

brothers and sisters

friends (GNT)

15:50b

flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God,

- our^(incl) bodies of flesh and blood cannot live in God’s country.
- our natural/material/physical bodies cannot have a part in the place where God rules.

flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God:

This indicates that human beings in their present earthly form cannot live in God’s kingdom.

flesh and blood: The phrase flesh and blood is an idiom that refers to human beings as they exist in this age. It includes both those who are alive and those who are already dead. See also Galatians 1:16 and Ephesians 6:12, where the same phrase occurs.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

our^(incl) bodies of flesh and blood

we fleshly/earthly beings

our bodies that die

inherit the kingdom of God: The word inherit is used as a figure of speech. Normally it refers to coming into possession of something. Here it means that God gives people the right to live in his kingdom.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

have a part in the kingdom of God

live in the kingdom of God

the kingdom of God: The phrase the kingdom of God refers to God's rule over his people. It refers to the time and place when God will rule over everything.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the place where God rules over everything

God's country

See Key Biblical Terms "Kingdom of God."

15:50c

nor does the perishable inherit the imperishable.

- Things that decay cannot live in the place where nothing will decay.
- Our bodies that die cannot have a part in the place where there is no death.

nor does the perishable inherit the imperishable:

Paul used the same words perishable and imperishable that he used in 15:42b-c.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

What decays cannot inherit what doesn't decay.
(GW)

our bodies that will die cannot go to the place
where nobody dies

General Comment on 15:50b-c

If it is not natural in your language to repeat things for emphasis, it may be necessary to combine the two verse parts. For example:

our bodies of flesh and blood will decay. This means that they cannot share in God's kingdom, which lasts forever. (CEV)

our earthly bodies can never live in God's unending kingdom

1 Corinthians 15:51

Section 15:1-58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1-11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then

(15:12-34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35-58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:50-58

In this paragraph Paul finished answering the questions of 15:35. He said that God will transform both living believers and dead believers so that they can live in God's heavenly kingdom.

15:51a

Listen, I tell you a mystery:

- Listen to this. I will tell you something that you do not know.
- Pay attention as I explain this hidden message.

Listen: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Listen calls attention to something important. Paul used it to tell his readers to pay attention to what he was about to write. You should translate this in a way that encourages your readers to pay attention to what follows.

I tell you a mystery: The phrase I tell you a mystery introduces something that Paul was about to write. In some languages it may be natural to use a future tense. For example:

I will tell you a mystery (NRSV)

mystery: The word mystery refers to a secret that Paul was going to explain.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

a secret

a hidden matter

a message that you do not know

15:51b

We will not all sleep, but we will all be changed—

- We^(incl) believers will not all die, but we^(incl) will all change.

- Some of us^(incl) will not die, but God will change all of us. He will change our bodies into new bodies.

We will not all sleep: The phrase We will not all sleep means “We will not all die.” Paul said that not all believers will die before Christ returns.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

some of us will not die

not all of us will die before the Lord comes back

but we will all be changed: All believers will be changed so that they can live in the kingdom of God. The verb be changed is in the passive. There are two ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

we will all be changed (NRSV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

all of us^(incl) will change

God will change all of us

all: The word all refers to believers who have died and also those who are still alive.

changed: The “change” that God will make is to give us new bodies.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

we will all be changed, both those who have died and those who are still alive

our^(incl) bodies will change to be new bodies

we will all be made new

God will change all of us and give us new bodies

1 Corinthians 15:52

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then

(15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:50–58

In this paragraph Paul finished answering the questions of 15:35. He said that God will transform both living believers and dead believers so that they can live in God’s heavenly kingdom.

15:52a

in an instant, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet.

- This will happen in one moment, like a single blink of an eye, when the final trumpets blows.
- It will be sudden, quicker than the blink of an eye, at the time when the trumpet sounds to signal the end of the world.

in an instant, in the twinkling of an eye: The two phrases in an instant and in the twinkling of an eye both mean that the change will take place very quickly.

in an instant: The phrase an instant refers to the smallest possible unit of time, a moment.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in one moment

suddenly

very quickly

in the twinkling of an eye: This is an idiom that also means “very quickly.” Consider how to emphasize speed and suddenness in a natural way in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this idiom:

like a single blink of an eye

as quickly as a person blinks

In some languages it may be natural to follow the CEV and state this as a separate sentence:

It will happen suddenly, quicker than the blink of an eye. (CEV)

at the last trumpet: The phrase at the last trumpet means “when the last trumpet makes a sound.” The sound of the last trumpet is a signal that the end of the age has come. See 1 Thessalonians 4:16 and Matthew 24:31.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

when the trumpet blows to show that it is the end of the world

trumpet: A trumpet is a wind instrument. The musician blows into it to make a loud sound.

trumpetIllustration from The New Bible Symbols: The Bible in Pictures book, © 1922, public domain.

If you do not have a word for this instrument, you could use a similar instrument that makes a loud sound, such as:

the last horn

15:52b-d

Paul gave a list of three things that will happen when our bodies are changed into new bodies. The three things are:

- The trumpet will sound.
- The dead will be raised imperishable.
- We will all be changed.

15:52b

For the trumpet will sound,

- For the trumpet will sound.
- For we will hear the sound of someone blowing a trumpet,

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces an explanation about the sudden change to our bodies.

the trumpet will sound: This is a reference to the phrase “at the last trumpet” in 15:52a. The text does not say who will blow on the trumpet. It may be an angel or an archangel. God will order the trumpet to sound.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

God will cause the trumpet to sound

we will hear the sound of someone blowing a trumpet

15:52c

the dead will be raised imperishable,

- The people who have died will rise and never die again,
- and God will raise those who have died and give them eternal life.

In Greek, this begins with a conjunction which is usually translated as “and.” The BSB does not translate this conjunction because in natural English the word “and” is used in a list only before the last item.

the dead will be raised imperishable: This phrase indicates that when dead people rise again, their bodies will be of a kind that will not ever die. The verb will be raised is passive. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the dead will be raised, never to die again (GNT)

those who have died will be raised to live forever (NLT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God will raise the dead and they will have bodies that will never die again

15:52d

and we will be changed.

- and we^(incl) will all change.
- Then God will change all of us. He will change our bodies into new bodies.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and introduces the third item on the list.

we will be changed: Paul used an inclusive we. He expected that he and many of the Corinthian believers would still be alive at the time of the last trumpet. He expected that they would be transformed and given spiritual bodies.

be changed: Paul used the same word that he used in 15:51b. See the notes there.

1 Corinthians 15:53

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:50–58

In this paragraph Paul finished answering the questions of 15:35. He said that God will transform both living believers and dead believers so that they can live in God's heavenly kingdom.

15:53a

For the perishable must be clothed with the imperishable,

- For our^(incl) bodies that can decay must change into bodies that cannot decay,
- These bodies on this earth will become bodies for heaven.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* introduces a further explanation of what Paul said in 15:50–52.

the perishable must be clothed with the imperishable: Paul used the same words perishable and imperishable that he used in 15:42b–c. In this verse he used them with a figure of speech. The change from natural bodies to spiritual bodies is compared to putting on clothes. There are two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

This body that can be destroyed must clothe itself with something that can never be destroyed. (NCV)

- Translate the meaning. For example:

This body that decays must be changed into a body that cannot decay (GW)

our dying bodies must be transformed into bodies that will never die (NLT)

the perishable must be clothed: This is a passive clause. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

Our dead and decaying bodies will be changed (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

the perishable must clothe itself (NIV)

Our bodies that are becoming spoiled must change (EASY)

15:53b

and the mortal with immortality.

- and our bodies that die must change into bodies that live forever.
- These bodies that die will become bodies that never die.

and the mortal with immortality: This is a short way to say, “and the mortal body must be clothed with immortality.” This means approximately the same as 15:53a. There are two ways to translate it:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

these bodies which are mortal must be wrapped with immortality (NJB)

- Translate the meaning. For example:

This mortal body must be changed into a body that will live forever. (GW)

the mortal: The phrase the mortal refers to things that can die.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

our^(incl) bodies that can die

immortality: The word immortality refers to things that will never die.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

bodies that cannot die

1 Corinthians 15:54

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:50–58

In this paragraph Paul finished answering the questions of 15:35. He said that God will transform both living believers and dead believers so that they can live in God's heavenly kingdom.

15:54a

When the perishable has been clothed with the imperishable

- When our bodies that can decay have changed into bodies that cannot decay,
- When these bodies on this earth have become bodies for heaven,

15:54b

and the mortal with immortality,

- and our bodies that die have changed into bodies that live forever,
- and when these bodies that die have become bodies that never die,

15:54a-b

When the perishable has been clothed with the imperishable and the mortal with immortality: This phrase is similar to 15:53a-b. You may be able to repeat the same words almost exactly. If it is confusing in your language to reuse the same words, you may be able to summarize this and say:

When this happens

15:54c

then the saying that is written will come to pass:

- then what is written in the Scriptures will happen:
- then it will be like what is written in the Scriptures. It says there,

then the saying that is written: This phrase introduces a free quotation of two Scripture verses.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

what is written in the Scriptures

the Scriptures (CEV)

will come to pass: The phrase will come to pass means “will happen.” Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

will come true (NIV)

will be fulfilled (NLT)

will take place

it will be like what is written

15:54d-55

In these verses Paul used a figure of speech called personification. See how you translated this figure of speech in 15:26. Paul spoke of death as an enemy whom God defeats in battle. The power of death to harm people comes to an end. In 15:54d, he spoke of death in the third person, and then in 15:55 he addressed death directly in the second person. In some languages you cannot address “death” in this way. In some languages there is no abstract noun for “death.”

Here is an example of how to translate this in a language that does not have a noun “death”:

^{54d}God is victorious and he has caused it to be that people will never die again. ^{55a}Where are the dead people? There are none! ^{55b}Where are those who mourn for dead people? There are none!

15:54d

“Death has been swallowed up in victory.”

- “God has defeated death. There is no longer any death.”
- “God has conquered his enemies and his people will no longer die.”

Death has been swallowed up in victory: This saying is based on Isaiah 25:8. This is a metaphor. It indicates that God defeated the enemy, which is death. From that time and forever, people will never again have to die. There are two ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor in some form. For example:

Death is destroyed

Death has been defeated

God has conquered death

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

God has conquered all his enemies, and his people will no longer die

1 Corinthians 15:55

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:50–58

In this paragraph Paul finished answering the questions of 15:35. He said that God will transform both living believers and dead believers so that they can live in God's heavenly kingdom.

15:55a

“Where, O Death, is your victory?”

- “Death, where is your^(sing) victory?”
- “Will death defeat us?”
- “Where are the dead people? There are none.”

Where, O Death, is your victory?: This saying is a reference to Hosea 13:14. It is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement that death does not have the victory. Death does not have power over people. People will no longer die.

Here are some ways to translate this strong statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Death, what happened to the victory you hoped to win?

Will death defeat us?

Where are the dead people?

- Use a rhetorical question with the answer supplied. For example:

Death, are you the victor? Never!

Where are the dead people? There are none.

- Use a strong statement:

Death, you have not won the victory

Death has not won the victory

There are no dead people any more

Translate this strong statement in a way that is natural in your language.

This rhetorical question uses a figure of speech in which death is addressed as though it were a person. The translation examples above show some ways to remove this figure of speech if you must do so.

15:55b

“Where, O Death, is your sting?”

- “Death, where is your power to hurt us?”
- “Does death have power to hurt us?”
- “Where are the people in pain while they are dying? There are none.”

Where, O Death, is your sting?: This saying is a reference to Hosea 13:14. There is a textual problem here. Instead of Death, some Greek manuscripts have a word meaning “Hades” or “the grave.” The KJV follows these manuscripts. The UBS Greek New Testament,

4th edition, follows the manuscripts that say Death. They give this reading a B rating indicating that it is “almost certain.” It is recommended that you follow this reading. It continues to address “death” directly as if death were a person.

This is a rhetorical question. Paul used it as a strong statement. He stated that death has no more power to harm people.

Here are some ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

...where now, O death, is your power to hurt us?
(JBP)

Does death have power over us^{(incl)?}

Who is in pain while they are dying?

Where are those who mourn for the dead people?

- Use a rhetorical question with the answer supplied. For example:

Death, can you still sting us^{(excl)?} No!

Who is in pain while they are dying? Nobody!

Where are those who mourn for the dead people?
There are none!

- Use a strong statement or exclamation. For example:

Death can no longer sting/hurt people

There are no more people who die in agony

Translate this strong statement in a way that is natural in your language.

your sting: The word sting refers to the bite of an insect or a snake. If this metaphor is not understood, you can translate the meaning:

where is your power to hurt us^{(incl)?}

you have no more power to harm us

1 Corinthians 15:56

Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:50–58

In this paragraph Paul finished answering the questions of 15:35. He said that God will transform both living believers and dead believers so that they can live in God’s heavenly kingdom.

15:56a

The sting of death is sin,

- Sin is like a poison that makes people die,
- People die because they sin,

The sting of death is sin: This continues to use a figure of speech which talks about death as if it were a person. There are several ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the figure of speech in some form. For example:

Death gets its power to hurt from sin (GNT)

sin is the sting that results in death (NLT)

- Translate the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

people die because they sin

sin is like poison that causes people to die

Translate this figure of speech in a way that is natural in your language.

15:56b**and the power of sin is the law.**

- and it is the law that gives sin its power.
- and they know they have sinned because of the law.

and the power of sin is the law: The phrase the power of sin is the law means that sin receives its power from the law. It is the law that made sin powerful. See Romans 5:13–20, and 7:5–11.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

sin gains its power from the law (REB)

it is the law that gives sin its strength

we know we have sinned because we learn it in the law

the law: The phrase the law refers to the Jewish religious laws, the Torah. This is the law that God gave to Moses. Sometimes it is called:

the law of Moses

1 Corinthians 15:57**Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead**

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:50–58

In this paragraph Paul finished answering the questions of 15:35. He said that God will transform both living believers and dead believers so that they can live in God's heavenly kingdom.

15:57a**But thanks be to God,**

- But thank God.
- But let us^(incl) give thanks to God that

But thanks be to God: The expression thanks be to God is a call to give thanks to God.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

let us^(incl) thank God

thank^(plur) God

15:57b**who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ!**

- He causes us^(incl) to win the victory over death through our Lord Jesus Christ.
- we will never die again because of what our Lord Jesus Christ has done.

who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ: Paul gave the reason for his exclamation of thanks in 15:57a. He is thankful that God makes his people victorious over sin and death through the Lord Jesus Christ.

who gives us the victory: The phrase who gives us the victory means that God makes his people able to win the victory. In some languages it may be natural to avoid the abstract noun victory and say:

he helps us^(incl) win

In some languages it may be necessary to say what God gives believers the victory over:

He gives us victory over sin and death (NLT)

who makes us^(incl) able to conquer death

because of him we will no longer die

because of him we are no longer afraid of death

through our Lord Jesus Christ: Here is another way to translate this phrase:

because of what our Lord Jesus Christ did

General Comment on 15:57a-b

Paul thanked God for giving us the victory. In some languages it may be natural to express this in two sentences, as the NIV does:

But thanks be to God! He gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ. (NIV)

1 Corinthians 15:58**Section 15:1–58: Believers will rise from the dead**

In this section Paul reminded the Corinthian believers about the gospel and showed them that the resurrection from the dead was an important part of the gospel. First (15:1–11) he wrote about the evidence showing that God raised Christ from the dead. Then (15:12–34) he taught that God will raise believers from the dead. Finally (15:35–58) he taught about what the resurrection body will be like.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The resurrection

People who die will live again

Christ has risen and his people will rise also

Paragraph 15:50–58

In this paragraph Paul finished answering the questions of 15:35. He said that God will transform both living believers and dead believers so that they can live in God's heavenly kingdom.

15:58a**Therefore, my beloved brothers, be steadfast**

- Dear brothers and sisters, you should therefore be firm in believing in God.
- Because of this, my dear friends, let your faith be strong.

15:58b**and immovable.**

- Do not move away from God.
- Do not let anybody turn you^(plur) away from trusting in God.

15:58a-b

Therefore: The word Therefore introduces a conclusion to what Paul said. Here is another way to translate this:

So then (GNT)

my beloved brothers: The phrase my beloved brothers is an affectionate way to address other believers. Here is another way to translate this:

my dear friends (GNT)

be steadfast: The phrase be steadfast is a command to be firm in faith. Paul encouraged the Corinthians to keep trusting the Lord.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

be steadfast in believing in God

strengthen your trust in God

let your faith be strong

be...immovable: The phrase be...immovable is more literally “don't move away.” Paul encouraged the Corinthians not to move away from the Lord.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

don't move away from God

don't separate from your faith

don't let anybody turn you away from trusting in God

15:58c**Always excel in the work of the Lord,**

- Always work hard for the Lord,
- At all times do the work that the Lord gives you to do enthusiastically/diligently,

Always excel in the work of the Lord: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as excel in the work of the Lord is more literally “abound in the work of the Lord.” It refers to working diligently and faithfully for the Lord Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

work hard for the Lord

be diligent/industrious/enthusiastic to work for the Lord

do the work that the Lord gives you to do with energy

15:58d

because you know that your labor in the Lord is not in vain.

- knowing that the work you^(plur) do for the Lord is not without benefit.
- You can be sure that working for the Lord is always valuable.

because you know that: This phrase introduces the reason why the Corinthians should always work hard for the Lord. Here is another way to translate this:

being sure that (NJB)

your labor in the Lord is not in vain: This phrase indicates that nothing a believer does for the Lord Jesus is useless. It is not a waste of time to work hard for the Lord.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

your work for the Lord is not for nothing

in the Lord none of your work is done with no benefit

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an emphatic positive statement. For example:

when you work for the Lord, you are certainly using your time well

everything you do for him is worthwhile (CEV)

in vain: See how you translated this same phrase at the beginning of the chapter in 15:2c.

1 Corinthians 16:1

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

16:1a

Now about the collection for the saints,

- ¶ Regarding the money you^(plur) should collect for God's holy people:
- ¶ There is another thing: I want you to collect money to help the believers in Jerusalem.

Now about: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Now about indicates a transition to a different topic. This same introduction was used in 7:1 and 7:25. See how you translated it there.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

As for the subject of

Now I want to write about

I have another command for you about

You should start this verse in a way that is natural for introducing a new topic in your language.

the collection for the saints: This is the new topic that Paul wanted to discuss. Many of the believers in Jerusalem were poor and Paul wanted the Corinthian Christians to collect money to help them.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the money to be raised to help God's people (GNT)

gathering money to help God's people

I want you to collect money to help God's people

collection: The word collection refers to gathering money together from many people.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

money

the money to be collected (GW)

the saints: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the saints is literally "the holy ones." See 1:2 where the same word occurs. Some English versions translate this as:

God's people

Paul wanted them to collect money for poor believers in Jerusalem. This is clear from 16:3c and from Romans 15:25–31. It may be helpful to put that information in this verse. For example:

the saints in Jerusalem who are poor

16:1b

you are to do as I directed the churches of Galatia:

- Follow^(plur) the instructions I gave to the churches in Galatia.
- I told the people in the churches of Galatia province how to do this. You should do the same.

you are to do as I directed the churches of Galatia:

Paul had already told the Christians in Galatia how to collect this money. He wanted the Christians in Corinth to do the same thing.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

You must do what I told the churches in Galatia to do. (GNT)

I told the churches in Galatia how to do this. You should do the same as they did.

the churches of Galatia: The phrase the churches of Galatia means “churches in Galatia Province.” Galatia was a province of Rome in what is now the country of Turkey. In some languages it may not be natural to speak of giving directions to churches. In those languages it may be better to say:

the believers in the churches of Galatia

1 Corinthians 16:2

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

16:2a

On the first day of every week, each of you should set aside a portion of his income,

- On the first day of each week you^(plur) should all put aside some money, according to how God has blessed you^(plur),
- Every Sunday, each of you are to take some of your money, according to how much money you gained that week.

On the first day of every week: The first day of every week in the Jewish calendar is Sunday. The believers met together to worship God on this day. If the first day of the week in your language does not fall on a Sunday, it may be possible to translate this as:

Every Sunday (GNT)

on the first day of the Jewish week

on every worship day/rest day

each of you should set aside a portion of his income: The phrase set aside implies that the believers were to keep the money at home. They were not to spend it but were to put it in a safe place.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you should divide out your money and set aside one part

take the money you will give and put it in a separate place at home

a portion of his income: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a portion of his income is more literally “as he has prospered.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in proportion to what you have earned (GNT)

according to how God has blessed you

according to how much money you got that week

if you earned a lot that week give a lot; if you earned a little give a little

16:2b saving it up,

- and save it.
- You should store it up at your house,

saving it up: Paul told the believers to keep this money safe and regularly add to it. The implied information is that they were to save it at their own home, not at the church building.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

set it aside at your house

store it up at home

General Comment on 16:2a-b

The order of the Greek clauses is different from the way the BSB has translated it. The RSV is an example of an English version that follows the Greek order:

On the first day of every week, each of you is to put something aside and store it up, as he may prosper (RSV)

Consider which order is most natural in your language.

16:2c so that when I come no collections will be needed.

- Then when I come to you^(plur) it will not be necessary to take up a collection.
- so that it will not be necessary to collect money when I arrive in Corinth.

so that when I come no collections will be needed: This clause explains why Paul asked the Corinthians to save up money. In some languages it may be necessary to translate the passive verb phrase will be needed as an active verb:

in order that you^(plur) will not have to collect money when I come to Corinth

Paul wanted the believers to have the money ready to give to him when he got to Corinth. Then he would not need to collect money from them.

1 Corinthians 16:3

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he

concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

16:3a Then, on my arrival,

- When I reach Corinth,
- When I get there

Then, on my arrival: This refers to the same time as “when I come” in verse 16:2c.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

At that time

When I arrive in Corinth

16:3b I will send letters with those you recommend

- I will write letters of introduction for the people you^(plur) choose,
- you should choose some people. I will write letters to the believers in Jerusalem about them.

16:3c to carry your gift to Jerusalem.

- and I will send those people to carry your^(plur) gift to Jerusalem.
- Then they will take your money to Jerusalem.

**16:3b-c
I will send letters with those you recommend to carry your gift to Jerusalem:** The Greek clauses are in a different order from the way the BSB has translated it. A more literal translation is: “whom you shall approve through letters I shall send them to bring your gift to Jerusalem.”

There are two ways to interpret the words “through letters”:

1. Paul will write the letters. The phrase “through letters” goes with the verb “I shall send.” For example:

I will write letters of recommendation for the messengers you choose to deliver your gift to Jerusalem (NLT) (BSB, NLT, NIV, NRSV, NJB, NABRE, NASB, REB, GW, NCV, GNT)

1. The Corinthians will write the letters. The phrase “through letters” goes with the verb “you shall approve.” For example:

I will send those whom you accredit by letter to carry your gift to Jerusalem (RSV) (RSV, ESV, CEV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is followed by the majority of English versions, and by several commentaries. See, for example, Fee, p. 814–815, and Thiselton, p. 1324.

letters: The Christians in Jerusalem knew Paul. Paul would write letters to them telling them about the money and about the people who carried it.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

witness letters

I will write letters to introduce them to the believers in Jerusalem

I will write a letter to the believers in Jerusalem saying that you want to help them

those you recommend: The believers in Corinth chose these people from among themselves. The Greek pronoun that the BSB translates as those is more literally “whom.” These people were probably men, but we do not know for sure.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the people you choose

to carry your gift: Paul would send this group of people from Corinth, and they would carry the money to Jerusalem. Paul did not know if he would travel with them.

The journey from Corinth to Jerusalem was 1300 kilometers. It would have taken them several weeks to travel by sea and by land.

General Comment on 16:3

In some languages it may be natural to follow a model that combines the parts of verse 16:3 in a different way. For example:

When I arrive, I will send whomever you approve to take your gift to Jerusalem. I will send them with letters of introduction. (NCV)

1 Corinthians 16:4

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

16:4a

And if it is advisable for me to go also,

- If it seems sensible for me to go to Jerusalem as well,
- It may be good for me to go to Jerusalem too.

And if it is advisable for me to go also: Paul was uncertain whether or not he should go to Jerusalem at that time. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence:

It may be good for me to go to Jerusalem as well.
If so...

advisable: The Greek word that the BSB translates as advisable can also be translated as:

if it seems appropriate for me to go (NLT)

if it is good/right for me to go

Paul did not say whether it was advisable to him or to the Corinthians. Probably he implied both things. If he and the Corinthians thought he should go too, then he would go.

Later, Paul decided to travel with these people and their collection of money. See 2 Corinthians 1:15–16.

16:4b

they can travel with me.

- then we^(excl) will go together.
- If so then those you choose will travel with me.

they can travel with me: The phrase they can travel with me indicates that Paul and the people the Corinthians choose will travel together.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I will accompany them

we^(excl) will go together

1 Corinthians 16:5

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:5–9

In this paragraph Paul wrote about his travel plans. Paul wrote this letter from Ephesus, probably in March or April. He said that he would stay in Ephesus until after Pentecost, which is in late May or early June. Then he would travel through Macedonia to go to Corinth. He planned to stay in Corinth through the winter.

16:5a

After I go through Macedonia, however, I will come to you;

- ¶ I am going to travel through Macedonia province and then I will visit you^(plur).
- ¶ After I go through Macedonia province I will go to see you.

After I go through Macedonia: Macedonia was the name of a Roman province. Today that territory is in northern Greece. Paul wrote this letter from Ephesus. A journey by land from Ephesus to Corinth goes through Macedonia.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I will travel across Macedonia Province on my way to see you

I will visit you after I visit the people in Macedonia Province

I will come to you: Translate this in a way that is natural for someone who is planning to visit friends. Here is another way to translate this:

I am coming to visit you (NLT)

16:5b

for I will be going through Macedonia.

- I do plan to pass through Macedonia.
- I am going to go by that route.

for I will be going through Macedonia: There are two ways to travel from Ephesus to Corinth. Paul could have gone by boat across the Aegean Sea. Instead he chose to go by land through Macedonia. This was new information to the Corinthians. You should introduce this information in a way that is natural for your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

for I do plan to travel through Macedonia Province

for I will be going by that route

1 Corinthians 16:6

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:5–9

In this paragraph Paul wrote about his travel plans. Paul wrote this letter from Ephesus, probably in March or April. He said that he would stay in Ephesus until after Pentecost, which is in late May or early June. Then he would travel through Macedonia to go to Corinth. He planned to stay in Corinth through the winter.

16:6a

Perhaps I will stay with you awhile, or even spend the winter,

- I may stay with you^(plur) for a while, and I may even stay with you through the winter.
- If it is possible I will stay with you for some time, perhaps until the cold season is finished.

Perhaps I will stay with you awhile: The Greek words are more literally Perhaps I will stay with you. The BSB has supplied the word awhile. Paul said that his visit with them may be longer than just a short time.

or even spend the winter: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as or even indicates that Paul is uncertain about how long he will stay with them. Express this uncertainty in a way that is natural in your language.

spend the winter: The phrase spend the winter is a short way of saying “I may stay with you the whole winter.” Paul thought that he might stay in Corinth all winter, but he was not sure. Another way to translate this is:

maybe until the cold season is finished

The Mediterranean Sea is in the northern hemisphere, and the winter is December through March. Travel during the winter was difficult, especially travel by boat.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

Perhaps I will stay awhile with you, possibly all winter (NLT)

I hope to stay with you for quite a long time. I may stay all winter.

16:6b

so that you can help me on my journey, wherever I go.

- Then you^(plur) can support me on my way, whichever way I go.
- Then you can give me the things I need for my next trip, wherever I go next.

so that you can help me on my journey: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as help me on my journey refers to providing money and food for a trip. This states part of Paul’s purpose for staying with them.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Then you can give me your support as I travel (GW)

so that you can give me the things I need for my next trip

wherever I go: The phrase wherever I go suggests that Paul had not decided where to go after he left Corinth.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

wherever I will go next

1 Corinthians 16:7**Section 16:1-24: Paul gave some final instructions**

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:5-9

In this paragraph Paul wrote about his travel plans. Paul wrote this letter from Ephesus, probably in March or April. He said that he would stay in Ephesus until after Pentecost, which is in late May or early June. Then he would travel through Macedonia to go to Corinth. He planned to stay in Corinth through the winter.

16:7a

For I do not want to see you now only in passing;

- I do not want to come and see you^(plur) now for just a brief time.
- I want to visit you for a long time, longer than I am able to stay right now.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces a further explanation about why Paul may spend the winter with the Corinthians.

I do not want to see you now only in passing: Paul wanted to visit with the Corinthians for a long time, not just a short time.

A literal translation of I do not want to see you now may suggest that Paul did not want to see the Corinthians. Be sure that in your translation it is clear

that Paul did want to see the Corinthians. He wanted to see them, and to stay for a long time.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I want to see you more than just briefly in passing (GNT)

I want my visit to you to be a long visit, not a short one

I do not want to come but stay only a short time and then go

now: In this context the word now means “in the near future.”

in passing: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in passing is an idiom that means “a short visit.” Consider if there is a natural idiom in your language that refers to a short stay with someone.

16:7b

I hope to spend some time with you, if the Lord permits.

- I want to stay with you^(plur) for a long time, if the Lord allows me to.
- If the Lord will let me, I hope to have a long visit.

I hope to spend some time with you: The phrase some time means:

quite a long time

if the Lord permits: Paul said that the Lord was in control of his plans, and that it might not be possible for him to do as he hoped.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

if the Lord allows (GNT)

if the Lord will let me (NLT)

General Comment on 16:7a-b

In some languages it may be natural to reorder this verse. It may be clearer to say what should happen, before you say what should not happen. For example:

^{7b}If the Lord lets me, I would rather come later for a longer visit ^{7a}than to stop off now for only a short visit. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 16:8

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:5–9

In this paragraph Paul wrote about his travel plans. Paul wrote this letter from Ephesus, probably in March or April. He said that he would stay in Ephesus until after Pentecost, which is in late May or early June. Then he would travel through Macedonia to go to Corinth. He planned to stay in Corinth through the winter.

16:8

But I will stay in Ephesus until Pentecost,

- But first I will stay here at Ephesus until the festival of Pentecost.
- But I will stay here in Ephesus City until after the Pentecost festival.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces new information about Paul’s visit to Corinth. Paul wanted to visit them but he needed to remain in Ephesus first to work there.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

In the meantime (NLT)

I plan to visit you, but first

You should translate this in a way that is natural in your language.

I will stay in Ephesus: Paul was in the city of Ephesus when he wrote this. In some languages it may be natural to say:

I will stay here in Ephesus

until Pentecost: Pentecost is a Jewish festival, a religious celebration. It is also mentioned in Acts 2:1. Pentecost comes during late May or early June, fifty days after Passover.

1 Corinthians 16:9

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:5–9

In this paragraph Paul wrote about his travel plans. Paul wrote this letter from Ephesus, probably in March or April. He said that he would stay in Ephesus until after Pentecost, which is in late May or early June. Then he would travel through Macedonia to go to Corinth. He planned to stay in Corinth through the winter.

16:9a

because a great door for effective work has opened to me,

- A wide door of opportunity has opened up for me to do good work,
- I will stay here because there are many people who want to believe in the word I preach.

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason why Paul wanted to stay longer in Ephesus.

a great door for effective work has opened to me: The Greek text is more literally “a door to me is opened, great and effective.” An open door is a metaphor indicating an opportunity. The BSB has supplied the word work to help clarify its meaning. This metaphor means that God gave Paul an opportunity to do effective ministry in Ephesus. He was able to preach the gospel often and he preached to many people.

There are several ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor of the open door. It may be necessary to supply a word that means work or “service.” For example:

there is a wide-open door for a great work here (NLT)

a door of great opportunity stands wide open for me (NET)

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

I have a great opportunity to do effective work here (GW)

there are many people here who want to believe in the word I teach

I am able to speak about the Lord to many people here

work: The work Paul talked about was the task of preaching the gospel. He did not refer to paid employment. He did not receive a salary.

16:9b

even though many oppose me.

- and many people are against me.
- Also there are many people who do not want me to preach.

even though: There are several ways to interpret the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as even though:

1. It continues the thought and introduces another reason why Paul will stay in Ephesus. For example:

and (NJB) (NJB, NIV, RSV, ESV, REB, NASB, NCV, KJV)

1. It introduces a contrasting thought. There was a good opportunity in Ephesus, but there were many adversaries. For example:

but (NET) (NET, NABRE, CEV)

1. It introduces a concession. There was a good opportunity, even though there were many enemies. For example:

although (GW) (BSB, GW, NLT, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This has more support among the English versions and commentaries. See Fee, p. 820; Hodge, p. 367; Robertson and Plummer, p. 390.

many oppose me: The phrase many oppose me indicates that there were many people in Ephesus who wanted Paul to stop preaching the gospel. They did not believe what he said.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

there are many people who do not want me to preach

1 Corinthians 16:10

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:10–11

In this paragraph Paul wrote about his fellow worker Timothy. Timothy was traveling to Corinth, and Paul wanted to make sure that his visit there was a good one.

16:10a

If Timothy comes, see to it that he has nothing to fear while he is with you,

- ¶ If Timothy arrives, do not make^(plur) him be afraid to work with you.
- ¶ Whenever Timothy reaches you^(plur), be sure that he can stay with you without fear.

If Timothy comes: Paul had already sent Timothy to Corinth (see 4:17). He hoped that Timothy would reach Corinth. However, he was not certain that this would happen or when it would be.

comes: The verb comes refers to reaching the city of Corinth. Paul himself was not in Corinth.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

gets to you

arrives in Corinth

see to it that: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as see to it that introduces a command.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

be sure that (he has nothing to fear)

do not (make him afraid)

he has nothing to fear while he is with you: Some of the Corinthians were angry at Paul, and Timothy was Paul's friend. Paul thought that because of this, the Corinthians might not receive Timothy in a friendly way.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

do not make him be afraid to work with you

do not threaten him

welcome him so that he won't be afraid of you

16:10b

for he is doing the work of the Lord, just as I am.

- For he is working for the Lord, the same as I am.
- He is working for the Lord in the same way that I work for the Lord.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces a reason why the Corinthians should do what Paul told them.

he is doing the work of the Lord: The phrase he is doing the work of the Lord means that the work Timothy did benefited the kingdom of God. He traveled to visit the Corinthians in order to serve the Lord.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he is doing the Lord's work (CEV)

he is working for the Lord (GNT)

just as I am: The phrase just as I am is a short way to say "just as I also am carrying on the work of the Lord."

16:10b–11a

he is doing the work of the Lord, just as I am. No one, then, should treat him with contempt: In some languages it may be clearer to reverse the order of these clauses.

Here is another way to translate these clauses:

No one should treat him with contempt, because he is doing the work of the Lord, just as I am

1 Corinthians 16:11

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:10–11

In this paragraph Paul wrote about his fellow worker Timothy. Timothy was traveling to Corinth, and Paul wanted to make sure that his visit there was a good one.

16:11a

No one, then, should treat him with contempt.

- So no one should treat him as unimportant.
- Therefore, nobody should disrespect him.

No one...should treat him with contempt: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as treat him with contempt is more literally “despise him.” Some of the Corinthians despised Paul, and they may have also despised Paul’s co-worker.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

none of you should treat Timothy as unimportant (NCV)

No one...should refuse to accept him (NIV)

no one should disrespect him

then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as then introduces another command that Paul gave based on the reason he gave in 16:10b.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

therefore

so

Translate this conjunction in a way that is natural in your language for introducing a command after a reason has been given for the command.

16:11b

Send him on his way in peace so that he can return to me,

- Support^(plur) him on his journey so that he can come back to me, and send him with your blessing of peace.
- When he comes back to me give him the things he needs for his trip, and give him your blessing as he leaves.

In Greek, this clause connects to the previous clause with a conjunction that the BSB does not translate. It introduces what the Corinthians were to do instead of despising Timothy.

Here are some ways to translate this conjunction:

But

Instead

Introduce this information in a way that is natural in your language.

Send him on his way: After Timothy visited the Corinthians, he planned to travel back to see Paul. Paul asked the Corinthians to help him on the journey. The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Send him was used in 16:6b. It refers to providing money and food for a trip.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

give him your support for his trip (GW)

when he leaves, give him what he needs for his journey

in peace: The traditional blessing when people departed from each other was “Go in peace.” Paul asked the Corinthians to give Timothy their blessing when he left.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and bless him with peace as he leaves

so that he can come to me peacefully/happily

so that he can return to me: This gives the purpose or reason the Corinthians should send Timothy on his way.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

so that he can come back to see me

In some languages it may be natural to combine this clause with the previous one:

send him back to me in peace

16:11c

for I am expecting him along with the brothers.

- I am waiting for him to come back with the other believers.
- I hope he will return to me soon, along with his companions.

for I am expecting him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as expecting can also be translated “wait for.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

for I am waiting for him

for I hope he will come soon

along with the brothers: There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. Paul expected Timothy to come in company with the other brothers. For example:

I am expecting him to come with the brothers (NCV) (BSB, NCV, NIV, ESV, NET, RSV, NASB, NABRE, GNT, GW, NLT, CEV, KJV)

1. Paul and the other brothers expected Timothy to come. For example:

the brothers and I are waiting for him (NJB) (NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This has more support among the English versions. However, most commentaries say that either interpretation could be correct. For discussion on this in the

commentaries see Fee, p. 822; Verbrugge & Harris, p. 410, and Grosheide, p. 401.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

with the other believers (NLT)

along with his companions

along with the other brothers and sisters who will travel with him

the brothers: The phrase the brothers refers to some other believers who were traveling at this time. They were not literally brothers of Timothy or of Paul.

1 Corinthians 16:12

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:12

In this paragraph Paul wrote about a Christian worker named Apollos. It appears that the Corinthians had asked for Apollos to visit them.

16:12a

Now about our brother Apollos:

- ¶ As for our^(incl) brother Apollos,
- ¶ In your letter you asked that Apollos, our^(incl) brother in Christ might visit you.

Now about our brother Apollos: The phrase Now about refers to a topic that the Corinthians had mentioned in their letter. This phrase has been used several times. See 7:1, 7:25, 8:1, 12:1 and 16:1. See how you translated this phrase in those places.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

In your letter you asked about our brother Apollos

In your letter you said you wanted our brother Apollos to visit you

our brother Apollos: Apollos was a Jewish Christian leader. The Corinthians probably asked about him in their letter to Paul. This is Paul's answer. Apollos is also mentioned in 1:12, 3:5, and Acts 18:24. Apollos was not literally Paul's brother. He was a spiritual brother, a fellow believer in Jesus Christ.

Probably Apollos was younger than Paul, although we do not know for sure. In languages that track the age of siblings it can be translated as:

my younger brother, Apollos

16:12b

I strongly urged him to go to you with the brothers.

- I encouraged him strongly to go to you^(plur) along with the other brothers.
- I told him to go visit you when the other brothers in Christ go.

I strongly urged him to go to you with the brothers:

Paul encouraged Apollos to visit the Corinthians.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I urged him to visit you with the other believers (NLT)

I begged him to go visit you when the other brothers went

the brothers: These brothers were Christian workers. They may be the same Christian brothers mentioned in 16:11, or they may be the three men mentioned in 16:17a.

16:12c

He was not at all inclined to go now,

- He does not want to go at this time,
- He said that he definitely would not go now.

In Greek, this clause connects to the previous clause with a conjunction that the BSB does not translate. This conjunction introduces Apollos' rejection of Paul's attempt to encourage him to visit Corinth. Many English versions translate this conjunction as:

but

He was not at all inclined to go now: This clause indicates that Apollos did not want to go to Corinth at

that time. The word translated as at all means that he was very unwilling.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He did not at all want to come now (NCV)

he was quite determined not to go at present (REB)

he said that he definitely would not go now

go: The BSB uses the word go to refer to Apollos' travel to Corinth. The NCV and some other English versions use the word "come." Consider whether go or "come" is more natural in your language.

16:12d

but he will go when he has the opportunity.

- but he will visit you^(plur) when he has a chance.
- However, he will go when the time is right.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but introduces a concession that contrasts with the refusal in 16:12c. In English it is not natural to use the word but in two consecutive phrases. English versions that use but in 16:12c sometimes begin a new sentence here without a conjunction. For example:

He will come when he has the opportunity. (NET)

You could also use a different conjunction, as the GNT has:

When he gets the chance, however, he will go. (GNT)

Connect these clauses in a way that is natural in your language.

he will go when he has the opportunity: Apollos hoped to visit the Corinthians at some future time that would be better or more convenient for him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause

he will visit you when he has an opportunity (GW)

When he gets the chance,...he will go (GNT)

he will go when there is nothing to hinder him

1 Corinthians 16:13

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:13–14

In this paragraph Paul wrote five general warnings and encouragements. Each of these is given as a brief command.

16:13a

Be on the alert. Stand firm in the faith.

- ¶ Do not^(plur) fall asleep. Stand firm^(plur) in the Christian faith.
- ¶ Be on guard against spiritual danger. Continue to believe in the good news.

Be on the alert: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Be on the alert is more literally “Be awake.” This is a figure of speech. It is a command to be on guard against anything that would hinder them spiritually. There are two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the metaphor of staying awake. For example:

stay awake

do not fall asleep

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

Be watchful (ESV)

be on guard against spiritual danger

See also how you translated this Greek word in Mark 13:35.

Stand firm in the faith: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Stand firm in the faith is literally “stand

in the faith.” The BSB has supplied the word firm. There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It refers to Christian doctrine and teaching. For example:

Be firm in the Christian faith (GW) (BSB, GW, NIV, GNT, NET, NJB, NABRE, KJV, NCV, NASB, ESV, REB, NLT)

1. It refers to one’s personal faith in God. For example:

stand firm in your faith (RSV) (RSV, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is supported by many English versions and by many commentaries. See, for example, Fee, p. 827–828; and Thiselton p. 1336.

The phrase “stand in the faith” is a figure of speech. It is a command to continue to believe the gospel message.

Here are some ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the metaphor of standing. For example:

stand firm in the faith (ESV)

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

continue to believe in the good news

continue believing

never stop trusting God (EASY)

Translate this figure of speech in the way that is most natural in your language.

16:13b

Be men of courage. Be strong.

- Be^(plur) courageous. Be^(plur) strong.
- Don’t be afraid of anything. Be strong in your faith.

Be men of courage: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Be men of courage is more literally “be men” or “act like men.” This is a figure of speech. It means “be brave.” Paul wanted both men and women to be brave.

Here are some other ways to translate this Greek word:

Be courageous. (NLT)

Be brave people.

Don't be afraid of anything.

Be strong: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Be strong refers to being strong in faith.

Here are some other ways to translate this Greek word:

be strong in holding to your faith

make your faith be strong

have strength in mind and heart

It is possible to combine the two commands of 16:13b like this:

be brave and strong in your faith

1 Corinthians 16:14

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:13–14

In this paragraph Paul wrote five general warnings and encouragements. Each of these is given as a brief command.

16:14

Do everything in love.

- Everything you^(plur) do should be done with love.
- In everything you do, you must love each other.

Do everything in love: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in love means “in a loving way.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Show love in everything you do (CEV)

In everything you do, you must love each other

1 Corinthians 16:15

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:15–18

In this paragraph Paul wrote about how Stephanas and his family had served the Corinthians, and he urged the Corinthians to appreciate what they had done. He also expressed appreciation for Stephanas and two other men who had come to visit him.

16:15a

You know that Stephanas and his household were the first converts in Achaia,

- ¶ You^(plur) know that Stephanas and those who live in his house were the first people in Achaia to believe.
- ¶ You know Stephanas and his family. They were the first family among you in Achaia Province to trust in Christ.

In Greek, this clause connects to the previous clause with a conjunction that the BSB does not translate. This conjunction functions to introduce a new topic. Some English versions translate it as “now.” You should introduce this new topic in a way that is natural for your language.

You know that: The phrase You know that introduces a new topic by reminding the Corinthians of something that they already knew. Stephanas and his family lived in Corinth and the believers there knew them.

Stephanas and his household: This family is also mentioned in 1:16. See the notes there. The word household refers to those who lived with Stephanas in his house. It may include slaves and servants as well as family members.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Stephanas and his family (GNT)

were the first converts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the first converts is literally “firstfruits.” It is the same word that occurs in 15:20b. Here it refers to the first entire family to believe in the Lord Jesus. Other individuals had been converted earlier. Another way to translate this is:

the first people to believe in Christ

the first family to believe in Christ

in Achaia: Corinth was in the Roman province of Achaia. The area is now southern Greece. See also Acts 18:12.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

there in Achaia Province

Paul was the person who baptized Stephanas and his family.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

when I first preached the gospel there in Achaia Province, Stephanas and his family were the first people to believe

16:15b

and they have devoted themselves to the service of the saints.

- They diligently work to serve the believers.
- They keep on working hard as they help to teach God’s people.

and they have devoted themselves: The phrase they have devoted themselves indicates that Stephanas and his family decided to help other believers. They chose to do this and they were doing it faithfully.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they...have given themselves (GNT)

they are working diligently

to the service of the saints: The phrase the service of the saints refers to serving God’s people. Stephanas and his family did all they could to help other Christians.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they serve God’s people

they help God’s people

We do not know for sure how Stephanas and his family served people. If it is necessary to expand on the word “serve” you can translate this as:

they serve by helping God’s people

they help to teach God’s people

saints: The Greek word that the BSB translates as saints is the same word as was used in 16:1a. You should use the same word here as you used in 16:1a.

16:15c

Now I urge you, brothers,

- My brothers and sisters, I encourage you^(plur)
- I ask you, friends,

Now I urge you, brothers: The phrase Now I urge you, brothers functions to strengthen and emphasize the command that follows.

brothers: Paul spoke to all the believers in Corinth, both men and women.

Here is another other way to translate this phrase:

Now I urge you, brothers and sisters

General Comment on 16:15–16

In the Greek text, verse 15 begins with the words “I urge you.” Paul started his appeal, and then he interrupted the appeal to give some information about the household of Stephanas. Then in verse 16 he returned to his appeal. The BSB changed the order in verse 15 so that the information about Stephanas is given first and then the parts of the appeal come together.

Some English versions place the words “I urge you” at the beginning of verse 16. For example:

¹⁵Now, brethren, you know the household of Stephanas were the first converts in Achaia, and they have devoted themselves to the service of the saints; ¹⁶I urge you to... (RSV)

Translate this so that Paul’s appeal to them to submit to Stephanas is clear.

1 Corinthians 16:16

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:15–18

In this paragraph Paul wrote about how Stephanas and his family had served the Corinthians, and he urged the Corinthians to appreciate what they had done. He also expressed appreciation for Stephanas and two other men who had come to visit him.

16:16a

to submit to such as these,

- to cooperate with people who are like this.
- to follow people who serve others like they do.

In Greek, this clause connects to the previous clause with a conjunction that the BSB does not translate.

Here are some ways to translate this conjunction:

also (NET)

in turn (NJB)

to submit to such as these: The phrase submit to such as these indicates that Paul wanted the Corinthians to receive direction and instructions from people who served others in the way that Stephanas's family did.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

follow the leadership of such people as these
(GNT)

put yourselves at the service of people like this
(NJB)

16:16b

and to every fellow worker and laborer.

- Also cooperate with all who share in this work and work hard at it.
- And follow all people who work with us^(incl) in the work of the Lord, and labor hard to do it.

and to every fellow worker and laborer: In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

Submit also to everyone fellow worker and laborer

fellow worker: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as fellow worker is literally “works with.” Paul did not say who these people worked with. If you need to be explicit you could say:

everyone who works with us^(incl) in doing the work of the Lord

and laborer: The Greek word that the BSB translates as laborer refers to someone who does hard work.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

and those who toil to do this work

1 Corinthians 16:17

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:15–18

In this paragraph Paul wrote about how Stephanas and his family had served the Corinthians, and he urged the Corinthians to appreciate what they had done. He also expressed appreciation for Stephanas and two other men who had come to visit him.

16:17a

I am glad that Stephanas, Fortunatus, and Achaicus have arrived,

- I am happy that Stephanas, Fortunatus, and Achaicus have come here.

- It is a joy that these men, Stephanas, Fortunatus, and Achaicus, have come to visit me.

I am glad that Stephanas, Fortunatus, and Achaicus have arrived: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as I am glad is in the present tense. These three men came from Corinth to Ephesus to visit Paul, and they were still with him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I am glad that Stephanas, Fortunatus, and Achaicus have come here

It is a great pleasure to me that Stephanas, Fortunatus, and Achaicus have arrived (REB)

16:17b
because they have supplied what was lacking from you.

- I miss you and they have made me happy in your absence.
- You could not be here, but they came in your place.

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because introduces a reason why Paul was glad that the three men had arrived. Some English versions leave this conjunction untranslated. This is natural in English because the relationship is clear without it. Make this relationship clear in a way that is natural in your language.

they have supplied what was lacking from you: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as what was lacking from you is literally “your lack.” There are at least two ways to interpret this:

1. Paul missed the Corinthians. The three messengers helped him to not miss them so much. For example:

they have made up for your absence (RSV) (RSV, GNT, ESV, NJB, NABRE, NCV, CEV, GW, NET)

1. The Corinthians were unable to do something for Paul. The messengers supplied something that the Corinthians could not do for him. For example:

They have been providing the help you weren’t here to give me. (NLT) (BSB, NLT, NIV, REB, NASB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It has stronger support in English versions and in the

commentaries. See, for example, Fee, p. 832, and Thiselton, p. 1340.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

You are not here, but they have filled your place. (NCV)

Having them here was like having you. (CEV)

1 Corinthians 16:18

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:15–18

In this paragraph Paul wrote about how Stephanas and his family had served the Corinthians, and he urged the Corinthians to appreciate what they had done. He also expressed appreciation for Stephanas and two other men who had come to visit him.

16:18a

For they refreshed my spirit and yours as well.

- For they gave rest to my spirit and to yours^(plur) also.
- They encouraged me, just as they also encouraged you.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces a reason why the three men made up for the absence of the Corinthians. They encouraged Paul’s spirit with the news they brought.

they refreshed my spirit and yours as well: The clause they refreshed my spirit and yours as well indicates that these men brought rest to both Paul and the Corinthians. They encouraged and strengthened them both.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they have raised my spirits—and no doubt yours too (REB)

they have set my mind at rest, just as they did yours (NJB)

refreshed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as refreshed is more literally “put at rest.” This is the word used in Matthew 11:28 when Jesus said, “I will give you rest.”

16:18b

Show your appreciation, therefore, to such men.

- So show^(plur) respect to people like this.
- Give honor to all people who do like they do.

Show your appreciation, therefore, to such men:

The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as therefore indicates that Paul told the Corinthians to honor people like Stephanas because of their qualities that he mentioned in verse 17 and 18a. Translate this connection in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some ways to translate this connection:

So then, recognize people like this. (NET)

Therefore acknowledge such men (NASB)

Show your appreciation: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Show...appreciation is more literally “acknowledge them.” Paul wanted the Corinthians to tell people that these men, and other people like them, were worthy of respect.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

show respect to people like this

give honor to people who do like these people do

such men: Paul referred to men who did the same good things that Stephanas, Fortunatus and Achaicus did.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

people who do things like these men do

1 Corinthians 16:19

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he

concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:19–20

In this paragraph Paul gave greetings from three groups of people in Asia. Consider the forms that are natural in your language for sending greetings in a letter.

16:19a

The churches in the province of Asia send you greetings.

- ¶ The churches here in Asia want you^(plur) to know that they ask about you.
- ¶ The believers in the churches here in Asia Province say that they think about you.

The churches: The word churches refers to the people in the churches of each town. In some languages it may not be possible to say that churches send greetings.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the believers in the churches

in the province of Asia: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in the province of Asia is more literally of Asia. The BSB has supplied the word province. Asia Province was in the western part of modern Turkey. It does not refer to the whole continent that we now call Asia. Ephesus, where Paul wrote this letter, was in the province of Asia.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the churches here in Asia Province

send you greetings: The believers in the province of Asia wished the believers in Corinth well. Choose a phrase that is natural for greeting somebody who is not present.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they say that they are asking about you

they send you a message that they think about you

they ask, “Are you well?”

16:19b

Aquila and Prisca greet you warmly in the Lord,

- Aquila and Prisca/Priscilla want you^(plur) to know that they ask about you a lot, because they love you in the Lord.
- Aquila and Priscilla say they they think often about you because you all belong to the Lord.

Aquila and Prisca: Aquila and Prisca were husband and wife. Use the appropriate forms for these names to indicate that the first is a man and the second a woman. This couple formerly lived in Corinth, but now they lived in Ephesus (see Acts 18:2–3).

Prisca: The Greek text has Prisca here, as in Romans 16:3 and 2 Timothy 4:19. The book of Acts refers to this woman as “Priscilla” (Acts 18:2, 18, 26). Use the form of the name that is best known in your churches, or insert a footnote to say that the names Prisca and Priscilla refer to the same woman.

greet you warmly in the Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as greet is the same word as was used in 19a, where the BSB translates it as “send you greetings.”

warmly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as warmly is literally “very much” or “a lot.” “Warmly” is an English idiom. You may have a different idiom in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

they give many greetings

they send strong greetings

they think about you a lot

they ask about you frequently

in the Lord: Aquila and Priscilla sent their greetings in the Lord because they and the Corinthians both called Jesus their Lord.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they love you^(plur) because of Jesus who is our^(incl) Lord

because you all belong to the Lord

16:19c

and so does the church that meets at their house.

- So do the people in the church that meets at their house.
- The church that gathers in their house also says that they think about you.

and so does the church that meets at their house:

At this time there were no church buildings. Churches met in the houses of believers.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the believers who meet in the church at their house also greet you

General Comment on 16:19b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information. For example:

^{19b}Aquila and Priscilla ^{19c}and the church that meets at their house ^{19b}send you warm greetings in the Lord.

1 Corinthians 16:20

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:19–20

In this paragraph Paul gave greetings from three groups of people in Asia. Consider the forms that are natural in your language for sending greetings in a letter.

16:20a

All the brothers here send you greetings.

- All the believers here want you^(plur) to know that they ask about you.
- All the brothers and sisters say that they think about you.

All the brothers here send you greetings: All the believers in Ephesus sent their greetings to the believers in Corinth.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

All of the Lord's followers send their greetings.
(CEV)

All the Christians here send greetings. (JBP)

16:20b

Greet one another with a holy kiss.

- Greet^(plur) one another with a kiss, as people who believe in Christ.
- Greet each other by shaking hands/hugging/bowing because you are God's holy people.
- When you meet, greet each other with love because you are God's holy people.

Greet one another: In verse 16:19 "greet" referred to sending a message to people far away. In this verse, the greeting is given to someone who is present. Choose the appropriate word in your language for each context.

with a holy kiss: In the early church, believers often greeted one another by kissing on the cheek. Paul used the word holy because this method of greeting was used by God's people. In some cultures it may not be acceptable for unmarried adults to kiss. There are several ways to translate the term holy kiss:

- Translate literally using the word kiss. You may wish to explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

FOOTNOTE: This kiss is holy because it is a sign of love and respect among God's people.

- Use a common gesture of greeting in your area, such as "shake hands," "bow," or "namaste." You may want to explain this in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

FOOTNOTE: Literally, "Greet one another with a holy kiss." This kiss is holy because it is a sign of love and respect among God's people.

- Translate the meaning of the gesture in a general way. For example:

Greet each other with love as God's holy people. If you do this, you may want to put a literal translation in a footnote.

1 Corinthians 16:21

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:21–24

Paul concluded his letter by writing a farewell greeting in his own hand.

16:21

This greeting is in my own hand—Paul.

- ¶ These last words I am writing with my own hand to greet you^(plur). I am Paul.
- ¶ Now I, Paul, am the person writing this greeting. I think about you all.

This greeting is in my own hand—Paul: Paul wrote verses 16:21–24 himself, in his own handwriting. He dictated the rest of the letter to a secretary, which was the custom in those days.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Here is my own greeting, written by me, Paul. (JBP)

These last words I am writing with my own hand to greet you. I am Paul.

Now I, Paul, am the one writing this. I think about you all.

1 Corinthians 16:22

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he

concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:21–24

Paul concluded his letter by writing a farewell greeting in his own hand.

16:22a

If anyone does not love the Lord, let him be under a curse.

- If someone does not love the Lord, may God curse him.
- May God punish with eternal punishment all those who do not love him.

If anyone does not love the Lord, let him be under a curse: There is a textual problem. Some Greek manuscripts have “the Lord Jesus Christ” instead of the Lord. Only the KJV follows those manuscripts. The UBS Greek New Testament has only the words the Lord. Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

May whoever does not love the Lord have a curse

I pray that God will put a curse on everyone who doesn’t love the Lord (CEV)

let him be under a curse: The clause let him be under a curse is a prayer, a wish that God will do harm to this person.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

May God curse him

May God punish him

16:22b

Come, O Lord!

- Come quickly, Lord.
- Come back quickly to the earth, Lord!

Come, O Lord!: The word that the BSB translates as Come, O Lord! is written in Aramaic instead of Greek. This Aramaic word can be transliterated as “Maranatha.” This is a prayer for the Lord Jesus to

return to the earth. Some English versions include both the Aramaic word and a translation.

Here are some other ways to translate this Aramaic word:

Maranatha—Come, Lord! (REB)

Our^(incl) Lord, come back quickly to the earth

O Lord: The English word O is an ancient vocative form. It shows that you are speaking to the Lord. Use a form for addressing God that is natural in your language.

1 Corinthians 16:23

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:21–24

Paul concluded his letter by writing a farewell greeting in his own hand.

16:23

The grace of the Lord Jesus be with you.

- May the Lord Jesus be gracious/kind to you^(plur).
- I ask Jesus our Lord to give you his grace.

The grace of the Lord Jesus be with you: This is a prayer. It is a wish that the Lord Jesus will be gracious and kind to the Corinthians.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I pray that the Lord Jesus will be kind to you (CEV)

I ask Jesus our Lord to give you his grace

1 Corinthians 16:24

Section 16:1–24: Paul gave some final instructions

In this final section of the book, Paul wrote briefly about several topics. He wrote about collecting money

for poor Christians in Jerusalem, and he wrote about the travel plans of him and his companions. Then he concluded his letter with some short exhortations, warnings, blessings, and greetings.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The conclusion of the letter

Final topics

Paragraph 16:21–24

Paul concluded his letter by writing a farewell greeting in his own hand.

16:24

My love be with all of you in Christ Jesus. Amen.

- I love you all because of Christ Jesus.
- My heart feels love for all of you who believe in Christ Jesus the same as I do.

My love be with all of you: Paul expressed his love for his readers. Consider how somebody would express love at the end of a letter in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I love every one of you

My heart feels love for all of you

in Christ Jesus: Paul said that he loved all of them because they shared a common faith in Christ Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because you believe in Christ Jesus the same as I do

you who abide in Christ Jesus

as a result of Christ Jesus

Amen: There is a textual issue here. Many Greek texts do not include the word Amen. The two options are:

1. The word Amen should not be included. (NET, NRSV, REB, NJB, NABRE, GW, NLT, GNT, NCV, CEV)
2. The word Amen should be included. (BSB, NIV, ESV, RSV, NASB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) and do not include the word Amen. This is the recommendation of the UBS Greek New Testament. It gives the text

without Amen a B rating, indicating that the text is almost certain.